Week beginning 16 November 2026

AUSTRALIA & NEW ZEALAND WEEKLY

Analysis and forecasts for this week's key releases.

In this week's edition:

Economic Insight: An RBA peak of greater conviction.

The Week That Was: Cost of living front and centre.

Focus on New Zealand: Post election, where are we left?

For the week ahead:

Australia: Q3 WPI, labour force survey, housing sentiment index, RBA Governor Bullock, RBA minutes.

New Zealand: Performance services index, selected prices, RBNZ survey of expectations.

China: Retail sales, industrial production, fixed asset investment.

Japan: Q3 GDP, core machinery orders, CPI.

Euro Area: Industrial production, ZEW survey of expectations, consumer confidence.

United Kingdom: Unemployment rate, CPI, consumer sentiment, retail sales.

United States: FOMC minutes, regional manufacturing surveys, housing market data, retail sales.

Information contained in this report current as at 13 November 2026.

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An RBA peak of greater conviction

Luci Ellis
Chief Economist, Westpac Group

It was already our view that the RBA was likely done hiking the cash rate after the November increase. Since then, our conviction on that call has strengthened. Later today we will publish the November *Market Outlook* with revised forecasts. GDP growth, the labour market and housing market have all been revised down in 2027.

Underlying inflation has been revised down slightly in the second half of 2027, bringing the year-ended figure for calendar 2027 more decisively inside the RBA's 2–3% target range than our previous forecast round. The unemployment rate forecast has been revised up to peak above 5%. Based on this revised forecast profile, an increase in the cash rate from here would be unlikely and – we would argue – undesirable.

A range of considerations underlie this forecast revision. **The housing market has undershot our forecasts over the past couple of months.** Turnover and financing activity have been coming in under our earlier expectations. Mortgage loan inquiries have taken another leg down in October after the September rate hike, after finding something of a level in prior months, with the additional impact of the November rate hike still to come.

We are also seeing early signs of a turn in the consumer. Consumer income and spending have so far been quite resilient to pressures from fuel prices and rising interest rates. But our Westpac Card Tracker is starting to show that discretionary services spending is turning down again in Q4, joining the discretionary goods category that was already quite weak. We would not over-emphasise this point, but it does imply that the risks of further surprising resilience are fading.

Subsequent to the November Monetary Policy Board (MPB) meeting, business survey data has shown weaker conditions and a sharp decline in forward orders. They also show further evidence that current inflation is mostly a non-labour cost shock that is not being fully passed through to consumer prices.

As we noted following the November MPB meeting, oil and fuel prices are already materially lower than the track assumed in the RBA's forecasts. Dated Brent is nearly one-fourth lower than on 28 October, the date the RBA's forecasts were finalised, and spot Brent is around 15% lower. This significantly lowers the risk of a new wave of pass-through of fuel costs to other prices, as well as easing consumer inflation perceptions and expectations.

Forecast changes

- **A full update to our forecasts has been published in our November Market Outlook.**

In the media conference following the November meeting, Governor Bullock flagged that it was a good time to "take stock" of the policy tightening to date. Both we and the market read this as a signal that the MPB would pause at the December meeting. The 6:3 split vote at the meeting also suggests that some external members are more attentive to downside risks than the internal members.

> **"A deeper housing downturn and early signs of cracks in the consumer sector point to an even softer 2027."**

A rate hike in February 2027 cannot be ruled out but it is looking even less likely given signs in the data and surveys. The MPB will at least discuss a hike in February. The staff and senior officials remain sensitive to inflation risks and have a downbeat view of supply capacity growth.

Given what we are seeing in the economy now, though, a rate hike in 2027 would require either a material new inflation shock that has not yet occurred, or would constitute a policy error on the part of the RBA (something that we will never forecast as a base case, knowing the talents and capabilities of the staff and the Board). We concur with the dissenting voters in the MPB that the downside risks need more attention.

Policy is clearly restrictive, and the risk of overdoing the inflation correction is growing. And by the time we get to February, we think there will be more evidence that the domestic economy is slowing materially, and the inflation outlook with it.

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Cliff Notes: cost of living front and centre

Elliot Clarke, Head of International Economics
Ryan Wells, Economist
Illiana Jain, Economist

In Australia, the Westpac-MI Consumer Sentiment Index fell 2.7% to 78.2 in November, its weakest reading since late-2022 and a level historically associated with periods of severe economic stress. Renewed cost-of-living and interest rate pressures were front and centre following another lift in inflation, including sharply higher petrol prices, and the RBA's November rate increase. Mortgage holders are feeling the squeeze most acutely, with sentiment across this group falling to a record low. Consumers have become noticeably more downbeat on the near-term economic outlook – the relevant sub-index dropping 10.2% to be 22% below its long-run average. Job-loss fears also continue to edge up.

Businesses are similarly troubled. The latest NAB business survey showed confidence slipped further to –15 in October as conditions held near their weakest level since the pandemic. Of concern for the outlook, forward orders fell to –12, also the weakest read since the pandemic, and capital expenditure intentions deteriorated. Purchase costs continue to grow materially faster than selling prices, further compressing already tight margins.

Housing provides a clear example of how caution and tighter financial conditions can jolt activity. The value of new dwelling finance approvals plunged 15% in Q3, the largest quarterly decline in the series' history, taking approvals 25% lower year-to-date. Investor lending bore the brunt of the adjustment, falling 30% over the quarter as higher rates combined with the housing tax changes announced in May. Owner-occupier lending also weakened, however, with first-home buyers proving particularly sensitive to the deterioration in affordability and market conditions.

Taken together, the data points to a further loss of momentum across the domestic economy, consistent with Westpac's expectation for subdued growth and concern over downside activity risks.

Meanwhile, in the US, October's headline CPI met our expectations but at 0.4% was a touch above the consensus view. Energy and food both contributed meaningfully to the result, but core inflation was also marginally stronger than forecast, +0.3%. Core goods inflation has accelerated over the past four months to average a gain of 0.2% as businesses look to pass tariffs, tech and energy input cost inflation through. Shelter meanwhile continued to rise at an above-average pace, gaining 0.3% in October.

The market impact of the October CPI report was accentuated by hawkish remarks from Fed Governor Waller prior to the release. He expressed confidence in economic activity and the labour market while showing significant concern over the strength and persistence of inflation, focusing on the passthrough of energy and technology input inflation. His conclusion for policy was clear: "if, as I expect, the monthly rate of inflation improves in October, I am leaning toward supporting an increase in our policy rate of 25 basis points at the FOMC's December meeting"; but "if the October CPI inflation data out later today are similar to the past two monthly readings—with core CPI inflation around 0.3 percent or even higher—then a stronger policy move may be needed".

Regional Fed Presidents Goolsbee, Logan and Hammack also kept the focus on inflation risks and stated or implied the FOMC needs to act. Market participants have responded to this week's updates, pricing a 25bp hike in for the December and January meetings, and a cumulative 3.5 hikes by September. We believe this pricing overstates the need for policy tightening given core inflation ex shelter remains relatively benign at 2.4% on a six-month annualised basis and the labour market is balanced; but it will take time for price concerns to subside.

While we agree that the US economy is strong in aggregate, US households are under pressure from the cost of living, and their investment decision making is constrained by borrowing costs. Highlighting this, US existing home sales fell 5.5% in October after a downwardly revised 1.0% gain in September, leaving the level of sales below the cycle lows of 2009 and 2010. Our November Market Outlook provide a full update on our expectations for the US and the world.

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Post election, where are we left?

Michael Gordon
Senior Economist

This week markets and the economy needed to digest the General Election results, as well as data on how the economy is tracking through the final months of the year. A centre-right coalition looks more likely to ultimately prevail, although it may be a while before we know for sure and longer again before a stable government emerges. Watch this space as paths to victory for the centre-left remain. Economic data are consistent with a still-strong external sector but a weaker domestically-generated growth impulse. Our upcoming Economic Overview next week will examine these trends in more depth.

The real star of the show this week was the outcome of the 2026 General Election, which delivered an election night lead to the centre-right coalition of the National, ACT and NZ First parties. The preliminary result was a 67-57 seat margin in an enlarged 131 seat parliament. Hence the centre-right won on election night with a slender one-seat margin, given that 66 seats are required to form a majority. Financial markets and the business sector generally cheered this outcome given their preference for a centre-right government. However, the margins are tight and there is the potential for the result to switch around when the final vote count becomes available on November 27.

National leads Labour by narrow margins in two electorates (Wairarapa and Hamilton East) and could lose those seats when all is said and done. Also, special votes tend to swing more to the left than the right historically and hence could boost the centre-left bloc. The star performer of the election was the Opportunity Party which debuted in parliament with 7 seats. The centre-left would require their support to get over the line in all scenarios, whereas the centre-right might or might not need them depending on how the special votes and final electorate results play out. There seems a clearer path to victory for the centre-right – especially if they can come to an agreement with Opportunity – but clients should be wary of complacency (which we note may be a risk).

A further complication is that the election left the incumbent National Party in a much-weakened position as their coalition partners picked up seats at their expense, and because their much-reduced share of the party vote (29.2%) meant that no National Party list MPs made it into parliament. Several seasoned and senior government ministers needed a list seat to make it into the new government including Finance Minister Nicola Willis. Even if the final results confirm a centre-right coalition win, there will be fierce debate within the coalition on which party staffs key ministerial roles. ACT party leader David Seymour is making a strong play for Finance Minister, which Prime Minister Christopher Luxon is fiercely resisting.

There is the potential for tough and protracted coalition negotiations to play out well into the Christmas period. Indeed, I spoke on a post-election panel with an ex-National Party senior minister this week who expressed the view that it might not be until Waitangi Day (February 6) before a new government is formed. Should anything like this play out then the implications for economic and market uncertainty could be significant. The initial relief rally in the New Zealand dollar might prove premature in that scenario.

For interest rate markets, the main conclusion drawn is that as a centre-left government seems a lower probability prospect, then so also is the likelihood of a return to a 'dual mandate' for the RBNZ. Chief Economist Paul Conway made remarks this week suggesting ongoing concern with inflation risks, suggesting he is still in the hike camp at this stage. This has seen markets firm up short-term OCR expectations such that a 25bp OCR increase in December is now seen as high probability (85-90% currently). Bond markets cheered the prospect of potentially tighter fiscal policy that could come with a centre-right government. The spread between the 10-year government bond and swap spread narrowed 4 basis points over the week and the 10-year government bond yield differential to the US fell to -49 basis points – the most negative since 2019.

Economic data showed further evidence of the two-speed economy that is showing above-trend growth yet at the same time feels quite unsatisfying to most voters. The low exchange rate, generally robust global demand and tight supply conditions in soft commodity markets have been delivering consistently strong export returns for a couple of years now.

This week we saw another very strong GDT Pulse auction that propelled whole milk powder futures higher – up some 20-25% on year ago levels in USD terms. Significant upside risk for our 2026/27 Farmgate Milk Price forecast of $9.75/kgMS now exists, which we will be delving into more deeply in our Economic Overview to be released on Wednesday. The manufacturing sector appears to remain in a solid state, with the manufacturing PMI slipping a touch in October to 54.9 from 56.3 in September.

Short-term visitor arrivals have resumed their prior strong uptrend, growing almost 3% for a second consecutive month in September and almost 10% higher than a year earlier. While arrivals from key European markets remain well below year-earlier levels – likely reflecting the disruption to travel through key Middle Eastern hubs along with higher jet fuel prices – this has been more than offset by a very sharp lift in arrivals from China. Indeed, Chinese arrivals in September were almost two-thirds higher than the same month last year.

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And in the September quarter, arrivals from China surpassed their pre-pandemic level for the first time. The number of Australian citizens visiting New Zealand grew just under 6%yr in September, but growth momentum from New Zealand's number one source market (a 30% share) does appear to have slowed somewhat in recent months.

Less positive trends were evident in the more domestically orientated areas of the economy. The most concrete indicator of the NZ economy – concrete poured – dropped back a touch in the September quarter, while consumer spending in fell 0.7% in October. We have concerns on the quality of the consumer spending data given that bank-sourced data indicates a rise in consumer spending in October. But nonetheless it's probably reasonable to infer that higher fuel costs in October crimped household budgets.

Housing market data for October were also week. House sales fell and are down almost 22% y/y, while house prices fell in October for the fifth consecutive month to be down almost 2% y/y. The weak performance of the housing market is likely another factor weighing on consumer spending and residential investment. That's another topic we will be taking a look at in next week's Economic Overview.

Net migration flows for September confirm still modest population growth. Arrivals of non-New Zealand citizens continues to drift higher while departures declined a touch. The net outflow of New Zealanders remains relatively high but is declining, as signs of firmer employment growth emerge in New Zealand at the same time as the Australian labour market shows signs of weakening.

NZ vs Aus unemployment and Net flow of NZ citizens

Source: Stats NZ, ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

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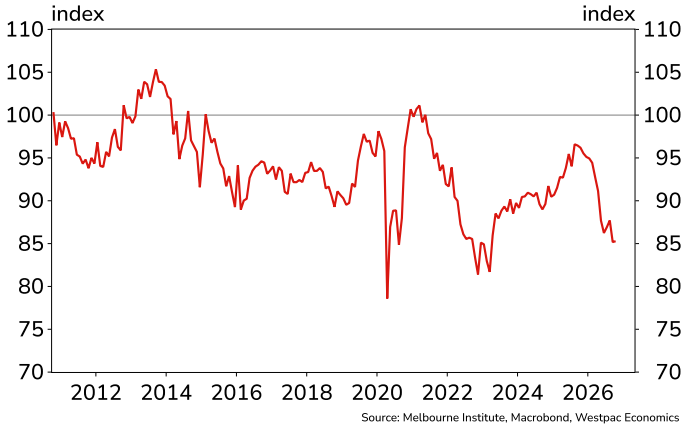
AUS: Nov Westpac Housing Sentiment (index)

Nov 17, Last: 85.3

The **Westpac Housing Sentiment Index** that appears in our regular **Housing Pulse** reports will now be published on a monthly basis a week after **Westpac-Melbourne Institute Consumer Sentiment** is released. The Index is a composite based on housing-related sentiment measures from the survey and has proven to be an extremely useful predictor of turning points in housing markets, both nationally and across states.

At 85.3, the Oct monthly Index read was holding near historic lows, well below the long run avg of 100. The Nov update will capture reactions to the RBA's latest interest rate rise and the deepening and broadening housing downturn. The release will also include results from two new questions added to the regular survey on consumers' property buying and selling intentions over the next twelve months.

Housing Sentiment Index



Source: Melbourne Institute, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

AUS: Q3 Wage Price Index (%qtr)

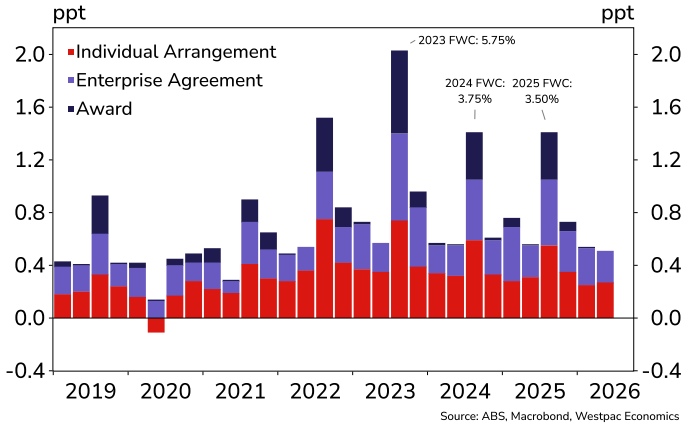
Nov 18, Last: 0.8, Westpac f/c: 1.0
Market f/c: 1.0, Range: 0.9 to 1.1

The Wage Price Index (WPI) rose 0.8% in Q2, leaving annual growth at 3.2%. Private sector wages continued to decelerate, in line with a softer labour market, while public sector wages provided a bit of an offset.

The Fair Work Commission's (FWC) 2026 Annual Wage Review handed down a larger-than-expected 4.75% increase in award wages. This will have a noticeable impact on the Q3 WPI, as the wage increases stemming from the review are typically passed on during the September quarter.

We have pencilled in a rise of 1.0% for Q3, lifting the annual pace to 3.4%yr. Detail on wages growth by bargaining stream will be closely watched for evidence of broader diffusion beyond arrangements directly linked to the FWC's decision.

Contributions to Quarterly WPI Growth



Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

AUS: Oct Labour Force – Employment Change (000s)

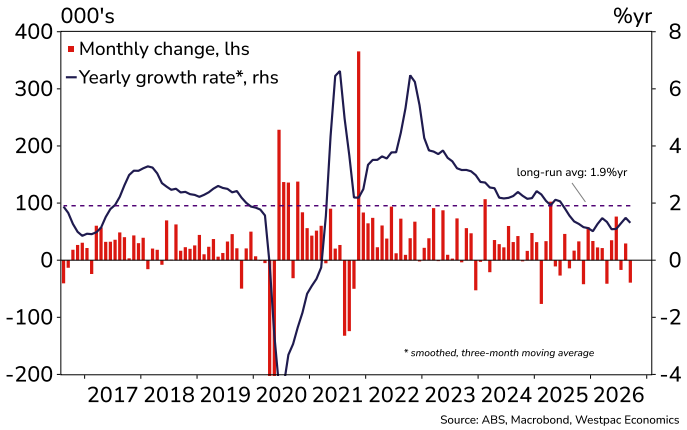
Nov 19, Last: –39.3, Westpac f/c: 30
Market f/c: 27.5, Range: 9.9 to 42

Employment fell by 39.3k in September, well below expectations for a 20k lift. Some of this weakness may reflect an unwind of a possible residual seasonality stemming from recent changes to the survey design, which saw August come in stronger.

Under the monthly noise, the labour market is loosening gradually as jobs growth runs slower than population growth. While some leading indicators point to near-term stability – such as job ads – business surveys and detail within the employment data point to some downside risk.

For October, we have pencilled in a lift in employment of +30k, which would see employment growth hold steady on a three-month average basis.

Employment growth



Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

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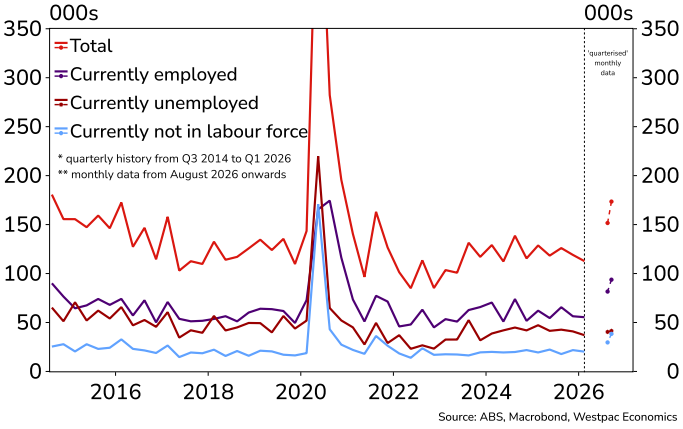
AUS: Oct Labour Force – Unemployment Rate (%)

Nov 19, Last: 4.7, Westpac f/c: 4.7
Market f/c: 4.7, Range: 4.6 to 4.8

Once again, the surprise in employment coincided with a surprise in labour force participation, which fell 0.2ppts to 66.8% from its near cycle high of 67.0% in August. This translated to a 26.2k decline in the size of the labour force, which was less than the drop in employment. As a result, the unemployment rate ticked slightly higher in September, from 4.65% to 4.72% (although it was steady at 4.7% to one decimal place), a new cycle high.

For October, we have the participation rate steady at 66.8%, which together with the forecast rise in employment, would see the unemployment rate also hold steady at 4.7%. Early signs of rising retrenchments are a key signal to watch over the coming months, especially if new hiring across other areas of the economy starts to dry up.

Retrenchments



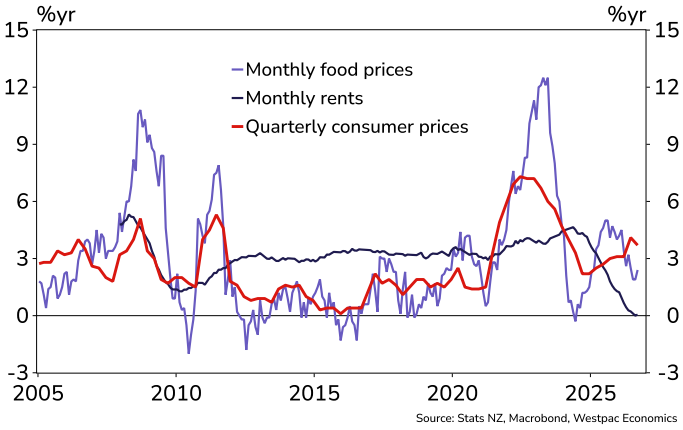
Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

NZ: Oct Selected Consumer Prices

Nov 17

Stats NZ's monthly Selected Prices provides an update on around half of the full CPI, including many of the more volatile items. In terms of the big groups, we're expecting a 0.1% rise in overall food prices, with fresh produce prices typically soft at this time of year. We also expect continued softness in housing rents. However, the key focus will be on transport costs. Petrol prices are expected to be up 11%. And we'll be watching to see if high global fuel prices are contributing to further increases in airfares after recent large increases. There is related uncertainty around holiday accommodation costs (which drive much of the month-to-month volatility in overall prices).

NZ selected consumer prices



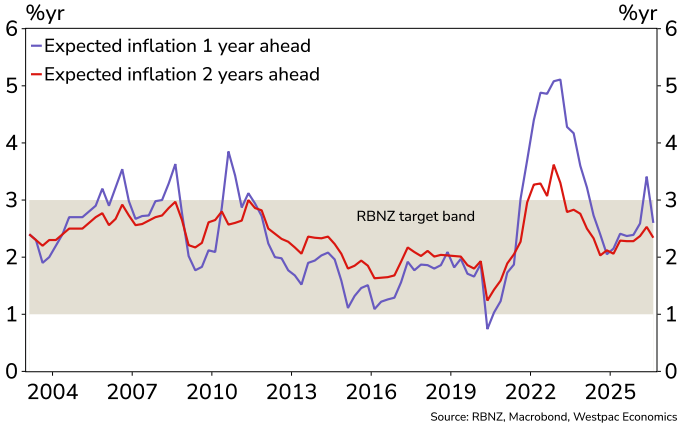
Source: Stats NZ, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

NZ: Q4 RBNZ Survey of Expectations (%yr)

Nov 17, Inflation 2yrs Ahead, Last: 2.34

With an easing in headline inflation in the September quarter, we're likely to see some easing in near-term inflation expectations (one year ahead). However, longer term inflation expectations, particularly the closely-watched two years ahead measure, are likely to remain broadly steady. While interest rates are moving higher, businesses are continuing to report pressures on operating costs. In addition, despite their recent easing, oil prices remain elevated. The only time longer-term inflation expectations have moved materially below 2.3% was in the mid-2010s. That followed an extended period when inflation was running below 2%.

RBNZ survey of inflation expectations



Source: RBNZ, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

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What to watch

	For	Data/Event	Unit	Last	Market f/c	Westpac f/c	Risk/Comment
Mon 16							
NZ	Oct	Performance Services Index	index	50.9	–	–	Improving, but has underperformed manufacturing this year.
Jpn	Q3	GDP	%qtr	0.4	0.1	–	Real growth still constrained by rising costs of essentials.
Chn	Oct	Retail Sales	ytd %yr	1.1	–	–	Chinese industrial activity continues to support growth ...
	Oct	Industrial Production	ytd %yr	5.3	–	–	... though pressures in the household sector remain as...
	Oct	Fixed Asset Investment	ytd %yr	–7.2	–7.0	–	... consumers lose out on AI windfall.
Eur	Sep	Industrial Production	%mth	–0.5	0.9	–	Global slowdown feeds through.
US	Nov	Fed Empire State Manufacturing	index	25.5	19.0	–	Domestic resilience continues to surprise.
		Fedspeak	–	–	–	–	Williams.
Tue 17							
Aus	Nov	Westpac Housing Sentiment	index	85.3	–	–	A monthly update following our consumer sentiment index.
		RBA Governor Bullock	–	–	–	–	Panel participation at ASIC Annual Forum, 10:00am AEDT.
	Nov	RBA Minutes	–	–	–	–	Further insights into the 6–3 split vote decision.
NZ		RBNZ Financial Stability Report	–	–	–	–	Six–monthly review of financial conditions.
	Oct	Selected Price Indices – Food	%mth	0.0	–	0.1	Softness in fresh produce prices.
	Oct	Selected Price Indices – Rents	%mth	0.1	–	0.0	Rents remain soft despite the usual seasonal upswing.
	Q4	RBNZ 2–Yr Inflation Expectations	%ann	2.34	–	–	Likely to remain broadly steady in the face of oil volatility.
Eur	Nov	ZEW Survey Of Expectations	index	18.5	–	–	Consumers are cautious about the outlook.
UK	Sep	ILO Unemployment Rate	%	4.7	4.7	–	Slack picks up speed in the labour market,
US	Oct	Retail Sales	%mth	0.8	0.2	–	Spending steady even as gas prices rise.
	Oct	Import Price Index	%mth	1.1	0.7	–	Tech puts pressure on import costs.
	Oct	Industrial Production	%mth	0.7	0.1	–	Utilities are leading the charge.
	Nov	NAHB Housing Market	index	29	29	–	Activity still subdued.
		Fedspeak	–	–	–	–	Hammack.
Wed 18							
Aus	Q3	WPI	%qtr	0.8	1.0	1.0	Will the award wage boost permeate more broadly?
NZ	Q3	PPI Output Prices	%qtr	1.6	–	–	A short–lived easing in fuel costs over the quarter.
UK	Oct	CPI	%ann	3.5	3.5	–	Breadth of inflation may trigger rate rise.
US	Oct	Housing Starts	%mth	–5.2	4.4	–	Housing market remains constrained by higher ...
	Oct	Building Permits	%mth	–0.4	–1.6	–	... borrowing costs which are seeing builders delay ...
	Oct	Pending Home Sales	%mth	–7.3	–	–	... projects and buyers remain hesitant.
	Oct	FOMC Minutes	–	–	–	–	Discussion around inflation risks.
		Fedspeak	–	–	–	–	Williams.
Thu 19							
Aus	Oct	Employment Change	000s	–39.3	27.5	30	Volatile employment data may reflect residual seasonality ...
	Oct	Unemployment Rate	%	4.7	4.7	4.7	... but the unemployment rate continues to march higher.
NZ		RBNZ Governor Breman	–	–	–	–	Fireside chat and Q&A on economy and policy, 7:00am NZDT.
		RBNZ Chief Economist Conway	–	–	–	–	Speaking at two different events, 9:00am and 3:00pm NZDT.
	Oct	Trade Balance	$mn	–1971	–	–1960	Seasonal upswing in exports; imports likely boosted by aircraft.
Jpn	Sep	Core Machinery Orders	%mth	5.2	1.7	–	AI boom continues to power the manufacturing sector.
US	Nov	Phily Fed Manufacturing	index	20.9	23.2	–	Resilience remains.
		Initial Jobless Claims	000s	200	197	–	Still at a low level versus history.
	Nov	Kansas City Fed Manufacturing	index	11.0	–	–	Some sectors holding up better than others.
		Fedspeak	–	–	–	–	Goolsbee, Hammack.
Fri 20							
Aus		RBA MPB Member	–	–	–	–	Fry–McKibben appearing at CAMA, 11:15am AEDT.
Jpn	Oct	CPI	%ann	2.1	2.5	–	Inflation is broadening.
Eur	Nov	Consumer Confidence	index	–17.9	–18.2	–	Borrowing costs are constraining confidence.
UK	Nov	GfK Consumer Sentiment	index	–24	–22	–	Sentiment downbeat as consumers face rising prices ...
	Oct	Retail Sales	%mth	–0.4	–0.1	–	... leading to some pull back in discretionary spending.
US	Nov	Uni. Of Michigan Sentiment	index	51.0	53.3	–	Final estimate.

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Economic & financial forecasts

Interest rate forecasts

Australia	Latest (13 Nov)	Dec–26	Mar–27	Jun–27	Sep–27	Dec–27	Mar–28	Jun–28	Sep–28	Dec–28
Cash	4.85	4.85	4.85	4.85	4.60	4.35	4.10	3.85	3.85	3.85
90 Day BBSW	4.95	4.96	4.96	4.81	4.56	4.31	4.11	3.96	3.95	3.95
3 Year Swap	4.78	4.75	4.70	4.65	4.60	4.50	4.40	4.35	4.30	4.25
3 Year Bond	4.78	4.75	4.70	4.65	4.60	4.50	4.40	4.35	4.30	4.25
10 Year Bond	5.11	5.00	4.95	4.90	4.95	4.95	5.00	5.00	5.00	5.00
10 Year Spread to US (bps)	–2	5	5	5	5	0	0	–5	–10	–15
United States										
Fed Funds	3.875	4.125	4.375	4.375	4.375	4.375	4.125	3.875	3.875	3.875
US 10 Year Bond	5.13	4.95	4.90	4.85	4.90	4.95	5.00	5.05	5.10	5.15
New Zealand										
Cash	2.75	3.00	3.50	3.75	4.00	4.00	4.00	4.00	3.75	3.75
90 Day Bill	3.20	3.40	3.75	4.00	4.20	4.20	4.20	4.15	3.95	3.95
2 Year Swap	3.79	3.95	4.10	4.25	4.20	4.20	4.15	4.15	4.10	4.10
10 Year Bond	4.71	4.80	4.85	4.95	5.05	5.05	5.05	5.05	5.05	5.05
10 Year Spread to US (bps)	–42	–15	–5	10	15	10	5	0	–5	–10

Exchange rate forecasts

	Latest (13 Nov)	Dec–26	Mar–27	Jun–27	Sep–27	Dec–27	Mar–28	Jun–28	Sep–28	Dec–28
AUD/USD	0.6806	0.70	0.70	0.71	0.71	0.71	0.72	0.72	0.72	0.72
NZD/USD	0.5547	0.56	0.58	0.60	0.61	0.62	0.62	0.63	0.63	0.64
USD/JPY	159.82	157	157	156	155	154	153	151	149	147
EUR/USD	1.1055	1.13	1.14	1.15	1.16	1.17	1.18	1.19	1.20	1.21
GBP/USD	1.3239	1.34	1.35	1.36	1.37	1.38	1.39	1.40	1.41	1.41
USD/CNY	6.6724	6.65	6.60	6.50	6.45	6.40	6.35	6.35	6.30	6.30
AUD/NZD	1.2269	1.24	1.22	1.19	1.16	1.15	1.15	1.15	1.14	1.14

Australian economic forecasts

	2026				2027				Calendar years			
% change	Q1	Q2	Q3(f)	Q4(f)	Q1(f)	Q2(f)	Q3(f)	Q4(f)	2025	2026(f)	2027(f)	2028(f)
GDP %qtr	0.3	0.4	0.5	0.2	0.3	0.2	0.3	0.3	–	–	–	–
%yr end	2.5	2.1	2.1	1.4	1.4	1.2	1.0	1.0	2.6	1.4	1.0	2.1
Unemployment rate %	4.2	4.4	4.6	4.8	5.0	5.2	5.2	5.1	4.2	4.8	5.1	4.7
Wages (WPI) (sa) %qtr	0.8	0.8	1.0	0.7	0.7	0.7	0.8	0.8	–	–	–	–
%yr end	3.2	3.2	3.4	3.3	3.3	3.2	3.0	3.0	3.4	3.3	3.0	3.3
Headline CPI %qtr	1.4	0.6	1.3	1.2	0.4	0.5	0.8	0.4	–	–	–	–
%yr end	4.1	3.9	3.9	4.6	3.5	3.4	2.9	2.1	3.6	4.6	2.1	2.2
Trimmed Mean CPI %qtr	0.8	0.8	1.0	0.9	0.7	0.7	0.6	0.6	–	–	–	–
%yr end	3.5	3.6	3.7	3.6	3.5	3.3	2.9	2.7	3.4	3.6	2.7	2.3

New Zealand economic forecasts

	2026				2027				Calendar years			
% Change	Q1	Q2	Q3(f)	Q4(f)	Q1(f)	Q2(f)	Q3(f)	Q4(f)	2025	2026(f)	2027(f)	2028(f)
GDP %qtr	0.9	0.2	0.6	0.7	0.9	0.5	0.6	0.7	–	–	–	–
Annual avg change	0.9	1.7	2.1	2.4	2.4	2.5	2.6	2.6	0.3	2.4	2.6	3.0
Unemployment rate %	5.4	5.6	5.7	5.7	5.6	5.5	5.3	5.1	5.4	5.7	5.1	4.5
CPI %qtr	0.9	1.5	0.7	1.2	0.3	0.4	0.5	0.2	–	–	–	–
Annual change	3.1	4.1	3.7	4.3	3.7	2.5	2.3	1.4	3.1	4.3	1.4	1.9

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Cliff Notes: cost of living front and centre

#cliffnotes #rba #australia #inflation #us #fomc #ecb #aud #usd

By Ryan Wells, Elliot Clarke & Illiana Jain

09:49 November 13 2026

Share

Key insights from the week that was.

In Australia, the Westpac-MI Consumer Sentiment Index fell 2.7% to 78.2 in November, its weakest reading since late-2022 and a level historically associated with periods of severe economic stress. Renewed cost-of-living and interest rate pressures were front and centre following another lift in inflation, including sharply higher petrol prices, and the RBA's November rate increase. Mortgage holders are feeling the squeeze most acutely, with sentiment across this group falling to a record low.

Consumers have become noticeably more downbeat on the near-term economic outlook – the relevant sub-index dropping 10.2% to be 22% below its long-run average. Job-loss fears also continue to edge up.

Businesses are similarly troubled. The latest NAB business survey showed confidence slipped further to –15 in October as conditions held near their weakest level since the pandemic. Of concern for the outlook, forward orders fell to –12, also the weakest read since the pandemic, and capital expenditure intentions deteriorated. Purchase costs continue to grow materially faster than selling prices, further compressing already tight margins.

Housing provides a clear example of how caution and tighter financial conditions can jolt activity. The value of new dwelling finance approvals plunged 15% in Q3, the largest quarterly decline in the series' history, taking approvals 25% lower year-to-date. Investor lending bore the brunt of the adjustment, falling 30% over the quarter as higher rates combined with the housing tax changes announced in May. Owner-occupier lending also weakened, however, with first-home buyers proving particularly sensitive to the deterioration in affordability and market conditions.

Taken together, the data points to a further loss of momentum across the domestic economy, consistent with Westpac's expectation for subdued growth and concern over downside activity risks.

Meanwhile, in the US, October's headline CPI met our expectations but at 0.4% was a touch above the consensus view. Energy and food both contributed meaningfully to the result, but core inflation was also marginally stronger than forecast, +0.3%. Core goods inflation has accelerated over the past four months to average a gain of 0.2% as businesses look to pass tariffs, tech and energy input cost inflation through. Shelter meanwhile continued to rise at an above-average pace, gaining 0.3% in October.

The market impact of the October CPI report was accentuated by hawkish remarks from Fed Governor Waller prior to the release. He expressed confidence in economic activity and the labour market while showing significant concern over the strength and persistence of inflation, focusing on the passthrough of energy and technology input inflation. His conclusion for policy was clear: "if, as I expect, the monthly rate of inflation improves in October, I am leaning toward supporting an increase in our policy rate of 25 basis points at the FOMC's December meeting"; but "if the October CPI inflation data out later today are similar to the past two monthly readings—with core CPI inflation around 0.3 percent or even higher—then a stronger policy move may be needed".

Regional Fed Presidents Goolsbee, Logan and Hammack also kept the focus on inflation risks and stated or implied the FOMC needs to act. Market participants have responded to this week's updates, pricing a 25bp hike in for the December and January meetings, and a cumulative 3.5 hikes by September. We believe this pricing overstates the need for policy tightening given core inflation ex shelter remains relatively benign at 2.4% on a six-month annualised basis and the labour market is balanced; but it will take time for price concerns to subside.

While we agree that the US economy is strong in aggregate, US households are under pressure from the cost of living, and their investment decision making is constrained by borrowing costs. Highlighting

this, US existing home sales fell 5.5% in October after a downwardly revised 1.0% gain in September, leaving the level of sales below the cycle lows of 2009 and 2010. Our November Market Outlook will provide a full update on our expectations for the US and the world when released on Westpac IQ this afternoon.

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12 November 2026

MORNING REPORT

Today's economic developments and market movements.

Key themes

Renewed optimism around AI drove US equities higher overnight, with positive developments around CoreWeave and Anthropic adding to enthusiasm around the sector and helping the S&P 500 and NASDAQ rally.

US cash bond markets were closed for Veterans Day, though futures continued to point to higher Treasury yields following this week's hotter-than-expected inflation data, which has all but cemented a December FOMC hike, with another two increases priced over 2027.

The US dollar received a solid bid alongside renewed strength in AI and tech stocks, lifting the DXY 0.7% to its highest since April 2025, while the Aussie slipped to around USD0.6850.

Australian dwelling finance approvals surprised materially to the downside in Q3, with the value of approvals plunging a record 15.5% as investor lending values dropped by nearly a third.

Data snapshot

FX Last 24 hrs	Current	Change
TWI	63.8	-0.5%
AUD/USD	0.6850	-0.2%
AUD/JPY	109.50	0.5%
AUD/GBP	0.5159	0.3%
AUD/NZD	1.2308	0.5%
AUD/EUR	0.6176	0.4%
AUD/CNH	4.5719	-0.3%
AUD/SGD	0.8801	0.0%
AUD/HKD	5.3741	-0.2%
AUD/CAD	0.9760	0.2%
EUR/USD	1.1093	-0.6%
USD/JPY	159.85	0.7%
USD Index	102.90	0.7%

AUS Interest Rate Swaps	Last	Change
30 day BBSY	4.86	0.01
90 day BBSY	4.99	0.01
180 day BBSY	5.35	0.03
1 year swap	4.95	0.01
2 year swap	4.82	0.02
3 year swap	4.76	0.02
4 year swap	4.74	0.01
5 year swap	4.76	0.01
6 year swap	4.80	0.01
7 year swap	4.84	0.01
8 year swap	4.88	0.01
9 year swap	4.93	0.01
10 year swap	4.96	0.00

Equities	Close	Change
S&P/ASX 200	9,153	0.3%
S&P 500	7,626	1.4%
Japan Nikkei	61,249	1.3%
Hang Seng	24,316	-1.0%
Euro Stoxx 50	6,393	1.0%
UK FTSE100	10,835	0.8%
VIX Index	17.4	-10.6%

Government Bond Yields	Close	Change
Australia		
3 year bond	4.73	0.07
10 year bond	5.04	0.06
United States		
3-month T Bill	4.11	-0.01
2 year bond	4.74	0.00
10 year bond	4.99	0.00
Other (10 year yields)		
Germany	3.32	0.00
Japan	2.80	0.11
UK	5.22	0.00

Commodities	Current	Change
CRB Index	386.48	0.7%
Gold	3985.69	-1.2%
Copper	13817	1.0%
Oil (WTI futures)	86.31	0.3%
Coal (coking)	253.50	-0.2%
Coal (thermal)	143.40	3.3%
Iron Ore	91.25	-0.4%
ACCU	36.13	-4.3%

Sydney Futures Exchange	Current	Change
10 yr bond	5.05	0.00
3 yr bond	4.73	0.01
3 mth bill rate	4.77	0.00
SPI 200	9,158	-0.4%

Data as at 7:30am AEDT. Change is from the previous trading day (excluding the SFE, which is the change during the night session). Source: Bloomberg.

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Financial Markets

- Share markets rallied across much of the globe. In the US, reports of an upgraded outlook for CoreWeave, an oversubscribed IPO for Anthropic and a stabilisation in Nvidia supported renewed optimism around AI which buoyed tech stocks, seeing the S&P 500 (+1.4%) and Nasdaq (+1.7%) both rally, though the smaller gain for the Dow Jones (+0.5%) shows the rally was more narrowly based.
- Across the pond, the Euro Stoxx 50 continued to build on recent momentum with another solid gain (+1.0%), while London's FTSE 100 bounced back from a modest decline yesterday (+0.8%). Stocks were up across most of Asia, including Tokyo (+1.3%), Shanghai (+0.4%) and Seoul (+2.6%), with only the Hang Seng (–1.0%) bucking the wider trend. The ASX 200 rose 0.3% yesterday, but weaker trading in futures overnight points to a mixed open this morning.
- Cash trading in bond markets were closed in the US for Veterans Day, but trading in futures points to a continued rise in yields following hotter-than-expected inflation data received earlier in the week, which all but cemented a December FOMC rate hike. Beyond December, markets are also pricing in another two rate hikes over the course of 2027.
- Yields were little changed elsewhere, with the 10Y Bund and Gilt steady on the day. The 10Y JGB meanwhile continued to sell-off, with yields jumping 10bps to 2.80% having effectively unwound the rally over late last week. ACGBs were also weaker during local trading, seeing yields rise 7bps on the 3Y and 6bps on the 10Y, following the sharp rise in global yields the day prior post US CPI. Swaps markets point to no hikes nor cuts from the RBA through to end-2027 at present.
- The USD received a solid bid overnight, buoyed by sharp inflows into AI and tech stocks that improved risk sentiment. The DXY finished 0.7% higher at around 102.9, the strongest since April 2025. That move has pushed the Euro down 0.6% back to a USD1.10 handle, the weakest since May 2025, while the Yen slipped 0.7% to JPY159.9, the weakest since the before the early-September rally. While moves in the AUD was comparatively small overnight, slipping 0.2% to around the USD0.6850 mark, that move builds on recent downward momentum and has the currency delicately positioned near 2026's lows.
- Oil prices rose slightly overnight, stabilising somewhat after recent declines amid ongoing uncertainty around the future of the US-Iran War, as President Trump downplays the possibility of further strikes on Iran all while negotiations show little progress. Brent rose 1.0% to US$92.4/bbl. The rebound in risk sentiment buoyed metals, with LME copper up 1.0% to US$13,817/mt while LME aluminium jumped 1.9% to US$3,068/mt. Gold prices meanwhile dipped 1.2%, falling back below the US$4,000/oz mark, building on recent momentum post US CPI which saw real yields jump higher

Today's key data and events

Time	Event	Exp	Prev
8:45	NZ Card Spending Oct	-	-0.5%
8:45	NZ Net Migration Sep	-	1530k
18:00	GB GDP Q3 Prel.	0.7%	0.5%
18:00	GB Trade Balance Sep	-£2100b	-£920b
0:30	US Initial Jobless Claims 7/11/2026	195k	189k
2:00	US Existing Home Sales Oct	-3.5%	1.5%

Times are AEDT. All data forecasts are m/m or q/q and seasonally adjusted unless otherwise specified. Forecasts for Australian data are our forecasts and for other countries they are consensus forecasts.

International Data

There was no major data out yesterday.

Domestic Data

In Australia, the value of **dwelling finance approvals** surprised materially to the downside in Q3, the 15.5% decline marking the largest quarterly decline on records going back to 1991. The decline looks to be mostly volume-driven, with the number of loans falling sharply compared to the average size of loans. Across segments, investor lending values dropped by nearly a third (see here).

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Cliff Notes: whiplash

#cliffnotes #rba #australia #inflation #us #fomc #ecb #aud #usd

By Ryan Wells & Elliot Clarke

11:20 November 06 2026

Share

Key insights from the week that was.

In Australia, the RBA delivered another 25bp rate increase at its November meeting, taking the cash rate to 4.85%. The move was widely expected, reflecting the Board's continued concern around inflation following the recent run higher in global energy prices, firmer domestic capacity pressures and signs that inflation expectations have edged up. Inflation is now not expected to return to the mid-point of the target band until mid-2028. This is despite weaker growth expectations and the unemployment

rate trending up to 5.1% by end-2028 on the RBA's forecasts.

Importantly, though, the decision was not unanimous, with three members preferring to remain on hold given downside risks to activity and the restraining influence of slower growth. Governor Bullock's suggestion that it was time to "take stock" after five rate increases also struck a less hawkish note, while the statement dropped September's explicit reference to raising rates further "if needed". In our view, February represents the next plausible opportunity for another hike, but we see this only as a risk.

Policy's effect on housing is becoming increasingly visible. Cotality home prices fell a further 1.2% in October to now be 6.7% below March's peak. The cumulative price decline is approaching the scale of previous housing corrections but appears to have regained momentum after September's rate increase. Dwelling approvals saw a 5.1% headline gain in September, but this was driven by volatile unit approvals while detached house approvals fell sharply, suggesting higher rates and the established-market downturn are beginning to weigh on the construction pipeline.

Official data on nominal household spending meanwhile rose 0.6% in September and 2.1% for Q3; however, much of the recent acceleration looks to be price-driven, particularly for fuel. Real spending volumes expanded by a much more modest (but still solid) 0.7% in Q3.

The Westpac-DataX Consumer Panel provides a granular look at income, spending and saving flows. The latest update suggests that, beneath the resilient headline story, households are increasingly being squeezed, particularly those with low savings buffers. With another rate increase now delivered, housing wealth declining and sentiment weak, Q3 increasingly looks like the high-water mark for growth in consumer spending.

Lastly for Australia, in September the goods trade surplus widened sharply to $2.8bn, with non-monetary gold trade yet again adding considerable noise month-to-month. The most notable development was another exceptionally strong result for data-processing equipment imports, taking the Q3 total to $11.1bn. This is another clear marker of the scale of Australia's data-centre investment boom, which should feature prominently in both business investment and imports in the Q3 National Accounts.

Offshore, the world has been focused on the US mid-term elections. In the House, Senate and a series of State Governor races, the Democrats experienced resounding victory. Come 2027, the Democrats will have a comfortable majority in both houses of Congress and are expected to make use of this strength to respond to voter concerns, particularly over cost-of-living pressures. The election result also limits President Trump's ability to fund an extended military action against Iran. Notably, both immediately before and after the election, President Trump and the administration have exhibited a greater interest in furthering negotiations with Iran. It is therefore not a surprise that Brent oil has backed off its most recent highs around USD118 last Friday, although the scale of the drop to near USD93 yesterday is arguably too optimistic. Brent has since traded back up to above USD99, still 16% below Friday's peak.

While the initial reaction to the US election result was a robust broad-based rally in major equity indexes, concerns over the potential for tighter regulation of AI and the related infrastructure buildout

jolted US equities lower overnight – the Nasdaq falling 5.5% and S&P500 4.4%, both a multiple of the prior session's gains. That said, US term interest rates and FOMC rate expectations have also been scaled back; so, while tech may come under greater scrutiny, a foundation for better outcomes across the rest of the US economy may become evident in time. US data out this week continued to suggest their economy is in robust health overall. And, if tensions in the Middle East abate, the FOMC's concerns over US inflation should subside. Gaining enough comfort for the FOMC to not hike in December is a high bar, but the probability of further hikes in 2027 should continue to fall.

Turning then to the UK, the Bank of England raised Bank Rate by 25bps to 4.00% at their November meeting as expected. On the Bank's baseline expectation, UK inflation is forecast to rise from 3.5%yr at September to 5.00% by mid-2027. Activity data has also surprised to the upside in recent months, though "there remains limited evidence of knock-on effects on other prices and wages".

In the press conference, Governor Bailey recognised the nascent improvement in energy price pressures over the past 48 hours and the effectiveness of monetary policy but also conveyed that "Unless progress towards resolving the conflict is made, or there is other news which softens the risk to inflationary pressures, a further increase in Bank Rate may be warranted". Governor Bailey's tone and comments made in the minutes by other Committee members did not suggest this was a decision that needs to be made in December, but rather a risk to be judged as additional information is received. This points to further tightening being more likely in early 2027 than before, and only if conditions / risks warrant.

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12 November 2026

MORNING REPORT

Today's economic developments and market movements.

Key themes

Renewed optimism around AI drove US equities higher overnight, with positive developments around CoreWeave and Anthropic adding to enthusiasm around the sector and helping the S&P 500 and NASDAQ rally.

US cash bond markets were closed for Veterans Day, though futures continued to point to higher Treasury yields following this week's hotter-than-expected inflation data, which has all but cemented a December FOMC hike, with another two increases priced over 2027.

The US dollar received a solid bid alongside renewed strength in AI and tech stocks, lifting the DXY 0.7% to its highest since April 2025, while the Aussie slipped to around USD0.6850.

Australian dwelling finance approvals surprised materially to the downside in Q3, with the value of approvals plunging a record 15.5% as investor lending values dropped by nearly a third.

Data snapshot

FX Last 24 hrs	Current	Change
TWI	63.8	-0.5%
AUD/USD	0.6850	-0.2%
AUD/JPY	109.50	0.5%
AUD/GBP	0.5159	0.3%
AUD/NZD	1.2308	0.5%
AUD/EUR	0.6176	0.4%
AUD/CNH	4.5719	-0.3%
AUD/SGD	0.8801	0.0%
AUD/HKD	5.3741	-0.2%
AUD/CAD	0.9760	0.2%
EUR/USD	1.1093	-0.6%
USD/JPY	159.85	0.7%
USD Index	102.90	0.7%

AUS Interest Rate Swaps	Last	Change
30 day BBSY	4.86	0.01
90 day BBSY	4.99	0.01
180 day BBSY	5.35	0.03
1 year swap	4.95	0.01
2 year swap	4.82	0.02
3 year swap	4.76	0.02
4 year swap	4.74	0.01
5 year swap	4.76	0.01
6 year swap	4.80	0.01
7 year swap	4.84	0.01
8 year swap	4.88	0.01
9 year swap	4.93	0.01
10 year swap	4.96	0.00

Equities	Close	Change
S&P/ASX 200	9,153	0.3%
S&P 500	7,626	1.4%
Japan Nikkei	61,249	1.3%
Hang Seng	24,316	-1.0%
Euro Stoxx 50	6,393	1.0%
UK FTSE100	10,835	0.8%
VIX Index	17.4	-10.6%

Government Bond Yields	Close	Change
Australia		
3 year bond	4.73	0.07
10 year bond	5.04	0.06
United States		
3-month T Bill	4.11	-0.01
2 year bond	4.74	0.00
10 year bond	4.99	0.00
Other (10 year yields)		
Germany	3.32	0.00
Japan	2.80	0.11
UK	5.22	0.00

Commodities	Current	Change
CRB Index	386.48	0.7%
Gold	3985.69	-1.2%
Copper	13817	1.0%
Oil (WTI futures)	86.31	0.3%
Coal (coking)	253.50	-0.2%
Coal (thermal)	143.40	3.3%
Iron Ore	91.25	-0.4%
ACCU	36.13	-4.3%

Sydney Futures Exchange	Current	Change
10 yr bond	5.05	0.00
3 yr bond	4.73	0.01
3 mth bill rate	4.77	0.00
SPI 200	9,158	-0.4%

Data as at 7:30am AEDT. Change is from the previous trading day (excluding the SFE, which is the change during the night session). Source: Bloomberg.

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Financial Markets

- Share markets rallied across much of the globe. In the US, reports of an upgraded outlook for CoreWeave, an oversubscribed IPO for Anthropic and a stabilisation in Nvidia supported renewed optimism around AI which buoyed tech stocks, seeing the S&P 500 (+1.4%) and Nasdaq (+1.7%) both rally, though the smaller gain for the Dow Jones (+0.5%) shows the rally was more narrowly based.
- Across the pond, the Euro Stoxx 50 continued to build on recent momentum with another solid gain (+1.0%), while London's FTSE 100 bounced back from a modest decline yesterday (+0.8%). Stocks were up across most of Asia, including Tokyo (+1.3%), Shanghai (+0.4%) and Seoul (+2.6%), with only the Hang Seng (–1.0%) bucking the wider trend. The ASX 200 rose 0.3% yesterday, but weaker trading in futures overnight points to a mixed open this morning.
- Cash trading in bond markets were closed in the US for Veterans Day, but trading in futures points to a continued rise in yields following hotter-than-expected inflation data received earlier in the week, which all but cemented a December FOMC rate hike. Beyond December, markets are also pricing in another two rate hikes over the course of 2027.
- Yields were little changed elsewhere, with the 10Y Bund and Gilt steady on the day. The 10Y JGB meanwhile continued to sell-off, with yields jumping 10bps to 2.80% having effectively unwound the rally over late last week. ACGBs were also weaker during local trading, seeing yields rise 7bps on the 3Y and 6bps on the 10Y, following the sharp rise in global yields the day prior post US CPI. Swaps markets point to no hikes nor cuts from the RBA through to end-2027 at present.
- The USD received a solid bid overnight, buoyed by sharp inflows into AI and tech stocks that improved risk sentiment. The DXY finished 0.7% higher at around 102.9, the strongest since April 2025. That move has pushed the Euro down 0.6% back to a USD1.10 handle, the weakest since May 2025, while the Yen slipped 0.7% to JPY159.9, the weakest since the before the early-September rally. While moves in the AUD was comparatively small overnight, slipping 0.2% to around the USD0.6850 mark, that move builds on recent downward momentum and has the currency delicately positioned near 2026's lows.
- Oil prices rose slightly overnight, stabilising somewhat after recent declines amid ongoing uncertainty around the future of the US-Iran War, as President Trump downplays the possibility of further strikes on Iran all while negotiations show little progress. Brent rose 1.0% to US$92.4/bbl. The rebound in risk sentiment buoyed metals, with LME copper up 1.0% to US$13,817/mt while LME aluminium jumped 1.9% to US$3,068/mt. Gold prices meanwhile dipped 1.2%, falling back below the US$4,000/oz mark, building on recent momentum post US CPI which saw real yields jump higher

Today's key data and events

Time	Event	Exp	Prev
8:45	NZ Card Spending Oct	-	-0.5%
8:45	NZ Net Migration Sep	-	1530k
18:00	GB GDP Q3 Prel.	0.7%	0.5%
18:00	GB Trade Balance Sep	-£2100b	-£920b
0:30	US Initial Jobless Claims 7/11/2026	195k	189k
2:00	US Existing Home Sales Oct	-3.5%	1.5%

Times are AEDT. All data forecasts are m/m or q/q and seasonally adjusted unless otherwise specified. Forecasts for Australian data are our forecasts and for other countries they are consensus forecasts.

International Data

There was no major data out yesterday.

Domestic Data

In Australia, the value of **dwelling finance approvals** surprised materially to the downside in Q3, the 15.5% decline marking the largest quarterly decline on records going back to 1991. The decline looks to be mostly volume-driven, with the number of loans falling sharply compared to the average size of loans. Across segments, investor lending values dropped by nearly a third (see here).

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12 November 2026

MORNING REPORT

Today's economic developments and market movements.

Key themes

Renewed optimism around AI drove US equities higher overnight, with positive developments around CoreWeave and Anthropic adding to enthusiasm around the sector and helping the S&P 500 and NASDAQ rally.

US cash bond markets were closed for Veterans Day, though futures continued to point to higher Treasury yields following this week's hotter-than-expected inflation data, which has all but cemented a December FOMC hike, with another two increases priced over 2027.

The US dollar received a solid bid alongside renewed strength in AI and tech stocks, lifting the DXY 0.7% to its highest since April 2025, while the Aussie slipped to around USD0.6850.

Australian dwelling finance approvals surprised materially to the downside in Q3, with the value of approvals plunging a record 15.5% as investor lending values dropped by nearly a third.

Data snapshot

FX Last 24 hrs	Current	Change
TWI	63.8	-0.5%
AUD/USD	0.6850	-0.2%
AUD/JPY	109.50	0.5%
AUD/GBP	0.5159	0.3%
AUD/NZD	1.2308	0.5%
AUD/EUR	0.6176	0.4%
AUD/CNH	4.5719	-0.3%
AUD/SGD	0.8801	0.0%
AUD/HKD	5.3741	-0.2%
AUD/CAD	0.9760	0.2%
EUR/USD	1.1093	-0.6%
USD/JPY	159.85	0.7%
USD Index	102.90	0.7%

AUS Interest Rate Swaps	Last	Change
30 day BBSY	4.86	0.01
90 day BBSY	4.99	0.01
180 day BBSY	5.35	0.03
1 year swap	4.95	0.01
2 year swap	4.82	0.02
3 year swap	4.76	0.02
4 year swap	4.74	0.01
5 year swap	4.76	0.01
6 year swap	4.80	0.01
7 year swap	4.84	0.01
8 year swap	4.88	0.01
9 year swap	4.93	0.01
10 year swap	4.96	0.00

Equities	Close	Change
S&P/ASX 200	9,153	0.3%
S&P 500	7,626	1.4%
Japan Nikkei	61,249	1.3%
Hang Seng	24,316	-1.0%
Euro Stoxx 50	6,393	1.0%
UK FTSE100	10,835	0.8%
VIX Index	17.4	-10.6%

Government Bond Yields	Close	Change
Australia		
3 year bond	4.73	0.07
10 year bond	5.04	0.06
United States		
3-month T Bill	4.11	-0.01
2 year bond	4.74	0.00
10 year bond	4.99	0.00
Other (10 year yields)		
Germany	3.32	0.00
Japan	2.80	0.11
UK	5.22	0.00

Commodities	Current	Change
CRB Index	386.48	0.7%
Gold	3985.69	-1.2%
Copper	13817	1.0%
Oil (WTI futures)	86.31	0.3%
Coal (coking)	253.50	-0.2%
Coal (thermal)	143.40	3.3%
Iron Ore	91.25	-0.4%
ACCU	36.13	-4.3%

Sydney Futures Exchange	Current	Change
10 yr bond	5.05	0.00
3 yr bond	4.73	0.01
3 mth bill rate	4.77	0.00
SPI 200	9,158	-0.4%

Data as at 7:30am AEDT. Change is from the previous trading day (excluding the SFE, which is the change during the night session). Source: Bloomberg.

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Financial Markets

- Share markets rallied across much of the globe. In the US, reports of an upgraded outlook for CoreWeave, an oversubscribed IPO for Anthropic and a stabilisation in Nvidia supported renewed optimism around AI which buoyed tech stocks, seeing the S&P 500 (+1.4%) and Nasdaq (+1.7%) both rally, though the smaller gain for the Dow Jones (+0.5%) shows the rally was more narrowly based.
- Across the pond, the Euro Stoxx 50 continued to build on recent momentum with another solid gain (+1.0%), while London's FTSE 100 bounced back from a modest decline yesterday (+0.8%). Stocks were up across most of Asia, including Tokyo (+1.3%), Shanghai (+0.4%) and Seoul (+2.6%), with only the Hang Seng (–1.0%) bucking the wider trend. The ASX 200 rose 0.3% yesterday, but weaker trading in futures overnight points to a mixed open this morning.
- Cash trading in bond markets were closed in the US for Veterans Day, but trading in futures points to a continued rise in yields following hotter-than-expected inflation data received earlier in the week, which all but cemented a December FOMC rate hike. Beyond December, markets are also pricing in another two rate hikes over the course of 2027.
- Yields were little changed elsewhere, with the 10Y Bund and Gilt steady on the day. The 10Y JGB meanwhile continued to sell-off, with yields jumping 10bps to 2.80% having effectively unwound the rally over late last week. ACGBs were also weaker during local trading, seeing yields rise 7bps on the 3Y and 6bps on the 10Y, following the sharp rise in global yields the day prior post US CPI. Swaps markets point to no hikes nor cuts from the RBA through to end-2027 at present.
- The USD received a solid bid overnight, buoyed by sharp inflows into AI and tech stocks that improved risk sentiment. The DXY finished 0.7% higher at around 102.9, the strongest since April 2025. That move has pushed the Euro down 0.6% back to a USD1.10 handle, the weakest since May 2025, while the Yen slipped 0.7% to JPY159.9, the weakest since the before the early-September rally. While moves in the AUD was comparatively small overnight, slipping 0.2% to around the USD0.6850 mark, that move builds on recent downward momentum and has the currency delicately positioned near 2026's lows.
- Oil prices rose slightly overnight, stabilising somewhat after recent declines amid ongoing uncertainty around the future of the US-Iran War, as President Trump downplays the possibility of further strikes on Iran all while negotiations show little progress. Brent rose 1.0% to US$92.4/bbl. The rebound in risk sentiment buoyed metals, with LME copper up 1.0% to US$13,817/mt while LME aluminium jumped 1.9% to US$3,068/mt. Gold prices meanwhile dipped 1.2%, falling back below the US$4,000/oz mark, building on recent momentum post US CPI which saw real yields jump higher

Today's key data and events

Time	Event	Exp	Prev
8:45	NZ Card Spending Oct	-	-0.5%
8:45	NZ Net Migration Sep	-	1530k
18:00	GB GDP Q3 Prel.	0.7%	0.5%
18:00	GB Trade Balance Sep	-£2100b	-£920b
0:30	US Initial Jobless Claims 7/11/2026	195k	189k
2:00	US Existing Home Sales Oct	-3.5%	1.5%

Times are AEDT. All data forecasts are m/m or q/q and seasonally adjusted unless otherwise specified. Forecasts for Australian data are our forecasts and for other countries they are consensus forecasts.

International Data

There was no major data out yesterday.

Domestic Data

In Australia, the value of **dwelling finance approvals** surprised materially to the downside in Q3, the 15.5% decline marking the largest quarterly decline on records going back to 1991. The decline looks to be mostly volume-driven, with the number of loans falling sharply compared to the average size of loans. Across segments, investor lending values dropped by nearly a third (see here).

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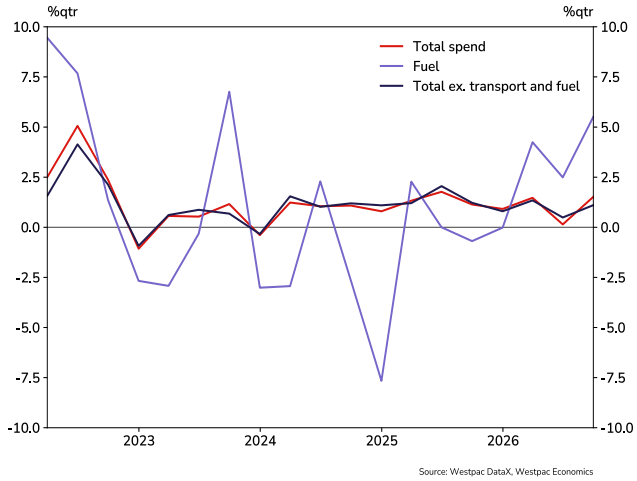
3 November 2026

CONSUMER PANEL Q3 2026
MORE RESILIENCE

Powered by DataX

- Average consumer spend across the **Westpac-DataX Consumer Panel** remained resilient, rising 1.5% in Q3 and 4.6%yr.
- While some of this reflected a price-driven surge in fuel spend (+0.3%qtr) discretionary categories also posted robust gains (contributing 0.9ppts to the headline rise) with non-fuel essential categories contributing positively as well (+0.5ptps).
- Households continued to add to savings and buffers. Savings rose 1.3%qtr, led by younger households and mortgagors, with average savings buffers increasing to 22.2 months of mortgage repayments.
- The detail shows financial pressures remain uneven but spending patterns appear to be converging across consumers with low, medium and high buffers. Much of this appears to relate to a reduction in fuel consumption.

Fuel and non-fuel spending lift



Source: Westpac DataX, Westpac Economics

Westpac–DataX Consumer Panel

The Westpac–DataX Consumer Panel is a large dataset that gives a timely and detailed picture of Australian consumer finances and behaviour. Developed by DataX, Westpac's data analytics team, the dataset links transaction activity with balance sheet information to give a complete view of income, spending, saving and borrowing flows.

All data is de-identified and aggregated to ensure privacy. The resulting sample of over one million customers gives an accurate representation of trends across the wider Australian consumer and is perfectly suited to quickly tracing responses to events like interest rate moves and energy price shocks.

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Solid rise in non-fuel spend and financial buffers

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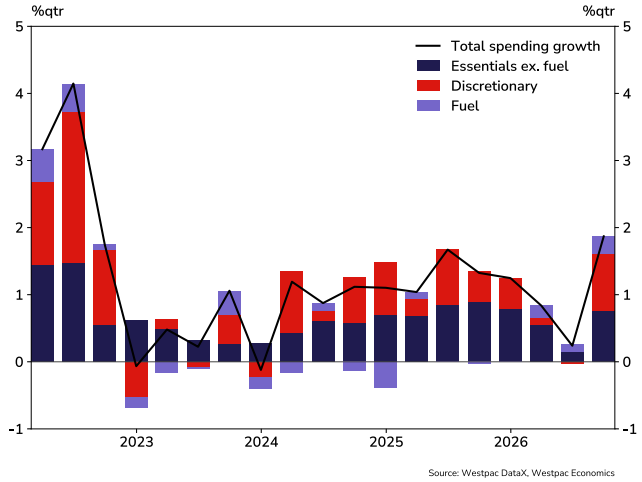
The Westpac DataX Consumer Panel shows average consumer spending remained resilient in Q3, rising 1.5% despite a further lift in fuel costs. Fuel contributed 0.3ppts to quarterly growth, but discretionary spending did more of the heavy lifting, contributing 0.9ppts as recreation and travel-related spending recovered. Households also continued to add to their financial buffers: savings up 1.3% in the quarter and average buffers across households with a mortgage increasing to 22.2 months of repayments. Beneath the aggregate picture, lower-buffer households remain more exposed to higher fuel costs and mortgage repayments, but their discretionary spending share is looking increasingly similar to other households.

Spending holds up despite higher fuel costs

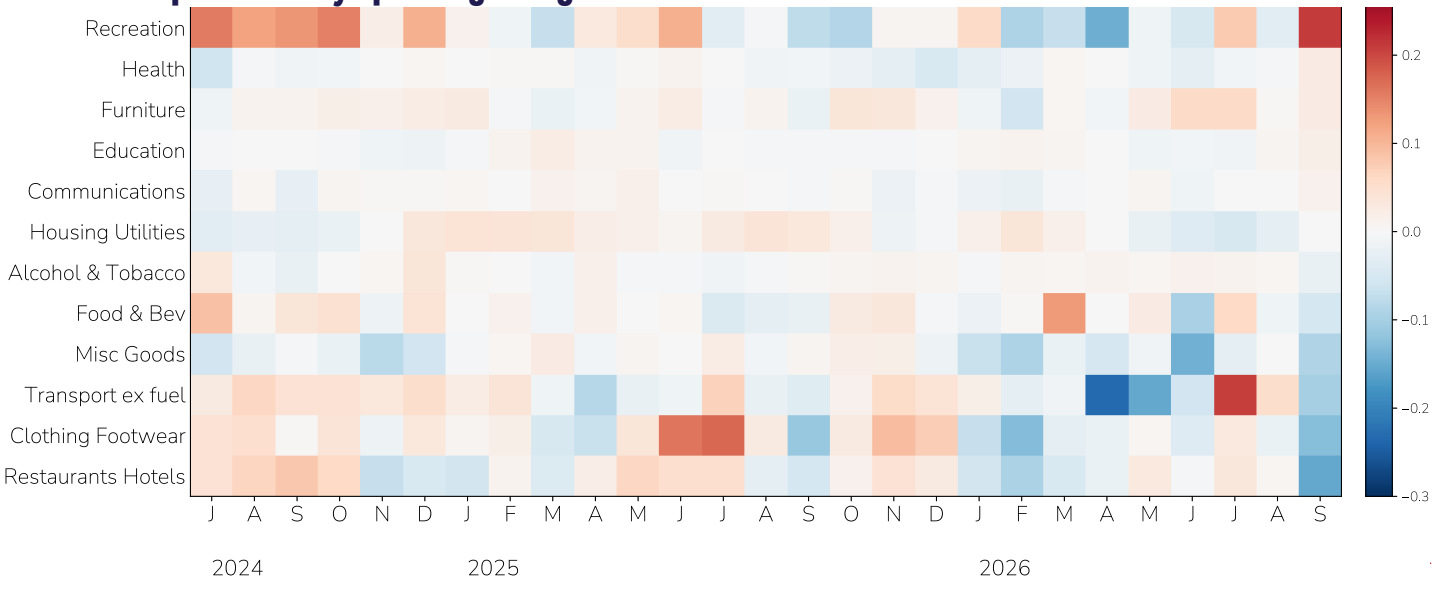
Average household spending increased 1.5% in Q3, with much of the strength again driven by transport-related spending. Fuel contributed 0.3ppts to quarterly growth, while transport excluding fuel contributed a further 0.4ppts. Excluding the direct effects of the price-driven lift in fuel, average spend was up 1.2%qtr. Importantly, stronger fuel spending did not come at the expense of discretionary purchases. Discretionary categories contributed 0.9ppts to quarterly spending growth, compared with 0.5ppts from non-fuel essentials.

Discretionary spending dominates



Recreation and culture contributed 0.3ppts to growth, reflecting stronger spending on sporting services, while restaurants and hotels added a further 0.2ppts. Transport spending was also boosted by a rebound in airline expenditure, which more than unwound the weakness recorded in Q2 when refunds relating to cancellations due to conflict in the Middle East weighed on the category. Discretionary spending rose 0.9%qtr, following a flat result and a 0.1% rise in the previous two quarters.

Heatmap of monthly spending categories



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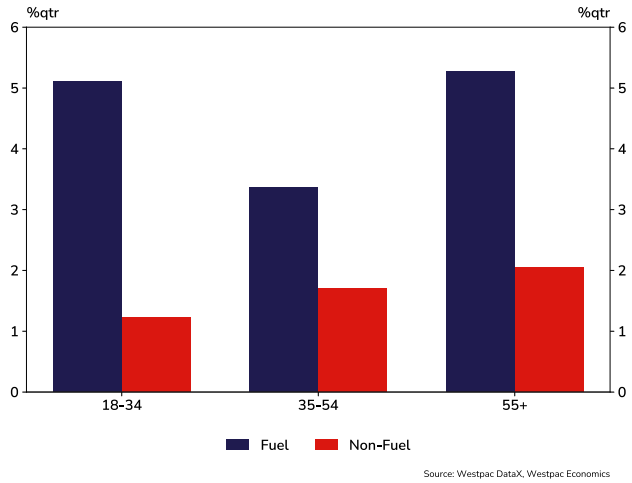
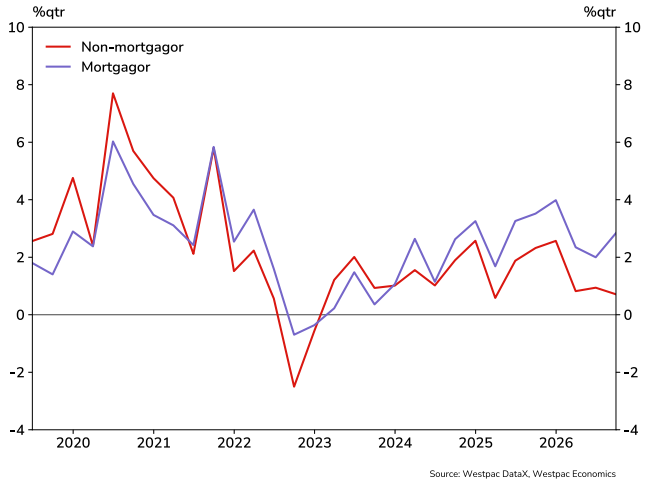
Fuel spending a clear drag on consumers



Source: Westpac DataX, Westpac Economics

Savings growth by mortgage status



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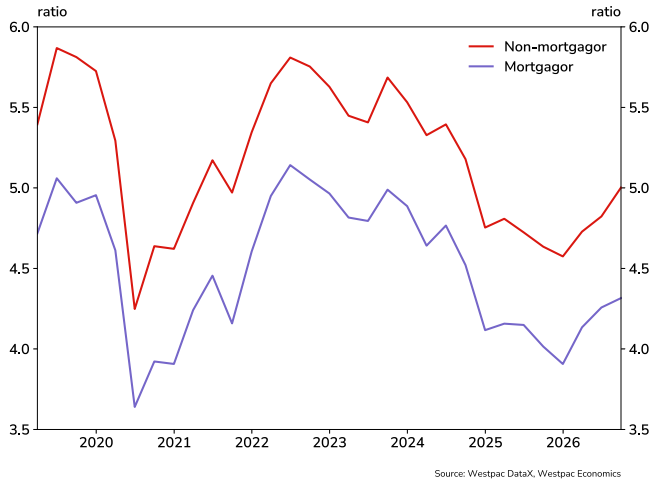
Fuel spending as a share of total spending



Source: Westpac DataX, Westpac Economics

Spending outcomes continued to vary across age groups.

The squeeze remains most apparent among younger households. Fuel spending rose 5.1%qtr for 18–34 year olds, against a 1.5%qtr increase in non-fuel spending. By contrast, non-fuel spending increased 2.1%qtr among households aged 55 and over.

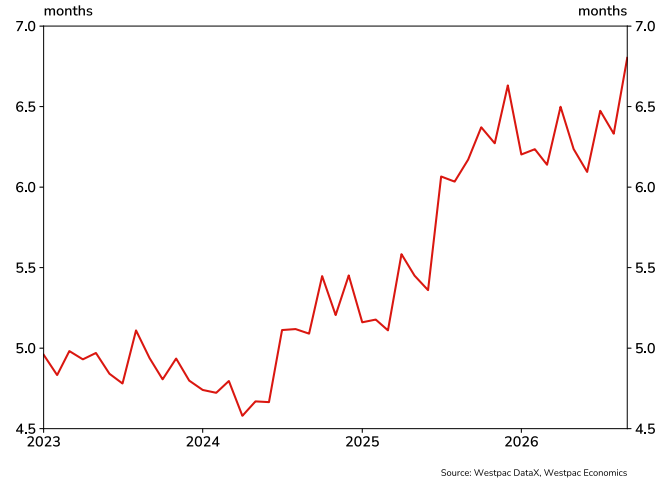
The gap between mortgagors and non-mortgagors was more modest. Spending rose 1.6%qtr among mortgagors and 1.9%qtr among those without a mortgage, suggesting mortgage status alone masks considerable variation in household financial positions – a divide that becomes clearer when households are grouped by the size of their mortgage buffers (see discussion further on in this note). Note that 'non mortgagors' covers a diverse range of consumers including those that are renting and those that own their homes without a mortgage.

Households continue to rebuild savings

Savings increased 1.3% in Q3, with the strongest gains again recorded among younger households. Savings balances for 18–34 year olds increased 2.0%qtr, compared with 0.7% for those aged 55 and over. Mortgagors also continued to accumulate savings more rapidly, recording a 2.8% increase compared with 0.7% among non-mortgagors. Savings growth among mortgagors has now outpaced non-mortgagors for three consecutive years.

Stronger savings have continued to lift mortgage buffers. Average buffers (savings divided by the sum of essential expenses and minimum mortgage repayments), increased to 22.2 months of repayments in September. Looking within the unit-record sample, median mortgage buffers jumped from 6.3 months in August to 6.8 months, its highest level since the series began in 2019.

Median mortgage buffers



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This suggests that in aggregate, household balance sheets are looking healthy. The picture is a little at odds with the very weak reads on our **Westpac-Melbourne Index Consumer Sentiment Index** which suggests finances are coming under much more pressure. The fact that both average spending and saving both rose suggests incomes over the quarter were not overly stretched and that more of the weakness in sentiment may relate to concerns about the outlook (something that may also be encouraging consumers to build buffers now, while they still can).

Pressures intense for low-buffer households

Aggregate buffer measures mask sizeable differences across mortgagors. We can get a sense of these variations by combining mortgagors into three broad groups according to buffer size, i.e. low, middle and high buffer groups. This shows that households with the smallest buffers are also more exposed to both interest rates and fuel costs.

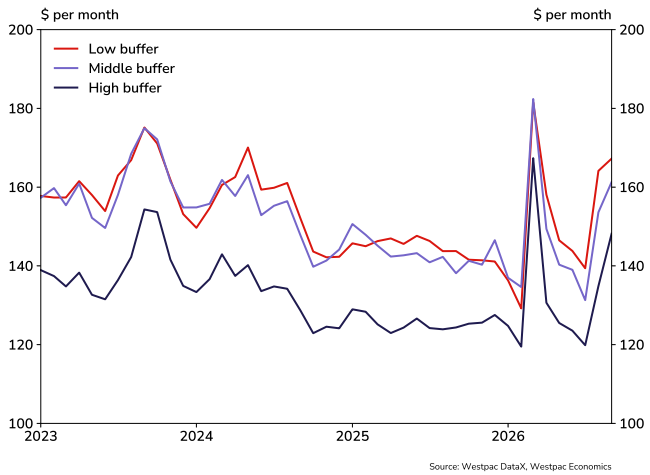
The buffer differences are relatively stark, the median savings of the low-buffer group just $2k compared to $15k for the middle-buffer group and $95k for the high buffer group.

Low buffer households face median minimum mortgage repayments of around $2,600 a month, compared with $2,400 for the middle buffer group and $2,200 for the highest-buffer group.

Low buffer households also spend more on fuel, at around $170 a month compared with $160 for the middle buffer group and $150 for the high buffer group.

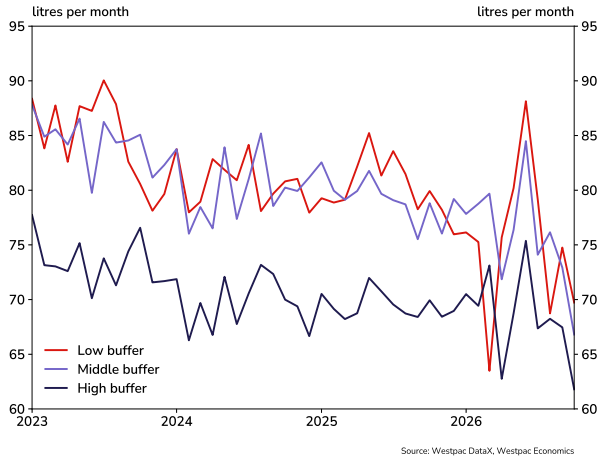
We can use average pump prices to estimate what this expenditure implies for fuel volumes. Low-buffer households consume around 70 litres a month, middle-buffer households 67 litres a month and the high-buffer group around 62 litres. This compares to an average of 81, 80 and 70 respectively through 2024-25.

Median fuel spend by customer



Source: Westpac DataX, Westpac Economics

Median litres of fuel consumed



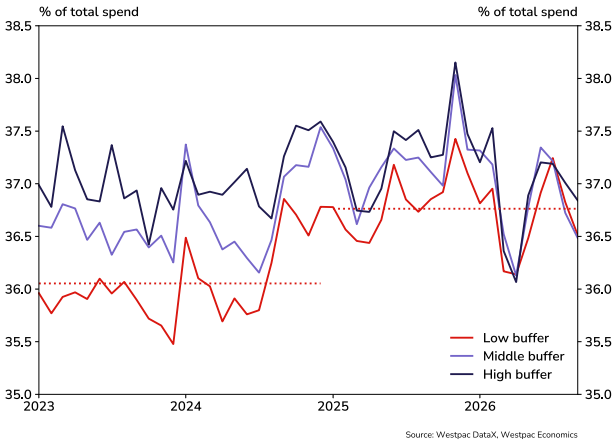
Source: Westpac DataX, Westpac Economics

More importantly, their consumption appears to be less responsive to price movements. During periods of cheaper fuel, high-buffer households show a noticeably larger lift in litres purchased, consistent with stockpiling when prices are favourable. Low-buffer households show much less of this response, while their fuel volumes have also adjusted less during the recent increase in fuel costs.

The spending data show the consequence. Fuel expenditure has risen sharply across all three groups recently, but remains highest among low-buffer households, where it also absorbs a larger share of total spending. Food spending has also declined since 2023. This may partly reflect households economising within the category, including switching towards cheaper or home-brand products, although further work is needed to test this.

Taken together, the households with the smallest savings cushions face higher mortgage repayments, spend more on fuel and appear to have less scope to adjust their fuel consumption when prices change.

Discretionary spend as a share of total



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Yet despite this greater exposure, the gap in broader spending behaviour has narrowed. High-buffer households continue to spend more on discretionary categories, averaging around $1,940 a month compared with $1,740 for low-buffer households. However, their discretionary share has been broadly stable since 2023, while the shares of low- and middle-buffer households have risen by close to a percentage point bringing them more in line with the high-buffer group.

Some of the convergence reflects a longer run down-trend in fuel spending that has been more pronounced amongst low and middle buffer households. This lowering in fuel spend lifts the share available for other categories.

Essential spending excluding fuel, meanwhile, has changed little across the three cohorts since 2023. The shift in spending patterns has largely occurred on the discretionary side.

The result is a somewhat mixed picture. Low-buffer households remain considerably more exposed to mortgage and fuel costs and have far smaller savings cushions. But their discretionary spending has nevertheless moved closer to that of better-buffered households, suggesting some recovery in spending flexibility despite these constraints.

Conclusion

Aggregate household finances remain resilient: spending and savings both increased in Q3 and mortgage buffers continued to rebuild. Discretionary spending has also held up despite the sharp increase in fuel costs.

But aggregate resilience masks a much more uneven distribution of pressure. Low-buffer households simultaneously face higher mortgage repayments, greater fuel exposure and much smaller savings cushions. While these households have so far maintained discretionary spending, their capacity to absorb further pressure is clearly more limited.

About the Westpac-DataX Consumer Panel

Developed by DataX, Westpac's data analytics service for institutional and business banking customers, the dataset links transaction activity with balance sheet information to give a complete view of income, spending, saving and borrowing flows.

The resulting sample of over one million customers provides an accurate representation of trends across the wider Australian consumer. Monthly observations are available back to January 2019 with timely updates provided a few weeks after the end of each month. As such, it is perfectly suited to quickly tracing the impact and responses to events like interest rate moves and energy price shocks.

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12 November 2026

MORNING REPORT

Today's economic developments and market movements.

Key themes

Renewed optimism around AI drove US equities higher overnight, with positive developments around CoreWeave and Anthropic adding to enthusiasm around the sector and helping the S&P 500 and NASDAQ rally.

US cash bond markets were closed for Veterans Day, though futures continued to point to higher Treasury yields following this week's hotter-than-expected inflation data, which has all but cemented a December FOMC hike, with another two increases priced over 2027.

The US dollar received a solid bid alongside renewed strength in AI and tech stocks, lifting the DXY 0.7% to its highest since April 2025, while the Aussie slipped to around USD0.6850.

Australian dwelling finance approvals surprised materially to the downside in Q3, with the value of approvals plunging a record 15.5% as investor lending values dropped by nearly a third.

Data snapshot

FX Last 24 hrs	Current	Change
TWI	63.8	-0.5%
AUD/USD	0.6850	-0.2%
AUD/JPY	109.50	0.5%
AUD/GBP	0.5159	0.3%
AUD/NZD	1.2308	0.5%
AUD/EUR	0.6176	0.4%
AUD/CNH	4.5719	-0.3%
AUD/SGD	0.8801	0.0%
AUD/HKD	5.3741	-0.2%
AUD/CAD	0.9760	0.2%
EUR/USD	1.1093	-0.6%
USD/JPY	159.85	0.7%
USD Index	102.90	0.7%

AUS Interest Rate Swaps	Last	Change
30 day BBSY	4.86	0.01
90 day BBSY	4.99	0.01
180 day BBSY	5.35	0.03
1 year swap	4.95	0.01
2 year swap	4.82	0.02
3 year swap	4.76	0.02
4 year swap	4.74	0.01
5 year swap	4.76	0.01
6 year swap	4.80	0.01
7 year swap	4.84	0.01
8 year swap	4.88	0.01
9 year swap	4.93	0.01
10 year swap	4.96	0.00

Equities	Close	Change
S&P/ASX 200	9,153	0.3%
S&P 500	7,626	1.4%
Japan Nikkei	61,249	1.3%
Hang Seng	24,316	-1.0%
Euro Stoxx 50	6,393	1.0%
UK FTSE100	10,835	0.8%
VIX Index	17.4	-10.6%

Government Bond Yields	Close	Change
Australia		
3 year bond	4.73	0.07
10 year bond	5.04	0.06
United States		
3-month T Bill	4.11	-0.01
2 year bond	4.74	0.00
10 year bond	4.99	0.00
Other (10 year yields)		
Germany	3.32	0.00
Japan	2.80	0.11
UK	5.22	0.00

Commodities	Current	Change
CRB Index	386.48	0.7%
Gold	3985.69	-1.2%
Copper	13817	1.0%
Oil (WTI futures)	86.31	0.3%
Coal (coking)	253.50	-0.2%
Coal (thermal)	143.40	3.3%
Iron Ore	91.25	-0.4%
ACCU	36.13	-4.3%

Sydney Futures Exchange	Current	Change
10 yr bond	5.05	0.00
3 yr bond	4.73	0.01
3 mth bill rate	4.77	0.00
SPI 200	9,158	-0.4%

Data as at 7:30am AEDT. Change is from the previous trading day (excluding the SFE, which is the change during the night session). Source: Bloomberg.

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Financial Markets

- Share markets rallied across much of the globe. In the US, reports of an upgraded outlook for CoreWeave, an oversubscribed IPO for Anthropic and a stabilisation in Nvidia supported renewed optimism around AI which buoyed tech stocks, seeing the S&P 500 (+1.4%) and Nasdaq (+1.7%) both rally, though the smaller gain for the Dow Jones (+0.5%) shows the rally was more narrowly based.
- Across the pond, the Euro Stoxx 50 continued to build on recent momentum with another solid gain (+1.0%), while London's FTSE 100 bounced back from a modest decline yesterday (+0.8%). Stocks were up across most of Asia, including Tokyo (+1.3%), Shanghai (+0.4%) and Seoul (+2.6%), with only the Hang Seng (–1.0%) bucking the wider trend. The ASX 200 rose 0.3% yesterday, but weaker trading in futures overnight points to a mixed open this morning.
- Cash trading in bond markets were closed in the US for Veterans Day, but trading in futures points to a continued rise in yields following hotter-than-expected inflation data received earlier in the week, which all but cemented a December FOMC rate hike. Beyond December, markets are also pricing in another two rate hikes over the course of 2027.
- Yields were little changed elsewhere, with the 10Y Bund and Gilt steady on the day. The 10Y JGB meanwhile continued to sell-off, with yields jumping 10bps to 2.80% having effectively unwound the rally over late last week. ACGBs were also weaker during local trading, seeing yields rise 7bps on the 3Y and 6bps on the 10Y, following the sharp rise in global yields the day prior post US CPI. Swaps markets point to no hikes nor cuts from the RBA through to end-2027 at present.
- The USD received a solid bid overnight, buoyed by sharp inflows into AI and tech stocks that improved risk sentiment. The DXY finished 0.7% higher at around 102.9, the strongest since April 2025. That move has pushed the Euro down 0.6% back to a USD1.10 handle, the weakest since May 2025, while the Yen slipped 0.7% to JPY159.9, the weakest since the before the early-September rally. While moves in the AUD was comparatively small overnight, slipping 0.2% to around the USD0.6850 mark, that move builds on recent downward momentum and has the currency delicately positioned near 2026's lows.
- Oil prices rose slightly overnight, stabilising somewhat after recent declines amid ongoing uncertainty around the future of the US-Iran War, as President Trump downplays the possibility of further strikes on Iran all while negotiations show little progress. Brent rose 1.0% to US$92.4/bbl. The rebound in risk sentiment buoyed metals, with LME copper up 1.0% to US$13,817/mt while LME aluminium jumped 1.9% to US$3,068/mt. Gold prices meanwhile dipped 1.2%, falling back below the US$4,000/oz mark, building on recent momentum post US CPI which saw real yields jump higher

Today's key data and events

Time	Event	Exp	Prev
8:45	NZ Card Spending Oct	-	-0.5%
8:45	NZ Net Migration Sep	-	1530k
18:00	GB GDP Q3 Prel.	0.7%	0.5%
18:00	GB Trade Balance Sep	-£2100b	-£920b
0:30	US Initial Jobless Claims 7/11/2026	195k	189k
2:00	US Existing Home Sales Oct	-3.5%	1.5%

Times are AEDT. All data forecasts are m/m or q/q and seasonally adjusted unless otherwise specified. Forecasts for Australian data are our forecasts and for other countries they are consensus forecasts.

International Data

There was no major data out yesterday.

Domestic Data

In Australia, the value of **dwelling finance approvals** surprised materially to the downside in Q3, the 15.5% decline marking the largest quarterly decline on records going back to 1991. The decline looks to be mostly volume-driven, with the number of loans falling sharply compared to the average size of loans. Across segments, investor lending values dropped by nearly a third (see here).

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Australian dwelling finance approvals surprised materially to the downside in Q3, with the value of approvals plunging a record 15.5% as investor lending values dropped by nearly a third.

Data snapshot

FX Last 24 hrs	Current	Change
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AUD/SGD	0.8801	0.0%
AUD/HKD	5.3741	-0.2%
AUD/CAD	0.9760	0.2%
EUR/USD	1.1093	-0.6%
USD/JPY	159.85	0.7%
USD Index	102.90	0.7%

AUS Interest Rate Swaps	Last	Change
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Financial Markets

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- Across the pond, the Euro Stoxx 50 continued to build on recent momentum with another solid gain (+1.0%), while London's FTSE 100 bounced back from a modest decline yesterday (+0.8%). Stocks were up across most of Asia, including Tokyo (+1.3%), Shanghai (+0.4%) and Seoul (+2.6%), with only the Hang Seng (–1.0%) bucking the wider trend. The ASX 200 rose 0.3% yesterday, but weaker trading in futures overnight points to a mixed open this morning.
- Cash trading in bond markets were closed in the US for Veterans Day, but trading in futures points to a continued rise in yields following hotter-than-expected inflation data received earlier in the week, which all but cemented a December FOMC rate hike. Beyond December, markets are also pricing in another two rate hikes over the course of 2027.
- Yields were little changed elsewhere, with the 10Y Bund and Gilt steady on the day. The 10Y JGB meanwhile continued to sell-off, with yields jumping 10bps to 2.80% having effectively unwound the rally over late last week. ACGBs were also weaker during local trading, seeing yields rise 7bps on the 3Y and 6bps on the 10Y, following the sharp rise in global yields the day prior post US CPI. Swaps markets point to no hikes nor cuts from the RBA through to end-2027 at present.
- The USD received a solid bid overnight, buoyed by sharp inflows into AI and tech stocks that improved risk sentiment. The DXY finished 0.7% higher at around 102.9, the strongest since April 2025. That move has pushed the Euro down 0.6% back to a USD1.10 handle, the weakest since May 2025, while the Yen slipped 0.7% to JPY159.9, the weakest since the before the early-September rally. While moves in the AUD was comparatively small overnight, slipping 0.2% to around the USD0.6850 mark, that move builds on recent downward momentum and has the currency delicately positioned near 2026's lows.
- Oil prices rose slightly overnight, stabilising somewhat after recent declines amid ongoing uncertainty around the future of the US-Iran War, as President Trump downplays the possibility of further strikes on Iran all while negotiations show little progress. Brent rose 1.0% to US$92.4/bbl. The rebound in risk sentiment buoyed metals, with LME copper up 1.0% to US$13,817/mt while LME aluminium jumped 1.9% to US$3,068/mt. Gold prices meanwhile dipped 1.2%, falling back below the US$4,000/oz mark, building on recent momentum post US CPI which saw real yields jump higher

Today's key data and events

Time	Event	Exp	Prev
8:45	NZ Card Spending Oct	-	-0.5%
8:45	NZ Net Migration Sep	-	1530k
18:00	GB GDP Q3 Prel.	0.7%	0.5%
18:00	GB Trade Balance Sep	-£2100b	-£920b
0:30	US Initial Jobless Claims 7/11/2026	195k	189k
2:00	US Existing Home Sales Oct	-3.5%	1.5%

Times are AEDT. All data forecasts are m/m or q/q and seasonally adjusted unless otherwise specified. Forecasts for Australian data are our forecasts and for other countries they are consensus forecasts.

International Data

There was no major data out yesterday.

Domestic Data

In Australia, the value of **dwelling finance approvals** surprised materially to the downside in Q3, the 15.5% decline marking the largest quarterly decline on records going back to 1991. The decline looks to be mostly volume-driven, with the number of loans falling sharply compared to the average size of loans. Across segments, investor lending values dropped by nearly a third (see here).

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- Share markets rallied across much of the globe. In the US, reports of an upgraded outlook for CoreWeave, an oversubscribed IPO for Anthropic and a stabilisation in Nvidia supported renewed optimism around AI which buoyed tech stocks, seeing the S&P 500 (+1.4%) and Nasdaq (+1.7%) both rally, though the smaller gain for the Dow Jones (+0.5%) shows the rally was more narrowly based.
- Across the pond, the Euro Stoxx 50 continued to build on recent momentum with another solid gain (+1.0%), while London's FTSE 100 bounced back from a modest decline yesterday (+0.8%). Stocks were up across most of Asia, including Tokyo (+1.3%), Shanghai (+0.4%) and Seoul (+2.6%), with only the Hang Seng (–1.0%) bucking the wider trend. The ASX 200 rose 0.3% yesterday, but weaker trading in futures overnight points to a mixed open this morning.
- Cash trading in bond markets were closed in the US for Veterans Day, but trading in futures points to a continued rise in yields following hotter-than-expected inflation data received earlier in the week, which all but cemented a December FOMC rate hike. Beyond December, markets are also pricing in another two rate hikes over the course of 2027.
- Yields were little changed elsewhere, with the 10Y Bund and Gilt steady on the day. The 10Y JGB meanwhile continued to sell-off, with yields jumping 10bps to 2.80% having effectively unwound the rally over late last week. ACGBs were also weaker during local trading, seeing yields rise 7bps on the 3Y and 6bps on the 10Y, following the sharp rise in global yields the day prior post US CPI. Swaps markets point to no hikes nor cuts from the RBA through to end-2027 at present.
- The USD received a solid bid overnight, buoyed by sharp inflows into AI and tech stocks that improved risk sentiment. The DXY finished 0.7% higher at around 102.9, the strongest since April 2025. That move has pushed the Euro down 0.6% back to a USD1.10 handle, the weakest since May 2025, while the Yen slipped 0.7% to JPY159.9, the weakest since the before the early-September rally. While moves in the AUD was comparatively small overnight, slipping 0.2% to around the USD0.6850 mark, that move builds on recent downward momentum and has the currency delicately positioned near 2026's lows.
- Oil prices rose slightly overnight, stabilising somewhat after recent declines amid ongoing uncertainty around the future of the US-Iran War, as President Trump downplays the possibility of further strikes on Iran all while negotiations show little progress. Brent rose 1.0% to US$92.4/bbl. The rebound in risk sentiment buoyed metals, with LME copper up 1.0% to US$13,817/mt while LME aluminium jumped 1.9% to US$3,068/mt. Gold prices meanwhile dipped 1.2%, falling back below the US$4,000/oz mark, building on recent momentum post US CPI which saw real yields jump higher

Today's key data and events

Time	Event	Exp	Prev
8:45	NZ Card Spending Oct	-	-0.5%
8:45	NZ Net Migration Sep	-	1530k
18:00	GB GDP Q3 Prel.	0.7%	0.5%
18:00	GB Trade Balance Sep	-£2100b	-£920b
0:30	US Initial Jobless Claims 7/11/2026	195k	189k
2:00	US Existing Home Sales Oct	-3.5%	1.5%

Times are AEDT. All data forecasts are m/m or q/q and seasonally adjusted unless otherwise specified. Forecasts for Australian data are our forecasts and for other countries they are consensus forecasts.

International Data

There was no major data out yesterday.

Domestic Data

In Australia, the value of **dwelling finance approvals** surprised materially to the downside in Q3, the 15.5% decline marking the largest quarterly decline on records going back to 1991. The decline looks to be mostly volume-driven, with the number of loans falling sharply compared to the average size of loans. Across segments, investor lending values dropped by nearly a third (see here).

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Open mouth operations

#australia #luciellis #rba

By Luci Ellis
Chief Economist Westpac Group, Westpac

13:34 October 23 2026

Share

The RBA does not want to promise what it will do, but it is increasingly trying to tell us what it thinks.

- Central banks' communication is carefully scrutinised for every nuance. Lately, there seems to have been more RBA communication to pore over. The method of delivery has also evolved. This has

sometimes caused confusion when tone seems to vary. Different audiences call for different tone and varying complexity.

- The content has evolved, too. RBA officials are increasingly using speeches directed to professional audiences to discuss more technical estimates of inferred variables such as neutral rates and financial conditions. They are also highlighting that monetary policy combats inflation in more ways than just squeezing mortgage holders.
- One thing has not changed: the RBA is not in the business of providing 'forward guidance' promises about the future path of interest rates. It does, however, give more running commentary about how it is interpreting recent data. These interpretations are themselves useful signals about what the RBA thinks it might do.

Market participants pore over every utterance by central banks for clues to future rate moves. They will have plenty to pore over in the run-up to the November RBA decision. After the flurry of fireside chats this week, '60 Minutes' will run a pre-recorded interview with chief economist Sarah Hunter on Sunday. Next Wednesday, the whole senior policy team will appear before Senate Estimates, just as the quarterly CPI is released. (This timing will have been the Senate's choice, not the RBA's.) After the decision will come the *Statement on Monetary Policy*, a media release and press conference. More speeches will follow, including one by the Deputy Governor on the Thursday.

RBA communication does seem to have changed, not just following the RBA Review but also more recently. There may be fewer policy meetings each year, but the communication outside that certainly feels more frequent than a couple of years ago. Back in 2024, speaking engagements felt a little sparse outside the post-meeting media conference and parliamentary appearances. We have counted 58 public engagements so far this year on the Speeches page on the RBA's website. This compares with 58 for the whole of last year and 52 in 2024. Excluding the 'compulsory' press conferences and parliamentary appearances, fewer than half of the 2024 events were related to economics, markets and monetary policy.

The 'how' has changed

The way the RBA communicates with markets has changed as well. There are fewer set-piece speeches on policy and a lot more semi-scripted 'fireside chats'. Compared with a few years ago, there are more interviews across a wide range of media. This is a big change from the pre-Review world. It was a huge deal when the previous Governor appeared on the *7:30 Report*; it is hard to imagine him agreeing to an Assistant Governor appearing on *60 Minutes*.

Part of the change reflects increased efforts to reach a general audience. Central banks want to explain why they do what they do. This matters especially when interest rates are rising but the household sector is not the source of the inflation.

Speaking differently to different audiences can sometimes confuse markets. As the RBA's Chief Communication Officer highlighted in a recent panel discussion, the post-meeting media conference is designed to speak to the public. Market participants and economists certainly tune in, but we are not

the primary audience. So if you think that what the Governor said in the media conference sounded more ‘dovish’ than what another official says in a more market-oriented forum, it is partly because she is trying to convey that the RBA understands that its recent policy actions are making things harder for many Australians. But this is in much the same way that a doctor might say, “This might hurt a bit.” It does, but that will not stop the treatment.

A related issue is that it is easier to control tone in pre-drafted material such as the minutes and set-piece speeches than in unstructured Q&A. Senior central bankers are trained to be careful with their words in unscripted settings. If the tone differs, the minutes are still more likely to say what the Board really means than an off-the-cuff answer.

Greater communication with the broader public might have reduced the pressure to make the set-piece speeches more accessible. Research on central bank communication often uses measures such as the Flesch–Kincaid Grade Level and Flesch Reading Ease score. A comprehensive analysis was beyond the scope of this note. However, a spot comparison suggests four speeches from 2026 (1, 2, 3, 4) were harder to read than four from 2021 (1, 2, 3, 4). The 2021 speeches scored in the 11 to 12 range, which is high-school-level complexity. The 2026 speeches scored between 12 and 15, which is academic or technically dense text requiring university-level education. (Including two of my own 2021 speeches is an obvious caveat, but the two speeches by then-Governor Phil Lowe also scored better on these metrics than the sample from this year. It should be noted, though, that readability metrics do not necessarily imply better clarity if the concepts discussed are more abstract.)

The ‘what’ has changed

As noted above, the content of RBA communication has evolved, too. As its intellectual framework has begun to put more weight on the balance of supply and demand, and those invisible ‘star’ variables (NAIRUs, neutral real rates, ‘financial conditions’, etc.), the communication to professional audiences has increasingly focused on those topics.

More recently, the RBA has also placed more emphasis on the full range of transmission channels from interest rates to inflation (though not, as we have noted previously, the labour supply channel). This is understandable in a world of supply shocks. People need to understand that monetary policy is not simply an exercise in hitting mortgage borrowers. We doubt they would be comforted, though, by the Deputy Governor’s explanation this week that the ‘cashflow channel’ was the smallest of the transmission channels from interest rates to inflation, with the exchange rate much more prominent. That implies a lot of pain for a small group, for little effect on inflation. It raises the question of whether other policy tools or institutional arrangements might get the same effect on inflation through the other channels without hitting a minority of households disproportionately.

We have also seen a move away from using catchphrases to summarise the position. From ‘narrow path’ to ‘not ruling anything in or out’ to ‘cautious and predictable’, once entrenched, a phrase can outlast its usefulness.

One thing that has not changed is the way the minutes record the presentations to the Board and the members' discussion. The minutes rarely convey much new information beyond the post-meeting statements. Sometimes, though, the minutes reveal the Board's reaction to the staff's analysis. The August 2024 minutes were a good example: the discussion highlighted just how sensitive the forecasts were to key judgements by the staff.

The 'why' has not changed

Despite these changes, the underlying objectives of the RBA's communication have not changed. It wants to explain – and perhaps justify – its decisions. And it wants to describe how it interprets incoming data, especially inflation, the labour market and the balance of supply and demand.

The RBA, like any central bank, is not really in the business of providing 'forward guidance' about future moves. Circumstances change, so it can never guarantee a particular future path for interest rates. Some academic literature argues that promising to keep rates low for a long time (or high, for that matter) independently amplifies the transmission of monetary policy beyond the effect of current-period interest rates alone, by shifting the short end of the yield curve. Central banks including the RBA have certainly tried jawboning in this way from time to time. The prevailing view, though, is that the potential cost of reputational loss if things do not turn out as predicted outweighs the benefits of a slightly stronger transmission mechanism.

In this context, it is the interpretation of data that provides the signal about future policy directions. This is why it was noteworthy that the Governor still characterised the labour market as 'a little tight' after the September meeting, even though the Board's post-meeting communication did not. We have been noting for some time that the RBA staff have a downbeat view of supply capacity. Together with the RBA's oft-stated concerns about inflation, this is why the Deputy Governor's 'hawkishness' did not surprise us.

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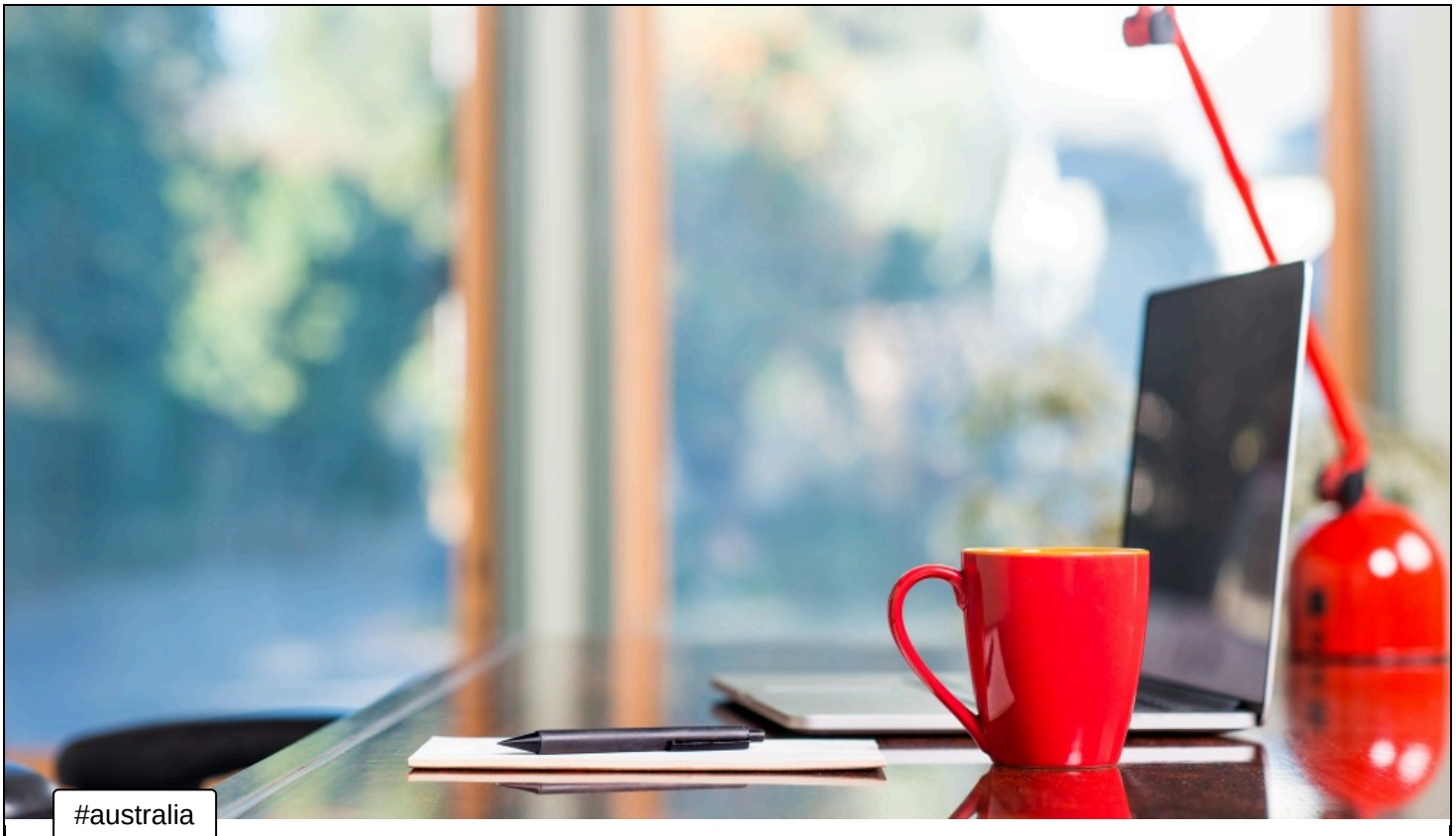
An RBA peak of greater conviction

November 13 2026 • 7 mins

By Luci Ellis



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An RBA peak of greater conviction

#australia #luciellis #rba

By Luci Ellis
Chief Economist Westpac Group, Westpac

08:56 November 13 2026

Share

We already believed the RBA cash rate was likely at a peak, even if RBA officials were less convinced. A deeper housing downturn and early signs of cracks in the consumer sector point to an even softer 2027. Fading inflation risks from oil also boost our conviction on rates being at a peak.

- **It was already our view that the RBA was likely done hiking the cash rate after the November increase. Since then, our conviction on that call has strengthened.** Later today we will publish the November *Market Outlook* with revised forecasts. GDP growth, the labour market and housing market have all been revised down in 2027. Underlying inflation has been revised down slightly in the second half of 2027, bringing the year-ended figure for calendar 2027 more decisively inside the RBA's 2–3% target range than our previous forecast round. The unemployment rate forecast has been revised up to peak above 5%. Based on this revised forecast profile, an increase in the cash rate from here would be unlikely and – we would argue – undesirable.
- A range of considerations underlie this forecast revision. **The housing market has undershot our forecasts over the past couple of months.** Turnover and financing activity have been coming in under our earlier expectations. Mortgage loan inquiries have taken another leg down in October after the September rate hike, after finding something of a level in prior months, with the additional impact of the November rate hike still to come.
- **We are also seeing early signs of a turn in the consumer**. Consumer income and spending have so far been quite resilient to pressures from fuel prices and rising interest rates. But our Westpac Card Tracker is starting to show that discretionary services spending is turning down again in Q4, joining the discretionary goods category that was already quite weak. We would not over-emphasise this point, but it does imply that the risks of further surprising resilience are fading.
- **Subsequent to the November Monetary Policy Board (MPB) meeting, business survey data has shown weaker conditions and a sharp decline in forward orders. They also show further evidence that current inflation is mostly a non-labour cost shock that is not being fully passed through to consumer prices.**
- **As we noted following the November MPB meeting, oil and fuel prices are already materially lower than the track assumed in the RBA's forecasts.** Dated Brent is nearly one-fourth lower than on 28 October, the date the RBA's forecasts were finalised, and spot Brent is around 15% lower. This significantly lowers the risk of a new wave of pass-through of fuel costs to other prices, as well as easing consumer inflation perceptions and expectations.
- In the media conference following the November meeting, Governor Bullock flagged that it was a good time to "take stock" of the policy tightening to date. Both we and the market read this as a signal that the MPB would pause at the December meeting. The 6:3 split vote at the meeting also suggests that some external members are more attentive to downside risks than the internal members.
- **A rate hike in February 2027 cannot be ruled out but it is looking even less likely given signs in the data and surveys**. The MPB will at least discuss a hike in February. The staff and senior officials remain sensitive to inflation risks and have a downbeat view of supply capacity growth.
- **Given what we are seeing in the economy now, though, a rate hike in 2027 would require either a material new inflation shock that has not yet occurred, or would constitute a policy error on the part of the RBA** (something that we will never forecast as a base case, knowing the talents and capabilities of the staff and the Board). We concur with the dissenting voters in the MPB that the downside risks need more attention. Policy is clearly restrictive, and the risk of overdoing the inflation correction is growing. And by the time we get to February, we think there will be more evidence that the domestic economy is slowing materially, and the inflation outlook with it.

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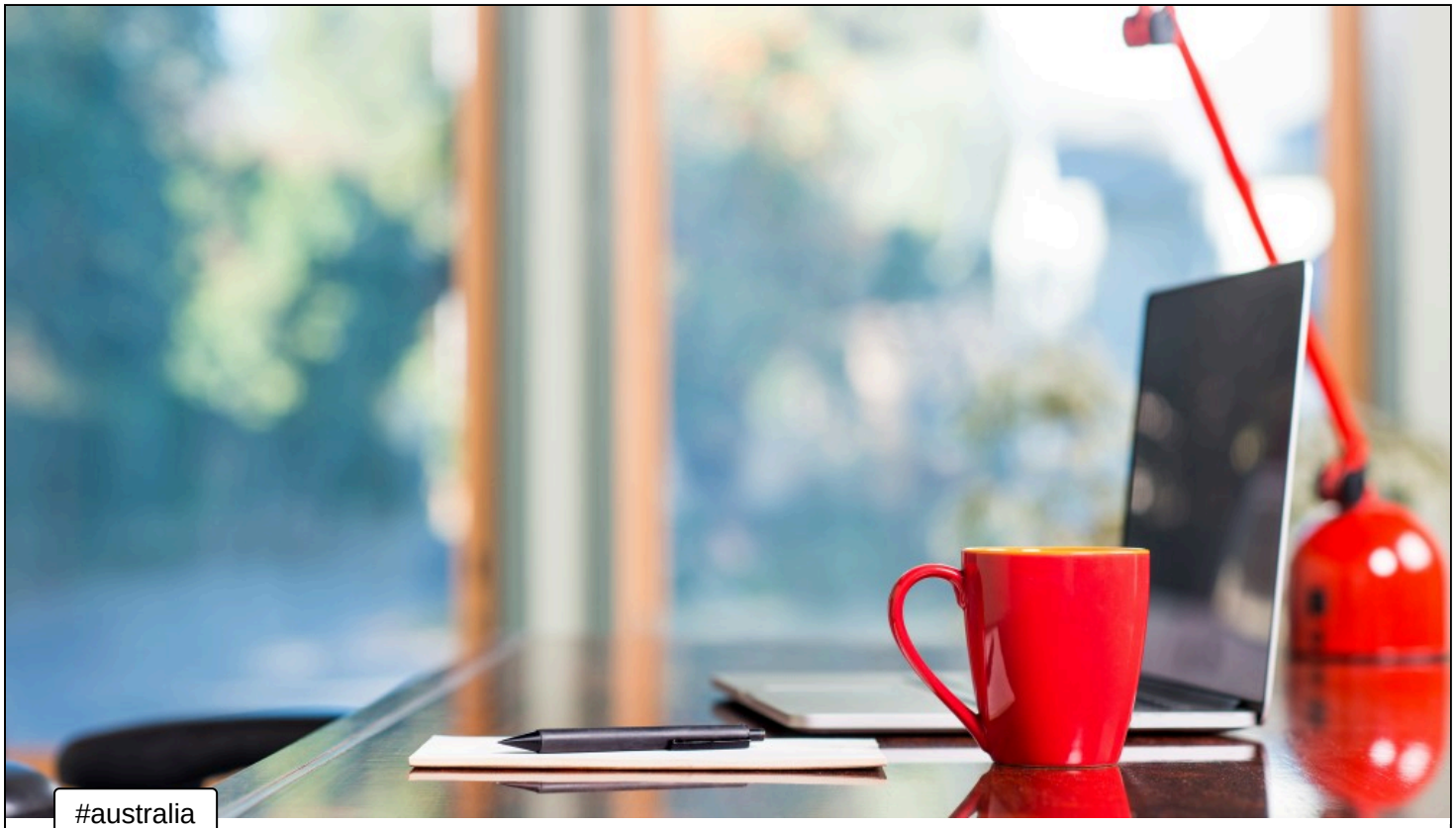

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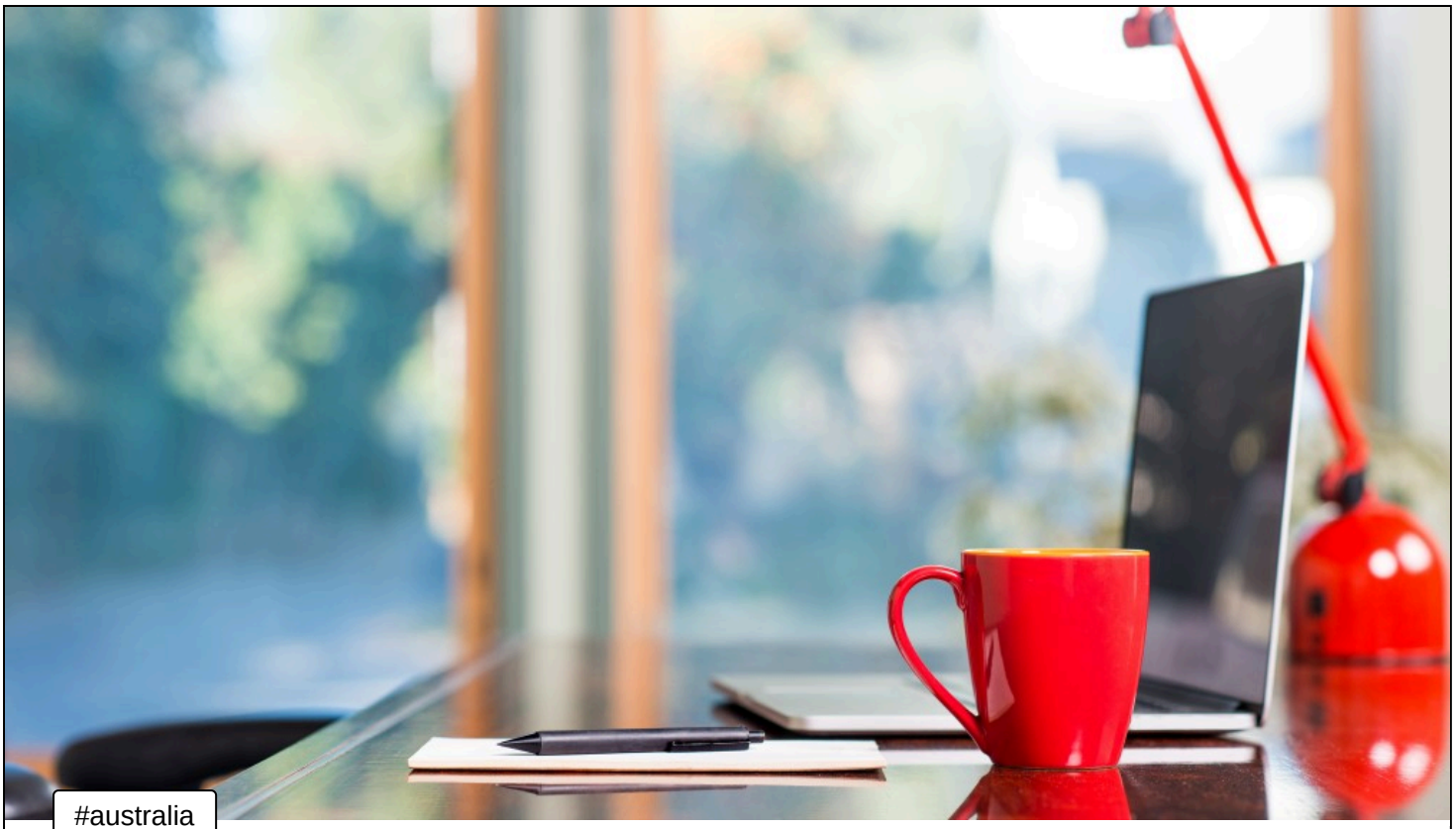

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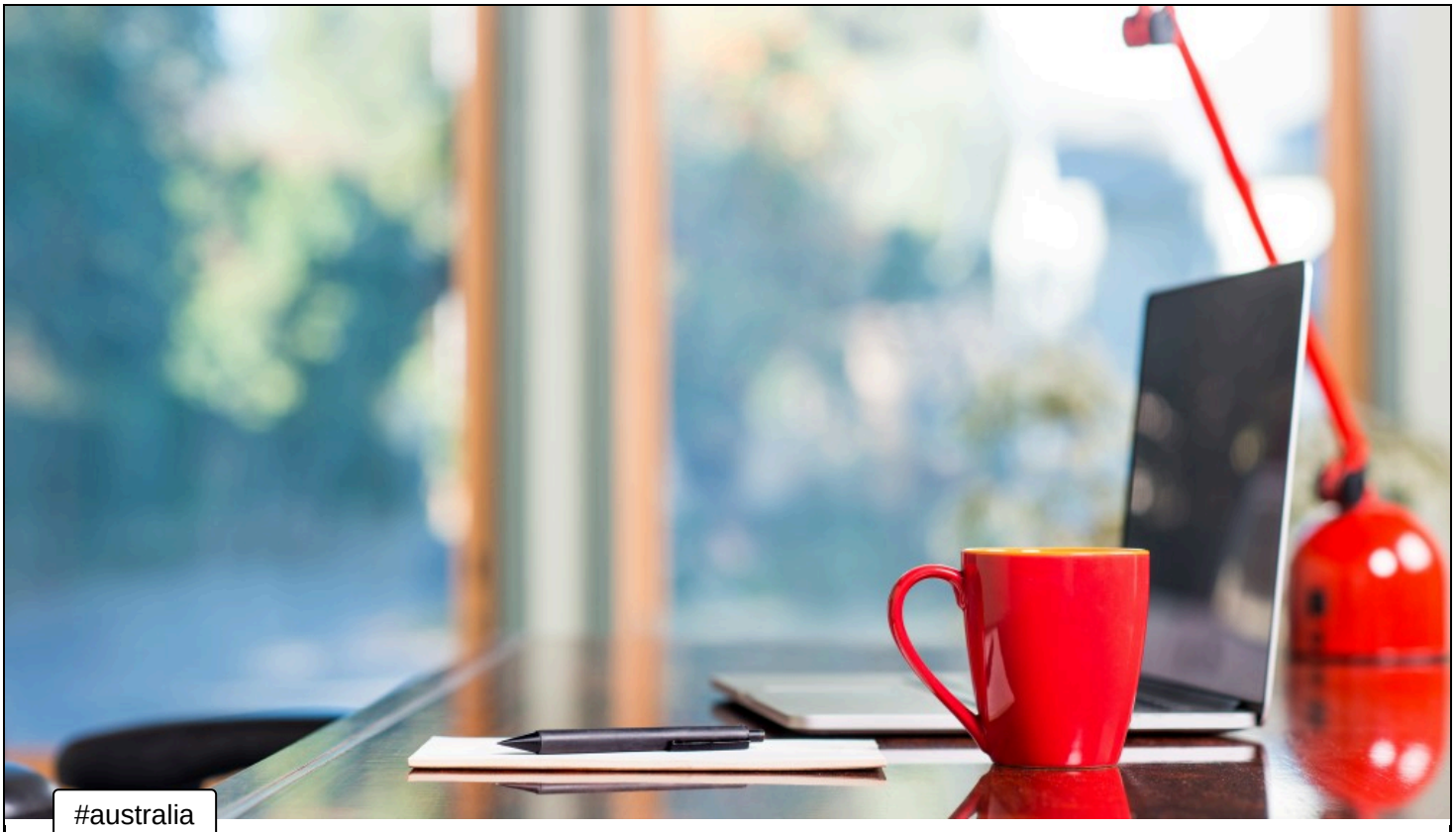

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12 November 2026

MORNING REPORT

Today's economic developments and market movements.

Key themes

Renewed optimism around AI drove US equities higher overnight, with positive developments around CoreWeave and Anthropic adding to enthusiasm around the sector and helping the S&P 500 and NASDAQ rally.

US cash bond markets were closed for Veterans Day, though futures continued to point to higher Treasury yields following this week's hotter-than-expected inflation data, which has all but cemented a December FOMC hike, with another two increases priced over 2027.

The US dollar received a solid bid alongside renewed strength in AI and tech stocks, lifting the DXY 0.7% to its highest since April 2025, while the Aussie slipped to around USD0.6850.

Australian dwelling finance approvals surprised materially to the downside in Q3, with the value of approvals plunging a record 15.5% as investor lending values dropped by nearly a third.

Data snapshot

FX Last 24 hrs	Current	Change
TWI	63.8	-0.5%
AUD/USD	0.6850	-0.2%
AUD/JPY	109.50	0.5%
AUD/GBP	0.5159	0.3%
AUD/NZD	1.2308	0.5%
AUD/EUR	0.6176	0.4%
AUD/CNH	4.5719	-0.3%
AUD/SGD	0.8801	0.0%
AUD/HKD	5.3741	-0.2%
AUD/CAD	0.9760	0.2%
EUR/USD	1.1093	-0.6%
USD/JPY	159.85	0.7%
USD Index	102.90	0.7%

AUS Interest Rate Swaps	Last	Change
30 day BBSY	4.86	0.01
90 day BBSY	4.99	0.01
180 day BBSY	5.35	0.03
1 year swap	4.95	0.01
2 year swap	4.82	0.02
3 year swap	4.76	0.02
4 year swap	4.74	0.01
5 year swap	4.76	0.01
6 year swap	4.80	0.01
7 year swap	4.84	0.01
8 year swap	4.88	0.01
9 year swap	4.93	0.01
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Equities	Close	Change
S&P/ASX 200	9,153	0.3%
S&P 500	7,626	1.4%
Japan Nikkei	61,249	1.3%
Hang Seng	24,316	-1.0%
Euro Stoxx 50	6,393	1.0%
UK FTSE100	10,835	0.8%
VIX Index	17.4	-10.6%

Government Bond Yields	Close	Change
Australia		
3 year bond	4.73	0.07
10 year bond	5.04	0.06
United States		
3-month T Bill	4.11	-0.01
2 year bond	4.74	0.00
10 year bond	4.99	0.00
Other (10 year yields)		
Germany	3.32	0.00
Japan	2.80	0.11
UK	5.22	0.00

Commodities	Current	Change
CRB Index	386.48	0.7%
Gold	3985.69	-1.2%
Copper	13817	1.0%
Oil (WTI futures)	86.31	0.3%
Coal (coking)	253.50	-0.2%
Coal (thermal)	143.40	3.3%
Iron Ore	91.25	-0.4%
ACCU	36.13	-4.3%

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10 yr bond	5.05	0.00
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Today's key data and events

Time	Event	Exp	Prev
8:45	NZ Card Spending Oct	-	-0.5%
8:45	NZ Net Migration Sep	-	1530k
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Times are AEDT. All data forecasts are m/m or q/q and seasonally adjusted unless otherwise specified. Forecasts for Australian data are our forecasts and for other countries they are consensus forecasts.

International Data

There was no major data out yesterday.

Domestic Data

In Australia, the value of **dwelling finance approvals** surprised materially to the downside in Q3, the 15.5% decline marking the largest quarterly decline on records going back to 1991. The decline looks to be mostly volume-driven, with the number of loans falling sharply compared to the average size of loans. Across segments, investor lending values dropped by nearly a third (see here).

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12 November 2026

MORNING REPORT

Today's economic developments and market movements.

Key themes

Renewed optimism around AI drove US equities higher overnight, with positive developments around CoreWeave and Anthropic adding to enthusiasm around the sector and helping the S&P 500 and NASDAQ rally.

US cash bond markets were closed for Veterans Day, though futures continued to point to higher Treasury yields following this week's hotter-than-expected inflation data, which has all but cemented a December FOMC hike, with another two increases priced over 2027.

The US dollar received a solid bid alongside renewed strength in AI and tech stocks, lifting the DXY 0.7% to its highest since April 2025, while the Aussie slipped to around USD0.6850.

Australian dwelling finance approvals surprised materially to the downside in Q3, with the value of approvals plunging a record 15.5% as investor lending values dropped by nearly a third.

Data snapshot

FX Last 24 hrs	Current	Change
TWI	63.8	-0.5%
AUD/USD	0.6850	-0.2%
AUD/JPY	109.50	0.5%
AUD/GBP	0.5159	0.3%
AUD/NZD	1.2308	0.5%
AUD/EUR	0.6176	0.4%
AUD/CNH	4.5719	-0.3%
AUD/SGD	0.8801	0.0%
AUD/HKD	5.3741	-0.2%
AUD/CAD	0.9760	0.2%
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12 November 2026

MORNING REPORT

Today's economic developments and market movements.

Key themes

Renewed optimism around AI drove US equities higher overnight, with positive developments around CoreWeave and Anthropic adding to enthusiasm around the sector and helping the S&P 500 and NASDAQ rally.

US cash bond markets were closed for Veterans Day, though futures continued to point to higher Treasury yields following this week's hotter-than-expected inflation data, which has all but cemented a December FOMC hike, with another two increases priced over 2027.

The US dollar received a solid bid alongside renewed strength in AI and tech stocks, lifting the DXY 0.7% to its highest since April 2025, while the Aussie slipped to around USD0.6850.

Australian dwelling finance approvals surprised materially to the downside in Q3, with the value of approvals plunging a record 15.5% as investor lending values dropped by nearly a third.

Data snapshot

FX Last 24 hrs	Current	Change
TWI	63.8	-0.5%
AUD/USD	0.6850	-0.2%
AUD/JPY	109.50	0.5%
AUD/GBP	0.5159	0.3%
AUD/NZD	1.2308	0.5%
AUD/EUR	0.6176	0.4%
AUD/CNH	4.5719	-0.3%
AUD/SGD	0.8801	0.0%
AUD/HKD	5.3741	-0.2%
AUD/CAD	0.9760	0.2%
EUR/USD	1.1093	-0.6%
USD/JPY	159.85	0.7%
USD Index	102.90	0.7%

AUS Interest Rate Swaps	Last	Change
30 day BBSY	4.86	0.01
90 day BBSY	4.99	0.01
180 day BBSY	5.35	0.03
1 year swap	4.95	0.01
2 year swap	4.82	0.02
3 year swap	4.76	0.02
4 year swap	4.74	0.01
5 year swap	4.76	0.01
6 year swap	4.80	0.01
7 year swap	4.84	0.01
8 year swap	4.88	0.01
9 year swap	4.93	0.01
10 year swap	4.96	0.00

Equities	Close	Change
S&P/ASX 200	9,153	0.3%
S&P 500	7,626	1.4%
Japan Nikkei	61,249	1.3%
Hang Seng	24,316	-1.0%
Euro Stoxx 50	6,393	1.0%
UK FTSE100	10,835	0.8%
VIX Index	17.4	-10.6%

Government Bond Yields	Close	Change
Australia		
3 year bond	4.73	0.07
10 year bond	5.04	0.06
United States		
3-month T Bill	4.11	-0.01
2 year bond	4.74	0.00
10 year bond	4.99	0.00
Other (10 year yields)		
Germany	3.32	0.00
Japan	2.80	0.11
UK	5.22	0.00

Commodities	Current	Change
CRB Index	386.48	0.7%
Gold	3985.69	-1.2%
Copper	13817	1.0%
Oil (WTI futures)	86.31	0.3%
Coal (coking)	253.50	-0.2%
Coal (thermal)	143.40	3.3%
Iron Ore	91.25	-0.4%
ACCU	36.13	-4.3%

Sydney Futures Exchange	Current	Change
10 yr bond	5.05	0.00
3 yr bond	4.73	0.01
3 mth bill rate	4.77	0.00
SPI 200	9,158	-0.4%

Data as at 7:30am AEDT. Change is from the previous trading day (excluding the SFE, which is the change during the night session). Source: Bloomberg.

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Financial Markets

- Share markets rallied across much of the globe. In the US, reports of an upgraded outlook for CoreWeave, an oversubscribed IPO for Anthropic and a stabilisation in Nvidia supported renewed optimism around AI which buoyed tech stocks, seeing the S&P 500 (+1.4%) and Nasdaq (+1.7%) both rally, though the smaller gain for the Dow Jones (+0.5%) shows the rally was more narrowly based.
- Across the pond, the Euro Stoxx 50 continued to build on recent momentum with another solid gain (+1.0%), while London's FTSE 100 bounced back from a modest decline yesterday (+0.8%). Stocks were up across most of Asia, including Tokyo (+1.3%), Shanghai (+0.4%) and Seoul (+2.6%), with only the Hang Seng (–1.0%) bucking the wider trend. The ASX 200 rose 0.3% yesterday, but weaker trading in futures overnight points to a mixed open this morning.
- Cash trading in bond markets were closed in the US for Veterans Day, but trading in futures points to a continued rise in yields following hotter-than-expected inflation data received earlier in the week, which all but cemented a December FOMC rate hike. Beyond December, markets are also pricing in another two rate hikes over the course of 2027.
- Yields were little changed elsewhere, with the 10Y Bund and Gilt steady on the day. The 10Y JGB meanwhile continued to sell-off, with yields jumping 10bps to 2.80% having effectively unwound the rally over late last week. ACGBs were also weaker during local trading, seeing yields rise 7bps on the 3Y and 6bps on the 10Y, following the sharp rise in global yields the day prior post US CPI. Swaps markets point to no hikes nor cuts from the RBA through to end-2027 at present.
- The USD received a solid bid overnight, buoyed by sharp inflows into AI and tech stocks that improved risk sentiment. The DXY finished 0.7% higher at around 102.9, the strongest since April 2025. That move has pushed the Euro down 0.6% back to a USD1.10 handle, the weakest since May 2025, while the Yen slipped 0.7% to JPY159.9, the weakest since the before the early-September rally. While moves in the AUD was comparatively small overnight, slipping 0.2% to around the USD0.6850 mark, that move builds on recent downward momentum and has the currency delicately positioned near 2026's lows.
- Oil prices rose slightly overnight, stabilising somewhat after recent declines amid ongoing uncertainty around the future of the US-Iran War, as President Trump downplays the possibility of further strikes on Iran all while negotiations show little progress. Brent rose 1.0% to US$92.4/bbl. The rebound in risk sentiment buoyed metals, with LME copper up 1.0% to US$13,817/mt while LME aluminium jumped 1.9% to US$3,068/mt. Gold prices meanwhile dipped 1.2%, falling back below the US$4,000/oz mark, building on recent momentum post US CPI which saw real yields jump higher

Today's key data and events

Time	Event	Exp	Prev
8:45	NZ Card Spending Oct	-	-0.5%
8:45	NZ Net Migration Sep	-	1530k
18:00	GB GDP Q3 Prel.	0.7%	0.5%
18:00	GB Trade Balance Sep	-£2100b	-£920b
0:30	US Initial Jobless Claims 7/11/2026	195k	189k
2:00	US Existing Home Sales Oct	-3.5%	1.5%

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12 November 2026

MORNING REPORT

Today's economic developments and market movements.

Key themes

Renewed optimism around AI drove US equities higher overnight, with positive developments around CoreWeave and Anthropic adding to enthusiasm around the sector and helping the S&P 500 and NASDAQ rally.

US cash bond markets were closed for Veterans Day, though futures continued to point to higher Treasury yields following this week's hotter-than-expected inflation data, which has all but cemented a December FOMC hike, with another two increases priced over 2027.

The US dollar received a solid bid alongside renewed strength in AI and tech stocks, lifting the DXY 0.7% to its highest since April 2025, while the Aussie slipped to around USD0.6850.

Australian dwelling finance approvals surprised materially to the downside in Q3, with the value of approvals plunging a record 15.5% as investor lending values dropped by nearly a third.

Data snapshot

FX Last 24 hrs	Current	Change
TWI	63.8	-0.5%
AUD/USD	0.6850	-0.2%
AUD/JPY	109.50	0.5%
AUD/GBP	0.5159	0.3%
AUD/NZD	1.2308	0.5%
AUD/EUR	0.6176	0.4%
AUD/CNH	4.5719	-0.3%
AUD/SGD	0.8801	0.0%
AUD/HKD	5.3741	-0.2%
AUD/CAD	0.9760	0.2%
EUR/USD	1.1093	-0.6%
USD/JPY	159.85	0.7%
USD Index	102.90	0.7%

AUS Interest Rate Swaps	Last	Change
30 day BBSY	4.86	0.01
90 day BBSY	4.99	0.01
180 day BBSY	5.35	0.03
1 year swap	4.95	0.01
2 year swap	4.82	0.02
3 year swap	4.76	0.02
4 year swap	4.74	0.01
5 year swap	4.76	0.01
6 year swap	4.80	0.01
7 year swap	4.84	0.01
8 year swap	4.88	0.01
9 year swap	4.93	0.01
10 year swap	4.96	0.00

Equities	Close	Change
S&P/ASX 200	9,153	0.3%
S&P 500	7,626	1.4%
Japan Nikkei	61,249	1.3%
Hang Seng	24,316	-1.0%
Euro Stoxx 50	6,393	1.0%
UK FTSE100	10,835	0.8%
VIX Index	17.4	-10.6%

Government Bond Yields	Close	Change
Australia		
3 year bond	4.73	0.07
10 year bond	5.04	0.06
United States		
3-month T Bill	4.11	-0.01
2 year bond	4.74	0.00
10 year bond	4.99	0.00
Other (10 year yields)		
Germany	3.32	0.00
Japan	2.80	0.11
UK	5.22	0.00

Commodities	Current	Change
CRB Index	386.48	0.7%
Gold	3985.69	-1.2%
Copper	13817	1.0%
Oil (WTI futures)	86.31	0.3%
Coal (coking)	253.50	-0.2%
Coal (thermal)	143.40	3.3%
Iron Ore	91.25	-0.4%
ACCU	36.13	-4.3%

Sydney Futures Exchange	Current	Change
10 yr bond	5.05	0.00
3 yr bond	4.73	0.01
3 mth bill rate	4.77	0.00
SPI 200	9,158	-0.4%

Data as at 7:30am AEDT. Change is from the previous trading day (excluding the SFE, which is the change during the night session). Source: Bloomberg.

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Financial Markets

- Share markets rallied across much of the globe. In the US, reports of an upgraded outlook for CoreWeave, an oversubscribed IPO for Anthropic and a stabilisation in Nvidia supported renewed optimism around AI which buoyed tech stocks, seeing the S&P 500 (+1.4%) and Nasdaq (+1.7%) both rally, though the smaller gain for the Dow Jones (+0.5%) shows the rally was more narrowly based.
- Across the pond, the Euro Stoxx 50 continued to build on recent momentum with another solid gain (+1.0%), while London's FTSE 100 bounced back from a modest decline yesterday (+0.8%). Stocks were up across most of Asia, including Tokyo (+1.3%), Shanghai (+0.4%) and Seoul (+2.6%), with only the Hang Seng (–1.0%) bucking the wider trend. The ASX 200 rose 0.3% yesterday, but weaker trading in futures overnight points to a mixed open this morning.
- Cash trading in bond markets were closed in the US for Veterans Day, but trading in futures points to a continued rise in yields following hotter-than-expected inflation data received earlier in the week, which all but cemented a December FOMC rate hike. Beyond December, markets are also pricing in another two rate hikes over the course of 2027.
- Yields were little changed elsewhere, with the 10Y Bund and Gilt steady on the day. The 10Y JGB meanwhile continued to sell-off, with yields jumping 10bps to 2.80% having effectively unwound the rally over late last week. ACGBs were also weaker during local trading, seeing yields rise 7bps on the 3Y and 6bps on the 10Y, following the sharp rise in global yields the day prior post US CPI. Swaps markets point to no hikes nor cuts from the RBA through to end-2027 at present.
- The USD received a solid bid overnight, buoyed by sharp inflows into AI and tech stocks that improved risk sentiment. The DXY finished 0.7% higher at around 102.9, the strongest since April 2025. That move has pushed the Euro down 0.6% back to a USD1.10 handle, the weakest since May 2025, while the Yen slipped 0.7% to JPY159.9, the weakest since the before the early-September rally. While moves in the AUD was comparatively small overnight, slipping 0.2% to around the USD0.6850 mark, that move builds on recent downward momentum and has the currency delicately positioned near 2026's lows.
- Oil prices rose slightly overnight, stabilising somewhat after recent declines amid ongoing uncertainty around the future of the US-Iran War, as President Trump downplays the possibility of further strikes on Iran all while negotiations show little progress. Brent rose 1.0% to US$92.4/bbl. The rebound in risk sentiment buoyed metals, with LME copper up 1.0% to US$13,817/mt while LME aluminium jumped 1.9% to US$3,068/mt. Gold prices meanwhile dipped 1.2%, falling back below the US$4,000/oz mark, building on recent momentum post US CPI which saw real yields jump higher

Today's key data and events

Time	Event	Exp	Prev
8:45	NZ Card Spending Oct	-	-0.5%
8:45	NZ Net Migration Sep	-	1530k
18:00	GB GDP Q3 Prel.	0.7%	0.5%
18:00	GB Trade Balance Sep	-£2100b	-£920b
0:30	US Initial Jobless Claims 7/11/2026	195k	189k
2:00	US Existing Home Sales Oct	-3.5%	1.5%

Times are AEDT. All data forecasts are m/m or q/q and seasonally adjusted unless otherwise specified. Forecasts for Australian data are our forecasts and for other countries they are consensus forecasts.

International Data

There was no major data out yesterday.

Domestic Data

In Australia, the value of **dwelling finance approvals** surprised materially to the downside in Q3, the 15.5% decline marking the largest quarterly decline on records going back to 1991. The decline looks to be mostly volume-driven, with the number of loans falling sharply compared to the average size of loans. Across segments, investor lending values dropped by nearly a third (see here).

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12 November 2026

MORNING REPORT

Today's economic developments and market movements.

Key themes

Renewed optimism around AI drove US equities higher overnight, with positive developments around CoreWeave and Anthropic adding to enthusiasm around the sector and helping the S&P 500 and NASDAQ rally.

US cash bond markets were closed for Veterans Day, though futures continued to point to higher Treasury yields following this week's hotter-than-expected inflation data, which has all but cemented a December FOMC hike, with another two increases priced over 2027.

The US dollar received a solid bid alongside renewed strength in AI and tech stocks, lifting the DXY 0.7% to its highest since April 2025, while the Aussie slipped to around USD0.6850.

Australian dwelling finance approvals surprised materially to the downside in Q3, with the value of approvals plunging a record 15.5% as investor lending values dropped by nearly a third.

Data snapshot

FX Last 24 hrs	Current	Change
TWI	63.8	-0.5%
AUD/USD	0.6850	-0.2%
AUD/JPY	109.50	0.5%
AUD/GBP	0.5159	0.3%
AUD/NZD	1.2308	0.5%
AUD/EUR	0.6176	0.4%
AUD/CNH	4.5719	-0.3%
AUD/SGD	0.8801	0.0%
AUD/HKD	5.3741	-0.2%
AUD/CAD	0.9760	0.2%
EUR/USD	1.1093	-0.6%
USD/JPY	159.85	0.7%
USD Index	102.90	0.7%

AUS Interest Rate Swaps	Last	Change
30 day BBSY	4.86	0.01
90 day BBSY	4.99	0.01
180 day BBSY	5.35	0.03
1 year swap	4.95	0.01
2 year swap	4.82	0.02
3 year swap	4.76	0.02
4 year swap	4.74	0.01
5 year swap	4.76	0.01
6 year swap	4.80	0.01
7 year swap	4.84	0.01
8 year swap	4.88	0.01
9 year swap	4.93	0.01
10 year swap	4.96	0.00

Equities	Close	Change
S&P/ASX 200	9,153	0.3%
S&P 500	7,626	1.4%
Japan Nikkei	61,249	1.3%
Hang Seng	24,316	-1.0%
Euro Stoxx 50	6,393	1.0%
UK FTSE100	10,835	0.8%
VIX Index	17.4	-10.6%

Government Bond Yields	Close	Change
Australia		
3 year bond	4.73	0.07
10 year bond	5.04	0.06
United States		
3-month T Bill	4.11	-0.01
2 year bond	4.74	0.00
10 year bond	4.99	0.00
Other (10 year yields)		
Germany	3.32	0.00
Japan	2.80	0.11
UK	5.22	0.00

Commodities	Current	Change
CRB Index	386.48	0.7%
Gold	3985.69	-1.2%
Copper	13817	1.0%
Oil (WTI futures)	86.31	0.3%
Coal (coking)	253.50	-0.2%
Coal (thermal)	143.40	3.3%
Iron Ore	91.25	-0.4%
ACCU	36.13	-4.3%

Sydney Futures Exchange	Current	Change
10 yr bond	5.05	0.00
3 yr bond	4.73	0.01
3 mth bill rate	4.77	0.00
SPI 200	9,158	-0.4%

Data as at 7:30am AEDT. Change is from the previous trading day (excluding the SFE, which is the change during the night session). Source: Bloomberg.

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Financial Markets

- Share markets rallied across much of the globe. In the US, reports of an upgraded outlook for CoreWeave, an oversubscribed IPO for Anthropic and a stabilisation in Nvidia supported renewed optimism around AI which buoyed tech stocks, seeing the S&P 500 (+1.4%) and Nasdaq (+1.7%) both rally, though the smaller gain for the Dow Jones (+0.5%) shows the rally was more narrowly based.
- Across the pond, the Euro Stoxx 50 continued to build on recent momentum with another solid gain (+1.0%), while London's FTSE 100 bounced back from a modest decline yesterday (+0.8%). Stocks were up across most of Asia, including Tokyo (+1.3%), Shanghai (+0.4%) and Seoul (+2.6%), with only the Hang Seng (–1.0%) bucking the wider trend. The ASX 200 rose 0.3% yesterday, but weaker trading in futures overnight points to a mixed open this morning.
- Cash trading in bond markets were closed in the US for Veterans Day, but trading in futures points to a continued rise in yields following hotter-than-expected inflation data received earlier in the week, which all but cemented a December FOMC rate hike. Beyond December, markets are also pricing in another two rate hikes over the course of 2027.
- Yields were little changed elsewhere, with the 10Y Bund and Gilt steady on the day. The 10Y JGB meanwhile continued to sell-off, with yields jumping 10bps to 2.80% having effectively unwound the rally over late last week. ACGBs were also weaker during local trading, seeing yields rise 7bps on the 3Y and 6bps on the 10Y, following the sharp rise in global yields the day prior post US CPI. Swaps markets point to no hikes nor cuts from the RBA through to end-2027 at present.
- The USD received a solid bid overnight, buoyed by sharp inflows into AI and tech stocks that improved risk sentiment. The DXY finished 0.7% higher at around 102.9, the strongest since April 2025. That move has pushed the Euro down 0.6% back to a USD1.10 handle, the weakest since May 2025, while the Yen slipped 0.7% to JPY159.9, the weakest since the before the early-September rally. While moves in the AUD was comparatively small overnight, slipping 0.2% to around the USD0.6850 mark, that move builds on recent downward momentum and has the currency delicately positioned near 2026's lows.
- Oil prices rose slightly overnight, stabilising somewhat after recent declines amid ongoing uncertainty around the future of the US-Iran War, as President Trump downplays the possibility of further strikes on Iran all while negotiations show little progress. Brent rose 1.0% to US$92.4/bbl. The rebound in risk sentiment buoyed metals, with LME copper up 1.0% to US$13,817/mt while LME aluminium jumped 1.9% to US$3,068/mt. Gold prices meanwhile dipped 1.2%, falling back below the US$4,000/oz mark, building on recent momentum post US CPI which saw real yields jump higher

Today's key data and events

Time	Event	Exp	Prev
8:45	NZ Card Spending Oct	-	-0.5%
8:45	NZ Net Migration Sep	-	1530k
18:00	GB GDP Q3 Prel.	0.7%	0.5%
18:00	GB Trade Balance Sep	-£2100b	-£920b
0:30	US Initial Jobless Claims 7/11/2026	195k	189k
2:00	US Existing Home Sales Oct	-3.5%	1.5%

Times are AEDT. All data forecasts are m/m or q/q and seasonally adjusted unless otherwise specified. Forecasts for Australian data are our forecasts and for other countries they are consensus forecasts.

International Data

There was no major data out yesterday.

Domestic Data

In Australia, the value of **dwelling finance approvals** surprised materially to the downside in Q3, the 15.5% decline marking the largest quarterly decline on records going back to 1991. The decline looks to be mostly volume-driven, with the number of loans falling sharply compared to the average size of loans. Across segments, investor lending values dropped by nearly a third (see here).

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Cliff Notes: the source and persistence of inflation

#cliffnotes #rba #australia #inflation #us #fomc #ecb #aud #usd

By Ryan Wells, Illiana Jain & Elliot Clarke

11:16 October 30 2026

Share

Key insights from the week that was.

In Australia this week, all eyes were on the September CPI. Headline inflation rose 0.8% (4.3%yr) in the month, largely owing to a 9.4% jump in fuel prices and a seasonal surge in domestic and international holiday travel & accommodation. The underlying inflation pulse also proved hotter than anticipated for Q3 overall, up 1.0% (3.7%yr).

While some parts of the basket are seeing disinflation – housing in particular looks to be cooling faster than expected as builders lure sales with discounts – other components are still showing persistence. Highlighting this is market services ex volatiles, which the RBA watches closely as an indicator of price pressures related to domestic capacity. In Q3, this metric rose 1.2% (3.2%yr), and the monthly detail points to momentum holding up – in line with our expectations for another chunky read in Q4.

With inflation running well above the RBA's August forecasts, and some of the energy risks flagged then materialising, we continue to expect the Monetary Policy Board will deliver a 25bp rate hike to 4.85% in November. Beyond November, another rate hike in February is a risk, but is not currently part of our base case.

Across the Tasman, the RBNZ this week surprised market expectations for a 25bp rate hike, deciding instead to wait for further information before taking the next step with policy. The decision was made 4:3, with the Governor in the 'on hold' camp. A 25bp hike in December to 3.00% and further tightening in 2027 (Westpac NZ forecasts a peak of 4.00% in September) seems probable; however, each decision will depend on fuel prices, inflation expectations and evidence of second-round pricing pressures, along with the evolution of global economic risks.

In the US, the FOMC also held rates steady at its October meeting. Based on prior comments by key members, the decision was not a surprise, and neither were Governor Cook and Cleveland Fed President Hammack's dissents in favour of a 25bp hike. The Committee remains positive on economic activity, characterising it in the statement as "expanding at a strong pace" (an upgrade from "solid" in September). Chair Warsh also subsequently emphasised the breadth of economic growth outside of tech-related investment (evinced by Q3 GDP the day after; see below).

The Committee refrained from spotlighting key price risks in the statement. However, inflation "remains elevated" and the FOMC are determined to achieve a "timely" and sustainable return of annual inflation to 2.0%yr after 6 years above target. This guidance and the "accumulation of more information will help the Committee determine the policy stance" suggests another 25bp hike is likely in December. Thereafter, the FOMC will remain attentive to any broadening in inflation and related risks through 2027; although, in the absence of another shock, we expect them to remain on hold.

The Q3 GDP report certainly supported Chair Warsh's view on the breadth of growth, the 3.4% annualised gain for GDP benefitting from a 3.8% annualised increase in household consumption, 12.7% growth in non-residential investment as well as a robust increase in government spending. Notably though, the contribution from business investment was effectively offset by net exports' drag given most of the componentry related to AI infrastructure investment is imported. This is not to say that US firms won't benefit from the investment once complete, but simply that much of the initial return goes to the foreign businesses who provide the necessary capital equipment.

On consumption, the monthly PCE data implies downside risks remain for the consumer, the increase in nominal spending seen in the month requiring dissaving and, on a real basis, consumption flat in the month following a 0.5% gain in August. Cost-of-living pressures and uncertainty over the outlook is

expected to see household consumption growth average around trend over the coming year, albeit with considerable volatility quarter to quarter. This should see PCE inflation slow back towards its 2.0%yr medium-term target as the FOMC desires, from 3.6%yr and 3.1%yr for the headline and core measures respectively as of September.

Across the Atlantic, the ECB also left its key policy rates unchanged in October. Of note from the meeting communications, energy prices continue to pose upside risks for inflation, but also downside risks for growth. "While the full effects of the energy shock are still unfolding, underlying inflation has remained broadly stable so far and wages do not show a material response". "Financing conditions have [also] tightened", "which is likely to weigh on inflation and growth". In the press conference, President Lagarde noted that, between the October and December meetings, a significant amount of new economic information will be released, allowing forecasts and risks assessments to be tested.

Based on the October meeting communications, we continue to expect a rate hike at the December meeting but believe this will be prove to be the last hike of the cycle. Note though, the spectrum of risks Europe faces is broad and skewed towards inflation in the near term, hence the Council’s guidance will remain hawkish. President Lagarde also announced today that she will step down as ECB President in February ahead of the scheduled conclusion of her term next October.

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September CPI: Inflation accelerating in the run up to Christmas

#inflation #australia #rba #economicbulletinsaustralia #inflation

By Justin Smirk & Neha Sharma

16:08 October 28 2026

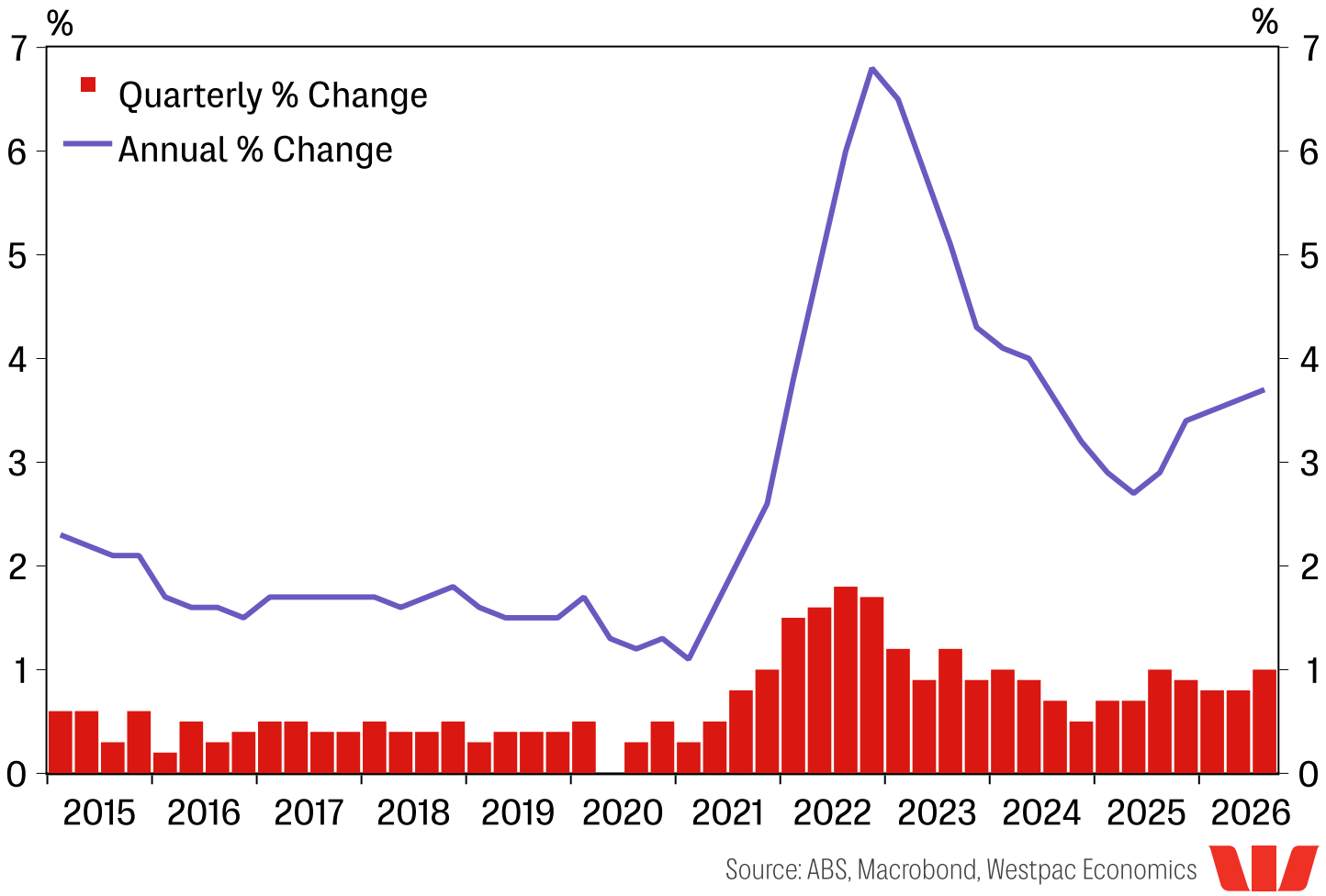
Share

September Monthly CPI: Headline 0.8%mth/4.3%yr, Trimmed Mean 0.3.%mth/3.6%yr. Market services ex volatile 1.6%mth/4.0%yr. September Quarter CPI: Headline 1.3%qtr/3.9%yr; Trimmed Mean 1.0%qtr/3.7%yr.

- The CPI rose 0.8% in the September month, stronger than Westpac's 0.6% estimate and the market's expectation of 0.7%. The annual pace picked up from 4.0%yr to 4.3%yr, The seasonally adjusted CPI rose 0.6% in September highlighting some positive seasonality in the month.

- Key factors driving the headline monthly result were: automotive fuels (9.4%mth); domestic holiday travel & accommodation (8.0%mth); international holiday travel & accommodation (7.2%mth); and property rates & charges (5.5%mth). There were modest offsets from: women's garments (–3.1%mth); household textiles (–6.6%mth); and accessories (–4.1%mth).
- The Trimmed Mean (TM) gained 0.3% in September, spot on both Westpac and market expectations with the annual pace lifting from 3.5%yr (revised from 3.6%yr) to 3.6%yr. The six-month annualised pace is now 4.0%yr the fastest in the short history of this series.
- Headline CPI lifted 1.3% in the September quarter compared to an expectation of 1.3% by Westpac and 1.2% by the market. This saw the annual pace hold at 3.9%yr.
- **The RBA's key underlying inflation measure, the quarterly TM, lifted 1.0% vs an expectation of 0.9% by Westpac and market estimate of 1.0%. The annual pace lifted from 3.6%yr to 3.7%yr with the six-month annualised pace accelerating to 3.7%yr from 3.4%yr.**
- Overall, the estimates come in broadly as expected so we see minimal risk to our current December quarter forecast of 1.3%qtr for the headline CPI. Softer housing inflation does present a very modest downside risk to our 0.9%qtr for the TM but there are offsetting gains elsewhere.
- The September CPI update revealed underlying inflationary pressures continuing even while a moderation in housing inflation (dwellings in particular) is unfolding slightly faster than we had anticipated. As such, the near-term risk for inflation remains to the upside. The RBA will remain alert to these near-term inflationary risks and as so, we hold to the view that the RBA will raise rates again at the November meeting.

Quarterly Trimmed Mean Inflation



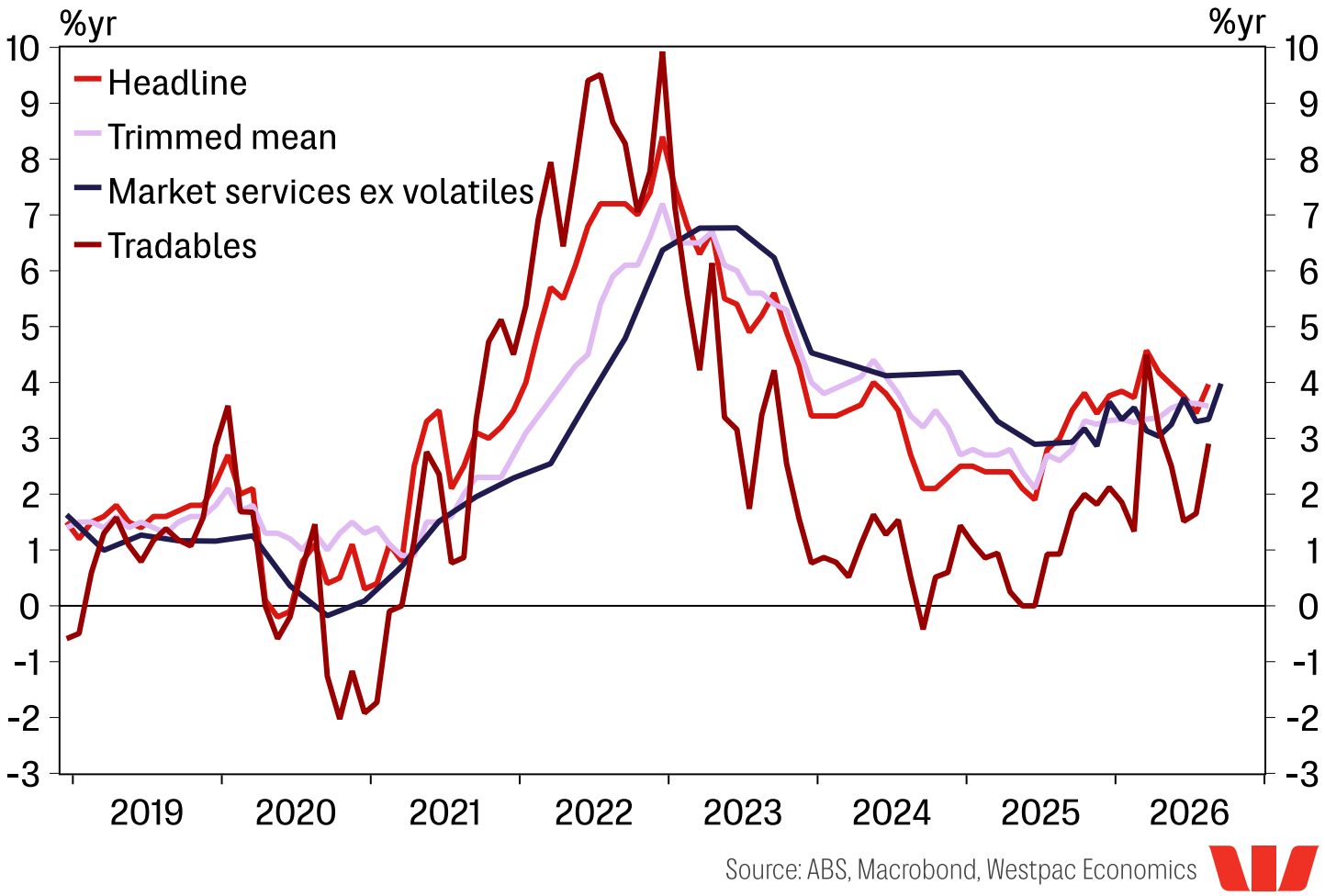
Month of September CPI

The monthly CPI rose 0.8%mth in September, above both our expectation of a 0.6%mth increase and the market forecast of 0.7%mth. This lifted the annual pace by 0.3ppts to 4.3%yr. On a seasonally adjusted basis, the CPI increased 0.6%mth.

The key contributors to the monthly increase were: automotive fuel (9.4%mth, +0.3ppts); and holiday travel & accommodation (7.6%mth, +0.5ppts), alongside a smaller contribution from the annual reset in property rates (5.5%mth, +0.1ppt). There was no single major offset. Instead, several components across household furnishings and clothing & footwear recorded modest declines, together subtracting a little over 0.1ppt from the monthly result.

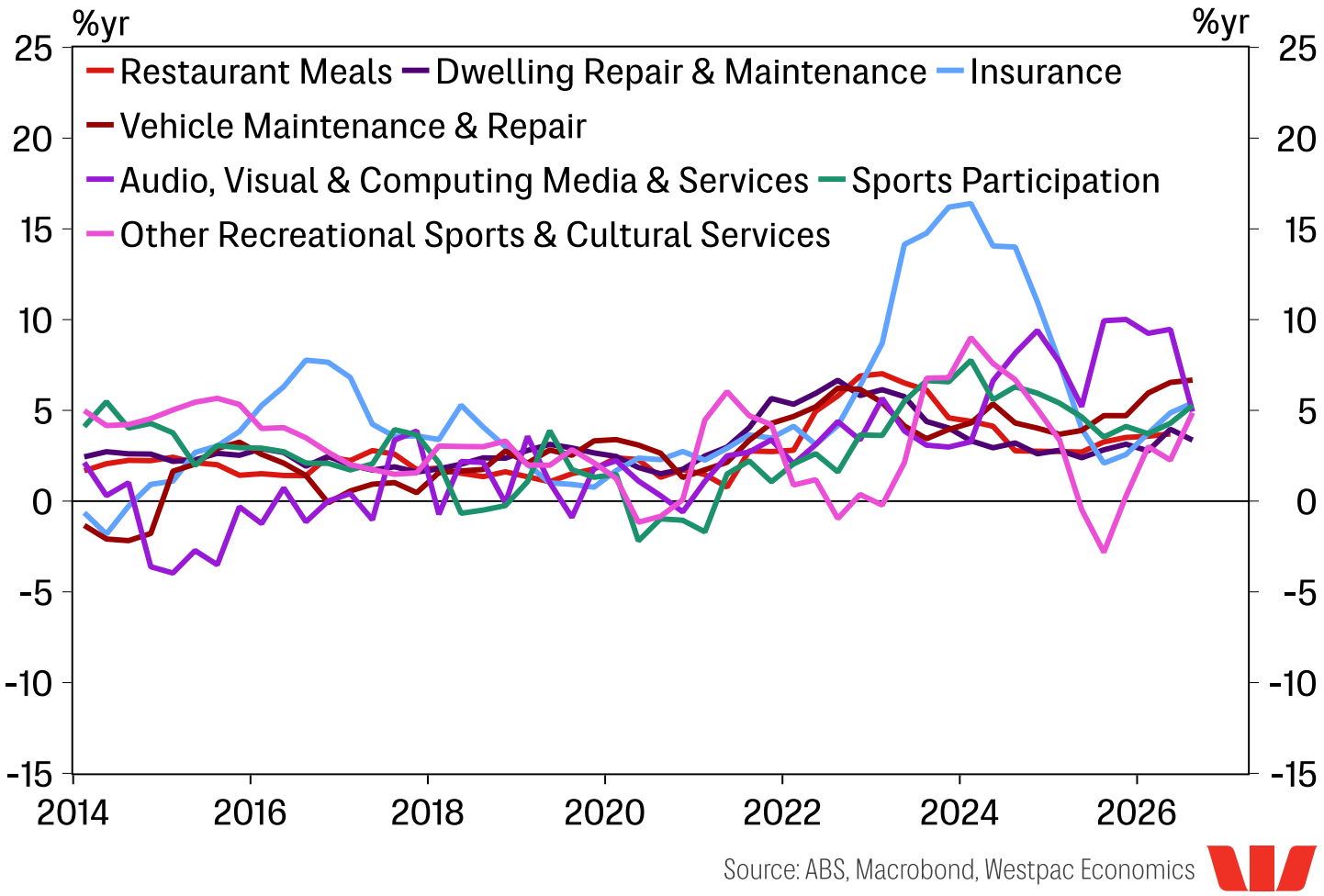
The monthly trimmed mean (TM) rose 0.3%mth, in line with both our and the market's expectations. The annual pace edged up to 3.6%yr, although the August outcome was revised down to 3.5%yr. Underlying inflation has remained broadly stuck in the 3.5–3.6%yr range since May. On a 3m/3m basis, the monthly TM was 1.1%.

Monthly Inflation Indicators



Market services excluding volatile items and holiday travel were flat in the month, with annual inflation easing to 3.8%yr, its softest pace since November 2025. On a seasonally adjusted basis, monthly inflation moderated across most components in this measure, with telecommunications services, rents and other financial services the key exceptions. However, all but two components are still recording annual price growth above 3%, suggesting that disinflation across market services remains slow and relatively narrow. The persistence of these underlying price pressures is likely to remain a concern for the RBA.

Selected Market Services



Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

Housing inflation was notably softer in the month, rising 0.3%mth to be 5.2% higher over the year. Rents increased 0.2%mth, slightly below our expectation for a 0.3%mth rise. The biannual indexation of Commonwealth Rent Assistance occurred late in the month, weighing on the September outcome, with the remainder of the impact expected to flow through in October. The ABS noted that rents would have risen 0.3%mth in the absence of the measure, while on a seasonally adjusted basis rents increased 0.4%mth.

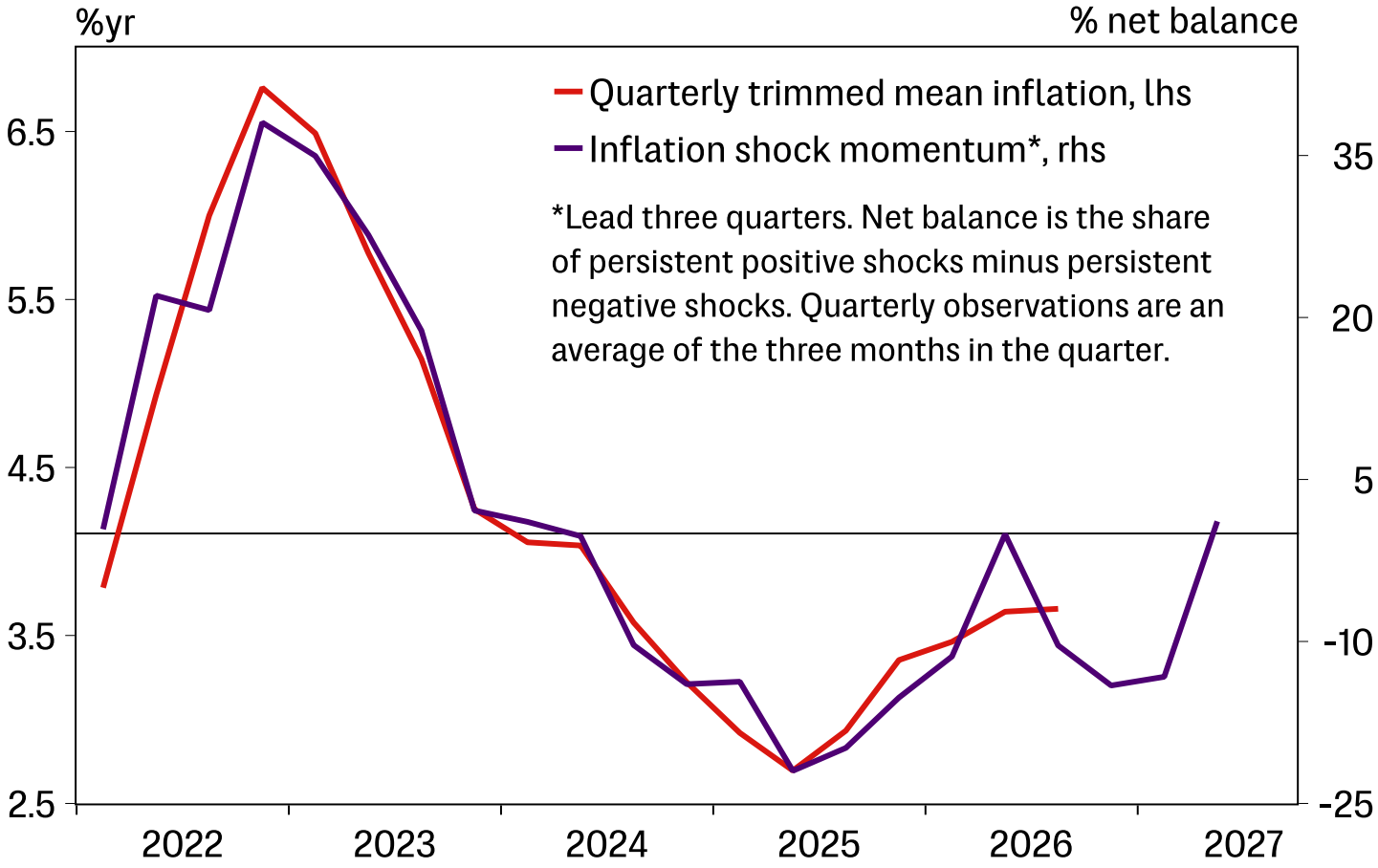
New dwelling inflation was flat in the month, the softest reading since May 2025. Monthly inflation has now slowed in each successive month since May 2026, suggesting homebuilders' pricing power is becoming increasingly constrained. The ABS noted that some project home builders raised base prices this month only to be offset by some builders increasing discounts and promotional offers in response to slowing demand. The annual pace eased to 4.7%yr. Dwelling repair costs were also a downside surprise, falling 0.1%mth, their first decline since February 2025, although prices remain 3.4% higher over the year. Some of this softness was offset by a firmer-than-expected increase in property rates and charges, which rose 5.6%mth.

Recently, we have also focused on audio, visual and computing given the potential for spillovers from strong global demand for semiconductors and other computing resources associated with the AI build out. Prices for both equipment and services came in weaker than August, with equipment prices falling 1.1%mth, while services rose 0.3%mth. Despite this, annual price growth remains relatively high for these categories, running at 4.6% and 4.9% respectively. Some of this pressure might also be showing

through in gaming, toys and hobbies, which is running at 5.2%mth/15.5%yr.

Overall, the breadth of inflation moderated for a second consecutive month. The share of the basket running above 3%yr fell from 40% to 35%, meanwhile the share below 2%yr lifted from 27% to 32%. Our replication of the San Francisco Fed's inflation shock momentum served as a good guide to the quarterly TM. With the full monthly reads in for the September quarter in, this measure does signal some persistence/upside pressures for the quarterly TM going into the coming quarters. It is worth cautioning that this measure will be impacted as the ABS refines its seasonal adjustment process for the monthly indexes.

Inflation Shock Momentum



Source: Federal Reserve Bank of San Francisco, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

Compared to our expectations, the key surprises were:

Upside surprises

- Fruit & vegetables was the key upside surprise, 0.6%mth against our expectations for 3.7%mth fall.
- Holiday travel & accommodation also surprised to the upside, following a run of downside surprises since early this year. It rose 7.6%mth against our expectations for a 4.4%mth lift.
- Automotive fuel rose 9.4%mth against expectations of an 8.3%mth lift.

Downside surprises

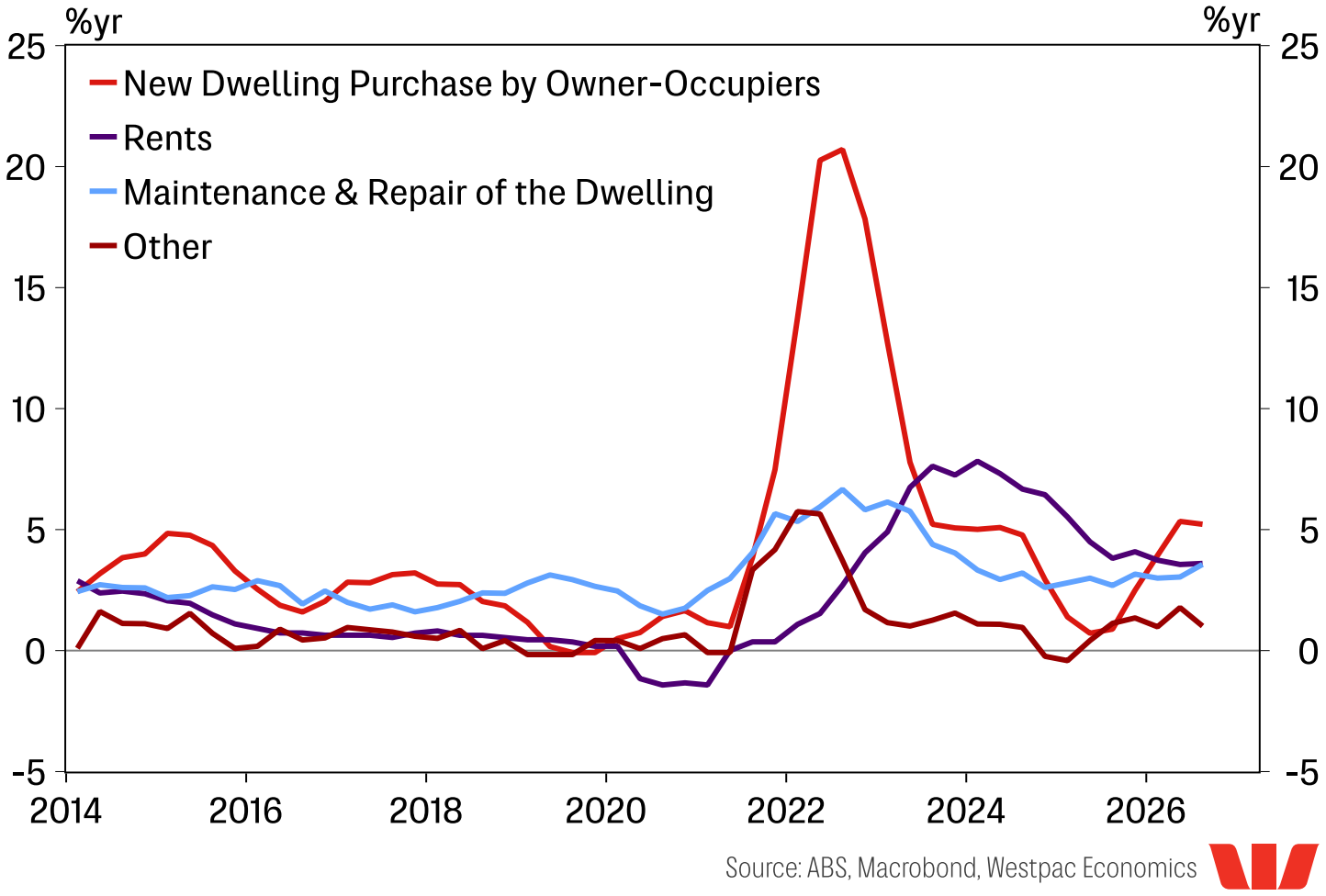
- Clothing & footwear was the key downside surprise with prices falling 2.7%mth against our expectations for a 0.2%mth fall. The misses were broad-based: garments (–2.3%mth vs –2.0%mth); footwear (–2.5%mth vs 1.8%mth); and accessories & clothing services (–4.1%mth vs 2.8%mth).
- Household textiles declined 6.6%mth against our expectations for a 3.2%mth fall. Furniture & furnishings rose by less-than-expected 0.4%mth vs 1.6%mth. Household appliances, utensils and tools also came in softer, –3.2%mth vs –2.4%mth.
- Dairy prices fell 1.2%mth against our expectations for a 0.1%mth lift.

	Qtr CPI	Monthly CPI			WBC fcs
CPI	Sep-26	Jul-26	Aug-26	Sep-26	Sep-26
Item	% qtr	% mth	% mth	% mth	% mth
Food	0.7	0.3	-0.1	0.0	-0.5
of which, bread & cereals	0.2	-0.3	0.0	-0.1	0.2
of which, meat & seafood	-0.4	0.2	-0.9	-0.7	0.0
of which, dairy & related products	1.4	0.2	-0.1	-1.2	0.1
of which, fruit & vegetables	-0.4	-0.8	-1.1	0.6	-3.7
of which, food products nec	0.0	0.0	0.3	0.5	0.0
of which, non-alcohol beverages	1.2	0.0	0.3	-0.4	-1.5
Alcohol & tobacco	1.7	1.2	0.5	0.7	1.1
of which, Alcohol	1.5	1.2	0.5	0.0	-0.3
of which, Tobacco	2.3	1.2	0.5	2.2	4.0
Clothing & footwear	-0.6	2.6	-0.9	-2.7	-0.2
of which, garments	-2.1	3.2	-1.9	-2.3	-2.0
Housing	1.1	0.4	0.2	0.3	0.6
of which, Rents	1.0	0.4	0.3	0.2	0.3
of which, House purchases	1.0	0.4	0.2	0.0	0.2
of which, Electricity	-1.2	-1.6	0.0	-0.8	0.0
of which, Gas & other fuels	3.5	2.8	0.0	-0.2	1.3
H/hold contents & services	1.2	4.4	-0.6	-0.6	-0.2
Health	-0.1	0.1	0.1	-0.3	-0.1
Transportation	3.3	2.6	4.2	3.0	2.0
of which, auto fuel	7.8	7.5	14.8	9.4	8.3
Communication	1.4	1.8	-0.2	0.5	-0.1
Recreation	2.5	1.8	-1.0	3.8	2.1
of which, holiday travel	2.7	1.8	-3.3	7.6	4.4
Education	0.1	0.0	0.1	0.0	0.0
Financial & insurance services	1.0	0.2	0.2	0.6	0.4
CPI: All groups %qtr/%mth	**1.3**	**1.0**	**0.4**	**0.8**	**0.6**
Trimmed Mean: %qtr/%mth	**1.0**	**0.5**	**0.2**	**0.3**	**0.3**

September Quarter CPI

The September quarter CPI printed spot on our expectation of 1.3%. The key factor driving this increase was the slightly stronger surge in auto fuel (7.8%, +0.27ppt) and holiday travel & accommodation (2.7%qtr, +0.16ppt) being offset by a slightly softer than expected increase in housing (1.1%qtr, +0.24ppt) with rents and dwellings both increasing 1.0% in the quarter and utilities lifting 1.2%. Food was also slightly stronger than expected (0.7%qtr, +0.12ppt) and while not significant to the overall result it is interesting to track the ongoing rise in motor vehicle prices (0.3%qtr) despite a very competitive market with Chinese manufacturers rapidly gaining market share over legacy brands.

Housing-related Inflation



It is worth noting that food was stronger than we expected (0.7% vs 0.5%) with a robust 1.7% increase in restaurant meals and a solid 1.2% increase in take away & fast foods outweighing the –0.4% decline in fresh fruit & vegetables and meat & seafoods. Overall, market services ex volatile prices increased a very solid 1.2%qtr but with the annual pace easing to 3.2%yr from 3.36%yr.

Outside of housing the other main downside surprise in the quarter was the –0.6% fall in clothing & footwear (+0.3% expected) with prices falling across just about all categories of garments, footwear and accessories.

September Quarter Trimmed Mean

Recall that the TM is calculated from seasonally adjust consumption expenditure classes so any numbers quoted here may not be the same as the original estimates quoted from the CPI. The TM gain of 1.0% in the quarter was slightly stronger than we had expected even though dwellings (which have a weight of almost 11% in the TM) was a touch softer at 1.0% compared to the 1.1% we had pencilled in. Rents (1.0%, 10% weight) also made a solid contribution as did restaurant meals (1.7%qr, 6% weight), take away & fast food (1.2%, 4% weight), other financial service (1.0%, 6% weight). Domestic travel was in the TM (1.0%, 4% weight) as was medical & hospital service (1.0%, weight 5%). The range of the TM was from 0.0% (motor vehicles) to 1.7% (beer).

What does this mean for our December quarter forecast and into 2027?

We are working though the monthly results to see what changes they may imply for individual component inflationary momentum. Our preliminary analysis suggests that the softer trend in dwellings is not enough, on its own, to change our Q4 CPI forecast of 1.3%. It does, however, suggest that if all else held equal (which is not the case as there is likely to be some offsetting stronger gains elsewhere) the moderation in dwelling inflation presents a very modest downside risk our Q4 TM estimate of 0.9%. We are still working the numbers and will publish an updated inflation profile as soon as we can. In addition, the overall momentum in underlying inflationary pressures suggest the downside risk to the TM from dwellings is more likely to appear in 2027 than in the last quarter of 2026.

CPI forecasts	Sep-26 Actual		Sep-26 14-Oct-26	
Item	% qtr	contrib	% qtr	contrib
Food	0.7	0.12	0.5	0.09
of which, fruit & vegetables	-0.4	-0.01	-1.8	-0.04
Alcohol & tobacco	1.7	0.11	1.9	0.12
of which, Tobacco	2.3	0.05	2.9	0.06
Clothing & footwear	-0.6	-0.02	0.3	0.01
Housing	1.1	0.24	1.4	0.31
of which, Rents	1.0	0.07	1.0	0.07
of which, House purchases	1.0	0.08	1.1	0.08
of which, Utilities	1.2	0.05	1.4	0.06
H/hold contents & services	1.2	0.09	1.3	0.10
Health	-0.1	-0.01	0.0	0.00
of which, Pharmaceuticals	-1.6	-0.01	-1.6	-0.01
Transportation	3.3	0.38	3.1	0.35
of which , car prices	0.3	0.01	0.0	0.00
of which, auto fuel	7.8	0.27	7.4	0.26
Communication	1.4	0.03	1.2	0.03
Recreation	2.5	0.31	1.7	0.21
of which, audio visual & computing	3.8	0.07	3.8	0.07
of which, holiday travel	2.7	0.16	1.6	0.10
Education	0.1	0.00	0.1	0.00
Financial & insurance services	1.0	0.05	0.9	0.05
CPI: All groups %qtr	**1.3**	–	**1.3**	–
CPI: All groups % year	**3.9**	–	**3.9**	–

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12 November 2026

MORNING REPORT

Today's economic developments and market movements.

Key themes

Renewed optimism around AI drove US equities higher overnight, with positive developments around CoreWeave and Anthropic adding to enthusiasm around the sector and helping the S&P 500 and NASDAQ rally.

US cash bond markets were closed for Veterans Day, though futures continued to point to higher Treasury yields following this week's hotter-than-expected inflation data, which has all but cemented a December FOMC hike, with another two increases priced over 2027.

The US dollar received a solid bid alongside renewed strength in AI and tech stocks, lifting the DXY 0.7% to its highest since April 2025, while the Aussie slipped to around USD0.6850.

Australian dwelling finance approvals surprised materially to the downside in Q3, with the value of approvals plunging a record 15.5% as investor lending values dropped by nearly a third.

Data snapshot

FX Last 24 hrs	Current	Change
TWI	63.8	-0.5%
AUD/USD	0.6850	-0.2%
AUD/JPY	109.50	0.5%
AUD/GBP	0.5159	0.3%
AUD/NZD	1.2308	0.5%
AUD/EUR	0.6176	0.4%
AUD/CNH	4.5719	-0.3%
AUD/SGD	0.8801	0.0%
AUD/HKD	5.3741	-0.2%
AUD/CAD	0.9760	0.2%
EUR/USD	1.1093	-0.6%
USD/JPY	159.85	0.7%
USD Index	102.90	0.7%

AUS Interest Rate Swaps	Last	Change
30 day BBSY	4.86	0.01
90 day BBSY	4.99	0.01
180 day BBSY	5.35	0.03
1 year swap	4.95	0.01
2 year swap	4.82	0.02
3 year swap	4.76	0.02
4 year swap	4.74	0.01
5 year swap	4.76	0.01
6 year swap	4.80	0.01
7 year swap	4.84	0.01
8 year swap	4.88	0.01
9 year swap	4.93	0.01
10 year swap	4.96	0.00

Equities	Close	Change
S&P/ASX 200	9,153	0.3%
S&P 500	7,626	1.4%
Japan Nikkei	61,249	1.3%
Hang Seng	24,316	-1.0%
Euro Stoxx 50	6,393	1.0%
UK FTSE100	10,835	0.8%
VIX Index	17.4	-10.6%

Government Bond Yields	Close	Change
Australia		
3 year bond	4.73	0.07
10 year bond	5.04	0.06
United States		
3-month T Bill	4.11	-0.01
2 year bond	4.74	0.00
10 year bond	4.99	0.00
Other (10 year yields)		
Germany	3.32	0.00
Japan	2.80	0.11
UK	5.22	0.00

Commodities	Current	Change
CRB Index	386.48	0.7%
Gold	3985.69	-1.2%
Copper	13817	1.0%
Oil (WTI futures)	86.31	0.3%
Coal (coking)	253.50	-0.2%
Coal (thermal)	143.40	3.3%
Iron Ore	91.25	-0.4%
ACCU	36.13	-4.3%

Sydney Futures Exchange	Current	Change
10 yr bond	5.05	0.00
3 yr bond	4.73	0.01
3 mth bill rate	4.77	0.00
SPI 200	9,158	-0.4%

Data as at 7:30am AEDT. Change is from the previous trading day (excluding the SFE, which is the change during the night session). Source: Bloomberg.

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Financial Markets

- Share markets rallied across much of the globe. In the US, reports of an upgraded outlook for CoreWeave, an oversubscribed IPO for Anthropic and a stabilisation in Nvidia supported renewed optimism around AI which buoyed tech stocks, seeing the S&P 500 (+1.4%) and Nasdaq (+1.7%) both rally, though the smaller gain for the Dow Jones (+0.5%) shows the rally was more narrowly based.
- Across the pond, the Euro Stoxx 50 continued to build on recent momentum with another solid gain (+1.0%), while London's FTSE 100 bounced back from a modest decline yesterday (+0.8%). Stocks were up across most of Asia, including Tokyo (+1.3%), Shanghai (+0.4%) and Seoul (+2.6%), with only the Hang Seng (–1.0%) bucking the wider trend. The ASX 200 rose 0.3% yesterday, but weaker trading in futures overnight points to a mixed open this morning.
- Cash trading in bond markets were closed in the US for Veterans Day, but trading in futures points to a continued rise in yields following hotter-than-expected inflation data received earlier in the week, which all but cemented a December FOMC rate hike. Beyond December, markets are also pricing in another two rate hikes over the course of 2027.
- Yields were little changed elsewhere, with the 10Y Bund and Gilt steady on the day. The 10Y JGB meanwhile continued to sell-off, with yields jumping 10bps to 2.80% having effectively unwound the rally over late last week. ACGBs were also weaker during local trading, seeing yields rise 7bps on the 3Y and 6bps on the 10Y, following the sharp rise in global yields the day prior post US CPI. Swaps markets point to no hikes nor cuts from the RBA through to end-2027 at present.
- The USD received a solid bid overnight, buoyed by sharp inflows into AI and tech stocks that improved risk sentiment. The DXY finished 0.7% higher at around 102.9, the strongest since April 2025. That move has pushed the Euro down 0.6% back to a USD1.10 handle, the weakest since May 2025, while the Yen slipped 0.7% to JPY159.9, the weakest since the before the early-September rally. While moves in the AUD was comparatively small overnight, slipping 0.2% to around the USD0.6850 mark, that move builds on recent downward momentum and has the currency delicately positioned near 2026's lows.
- Oil prices rose slightly overnight, stabilising somewhat after recent declines amid ongoing uncertainty around the future of the US-Iran War, as President Trump downplays the possibility of further strikes on Iran all while negotiations show little progress. Brent rose 1.0% to US$92.4/bbl. The rebound in risk sentiment buoyed metals, with LME copper up 1.0% to US$13,817/mt while LME aluminium jumped 1.9% to US$3,068/mt. Gold prices meanwhile dipped 1.2%, falling back below the US$4,000/oz mark, building on recent momentum post US CPI which saw real yields jump higher

Today's key data and events

Time	Event	Exp	Prev
8:45	NZ Card Spending Oct	-	-0.5%
8:45	NZ Net Migration Sep	-	1530k
18:00	GB GDP Q3 Prel.	0.7%	0.5%
18:00	GB Trade Balance Sep	-£2100b	-£920b
0:30	US Initial Jobless Claims 7/11/2026	195k	189k
2:00	US Existing Home Sales Oct	-3.5%	1.5%

Times are AEDT. All data forecasts are m/m or q/q and seasonally adjusted unless otherwise specified. Forecasts for Australian data are our forecasts and for other countries they are consensus forecasts.

International Data

There was no major data out yesterday.

Domestic Data

In Australia, the value of **dwelling finance approvals** surprised materially to the downside in Q3, the 15.5% decline marking the largest quarterly decline on records going back to 1991. The decline looks to be mostly volume-driven, with the number of loans falling sharply compared to the average size of loans. Across segments, investor lending values dropped by nearly a third (see here).

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Cliff Notes: managing expectations

#cliffnotes #rba #australia #inflation #us #fomc #ecb #aud #usd

By Ryan Wells, Illiana Jain & Elliot Clarke

11:04 October 23 2026

Share

Key insights from the week that was.

With little domestic data of significance, participants' attention focused on RBA Deputy Governor Hauser's fireside chat, which saw an abrupt shift in market expectations of a follow-up rate hike at the November meeting.

Hauser warned in his remarks that the current inflation outlook was "materially worse" than the RBA's

August forecasts. Three upside inflation risks were characterised as having "crystallised" ahead of the September meeting – the Middle East, the AI boom, and domestic supply constraints. Hauser noted the Middle East picture "looks worse" given oil prices are "about a third higher than [the RBA] assumed in August". He then positioned AI and data centre developments among an "extraordinary sequence of positive demand shocks around the world", with "higher AI prices, tech prices feeding through into CPI". Finally, on domestic capacity pressures, the Deputy Governor noted that "inflation's been coming in at or a little bit above expectations, despite an apparent easing in the labour market". He went on to state that the staff are currently assessing "whether [the RBA] need to change [its] judgement on capacity pressures in the labour market again" – in other words, revise up their assumption for the NAIRU.

Hauser's comments prompted a material reassessment of market pricing for a follow-up November hike, from just a 20% chance at the end of last week to a 50/50 proposition today ahead of next week's Q3 CPI. For that release, we are forecasting a 1.3% (4.1%yr) lift in headline inflation and a 0.9 (3.5%yr) increase in trimmed mean inflation. Our preview provides more detail behind the component mix for Q3 as well as our upward revisions to the preliminary Q4 forecast. Provided inflation prints broadly in line with our expectations, the RBA is likely to hike by 25bp at the November meeting.

Across in New Zealand, consumer prices rose 0.7% in Q3 and annual inflation eased from 4.1%yr to 3.7%yr. Under the surface of this 'as expected' read though, several closely watched measures of core inflation took a step higher to now be at or slightly above the top of the RBNZ's target band. Our NZ economics team consequently expect the RBNZ will raise the OCR 25bps to 3.00% at its October policy review, while retaining a 4.00% terminal OCR forecast for September 2027.

Earlier in the week, China's economy surprised to the upside in Q3, GDP growth accelerating from 0.9%qtr to 1.2%qtr, lifting annual growth from 4.3%yr to 4.5%yr – keeping authorities on track to achieve their 4.5-5.0% full-year growth objective.

While annual retail sales growth improved in September, rising from 0.4%yr to 1.1%yr, the current pace of growth is only a quarter of the gain seen just a year ago and very weak versus history. Consumer spending continues to be constrained by weak confidence, particularly with respect to employment prospects and wealth. On housing wealth, five years into the property downturn, house prices continue to decline month-on-month and investment remains in a deep downturn, -20.6%ytd.

Total fixed asset investment has been detracting from annual GDP growth since April owing to a lull in high-tech investment, a lack of confidence in future demand amongst domestically oriented businesses as well as property's malaise. For aggregate growth to hold up through 2027 and 2028 as the contribution from net exports moderates, broad-based stimulus in scale will prove necessary. Expect recent targeted support measures to be broadened and given much greater scale in coming months.

Finally, in the UK, inflation accelerated from 3.1%yr to 3.5%yr in September, exceeding both market expectations and the Bank of England's July forecast. The surprise was largely driven by energy, fuel prices rising 5.4%mth. However, core inflation also edged up from 2.6%yr to 2.8%yr as services inflation increased from 3.4%yr to 3.7%yr. While not an immediate concern inflation, the labour market showing resilience, the ILO unemployment rate falling from 4.9% to 4.7% in August, suggests demand

risks for inflation will need close monitoring as well as supply-side concerns.

Next week will see the focus once again return to the US as the FOMC meet and US Q3 GDP is released. For both events, the implications for risks to the outlook will be the focus. The week after, the US mid-term elections are due.

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12 November 2026

MORNING REPORT

Today's economic developments and market movements.

Key themes

Renewed optimism around AI drove US equities higher overnight, with positive developments around CoreWeave and Anthropic adding to enthusiasm around the sector and helping the S&P 500 and NASDAQ rally.

US cash bond markets were closed for Veterans Day, though futures continued to point to higher Treasury yields following this week's hotter-than-expected inflation data, which has all but cemented a December FOMC hike, with another two increases priced over 2027.

The US dollar received a solid bid alongside renewed strength in AI and tech stocks, lifting the DXY 0.7% to its highest since April 2025, while the Aussie slipped to around USD0.6850.

Australian dwelling finance approvals surprised materially to the downside in Q3, with the value of approvals plunging a record 15.5% as investor lending values dropped by nearly a third.

Data snapshot

FX Last 24 hrs	Current	Change
TWI	63.8	-0.5%
AUD/USD	0.6850	-0.2%
AUD/JPY	109.50	0.5%
AUD/GBP	0.5159	0.3%
AUD/NZD	1.2308	0.5%
AUD/EUR	0.6176	0.4%
AUD/CNH	4.5719	-0.3%
AUD/SGD	0.8801	0.0%
AUD/HKD	5.3741	-0.2%
AUD/CAD	0.9760	0.2%
EUR/USD	1.1093	-0.6%
USD/JPY	159.85	0.7%
USD Index	102.90	0.7%

AUS Interest Rate Swaps	Last	Change
30 day BBSY	4.86	0.01
90 day BBSY	4.99	0.01
180 day BBSY	5.35	0.03
1 year swap	4.95	0.01
2 year swap	4.82	0.02
3 year swap	4.76	0.02
4 year swap	4.74	0.01
5 year swap	4.76	0.01
6 year swap	4.80	0.01
7 year swap	4.84	0.01
8 year swap	4.88	0.01
9 year swap	4.93	0.01
10 year swap	4.96	0.00

Equities	Close	Change
S&P/ASX 200	9,153	0.3%
S&P 500	7,626	1.4%
Japan Nikkei	61,249	1.3%
Hang Seng	24,316	-1.0%
Euro Stoxx 50	6,393	1.0%
UK FTSE100	10,835	0.8%
VIX Index	17.4	-10.6%

Government Bond Yields	Close	Change
Australia		
3 year bond	4.73	0.07
10 year bond	5.04	0.06
United States		
3-month T Bill	4.11	-0.01
2 year bond	4.74	0.00
10 year bond	4.99	0.00
Other (10 year yields)		
Germany	3.32	0.00
Japan	2.80	0.11
UK	5.22	0.00

Commodities	Current	Change
CRB Index	386.48	0.7%
Gold	3985.69	-1.2%
Copper	13817	1.0%
Oil (WTI futures)	86.31	0.3%
Coal (coking)	253.50	-0.2%
Coal (thermal)	143.40	3.3%
Iron Ore	91.25	-0.4%
ACCU	36.13	-4.3%

Sydney Futures Exchange	Current	Change
10 yr bond	5.05	0.00
3 yr bond	4.73	0.01
3 mth bill rate	4.77	0.00
SPI 200	9,158	-0.4%

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Financial Markets

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Today's key data and events

Time	Event	Exp	Prev
8:45	NZ Card Spending Oct	-	-0.5%
8:45	NZ Net Migration Sep	-	1530k
18:00	GB GDP Q3 Prel.	0.7%	0.5%
18:00	GB Trade Balance Sep	-£2100b	-£920b
0:30	US Initial Jobless Claims 7/11/2026	195k	189k
2:00	US Existing Home Sales Oct	-3.5%	1.5%

Times are AEDT. All data forecasts are m/m or q/q and seasonally adjusted unless otherwise specified. Forecasts for Australian data are our forecasts and for other countries they are consensus forecasts.

International Data

There was no major data out yesterday.

Domestic Data

In Australia, the value of **dwelling finance approvals** surprised materially to the downside in Q3, the 15.5% decline marking the largest quarterly decline on records going back to 1991. The decline looks to be mostly volume-driven, with the number of loans falling sharply compared to the average size of loans. Across segments, investor lending values dropped by nearly a third (see here).

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12 November 2026

MORNING REPORT

Today's economic developments and market movements.

Key themes

Renewed optimism around AI drove US equities higher overnight, with positive developments around CoreWeave and Anthropic adding to enthusiasm around the sector and helping the S&P 500 and NASDAQ rally.

US cash bond markets were closed for Veterans Day, though futures continued to point to higher Treasury yields following this week's hotter-than-expected inflation data, which has all but cemented a December FOMC hike, with another two increases priced over 2027.

The US dollar received a solid bid alongside renewed strength in AI and tech stocks, lifting the DXY 0.7% to its highest since April 2025, while the Aussie slipped to around USD0.6850.

Australian dwelling finance approvals surprised materially to the downside in Q3, with the value of approvals plunging a record 15.5% as investor lending values dropped by nearly a third.

Data snapshot

FX Last 24 hrs	Current	Change
TWI	63.8	-0.5%
AUD/USD	0.6850	-0.2%
AUD/JPY	109.50	0.5%
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18:00	GB Trade Balance Sep	-£2100b	-£920b
0:30	US Initial Jobless Claims 7/11/2026	195k	189k
2:00	US Existing Home Sales Oct	-3.5%	1.5%

Times are AEDT. All data forecasts are m/m or q/q and seasonally adjusted unless otherwise specified. Forecasts for Australian data are our forecasts and for other countries they are consensus forecasts.

International Data

There was no major data out yesterday.

Domestic Data

In Australia, the value of **dwelling finance approvals** surprised materially to the downside in Q3, the 15.5% decline marking the largest quarterly decline on records going back to 1991. The decline looks to be mostly volume-driven, with the number of loans falling sharply compared to the average size of loans. Across segments, investor lending values dropped by nearly a third (see here).

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RESERVE BANK OF AUSTRALIA

Statement on Monetary Policy

November 2026

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Statement on Monetary Policy

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Overview

Inflation in Australia remains well above target and a number of upside risks have crystallised since the August *Statement*. In particular, materially higher global energy prices as a result of the Middle East conflict have added to inflationary pressures. Government bond yields in advanced economies have risen to their highest levels in many years, reflecting a combination of higher term premia, higher neutral rates and expectations of higher policy rates for a time in response to global inflationary pressures. Domestically, housing market conditions have eased and the unemployment rate has risen further than anticipated. However, a range of data, including persistently strong inflation and growth in a broad range of costs, suggest that domestic capacity pressures have been a little greater than previously assessed.

The outlook for inflation has been revised materially higher and reflects a higher assumed path for energy prices amid the ongoing Middle East conflict and greater domestic capacity pressures. Headline and underlying inflation are expected to remain above 3 per cent until end-2027, some time later than forecast in August, and reach the midpoint of the 2–3 per cent range in mid-2028. The risks to the inflation outlook are judged to remain skewed to the upside reflecting risks posed by the Middle East conflict. Tighter monetary policy alongside a weaker outlook for the housing market is expected to keep GDP growth below trend. The unemployment rate is projected to reach a bit over 5 per cent at the end of 2028.

The Monetary Policy Board decided it was appropriate to increase the cash rate target by 25 basis points to 4.85 per cent. Inflation remains elevated and recent data indicate that it is broadly based. The Board noted the increasing risk that higher inflation expectations will become embedded and judged that a further tightening in financial conditions is warranted to support the return of inflation to target.

Globally, higher energy prices and resilient demand growth have added to inflationary pressures, and most advanced-economy central banks have either raised policy rates or are expected to.

The ongoing Middle East conflict has pushed up energy prices. As a result, headline inflation has increased across most economies. Prices for a range of base metals and agricultural commodities have also risen sharply in recent months, driven by the conflicts in the Middle East and Ukraine and adverse weather.

Global economic demand has also been more resilient than expected, supported by the AI boom overseas. GDP growth in Australia's major trading partners has trended higher over recent years. Recently, the boost to trading partner growth from AI-related demand and supportive fiscal measures in many economies has offset the adverse effects of the Middle East conflict. Market pricing implies that most advanced economy central banks are expected to increase policy rates at least twice by the end of 2027, in line with higher near-term inflationary pressures.

This in part explains why government bond yields have risen to multi-year highs.

Against the backdrop of stronger global inflationary pressures, government bond yields have risen since the August *Statement*, to their highest level in many years, including in Australia. This reflects a range of factors including expectations of tighter monetary policy in the near term given global capacity and inflationary pressures, as well as some combination of higher neutral interest rates and higher term premia. Long-term inflation expectations in financial markets remain consistent with central bank targets.

Growth in Australia's major trading partners is still expected to moderate over the next couple of years as the boost from AI-related activity slows and growth in China eases. Headline inflation is expected to remain above central bank targets into 2027 in many advanced economies, reflecting higher energy and other commodity prices, resilient demand and rapid growth in AI-related prices. Risks to global inflation are judged to remain skewed to the upside.

Domestically, growth in activity has slowed, housing market conditions have eased further, and the unemployment rate has risen by more than expected.

In Australia, GDP growth has slowed to a little below its estimated potential growth rate, largely reflecting softer growth in household consumption – consistent with the earlier easing in growth in household income and wealth – exports and public demand. Notwithstanding this slowing in growth, recent data suggest that activity growth this year has been a little stronger than anticipated in the August *Statement*, supported by rapid growth in data centre investment.

By contrast, conditions in the housing market have eased further. Housing prices in September were almost 5 per cent below their March peak, reflecting higher interest rates and tax changes announced in the federal budget. The unemployment rate rose by more than expected to average 4.6 per cent in the September quarter. That appears to largely reflect a stronger-than-expected pick-up in labour force participation amid cost-of-living pressures, while employment growth has held up.

But inflation has been higher than expected, cost pressures remain elevated, and capacity constraints are now assessed to have been a little tighter than previously thought.

Headline inflation was 3.9 per cent over the year to the September quarter and trimmed mean inflation was 3.7 per cent. While the price of fuel has increased significantly, inflation has been broad-based, with sizeable price increases for a range of market services. Liaison contacts across most industries continue to report sustained cost pressures.

The persistence of high inflation and cost pressures, despite the easing in GDP growth and the rise in unemployment, suggests that domestic capacity constraints have been tighter than previously assessed. Reflecting this, the staff's assessment of the unemployment rate consistent with low and stable inflation has increased a little, though this assessment remains highly uncertain.

Financial conditions appear to be restrictive, which is expected to weigh on domestic capacity pressures.

Financial conditions are judged to be restrictive. There is, however, significant uncertainty around the extent of this restrictiveness given conflicting evidence. Supporting this assessment, the current level of the cash rate is slightly above the top of the range of central estimates of the neutral rate, and the expected cash rate path is higher still. Housing prices have declined and new housing lending has fallen sharply. However, business credit growth remains strong and corporate risk premia remain low.

The Australian dollar has appreciated since the start of the year and is judged to be around estimates of its long-run equilibrium.

Ahead of the November meeting, market pricing was implying expectations of around one and a half further cash rate increases by mid-next year.

Inflation is expected to remain above 3 per cent until late 2027, reflecting recent increases in fuel and other conflict-related costs and greater domestic capacity pressures.

The outlook for inflation has been revised materially higher relative to the August *Statement*, particularly through to late 2027. Fuel and other conflict-related costs have increased by more than expected since August, owing to the ongoing conflict in the Middle East. Some of these additional costs are expected to be passed on to consumer prices, while elevated prices of petrol and diesel will also contribute directly to higher headline inflation in the near term. The stronger outlook for underlying inflation also reflects the staff's judgement that capacity pressures have been a little greater this year than thought in August. Headline and trimmed mean inflation are now expected to remain above 3 per cent until end-2027, some time later than forecast in August, and to return to 2.5 per cent in mid-2028.

The risks to the inflation outlook remain skewed to the upside.

Some of the upside risks identified in August have materialised and are now incorporated in the central forecast, including greater domestic capacity pressures and higher oil prices. But upside risks to inflation from the Middle East conflict and AI-related investment are judged to remain. Energy prices could stay at current elevated levels or rise further, rather than decline as assumed, if disruptions to shipping and refining persist. Combined with ongoing capacity pressures in the domestic economy and elevated inflation expectations, this would increase the risk of stronger pass-through to consumer prices. Strong AI-related investment activity could also push up input costs by more than expected, both directly and by adding to capacity pressures.

However, inflation could fall faster than forecast. For example, capacity pressures could ease sooner if higher interest rates, conflict-related cost pressures and uncertainty, and falling housing prices combine to weigh more heavily than expected on spending and investment.

In Australia, tighter monetary policy is expected to keep GDP growth below potential, with spare capacity emerging in the labour market in 2027.

Higher-than-expected global energy prices, a softer housing market and a higher assumed path for the cash rate than in the August forecasts are expected to constrain domestic GDP growth. The very strong expansion in data centre investment is expected to only partly offset these headwinds to growth.

Labour market conditions are expected to ease. The unemployment rate is forecast to rise to a bit over 5 per cent by end-2028. That is consistent with below-potential GDP growth but is around ¼ percentage point higher than previously expected, largely reflecting the judgement that more people than previously forecast will remain in or join the labour force. The economy is currently operating with excess demand and is judged to reach balance next year, slightly later than previously thought, with spare capacity emerging in 2027.

The Monetary Policy Board decided to increase the cash rate target.

Inflation remains elevated and data since the previous meeting have confirmed that underlying inflation remains broadly based. Capacity pressures appear a little tighter than previously estimated and there are indications that higher fuel prices are being passed through to prices of other goods and services. Inflation is now expected to remain above 3 per cent for the coming year and there is an increasing risk that higher inflation expectations will become embedded. Given the revised inflation outlook and the continuing upside risks, the Board judged that a further tightening in financial conditions is warranted to support the return of inflation to target. The Board stated that it will continue to do what it considers necessary to bring inflation sustainably back to target.

Table: Output Growth, Unemployment and Inflation Forecasts[a]

Per cent

	Year-ended					
	June 2026	Dec 2026	June 2027	Dec 2027	June 2028	Dec 2028
GDP growth	2.1	1.6	1.6	1.3	1.3	1.5
(previous)	(1.9)	(1.4)	(1.5)	(1.6)	(1.6)	(1.8)
Unemployment rate[b]	4.4	4.7	4.8	4.9	5.0	5.1
(previous)	(4.4)	(4.5)	(4.6)	(4.7)	(4.8)	(4.8)
CPI inflation	3.9	4.5	3.7	2.7	2.5	2.4
(previous)	(3.9)	(3.6)	(2.8)	(2.6)	(2.4)	(2.4)
Trimmed mean inflation	3.6	3.6	3.5	2.9	2.5	2.4
(previous)	(3.6)	(3.3)	(3.0)	(2.6)	(2.4)	(2.4)

	Year-average					
	2025/26	2026	2026/27	2027	2027/28	2028
GDP growth	2.3	2.1	1.8	1.5	1.3	1.4
(previous)	(2.2)	(1.9)	(1.5)	(1.5)	(1.6)	(1.7)

	Assumptions[c]					
Cash rate (%)	4.3	4.7	4.9	4.8	4.8	4.8
Trade-weighted index (index)	66.1	65.2	65.3	65.3	65.3	65.3

(a) Forecasts finalised on 28 October. Shading indicates historical data.

(b) Average rate in the quarter.

(c) The forecasts incorporate several technical assumptions. The cash rate is assumed to move in line with expectations derived from financial market pricing as per 28 October and the daily exchange rate (TWI) is assumed to be unchanged from its level at 28 October 2026 going forward. See notes to Table 3.1: Detailed Forecast Table in Chapter 3: Outlook for other forecast assumptions.

Sources: ABS; LSEG; RBA.

Chapter 1
Financial Conditions

Summary

- **Financial conditions are judged to be restrictive, but with various cross-currents making it difficult to determine the extent of this.** Over the course of this year, the rise in the cash rate target and the expected path of rates, along with higher term premia, have contributed to tighter financial conditions. And while some estimates of the neutral rate have also risen, the cash rate and market-implied path are still a little above the top of the range of central estimates of neutral. Also, housing prices have declined by more than expected and new housing lending has declined sharply in response to tighter monetary policy and recent tax changes. Meanwhile, the nominal exchange rate has appreciated since the start of the year but remains broadly in line with estimates of its long-run equilibrium relationship. By contrast, business credit growth remains very strong and corporate risk premia are very low. Moreover, funding remains readily available for banks and most household and business borrowers.
- **Overnight indexed swap (OIS) pricing implies market participants assign an 85 per cent probability to a cash rate increase in November, with around one and a half cash rate increases priced in by mid-2027.** Expectations for the cash rate have increased since the August *Statement*. This reflects stronger-than-expected domestic inflation data, higher oil prices, the September cash rate increase, and RBA communications that on balance were interpreted as hawkish. Almost all market economists tracked by the staff expect a cash rate increase in November.
- **Most advanced economy central banks are expected to raise policy rates further over the next year.** Since the August *Statement*, the US Federal Reserve (Fed), European Central Bank (ECB), Bank of Japan (BoJ), Bank of Canada (BoC), Reserve Bank of New Zealand (RBNZ), Norges Bank and Bank of Korea (BoK) increased their policy rates, while the Bank of England (BoE) left its policy rate unchanged but retained a tightening bias. These actions, and the increase in market-implied future policy paths since August, reflect the re-escalation of the Middle East conflict and, in some economies, persistent inflationary pressures stemming from capacity constraints. Market pricing implies that most advanced economy central banks are expected to increase policy rates at least twice by the end of 2027.

- **Government bond yields have increased notably across advanced economies in recent months, in many cases reaching their highest levels in many years, including in Australia.** Higher yields reflect expectations of tighter monetary policy in the near term, higher neutral interest rates and higher term premia. The increase in longer-term yields has occurred at a time of strong public and private sector debt issuance, and models suggest that roughly half of the rise in yields is due to term premia and half to perceptions of neutral (although there is considerable uncertainty around these estimates). Long-term inflation expectations remain consistent with central bank targets even though shorter-term expectations are elevated. While sovereign debt markets have continued to function well across major advanced economies, bond market volatility has increased in recent weeks and the rise in bond yields in some European countries has been large (particularly France, amid fiscal concerns).
- **In corporate funding markets, equity and credit risk premia remain low for higher-quality firms but have risen for lower-rated and more interest-rate-sensitive firms.** Spreads on investment-grade corporate bonds, including in Australia, remain around historical lows despite strong issuance, while sub-investment grade spreads have widened but remain very low in historical terms. In major equity markets, strong gains in energy stocks and some IT stocks since the August *Statement* have offset declines in most other sectors, though investors are differentiating more between AI-related firms. Australian equity prices have declined in response to the rise in interest rates and as the downturn in the housing market has lowered earnings expectations in some key sectors.

1.1 Assessment of financial conditions

Financial conditions in Australia are assessed to be restrictive, but with various cross-currents making it difficult to determine the extent of this.

The cash rate is slightly above the range of model-based and market economist estimates of neutral, and the expected cash rate path based on market pricing is higher still, suggesting that policy is restrictive. Other indicators paint a mixed picture. For example, housing market conditions have weakened by more than the tightening in monetary policy would suggest and funding conditions for property developers have tightened, suggesting that financial conditions are clearly restrictive. At the same time, however, funding conditions for most other businesses remain favourable and do not suggest that conditions are particularly restrictive. Table 1.1 summarises evidence contributing to this assessment.

Table 1.1: Various Measures of Financial Conditions[(a)]

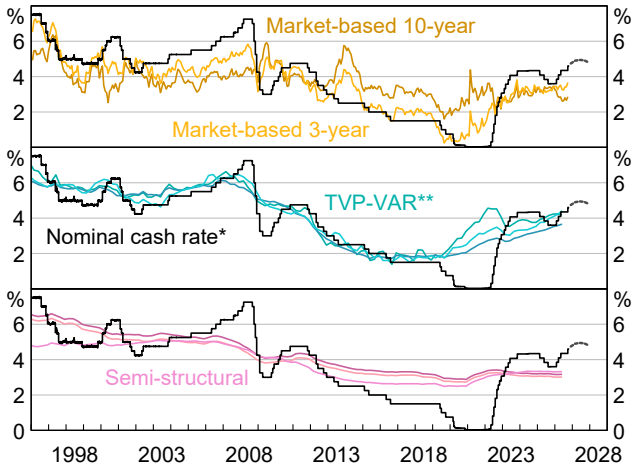
Measure	Implications for financial conditions	Notes supporting assessment
Cash rate path (as per market)	Restrictive (●)	Cash rate is slightly above the top of the range of model and market economists' estimates of neutral; the market path rises above that
Housing market indicators and household credit	Weakening, implies financial conditions are restrictive (●)	Tax changes amplifying the effects of monetary policy; prices and lending falling faster than expected (albeit after very strong growth)
Long-term Australian Government Securities (AGS) yields	May be adding to restrictiveness at the margin (○)	At least some of the recent increase is judged to be driven by term premia, raising longer-term borrowing costs and weighing on asset valuations; however, effects of longer-term yields are less than shorter-term yields in Australia
AUD trade-weighted index (TWI)	TWI judged to be in line with fundamentals, although there is uncertainty around this assessment	Broadly consistent with moves in interest rates
Bank lending rates	In line with the rise in the cash rate	Broadly consistent with moves in the cash rate
Business credit	Implies financial conditions are less restrictive (♦)	Growth remains strong and credit remains readily available for most borrowers
Corporate risk premia	Implies financial conditions are less restrictive (♦)	Credit and equity risk premia are low despite subdued Australian earnings expectations

(a) Red shading (● and ○) is used for measures that imply more restrictive financial conditions, while green shading (♦) is used for measures that imply less restrictive conditions.

Source: RBA.

There are some tentative signs that neutral rates may be rising, globally and in Australia. Since the pandemic, estimates of neutral rates in advanced economies have increased by 1–3 percentage points, and the recent sharp increase in long-term global bond yields is consistent with market participants revising their estimates of the global neutral rate higher still (see Box A: How Does an Increase in Longer-term Real Yields Affect Financial Conditions?). As a small open economy, Australia's neutral rate is likely to be significantly influenced by neutral rates globally (see Box B: Developments in the Neutral Rate of Interest). Consistent with that, some of our estimates of neutral and those of market economists have increased since the August *Statement*, though the average of all measures is not much changed (Graph 1.1).

Graph 1.1
Nominal Neutral Rate
Suite of models



* Dashed line shows cash rate expectations implied by overnight index swap rates.
** Time-varying parameter vector autoregression models (TVP-VAR).
Source: RBA.

By itself, a rising neutral rate would imply that any given path for policy rates is somewhat less restrictive than previously assessed. However, the cash rate and market path have also increased since the August *Statement*, and term premia estimates are higher. Long-term inflation expectations are little changed and consistent with the inflation target, suggesting that market participants expect policy will be set at a level that is sufficiently restrictive to contain inflationary pressures.

Other indicators of financial conditions provide a mixed picture. Bank lending rates and short-term bond yields have evolved broadly in line with increases in the cash rate and its expected path. Housing prices and new lending have declined by more than expected, indicating tight financial conditions for the housing sector in response to monetary policy tightening and tax changes. By contrast, strong business credit growth and generally very low corporate borrowing spreads and equity risk premia suggest that financial conditions are not overly restraining aggregate business funding (though conditions have tightened considerably in some sectors, most notably housing construction).

This assessment of financial conditions is subject to uncertainty. Elevated global borrowing by the public and private sector, including to fund AI investments – and the possibility of stronger AI-led productivity growth in future – could materially raise global and domestic neutral rates over time. Conversely, the strong response of the Australian housing market could indicate that the tax changes are amplifying the effects of tighter monetary policy by more than expected, while weaker-than-expected labour market outcomes suggest that policy is working to restrain economic activity. Term premia also appear to have risen, which would tighten financial conditions at the margin. However, there is considerable uncertainty around estimates of term premia, neutral rates and the lags with which changes in the cash rate affect financial conditions.

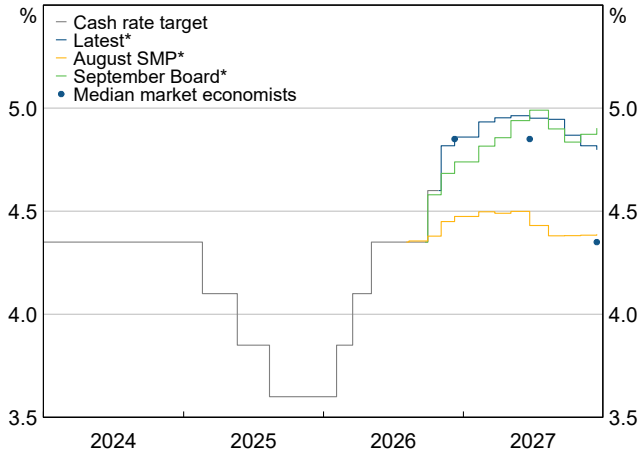
1.2 Interest rate markets

Expectations for the cash rate implied by market pricing have risen since the August *Statement*.

OIS pricing implies market participants assign an 85 per cent probability to a cash rate increase in November, and around one and a half cash rate increases are priced by mid-2027 (Graph 1.2). The rise in expectations reflects stronger-than-expected domestic inflation data, higher oil prices, the September cash rate increase, and RBA communications that on balance were interpreted as hawkish. Almost all market economists tracked by the staff expect a cash rate increase in November.

Graph 1.2

Cash Rate Expectations



* Cash rate expectations implied by overnight index swap rates, latest is at close 28 October.

Sources: LSEG; RBA.

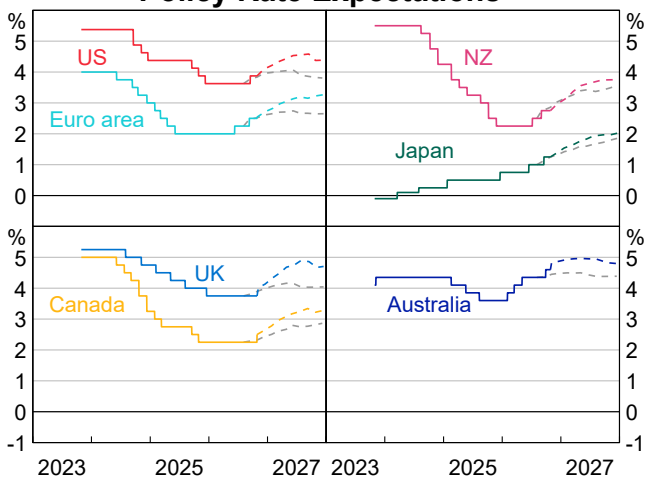
Most advanced economy central banks are expected to tighten policy further, reflecting inflationary pressures, including from the effects of the Middle East conflict.

Since the August *Statement*, the Fed, ECB, BoJ, BoC, RBNZ, Norges Bank and BoK all increased their policy rates. Many of these central banks highlighted the strength or resilience of economic growth and inflationary pressures from the re-escalation in the Middle East conflict, with inflation already persistently above target in some economies. By contrast, the BoE left its policy rates unchanged, citing a balance between downside risks to activity and upside risks to inflation. The BoE indicated that it would tighten policy further if upside inflation risks were to materialise.

Market-implied policy paths have shifted up in advanced economies since the August *Statement* (Graph 1.3). Market pricing implies policy rates are expected to increase by around 75 basis points and be at or above the range of estimates of neutral in many advanced economies by the end of next year (although central banks have expressed uncertainty about the level of neutral) (Graph 1.4). For most economies, much of the increase in policy rate paths occurred following the re-escalation in the Middle East conflict. Stronger-than-expected economic activity and central bank communication emphasising upside risks to inflation also contributed to the upward shift in some economies.

Graph 1.3

Policy Rate Expectations*

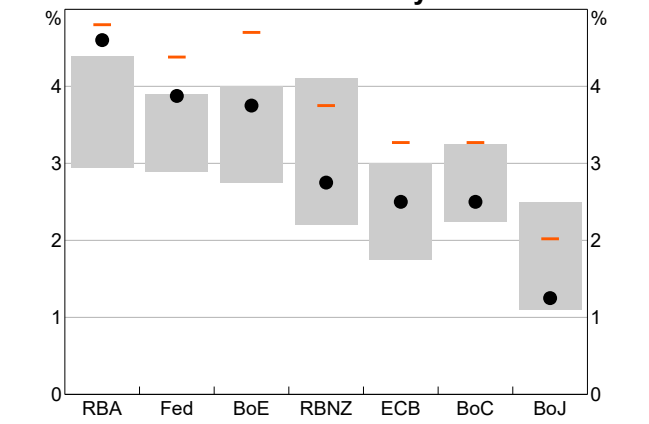


* Coloured dashed lines show expectations implied by current overnight index swap rates; grey dashed lines show the same expectations as of 5 August 2026.

Sources: Bloomberg; RBA.

Graph 1.4

Estimates of Central Bank Policy Restrictiveness*



* Range of estimates of nominal neutral rate are based on assessments by individual central banks and are not directly comparable across countries.

** Based on OIS pricing for policy rates at the end of 2027.

*** Ranges for the RBA, RBNZ, BoC, BoE, ECB and BoJ are based on the range of central estimates from a range of models; and for the Fed are the range of FOMC participants' longer-run Fed Funds rate projections.

Sources: Bloomberg; central banks; RBA.

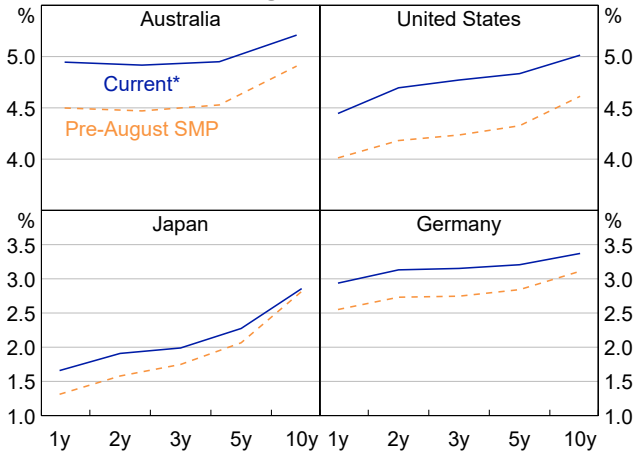
The People's Bank of China (PBC) has retained a slight easing bias amid low inflation, and incrementally eased policy in late September through structural policy tools. The tools direct lending to priority sectors, including infrastructure and manufacturing, and accompanied increased bond issuance quotas for local governments (see Chapter 2: Economic Conditions). Authorities have said that they are concerned that broader monetary easing through a lower policy rate would pressure bank profitability.

Advanced economy government bond yields have risen further to be around their highest level in many years.

Government bond yields have increased materially across advanced economies since the August *Statement*, notwithstanding some retracement over recent weeks alongside declines in equity prices. Shorter-term yields are around 40 basis points higher, reflecting expectations of monetary policy tightening in response to near-term inflationary pressure (Graph 1.5). Longer-term yields have increased by around 30 basis points for many economies, driven by an increase in real yields. Most recently, growing concerns about the sustainability and profitability of capital expenditure plans at some AI-related firms (see below) has seen yields decline somewhat as investors have switched into safer government bonds. Model-based decompositions attribute roughly half of the increase in the US 10-year nominal Treasury yield since the August *Statement* to higher expected future real policy rates, and the rest to higher term premia, but there is considerable uncertainty around these estimates. Box A: How Does an Increase in Longer-term Real Yields Affect Financial Conditions? discusses the recent increase in yields globally and the implications for financial conditions in Australia, while Box B: Developments in the Neutral Rate of Interest discusses the neutral rate and its longer-term drivers.

Graph 1.5

Sovereign Yield Curves

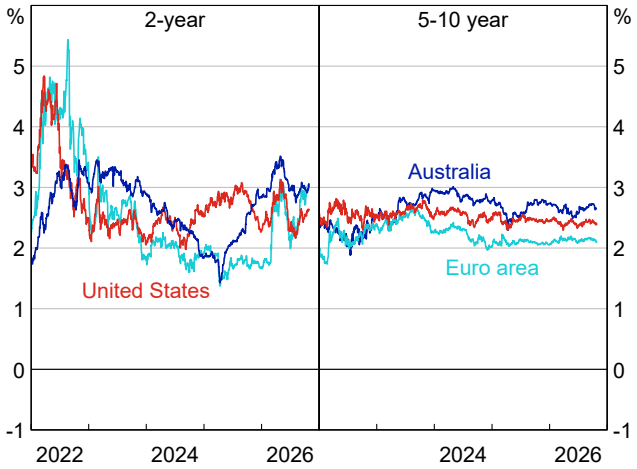


* At market close 28 October 2026.

Source: Bloomberg.

Longer-term inflation compensation is little changed and remains consistent with central bank targets, implying that market participants expect central banks to set policy rates to ensure that inflation is returned to target in a timely way (Graph 1.6).

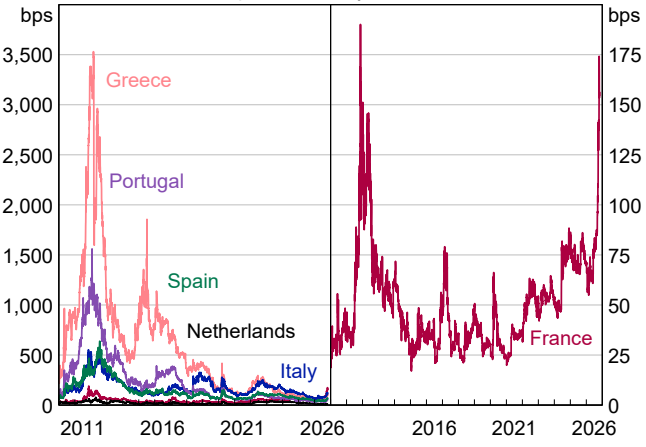
Graph 1.6
Measures of Inflation Compensation
Implied by market pricing*



* Inflation swap-implied rates, except for the Australian 2-year rate, which is the breakeven inflation rate implied by inflation-linked bonds.
Sources: Bloomberg; RBA.

Volatility has increased in many sovereign bond markets. Concerns about fiscal sustainability in France saw the spread between 10-year French and German government bonds rise to around the highest level since the eurozone crisis (Graph 1.7). However, outside Europe, market pricing provides little evidence of material concerns about sovereign credit risk: government bond auctions have generally remained well supported, long-term inflation compensation remains anchored and sovereign credit default swap premia remain low.

Graph 1.7
10-year Government Bond Yields
Euro area spreads to 10-year German Bund

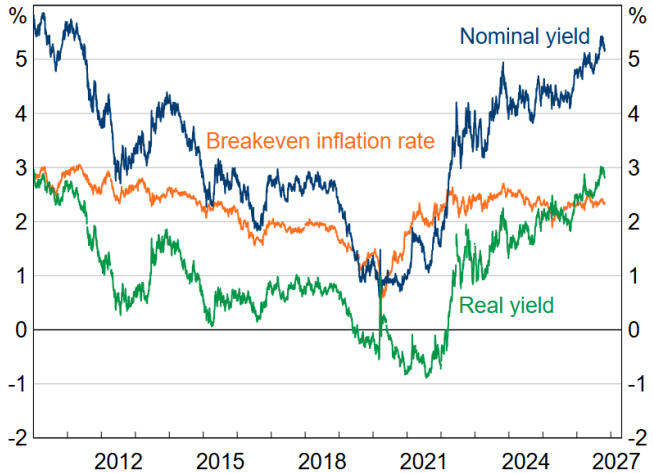


Source: Bloomberg.

In emerging markets, local-currency sovereign bond yields have risen since the August *Statement*, though in many cases by a little less than in advanced markets. Chinese bond yields remain little changed, underpinned by low inflation and low policy rates, and with capital controls reducing the sensitivity of Chinese yields to movements in global rates. In the rest of emerging Asia, lower debt-to-GDP ratios in many countries, compared with advanced economies, may be contributing to generally more modest yield increases.

Australian government bond yields have also increased since the August *Statement* to be around their highest levels in many years (Graph 1.8). As in other advanced economies, much of the increase in longer-term yields has been driven by a rise in real yields, while measures of longer-term inflation compensation have been little changed. Market contacts have attributed the rise in longer-term real yields to a combination of higher expected policy rates (including because of a potential rise in the neutral rate) and higher term premia, although views differ on the relative importance (the RBA's model estimates suggest a roughly even split between the two). In recent weeks, yields have declined a little alongside similar moves offshore. The increase in volatility in AGS has been smaller than in peer economies, and AGS market functioning remains good.

Graph 1.8
Components of the 10-year AGS Yield



Sources: Bloomberg; RBA.

1.3 Corporate funding markets

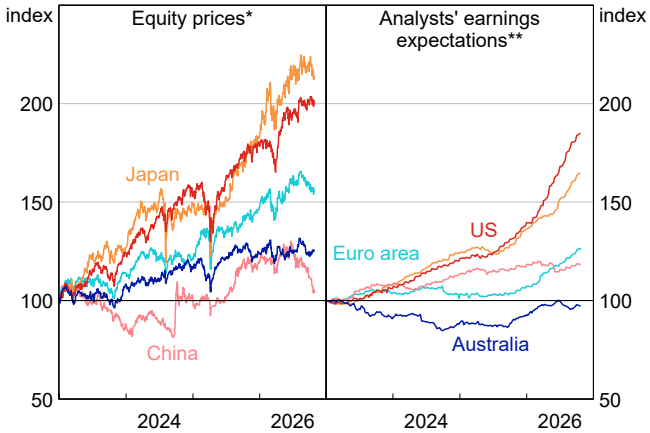
Risk premia for equities and investment-grade corporate bonds remain very low but have increased for lower-rated bonds.

Equity prices in advanced overseas economies have been overall little changed since the August *Statement*, masking significant divergences across sectors and economies (Graph 1.9). Higher interest rates and ongoing tensions in the Middle East have weighed on some sectors, with consumer discretionary and industrial stocks – which are more sensitive to higher yields and energy prices – declining the most (Graph 1.10). By contrast, energy stocks and some IT stocks have continued to rise, although investors are differentiating between technology firms more (see below). In China, equity prices have declined sharply, particularly for AI stocks affected by declining data centre investment sentiment. Meanwhile, earnings growth in the United States has remained broadly based, reflecting continued resilience in economic activity, with growth strongest in AI-related firms. Measures of equity risk premia remain around long-term lows.

Graph 1.9

Equity Prices and Analysts' Earnings Expectations

1 Jan 2023 = 100



* Series is of equity prices returns, rather than total (dividend-adjusted) returns, as price returns are more closely linked to expected future earnings. However, price returns will tend to understate the overall return from investing in Australian equities relative to other markets, given Australian firms typically pay out a greater share of earnings as dividends.

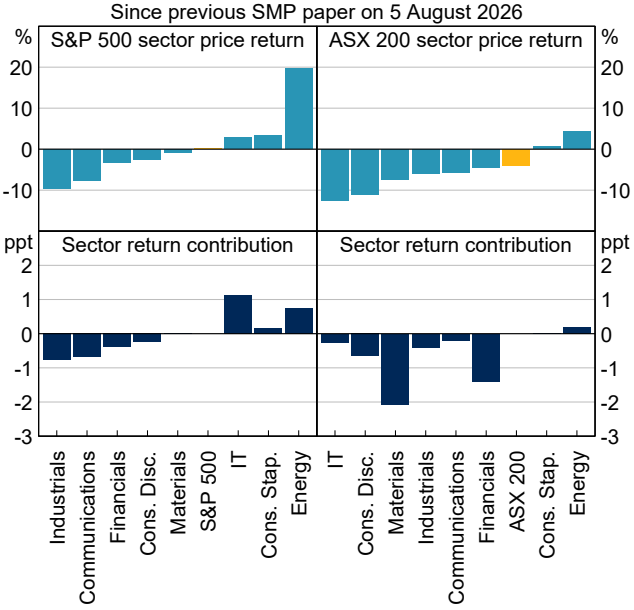
** 12-month forward earnings per share.

Sources: Bloomberg; LSEG; RBA.

Graph 1.10

Equity Sector Price Returns

Since previous SMP paper on 5 August 2026



Sources: Bloomberg; LSEG; RBA.

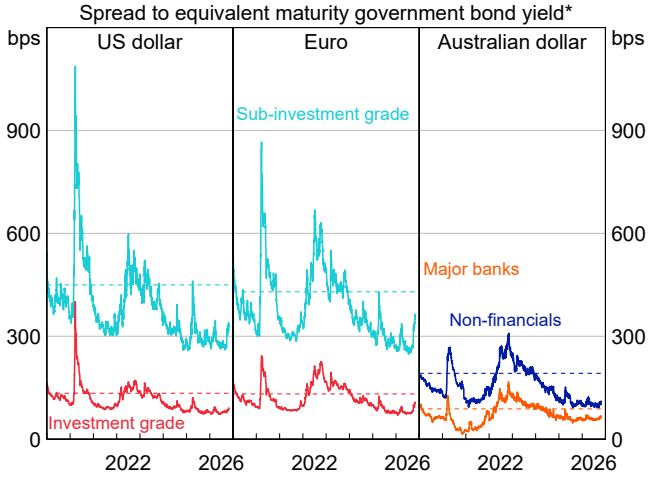
Australian equity prices have declined since the August *Statement*, owing to the effect of higher interest rates and weakness in sectors exposed to the downturn in the domestic housing market. Share prices for banks, consumer discretionary and real estate firms have declined alongside weaker earnings expectations and a higher expected path for the cash rate, and suggest that investors expect consumer spending to remain subdued. Consumer-facing firms continue to report that households remain value conscious and are trading down to lower-cost alternatives, weighing on profitability in discretionary sectors. Profits at consumer staples firms have been more resilient, while equity prices for Australian-listed energy companies have increased alongside higher oil prices. Overall, analysts' earnings expectations for Australian firms have declined recently, having trailed other advanced economies for some years including due to lower prices for key commodities and subdued economic growth.

Investment grade corporate bond spreads have increased slightly in advanced economies but remain around historically low levels (Graph 1.11). The rise in spreads for sub-investment grade firms has been more noticeable, in part because their creditworthiness is more sensitive to higher interest rates, although spreads remain low. The slight increase in Australian bond spreads has tightened funding conditions in Australia at the margin, though funding is readily available to investment grade firms. Borrowers reliant on private credit have seen a more significant tightening of funding conditions, discussed below.

Graph 1.11

Corporate Bond Spreads

Spread to equivalent maturity government bond yield*



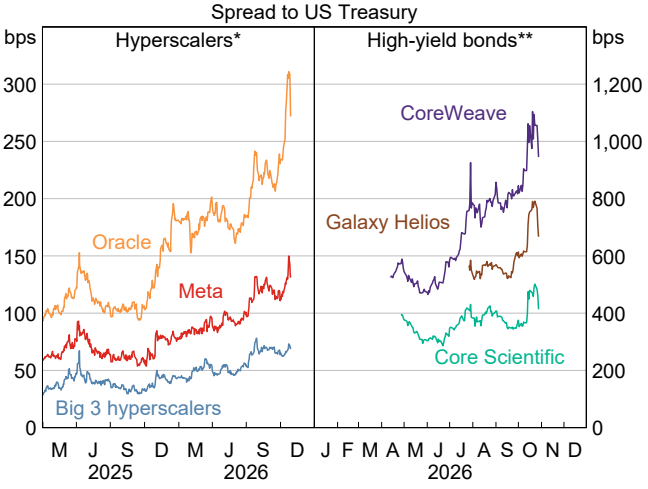
* Dashed lines show long-run averages since 2010.
Sources: Bloomberg; ICE Data used with permission; RBA.

Investors are differentiating between technology firms more. Large 'AI hyperscalers' reported very strong revenue growth in the latest quarter, but their share prices and bond spreads have become more sensitive to substantial upward revisions to planned capital expenditure and to concerns about whether this investment will earn adequate returns (Graph 1.12). Capital expenditure by these firms is now expected to be around US$800 billion this year and to approach US$1.4 trillion by the end of 2027 – around 5 per cent of US GDP and around twice what was expected in late 2025 – with a growing share financed through bond issuance. Korean equity prices have declined, driven by falls in the share prices of memory chip producers amid concerns about the scale and sustainability of the AI data centre build-out; these concerns have also affected Chinese AI stocks (Graph 1.13). By contrast, Taiwanese equities have outperformed those elsewhere in Asia, partly reflecting stronger earnings expectations for chip manufacturer TSMC.

Graph 1.12

Data Centre Corporate Bond Spreads

Spread to US Treasury

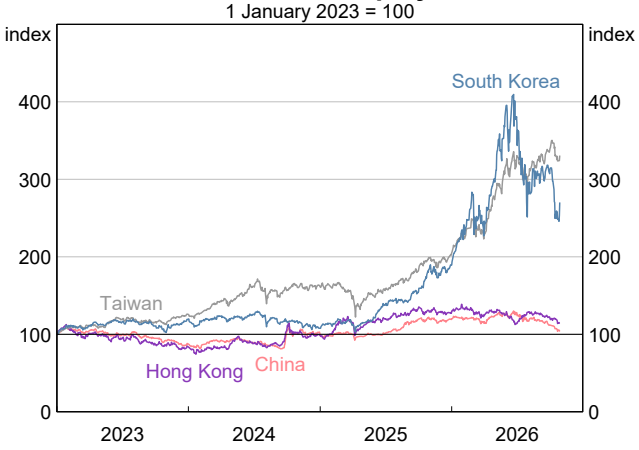


* The Big 3 hyperscalers are Amazon, Google and Microsoft, shown as a simple average. Hyperscaler spreads are interpolated 10-year spreads from LSEG.
** The high-yield data centre bonds are individual bonds that mature in 2031.
Sources: LSEG; RBA.

Graph 1.13

North-East Asian Equity Prices

1 January 2023 = 100



Sources: Bloomberg; LSEG; RBA.

Similarly, some Australian data centre firms have faced increased investor scrutiny. Most notably, AI data centre developer Firmus withdrew its planned initial public offering (IPO) in October following weak investor demand at the proposed valuation, and some other data centre operators have experienced equity price falls and a widening in credit spreads; commentators suggest that the IPO withdrawal may have been one factor contributing to weaker global sentiment towards AI-related firms. By contrast, a range of other Australian data centre operators have seen little change in their cost of capital.

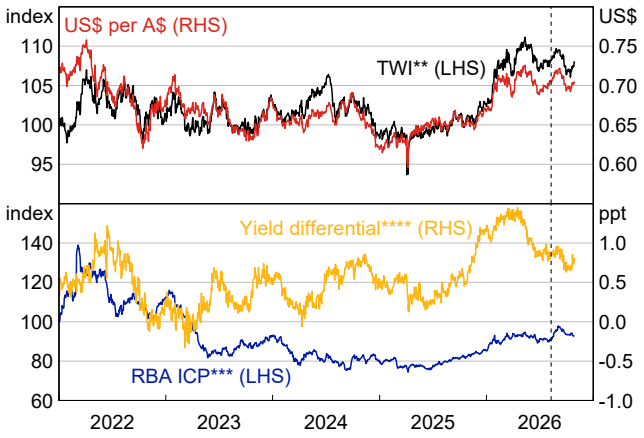
Low corporate credit and equity risk premia suggest that investors continue to expect the economic impact of the Middle East conflict to be limited and AI investment to ultimately be profitable, among other things. However, a material reassessment of the economic viability of AI-related investment, the effects of the Middle East conflict, US policy uncertainty following the midterm elections or concerns about fiscal sustainability globally could lead to a broader weakening in risk sentiment. This could spill over to Australian markets via higher risk premia and reduced access to funding.[1]

1.4 Foreign exchange markets

The Australian dollar is little changed since the August *Statement* and remains around 5 per cent higher than the start of the year.

The Australian dollar TWI is little changed since the August *Statement* (Graph 1.14). Australian government bond yields have risen since August, but major trading partner yields have risen by a similar, and in some cases greater, degree. This modest narrowing in yield differentials has been offset by support from the weaker euro following concerns regarding fiscal sustainability in France. Since the start of the year, the Australian dollar has appreciated by around 5 per cent in TWI terms and remains broadly consistent with estimates of its long-run equilibrium level, although there is a degree of uncertainty around this assessment.

Graph 1.14
Australian Dollar*



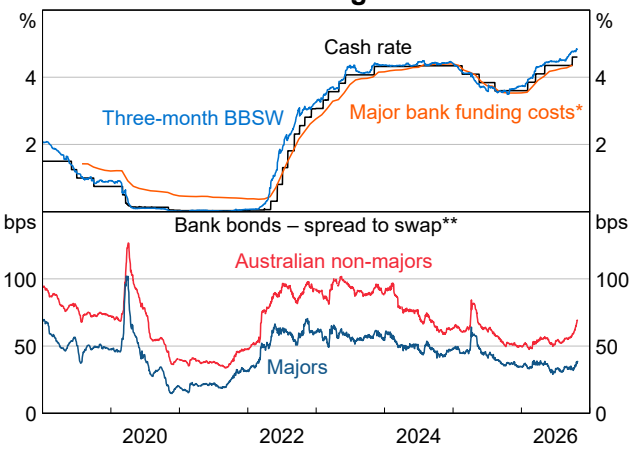
* Dotted vertical line indicates latest SMP publication.
** Trade-weighted index; 01 January 2022 = 100.
*** Index of Commodity Prices (USD terms); 01 January 2022 = 100.
**** Three-year Australian sovereign yield less yields of the United States, Japan and Germany, weighted by GDP.
Sources: Bloomberg; RBA.

1.5 Australian banks and credit markets

Banks' funding costs and lending rates have increased in line with the cash rate since the beginning of the year.

Banks' funding costs rose by around 80 basis points between January and September, and will rise further as September's increase in the cash rate continues to be passed through (Graph 1.15). Banks have increased average deposit rates broadly in line with increases in the cash rate this year. This contrasts with previous easing and tightening phases, when average deposit rates have tended to change by less than the cash rate because some deposits, such as transaction accounts, do not reprice fully when the cash rate changes. The stronger-than-usual pass-through this year is consistent with some banks highlighting strong competition for deposits over recent quarters. Wholesale funding conditions remain favourable, with spreads between bank bond yields and swap rates remaining low. Bank bond issuance has been a little above average in 2026.

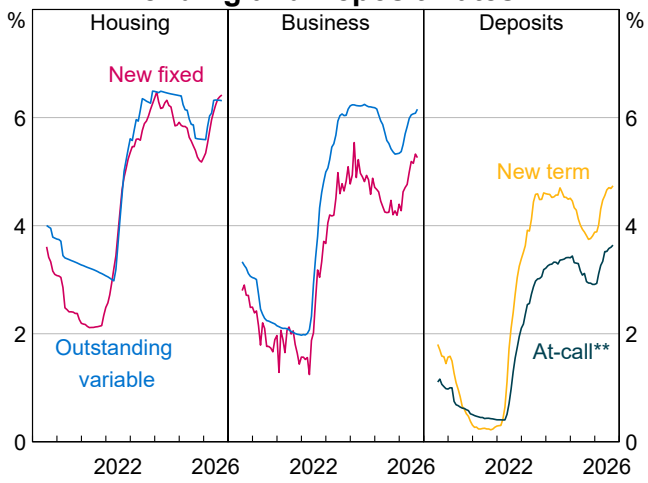
Graph 1.15
Bank Funding Costs



* RBA estimates of overall outstanding hedged debt and deposit costs for the major banks.
** Domestic secondary market; three-year target tenor.
Sources: APRA; ASX; Bloomberg; LSEG; major bank liaison; RBA.

Lending rates have increased broadly in line with the cash rate and other reference rates over 2026 (Graph 1.16). Variable mortgage rates rose by almost 75 basis points between January and September, and most banks have since increased their standard variable mortgage rates in line with the September cash rate increase. Prior to September, some lenders had reduced advertised mortgage rates slightly amid strong competition for mortgage customers, though this has had a negligible effect on average new and outstanding mortgage rates. Variable business rates have increased broadly in line with increases in bank bill rates (BBSW) and the cash rate this year.

Graph 1.16
Lending and Deposit Rates*

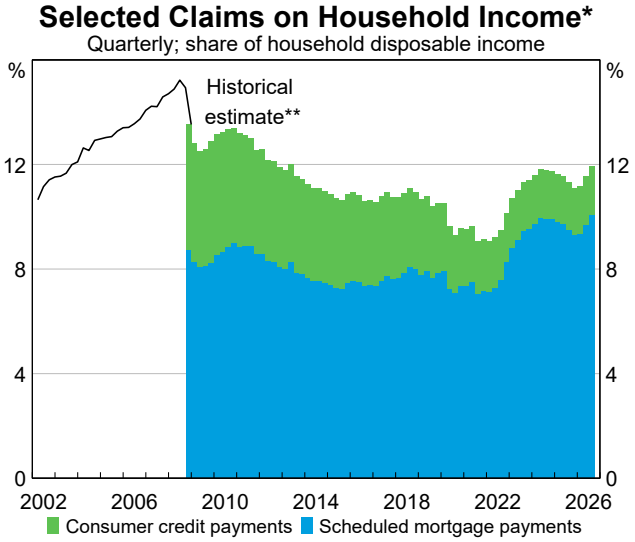


* Latest observation is September 2026.
** Includes deposits in housing loan offset accounts.
Sources: APRA; RBA.

Cash rate increases over 2026 have flowed through to higher scheduled mortgage payments.

Scheduled principal and interest mortgage payments increased to just over 10 per cent of household disposable income in the September quarter, around their 2024 peak (Graph 1.17). Scheduled mortgage payments will rise a little further as September's increase in the cash rate is passed through to mortgage payments (which can take up to three months). Nonetheless, total scheduled household debt payments (including estimated repayments on consumer credit) remain well below the 2008 peak, reflecting a long-run decline in consumer credit relative to household disposable income.[2]

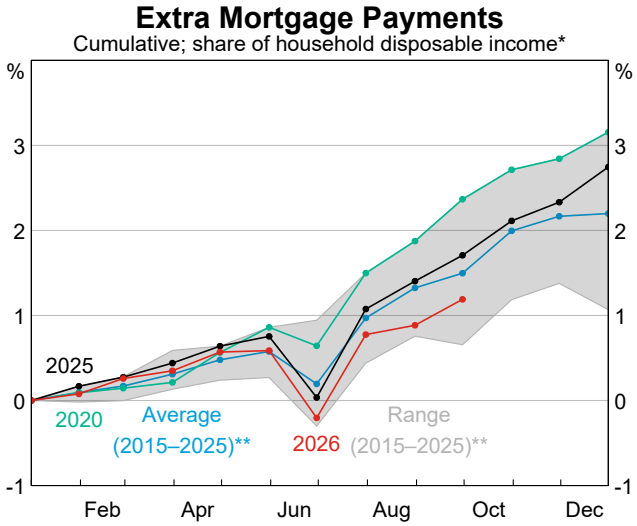
Graph 1.17



* Seasonally adjusted and break-adjusted. Latest observation is September 2026. September quarter 2026 data are based on forecasts for household disposable income.
** Estimated using credit foncier model.
Sources: ABS; APRA; RBA.

Extra mortgage payments have been a bit lower in 2026 compared with 2025 (Graph 1.18). By contrast, the overall household saving ratio has remained relatively stable (see Chapter 2: Economic Conditions). While higher interest rates provide an incentive to save, they also reduce borrowers' cash flows, which can lead to a reduction in extra mortgage payments. Nonetheless, extra payments are still positive and so adding to the significant mortgage buffers that most borrowers have. Indeed, the median borrower in the lowest income quartile has enough savings in offset and redraw accounts to cover around a year's worth of scheduled mortgage payments.[3]

Graph 1.18

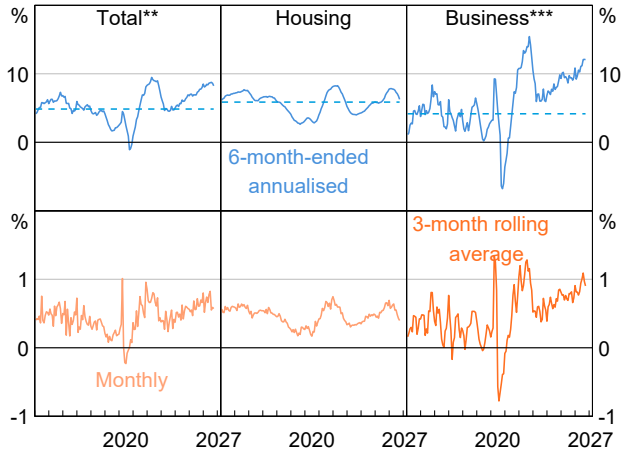


* Data are not seasonally adjusted. Series are calculated as the cumulative sum of extra payments divided by the total for household disposable income over that year. September quarter 2026 data are based on forecasts for household disposable income.
** Available data prior to 2020 are quarterly.
Sources: ABS; APRA; RBA.

Total credit growth has remained well above its post-global financial crisis (GFC) average over recent months.

Total credit growth has declined slightly since the August *Statement*, but remains strong at 8.2 per cent in six-month-ended annualised terms (Graph 1.19). A decline in housing credit growth, to around its post-GFC average, has been largely offset by an increase in business credit growth. These contrasting trends are discussed in more detail below.

Graph 1.19
Credit Growth by Sector*

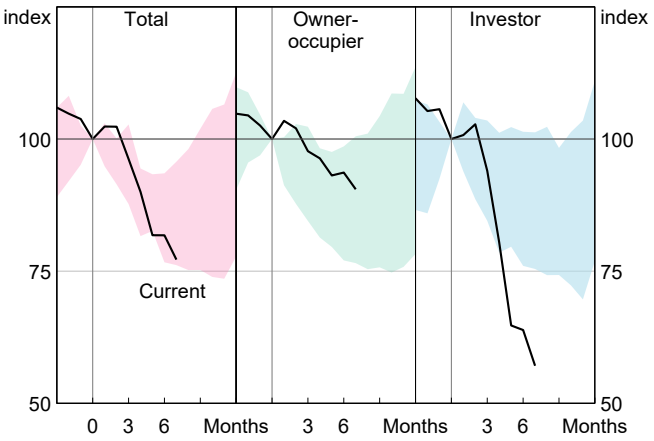


* Seasonally adjusted and break-adjusted. Dashed lines represent average growth rate.
** Includes housing, personal and business credit.
*** Excludes financial businesses.
Sources: APRA; RBA.

New housing loan commitments have declined sharply, particularly for investors, and housing credit growth has eased.

New housing loan commitments have declined further since the August *Statement* and are now 27 per cent below their peak in November 2025. The decline in overall housing loan commitments to date is larger than most tightening phases since 1990, though not as large as at the same point in the 2022 tightening phase (Graph 1.20).[4] While the increase in interest rates over 2026 has weighed on demand from all categories of borrowers, the decline in new lending has been most pronounced for investors and has been concentrated in loans to purchase established dwellings. This is consistent with the recent changes to negative gearing and capital gains tax decreasing the after-tax returns on investments in established housing.

Graph 1.20
New Housing Commitments over Tightening Phases*
Indexed to month of first rate increase

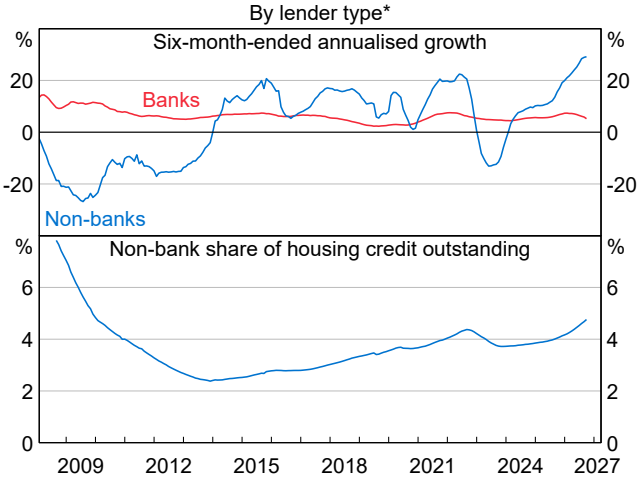


* Monthly data, excluding refinancing, seasonally adjusted and break-adjusted. Shaded areas represent historical range of cumulative changes in commitments during previous tightening phases since 1990.
Sources: ABS; APRA; RBA.

Housing credit growth is now 6.3 per cent in six-month-ended annualised terms, lower than at the time of the August *Statement* but still around its post-GFC average. The recent decline has reflected a fall in investor credit growth; owner-occupier credit growth has remained little changed in six-month-ended terms and has softened only slightly in monthly terms, in line with the more modest decline in owner-occupier commitments. Housing loan commitments and credit growth tend to lag housing price growth by up to three months, largely reflecting lags between the purchase and settlement of property. As a result, housing credit growth is expected to decline further over coming months as recent declines in housing prices and turnover continue to flow through to credit (see Chapter 2: Economic Conditions).

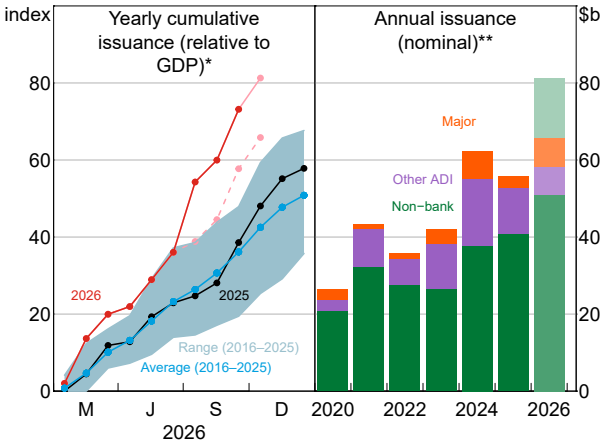
Non-bank housing credit is a small share of total housing credit but has been growing quickly (Graph 1.21). Growth in non-bank housing credit has accelerated considerably over the past 18 months, mainly reflecting new lending rather than refinancing of bank loans. In part, this growth is likely to reflect less stringent debt servicing tests at some non-banks compared with banks (which are required to assess serviceability at an interest rate that is three percentage points above the prevailing mortgage rate, reflecting the Australian Prudential Regulation Authority's (APRA) serviceability buffer). Non-bank credit growth has also been supported by generally favourable conditions in securitisation markets – a key funding source for these lenders – allowing non-banks to compete more readily with banks for customers. Issuance of residential mortgage-backed securities has been very strong, with cumulative issuance in the year-to-date (relative to GDP) exceeding the range seen in recent years (Graph 1.22). While spreads on residential mortgage-backed securities have increased recently they remained very narrow in historical terms.

Graph 1.21
Housing Credit
By lender type*



* Seasonally adjusted and break-adjusted.
Sources: APRA; RBA.

Graph 1.22
RMBS Issuance



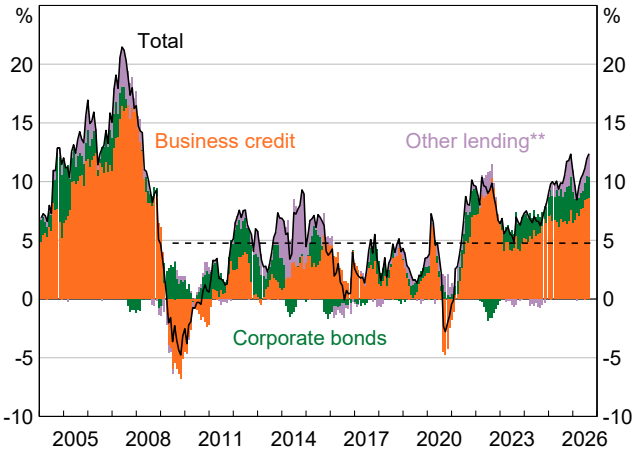
* For years before 2026, cumulative issuance is scaled by that year's nominal GDP relative to 2026. Dotted line shows issuance excluding non-bank Pepper Cashmere deal ($15b portfolio transfer RMBS) as the deal did not constitute new credit. Latest observation is 28 October 2026.

** Lighter green in 2026 partial data denotes Pepper Cashmere deal.
Sources: ABS; KangaNews; RBA.

Growth in business debt remains strong and has increased recently.

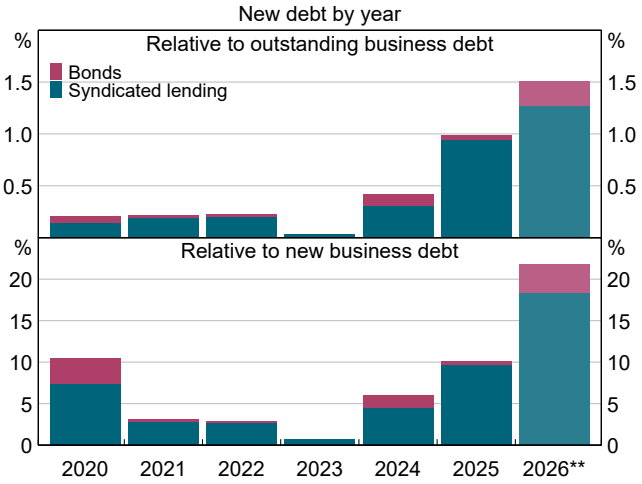
Business debt growth is well above its post-GFC average (Graph 1.23). Business credit growth has accelerated in recent months, supporting the strong growth in overall business debt. By contrast, corporate bond issuance has slowed, largely because high earnings have allowed some resource companies (which typically play a material role in debt issuance) to rely more heavily on internal funding. The largest contributors to business debt growth have been industrial businesses – including borrowing to fund data centre investment, discussed below – as well as consumer-facing industries and real estate businesses.

Graph 1.23
Business Debt Growth*



* Six-month-ended annualised, seasonally adjusted. Dashed line is average since 2009.
** Lending to large businesses by institutions that do not report to APRA.
Sources: APRA; Bloomberg; LSEG; RBA.

Graph 1.24
Australian Data Centre Debt Funding*



* Selected debt funding sources only, comprising syndicated loans and bond issuance; excludes other bank loans. Sample comprises NextDC, Infratil (CDC), Macquarie Technology, Goodman, AirTrunk, Firmus and local funding vehicles of Stack and Equinix.
** Data updated to 28 October 2026.
Sources: Bloomberg; LSEG; RBA.

As in some overseas jurisdictions, debt financing for Australian data centre operators has been an important contributor to strong business debt growth. In 2026 to date, operators have raised at least $30 billion in the bond and syndicated loans markets (domestically and offshore), including syndicates involving Australian banks. This is equivalent to around one-fifth of the increase in the stock of business debt so far this year (Graph 1.24). However, operators may also use other sources of debt funding such as bilateral bank loans and private credit. This suggests that the total volume of borrowing by operators is likely to be higher than the $30 billion quoted above (though it is unclear how much higher). So far, the decline in global and domestic investor sentiment towards some riskier AI-related firms (discussed above) is having only a limited effect on broader cost and availability of funding for most Australian data centre operators. Even so, this remains a risk if sentiment were to deteriorate further.

Funding conditions for private credit lenders have tightened recently, which could reduce the availability of credit for new residential construction. Media reports and liaison information have noted an increase in investors' redemption requests at some funds. At the same time, lenders have noted a less profitable outlook for new residential property developments due to higher construction costs and weaker housing market conditions, which is expected to weigh on both developers' demand for finance and lenders' appetite to supply finance. Available information suggests non-bank lenders (including private credit funds) comprise at least 40–50 per cent of lending for residential property construction.[5]

Endnotes

1 For further discussion, see RBA (2026), *Financial Stability Review*, October.

2 See Appendix A of Jennison S and M Miller (2025), 'An Update on the Household Cash-flow Channel of Monetary Policy', RBA *Bulletin*, January.

3 See Graph 2.4 in RBA (2026), 'Chapter 2: Resilience of Australian Households and Businesses', *Financial Stability Review*, October.

4 At the same point in the 2022 tightening phase the cash rate target was at 3.10 per cent, following 300 basis points of cash rate increases (with around 75 basis points of additional increases expected over the coming year).

5 For example, see Graph 12 in Jennison S, J Spiller and P Wallis (2026), 'Recent Changes in Credit Markets and Their Implications for Monetary Policy', RBA *Bulletin*, February.

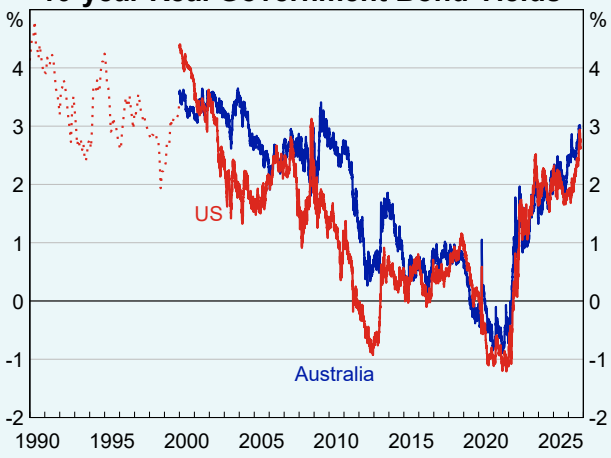
Box A: How Does an Increase in Longer-term Real Yields Affect Financial Conditions?

Longer-term real government yields have risen sharply across advanced economies in recent months. Whether this tightens financial conditions depends on why yields have risen. If yields have risen because markets expect stronger growth, the prospect of higher earnings and returns on investment can more than offset higher discount rates, thereby supporting asset prices and investment. If they have risen because markets expect more restrictive monetary policy or require a higher term premium, there is no such support and financial conditions are likely to have tightened. The recent rise in yields appears to reflect a mix of factors. In Australia, long-term yields have less direct influence on borrowing costs than in the United States because most borrowing here is at variable rates. However, this does not necessarily mean weak transmission overall: increases in foreign yields can still affect domestic financial conditions through asset prices and the exchange rate. This Box examines the drivers of longer-term real yields, places the recent increase in historical context, and considers how higher yields affect financial conditions in Australia.

Longer-term real government yields have risen by as much as 85 basis points over 2026, reaching their highest levels since the early 2000s (Graph A.1). Most of this increase reflects higher real yields rather than changes in longer-term inflation expectations, which have remained broadly stable. The current increase is part of a broader and more sustained rise in longer-term yields since 2021 (see Box B: Developments in the Neutral Rate of Interest). Higher real yields do not necessarily imply tighter financial conditions. Their effect on financial conditions depends on what is driving the increase and how changes in long-term rates are transmitted through the economy.

Graph A.1

10-year Real Government Bond Yields*



* US data before January 2000 (dotted red line) are the Federal Reserve Bank of Cleveland's model-based monthly 10-year real interest rate.

Sources: Bloomberg; Federal Reserve Bank of Cleveland; RBA.

What drives longer-term real yields?

Longer-term real yields reflect the expected path of future short-term real rates and a so-called 'term premium'. Increases in real yields can be grouped into three broad drivers, with the first two working through expected policy rates:

1. **stronger expected growth:** markets may expect stronger economic growth, which can raise expected real policy rates because the neutral rate is thought to have risen (e.g. because of higher productivity growth)
2. **other policy repricing:** markets could expect policy rates to stay higher for longer for reasons other than stronger growth, such as when inflationary pressures lead markets to expect policy to remain restrictive (i.e. above the neutral rate) for a time, such as during persistent adverse supply shocks
3. **higher term premium:** investors may demand greater compensation to hold longer-term bonds, above what they would demand to hold a series of equivalent shorter-term instruments, while expectations for growth and policy rates are little changed.

These drivers can have different implications for financial conditions. When higher yields reflect stronger expected growth, higher expected earnings and returns on investment can more than offset higher discount rates, thereby supporting asset prices. By contrast, when yields rise because of expectations of more restrictive monetary policy or a higher term premium, there is no comparable offset and financial conditions are more likely to tighten. In practice, yield movements can reflect a combination of these drivers.

Putting the recent increase in historical context.

The increase in real yields this year is notable, but not unprecedented. It is comparable in size with several previous episodes, including the dot-com boom, the pre-global financial crisis (GFC) expansion and the 2023 term premium sell-off (Graph A.2). The drivers of these episodes differed, however. Table A.1 classifies past episodes by our assessment of their predominant driver, based on contemporaneous market developments and revisions to consensus forecasts of activity, inflation and policy rates. Several episodes reflected more than one driver.

Table A.1: Historical Episodes of Increases in Real Rates
Grouped by predominant driver

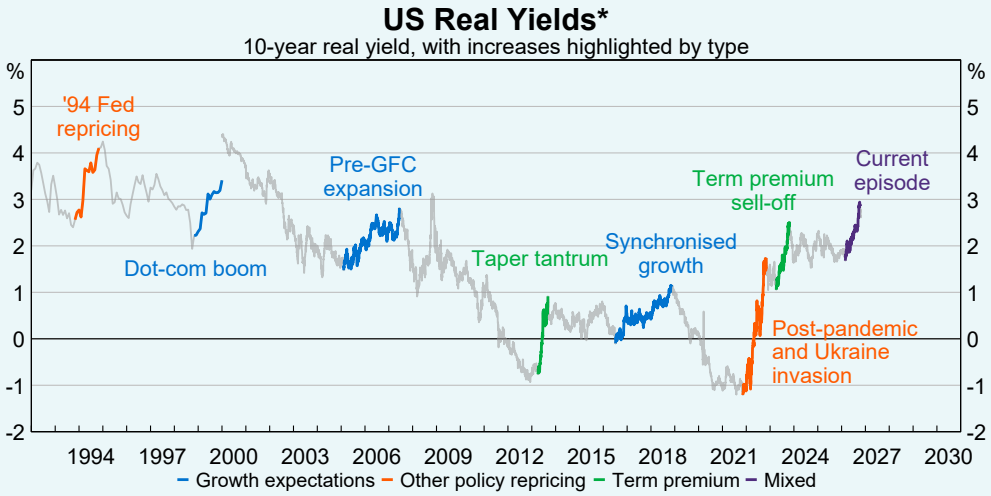
Episode	Period	Description
Growth expectations		
Dot-com boom	Oct 1998–Jan 2000	Optimism about technology and productivity supported a sharp rise in equity prices. Long-term growth forecasts rose substantially, while long-term inflation forecasts were broadly stable.
Pre-GFC expansion	Feb 2005–Jun 2007	Solid global growth, rising equity and housing prices and rapid credit growth pointed to optimism about future activity and returns.
Synchronised growth	Jul 2016–Nov 2018	A broad-based global upswing in economic activity, along with higher equity prices and compressed risk spreads.
Other policy repricing		
'94 Fed repricing	Oct 1993–Nov 1994	Stronger activity and concerns about prospective inflation, together with limited advance communication, left markets unprepared for the pace of monetary tightening, producing a sharp bond-market adjustment.
Post-pandemic reopening and Russian invasion of Ukraine	Nov 2021–Nov 2022	Reopening of economies, supply disruptions and the energy shock led markets to expect rapid monetary tightening; bond yields increased, equity prices declined, and growth forecasts were revised lower.
Term premium		
Taper tantrum	Apr–Sep 2013	The prospect of reduced asset purchases by the US Federal Reserve triggered a sharp bond sell-off and retrenchment from emerging-market assets.

Episode	Period	Description
Term premium sell-off	Apr–Oct 2023	Increased government bond supply raised term premia and risky asset prices weakened as yields rose.
Mixed		
Current episode	Feb 2026–	Stronger US earnings expectations, AI-related equity gains and modestly higher long-term growth forecasts point to a growth component. Increased bond issuance and quantitative tightening point to higher term premia, while expected policy rates have also risen.

Source: RBA.

The dot-com boom provides the clearest example of higher yields accompanying stronger expected longer-term growth. The pre-GFC and 2016–2018 synchronised growth periods were also associated with strong asset prices and economic activity, but forecasts at the time suggest that stronger growth was expected to be cyclical rather than structural. By contrast, the taper tantrum and 2023 term premium sell-off were associated with weaker asset prices and little change in long-term growth expectations, consistent with a larger role for term premia.

Graph A.2



* Grey line: US TIPS yield from January 2000; prior observations are Federal Reserve Bank of Cleveland model estimates (monthly). The series are not spliced due to differences in measurement and levels.

Sources: Bloomberg; Federal Reserve Bank of Cleveland.

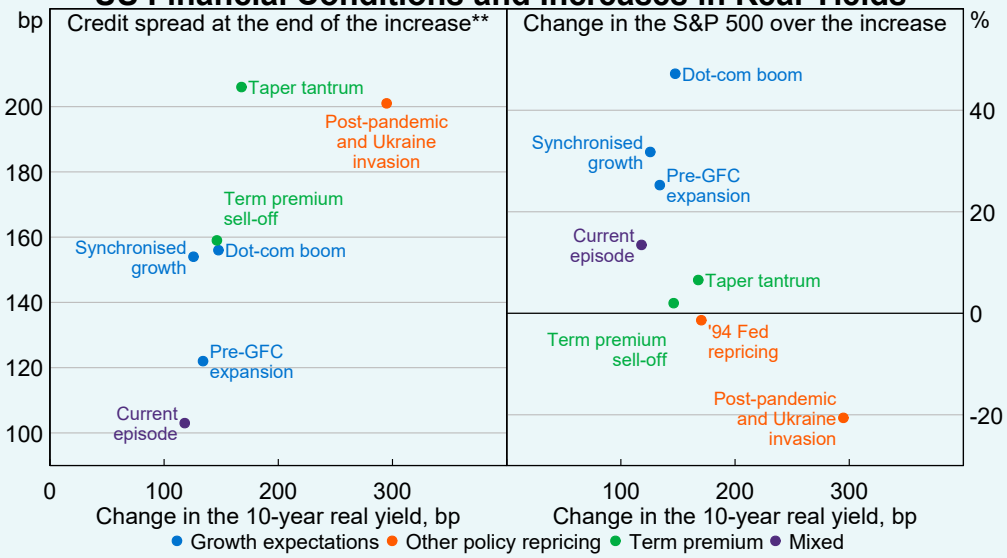
Historical experience also provides a useful reminder that the expectations underpinning market pricing are not always realised. In some cases, periods of strong optimism about future growth have given way to sharp falls in risk asset prices, notably following the dot-com boom and the expansion preceding the GFC. In others, interest rate markets may be slow to recognise lasting improvement in growth prospects.

The current episode appears to reflect a combination of these drivers. In the United States, higher growth expectations appear to have contributed: rising yields have coincided with stronger earnings expectations and higher equity prices, particularly in AI-sensitive sectors, while credit spreads have remained near historical lows (Graph A.3). Expectations of a higher path for policy rates have also contributed. Increased debt issuance and ongoing quantitative tightening, alongside an investor base that is becoming more sensitive to expected returns, also appear to be placing upward pressure on term premia.

In Australia, however, the rise in yields has not been accompanied by a comparable improvement in growth expectations priced into financial assets. That is consistent with the much smaller AI-related sector here, and the less pronounced reassessment of the broader domestic economic outlook. Instead, the rise in Australian yields appears to reflect expectations of a higher path for the cash rate and spillovers from global yields (see Chapter 1: Financial Conditions and Box B: Developments in the Neutral Rate of Interest). As a small open economy, Australia is affected by global movements in longer-term yields, including in neutral rates and term premia, even when domestic fundamentals have changed little.

Graph A.3

US Financial Conditions and Increases in Real Yields*



* Each dot is an episode of a material increase in US 10-year real yields (US TIPS yield; Cleveland Fed estimate for 1994 and 1998–2000).
** US BBB option-adjusted spread; '94 Fed repricing omitted (no spread data).
Sources: Bloomberg; Federal Reserve Bank of Cleveland; ICE Data.

How do longer-term real yields affect financial conditions in Australia?

An increase in longer-term real yields can be transmitted into broader financial conditions through borrowing costs, asset prices, investment and the exchange rate. The overall effect on financial conditions depends on why yields have risen, with the three drivers discussed above having different implications for Australia.

When higher global yields reflect stronger expected growth, the implications for Australian financial conditions are ambiguous. If stronger growth is also expected for Australia, higher expected earnings and returns on investment may offset the effects of higher discount rates. But if the improvement in growth expectations is concentrated abroad, such as from AI-related investments, Australia may import some of the rise in long-term yields without receiving the same benefit of higher expected growth. In that case, the increase in global yields could tighten Australian financial conditions. A persistent productivity or growth differential (in favour of the United States for example) would also be expected to put downward pressure on the real exchange rate, which would provide some offset to the tightening in domestic financial conditions. Similarly, stronger overseas activity could provide some offset by lifting domestic incomes (through trade and commodity-price channels).

When higher yields reflect expectations of more restrictive monetary policy, financial conditions are more likely to tighten. Expected borrowing costs rise, while higher discount rates weigh on asset prices and investment. If Australian policy rates are expected to rise relative to those abroad, a higher exchange rate could tighten domestic conditions further.

When higher yields reflect a higher term premium, the direct effect on broader financial conditions depends partly on the economy's exposure to longer-term rates. Differences in financing structures can therefore mean that the same rise in longer-term yields is transmitted differently across economies.

Australian household borrowing is concentrated in variable-rate mortgages, making borrowing costs less directly sensitive to term premia than in the United States (Table A.2). Thirty-year fixed-rate mortgages are common in the United States, which makes new borrowing rates sensitive to term premia but also means that changes in term premia can take a long time to affect average outstanding rates on mortgages. The differences are less clear-cut for business financing. Higher discount rates may have a larger direct effect on aggregate US equity indices because they are more heavily weighted towards technology companies, whose valuations depend heavily on earnings many years ahead.

Table A.2: Selected Financing Features in Australia and Other Advanced Economies

	Australia	United States	United Kingdom
Household borrowing			
Effective period before mortgage rates reprice[(a)]	<1 month	8.5 years (mostly 30-year fixed term)	3 years (mostly fixed terms of 2–5 years)
Business borrowing[(b)]			
Bank loan structure	89 per cent variable-rate	Mostly variable-rate for larger businesses; mostly fixed-rate for small businesses	Mostly variable-rate
Bond tenor[(c)]	6.0 years	8.4 years	8.3 years[(d)]
Bond/loan share	19 per cent bonds	39 per cent bonds	24 per cent bonds
Government borrowing			
Funding tenor[(e)]	6.5 years	5.9 years	13.4 years

(a) Effective period for which rates on outstanding mortgages are fixed. For Australia and the United Kingdom, this is calculated as a weighted (by amount outstanding) average of the fixed-rate period, with variable-rate mortgages treated as able to reprice immediately; the Australian figure uses the residual term of the fixed-rate period, while the UK figure uses original maturity due to data limitations. The US estimate uses average duration of agency mortgage-backed securities.

(b) Non-financial incorporated and unincorporated businesses.

(c) Residual tenor. Australian and US figures are for bonds only, while the UK figure includes bills but excludes commercial paper. Includes offshore issuance, where available.

(d) Average residual maturity of UK non-financial corporate fixed-rate, non-convertible bonds from 1997Q4 to 2024Q2, excluding those maturing in less than a year.

(e) Residual tenor on all debt including bills.

Sources: AOFM; APRA; Bank of England; Bloomberg; Federal Reserve; LSEG; Office for National Statistics; RBA; UK Debt Management Office; US Congress Joint Economic Committee.

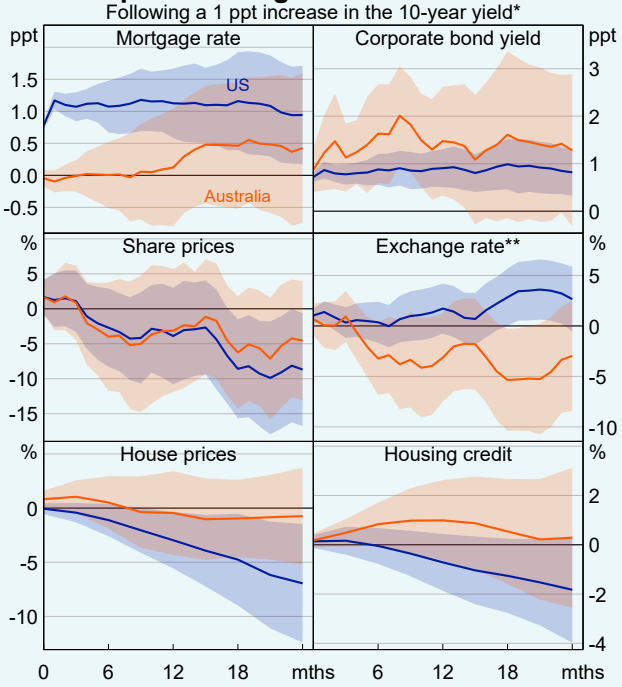
While differences in financial structures affect the direct transmission of higher yields to the economy, the overall effect on financial conditions also depends on broader responses in asset prices and other financial variables. Model-based estimates, using data from 1995 onwards, suggest that US term-premia-driven increases in longer-term yields have, on average, been associated with higher borrowing costs and lower equity and housing prices in both Australia and the United States (Graph A.4).[1]

As expected, these estimates show a larger impact on mortgage rates and housing prices in the United States than in Australia. By contrast, equity prices fall by at least as much in Australia as in the United States, illustrating that weaker direct pass-through to borrowing rates does not necessarily imply weaker transmission overall. Even so, the associated wealth effects from equity market holdings may be weaker in Australia than in the United States because a substantial share of Australian households' equity wealth is held indirectly through superannuation, which is less readily accessible for consumption.[2] The Australian dollar also tends to depreciate in such situations, partly offsetting the tightening in domestic financial conditions; this is consistent with a US term-premium shock raising US yields more than Australian yields.

Graph A.4

Response to Higher US Term Premia

Following a 1 ppt increase in the 10-year yield*



* Increase in each country's own 10-year yield, instrumented with the change in the US 10-year term premium (Kim-Wright); local projections, 1995-2026. Controls: lags of the outcome, the yield and the policy rate. Shaded areas are 95 per cent confidence intervals.

** Each country's trade-weighted exchange rate: the BIS broad nominal index of the US dollar for the US, the Australian dollar TWI for Australia.

Sources: BIS; Bloomberg; Federal Reserve; FRED; Kim and Wright (2005); RBA.

Endnotes

1 The responses in Graph A.4 are estimated using local projections (Jordà O (2005), 'Estimation and Inference of Impulse Responses by Local Projections', *American Economic Review*, 95(1), pp 161–182), with the change in the US 10-year term premium (Kim D and J Wright (2005), 'An Arbitrage-Free Three-Factor Term Structure Model and the Recent Behavior of Long-Term Yields and Distant-Horizon Forward Rates', FEDS No 2005-33) used as an instrument for each market's 10-year government bond yield. Because US term premium movements can reflect a range of underlying shocks, the estimates capture average historical associations rather than the effects of a specific structural shock. In addition, the term premium estimates we use are model-based decompositions that cannot always distinguish perfectly between increases in yields stemming from the term premium and those from other drivers such as growth expectations. For a small open economy like Australia, the instrumental variable approach nonetheless helps to separate movements in yields from developments affecting both yields and financial conditions (this interpretation is less straightforward for the United States). This means that some of the results in Graph A.4 – for instance, the slight increase in mortgage rates and housing credit – may reflect in part higher expected global growth instead of a 'pure' increase in the US term premium. The confidence intervals around these estimates are wide, particularly for Australia.

2 Equity ownership is more concentrated among wealthy households in the United States, which may reduce the aggregate consumption response because those households tend to have lower marginal propensities to consume out of stock market wealth. However, their large quantity of equity holdings means that they can still account for a substantial share of the aggregate consumption response to equity price movements (Mitra I and D Rapach (2026), 'Downside Risk to the Stock Market and Consumption', Federal Reserve Bank of Atlanta Policy Hub Series No 6-2026).

Box B: Developments in the Neutral Rate of Interest

Long-term bond yields in advanced economies have increased substantially recently, continuing their upward trend in the post-pandemic period (see Chapter 1: Financial Conditions). Part of this increase is likely to reflect a rise in the neutral rate of interest – the level of the short-term real interest rate that balances saving and investment and neither stimulates nor dampens demand once temporary influences on the economy have faded. The neutral rate can help inform assessments of the stance of monetary policy. All else equal, a higher neutral rate implies that a given level of the cash rate is less restrictive than otherwise. However, the neutral rate is not directly observed and estimates are subject to considerable uncertainty both about its level and underlying drivers. There is also uncertainty about estimates of other influences on long-term interest rates, notably term premia, which have also contributed to the increase in longer-term sovereign bond yields. This Box discusses the concept of the neutral rate, its possible drivers and the associated uncertainties.

What is the neutral interest rate?

The neutral rate of interest can refer to short-run or long-run concepts, each of which has different connections to forecasts and policy. The long-run neutral rate is the level of the cash rate that neither stimulates nor dampens demand once temporary shocks and structural forces have played out. At that point, demand and potential supply will be in balance, with full employment and inflation at target. It is also consistent with global saving and investment being in balance. Some of the RBA's Australian neutral rate models lend themselves more to this long-run concept of neutral.[1]

However, the long-run neutral rate may not correspond to the appropriate setting for the cash rate in the short term because monetary policy may need to respond to temporary influences on activity and inflation. The short-run neutral rate is a related concept that aims to capture these forces. This is the cash rate that neither stimulates nor dampens demand over the next few years, taking account of ongoing shocks and structural changes.[2] The short-run neutral rate is less commonly estimated in the literature, although some models in the RBA's suite provide signals about shorter-run developments, particularly those based on forward-looking financial market pricing. In practice, it is often unclear in real time whether developments are temporary or persistent, meaning that short-run and long-run concepts of neutral can overlap. Consequently, even models that are intended to represent a long-run forecast of the policy rate may partly capture shorter-run trends.

The RBA's forecasts set out our assessment of how shorter-run developments in financial and economic conditions are likely to affect inflation and unemployment, which helps inform the Monetary Policy Board's assessment of the appropriate stance of monetary policy. The forecasts also attempt to capture the direct impact on the economic outlook of structural change, for example by factoring in estimates of the non-accelerating inflation rate of unemployment and potential output. Estimates of neutral rates provide a useful cross-check of the forecasts. These estimates are shaped by many of the same developments but infer their effects from economic data and market prices using different techniques. This provides an additional perspective on developments in the economy but can also make it difficult to tell whether developments driving the neutral rate estimates are reflected in the forecasts. The value of the cross-check comes from understanding what the estimates imply about the stance of monetary policy and what is likely to be driving these estimates.

When examining the neutral rate and its drivers, it is important to consider both domestic and global factors. Australia is a small open economy, which means that we are price takers in global financial (and other) markets given the sizeable influence of capital flows on domestic financial conditions. Hence, shifts in the

global balance of saving and investment will have a large influence on the neutral rate in Australia, though they are not the only influence (see below). Global forces relevant to the neutral rate include productivity growth, demographic trends and government debt levels.

Estimates of neutral rates have increased in the post-pandemic period and there are a range of possible explanations.

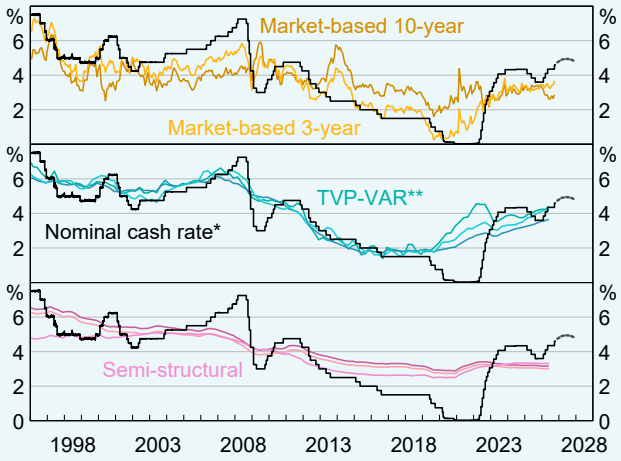
Estimates of the neutral rate in Australia have increased over recent years to be above their pre-pandemic levels, partly reversing a long-run decline (Graph B.1). A similar trend is evident in many advanced economies, including the United States.[3] Although the increase over recent years is relevant to the assessment of the current stance of monetary policy, understanding it requires considering why neutral rate estimates declined over the decades leading up to the pandemic. The research literature has put forward two competing explanations. First, the decline could reflect slow-moving structural factors, such as demographics, weak productivity growth and inequality, that caused 'secular stagnation'. Second, the particularly sharp decline in neutral rate estimates in the 2010s could be picking up more temporary factors, such as the need to repair balance sheets in the aftermath of the global financial crisis (GFC).[4]

The first explanation, secular stagnation, argues that households and businesses increasingly wished to save more, relative to firms' desired investment, placing downward pressure on interest rates.[5] Three possible causes identified in the literature are demographic change, weak productivity growth and rising inequality globally. Population ageing and rising inequality can increase desired saving, while weaker productivity growth can reduce desired investment. Together, these factors will put downward pressure on interest rates. At the same time, a number of governments globally ran substantial fiscal deficits, including because of increased social security expenditure to support ageing populations. The literature argues that the decline in neutral rates would probably have been even larger without these fiscal deficits.

Graph B.1

Nominal Neutral Rate

Suite of models



* Dashed line shows cash rate expectations implied by overnight index swap rates.
** Time-varying parameter vector autoregression models (TVP-VAR).
Source: RBA.

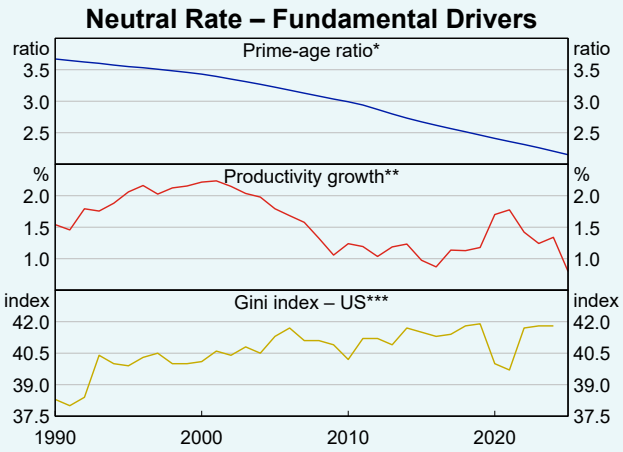
A second explanation is that the unsustainable credit boom in the 2000s and the balance sheet damage caused by the resulting GFC placed persistent, but ultimately temporary, downward pressure on interest rates.[6] This literature argues that many of the slow-moving structural factors associated with secular stagnation do not align with either the steep decline in estimated neutral rates during the 2010s or their subsequent increase. For example, the working-age population has declined relative to the old-age population in the OECD in a relatively steady way that does not match the sharper decline and then rebound in neutral rate estimates. Instead, this literature argues that high levels of household and business debt and large falls in asset prices led households, businesses and financial intermediaries to spend a prolonged period repairing their balance sheets. This desire to increase private saving and reduce private investment worked to lower neutral rates. As the effects of the GFC faded and balance sheets were repaired, this downward influence on neutral should have dissipated.

While the estimates presented above suggest that neutral interest rates have increased materially since the pandemic, the drivers of that increase remain uncertain. The increase over recent years is broadly consistent with explanations that emphasise the fading effects of the GFC, but it could also reflect

changes in longer-running structural factors (Graph B.2; Table B.1). For example, the post-pandemic rise in neutral rate estimates has coincided with a rapid expansion in AI-related investment and stronger US productivity growth than in the 2010s. Higher expected productivity can raise the expected return on investment and encourage businesses to invest more, placing upward pressure on neutral rates. Large and persistent fiscal deficits in advanced overseas economies could also be putting upward pressure on neutral rate estimates by reducing public saving. As a share of GDP, post-pandemic deficits in the United States and elsewhere have been larger than in the late 2010s or before the GFC.

The magnitude of these effects remains highly uncertain.[7] Structural changes, such as in expected future productivity, are hard to measure and do not necessarily occur gradually nor independently of other forces. Newer and ongoing structural changes are likely to be evolving in their effect on neutral rates. The effects of climate change, for example, are ambiguous: additional investment in renewables, including to meet the energy requirements of AI, could put upward pressure on neutral rates, whereas the higher returns required by investors to compensate for physical climate risks could work in the opposite direction.[8] Globally, government deficits have also continued to increase, and political and geopolitical factors could sustain this trend. At the same time, ageing populations and rising inequality continue to weigh on neutral rates.

Graph B.2



* Population aged 25-55 divided by population over 65 for available OECD countries.
** Rolling 5-year average growth in real GDP per hour worked for available OECD countries, weighted by GDP-PPP.
*** Gini index represents the distribution of income among households relative to a perfectly equal distribution. A higher Gini index represents greater income inequality.
Sources: OECD; RBA; World Bank.

Table B.1: Neutral Rate – Selected Potential Drivers(a)

Economic/financial development	Channel	Implication for r*	Persistence
Population ageing	Increases desired household saving	Lower	Structural
Rising inequality	Shifts income towards households with higher saving propensities	Lower	Structural
Stronger/weaker productivity growth	Increases/reduces expected returns to capital and desired investment	Higher/Lower	Structural
Post-GFC balance sheet repair	Raises private saving and reduces investment while households and firms deleverage	Lower	Persistent but temporary
Larger government deficits	Reduce public saving	Higher	Depends on fiscal persistence
Climate change and adaptation	Raises investment in energy transition, while greater physical climate risk can weigh on investment, among others	Ambiguous	Potentially structural

(a) Summary of potential macroeconomic drivers of the neutral rate discussed above and in International Monetary Fund (2023), 'The Natural Rate of Interest: Drivers and Implications for Policy', *World Economic Outlook*, April, Chapter 2. Other potential economic/financial drivers of neutral rates from IMF (2023) include scarcity of safe assets, risk aversion and financial stress.

Sources: IMF (2023); RBA.

The global neutral rate is not the only driver of the neutral rate in Australia.

As mentioned above, global forces have a strong influence on the Australian neutral rate because of Australia's role as a small open economy. However, they do not determine it completely. One study suggests that changes in US neutral rates explain around half of the variation in Australian neutral rate estimates.[9] In theory, once the economy is in balance, shocks have dissipated and monetary policy is therefore no longer responding to domestic or international shocks, the neutral rate in a small open economy should equal the global neutral rate plus a risk premium. This risk premium could reflect impediments to the free flow of capital or differences in the compensation that domestic and international investors require for risk.

There remain considerable uncertainties about both the level and drivers of the neutral rate, which are consequential for policy.

Although neutral interest rates are an important conceptual framework for considering the stance of policy, they cannot be observed directly and are difficult to measure. Different approaches to measuring neutral rates offer different perspectives. Some approaches infer neutral from financial market prices and some are estimated by examining the evolution of macroeconomic variables. The RBA accounts for this uncertainty by examining a range of models. Another source of uncertainty arises from how these statistical models are estimated, meaning that even a single model can produce a wide range of plausible estimates of the neutral rate.[10] And, as noted above, it is difficult to tell in real time how much each model reflects long-run trends rather than shorter-term developments.

Reflecting this uncertainty, policymakers are cautious when interpreting (small) short-term moves. Most models suggest that neutral rates have increased over recent years. However, the rise in long-term bond yields over the year to date could reflect a number of factors other than changes in neutral rates, such as expectations about future inflation and the additional compensation that investors require to hold longer-term bonds (see Box A: How Does an Increase in Longer-term Real Yields Affect Financial Conditions). An increase in long-term yields therefore does not, by itself, mean that the neutral rate has risen.

Even if neutral rates have increased, it is difficult to determine what has driven the increase. The relevance of the long-run neutral rate estimates to current policy is mainly the information they contain about underlying developments in the economy, and whether those are adequately reflected in the RBA's forecasts. The persistence and effects of these developments matter for the appropriate setting of policy over the next few years, as captured by the short-run concept of neutral.

As an example, suppose the emergence of AI technologies leads to a modest increase in global productivity in the long term. This could place some upward pressure on long-run neutral rate estimates without necessarily significantly affecting near-term inflation or the appropriate cash rate today. However, if AI also increased near-term aggregate demand by increasing investment in data centres and related infrastructure, then the appropriate policy response could be to increase the cash rate by more than the change in the long-run neutral rate. Given the uncertainty around both the extent of any increase in neutral rates and the forces driving it, the possibility of a higher neutral rate is partially embedded in the current forecasts and is otherwise being monitored as a source of uncertainty for the outlook (see Chapter 3: Outlook).

The RBA will continue to develop our understanding of the structural drivers of neutral rates and the degree to which they are likely to have implications over different horizons for the appropriate setting of monetary policy. Key areas for research include connecting movements in the neutral rate suite to fundamental economic drivers, including better understanding the 'wedge' between domestic and global neutral rates.

Endnotes

1 See, for example, Kent C (2026), 'Reassessing Australian Financial Conditions', Speech at the KangaNews Debt Capital Market Summit, Sydney, 26 March. Also see Smith P (2025), 'How Developments in International Financial Markets Shape Financial Conditions in Australia', Speech at Australian Securitisation Conference, Sydney, 26 November, on the role of global neutral.

2 See Kent, n 1. Also see Obstfeld M (2023), 'Natural and Neutral Real Interest Rates: Past and Future', NBER Working Paper No 31949.

3 See Federal Reserve Bank of New York (2026), 'Measuring the Natural Rate of Interest', available at <https://www.newyorkfed.org/research/policy/rstar/>.

4 This is not an exhaustive survey of possible drivers of the neutral interest rate; other explanations include changes in the demand for safe and liquid assets and associated convenience yields. See International Monetary Fund (2023), 'The Natural Rate of Interest: Drivers and Implications for Policy', *World Economic Outlook*, April, Chapter 2.

5 See Rachel L and L Summers (2019), 'On Secular Stagnation in the Industrialized World', Brooking Papers on Economic Activity No 26198.

6 Eggerston G and P Krugman (2012), 'Debt, Deleveraging, and the Liquidity Trap: A Fisher-Minsky-Koo Approach', *The Quarterly Journal of Economics*, 127(3), pp 1469–1513; and Rogoff K (2025), 'Debt Supercycle Versus Secular Stagnation', *Journal of Policy Modelling*, 47(4), pp 723–737.

7 See Korinek A *et al* (2026), 'Economic Scenarios for Transformative AI', Centre for Economic Policy Research Paper No 21939.

8 See Angeli M *et al* (2022), 'Climate Change: Possible Macroeconomic Implications', Bank of England *Quarterly Bulletin*, October.

9 Morley J and B Wong (2026), 'How Important is Global R-star for Open Economies?', *European Economic Review*, 188(August), No 105391.

10 For example, in one of the RBA's semi-structural models, the 90 per cent probability interval for the current neutral rate spans around 7 percentage points, indicating that the true neutral rate could be far from the central estimate.

Chapter 2
Economic Conditions

Summary

Global cost pressures from the Middle East conflict and AI boom have increased since August.

- **The re-escalation of the Middle East conflict has pushed up energy prices**, as global energy supply continues to be constrained by disruptions to shipping and damage to refineries. Crude oil and refined product prices have risen by 20–25 per cent and are materially higher than was assumed in the August forecasts. Prices of a range of base metals and agricultural commodities have also increased this year, including because of the conflicts in the Middle East and Ukraine and adverse weather.
- **Global economic activity has been more resilient than expected, underpinned by the AI boom and supportive fiscal measures.** GDP growth in Australia's major trading partners has trended higher over the past few years. Recently, the strength in global AI-related demand and fiscal measures in some major economies have more than offset the negative impacts of the Middle East conflict. The underlying strength in the global economy has added to global cost and price pressures, with the surge in data centre activity creating capacity constraints in related supply chains.
- **The extent to which global cost pressures will pass through to consumer prices is uncertain.** Headline inflation has increased in most economies following increases in energy prices, while core inflation is already above central bank targets in many advanced economies. Policy rate expectations implied by market pricing have increased in many advanced economies, in line with higher near-term inflationary pressures (see Chapter 1: Financial Conditions).

In Australia, GDP growth has slowed this year to a little below its potential growth rate.

- **This largely reflects softer growth in household consumption, consistent with the earlier easing in household income growth, as well as in exports and public demand.** The Middle East conflict is assessed to have had only modest effects on overall domestic activity so far. Notwithstanding the slowing in growth, recent data suggest that activity growth this year has been a bit stronger than anticipated in the August forecasts, supported by very strong investment in data centres.
- **Conditions in the housing market have eased and the unemployment rate has increased, both by more than expected in August.** Housing prices have declined further from their peak in March, primarily reflecting the effects of monetary policy and tax changes announced in the federal budget. The unemployment rate increased to 4.6 per cent in the September quarter. That appears largely to reflect stronger-than-expected labour supply; employment growth held up in the September quarter as expected and liaison and leading indicators suggest a stable near-term outlook for labour demand.

Domestic inflation is elevated and has been stronger than expected recently. We now assess that capacity constraints in the first half of the year were a little tighter than previously judged.

- **Headline inflation was 3.9 per cent over the year to the September quarter and trimmed mean inflation ticked up to 3.7 per cent.** The upside surprise in trimmed mean inflation – relative to the August forecasts – is judged to reflect that domestic capacity pressures this year have been stronger than previously assessed, with the indirect effects of cost pressures related to the Middle East conflict passing through to inflation broadly as anticipated. While the price of fuel has increased strongly, inflation has been broad-based, including significant price increases for a range of market services. This is consistent with elevated growth in unit labour costs. Liaison contacts across most industries continue to report sustained cost pressures.
- **Despite the easing in GDP growth and increase in the unemployment rate we continue to assess that there are some capacity pressures in the economy.** While below-trend GDP growth and rising unemployment by themselves imply that aggregate demand and potential supply are moving closer to balance, a range of data – including persistently high inflation and elevated growth in labour and non-labour input costs – suggest that domestic capacity constraints are greater than previously assessed and so capacity pressures remain. Accordingly, we have raised our estimate of the unemployment rate consistent with low and stable inflation a little, though this estimate remains very uncertain.
- **Some measures of short-term and longer-term inflation expectations have increased since August.** Elevated inflation expectations, including shorter-term expectations, may contribute to higher realised inflation if they influence wage- and price-setting decisions today.

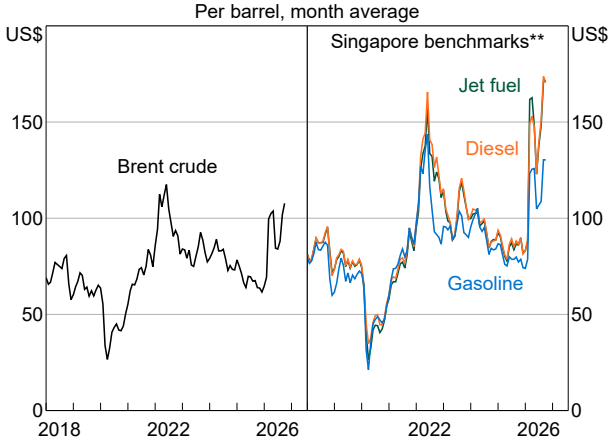
2.1 Commodity price developments

Some of the upside risks to global cost pressures identified in the August *Statement* have materialised. Global oil and refined product prices have increased sharply due to ongoing disruptions related to the Middle East conflict, and these prices are now expected to remain elevated for longer. More broadly, a range of supply disruptions caused by conflicts and adverse weather events, alongside strong AI-related demand, are boosting prices of a range of commodities and inflation in many economies.

Energy prices have increased since the August *Statement*.

Front-month Brent crude oil futures prices have increased by around 25 per cent since the August *Statement* and are currently around US$115 per barrel (Graph 2.1). A renewal of hostilities in the Middle East led to a sharp increase in global crude oil prices in September and October, to around their peak level from earlier this year. That is despite a recovery in crude oil exports from the Middle East owing to the rerouting of oil flows and use of ship-to-ship transfers to enable crude oil flows through the Strait of Hormuz. Elevated prices likely also reflect an increased geopolitical risk premium associated with the risk of further disruption to crude oil flows due to the conflict.

Graph 2.1
Oil and Refined Product Prices*
Per barrel, month average

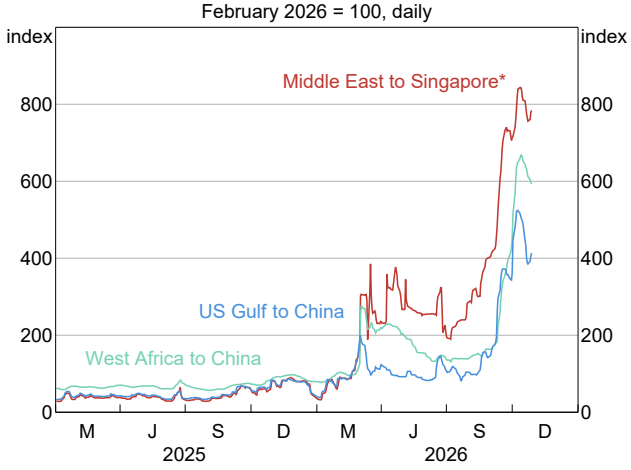


* The October 2026 observation for all series is an average to 28 October.
** Front-month forward prices.
Sources: Bloomberg; RBA.

There continues to be little sign of progress toward a resolution of the conflict and commodity analysts have revised their outlook for oil prices higher in 2026 and 2027. The downward slope of the futures curve has also steepened since the August *Statement*, reflecting tight physical oil supply and falling inventories as conflicts escalated over September and October (see Graph 3.1 in Chapter 3: Outlook).

Prices of refined oil products have increased substantially since the August *Statement*. The spreads between the prices of refined products and crude oil ('crack spreads') have been elevated for some time, reflecting supply constraints. Refined product exports from the Middle East have recovered by less than crude oil exports in recent months. In addition, global refining capacity remains constrained due to outages in Russia and the Middle East, further limiting supplies, particularly of diesel. Since August, gasoline, diesel and jet fuel prices have increased by around 20–25 per cent. That largely reflects increases in the cost of buying and shipping oil, as the rerouting of crude oil and the use of ship-to-ship transfers have caused congestion and raised shipping costs for refiners (Graph 2.2). Market reporting indicates that higher shipping costs have not been fully passed through to refined product prices, as profit margins for some Asian refiners have been squeezed. Compressed margins may discourage refiner production in the near term, helping maintain elevated refined product prices and crack spreads.

Graph 2.2
Crude Oil Shipping Cost Indexes
February 2026 = 100, daily



* Route begins in the Strait of Hormuz. Price formation for this index is likely disrupted.
Sources: LSEG; RBA.

Low inventory levels and a recovery in Chinese oil imports leave energy markets vulnerable to further supply disruptions and upward pressure on prices. A drawdown in global inventories and a reduction in Chinese demand for oil imports helped energy markets absorb the initial impact of the Middle East conflict. While increases in crude oil supply over August and early September allowed for a modest restocking of global crude oil inventories, market analysts estimate that inventories remain around historically low levels. Refined product inventories have continued to decline and are approaching historical minimum levels. Chinese oil imports have increased recently and a sustained recovery – for example, to support inventory restocking – presents an upside risk to global crude oil prices.

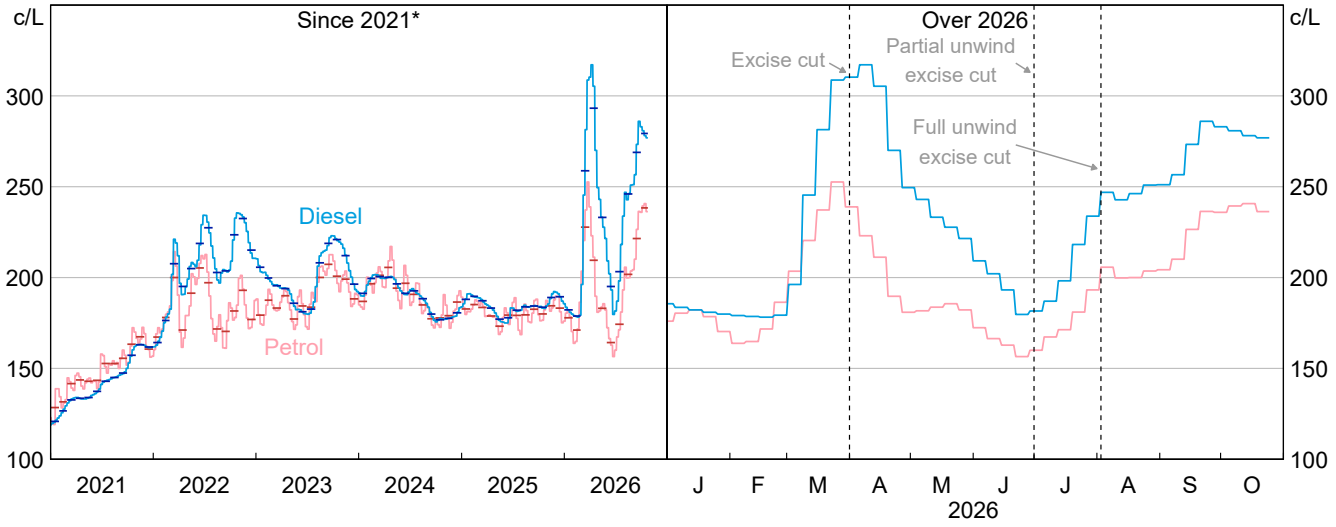
Retail petrol and diesel prices in Australia have increased substantially and are well above the August forecast assumption and their pre-conflict levels (Graph 2.3). The increase reflects both the rise in regional benchmark prices for refined fuel and the ending of the temporary fuel excise reduction in July and August. Nonetheless, refined fuel prices, especially for diesel, remain below the peaks observed earlier this year, which reflected severe dislocations in Asian refined product markets following the announcement of export bans in several exporting countries in the region.

Prices of natural gas have increased in line with other energy commodities. Asian liquefied natural gas (LNG) and European natural gas prices have increased by more than 50 per cent to be around the high levels observed during the early stages of the Middle East conflict, driven by restocking demand in Europe ahead of winter and concerns over future supply from the Middle East.

Graph 2.3

Fuel Prices by Type

Cents per litre, weekly



* Darker horizontal lines are monthly averages.

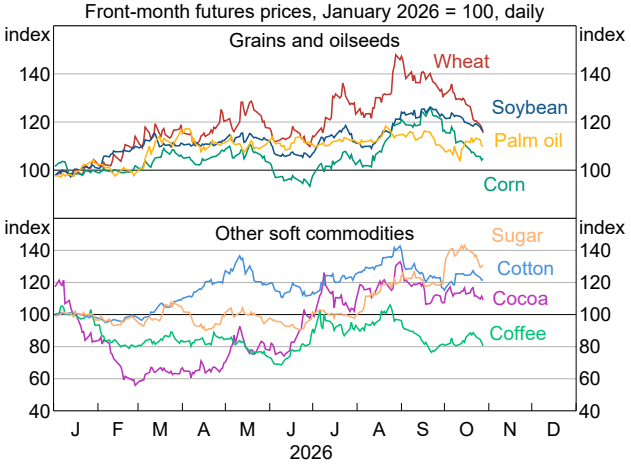
Sources: Australian Institute of Petroleum; RBA.

Supply disruptions continue to affect a range of other commodity prices.

Prices of some base metals have risen since August, while agricultural commodity prices remain elevated. Copper, zinc and aluminium prices remain elevated following mining and shipping disruptions, including due to the Middle East conflict, alongside continued demand pressure from the energy transition and AI-related investment. Prices for agricultural commodities, including wheat, have risen through 2026, following supply chain disruptions in the Middle East and Ukraine (Graph 2.4). The increase in fertiliser prices in March and April as a result of the Middle East conflict may now also be contributing to elevated agricultural commodity prices. Adverse weather conditions, including drought in parts of the United States and repeated heatwaves in Europe, have also affected harvests, pushing up grain prices earlier this year.

The internationally declared El Niño event is yet to materially affect commodity prices but poses risks to agricultural yields and prices over the year ahead. The estimated effects on agricultural output and prices in previous El Niño episodes have varied and tend to differ across both regions and commodities. El Niño can increase the likelihood of extreme weather events, which may exacerbate supply disruptions and contribute to periods of elevated commodity price volatility.

Graph 2.4
Agricultural Commodity Prices
Front-month futures prices, January 2026 = 100, daily



Sources: Bloomberg; RBA.

In terms of key Australian commodity exports, the price of iron ore has fallen slightly, while the price of coking coal has increased by 6 per cent since the August *Statement*. Iron ore price pressures remain subdued as supply remains abundant, while coking coal prices have been boosted by supply disruptions in China and Indonesia.

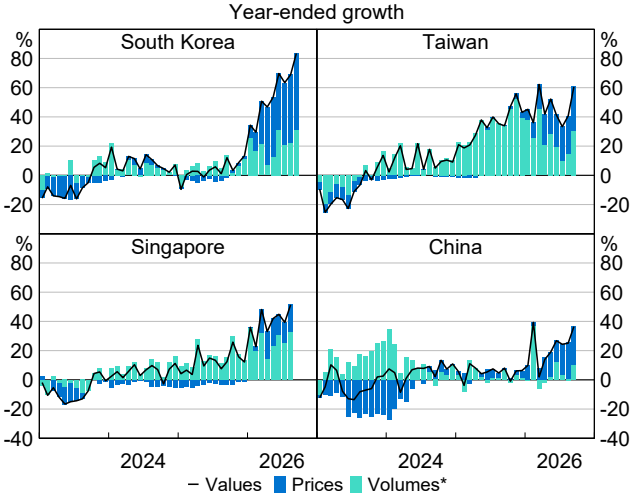
2.2 Global economic conditions

Economic growth in Australia's major trading partners (MTPs) has trended higher and been consistently stronger than expected over the past year or so. MTP growth has been resilient and slightly higher than some estimates of trend growth recently. Growth has been supported by the global surge in AI-related investment, fiscal policy measures targeted at households and business in many economies, and higher defence spending in some economies. Against a backdrop of higher public and private investment, government bond yields have increased across advanced economies; this reflects expectations that policy rates will remain higher for longer, as well as increases in term premia (see Chapter 1: Financial Conditions). Upstream cost pressures are intensifying as capacity in AI-related supply chains struggles to keep pace with soaring demand – particularly in high-income east Asia – and global energy prices have been persistently elevated. These pressures are passing through to some consumer goods prices. The rise in goods prices has occurred alongside a stalling in disinflation in services prices, leaving core measures of inflation elevated relative to central banks' targets. Central bank policy responses are discussed in Chapter 1: Financial Conditions.

MTP growth has been stronger than expected in the August *Statement*, supported by the boom in AI-related investment that has more than offset headwinds from the Middle East conflict.

Growth in Australia's trading partners remained resilient in the June and likely also the September quarters, partly reflecting the global investment boom, particularly for AI-enabling products. GDP growth was stronger than expected in economies with significant exposure to AI-related supply chains, such as South Korea and Singapore, reflecting robust net exports and an increase in construction activity. Timely trade data across several east Asian economies indicate that export prices continued to rise sharply in the September quarter – by around 40 per cent in year-ended terms in South Korea – consistent with manufacturing capacity being fully utilised, compounding cost pressures from higher energy prices (Graph 2.5). These upstream cost pressures have flowed through east Asian supply chains and into some consumer goods prices.

Graph 2.5
East Asia Goods Exports
Year-ended growth



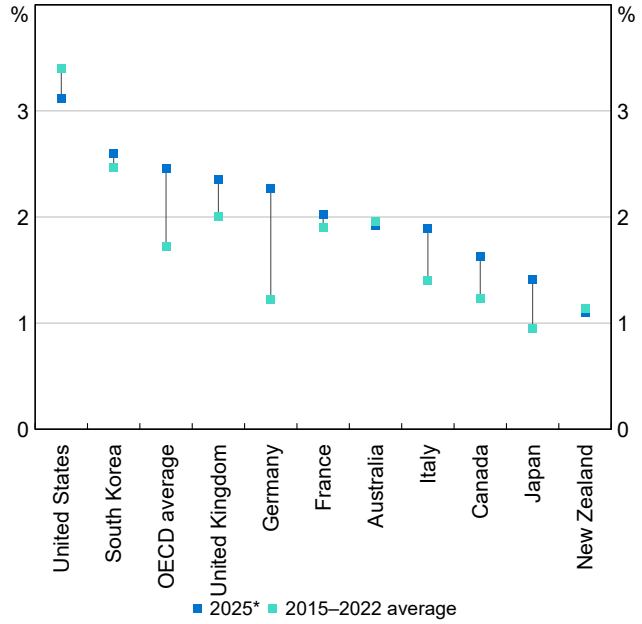
* Volumes are implied from US dollar export values and export price indices.
Sources: CEIC Data; LSEG; RBA.

Outside of east Asia, growth in advanced economies appears to have remained steady in the September quarter following stronger-than-expected growth in the June quarter. Timely indicators point to continued strength in manufacturing activity and investment in the September quarter, reflecting AI- and defence-related demand. Business surveys also suggest that services activity growth may have strengthened in the September quarter. In the United States, household consumption and private sector labour demand remain resilient despite higher energy prices; retail sales growth over August and September was strong, while employment growth has remained broadly in line with estimates of labour supply growth, leaving the unemployment rate little changed.

Growth in many trading partners has also been supported by fiscal policies shielding households and businesses from higher energy costs, as well as rising defence spending in some economies. In the first half of the year, many governments implemented tax cuts, subsidies and fiscal transfers to support households and businesses through the Middle East energy shock. While there had been a gradual shift away from subsidies and price caps for retail fuel, allowing

upstream cost increases to pass through to producer and consumer prices, some trading partners have extended or re-introduced these policies following more recent increases in refined product prices globally. Defence spending has also supported growth in some trading partners, particularly in the euro area where its share in GDP has increased since Russia's invasion of Ukraine in 2022 (Graph 2.6). The impact of higher government spending (and other factors) on government bond yields globally is discussed further in Box B: Developments in the Neutral Rate of Interest.

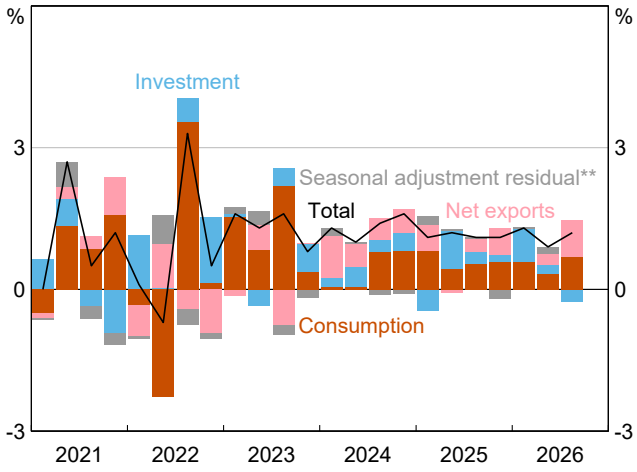
Graph 2.6
Defence Spending in Selected Major Trading Partners
Share of GDP



* Data are OECD estimates.
Sources: OECD; RBA.

consumption, lifting the savings ratio amid ongoing weakness in household sentiment and spending. Monthly indicators suggest that there was some improvement in momentum towards the end of the quarter, led by fixed asset investment and industrial production as authorities continue to prioritise development of advanced manufacturing and 'Six Networks' infrastructure projects.[1] Local government special bond issuance increased in August and September, which should support infrastructure investment further over the coming months. Property sector activity continued to decline. Developments in the Middle East conflict and the AI-investment boom have affected Chinese trade flows and contributed to large increases in Chinese export prices.

Graph 2.7
China – GDP Growth*
Quarterly with estimated contributions



* Components seasonally adjusted by the RBA and their contributions calculated by the RBA.
** Reflects the difference between RBA and NBS seasonal adjustment.
Sources: CEIC Data; RBA.

GDP growth in China rebounded in the September quarter which, alongside the announcement of additional policy support, means that growth is on track to achieve the annual GDP growth target.

Chinese economic activity strengthened over the September quarter, following a period of subdued activity. Growth was supported by a moderate increase in consumption and a large positive contribution from net exports, while investment declined (Graph 2.7). Household income growth continued to outpace

In response to subdued growth in the middle of the year, authorities shifted to a more supportive policy stance and reaffirmed their commitment to achieve the 2026 annual growth target. The new policy measures include expanding policy bank lending to cover infrastructure projects that are part of the 'Six Networks' construction initiative and allowing local governments to draw on unused special bond quotas from previous years. Alongside other adjustments to monetary policy settings and mortgage policies, the new measures signal that lifting economic growth to achieve the annual target has become more of a policy priority, which should support a strong increase in infrastructure investment over the remainder of 2026 and early 2027.

Core inflation remains elevated in many economies and energy and upstream AI cost pressures have intensified.

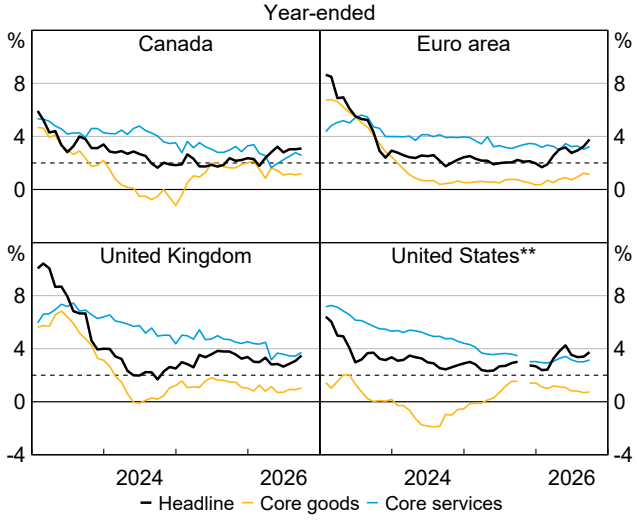
Headline inflation has risen across most economies, driven by higher energy prices following the re-escalation of hostilities in the Middle East (Graph 2.8). Most advanced economy central banks have revised their near-term headline inflation forecasts higher to reflect elevated energy prices, though most still expect inflation to return to target by 2028. Available measures of households' longer-term inflation expectations have risen in some advanced economies, in line with higher energy price inflation. Producer prices and a range of indicators from timely business surveys suggest that cost pressures for firms in all advanced economies remain elevated due to higher energy, materials and transport prices related to suply disruptions caused by the Middle East conflict. Some firms also report limited ability to pass cost increases on to price-sensitive consumers.

Upstream costs in AI-related supply chains are passing through to some core consumer goods prices, while disinflation in services prices has stalled, leaving core inflation elevated. Core goods inflation has picked up in many advanced economies this year and remains above its pre-pandemic averages in most economies. Prices of some consumer electronics have risen sharply as upstream costs in AI-related supply chains have been passed through to related consumer goods like personal computers. Impacts on aggregate headline and core measures of inflation have so far been limited because the affected goods tend to have small weights in consumer price baskets. Core services inflation remains above rates consistent with central bank targets and progress on disinflation in a number of advanced economies has stalled alongside upward pressure on transportation costs and signs of strengthening activity in their services sectors.

Graph 2.8

Goods and Services Consumer Price Inflation*

Year-ended

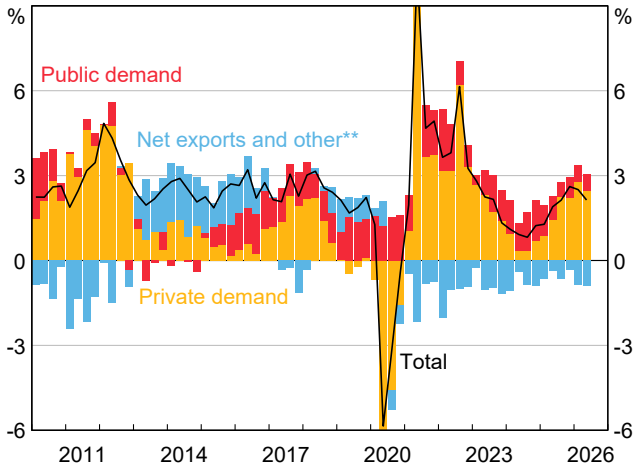


* Dashed line is the central bank headline inflation target or midpoint of central bank target range; PCE inflation target for the United States.
** CPI data not available for October 2025.
Sources: BLS; Eurostat; LSEG; RBA.

2.3 Domestic economic activity

GDP growth has slowed to below its potential growth rate in 2026, as some of the factors that supported above-trend growth in late 2025 (including strong growth in income) have waned. The initial phase of the Middle East conflict looks to have weighed only modestly on activity growth, as expected. However, the slowing has been a little more gradual than was expected in August, largely reflecting stronger-than-expected business investment related to data centres and the renewable energy transition. Household consumption growth has moderated broadly as expected, despite consumer sentiment being very low, supported by resilient household balance sheets and modest real income growth. By contrast, housing market conditions have eased by more than expected over recent months.

Graph 2.9
GDP Growth*
Year-ended with contributions



* Outliers during the COVID-19 pandemic have been truncated.
** Includes change in inventories and the statistical discrepancy.
Sources: ABS; RBA.

Growth in domestic activity has slowed in 2026 following strong growth over the second half of 2025.

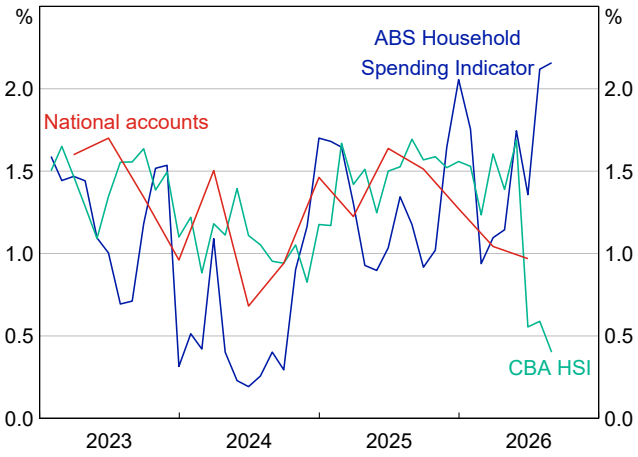
GDP grew by 0.4 per cent in the June quarter, below its potential growth rate but a little stronger than expected in the August forecasts (Graph 2.9). Growth eased in the first half of 2026. That reflected softer growth in household consumption, exports and public demand, which outweighed strong growth in dwelling investment and business investment. The strength in business investment was relatively broad-based, though spending related to data centres and renewable energy projects was particularly strong. Investment in data centres has mostly been met by stronger imports, which has limited the impact on overall GDP. Given the usual lags, the recent tightening in monetary policy and easing in conditions in the established housing market are assessed to have had only modest effects on GDP growth in the first half of the year.

Household consumption growth has slowed this year to be a little below trend, consistent with the earlier slowing in the growth of household income.

Consumption growth in the June quarter was as expected, with the net effects from the Middle East conflict appearing to be modest. Household consumption grew by 0.4 per cent in the quarter and year-ended growth slowed to 1.8 per cent alongside slowing growth in income. Australians' spending on overseas travel fell sharply in the quarter, and consumption of fuel and transport services declined. However, this was largely offset by stronger electric vehicle purchases and discretionary spending domestically.

We assess that consumption growth in the September quarter was little changed from the June quarter's below-trend rate, though given the mixed signals from the available timely indicators, this assessment is quite uncertain (Graph 2.10). The ABS Household Spending Indicator, which captures spending within Australia, was unchanged in August but points to strong quarterly growth in nominal spending. However, other indicators, including liaison and transaction data from some banks, suggest more modest growth. Vehicle purchases remained at very high levels in July and August but are not expected to contribute much to growth in the quarter. There appears to have been only a modest recovery in overseas travel so far, based on spending and departures data.

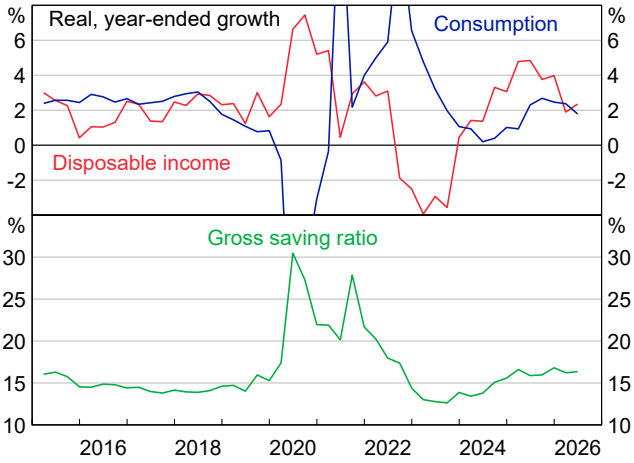
Graph 2.10
Household Consumption Indicators*
Nominal, quarterly growth



* CBA HSI and the ABS Household Spending Indicator are three-month-on-three-month growth rates as these series are monthly.
Sources: ABS; CBA; RBA.

The moderation in consumption growth this year, compared with the second half of last year, is consistent with the earlier slowing in growth in household income. Year-ended growth in real household disposable income has slowed materially as the earlier boost from the Stage 3 tax cuts has waned, alongside slower growth in labour and rental income and higher inflation (Graph 2.11). Despite consumer sentiment remaining near all-time lows (across all income levels and for both renters and homeowners, regardless of whether they have a mortgage), the household saving ratio has been relatively stable since the start of the year, suggesting little change in aggregate consumption or saving behaviour so far. This is consistent with the fact that household balance sheets remain quite resilient on average – real household net wealth remains around 37 per cent higher than its pre-pandemic level – and with the results of previous analysis that sentiment is typically not an independent driver of consumption over and above fundamentals such as income and wealth. However, there is a risk that the multiple headwinds affecting households and historically low sentiment have a greater bearing on household spending decisions than would normally be expected (see Chapter 3: Outlook).

Graph 2.11
Household Consumption and Income*

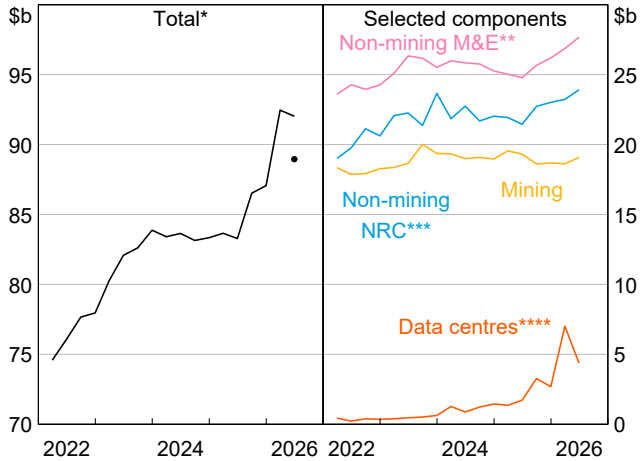


* Outliers during the COVID-19 pandemic have been truncated.
Sources: ABS; RBA.

Business investment grew strongly over the past year; while increased investment in data centres and renewable energy projects were key drivers, investment picked up across other industries too.

Business investment in the June quarter was significantly stronger than expected, increasing by 10.5 per cent over the year (Graph 2.12). While investment declined a little in the quarter, we had expected a larger decline following very strong growth in the March quarter related to data centres. Non-residential construction, particularly of lumpy renewable energy projects (unrelated to data centres), made the largest contribution to the upside surprise on investment. Data centre investment grew strongly over the past year but was volatile. Much of this spending was on imported equipment, which limited the boost to GDP. Strength in investment was also evident across a broad range of industries, consistent with the earlier easing in financial conditions and the upswing in domestic activity through 2025.

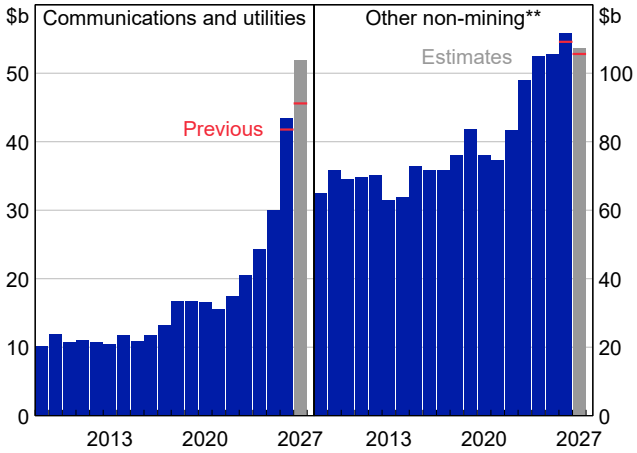
Graph 2.12
Business Investment
Chain volume, quarterly



* Dot represents nowcast at August 2026 SMP for comparison.
** Non-mining machinery & equipment; excluding investment in data centres.
*** Non-mining non-residential construction; excluding investment in data centres.
**** Estimate of data centre spending derived from information media & telecommunications capital expenditure and subject to assumptions.
Sources: ABS; RBA.

Firms' surveyed capital expenditure intentions for the year ahead have been revised higher, underpinned by strong growth in expected investment in data centres and renewables (Graph 2.13). Building approvals for these industries have risen persistently and firms in the liaison program note that buoyant conditions for data centre development could support renewable energy investment in the medium term. Timely trade data point to strong data centre investment in the September quarter; imports of equipment related to data centre fit outs increased sharply in July and August, while prices are also expected to have risen alongside surging global demand for AI-enabling products.

Graph 2.13
Non-mining Capital Expenditure*
Nominal, financial year



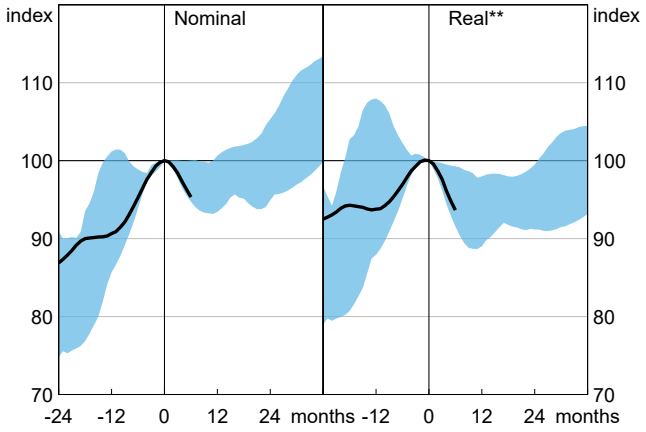
* Data from Capex survey. Estimates are firms' expected capital expenditure adjusted for the historical average difference between expected and realised spending. Survey estimates are typically below the level of business investment recorded in the National Accounts due to differences in coverage, definitions and sources.
** Excluding communications and utilities.
Sources: ABS; RBA.

Outside of data centres and renewables, capital expenditure intentions suggest investment will decline a little but remain around the average level of recent years. The effects of tighter monetary policy and cost pressures related to the Middle East conflict appear to be dampening capital expenditure intentions a little. Surveyed business conditions in the September quarter declined to their lowest level since 2020, consistent with continued input cost growth in recent months weighing on profitability, while business confidence also remains very low. However, there is only a moderate correlation between business conditions, business confidence and investment activity. Notwithstanding the modest decline expected over the year ahead, firms in the liaison program expect investment to remain a little above the long-term average.

Established housing market conditions have continued to weaken by more than expected, driven by a range of factors, including higher interest rates and tax changes for investors.

In September, national housing prices were 4.7 per cent below their recent peak (Graph 2.14). The current downturn is one of the steepest over the past 50 years, and price declines have broadened to most capital cities. Housing market activity has also continued to soften, with auction clearance rates remaining very low, time on market rising sharply to above long-run average levels and housing market turnover declining to low levels.

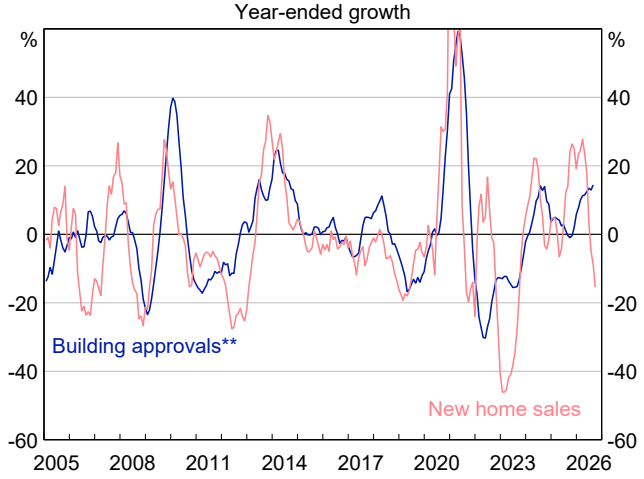
Graph 2.14
Housing Price Downturns*
Indexed to nominal pre-downturn peak



* Shaded area shows the range across previous downturns; the line is the current cycle.
** Deflated by quarterly trimmed mean CPI, interpolated to months.
Sources: ABS; Cotality; RBA.

Dwelling investment was much stronger than expected over the first half of 2026, although leading indicators of activity have started to soften, consistent with the ongoing housing market downturn (Graph 2.15). Activity was stronger than expected in the June quarter and there were also upward revisions to earlier periods, suggesting there is more capacity in the sector than previously assessed. Growth in higher density construction and renovation activity were particularly strong, but construction of detached housing also increased over the year. Elevated cost growth and trade availability measures remain consistent with ongoing capacity pressures. Consistent with the usual lags, early indications of a softening in residential construction activity have become visible in recent months following the declines in established housing prices. HIA new home sales, a leading indicator of dwelling demand, have declined materially, and many builders in the liaison program have reported a decline in enquiries, buyer conversion rates and sales.

Graph 2.15
Dwelling Investment Indicators*
Year-ended growth



* Three-month moving average of year-ended growth rates. Outliers during the COVID-19 pandemic have been truncated.
** Detached building approvals.
Sources: ABS; HIA; RBA.

Public demand growth has moderated over the past year.

Public demand was weaker than expected over the first half of the year, with growth moderating from elevated rates observed over recent years. An easing in public consumption growth reflected the ending of some temporary cost-of-living measures, alongside moderation in some categories of government spending such as defence and disability and aged care services. Public investment has moved around a broadly stable level since late 2024, and budget projections continue to suggest that there is a substantial pipeline of public infrastructure projects.

Exports supported GDP growth in the June quarter, though the strength largely reflected temporary supply factors and growth has slowed since late 2025.

Exports increased by 0.8 per cent in the quarter, in line with expectations and driven by resource and manufactured exports, though year-ended growth slowed further. A rebound in resource exports largely reflected a recovery from weather-related disruptions in the previous quarter, met by strong mining inventory drawdowns. As expected, the effect of the Middle East conflict on resource exports has largely operated through higher commodity prices and export earnings; production and export volumes are unlikely to respond materially to price movements unless higher prices are expected to persist, given the long lead times for new investments. Services exports have declined this year, reflecting declines in both education and tourism exports, with support from stronger global growth offset by changes to student visa settings, some disruption to international travel from the Middle East conflict, and the appreciation of the Australian dollar since late last year. The boom in AI-related activity globally does not appear to have had a material influence on Australia's exports, as production of critical minerals remains small and the expansion in data centre capacity has been to service domestic demand for computing capacity.

2.4 Labour market and wages

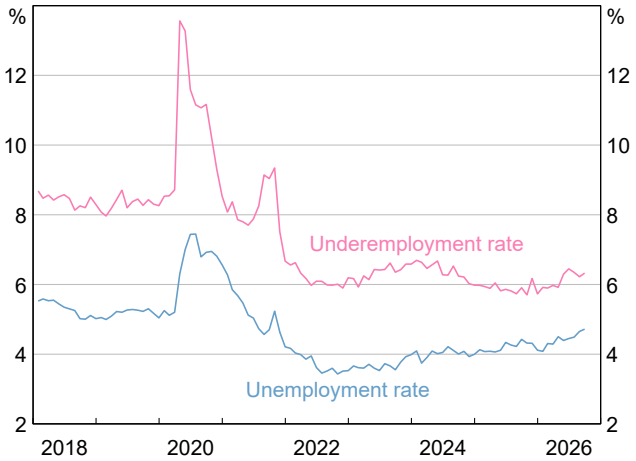
Labour market conditions have eased by more than expected recently. This easing is judged largely to reflect stronger-than-expected labour supply, rather than an unexpected weakening in labour demand. Elevated cost-of-living pressures may be leading some people to seek additional hours or enter the labour force, which may be contributing to the increase in labour supply. Timely indicators of labour demand, such as job advertisements, are generally consistent with stable growth in labour demand in the near term, though signals differ across the measures. Despite the recent easing in conditions, we continue to assess that the labour market remains a little tight (see section 2.5 Assessment of spare capacity). Wages growth was stable over the first half of 2026 and in line with expectations, though growth in unit labour costs picked up in the first half of the year to be further above average, and a little stronger than anticipated. Liaison contacts' expectations for wages growth over the year ahead remain elevated, driven by an expected continuation of cost-of-living pressures.

Labour market conditions have eased by more than expected in recent months.

The unemployment rate was 4.7 per cent in the month of September, and averaged 4.6 per cent in the September quarter (Graph 2.16).[2] This was higher than our August *Statement* forecast of 4.4 per cent for the quarter and was accounted for by stronger-than-expected labour force participation rather than weaker-than-expected employment. The underemployment rate increased to 6.3 per cent in September, though remained low by historical standards.

Over the year to the June quarter, employment growth was increasingly driven by the market sector, with construction making the largest contribution to growth. In the September quarter, the employment-to-population ratio was 63.8 per cent, in line with expectations in August (Graph 2.17). After declining for a few months, average hours per worker have partially recovered recently, to be near their levels at the beginning of the year (Graph 2.17).

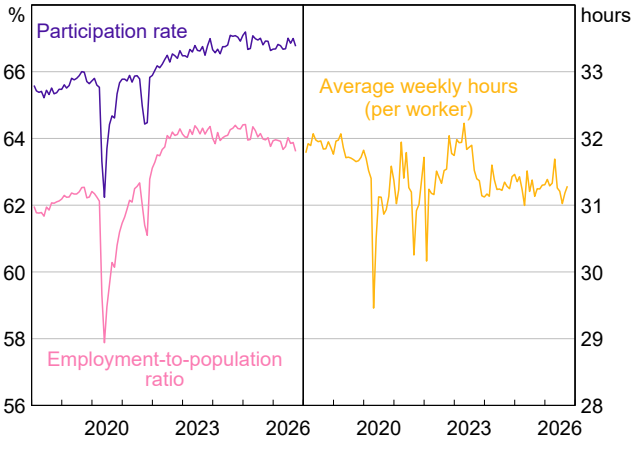
Graph 2.16
Labour Underutilisation



Source: ABS.

The participation rate increased to 66.9 per cent in the September quarter, above our expectations, reflecting ongoing resilience in labour supply (Graph 2.17). The participation rate remained around historically high levels, supported by long-run trends such as higher female participation, as well as cyclical pressures – such as elevated cost-of-living pressures – which may be encouraging people to enter or remain in the labour force. The share of employed persons holding multiple jobs also increased sharply from 6.5 per cent to 6.9 per cent in the June quarter.

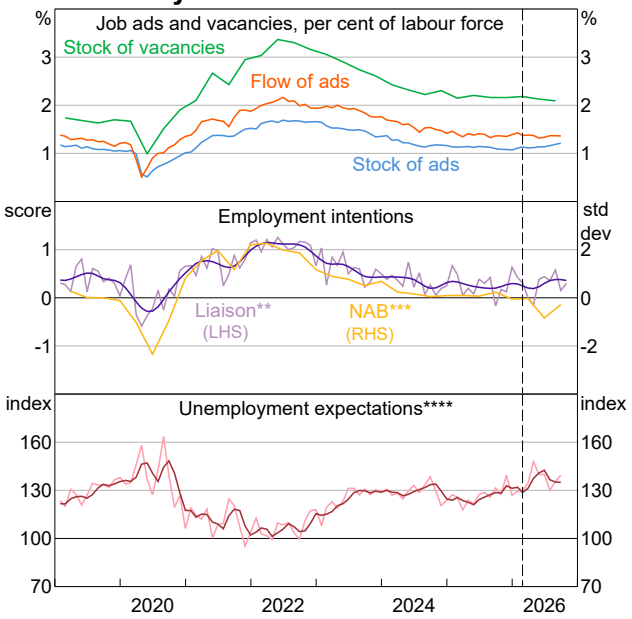
Graph 2.17
Labour Market Indicators



Sources: ABS; RBA.

Leading indicators generally point to stable growth in labour demand in the near term, although the signal differs somewhat across measures. Job advertisements have increased slightly or remained broadly stable over recent months, while vacancies (as a share of the labour force) declined in the past quarter (Graph 2.18). Employment intentions from business surveys partially rebounded in the quarter and the measure from the RBA's liaison program has also strengthened a little since earlier in the year. Households' unemployment expectations have ticked back up in August and September to be a little above their long-run average.

Graph 2.18
Timely Labour Market Indicators*

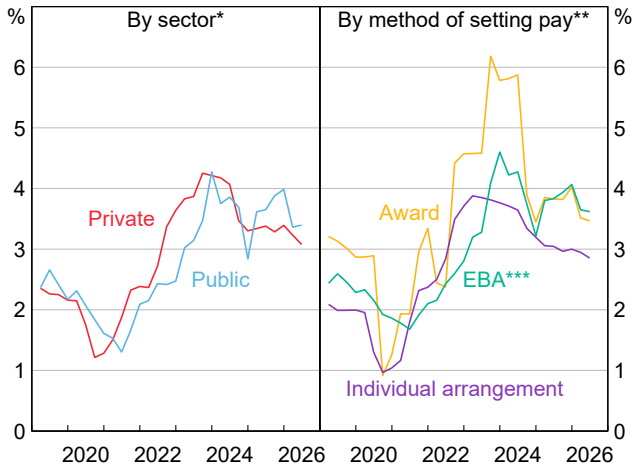


* Dashed line shows the start of the Middle East conflict.
** Score of 0 indicates a firm has reported no change; dark line shows Henderson trend.
*** 12 months ahead; standard deviations from mean.
**** Dark line shows three-month moving average.
Sources: ABS; ANZ–Indeed; JSA; NAB; RBA; Westpac–Melbourne Institute.

Aggregate wages growth remained stable (at a relatively elevated rate) in the June quarter, as expected, but liaison contacts report a noticeable increase in wages growth since July.

The June quarter Wage Price Index (WPI) affirmed our assessment in the August *Statement* that growth in base wages had remained broadly stable. The WPI increased by 3.2 per cent over the year; private sector WPI growth remained broadly stable at 0.7 per cent in the quarter and eased to 3.1 per cent over the year, as expected (Graph 2.19). Wages growth for workers on individual arrangements – which tends to be most responsive to current labour market conditions – remained at 2.9 per cent over the year but eased a little relative to its pace in 2025, consistent with an easing in labour market conditions since then. Public sector WPI growth remained stronger than private sector WPI growth. Overall, the June quarter data are consistent with our assessment that labour market conditions remain a little tight.

Graph 2.19
Wages Growth
Year-ended



* Seasonally adjusted.
** Non-seasonally adjusted.
*** Enterprise bargaining agreement.
Source: ABS.

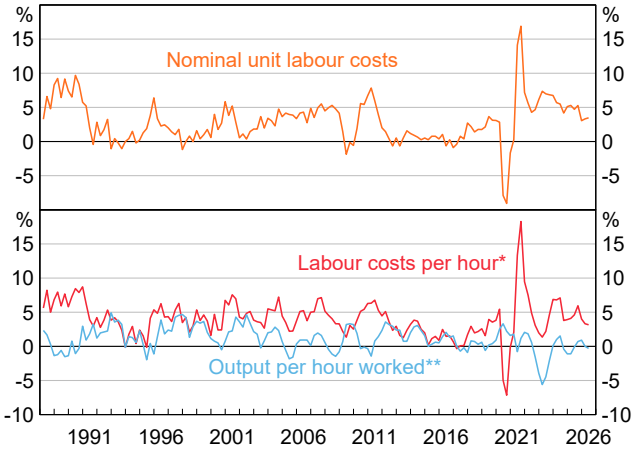
Wages growth is expected to have picked up in the September quarter, in part reflecting the recent Fair Work Commission (FWC) decision to increase all modern award wages by 4.75 per cent. Meanwhile, some pass-through from higher inflation to private enterprise bargaining agreements and individual arrangements is expected to have supported wages growth, as workers seek to preserve recent real wage gains. Consistent with this, liaison contacts have reported that wages growth has increased noticeably since July, including for firms that are not reliant on awards for setting wages. Liaison contacts' expectations for wages growth over the year ahead remain elevated, driven by an expected continuation of cost-of-living pressures.

Growth in the national accounts' measure of average earnings per hour (AENA) eased to 3.2 per cent over the year to the June quarter. AENA growth was stronger than forecast in the August *Statement*, suggesting there was a little more momentum in labour costs than previously expected. AENA is a broader measure of labour costs than the WPI but tends to be more volatile, and so provides a noisier read on wage pressures arising from conditions in the labour market. In real terms, AENA has grown by more than real WPI in recent years and is above its pre-pandemic level. Despite the easing in average earnings growth, it remained elevated relative to the current pace of productivity growth, and weaker productivity growth contributed to an increase in growth in unit labour costs (ULCs) in the first half of this year (Graph 2.20). At 3.5 per cent in year-ended terms, ULCs growth remained significantly above the rate that is consistent with inflation being at target, contributing to ongoing domestic cost pressures and pointing to some tightness in labour market conditions.

Graph 2.20

Nominal Unit Labour Cost Growth

Non-farm, year-ended



* Compensation of employees plus payroll taxes less employment subsidies, divided by employee hours worked.
** Includes self-employed.
Sources: ABS; RBA.

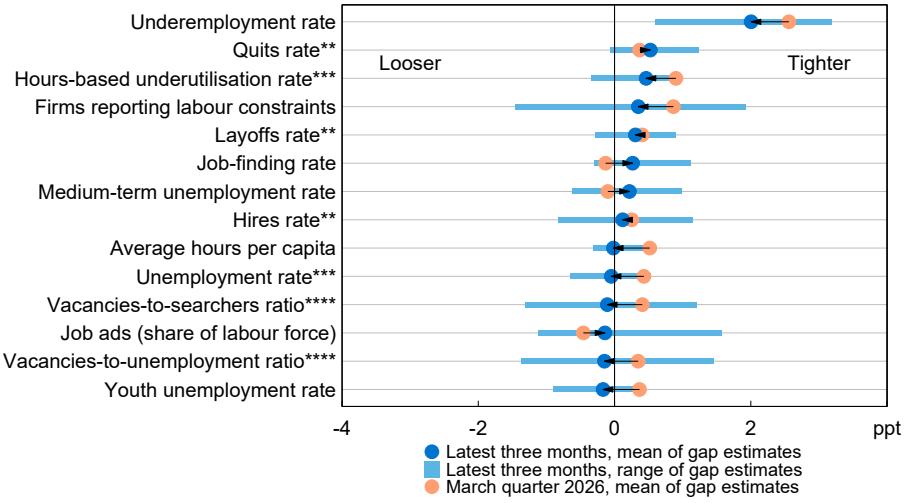
2.5 Assessment of spare capacity

Despite the recent slowing in demand growth and easing in labour market conditions, we continue to assess that there are some capacity pressures in the Australian economy. Further, those capacity pressures are now assessed to have been a little greater over the first half of the year than we thought at the time of the August *Statement*. A number of factors support this judgement, including: strong ongoing domestically generated cost and price pressures, particularly in components most sensitive to domestic capacity pressures; continued weak productivity outcomes; and survey evidence pointing to elevated capacity pressures. Consistent with that, we have raised our assessment of the non-accelerating inflation rate of unemployment (NAIRU) a little. A higher NAIRU implies tighter labour market conditions for a given unemployment rate. As a result, despite actual unemployment having increased recently, we assess that the labour market remains a little tight, broadly as anticipated in August.

Labour market conditions have eased over recent months, but are judged to remain a little tight.

Most of the labour market indicators we monitor suggest some easing in conditions over recent months. But a majority are close to or slightly tighter than their estimated trend levels (Graph 2.21).[3] The underemployment rate, hours-based underutilisation rate and quits rate in particular point to some tightness in the labour market.

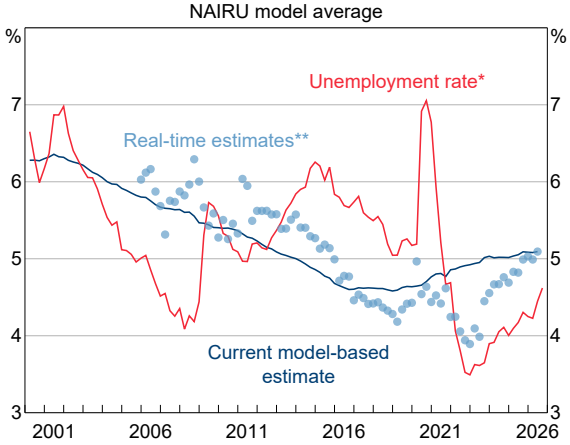
Graph 2.21
Indicators of Labour Market Tightness*
Gap between current conditions and estimated trends



* Indicators scaled to the units of the unemployment rate.
** Latest observations are for June quarter 2026.
*** Range includes model-based estimates.
**** Log-transformed.
Sources: ABS; ANZ–Indeed; NAB; RBA.

Model-based estimates of the NAIRU have gradually moved higher over recent years. The model average is now around 5 per cent (Graph 2.22), although these estimates are just one input to our overall assessment of the NAIRU (see below), alongside evidence from the broader suite of indicators and judgement. Model-based estimates have moved higher in response to persistently elevated unit labour cost growth and inflation over recent years.

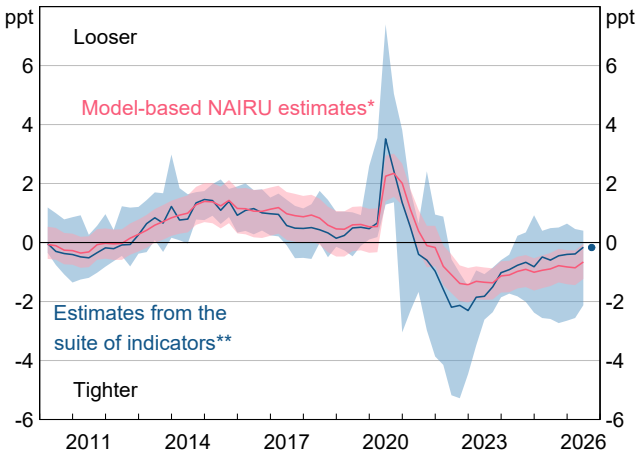
Graph 2.22
Model-based NAIRU Estimates
NAIRU model average



* Quarterly average of monthly data.
** Up to March quarter 2024, dots are model-based NAIRU endpoint reconstructions applying a consistent model framework to the data available at each point in time. See Sullivan and West (forthcoming). From June quarter 2024, dots are model-based NAIRU endpoint estimates as produced at the time, including any model framework changes. These do not reflect the RBA's overall assessment of the NAIRU at the time.
Sources: ABS; RBA.

We now assess the NAIRU to be slightly higher than was factored into the August forecasts. For some time we have noted that our model-based estimates have been pointing to a higher NAIRU – and therefore more capacity pressures – than the broader suite of labour market indicators (Graph 2.23). Our overall assessment has generally taken more signal from the broader set of indicators. However, underlying inflation and labour cost growth have been persistently elevated, and stronger than expected recently (see section 2.6 Inflation). These outcomes suggest putting a little more weight on the model-based estimates than we had been doing. Accordingly, we are increasing our assessment of the NAIRU to around 4¾ per cent. This is a modest adjustment when compared with the range of uncertainty around estimates from either the models or broader set of indicators.

Graph 2.23
Labour Market Spare Capacity



* Red line shows the model average and swathe shows the highest and lowest bounds of the one-standard-error confidence intervals across the selection of models.
** Blue line shows median indicator, swathe shows range of indicators and dot indicates partial estimate of median indicator for September quarter 2026.
Source: RBA.

Given this judgement, we continue to assess that the labour market is a little tight, despite the recent easing in a number of indicators. The revision to our NAIRU estimate implies that the labour market was a little tighter through the first half of this year than previously assessed. It also implies that there was a small amount of tightness remaining in the September quarter, despite the unemployment rate having increased by more than expected in recent months (because the unemployment rate remained a little below our upwardly revised assessment of the NAIRU). That is consistent with the signal from the broader suite of labour market indicators for the September quarter, which continue to suggest a little tightness in labour market conditions.

Economy-wide indicators continue to suggest that some capacity pressures remain in the broader economy, consistent with the signal from the labour market. The June quarter output gap is now estimated to have been a little larger than assessed in August.

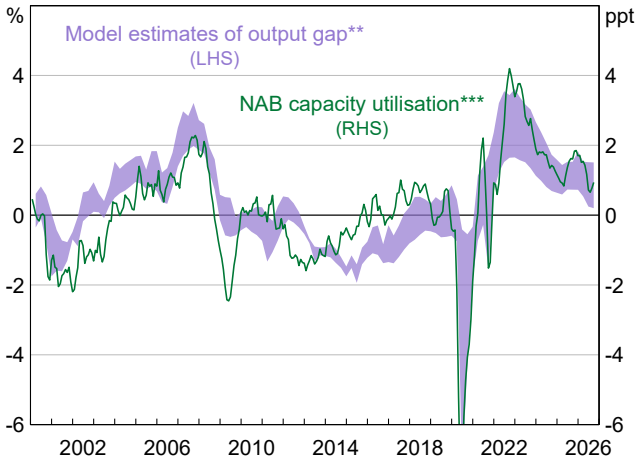
Slower productivity growth has lowered the economy's potential growth rate compared with previous decades. The level of productivity is broadly unchanged since the end of 2019. This has contributed to capacity pressures persisting despite relatively modest GDP growth in recent years. Combined with resilient wages growth and elevated growth in non-labour input costs, the lack of productivity improvement is likely to have limited firms' ability to absorb higher costs without raising output prices and to have contributed to inflation being above the target range.

Indicators of capacity utilisation continue to point to there being some capacity pressures in the economy. Signals across sectors are mixed, but the NAB measure of capacity utilisation remains above its historical average. There is also marked variation across states, with business liaison suggesting that parts of Queensland in particular continue to face capacity constraints, whereas conditions are less tight in Victoria.

Taking survey evidence together with model-based estimates of the output gap, we assess that the output gap was positive in the June and September quarters (Graph 2.24) and slightly larger than assessed in August. That reflects both stronger-than-expected real activity data and a small downward judgement applied to the level of potential output. This is consistent with our judgement on the NAIRU; other things equal, a higher NAIRU implies lower potential supply capacity. Our judgement on potential output and the output gap is relatively modest compared with the uncertainty around estimates of capacity pressures; the range of model estimates and responses to the RBA survey of market economists in August suggests the output gap could be between zero and 1½ per cent. An alternative rationale for downwardly adjusting the level of potential output would be to take greater signal from the weakness in actual productivity outcomes for the trend level of productivity. We have not changed our expectation of potential output growth and productivity growth in the medium term.

Graph 2.24

Estimates of Capacity Utilisation*



* Outliers during the COVID-19 pandemic have been truncated.
** Per cent of potential output; the shaded region shows an illustrative range of central gap estimates from a selection of RBA internal models with different measures and definitions of the output gap. The latest observation is an expectation for the September quarter.
*** Three-month moving average deviation from the long-run average capacity utilisation rate; the long-run average is calculated from March 1997 onwards; excludes mining; weighted by industry using share of gross value added.

Sources: ABS; NAB; RBA.

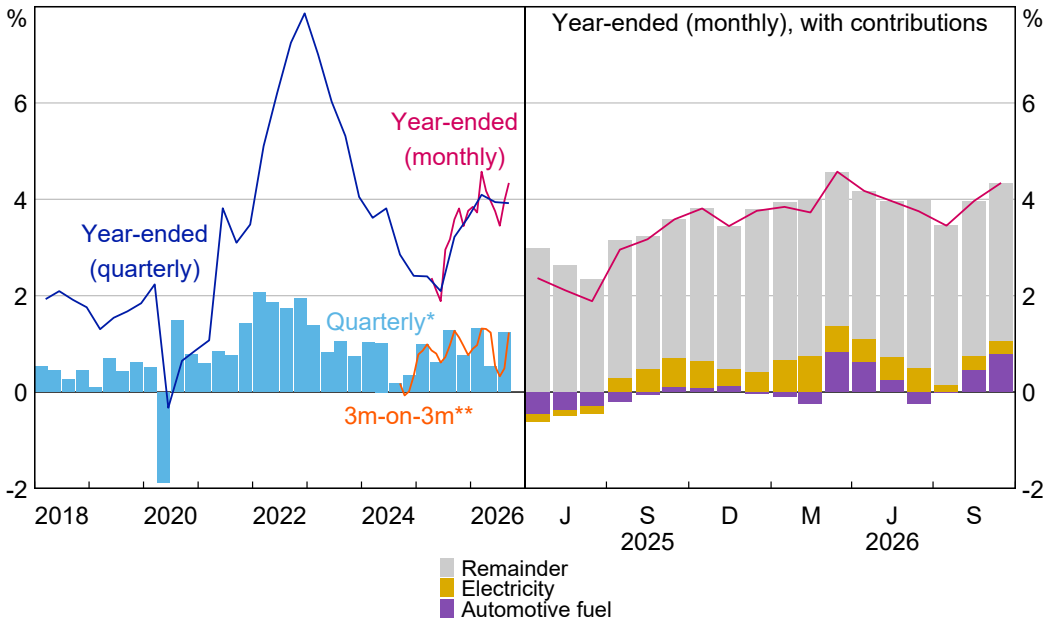
2.6 Inflation

Inflation in the September quarter was stronger than anticipated in the August forecasts and remained well above target, as some of the upside risks identified in August materialised. Retail fuel prices made the largest contribution to the upside surprise in headline inflation. We judge that domestic capacity pressures also made a stronger-than-expected contribution to both underlying and headline inflation in the quarter. Wider cost pressures related to the Middle East conflict have contributed to inflation, with the size of these effects having been broadly as anticipated so far (excluding the direct effect of retail fuel prices). Measures of cost growth remain elevated, with renewed pressure on fuel costs following the re-escalation of the conflict and ongoing cost pressures from wages, technology and services. Some measures of inflation expectations – including longer-term measures – have increased, and this may be contributing to inflation if it is influencing households' and firms' expectations for wages and cost growth. Households and firms have increasingly been paying greater attention to inflation, which may make their inflation expectations more sensitive to future shocks.

Headline inflation in the September quarter was stronger than anticipated in the August *Statement*.

In year-ended terms, headline inflation was unchanged at 3.9 per cent in the September quarter. This outcome reflected stronger-than-expected underlying inflation, as well as stronger-than-expected growth in automotive fuel prices because of a material increase in regional benchmark prices for refined fuel (see section 2.1 Commodity price developments) (Graph 2.3). Fuel contributed around 0.4 percentage points to year-ended headline inflation in the quarter, which was higher than expected at the time of the August *Statement*. Headline inflation in the month of September increased to 4.3 per cent, consistent with ongoing upward pressure from fuel prices (Graph 2.25).

Graph 2.25
Headline Inflation

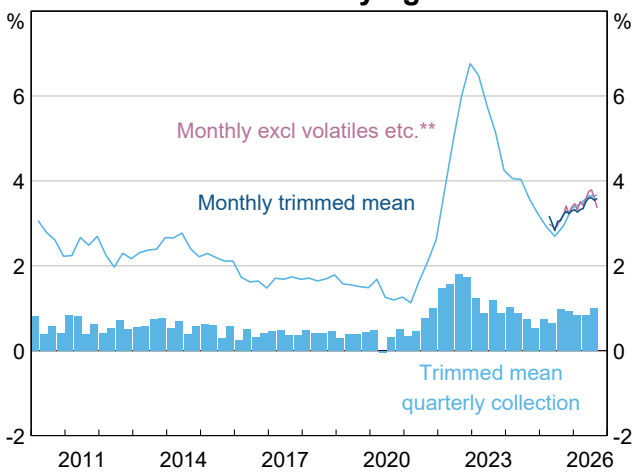


* Seasonally adjusted.
** Three-month-on-three-month percentage change; seasonally adjusted.
Sources: ABS; RBA.

Underlying inflation picked up in the September quarter by more than expected; we attribute this to stronger-than-expected domestic capacity pressures.

Trimmed mean inflation increased to 1.0 per cent in the September quarter, from 0.8 per cent in the June quarter, and picked up to 3.7 per cent in year-ended terms. Various measures of underlying inflation from the monthly CPI also picked up in the September quarter and remained elevated in year-ended terms (Graph 2.26). A majority of items in the CPI (by count and weight) recorded inflation above rates consistent with the inflation target, and this share has increased since the beginning of the year. We assess that the upward surprise in underlying inflation reflects stronger-than-expected domestic capacity pressures this year. Inflation for market services (excluding telecommunication and domestic travel), which is typically among the most sensitive to domestic conditions, increased and was materially stronger than expected in the August forecasts; some of this strength reflects the award wage increase.

Graph 2.26
Measures of Underlying Inflation*



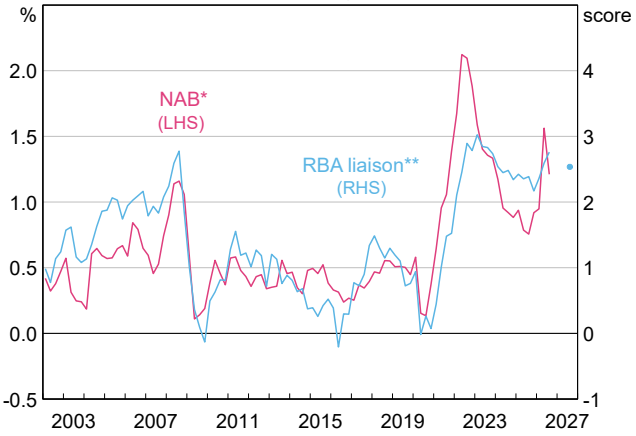
* Lines represent year-ended inflation and bars represent quarterly inflation.
** Monthly CPI excluding volatiles, holiday travel and electricity.
Sources: ABS; RBA.

Cost pressures related to the Middle East conflict are judged to have contributed to higher prices in the September quarter.

Conflict-related cost pressures are estimated to have contributed around 0.1 percentage points to quarterly trimmed mean inflation (excluding the direct effect of higher retail fuel prices), broadly as expected in the August *Statement*. However, these cost pressures appear to have affected a broader range of prices in the quarter than previously anticipated. Increases in building materials costs are judged to have had less effect on new dwellings inflation than expected. However, information from RBA liaison suggests conflict-related cost pressures contributed to price increases for other items, including some market services and durable goods. Many liaison contacts have continued to report higher fuel costs, while some have also continued to note ongoing concerns about higher costs for oil-derived products such as plastics following the re-escalation of tensions in the Middle East (see Box C: Insights from Liaison).

Broader measures of cost growth from business surveys and RBA liaison remain elevated (Graph 2.27). Liaison contacts report that a broad range of cost pressures – including for wages, technology and services – are contributing to expectations of continued elevated cost growth over the year ahead. AI-related cost pressures have had only a modest impact on consumer prices to date, but strong price growth for technology-related goods and services such as computers and software is contributing to firms' cost pressures. Firms are also noting potential future risks to food supply chains arising from El Niño and avian influenza, which could put further upward pressure on costs. Firms' expectations for aggregate inflation are also elevated, which may be reinforcing expectations of strong growth in their own costs.

Graph 2.27
Non-labour Costs
Current and expected



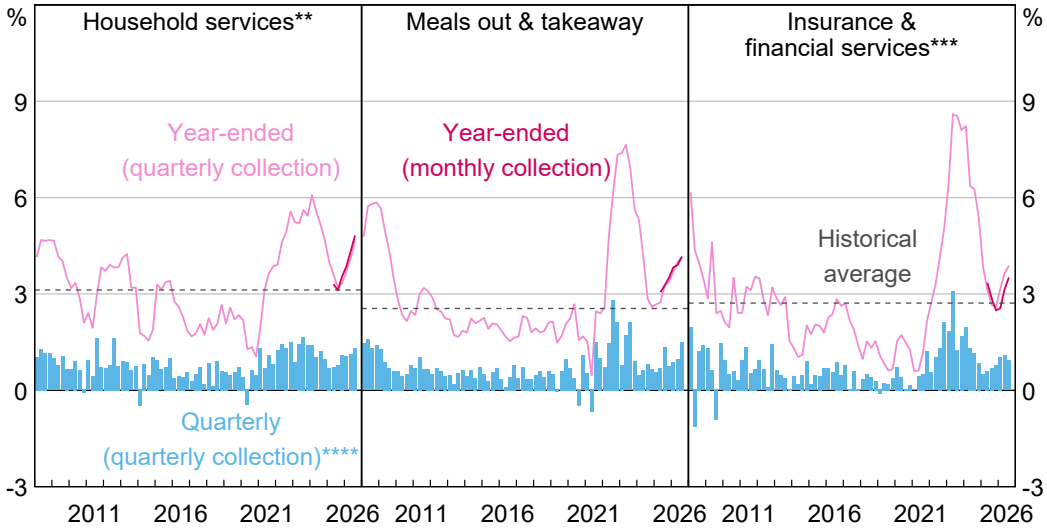
* Average of respondents' quarterly per cent changes.
** Quarterly average. Dot shows expectation for 12 months ahead.
Sources: NAB; RBA.

Survey and liaison data suggest that many firms have not yet been able to fully pass through increases in labour and non-labour costs to consumer prices, resulting in downward pressure on margins over the past few months. However, in the Business Outlook Scenario Survey (BOSS) in September, firms reported that they plan to continue to increase prices in response to past cost increases arising from the Middle East conflict, and that they plan to pass through a greater share of these future cost increases to prices than they had planned in April.[4] Moreover, firms that experienced larger changes in costs in response to the conflict have increased the frequency with which they adjust prices. Consistent with this, liaison contacts are not expecting growth in costs, wages and selling prices to ease much over the year ahead.

Inflation was elevated across most sectors in the September quarter and picked up for market services, rents and consumer durables.

Market services inflation (excluding telecommunications and domestic travel) increased to 1.3 per cent in the September quarter, from 1.1 per cent in the June quarter. In year-ended terms, it increased to 4.2 per cent (Graph 2.28). We assess that this strength primarily reflected domestic capacity pressures and, to a lesser extent, pass-through of conflict-related cost pressures (such as from food and fuel inputs). Some of the recent increase in inflation, for example in the prices of restaurant meals, likely reflected the impact of the FWC award wage decision (which came into effect on 1 July). While the effect of the award wage increase on inflation may be short-lived, firms' apparent ability to pass through this cost increase to prices is consistent with there being some remaining capacity pressures.

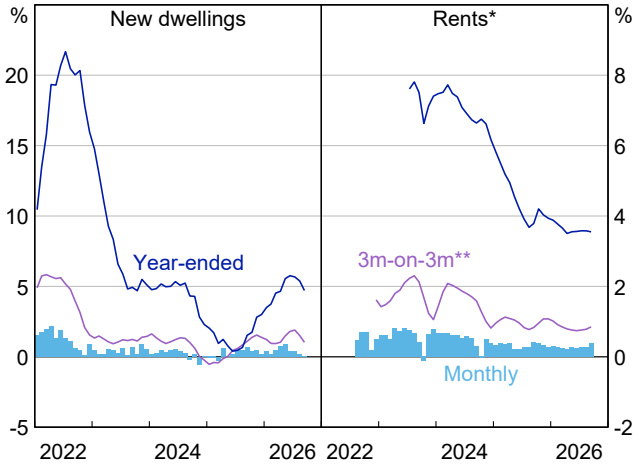
Graph 2.28
Market Services Inflation*



* Historical averages are for year-ended (quarterly collection) inflation. The average is calculated from 1993–2019 for household services as well as meals out & takeaway. The average is calculated from 2001–2019 for insurance & financial services.
** Includes home cleaning, vehicle repairs, hairdressing, veterinary services, sports and leisure services.
*** Excludes deposit & loans to June quarter of 2011.
**** Seasonally adjusted.
Sources: ABS; RBA.

New dwelling construction prices increased by 1.0 per cent in the September quarter to be 5.2 per cent higher over the year (Graph 2.29). This was weaker than expected in the August *Statement*, which we judge reflected smaller conflict-related cost effects than anticipated. Liaison information suggests that while homebuilders continue to experience elevated labour and materials costs, they have been less able to pass these costs through to prices recently in states where housing demand has weakened. New dwelling inflation tends to lag conditions in the established housing market, so this may be early evidence that the easing in housing market conditions that began late last year is beginning to weigh on new dwelling construction prices (see section 2.3 Domestic economic activity).

Graph 2.29
Housing Inflation

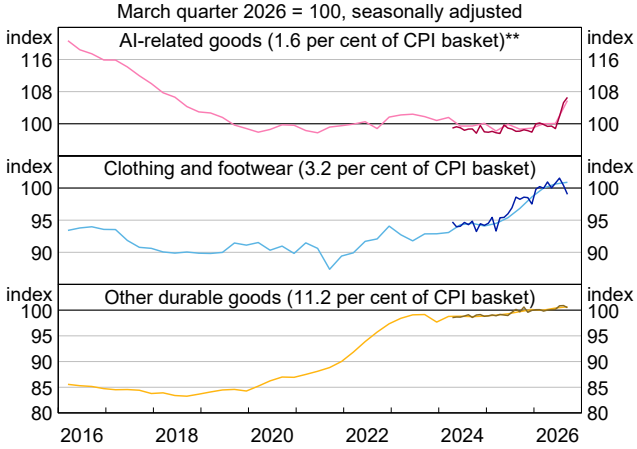


* Monthly and 3m-on-3m inflation rates are calculated using seasonally adjusted data.
** Three-month-on-three-month percentage change.
Sources: ABS; RBA.

CPI rent inflation increased to 0.9 per cent in the September quarter, from 0.6 per cent in the June quarter, and was 3.6 per cent in year-ended terms. The pick-up in the quarter was stronger than expected in the August *Statement*. This may be early evidence that the earlier strong growth in advertised rents – arising from an imbalance between housing supply and demand, as reflected in low vacancy rates – is beginning to pass through to CPI rents, following limited pass-through over the year to the June quarter. More recently, vacancy rates have increased modestly and growth in advertised rents has slowed.

Retail goods inflation was stronger than expected in the September quarter, largely driven by a pick-up in consumer durables inflation. This outcome reflected higher prices for some consumer electronics (such as computers, televisions and gaming consoles) driven by strong memory chip cost growth associated with demand for AI-enabling inputs (Graph 2.30). Although it is too early to judge the persistence of these price rises, similar price increases from AI-related cost pressures have been observed in other advanced economies (see section 2.2 Global economic conditions).

Graph 2.30
Components of Durables Prices*
March quarter 2026 = 100, seasonally adjusted

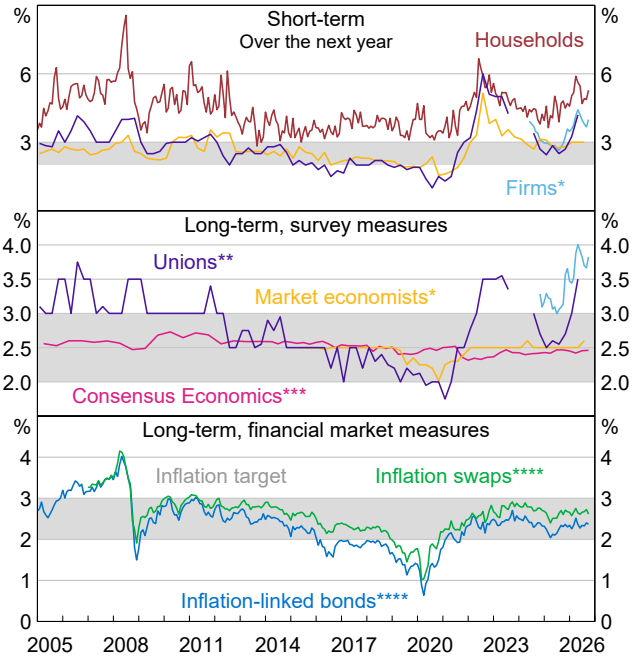


* Light coloured line is quarterly collection, dark coloured line is monthly collection.
** Includes audio, visual & computing equipment as well as games, toys & hobbies.
Sources: ABS; RBA.

Some measures of short-term inflation expectations have increased from already elevated levels. While most measures of longer-term inflation expectations remain consistent with achieving the inflation target, some have also increased.

Households' short-term inflation expectations have increased in recent months, and are above levels observed prior to the Middle East conflict (Graph 2.31). Expectations rose sharply following the onset of the conflict and associated increase in fuel prices, before easing as fuel prices declined from May. More recently, they have increased again alongside stronger fuel price inflation and the re-escalation of the conflict. Firms' short- and medium-term inflation expectations have also increased in recent months.

Graph 2.31
Inflation Expectations

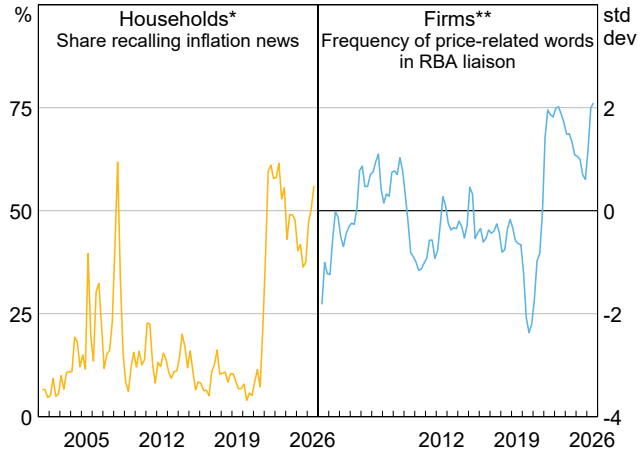


* Long-term expectations are the average expected annual rate of inflation over the next 5–10 years.
** Inflation expectations are unavailable between November 2023 and May 2024, and after May 2026. Long-term expectations are the average expected annual rate of inflation over the next 5–10 years.
*** Long-term expectations are the average expected annual rate of inflation over the 5 years starting from 5 years ahead.
**** Long-term expectations are the average expected annual rate of inflation over the next 10 years.
Sources: Australian Council of Trade Unions; Bloomberg; Consensus Economics; Employment Research Australia; Macquarie University; Melbourne Institute; RBA; Workplace Research Centre.

Longer-term inflation expectations are mostly consistent with the inflation target, although some measures have increased. Financial market measures of inflation expectations remain consistent with inflation at target over the longer term. However, other longer-term inflation expectations have increased. The median market economist now expects inflation to average 2.6 per cent over the next 5–10 years. Firms' longer-term inflation expectations have also increased since mid-2025, and the BOSS survey suggests firms have become less confident that inflation will return to target, a sentiment also shared by some contacts in the liaison program.

Elevated inflation expectations may be contributing to higher realised inflation if they are influencing households' and firms' expectations for wages and cost growth. Households and firms are increasingly paying more attention to inflation, which may make their inflation expectations more backward-looking and more sensitive to future shocks (Graph 2.32). The heightened attentiveness of households and firms to inflation – together with the re-escalation of the conflict – raises the likelihood that elevated inflation expectations feed into price- and wage-setting decisions, thereby posing a key upside risk to the outlook for wages growth and inflation (see Chapter 3: Outlook).

Graph 2.32
Inflation Awareness



* Share of respondents to quarterly Westpac–Melbourne Institute survey recalling inflation news.
** Frequency of price-related words in RBA liaison, based on an expert-selected dictionary; higher values indicate greater prominence. Standardised over full history; two-quarter rolling average.
Sources: RBA; Westpac–Melbourne Institute.

Endnotes

1 Authorities announced plans to invest around RMB7 trillion in the 'Six Networks' initiatives in 2026, as part of the 15th Five-Year Plan, with projects spanning water, energy, computing, communications, logistics and urban pipeline infrastructure.

2 Changes to the ABS Labour Force Survey in August may have introduced some additional volatility in seasonally adjusted employment and unemployment, although the ABS has said it expects these effects to be small relative to the normal month-to-month variation. For more information, see ABS (2026), 'Supplementary Survey Methodology Changes in the Labour Force Survey', September.

3 Some labour market indicators have been affected by changes to the Labour Force Survey from April 2026 onwards. See RBA (2026), 'Box B: Changes to the Labour Force Survey', *Statement on Monetary Policy*, May.

4 This is consistent with the pass-through of costs to prices and the role of expectations described in Georgiakakis F, J Hambur and C Ryan (2026), 'Digest: The Literature on Non-linear Phillips Curves', Insight 2026-01.

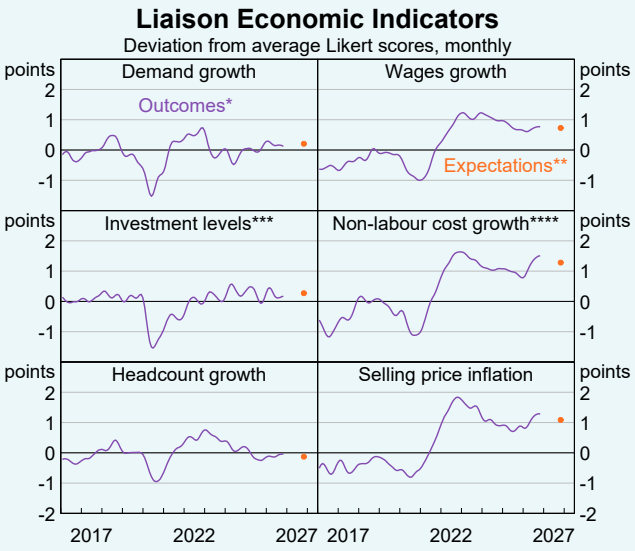
Box C: Insights From Liaison

This Box highlights key messages collected by the RBA's liaison teams based in New South Wales, Queensland, South Australia, Victoria and Western Australia during discussions with around 240 businesses, industry bodies, government agencies and community organisations from early-August to end-October 2026.

Liaison contacts report that cost and price pressures remain elevated and are expected to ease only moderately over the year ahead (Graph C.1). Wages growth outcomes and expectations have picked up since the middle of the year. Demand conditions generally remain around longer-run averages, with softening conditions in retail and dwelling investment being broadly offset by relatively stronger conditions in other areas of business activity. Expectations for growth in demand, investment and employment are also close to their longer-run averages, although with some variation across regions.

Businesses across most industries continue to report sustained labour and non-labour cost pressures, which are flowing through to prices. Most firms continue to expect above-average increases in their selling prices over the year ahead. Retail conditions are increasingly mixed; food retailers, for example, report fairly solid underlying growth, while more discretionary spending is softer than earlier in the year. Housing construction activity is currently being supported by existing pipelines of work in many regions, but a marked slowdown in forward sales suggests a weaker outlook. Nationally, non-residential construction and other business investment spending has been solid, and investment intentions are a bit above average at present. Employment intentions are close to average, having stabilised since earlier in the year.

Graph C.1



* Outcomes over the 12 months before each observation; smoothed with a 13-month Henderson trend.
** Expectations over the next 12 months from October 2026; smoothed with a 13-month Henderson trend.
*** Non-mining firms.
**** Expectations series adjusted by the mean of the current non-labour cost growth series because of short history.
Source: RBA.

Cost and price pressures remain broadly based and elevated and are expected to ease only a little over the year ahead.

Businesses continue to report widespread increases in operating costs. Higher fuel costs are flowing through in the form of surcharges and general transport-related expenses. While some firms are singling this out as a specific cost driver, others report that fuel-related costs are increasingly mingled into the broader elevated operating cost environment they are facing. Higher global costs for other oil-derived products are also flowing through to offshore and domestic supply chains and to consumer prices, though some contacts note that the appreciation of the Australian dollar is helping to moderate some of this impact.

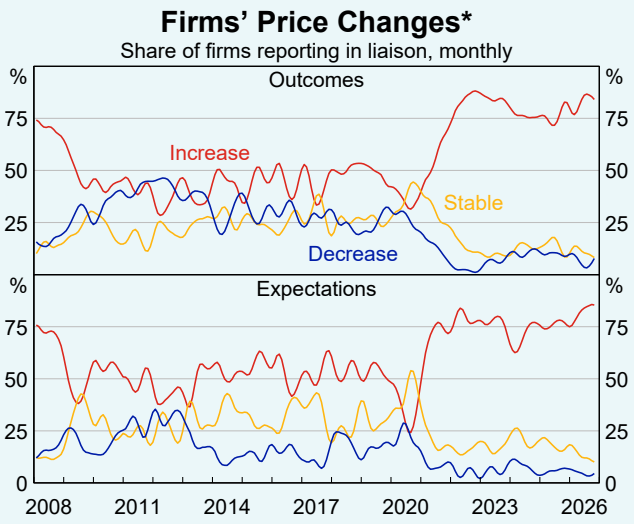
There is also ongoing upward pressure on other cost base components. Faster growth in IT costs, in part driven by global competition for memory chips, has been highlighted by many firms. Where firms are purchasing services from global and domestic IT vendors, these firms are passing through their own upstream costs into service and subscription prices. Other frequently cited components of operating cost increases include occupancy expenses, professional services, other labour-intensive third-party services, government

charges and regulatory compliance costs. Many contacts observe that these categories have experienced repeated increases over recent years. Firms are generally expecting cost growth to remain above longer-run averages over the year ahead.

Reflecting this cost environment, price increases – both business-to-business and consumer-facing – remain broadly based across firms in the liaison program (Graph C.2). Over three-quarters of firms reported increasing prices over the past year; this share had drifted a little lower through to 2025 but picked up again over the past year. In contrast to the experience pre-pandemic, very few firms reported that prices had been reduced or held steady over the past year.

Within this, the size of increases in consumer-facing prices has been mixed, in part reflecting different demand conditions. Price increases for household goods have been relatively modest in general, although an exception has been consumer electronics given global IT hardware cost developments. New detached dwelling price growth is increasingly uneven across states. Builders have generally been able to pass cost increases through to prices in markets where demand conditions are stronger and land supply relatively tight, whereas pass-through has been more limited in Victoria and New South Wales, with some contacts in those states reporting some discounting to support sales.

Graph C.2



* Over the past 12 months for outcomes and over the next 12 months for expectations; smoothed with a 13-month Henderson trend; data to October 2026 (partial).

Source: RBA.

Looking ahead, the share of firms expecting to increase prices is elevated and has increased further over recent months. Firms generally expect above-average increases in selling prices in the year ahead. Given firms generally see little prospect of moderating upstream cost pressures, in many cases contacts note that margins are under pressure and therefore they continue to look for ways to adjust their cost structures to manage this.

Household spending growth has been fairly steady overall, although discretionary spending is softer than earlier in the year.

Food retailers continue to report solid growth in consumption spending, broadly tracking trends in population and household income growth. In contrast, household goods retailers report that conditions are more challenging now than they were six months or so ago. Contacts attribute this to persistent household budget pressures, including from higher interest rates and the effects of the Middle East conflict on fuel prices. Consistent with this, some contacts have flagged an increase in consumers trading down and a greater focus on bargain hunting than was seen earlier in the year. Businesses in the tourism sector similarly report softer conditions than earlier in the year, although major sporting and cultural events continue to generate strong demand. Contacts generally expect that current softer conditions for consumer discretionary spending will continue into 2027.

Retailers with exposure to multiple states report better conditions in Queensland and Western Australia and relatively weaker conditions in Victoria. Higher fuel prices and general cost-of-living pressures are reported to be having a greater effect in remote areas and for lower-income households than in major urban centres and higher-income groups.

As has been the case for some time, community services organisations report elevated demand for their services, with a growing trend of more acute and complex needs. Over recent years there has been a larger cohort of people looking for support from these organisations to address housing stress and budget pressures, including dual-income households.

Housing construction activity is currently solid, but declining forward sales point to a weaker outlook …

Residential builders in most markets report solid activity levels at present, with earlier strength in sales supporting current work pipelines. This is expected to maintain momentum in construction activity into early 2027; contacts in Sydney and Melbourne report around six months of work compared with longer pipelines for those operating elsewhere. Softer activity is expected over the year ahead, given the decline in sales since earlier in 2026. Builders and developers variously attribute this to higher interest rates, tax reforms, and broader economic uncertainty. Several contacts have reported more buyers are adopting a 'wait-and-see' approach, reflected in longer decision-making timeframes and weaker sales, as well as some increase in contract cancellation rates over recent months.

Apartment builders continue to report affordability constraints and poor project feasibility as key factors weighing on development activity, with viable projects mainly concentrated in more premium segments of the market. Contacts note that demand fundamentals – strong population growth, low unemployment and ongoing housing shortages in many markets – are supportive, but there remains a significant gap between current market pricing and the price at which most apartments can be profitably built.

… while conditions for non-residential construction and other business investment are more resilient.

Firms' investment intentions have been resilient over recent months and remain a little above longer-run averages. Within this, a number of businesses have noted upward revisions to capex costs over recent months, in part due to increases in construction and technology costs, but this has not materially changed plans. Firms with above-average investment intentions are primarily spending on projects to expand their businesses and to slow growth in operating costs. Commonly cited project types include construction to expand sites and capacity, new machinery and equipment (including automation), and technology programs.

Consistent with this, firms in the non-residential construction sector report solid demand conditions; public and private sector spending is fairly strong at present, and contacts are anticipating a good pipeline of activity over the next year or so across many regions. Firms associated with data centre developments continue to report particularly buoyant conditions, although contacts have flagged some uncertainty from approval processes and constraints on construction resource availability, as well as fluidity in underlying client demand. Developers of renewable energy generation assets generally see the data centre pipeline as a positive for their sector, but note that these renewables projects are more difficult to progress than was the case a few years ago and also typically involve longer timelines than data centres. Challenges cited include approval delays, longer investment decision-making timetables and interdependencies with grid expansions. Revenue projections for some proposals could also be at risk if the relatively low and stable wholesale electricity prices seen over the past year were sustained.

Some contacts in the higher education sector note discretionary capex is being deferred or scaled back given reduced fee revenue from weaker international student enrolments; instead, capex is being increasingly concentrated in committed projects and essential maintenance. Current and expected spending across other categories of public investment remain solid, including in defence, transport infrastructure, water utilities and healthcare projects in many regions.

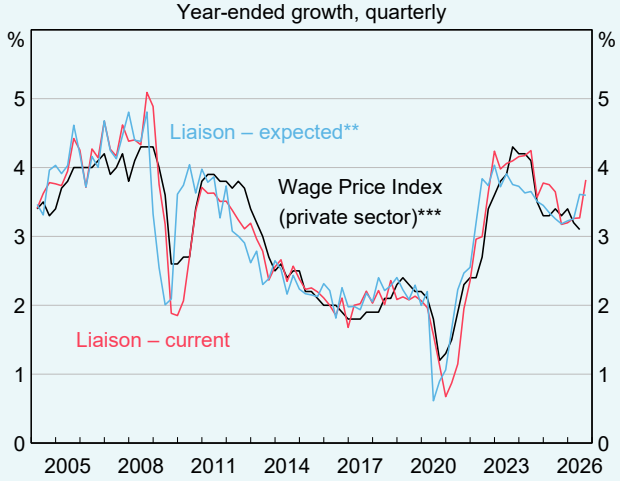
Firms report hiring intentions are around their long-run average and wages growth has strengthened.

Consistent with broadly steady demand conditions, firms' employment intentions are currently sitting close to their long-run average, having strengthened a little since earlier in the year (when some contacts noted uncertainty in hiring plans during the acute period of the Middle East conflict and oil price increases). Contacts expecting headcount growth report this as being supported by project work, expansion activity, ongoing growth in regulatory and compliance obligations, as well as underlying demand conditions. Firms' characterisations of labour market conditions have not changed materially over recent months. While recruiting and retaining staff is generally reported to be easier than a couple of years ago, some firms note competition for labour remains strong, particularly in sectors such as health care, mining, transport and construction trades, though with some variation across regions.

Labour costs remain a focus for firms, amid a recent pick-up in wages growth. Reported wages growth has lifted to be around 3¾ per cent over the September quarter, a marked move upwards from earlier in the year (Graph C.3). This is consistent with the flow-through since July of the Fair Work Commission's 4.75 per cent award wage increase decision. Firms also note general cost-of-living pressures and labour market tightness in some areas as factors influencing wage outcomes over recent months. Contacts expect these factors to also bear on outcomes over the year ahead and are generally not expecting wages growth to slow materially from the current pace.

Given this, many contacts have noted they are looking to drive efficiency gains from improved rostering, staff reallocations and technological improvements. For most firms, AI has not affected headcount and is not expected to do so over the next year. Many firms are hopeful that AI-driven productivity gains will support more efficient use of existing staff resources and may influence future hiring decisions. To date, though, firms have reported mixed productivity experiences; while some more routine tasks are being successfully automated, some contacts have noted the increased overhead associated with exploring and implementing AI as well as responding to AI-generated material from customers and other third parties.

Graph C.3
Private Sector Wages*
Year-ended growth, quarterly



* Liaison series are trimmed and rescaled by the mean of Wage Price Index (private sector).
** Data prior to 2019:Q3 is derived from Likert scores of firms' wage expectations.
*** Total hourly rates excluding bonuses.
Sources: ABS; RBA.

Chapter 3
Outlook

Summary

- **The outlook for inflation has been revised materially higher, especially in the earlier part of the forecast period; the forecasts assume that the cash rate follows the market path.** A number of upside risks flagged in the August *Statement* have since been incorporated into the central inflation forecast. Fuel and other commodity prices affected by the ongoing Middle East conflict are expected to contribute more to underlying and headline inflation than previously expected. Capacity constraints are also judged to have been somewhat greater throughout this year than we thought in August and inflation expectations have increased, adding to inflationary pressures. Underlying inflation is now expected to remain above 3 per cent until late 2027 and to reach 2½ per cent around mid-2028.
- **Headline inflation is expected to remain above 3 per cent until late 2027, around three quarters longer than in the August forecast.** Headline inflation is expected to peak at 4.5 per cent in the December 2026 quarter and reach the midpoint of the 2–3 per cent inflation target a bit later than was expected in August. The decline in inflation is expected to reflect conflict-related cost pressures easing and spare capacity emerging in the labour market and economy more broadly. Risks to the domestic inflation outlook are more balanced than they were in the August *Statement*, but still skewed to the upside. This reflects the incorporation in the central inflation forecast of some of the risks identified in August. However, inflation could be higher if global and domestic cost pressures are more persistent than assumed, or if inflation expectations rise further or exert greater influence on wage- and price-setting.
- **The outlook for growth in Australia's major trading partners has been revised higher, owing to a stronger outlook for AI-related activity and, more broadly, resilient demand.** Growth is still expected to moderate from its current strong pace over the next couple of years, as the boost from AI-related activity slows and growth in China continues to ease. The risks to the outlook are relatively balanced. AI-related activity could continue to be stronger than expected, while ongoing higher energy prices could weigh on growth by more than anticipated. The rise in global interest rates presents risks on both sides of the outlook: it may signal stronger demand and investment than currently expected, but may also result in tighter financial conditions than assumed.
- **The global inflation outlook has also been revised higher, reflecting renewed pressure from energy and other commodity prices, resilient demand and rapid growth in AI-related prices.** The oil price assumption underpinning the forecasts is much higher than in August, reflecting the re-escalation of tensions in the Middle East in recent months. Consensus forecasters expect headline inflation to remain above central bank targets into 2027 in many advanced economies as a result of higher energy costs. More broadly, increases in a range of commodity prices and strong AI-related demand are driving up input costs, which are expected to be passed through to inflation to some degree. The risks to global inflation are judged to remain skewed to the upside.

- **Australian GDP growth is expected to remain below estimates of potential growth over coming years.** Based on financial market pricing, the forecasts assume the cash rate will increase by around 35 basis points by mid-2027; this cash rate path is up to 50 basis points higher than was assumed in the August forecasts. Compared with August, the outlook for GDP growth over the year ahead has been revised higher, driven by a stronger outlook for data centre investment. From mid-2027, however, forecast growth has been revised lower because of the higher assumed cash rate path and a weaker outlook for the housing market. Higher-than-expected global energy prices is also expected to weigh a little on activity. Overall, the forecast level of GDP at end-2028 is broadly unchanged from the August forecasts. The risks to domestic growth appear to be broadly balanced. There are upside risks to global and domestic economic activity from AI-related demand, but economic activity could be weaker if the Middle East conflict and the decline in housing prices affect the economy by more than assumed in the central forecast.
- **Labour market conditions are expected to ease further, consistent with below-potential GDP growth.** The unemployment rate is forecast to increase to 5.1 per cent by end-2028. This is around ¼ percentage points higher than previously expected, largely reflecting the higher starting point for the unemployment rate and an expectation that more people will remain in or join the labour force.
- **Despite this, we assess that capacity constraints in the economy and labour market have been a little tighter than previously judged, contributing more to wage and inflationary pressures** (see Chapter 2: Economic Conditions). From this starting point, we judge that aggregate demand and potential supply in the economy are likely to reach balance next year (slightly later than previously thought), before spare capacity emerges. It is possible we have misjudged the supply capacity of the economy and labour market.

3.1 Key judgements in the forecast

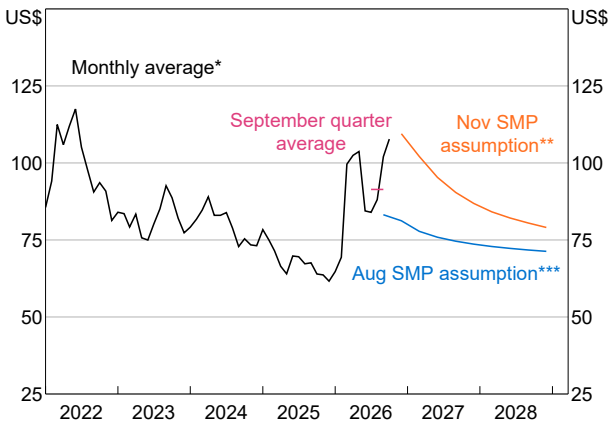
The central forecast incorporates many judgements, such as the choice of models used and whether to deviate from the models given the signal from recent data or information from liaison. These judgements are extensively considered and debated during the construction of the forecast. The three most important judgements for our current assessment of the economic outlook are discussed below.

The annual review of the staff's economic forecasts will be discussed at the December Board meeting (and the results will be published following the meeting). The review will assess what we have learned about the economy, how the judgements that underpin the forecasts have fared and how the risks around the outlook have evolved.

Key judgement #1 – Global oil and refined product prices decline gradually but remain above pre-conflict levels.

The assumption that global oil and related prices decline gradually but remain above levels prior to the Middle East conflict underpins the central forecasts (Graph 3.1). The assumed oil price in the December quarter is 35 per cent higher than assumed in August, following a re-escalation of the conflict in recent months. From this higher starting point, oil prices are assumed to be 11 per cent higher by end-2028 than assumed in August. This assumed decline is consistent with energy markets continuing to adjust to the conflict and/or progress towards resolution of the conflict, and is within the range of the latest Consensus forecasts. The spreads between prices for refined fuels and Brent crude oil, which have widened since the start of the conflict, are assumed to return to their historical averages by mid-2027 – around two quarters later than assumed in the August *Statement*. Oil and refined product prices could rise further or remain elevated for longer than assumed, which would drive up global and domestic inflation and could also weigh on activity (see Key risk #1 and Key risk #3).

Graph 3.1
Brent Oil Price
Per barrel



* Monthly average for October 2026 is average of daily prices to 28 October 2026.
** Based on Brent crude oil futures prices as at 28 October.
*** Based on Brent crude oil futures prices as at 5 August.
Sources: Bloomberg; LSEG; RBA.

Key judgement #2 – Restrictive financial conditions will contribute to the emergence of some spare capacity in the economy and the labour market, helping reduce inflationary pressures.

The forecasts are conditioned on a market path for the cash rate that increases by 35 basis points by mid-2027, before declining a little to stabilise at 4.8 per cent in 2028. This is up to 50 basis points higher than the path that underpinned the August forecasts. Conditioned on that path, the forecast is for a period of below-potential growth that is sufficient to generate some spare capacity in the economy and help return inflation to target. In other words, the assumed path for policy is judged to be restrictive.

One way to cross-check the plausibility of this judgement is to compare the market path with current estimates of the neutral cash rate derived from models and market economists. The assumed cash rate path lies above the top of the range of these estimates (see Chapter 1: Financial Conditions). These estimates are subject to considerable uncertainty, however, and it is common for them to be revised as more information becomes available. A key question is how to interpret

the recent material increase in longer-term real yields (see Box A: How Does an Increase in Longer-term Real Yields Affect Financial Conditions? and Box B: Developments in the Neutral Rate of Interest). To the extent that this reflects higher neutral policy rates globally (and for Australia), the assumed cash rate path would, by itself, be less restrictive and could weigh less on activity than projected. On the other hand, if the recent rise in global yields primarily reflects higher term premia, that would imply tighter financial conditions than assumed in the forecast, although this is less likely to materially change our assessment of restrictiveness, given the relatively short duration of household and business liabilities in Australia.

Key judgement #3 – Some of the current drivers of inflation are expected to persist and will take time to moderate.

Some of the upside risks to the inflation outlook identified in the August *Statement* have since materialised and are now incorporated in the central forecast for inflation. These factors have led to an upward revision to the inflation outlook over the next year or so and a delay in the expected timeframe for inflation to return to the target range. Higher fuel and other commodity prices from the Middle East conflict are expected to put sustained upward pressure on inflation over the coming year as these higher input costs are passed on to consumer prices to some degree over time. These cost pressures are expected to ease over the latter part of the forecast period, contributing to the decline in inflation. The change to the judgement around the degree of domestic capacity constraints implies more persistent inflationary pressures than in the August forecasts, all else equal (see Chapter 2: Economic Conditions). That is, we now assess that domestic capacity pressures have been contributing more to recent elevated inflation outcomes than we had previously judged, and from this higher starting point will contribute a bit more to inflation in the next year. The elevated level of inflation expectations is also projected to influence price- and wage-setting behaviour and boost inflation and wages growth a little more than previously expected.

We view the risks to the inflation outlook as still skewed to the upside. Alongside the potential for global cost pressures to be higher than assumed, it is also possible we have misjudged the extent of capacity pressures in the economy and the labour market, and the impact of the recent increase in inflation expectations in price- and wage-setting behaviour (see section 3.4 Key risks to the outlook).

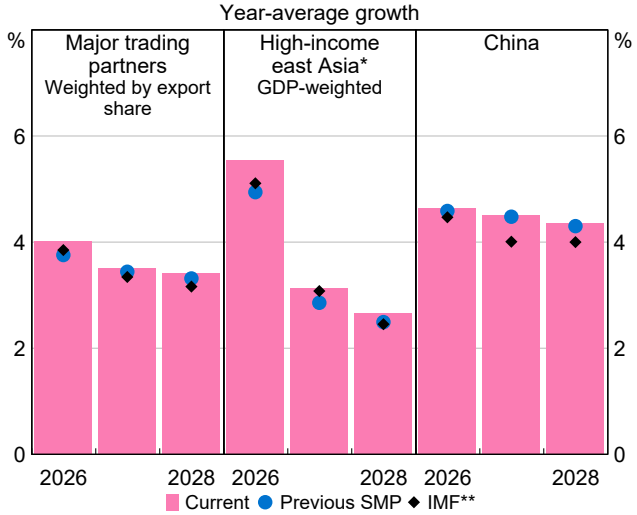
3.2 The global outlook

The outlook for growth in Australia's major trading partners (MTPs) has been revised higher over the next couple of years, but growth is expected to moderate from its current strong pace.

The MTP GDP growth forecast has been revised upwards to 4.0 per cent in 2026, before slowing to 3.5 per cent in 2027 and 3.4 per cent in 2028 as growth in global AI-related activity and China is expected to moderate (Graph 3.2). Growth has been above some estimates of potential and stronger than expected over the past year, reflecting strong AI-related activity and, in some economies, continued fiscal support. These have more than offset the headwinds from the Middle East conflict. MTP growth is expected to moderate to around potential over 2027 and 2028. Overall, we judge that the risks around this outlook for MTP growth are broadly balanced. The expansion in global AI-related investment and production may be more persistent than Consensus forecasters have factored in, but higher energy prices could also weigh on activity by more than currently assumed. The outlook for MTP growth as a whole is broadly in line with the International Monetary Fund's projections in the October 2026 *World Economic Outlook*.

The upward revision to MTP growth is concentrated in high-income east Asian economies, which are key exporters of AI-related goods. Strong demand for semiconductors and other AI-enabling technologies has supported activity in economies that are deeply integrated into regional technology supply chains, such as South Korea and Taiwan. While the outlook for growth in 2027 has been revised a little higher by external forecasters, it is still expected to moderate from the strong pace over the past year towards estimates of potential growth.

Graph 3.2
Major Trading Partner GDP Forecasts
Year-average growth



* High-income east Asia is a GDP-weighted average of South Korea, Taiwan, Hong Kong and Singapore.
** IMF forecasts from the October 2026 World Economic Outlook.
Sources: ABS; CEIC Data; Consensus Economics; IMF; LSEG; Oxford Economics Limited; RBA.

Growth in other advanced economies has also been more resilient than expected, prompting upward revisions to near-term forecasts. AI-related investment and stronger underlying momentum have supported activity in the United States, while defence spending and broader resilience across services and investment have contributed to growth in the euro area. Activity in the United Kingdom has also held up better than expected, supported by business investment. These tailwinds across advanced economies have so far offset some of the drag to activity from higher energy costs. However, external forecasters and central banks expect persistently elevated energy costs to reduce household purchasing power, raise firms' costs and increasingly weigh on consumption and investment. In some advanced economies, tighter financial conditions will also weigh on growth.

The outlook for GDP growth in China is broadly unchanged from the August *Statement*, though there have been some changes to the expected timing and composition of growth. GDP growth is forecast to be 4.6 per cent in 2026, before easing slightly to 4.5 per cent in 2027 and 4.4 per cent in 2028. The pick-up in growth in the September quarter is expected to continue in the near term, given the announcement of new policy support for infrastructure investment and signals from authorities that supporting economic activity will be elevated as a near-term policy priority. Infrastructure investment is now expected to recover from late 2026 as this support takes effect, while structural headwinds are expected to continue weighing on domestic demand more broadly. The timing and effectiveness of the policy support remain uncertain, particularly given high local government debt and a range of barriers to some local governments commencing infrastructure projects.

Longer-term government bond yields have risen across advanced economies, alongside resilient activity and persistent inflation. The increase appears to reflect a combination of higher expected near-term policy rates and higher longer-term real rates, reflecting a mix of higher term premia and potentially higher neutral rates. Market-based measures of long-term inflation expectations remain consistent with central bank targets. Strong investment and public demand may be placing upward pressure on real rates, and expectations of stronger future productivity growth – including from the adoption of AI – may also be contributing. Higher public and private debt issuance and uncertainty about inflation and fiscal trajectories may also be adding to the compensation investors require to hold longer-duration bonds (see Box A: How Does an Increase in Longer-term Real Yields Affect Financial Conditions? and Box B: Developments in the Neutral Rate of Interest).

The global inflation outlook has been revised higher, reflecting an increase in energy prices and continued resilience in global demand. Consensus forecasters expect headline inflation to remain above central bank targets into 2027 in many advanced economies. Services disinflation has stalled, while core goods inflation has picked up. The outlook for globally traded goods inflation has been revised higher, reflecting higher commodity prices and further strong increases in export prices for semiconductors and other AI-related goods across parts of Asia. AI-related price pressures have not broadened materially beyond electronics but could become more persistent or spread to other parts of global supply chains if strong demand continues to run ahead of the expansion in productive capacity (see Key risk #2). The further increase in energy prices since August could add to these upstream cost pressures, although the extent and timing of pass-through to consumer prices remains uncertain. Overall, we continue to judge that the risks to global inflation remain skewed to the upside.

3.3 Domestic outlook

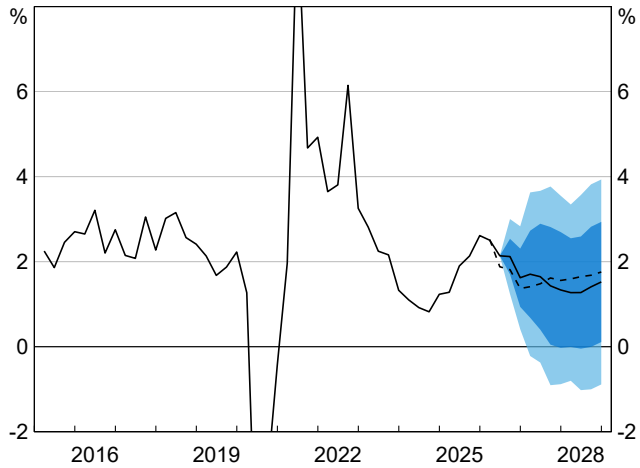
Australian GDP growth is expected to remain below our estimate of potential growth throughout the forecast period.

GDP growth has slowed since the end of 2025 and is expected to remain subdued over the next couple of years (Graph 3.3). The expected slowing in growth over 2026 reflects the effects of several headwinds weighing on private activity, including the reduction in household disposable incomes from higher inflation, weaker conditions in the established housing market, and the tightening in monetary policy, which more than offset very strong data centre-related investment. Growth is expected to remain below potential over the forecast period, reflecting an assumption that financial conditions remain restrictive (see Key judgement #2). Consistent with the latest state and federal budgets, public demand is expected to continue supporting growth over the forecast period.

The risks to activity appear to be broadly balanced. Stronger-than-expected global growth and further strength in AI and data centre-related activity pose upside risks to domestic growth (see Key risk #2). However, historically low consumer and business sentiment could be pointing to the risk that the combined effect on domestic activity of the Middle East conflict, the decline in housing prices and the tightening in monetary policy could be more than assumed (see Key risk #3).

The level of GDP at end-2028 is expected to be broadly unchanged from the August forecasts. Growth is projected to be slightly stronger than expected in the near term, reflecting a much stronger outlook for data centre-related investment compared with the August *Statement*. Weighing against that is the higher assumed market path for the cash rate, a weaker outlook for the housing market and higher oil prices. These pull growth in the latter part of the forecast period a little below that expected in the August *Statement*.

Graph 3.3
GDP Growth Forecast*
Year-ended



* Dashed line shows previous SMP forecast; confidence intervals reflect RBA forecast errors since 1993, with the 70 per cent interval shown in dark blue and the 90 per cent interval shown in light blue. Outliers during the COVID-19 pandemic have been truncated.

Sources: ABS; RBA.

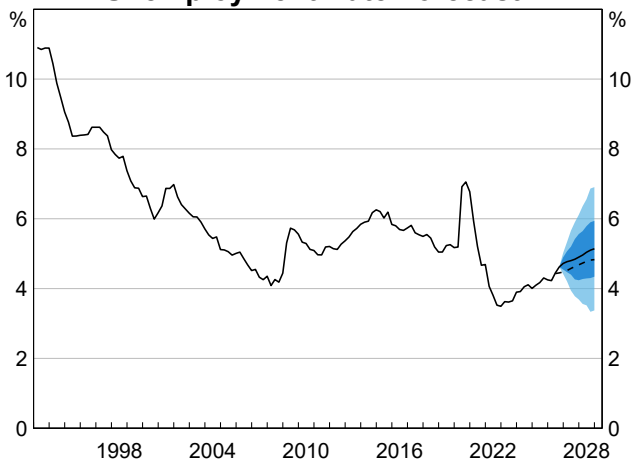
Business investment is expected to increase strongly and the outlook has been revised up significantly, largely driven by data centre-related investment. Business investment was stronger than expected in the June quarter and firms' surveyed expectations of future investment were again revised higher. External projections for the expected increase in Australia's data centre capacity through to 2030 have also continued to be revised up as the size of the development pipeline has increased. Our forecast for data centre investment is in line with recent baseline external projections, but below projections that assume Australia becomes a significant regional hub for data centres. There is considerable uncertainty around the extent of data centre investment over coming years. This will depend on a range of factors such as government policy, community expectations, future demand for AI services and grid capacity. We continue to expect that much of this additional investment will be imported (around 70 per cent), limiting the boost to GDP growth. However, data centre construction, as well as any potential spillovers to higher investment in energy and utilities infrastructure, will require domestically sourced labour and materials. At this stage, most of this investment pipeline is in New South Wales and Victoria where liaison information suggests capacity constraints in the construction sector are somewhat less binding.

At the same time, a higher assumed cash rate path, a more significant easing in the established housing market and higher global oil prices are expected to weigh more on activity than in the August forecasts. The forecasts are conditioned on a higher market path for interest rates relative to August. In addition, established housing prices have continued to fall more quickly than expected, with external forecasters now expecting a deeper downturn than assumed a few months ago. The outlook for oil prices is also much higher than assumed in August, which will weigh on real household incomes. Reflecting these factors, the outlook for household consumption and dwelling investment has been revised lower, as has the outlook for business investment unrelated to data centres.

The labour market is expected to continue easing over the forecast period, consistent with below-potential GDP growth.

The unemployment rate is forecast to increase to 5.1 per cent by the end of 2028, which is around ¼ percentage point higher than previously expected (Graph 3.4). The unemployment rate has risen by more than expected over recent months, and the upward revision to forecast relative to the August *Statement* largely reflects this higher starting point. Elevated cost-of-living pressures appear to have encouraged workers to enter or remain in the labour force to a greater extent in recent months than was expected at the time of the August *Statement*. These pressures are expected to continue to support participation for some time. The participation rate is expected to decline very modestly by the end of 2028 as easing cyclical pressures are expected to more than offset the longer-run upward trend in female participation. A slightly weaker outlook for demand later in the forecast period is also contributing a little to the upward revision to the unemployment rate profile by late 2028.

Graph 3.4
Unemployment Rate Forecast*



* Dashed line shows previous SMP forecast; confidence intervals reflect RBA forecast errors since 1993, with the 70 per cent interval shown in dark blue and the 90 per cent interval shown in light blue.
Sources: ABS; RBA.

As in previous forecasts, the employment-to-population ratio is expected to decline through to late 2028. Employment growth is expected to remain broadly stable over the next year, in line with the leading indicators of labour demand. From mid-2027, employment growth is expected to be a little weaker than in the August *Statement*, reflecting the weaker outlook for GDP growth later in the forecast period. The forecast employment-to-population ratio is similar to the August *Statement* in the near term, before declining more quickly to reach a lower level by the end of the forecast period.

The economy is expected to move into balance in 2027, with spare capacity then emerging in the economy over the rest of the forecast period.

Below-potential output growth and an easing in labour market conditions are expected to see the economy move from a position of excess demand to around balance in 2027, before some spare capacity emerges. The timing of the return to balance is slightly later than in the August *Statement*, as a result of the upgrade to near-term GDP growth.

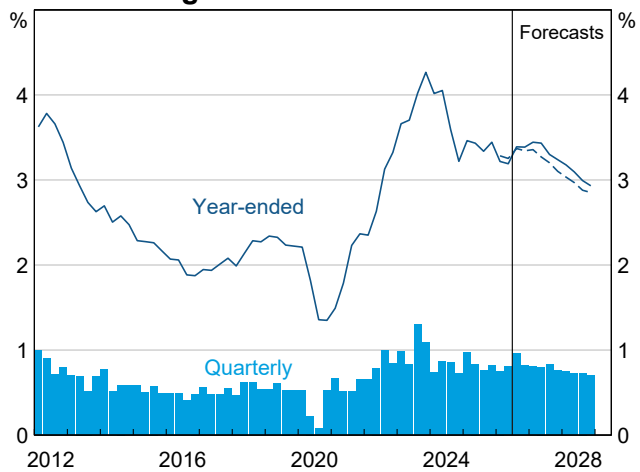
However, there is considerable uncertainty around the assessment of when the economy will return to balance and the extent of spare capacity that emerges. The impact of conflict-related costs on inflation over the period ahead will also make it more difficult to assess the degree of underlying capacity pressures in the domestic economy. Our assumption for potential output growth over the next couple of years assumes productivity growth will pick up gradually (see Key risk #4). However, with the level of labour productivity remaining around the same rate as prior to the pandemic – implying near-zero productivity growth on average over that period – continued weak productivity outcomes may be constraining the ability of firms to grow their supply capacity without generating inflationary pressure.

Wages growth is expected to pick up a little in the near term, then moderate gradually from 2027 as labour market conditions ease.

The forecast for year-ended wages growth has been revised a little higher across the forecast period. In the near term, nominal wages growth is expected to be supported by the effect of higher-than-expected capacity pressures in the first half of the year as well as the Fair Work Commission's award wage decision (which had already been incorporated in the August forecasts). The influence of both higher-than-expected inflation outcomes and inflation expectations on wage negotiations is expected to add further upward pressure on wages growth relative to the August forecast. Some large wage increases in enterprise bargaining agreements are expected to support wages growth in the near term, although the timing of pay increases for these agreements may contribute to volatility in quarterly outcomes, particularly for the public sector.

Wages growth expectations from firms in the RBA's liaison program are elevated and suggest little easing over the year ahead (see Box C: Insights from Liaison). This is consistent with the central forecast for wages growth. Growth is expected to moderate from mid-2027 onwards, reflecting easing labour market conditions and lower inflation outcomes. Wages growth is expected to have eased to 2.9 per cent in year-ended terms by end-2028 (Graph 3.5).

Graph 3.5
Wage Price Index Growth*



* Dashed line shows previous SMP forecast; seasonally adjusted.
Sources: ABS; RBA.

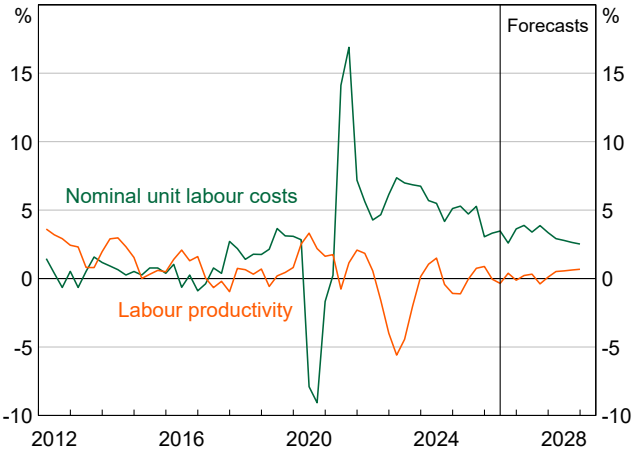
Unit labour cost growth is forecast to be elevated in the near term, before easing over the second half of the forecast period.

Year-ended growth in unit labour costs (ULCs) is expected to increase in coming quarters, reflecting weak productivity growth and higher wages growth. Year-ended growth in ULCs is then expected to moderate from late 2027 onwards, alongside slowing nominal wages growth and the pick-up in productivity growth to its assumed medium-term trend growth rate of 0.7 per cent per year (Graph 3.6). Nominal ULCs are the measure of labour costs most relevant for firms' cost of production and so for inflation outcomes. Year-ended ULCs growth is expected to remain above 2.5 per cent – the rate that is consistent with inflation being sustainably at target – until late in the forecast period.

Graph 3.6

Labour Cost and Productivity Growth

Non-farm, seasonally adjusted, year-ended



Sources: ABS; RBA.

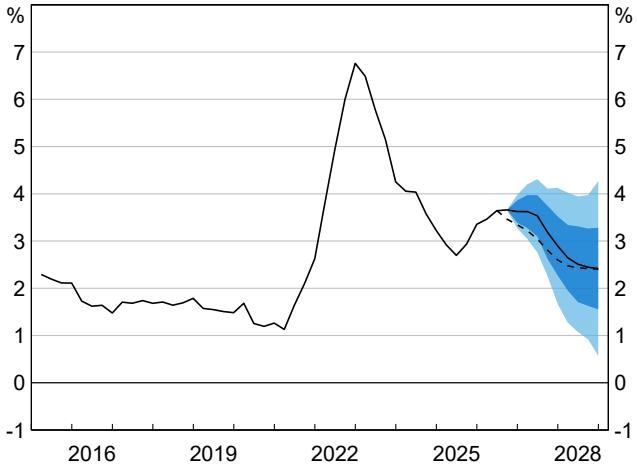
The forecast for underlying inflation has been revised higher over the next year, mainly owing to higher conflict-related cost pressures and higher-than-expected domestic capacity pressures.

Trimmed mean inflation is expected to remain above 3 per cent until the end of 2027, easing gradually to reach 2½ per cent around mid-2028 (Graph 3.7). Year-ended underlying inflation is expected to remain elevated at a little above 3½ per cent until mid-2027, reflecting existing capacity pressures in the economy and the pass-through of higher conflict-related costs to consumer prices. Elevated inflation expectations are also contributing to underlying inflation over the coming year or so. From mid-2027 onwards, inflation is expected to ease due to the emergence of spare capacity in the economy and labour market and as conflict-related cost effects begin to unwind.

Graph 3.7

Trimmed Mean Inflation Forecast*

Year-ended



* Dashed line shows previous SMP forecast; confidence intervals reflect RBA forecast errors since 1993, with the 70 per cent interval shown in dark blue and the 90 per cent interval shown in light blue.

Sources: ABS; RBA.

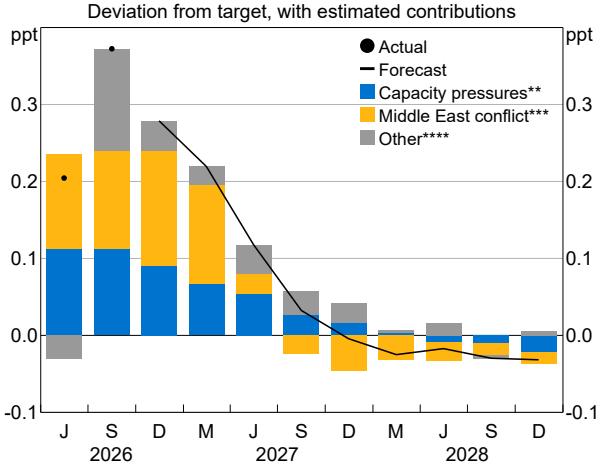
Cost pressures related to the Middle East conflict are expected to place more upward pressure on underlying inflation over the year ahead than previously assumed. A possible re-escalation in the conflict had been flagged as an upside risk to inflation in the August *Statement*. Since then, oil and fuel prices have increased by much more than had been assumed and are now assumed to remain at a higher level over the forecast period. We expect higher global energy prices will contribute to higher domestic inflationary pressures in late 2026 and early 2027, even as domestic activity slows and the labour market eases (Graph 3.8). The judgement around the degree of pass-through from global energy prices to domestic prices is broadly similar to what had been assumed in August. It is consistent with information from liaison and the Business Outlook Scenario Survey (BOSS) in September, where firms reported plans to continue raising prices in response to past cost increases arising partially from the conflict. From mid-2027 onwards, we expect cost effects to unwind in net terms, albeit to a lesser extent than assumed in the August *Statement* as oil prices are now assumed to remain at a higher level than previously expected and refined margins are assumed to remain elevated for longer (see Key judgement #1). The balance of risks to conflict-related inflationary pressures remains skewed to the upside, particularly as crude oil and refined fuel prices could remain elevated or rise further (see Key risk #1).

Relative to the August forecasts, domestic capacity pressures are also expected to exert a bit more upward pressure on inflation over the year ahead. We now judge that stronger-than-expected domestic capacity pressures explain more of the recent unexpected strength in underlying inflation (see Chapter 2: Economic Conditions). Those higher capacity pressures are also expected to contribute a little more to inflation over the year ahead. This upward pressure is expected to ease gradually over the forecast period, as spare capacity emerges in the economy and the labour market.

Graph 3.8

Quarterly Trimmed Mean Inflation Forecast*

Deviation from target, with estimated contributions



* Deviation from a quarterly rate of underlying inflation that is consistent with the midpoint of the target range.

** Includes contributions from the unemployment gap, output gap and nominal unit labour costs in a suite of trimmed mean inflation models.

*** Includes indirect cost effects from the conflict in the Middle East (excluding fuel) and short-term inflation expectations.

**** Includes contributions from some imported goods, automotive fuel and factors not otherwise specified.

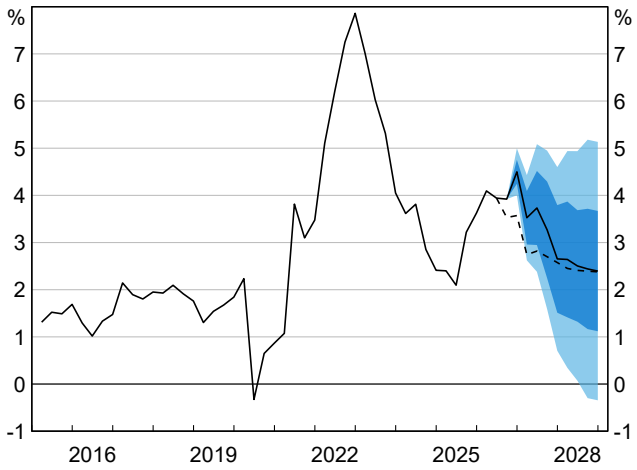
Sources: ABS; RBA.

Elevated inflation expectations are expected to contribute to inflationary pressure over the forecast period, supporting the pass-through of firms' costs to consumer prices. Several measures of short- and medium-term inflation expectations have increased alongside the recent increases in fuel prices, and some measures of longer-term expectations have also drifted higher (see Chapter 2: Economic Conditions). We judge that elevated expectations will contribute to higher realised inflation by supporting expected cost growth, making firms more willing to pass these higher costs through to prices, and placing upward pressure on wages growth. If the conflict in the Middle East is more protracted than assumed in our baseline forecasts, there is a risk that inflation expectations may increase further (see Key risk #1).

Headline inflation has been revised higher in the near term due to stronger growth in fuel prices and higher underlying inflation.

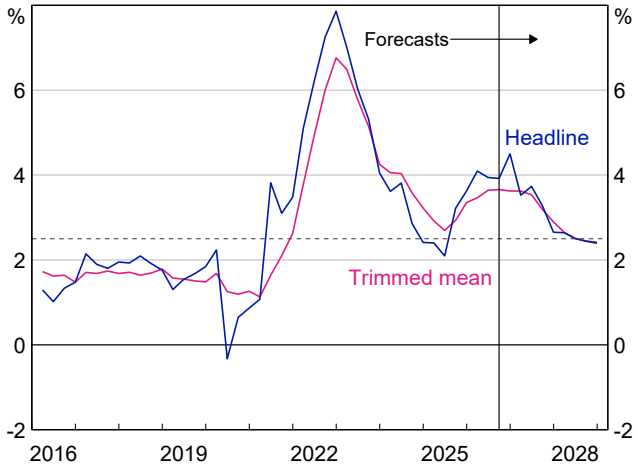
Headline inflation is expected to remain above 3 per cent until late 2027, which is around three quarters longer than in the August forecast, and reach the midpoint of the 2–3 per cent inflation target range a bit later than expected in August (Graph 3.9). Headline inflation is expected to peak at 4.5 per cent in the December quarter this year due to higher-than-expected fuel prices. The assumed decline in global oil prices is expected to put downward pressure on headline inflation from early 2027. Over the remainder of the forecast period, headline inflation has been revised higher relative to our August forecasts, reflecting higher underlying inflation (Graph 3.10). Headline inflation is expected to reach the midpoint of the target in mid-2028 as capacity pressures and conflict-related costs ease.

Graph 3.9
Headline Inflation Forecast*
Year-ended



* Dashed line shows previous SMP forecast; confidence intervals reflect RBA forecast errors since 1993, with the 70 per cent interval shown in dark blue and the 90 per cent interval shown in light blue.
Sources: ABS; RBA.

Graph 3.10
Inflation*
Year-ended



* Dashed line is midpoint of 2–3 per cent target range.
Sources: ABS; RBA.

3.4 Key risks to the outlook

The staff assess that the risks to the domestic inflation outlook are skewed to the upside, despite becoming more balanced since the August *Statement* as some of the risks identified then have been incorporated into the central forecast. In August, we identified three main sources of upside risk to the global and domestic inflation outlook: a re-escalation of the Middle East conflict; domestic capacity pressures being greater than assumed; and the global AI boom generating more of an inflationary impetus than assumed. Since then, the risk of a re-escalation of the Middle East conflict has crystallised and staff have re-evaluated the extent of domestic capacity constraints; both of which have led to upward revisions to the central inflation forecast over the next year. However, there is still uncertainty around the outlook for global energy prices, the role of inflation expectations in price and wage dynamics as well as the impact on inflation from AI activity.

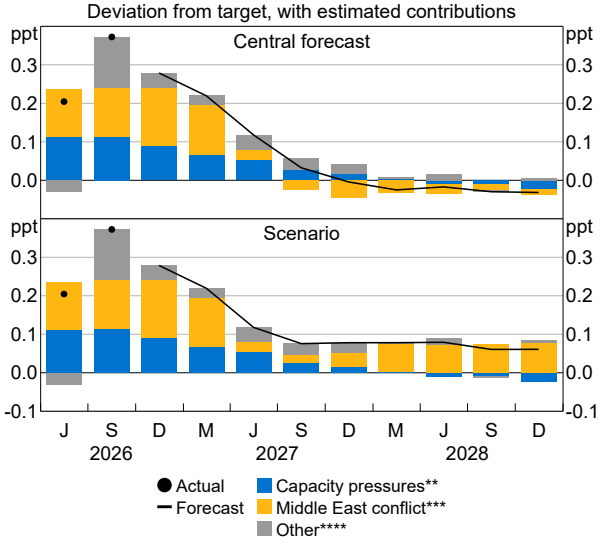
The staff also identified in August that there were upside risks to global and domestic economic activity from AI-related demand, but that domestic economic activity could be weaker if the Middle East conflict and the decline in housing prices affected the economy by more than assumed in the central forecast. These remain key risks to the outlook.

Key risk #1 – High inflation could be more persistent if energy prices remain elevated, or if inflation expectations increase or start to have a greater bearing on wage- and price-setting.

We have modelled a scenario where crude oil remains around US$100 per barrel and refined product prices remain at elevated levels over the forecast period. Many external forecasters are revising higher their outlook for crude oil and refined product prices, on concerns that some of the key margins of adjustment in global energy markets that have helped to cushion the impact of the disruption to oil supply and global activity are reaching their limits (see Chapter 2: Economic Conditions and Key judgement #1).

Persistently higher global oil prices would leave domestic inflation higher for a longer period than in the central forecast. Higher oil prices would directly increase fuel prices and firms' input costs, with the latter gradually passed through to consumer prices as firms adjust to persistently higher costs. By contrast, the central forecast assumes a decline in oil prices, which starts to ease cost pressures related to the Middle East conflict from mid-2027, contributing to lower inflation over time (Graph 3.11). Higher inflation also raises inflation expectations in the scenario, reinforcing inflationary pressures over the forecast period. Assuming that the cash rate and exchange rate follow the same path that underpins the central forecasts, underlying inflation would be around 2¾ per cent by end-2028 rather than being around the 2½ per cent.

Graph 3.11
Quarterly Trimmed Mean Inflation Forecast*
Deviation from target, with estimated contributions



* Deviation from a quarterly rate of underlying inflation that is consistent with the midpoint of the target range.
** Includes contributions from the unemployment gap, output gap and nominal unit labour costs in a suite of trimmed mean inflation models.
*** Includes indirect cost effects from the conflict in the Middle East (excluding fuel) and short-term inflation expectations.
**** Includes contributions from some imported goods, automotive fuel and factors not otherwise specified.
Sources: ABS; RBA.

It is possible that inflation expectations could rise even further or that inflation expectations provide greater impetus to wages growth and inflation through second-round effects. The central forecasts and scenario assume that the increase in households' and firms' inflation expectations do exert some upward pressure on inflation and wages growth. However, given households and firms are paying particularly close attention to inflation, it is possible that inflation expectations will influence price- and wage-setting decisions by more than assumed. This heightened attentiveness to inflation could also make expectations more persistent and more responsive to realised inflation. With headline inflation forecast to rise further in the near term, this increases the risk that inflation expectations remain higher for longer than assumed in our central forecast.

Key risk #2 – The global AI demand boom may continue to drive up global growth and inflation.

MTP growth may not moderate as expected over the next few years if AI-demand growth continues at the same pace. It is possible that growth forecasts could continue to be upwardly revised by Consensus forecasters if the current upswing in AI-related investment (and spillovers associated with the boom) is more persistent than currently assumed. The rise in interest rates across the yield curve in many advanced economies may reflect higher neutral rates – that is, expectations that demand will prove more resilient and inflation more persistent than currently assumed. Higher longer-term real rates may partly reflect expectations of stronger future productivity growth, including from the adoption of AI. Further investment in anticipation of higher productivity could also support demand and add to capacity pressures over the next few years, while most of the productivity gains are likely to manifest beyond the next two years (at least in Australia).

The ramp-up of investment in data centres may also contribute to capacity and pricing pressures domestically, particularly by drawing on resources in the construction industry. These price pressures could be stronger than currently expected as the forecast pipeline of investment is worked through, or if investment proves stronger than expected.

Key risk #3 – Domestic economic activity could be weaker than expected.

It is possible that the headwinds affecting households and businesses over the next year could have a larger adverse effect than assumed. The central forecasts assume that higher oil prices, higher interest rates and lower housing prices all weigh on domestic economic activity broadly in line with average historical relationships. Timely indicators of spending remain consistent with this assumption, with no evidence of a material slowing in consumption growth in recent months. However, the very weak levels of consumer and business sentiment could be pointing to a more pronounced slowing in household and business spending growth than assumed.

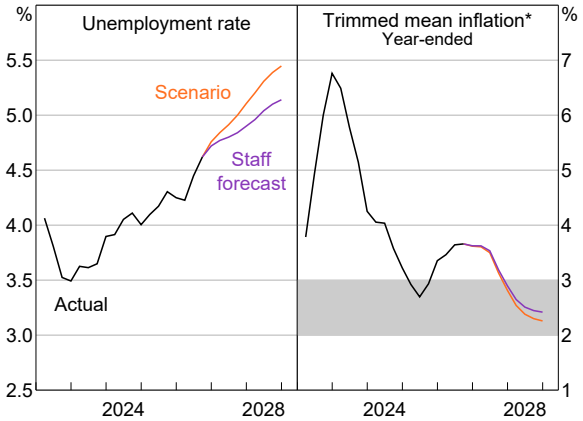
We have calibrated a downside domestic activity scenario where there is a larger response in household and business spending to these headwinds. There is a range of estimates for the effects of these headwinds in the literature, highlighting the uncertainty around their impact on economic activity. Drawing on this evidence, the scenario uses larger responses than assumed in the central forecast, thereby identifying a plausible downside outlook for domestic activity. In the scenario, firms feel forced to pass on the conflict-related costs to prices as in the central forecast; but households respond more cautiously to the resultant pressures on real income and wealth, reducing discretionary consumption by more than assumed in the central forecast. Such an effect on spending might be compounded by a tightening in borrowing constraints and incentives for housing investors. The scenario assumes firms respond to weaker demand and margin pressure with a sharper pullback on (non-data centre) investment and hiring. Overall, the level of GDP is around 1.0 per cent lower than the central forecasts by end-2028.

The larger pullback in household and business spending results in weaker activity and employment growth, but only modestly lower inflation than in the central forecast, assuming interest rates and the exchange rate follow the same path as the central forecast. The greater caution exhibited by households pushes the gross household saving ratio up gradually to a peak of around 17 per cent, where it remains over the remainder of the forecast period. The greater reduction

in hiring pushes the unemployment rate 0.3 percentage points higher by end-2028, creating more spare capacity in the domestic economy than in the central forecast (Graph 3.12). The additional spare capacity in the economy and the labour market reduces inflationary pressures somewhat, but the assumption of cost pass-through by firms limits this effect. Overall, trimmed mean inflation reaches 2½ per cent only one quarter earlier than in the central forecast.

Graph 3.12

Weaker Domestic Economic Activity – Labour Market and Inflation Outcomes



* Shaded area shows 2–3 per cent inflation target range.

Sources: ABS; RBA.

Key risk #4 – There remains considerable uncertainty about the degree of capacity pressures in the domestic economy and labour market.

Despite the recent reassessment, it is possible that we are still understating the extent of capacity pressures. While we assess that capacity constraints in the economy and labour market have been tighter than previously judged, model-based estimates of the unemployment rate that is consistent with low and stable inflation continue to point to greater tightness in labour market conditions than our central assessment. In addition, if productivity growth were to remain subdued over the forecast period, rather than pick up modestly as assumed, it may suggest that the economy's supply capacity would be lower than currently expected. The implications for inflation would depend on how households and businesses adjust their spending and expectations.

Conversely, capacity pressures may be weaker than expected. The broader suite of full employment indicators points to somewhat less labour market tightness than our central assessment. It is also possible that more of the recent strength in wages growth and inflation reflects factors other than excess demand, such as conflict-related cost effects or higher inflation expectations. In these cases, wages growth and inflation may moderate more quickly than in the central forecast. Productivity growth could also recover more quickly than assumed, including if the anticipated benefits of AI adoption and other technological developments are realised sooner.

There is also a risk that the unemployment rate increases by more than expected if labour supply remains stronger than assumed. There is a risk that elevated cost-of-living pressures could support labour force participation for longer, or to a greater extent, than assumed. If so, stronger labour supply could result in a higher unemployment rate than forecast, even if labour demand evolves broadly as expected.

3.5 Detailed forecast information

Table 3.1 provides additional detail on forecasts of key macroeconomic variables. The forecast table from current and previous *Statements* can be viewed, and data from these tables downloaded, via the Statement on Monetary Policy – Forecast Archive.

Table 3.1: Detailed Forecast Table[(a)]
Percentage change through the four quarters to quarter shown, unless otherwise specified[(b)]

	Jun 2026	Dec 2026	Jun 2027	Dec 2027	Jun 2028	Dec 2028
Activity						
Gross domestic product	2.1	1.6	1.6	1.3	1.3	1.5
Household consumption	1.8	1.4	1.4	1.8	1.7	1.6
Dwelling investment	5.8	5.1	1.3	−2.8	−3.5	−1.8
Business investment	10.5	12.0	7.8	2.2	0.2	−0.3
Public demand	2.1	2.1	3.8	3.0	2.7	2.3
Gross national expenditure	2.9	2.6	2.7	2.0	1.6	1.6
Major trading partner (export-weighted) GDP	4.1	3.8	3.5	3.6	3.4	3.3
Trade						
Imports	6.7	4.6	4.0	3.7	2.7	2.0
Exports	2.9	−0.3	0.3	0.9	1.3	1.8
Terms of trade	−0.5	−2.4	−4.9	−2.4	0.9	0.9
Labour market						
Employment	1.1	1.4	1.2	1.1	1.0	1.1
Unemployment rate (quarterly, %)	4.4	4.7	4.8	4.9	5.0	5.1
Hours-based underutilisation rate (quarterly, %)	5.5	5.8	5.9	6.0	6.2	6.4
Income						
Wage Price Index	3.2	3.4	3.4	3.2	3.1	2.9
Nominal average earnings per hour (non-farm)	3.2	3.5	3.7	3.5	3.4	3.2
Real household disposable income	2.3	1.0	1.6	1.5	1.3	1.3
Inflation						
Consumer Price Index	3.9	4.5	3.7	2.7	2.5	2.4
Trimmed mean inflation	3.6	3.6	3.5	2.9	2.5	2.4
Assumptions						
Cash rate (%)[(c)]	4.3	4.7	4.9	4.8	4.8	4.8
Trade-weighted index (index)[(d)]	66.1	65.2	65.3	65.3	65.3	65.3
Brent crude oil price (US$/bbl)[(e)]	94.9	109.5	95.3	86.9	82.1	79.1
Estimated resident population[(f)]	1.5	1.5	1.3	1.2	1.2	1.2
Memo items						
Labour productivity[(g)]	−0.4	−0.1	0.3	0.1	0.6	0.7
Household savings rate (%)[(h)]	6.5	6.6	6.7	6.3	6.3	6.0
Real Wage Price Index[(i)]	−0.8	−1.0	−0.3	0.6	0.6	0.5
Real average earnings per hour (non-farm)[(i)]	−0.8	−0.9	0.0	0.8	0.8	0.8

(a) Forecasts finalised on 28 October.

(b) Forecasts are rounded to the first decimal point. Shading indicates historical data.

(c) The cash rate is assumed to move in line with expectations derived from financial market pricing. Prior to the May 2024 *Statement*, the cash rate assumption also reflected information derived from surveys of professional economists. For more information, see A Change to the Cash Rate Assumption Method for the Forecasts.

(d) The daily exchange rate (TWI) is assumed to be unchanged at its current level going forward.

(e) For the current quarter, Brent crude oil prices are based on observed spot prices to date and market pricing for the remainder of the quarter. Thereafter, Brent crude oil prices are guided by market pricing.

(f) The population assumption draws on a range of sources, including partial indicators from the Australian Bureau of Statistics, migration policies, and estimates made by the Australian Government.

(g) GDP per hour worked (non-farm).

(h) Household savings ratio refers to the ratio of household saving (disposable income minus consumption) to household disposable income, net of depreciation.

(i) Real Wage Price Index and non-farm average earnings per hour worked are both deflated by Consumer Price Index.

Sources: ABS; Bloomberg; CEIC Data; Consensus Economics; LSEG; Oxford Economics Limited; RBA.

12 November 2026

MORNING REPORT

Today's economic developments and market movements.

Key themes

Renewed optimism around AI drove US equities higher overnight, with positive developments around CoreWeave and Anthropic adding to enthusiasm around the sector and helping the S&P 500 and NASDAQ rally.

US cash bond markets were closed for Veterans Day, though futures continued to point to higher Treasury yields following this week's hotter-than-expected inflation data, which has all but cemented a December FOMC hike, with another two increases priced over 2027.

The US dollar received a solid bid alongside renewed strength in AI and tech stocks, lifting the DXY 0.7% to its highest since April 2025, while the Aussie slipped to around USD0.6850.

Australian dwelling finance approvals surprised materially to the downside in Q3, with the value of approvals plunging a record 15.5% as investor lending values dropped by nearly a third.

Data snapshot

FX Last 24 hrs	Current	Change
TWI	63.8	-0.5%
AUD/USD	0.6850	-0.2%
AUD/JPY	109.50	0.5%
AUD/GBP	0.5159	0.3%
AUD/NZD	1.2308	0.5%
AUD/EUR	0.6176	0.4%
AUD/CNH	4.5719	-0.3%
AUD/SGD	0.8801	0.0%
AUD/HKD	5.3741	-0.2%
AUD/CAD	0.9760	0.2%
EUR/USD	1.1093	-0.6%
USD/JPY	159.85	0.7%
USD Index	102.90	0.7%

AUS Interest Rate Swaps	Last	Change
30 day BBSY	4.86	0.01
90 day BBSY	4.99	0.01
180 day BBSY	5.35	0.03
1 year swap	4.95	0.01
2 year swap	4.82	0.02
3 year swap	4.76	0.02
4 year swap	4.74	0.01
5 year swap	4.76	0.01
6 year swap	4.80	0.01
7 year swap	4.84	0.01
8 year swap	4.88	0.01
9 year swap	4.93	0.01
10 year swap	4.96	0.00

Equities	Close	Change
S&P/ASX 200	9,153	0.3%
S&P 500	7,626	1.4%
Japan Nikkei	61,249	1.3%
Hang Seng	24,316	-1.0%
Euro Stoxx 50	6,393	1.0%
UK FTSE100	10,835	0.8%
VIX Index	17.4	-10.6%

Government Bond Yields	Close	Change
Australia		
3 year bond	4.73	0.07
10 year bond	5.04	0.06
United States		
3-month T Bill	4.11	-0.01
2 year bond	4.74	0.00
10 year bond	4.99	0.00
Other (10 year yields)		
Germany	3.32	0.00
Japan	2.80	0.11
UK	5.22	0.00

Commodities	Current	Change
CRB Index	386.48	0.7%
Gold	3985.69	-1.2%
Copper	13817	1.0%
Oil (WTI futures)	86.31	0.3%
Coal (coking)	253.50	-0.2%
Coal (thermal)	143.40	3.3%
Iron Ore	91.25	-0.4%
ACCU	36.13	-4.3%

Sydney Futures Exchange	Current	Change
10 yr bond	5.05	0.00
3 yr bond	4.73	0.01
3 mth bill rate	4.77	0.00
SPI 200	9,158	-0.4%

Data as at 7:30am AEDT. Change is from the previous trading day (excluding the SFE, which is the change during the night session). Source: Bloomberg.

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Financial Markets

- Share markets rallied across much of the globe. In the US, reports of an upgraded outlook for CoreWeave, an oversubscribed IPO for Anthropic and a stabilisation in Nvidia supported renewed optimism around AI which buoyed tech stocks, seeing the S&P 500 (+1.4%) and Nasdaq (+1.7%) both rally, though the smaller gain for the Dow Jones (+0.5%) shows the rally was more narrowly based.
- Across the pond, the Euro Stoxx 50 continued to build on recent momentum with another solid gain (+1.0%), while London's FTSE 100 bounced back from a modest decline yesterday (+0.8%). Stocks were up across most of Asia, including Tokyo (+1.3%), Shanghai (+0.4%) and Seoul (+2.6%), with only the Hang Seng (–1.0%) bucking the wider trend. The ASX 200 rose 0.3% yesterday, but weaker trading in futures overnight points to a mixed open this morning.
- Cash trading in bond markets were closed in the US for Veterans Day, but trading in futures points to a continued rise in yields following hotter-than-expected inflation data received earlier in the week, which all but cemented a December FOMC rate hike. Beyond December, markets are also pricing in another two rate hikes over the course of 2027.
- Yields were little changed elsewhere, with the 10Y Bund and Gilt steady on the day. The 10Y JGB meanwhile continued to sell-off, with yields jumping 10bps to 2.80% having effectively unwound the rally over late last week. ACGBs were also weaker during local trading, seeing yields rise 7bps on the 3Y and 6bps on the 10Y, following the sharp rise in global yields the day prior post US CPI. Swaps markets point to no hikes nor cuts from the RBA through to end-2027 at present.
- The USD received a solid bid overnight, buoyed by sharp inflows into AI and tech stocks that improved risk sentiment. The DXY finished 0.7% higher at around 102.9, the strongest since April 2025. That move has pushed the Euro down 0.6% back to a USD1.10 handle, the weakest since May 2025, while the Yen slipped 0.7% to JPY159.9, the weakest since the before the early-September rally. While moves in the AUD was comparatively small overnight, slipping 0.2% to around the USD0.6850 mark, that move builds on recent downward momentum and has the currency delicately positioned near 2026's lows.
- Oil prices rose slightly overnight, stabilising somewhat after recent declines amid ongoing uncertainty around the future of the US-Iran War, as President Trump downplays the possibility of further strikes on Iran all while negotiations show little progress. Brent rose 1.0% to US$92.4/bbl. The rebound in risk sentiment buoyed metals, with LME copper up 1.0% to US$13,817/mt while LME aluminium jumped 1.9% to US$3,068/mt. Gold prices meanwhile dipped 1.2%, falling back below the US$4,000/oz mark, building on recent momentum post US CPI which saw real yields jump higher

Today's key data and events

Time	Event	Exp	Prev
8:45	NZ Card Spending Oct	-	-0.5%
8:45	NZ Net Migration Sep	-	1530k
18:00	GB GDP Q3 Prel.	0.7%	0.5%
18:00	GB Trade Balance Sep	-£2100b	-£920b
0:30	US Initial Jobless Claims 7/11/2026	195k	189k
2:00	US Existing Home Sales Oct	-3.5%	1.5%

Times are AEDT. All data forecasts are m/m or q/q and seasonally adjusted unless otherwise specified. Forecasts for Australian data are our forecasts and for other countries they are consensus forecasts.

International Data

There was no major data out yesterday.

Domestic Data

In Australia, the value of **dwelling finance approvals** surprised materially to the downside in Q3, the 15.5% decline marking the largest quarterly decline on records going back to 1991. The decline looks to be mostly volume-driven, with the number of loans falling sharply compared to the average size of loans. Across segments, investor lending values dropped by nearly a third (see here).

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LABOUR MARKET CHARTPACK

4 Nov 2026

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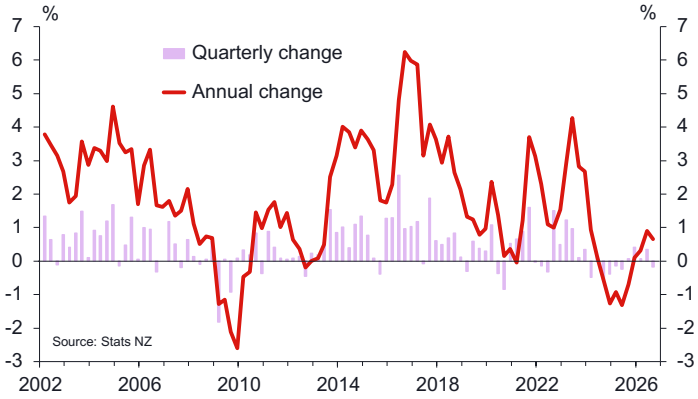
Key points – September quarter 2026

- The September quarter surveys pointed to ongoing softness in labour market conditions. The unemployment rate rose from 5.6% to 5.7%, continuing an almost five-year run of increases. The unemployment rate is now at its highest level since September 2015.
- There were mixed messages in terms of jobs growth: the Household Labour Force Survey reported a 0.1% fall in employment, while the employer-focused Quarterly Employment Survey suggested a modest rise. The Monthly Employment Indicator had also pointed to a small rise in jobs.
- The fall in HLFS employment was accompanied by a fall in the participation rate. These co-movements essentially reversed the surprisingly large increases that we saw in the June quarter, which we had suggested at the time were more likely due to sampling error in the survey rather than a genuine surge.
- We generally recommend focusing on the unemployment rate, which is less vulnerable to sampling errors – and the message here is one of softness. Our best interpretation is that, to the extent that jobs are growing, it's not fast enough to absorb the growth in the population.
- While the economy has returned to growth over the last year or so, hiring activity remains weak. This may be an ongoing legacy of employment trends in previous years, when firms were relatively reluctant to lay people off during the slowdown, which then potentially left them overstaffed even as activity started to pick up again. It's not clear how long this effect can persist, though.
- Wage growth remains muted. Although cost-of-living pressures have increased on workers, the existing degree of spare capacity in the labour market doesn't give them much leverage to negotiate larger pay increases.
- Overall, we judge these results to be weaker than the RBNZ expected, in particular the rise in the unemployment rate. This data supports the views of those on the policy committee who were less convinced in October about the potential for second-round inflation pressures in the economy.

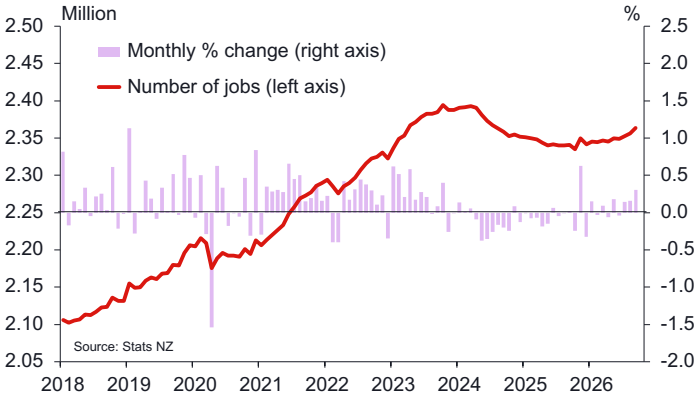
Employment

- The number of people employed fell by 0.1% in the September quarter, according to the Household Labour Force Survey (HLFS). Previous quarters were revised down a little, reflecting downward revisions to the working-age population estimates. Annual employment growth slowed from 0.9% to 0.7%.
- This was substantially softer than our forecast of a 0.5% rise for the quarter. Our forecast was based on the Monthly Employment Indicator (MEI), a comprehensive measure that is drawn from income tax data. While there are some differences in coverage for these two measures, any significant divergence between the two is most likely to reflect sampling error in the HLFS.
- Meanwhile, the employer-focused Quarterly Employment Survey (QES) recorded a 0.1% rise in the number of filled jobs and a 0.6% rise in hours paid. (This survey is of course vulnerable to sampling error as well.)
- We're most inclined towards the MEI measure of employment, given the breadth of its coverage. But our best interpretation is that, to the extent that jobs are growing, it's not yet fast enough to absorb the growth in the adult population – hence the further rise in the unemployment rate.

HLFS number of people employed



Monthly Employment Indicator filled jobs



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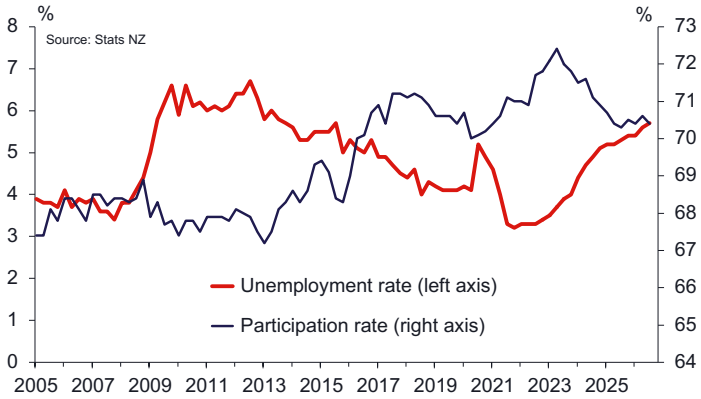
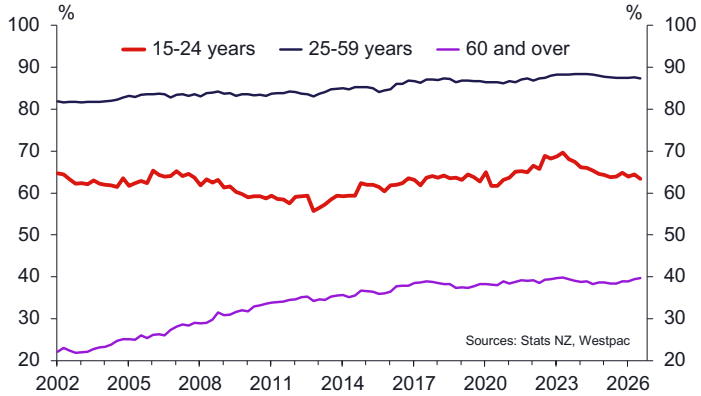
Labour force participation

- The surprising fall in HLFS employment was accompanied by a drop in the participation rate from 70.6% to 70.4%.
- These co-movements are effectively a reversal of the surprisingly large increases that we saw in the June quarter, which we noted at the time were suggestive of sampling error in the survey. Any such errors largely wash out when it comes to the unemployment rate, however, which is why we recommend focusing on this measure.
- Setting aside the usual quarterly volatility, labour force participation remains caught between two competing forces. One is cyclical weakness, especially among younger people, who are finding it difficult to break into a "low-fire, low-hire" labour market. The teen unemployment rate of around 25% is a record high going back to the start of the survey in 1986.
- The other force is rising participation among the over-60s (who also make up a growing share of the population). Kiwis have had a growing propensity to work beyond the NZ Super age, as there is no penalty for doing so. It's unclear to what extent this can be considered an increase in the pool of available workers: older workers tend to have low mobility between jobs, and if they find themselves out of work are more likely to leave the labour force altogether.

Unemployment and participation rates



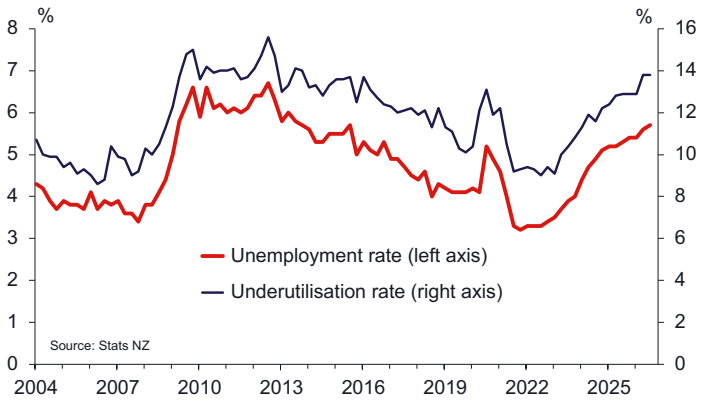
Participation by age group



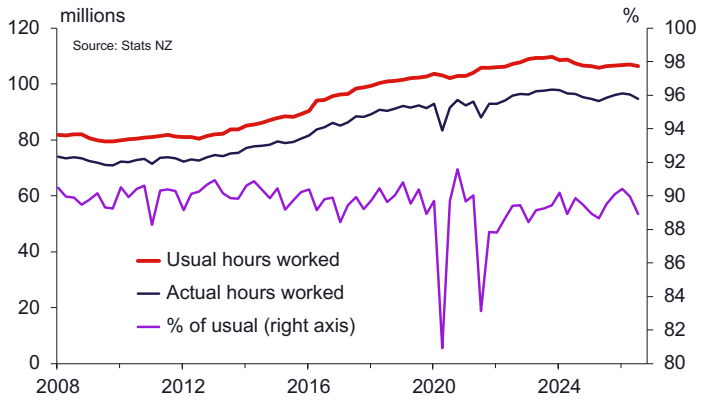
Unemployment and underutilisation

- The unemployment rate rose from 5.6% to 5.7% in the September quarter. This was the highest rate since September 2015.
- While there are other indicators of spare capacity in the labour market, we're not convinced that there is additional information to draw from them this time.
- The broader underutilisation measure, which includes discouraged jobseekers and part-time workers wanting more hours, was steady at 13.8% after having risen sharply from 12.9% last quarter. This measure is both higher (by definition) and more variable than the unemployment rate, but tells a similar story in that it's around an 11-year high.
- There was a marked 1.6% fall in the number of hours worked (although 'usual' hours were down just 0.4%). However, we suspect this was largely driven by Matariki – a floating holiday that won't be captured in the seasonal adjustment.
- This may also account for the 2.5% rise in part-time employment, against a 0.7% fall in full-time employment. Some workers may have been pushed into the part-time category (less than 30 hours a week) simply by virtue of only working four days during the survey week.

Unemployment and underutilisation rates



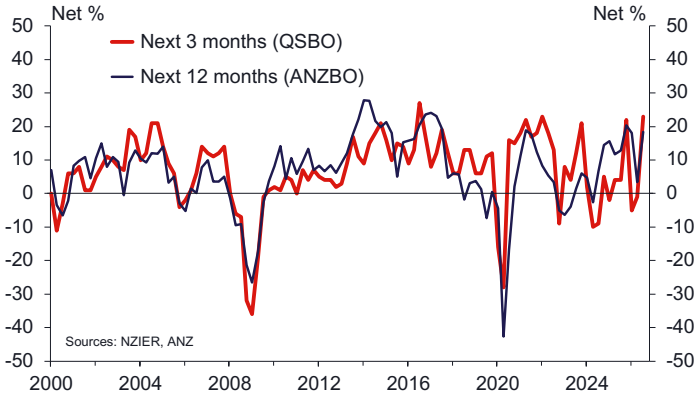
Usual vs actual hours worked



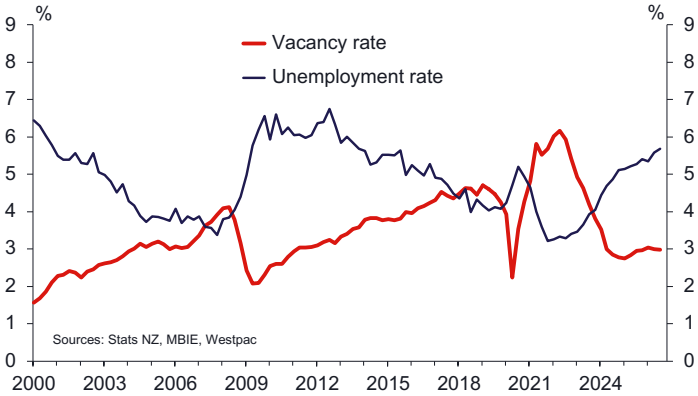
Hiring

- Business confidence surveys have shown a lift in hiring intentions in recent months, as firms have shaken off the initial shock of the Iran conflict and the surge in fuel prices.
- However, those stated intentions aren't obviously turning into reality yet. Job advertisements were down about 1% for the September quarter in seasonally adjusted terms, and they remain well below pre-Covid levels. Job ads will capture 'churn' within existing roles as well as new job creation, but both of these would be associated with a strong labour market.
- With the working-age population growing at the same time, the result was a modest fall in the vacancy rate, one of the RBNZ's highest-ranked measures of labour market tightness.
- We estimate that there are around 1.9 people unemployed for every job vacancy, up from around 1.8 people this time last year.
- Firms have told us that they were reluctant to lay off workers during the economic downturn in 2023-24, as they were wary of the extreme labour shortages that had developed in the previous boom years. As a result, they may find themselves still overstaffed even as demand has started to pick up again, and haven't needed to return to hiring yet.

Business employment intentions



Job vacancies as a % of the labour force

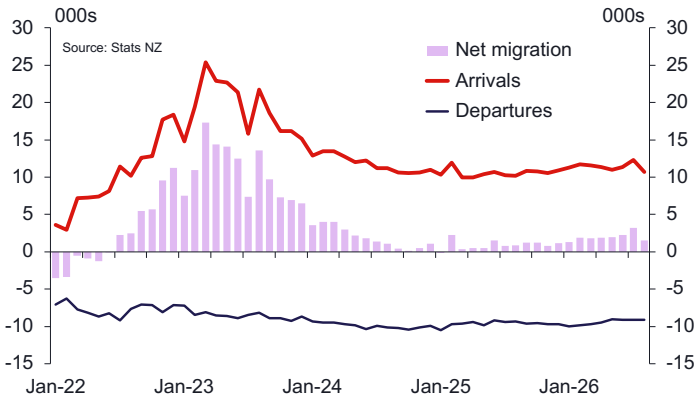


Population and migration

- The working-age population grew by around 1.0% over the last year, compared to a peak of 3.3% growth over 2023. Jobs growth (based on the less volatile MEI measure) is still lagging behind population growth on an annual basis.
- The pool of potential workers is generally becoming older, with the Baby Boomers increasingly reaching pension age and beyond, and with migrant arrivals tending to be an older cohort than we saw pre-Covid – more in their 30s and 40s than their 20s.
- Net migration flows have started to pick up from their lows since late 2025. Departures of New Zealanders have come down from their highs, though they remain above pre-Covid levels, as the relative appeal of the Australian jobs market has narrowed.
- Foreign arrivals have picked up to some degree, although the growth appears to have been mostly driven by students rather than those on work visas.

Employment and working-age population

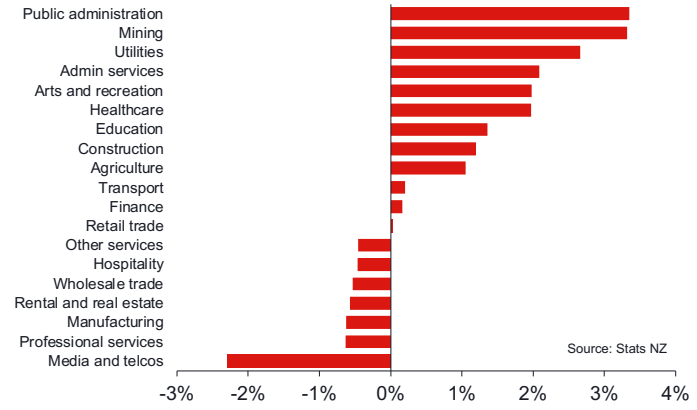
Monthly migration flows



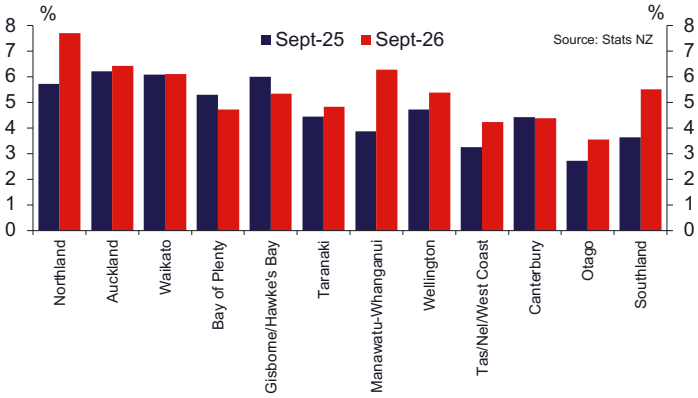
Sectoral and regional trends

- Jobs growth has been relatively strong in government-connected sectors such as healthcare and education, as well as in local and central government administration.
- Mining and utilities have seen strong growth in percentage terms, but neither of these sectors are big employers in absolute terms.
- The construction sector is now starting to see a lift in employment, after a steep decline over 2024-25. Residential building consents have risen strongly over the last year or so, pointing to a growing pipeline of work for the homebuilding industry.
- Sectors that are connected to international tourism, such as transport and recreational services, had previously seen strong employment growth, but this appears to have flattened out in recent months.
- Employment trends have generally been more positive in the South Island than the North, which likely reflects the greater influence of the agricultural sector – while not a large employer in itself, farmers have benefited from high export prices and their spending has flowed into other sectors.

Filled jobs by sector, annual % change



Regional unemployment rates



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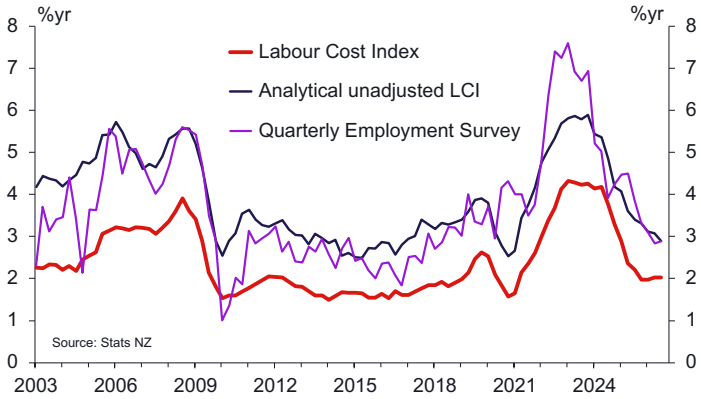
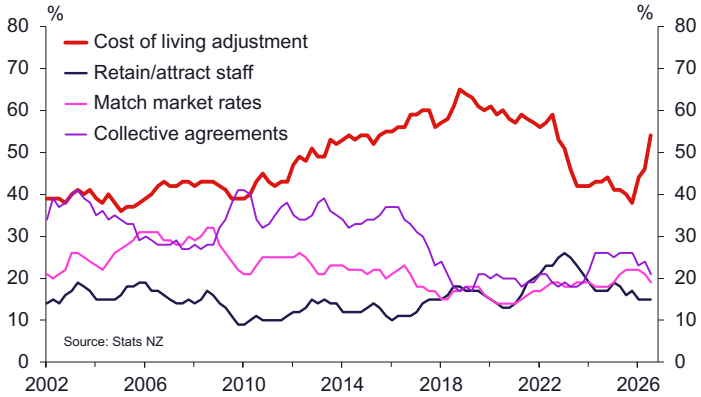
Wages

- The Labour Cost Index (LCI) rose by 0.5% in the September quarter. Annual growth remained around the lowest since 2021.
- While the overall result was in line with our forecast, the details were a little weaker than we expected, with less contribution from private sector wages (up 0.5%) and a surprisingly large 0.7% increase in the public sector.
- The distribution of pay rates has returned to pre-Covid trends. Only 44% of roles saw a pay rise over the last year; of those roles that did see an increase, the average size has converged on the 2-3% range.
- The LCI is not a measure of what workers actually receive – it reflects the cost to businesses for a given unit of labour – and hence shouldn't be compared to the inflation rate. A more suitable measure is the analytical unadjusted LCI, which includes pay rises that are related to productivity gains. This measure slowed from 3.1% to 2.9% on an annual basis, the lowest since March 2021.
- There was a marked pickup in the proportion of firms reporting cost-of-living adjustments as the main reason for pay increases. However, the size of those increases varied greatly, with many of them below the rate of CPI inflation.
- This seems to reflect a shift in the justification for pay rises, rather than an overall increase in wage pressures – firms are more likely to cite cost-of-living adjustments because they're less likely to cite demand-side pressures.

Measures of wage growth



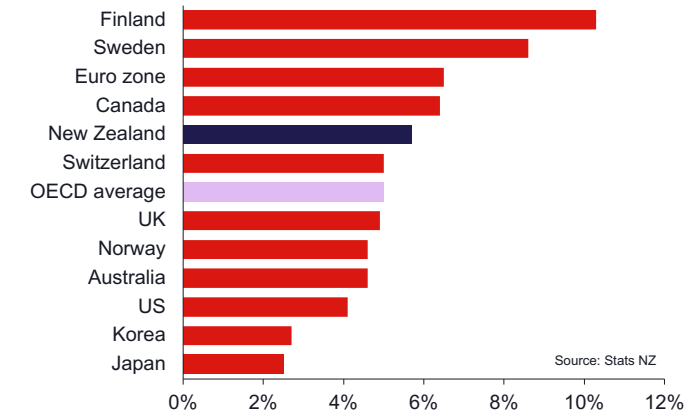
Reasons given for pay increase



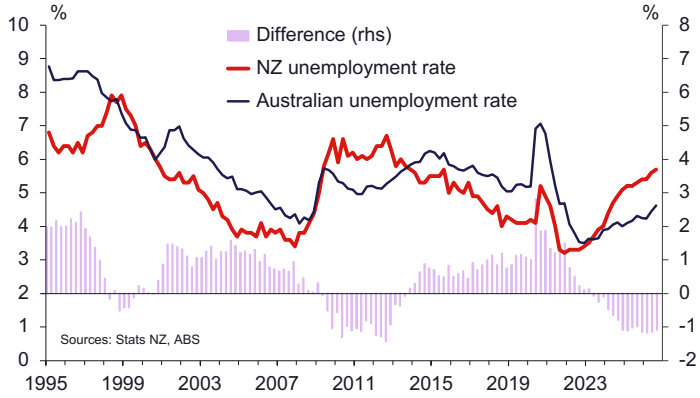
International comparisons

- New Zealand's unemployment rate is the 18th lowest in the OECD (out of 38 countries). This ranking has been broadly unchanged over the last year or so.
- Notably, New Zealand's unemployment rate is substantially above Australia's, whereas historically it has been lower on average. This shift in relative job opportunities has been a key attractor for New Zealanders over the last couple of years – as it was in the early 2010s when the Australian economy was benefiting from a boom in mining construction.
- However, that gap between unemployment rates is no longer widening, with the Australian jobs market starting to soften this year as the RBA has raised interest rates to rein in inflation (which was already running too high before the Iran conflict and the surge in oil prices). We expect Australia's unemployment to rise further over the year ahead.
- New Zealand has the 7th highest employment rate in the OECD (down from 6th last quarter). We tend to have high rates of labour force participation for 15-64 year olds, and particularly high participation for the over-65s, as the lack of means testing for NZ Superannuation means there is no financial disincentive to working beyond pension age.

Selected unemployment rates



NZ vs Australian labour markets



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Westpac Banking Corporation.

1 October 2026

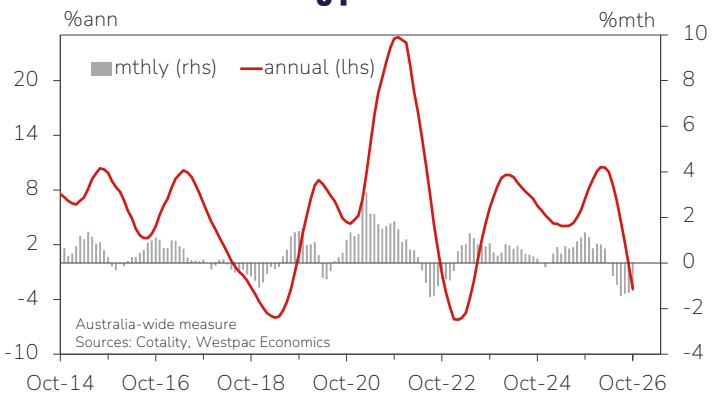
AUSTRALIAN DWELLING PRICES BULLETIN

Sea of red

Key points

- The Cotality home value index – covering all of Australia – fell 1.2% in October following a 1.3% decline in September and 1.4% falls in August and July. Annual growth has turned negative, running at –2.8%yr with prices down 6.7% from their peak in March.
- Across the major cities, Brisbane and Perth led the declines in the October month, recording falls of 2.0% and 1.7% respectively, but the correction remains more pronounced in Sydney (prices down a further 1.6%mth to be off 9.4%yr) with Melbourne also off more sharply over the year (–7.6%yr) but recording a milder October (–0.8%mth). Adelaide remains relatively resilient, recording a 1.2% decline in the month but prices still up 3.7%yr.
- Preliminary estimates show the number of sales, in rolling 3mth terms, down 5.6%qtr and 22.5%yr.

Australian dwelling prices



Oct Cotality home value index: –1.2%mth; –2.8%yr

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Housing downturn deepens

Matthew Hassan
Head of Australian Macro–Forecasting

The Cotality home value index, covering all of Australia, fell 1.2% in October with slight revisions to previous months again shaving a further 0.3% off prices. The correction has now seen prices decline 6.7% from their March peak with annual growth firmly in negative at –2.8%yr. Turnover continues fall as well, down 22.5%yr. Housing-related tax policy changes, interest rate rises and heightened uncertainty have triggered a sharp contraction in markets.

The downturn is now comparable to the previous two housing market corrections. Nationally, the downturn in 2022-23 saw prices decline 7.5% and turnover fall 29% peak to trough. The 2017-18 correction saw prices fall 8.6% and turnover by 24%, with larger falls in Sydney and Melbourne.

Note that unless specified, figures in titles, tables and commentary are in non-seasonally adjusted terms, consistent with the 'headline' figures reported by Cotality. However, figures shown in charts are in seasonally adjusted terms.

Preliminary estimates of turnover show rolling 3mth volumes down 5.6%qtr in October, previous estimates again revised lower. The monthly pattern suggests declines re-accelerated through September-October after stabilising somewhat in July-August. The RBA's interest rate rise in late September and a further expected tightening likely contributed to the shift.

The detail shows Brisbane and Perth are now leading the way in terms of monthly price declines although corrections to date remain significantly larger in Sydney and Melbourne while smaller capitals and regional areas continue to see much milder downturns. Across price tiers, all segments are now showing similar rates of decline after top price tiers had seen a more pronounced and earlier downturn. 'Top tier' segments have tended to lead recent price cycles.

Looking across jurisdictions,

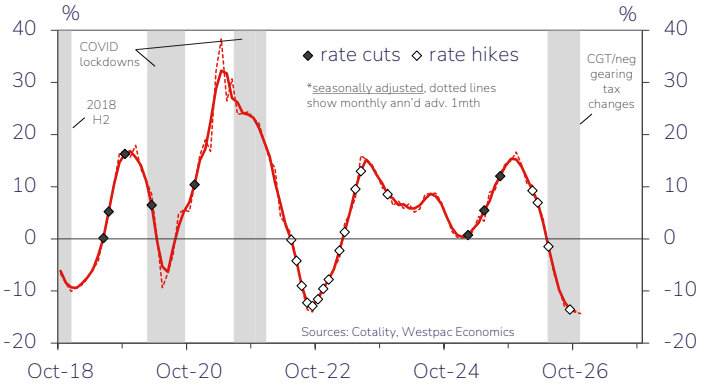
- **Sydney** prices dropped 1.6% in October having averaged similar-sized declines over the previous five months. While all segments and tiers continue to record falls, the last few months has seen the pace of decline moderate a touch in the top tier segments that have led cycles in the past, although they are still a long way from stabilisation.
- **Melbourne** prices declined 0.8%mth, in line with September's move and continuing the slower pace of retreat. As noted, this likely reflects the weaker starting point coming into the correction, prices already at 5½ year lows. Interestingly, the detail shows the moderation in price declines in recent months has been more pronounced for 'top tier' units where prices are back where they were in 2016.

Cotality home value index: October 2026

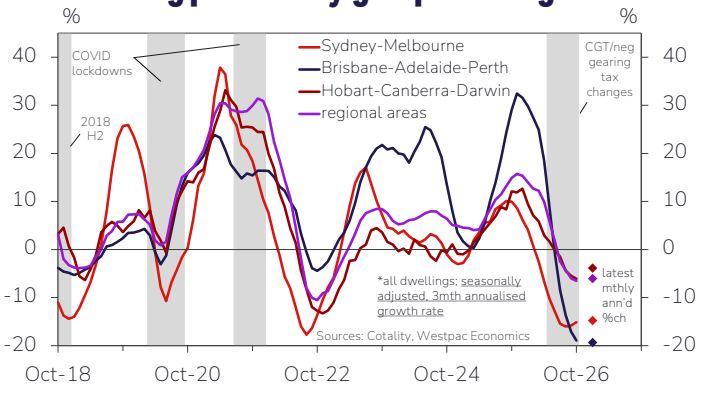
	%mth				%ann			
	Jul	Aug	Sep	Oct	Jul	Aug	Sep	Oct
Australia*	**–1.4**	**–1.4**	**–1.3**	**–1.2**	**4.6**	**2.2**	**–0.3**	**–2.8**
seas. adjusted	–1.2	–1.2	–1.2	–1.3	4.6	2.2	–0.2	–2.8
– houses	–1.5	–1.5	–1.4	–1.4	5.0	2.4	–0.3	–3.0
– units	–1.2	–0.9	–1.1	–0.8	3.0	1.4	–0.4	–2.2
Major capital cities								
Sydney	–1.9	–1.6	–1.5	–1.6	–2.3	–4.8	–7.1	–9.4
Melbourne	–1.5	–1.2	–0.8	–0.8	–2.9	–4.6	–6.1	–7.6
Brisbane	–1.8	–2.1	–2.1	–2.0	13.0	8.9	4.7	0.4
Adelaide	–0.3	–1.0	–1.7	–1.2	10.9	9.1	6.3	3.7
Perth	–1.9	–2.0	–2.1	–1.7	17.9	13.8	8.8	3.9
Turnover^	**–8.4**	**–8.9**	**–5.8**	**–5.6**	**–18.2**	**–19.6**	**–20.2**	**–22.5**

* Australia–wide measure, covering both capital cities and regional areas.
Sources: Cotality, Westpac Economics.
^ rolling 3mth total, %3mth and %ann ch, seasonally adjusted by Westpac.

Australian dwelling prices: 3mth ann'd



Dwelling prices: city groups and regional areas



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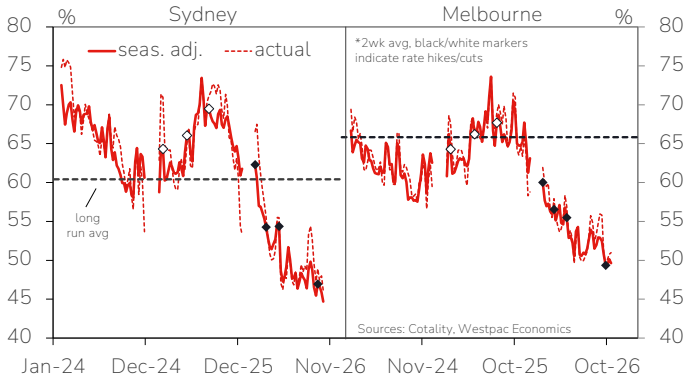
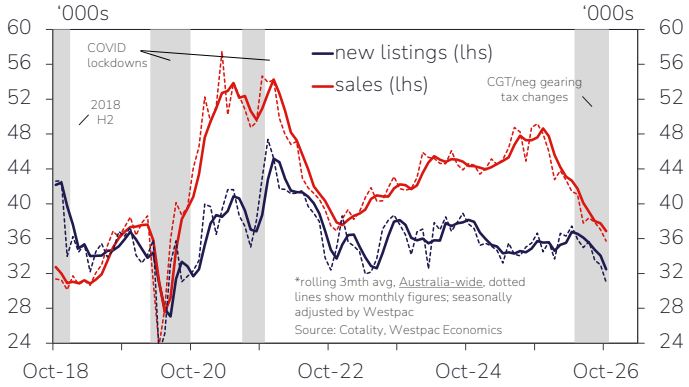
- **Brisbane** prices are tracking a very fast rate of decline that is also seeing large downward revisions. Prices fall 2% in October with September and August now both showing 2.1% falls, revised down from 1.5% and 1.6% respectively (August having previously been estimated at just 1%, July's move having seen a similar series of revisions –1.2% to –1.8%). The combined effect has taken the rolling 3mth change to –6.1%qtr from –4.7%qtr last months and –2.7%qtr in August and –0.6%qtr in July. At 0.4%yr, annual price growth has virtually stalled flat having run at 18%yr as recently as May. All tiers and segments are recording similar rates of decline.
- **Perth** is seeing something very similar, prices dropping a further 1.7% in October, with September's decline revised down to 2.1% from –1.2% and August's to 2.0% from –1.7%. At 3.9%yr, annual growth is still positive but off steeply from the 24% pace back in May. As with Brisbane, all tiers and segments are recording similar rates of decline.
- **Adelaide** dwelling prices posted a somewhat milder 1.2% decline in October, , September's –1.3% decline marked down to –1.7%. Annual price growth slowed to 3.7%yr, similar to Perth's but with less of a whiplash from strong gains to large declines. Turnover has also been much steadier, sales holding flat over the last three months and down just 12.4%yr.
- The smaller capitals were again more mixed, price growth still positive in Darwin (0.6%mth, 9.7%yr), relatively resilient in Hobart (+0.5%mth, 5.5%yr) but weaker in Canberra (–0.7%mth, –3.7%yr).
- **Regional markets** showed a 0.9% decline in Qld but slightly milder declines in NSW (–0.7%) and Victoria (0.6%). Annual prices growth is in the 1.4-3.5%yr range.

All up, the October updates make for bleak reading. With the RBA widely expected to raise interest rates again, the near term outlook remains very challenging. Next week's consumer sentiment update will show how this is shaping housing-related sentiment – so far, consumer price expectations have weakened but stopped short of swinging to the clear negative consensus that emerged in the 2022-23 correction. That now looks to be at risk. Either way, momentum looks set to remain weak into year-end and, barring a significantly improved inflation and interest rate outlook, well into 2027.

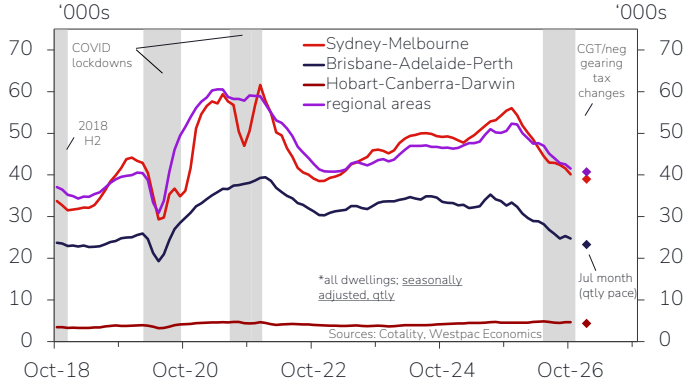
Auction clearance rates



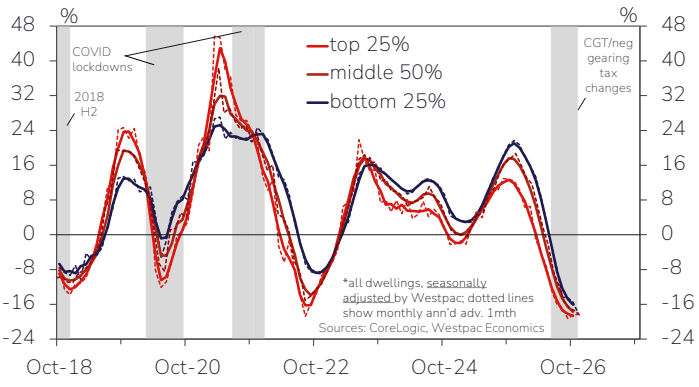
Australian dwellings: sales and listings



Dwelling sales: city groups and regional areas



Australian dwelling prices: price tiers



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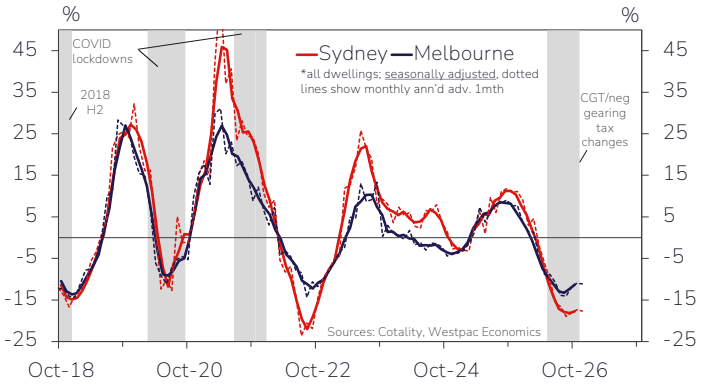
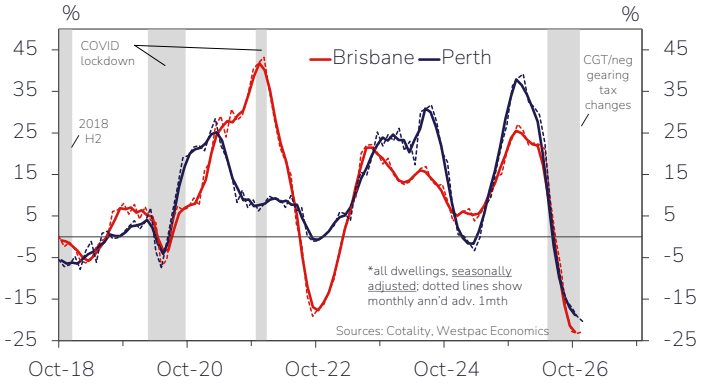
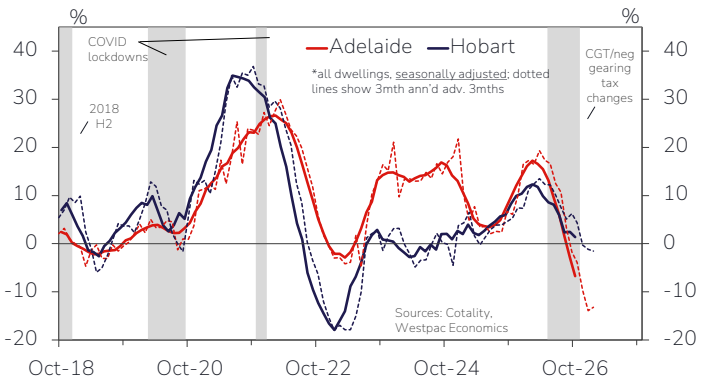
Sydney, Melbourne dwelling prices: 3mth ann'd



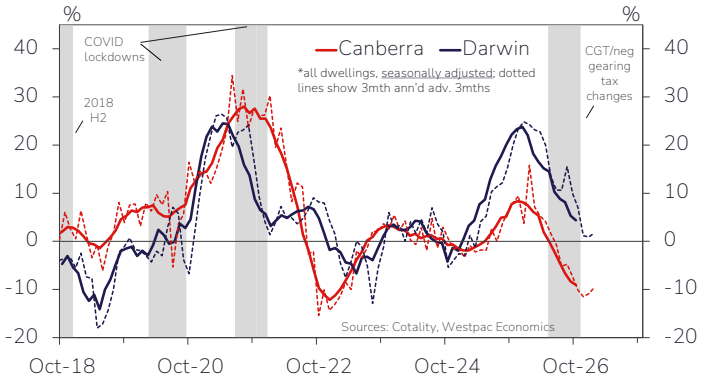
Brisbane, Perth dwelling prices: 3mth ann'd



Adelaide, Hobart dwelling prices: 6mth ann'd



Canberra, Darwin dwelling prices: 6mth ann'd



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ECONOMIC BULLETIN

New Zealand 2026 General Election: Preliminary results and next steps.

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- As polls suggested, the election was a nailbiter that has not yet been resolved. Election night results show a lead to the centre-right on paper in a significantly enlarged parliament.
- The centre-right bloc of National, NZ First and ACT won 67 seats. The centre-left bloc of Labour, Greens and Te Pāti Māori won 57 seats. There was a swing away from National to its coalition partners while the centre left grouping picked up a few seats.
- The Opportunity Party delivered on its polling and will enter parliament with at least 7 seats, reducing what could have been a larger swing to the centre-left grouping.
- The size of parliament will expand by around 9 seats as National held onto a large share of its electorate votes, entitling it to more seats than implied by its party vote share. As a result, a bloc would require 66 seats to command a majority in parliament.
- Several senior National ministers have not been re-elected, including Finance Minister Nicola Willis. She will continue in a caretaker role but will need to be replaced in any new centre-right government.
- Significant uncertainty about the result exists. National might lose perhaps two marginal electorates in the final analysis. There are 400,000 special votes to count which may shift the list seat allocations as these tend to reduce the share of the centre-right bloc by 1.6-1.7ppts. Hence, when all is said and done, the centre-right's 10 seat advantage on election night could reduce by 1-4 seats.
- Should this play out the centre-right would not have sufficient seats to reach a majority in an enlarged house and would require the support of the Opportunity Party to govern.
- The final election outcome will not be known until 27 November. Serious coalition negotiations likely won't begin until then and delays could occur. Should recounts be required, some further delay is possible.
- Based on these results, we see a higher probability of a centre-right government ultimately emerging that likely will require the support of the Opportunity Party in some form. The Opportunity Party likely won't enter Cabinet but may offer support on confidence and supply in exchange for policy concessions.
- But a centre-left government can't be ruled out if special votes heavily favour the centre left bloc, and especially if an agreement between the Opportunity Party and the centre-right parties can't be reached.
- Regardless of the final count, the results suggest a government with weak support and ongoing vulnerabilities. Hence the prospect of controversial large changes may be modest. For a centre-right government that might limit the extent of fiscal consolidation, while the centre left's plans for larger scale tax and spending initiatives could be trimmed back.
- A centre-right government won't change the RBNZ mandate while a centre-left government likely still will. A new finance minister will be required with the possibility of ACT leader David Seymour taking on that role.

Table 1: Election 2023 (final) vs 2026 (provisional) results

	Electorate Seats			Party Vote Share			Total Seats		
	2023 Final	2026 Election Night	Change	2023 Final	2026 Election Night	Change	2023 Final	2026 Election Night	Change
Labour	17	21	4	26.9	29.4	2.5	34	36	2
Green	3	2	-1	11.6	13.3	1.7	15	16	1
Te Pati Māori	6	5	-1	3.1	0.6	2.	6	5	-1
Total centre-left	**26**	**28**	**2**	**41.6**	**43.3**	**1.7**	**55**	**57**	**2**
National	43	42	-1	38.1	29.2	-8.9	48	42	-6
ACT	2	1	1	8.6	10.9	2.3	11	13	2
NZ First	0	0	0	6.1	9.8	3.7	8	12	4
Total centre-right	**45**	**43**	**-2**	**52.8**	**49.9**	**-2.9**	**67**	**67**	**0**
Opportunity	0	0	0	2.2	6.0	3.8	0	7	7
Others	0	0	0	2.2	0.9	-1.3	0	0	0
Total others	0	0	0	4.4	6.8	2.4	0	7	7
Total all	**71**	**71**	**-**	**100.0**	**100.0**	**-**	**122**	**131**	**9**

The result.

The preliminary results of the 2026 General Election, based on the election night count, are set out in the table above. In summary:

- The centre-right bloc of National, NZ First and ACT won 67 seats.
- The centre-left bloc of Labour, Greens and Te Pāti Māori won 57 seats.
- The Opportunity Party delivered on its polling and will enter parliament with 7 seats.

These results indicate a swing away from National to its coalition partners while the centre-left grouping picked up a few seats. The big gainer was the Opportunity Party who perhaps took a big share of what otherwise could have been a larger swing to the centre-left grouping.

The size of parliament will expand by around nine seats, as National held onto a large share of its electorate votes and hence has more seats than it would have been entitled to based on its party vote share. As a result, a governing bloc would require 66 seats to command a majority in parliament.

Several of the electorate seats are very tight (see Table 2), so election night majorities could easily be overturned once special votes are counted. Of particular relevance is the seat of Wairarapa, where the National candidate is leading the Labour candidate by just 139 votes. If Labour were to win that seat (specials favoured Labour in 2020 but National in 2023), all else equal the centre-right seat count would decline to 66 seats in what would become a 130-seat Parliament – just enough to command a majority. But if either NZ First or ACT were to lose a single party vote seat to the left bloc once specials are counted then that majority would disappear.

On that score, historically the election night results have tended to overstate the support of the centre-right bloc and understate the support for parties on the left of the political spectrum. For example, over the previous three elections (2017, 2020, 2023), the current centre-right bloc's vote share has declined 1.9%, 1.7% and 1.6% respectively following the counting of special votes, with the National Party losing 2 seats on each occasion once the official results were declared (Labour, the Greens and Te Pāti Māori have benefited). On this occasion, given its overhang, a lower party vote share would not lower the National Party's final vote count, although it could alter the size of its overhang and thus the number of seats required to command a majority. In recent elections both NZ First and ACT have seen their vote shares decline following the counting of special votes.

The process from here.

Official results.

The official results will be declared on 27 November, adding the results of an estimated 400,000 special votes (with around a quarter of these cast overseas) to the 2.41m votes counted on election night.

We expect discussions between potential coalition partners will begin immediately to start sketching out the parameters of a coalition agreement. But given the tight margins of the current vote count, no firm positions will be agreed until the results are declared.

The writ and recounts.

After 27 November, the writ is scheduled to be returned on 3 December – formally certifying who has been elected. However, that date is subject to any recounts

Table 2: Most marginal electorate contests

Electorate	Current winner	Winner party	Runner-up	Runner-up party	Margin (votes)
Wairarapa	Mike Butterick	National	Kieran McAnulty	Labour	139
Wellington Bays	Craig Renney	Labour	Julie Anne Genter	Green	140
Mt Roskill	Michael Wood	Labour	Carlos Cheung	National	262
Te Tai Tokerau	Aperahama Edwards	Te Pāti Māori	Hūhana Lyndon	Green	436
Hamilton East	Ryan Hamilton	National	Georgie Dansey	Labour	456
Hutt South	Ginny Andersen	Labour	Chris Bishop	National	889
Whangārei	Lloyd Sam Budd	National	Gary Payinda	Labour	1,092
Nelson	Blair Cameron	National	Rachel Boyack	Labour	1,210
Takanini	Rima Nakhle	National	Kharag Singh	Labour	1,487
Epsom	David Seymour	ACT	Paul Goldsmith	National	2,044

that might be requested. Parliament is required to meet no later than 14 January (six weeks after the return of the writ), providing an opportunity for a new government to test that it has the confidence of the House. It is worth noting that Parliament can be summoned and begin functioning even if coalition negotiations are still occurring. If no coalition or confidence-and-supply arrangement has been reached by then, negotiations can simply continue and the incumbent Government remains in office under the caretaker convention (Ministers in the outgoing government retain executive authority temporarily, even if they are no longer MPs).

Given that the Pre-Election Economic and Fiscal Update was released in late September there is no legal requirement for the Treasury to publish a Half Year Economic and Fiscal Update (HYEFU) this year. And given that it will be some weeks before a government is formed, it seems unlikely that there will be a government in place that would request that a HYEFU be produced despite there being no statutory requirement (certainly there would be little time to incorporate policy changes that fall out of new coalition agreements, thus diminishing its value). Once a government is formed, it will have an opportunity to lay out its immediate priorities in the Budget Policy Statement (BPS), which by law needs to be released before the end of March next year. The new government could decide to release an interim fiscal update with the BPS if that was thought necessary.

Potential coalition outcomes.

We see three main likely outcomes:

- A three-party majority coalition between National, ACT and NZ First.
- A three-party majority coalition between National, ACT and NZ First with the support of the Opportunity Party on confidence and supply.
- Some coalition of Labour, the Greens, Opportunity and Te Pāti Māori, potentially with Opportunity and Te Pāti Māori sitting outside the cabinet.

Our **preview of the election** discussed the policies of the main political parties, while the figure on page 5 highlights some points of commonality with the centre-right and centre-left blocs.

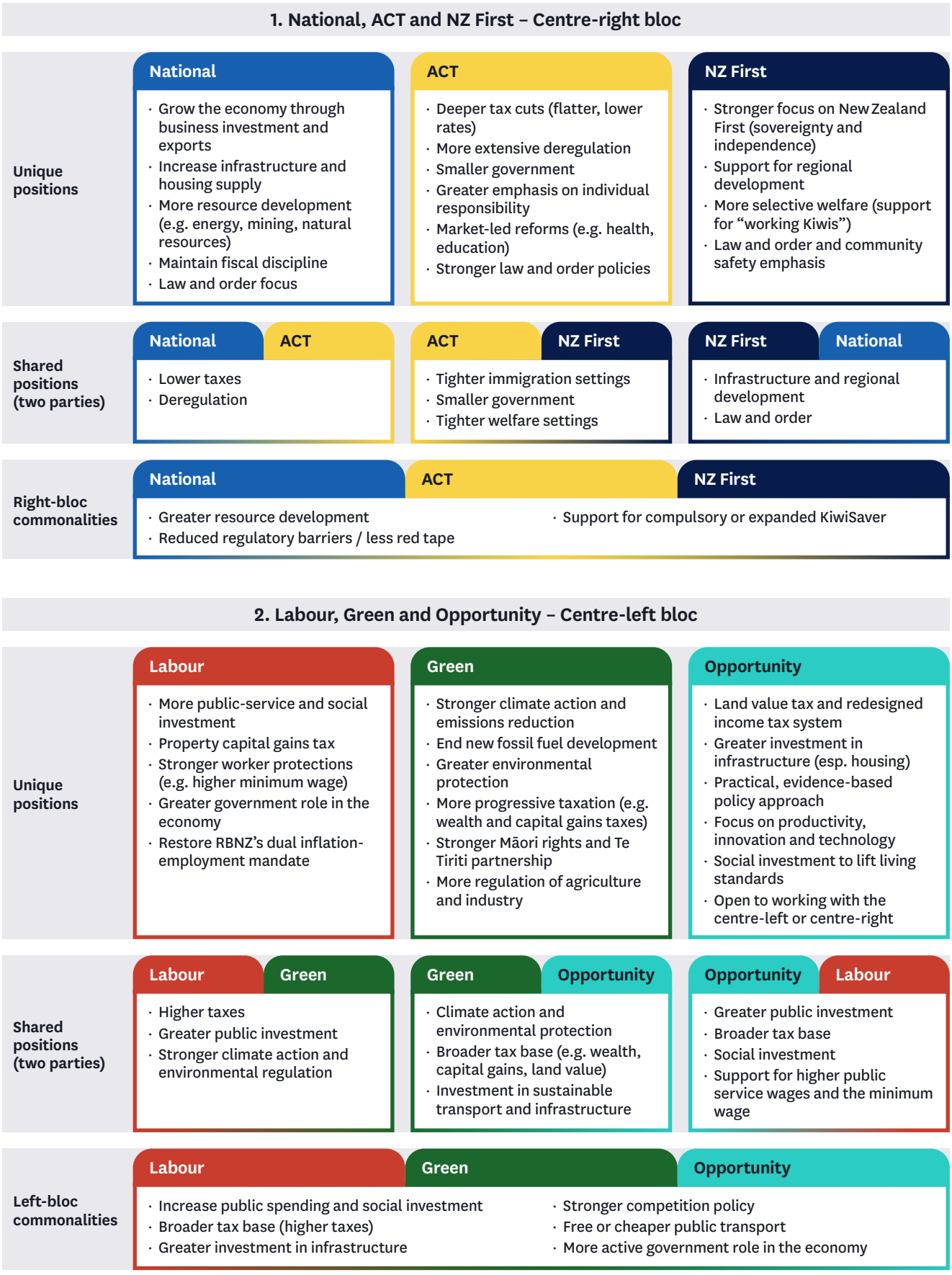
National, ACT and NZ First share a broadly pro-development and deregulatory agenda, including support for greater resource development, fewer regulatory barriers and compulsory or expanded KiwiSaver. Beyond that common core, National and ACT align particularly closely on lower taxes and deregulation, while National and NZ First share an emphasis on infrastructure, regional development and law and order. ACT and NZ First favour tighter immigration settings and tighter welfare policies. The differences are clearest at the edges: ACT advocates deeper tax cuts, smaller government and more market-led provision, while NZ First places greater emphasis on economic sovereignty, regional development and targeted support for working New Zealanders. National occupies more of the middle ground, combining fiscal discipline and a pro-business agenda with increased infrastructure and housing supply.

The Opportunity Party presents itself as a middle alternative that can work with the left or the right groupings. They have five bottom line policies they say they need to support any new government. These include competition reform through enhanced Commerce Commission powers, more restrictions on political lobbyists and donors, a ten-year plan of investment in the healthcare sector, an end to bottom trawling in inshore areas and a phase out elsewhere and for the Government to recommit to New Zealand's Paris Agreement obligations. Their success in meeting these bottom lines with a new government and their flexibility around these requirements will be key to their ability to form an agreement with either side. There is better congruence of the Opportunity Party's policies with the left than the right – so progress here will be critical to watch should their support be required to form a new government. We suspect they will be very motivated to avoid the need for a new election via a hung parliament should push come to shove.

Labour, the Greens and Opportunity share support for increased public and social investment, a broader tax base, greater infrastructure investment, stronger competition policy, cheaper public transport and a more active role for government. Labour and the Greens overlap particularly on higher taxation, public investment and stronger climate and environmental policy, while Labour and Opportunity share an emphasis on social investment and higher public-service wages. The Greens and Opportunity both favour broader taxation and stronger climate action, although their preferred tax instruments differ. Their distinctive priorities are also clear: Labour places more weight on worker protections and restoring the RBNZ's dual mandate; the Greens on environmental protection, progressive taxation and Te Tiriti; and Opportunity on land-value taxation, housing infrastructure, productivity, innovation and evidence-based policy.

See next page for figure of party policy commonalities and differences.

Figure 1. Policy commonalities and differences between NZ political parties



Based on the policy positions in our **Preview of 2026 General Election**.

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NZ Q3 Labour market data - Potential RBNZ implications

#labour #newzealand

By Kelly Eckhold
Chief Economist, Westpac New Zealand

13:16 November 04 2026

Share

The Q3 labour market statistics were weaker than expected. We discuss potential implications for the RBNZ noting that a December hike remains more likely than not at this point.

Q3 Labour market data: potential RBNZ implications

- The Q3 labour market data were weaker than RBNZ and our expectations.

- A December hike remains more likely than not, but there will be a clear debate to be had between the MPC hawks and doves.
- The forecast peak OCR is likely less impacted than the time to reach that peak. Further pauses in the tightening cycle could come earlier than currently forecast.
- The outlook for the exchange rate is especially clouded by this data should it take a longer time for NZ rates to move closer to global norms.
- Watch for updated RBNZ commentary on 10 and 19 November. The Governor's observation that it would have been useful to update markets ahead of the October meeting could imply a greater willingness to comment in the coming weeks.

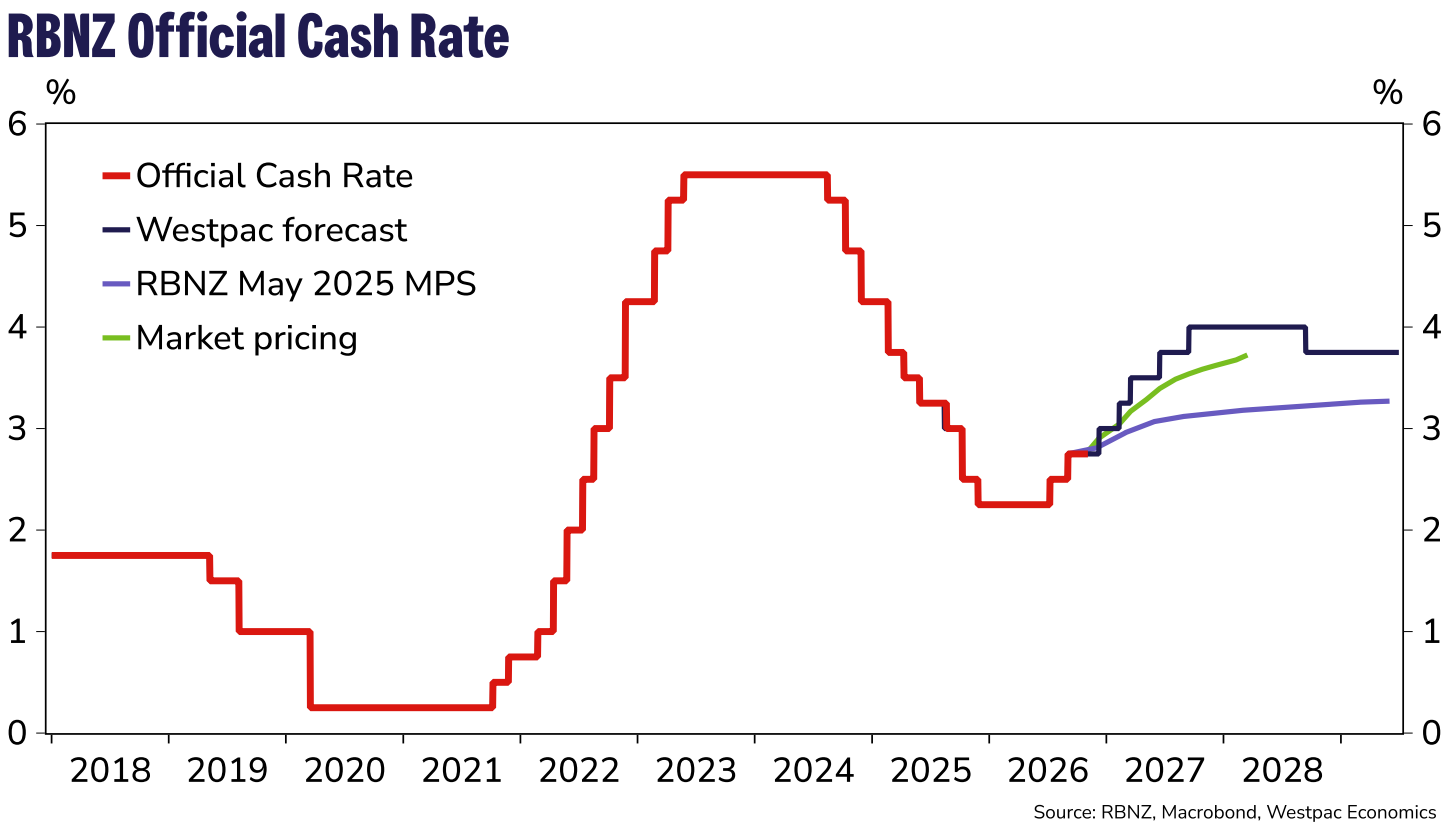
Today's labour market data seem unequivocally weaker than expected by either us or the RBNZ. While likely not a gamechanger for the cycle overall, it will add ammunition to the arguments of the MPC doves that a pause in interest rate rises will make sense soon - perhaps in December or in the New Year. It's likely the case that a bit much was priced into December, so the change in market probabilities in the wake of today's data makes sense - although my base case remains that a December rate rise remains more likely than not.

The message from the RBNZ in the October meeting though was to be careful about pricing in "done deals" and that the outlook will be data-dependent. As we noted at the time, alongside measures of inflation expectations, the key domestic data to watch ahead of the RBNZ's 9 December meeting will be indicators of what is happening to excess capacity (the output gap) as this will be a key determinant of the Bank's assessment of the outlook for inflation over the coming year.

It's useful to remember in the RBNZ's forecasting framework that GDP figures are the main determinant of excess capacity in the economy (i.e., the output gap). The Q2 GDP data told us that the output gap probably narrowed a bit through Q2, mainly reflecting historical revisions. In light of today's labour market numbers, the forecast for growth in Q3 may have some downside risk - but there are conflicting indicators there, so it's not that clear. However, it's probably hard to argue that the level of excess capacity reduced further in Q3 given today's data.

In the eyes of dovish MPC members, the rise in the unemployment rate and other measures important for the RBNZ's labour market dashboard likely push in the direction of having greater comfort with the medium-term inflation outlook. The vacancy to unemployment ratio increased a bit, labour constraints eased a bit, and the unemployment rate has increased. Hence from a labour market perspective it could be argued that policy could have more time all else equal. The outcome of the election, with the possibility of a new RBNZ mandate, could increase the prominence of these factors - although this won't likely be an explicit factor in the RBNZ's thinking in December even though it may be in the minds of individual MPC members.

It could be the case that the argument for increases in the OCR track through 2027 could be undermined with this data. It's important to note (probably self-evidently) that there are other data that will also be relevant. Hence the risk of a pause earlier in the New Year has probably increased with this data, all else equal. I don't think our forecast peak OCR is really at issue here, but the time taken to get there could be more flexible. Takes along the lines of "3% is the terminal rate" are very premature and misplaced, in our view.



The outlook for the exchange rate is undermined by this data. I feel very happy about our year-end target of 79c for the NZD/AUD rate with the risk that a recovery in the NZD takes longer than currently assumed.

Looking ahead, there are some opportunities for the RBNZ to update markets on their views. Top of mind is Paul Conway's 10 November speech to the UBS Australasia Conference. The Governor is also speaking to the Institute of Directors on 19 November. If the RBNZ has something to say, then it might happen in conjunction with these events (the 10 November speech is titled “How is the NZ economy tracking”, so it will be difficult for Conway to avoid saying something about how he is interpreting today’s data). We also note the Governor's comments in the October MPR that it could have been useful to have been more flexible about updating markets on emerging views of new economic data. This might increase the likelihood that these events could be used to provide guidance on the RBNZ’s views of this data (and other emerging events), especially if it feels that the market’s interpretation is at odds with its own.

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2 November 2026

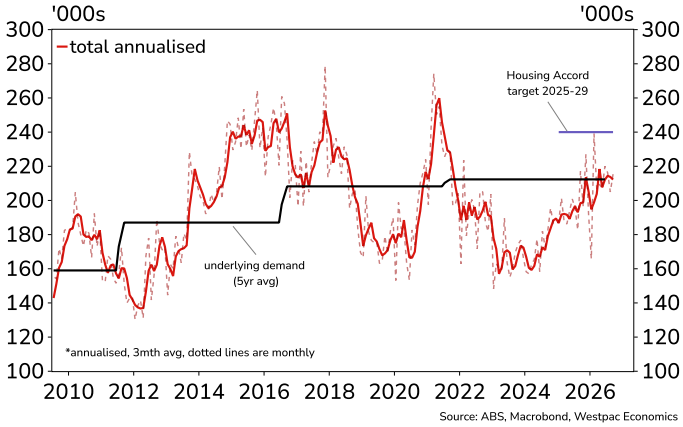
AUSTRALIAN DWELLING APPROVALS BULLETIN

Units lift the headline

Key points

- Total dwelling approvals rose 5.1%mth in September, although the annual pace moved into contraction at –0.8%yr with the detail suggesting the underlying cycle is starting to turn down.
- The headline increase was driven by another volatile rise in private unit approvals (+16.6%) which more than offset a significant decline in private detached house approvals (–5.3%).
- Units drove gains in NSW and Queensland. WA, SA and Victoria all recorded declines. Detached dwelling approvals fell across all states.
- The total value of residential approvals fell 2.8%mth but a sharp rise in non-residential approvals – led by the data centres – saw the total value of building approvals rise 13%mth.
- Interest rate increases, weakness in established housing markets, rising costs and pessimistic consumer sentiment are likely to remain headwinds.

Dwelling approvals



Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

Total dwelling approvals +5.1%mth, –0.8%yr

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Detached approvals point to softer momentum

Luka Belobrajdic
Economist

Total dwelling approvals rose 5.1%mth in September, while the annual pace moved into contraction at –0.8%yr. The result was well above both Westpac's expectation for a 7.0%mth decline and the market expectation for a 2.0%mth rise. Unit approvals continued to drive headline volatility, surging in September, while detached dwellings, which provide a better read on the underlying trend, recorded a sizeable decline.

Note that most figures in the charts and table are presented on a rolling-three month basis to smooth out monthly volatility.

Private detached dwelling approvals fell 5.3%mth in September, unwinding August's upwardly-revised 5.4%mth rise (+1.7ppts). Recent resilience has kept the segment elevated, with approvals remaining above 10,000 and the annual pace at 9.6%yr. However, the quarterly profile provides a clearer read on the underlying trend and suggests detached dwelling approvals are beginning to respond to recent interest rate increases (see here). Approvals rose just 0.9%qtr in September vs 3.1%qtr in June and 5.9%qtr in March.

Private unit approvals remained volatile, rising 16.6%mth in September following 21.7%mth decline in August. Strength was led by high-rise approvals, while low-mid-rise approvals recorded a more modest increase. Despite the monthly rise, the annual pace fell further into contraction at –20.5%yr.

Among the states, NSW recorded the strongest result, with private approvals rising 35.3%mth led by a surge in private unit approvals. Queensland also recorded an increase (+9.3%mth), while WA (–2.9%mth), SA (–3.5%mth) and Victoria (–29.0%mth) all declined.

In value terms, residential building approvals fell 2.8%mth, driven by a 3.3%mth decline in new residential approvals, partially offset by a 0.8%mth rise in renovation activity. Non-residential approvals once again reversed sharply, rising 45.9%mth, as the data centre-dominated 'other commercial' segment recorded an 8-fold increase on a non-seasonally adjusted basis. The total value of building approvals rose 13.0%mth in September. On a non-seasonally adjusted basis, the value of building approvals rose 8.3%mth overall, but declined 3.0%mth when excluding the 'other commercial' segment.

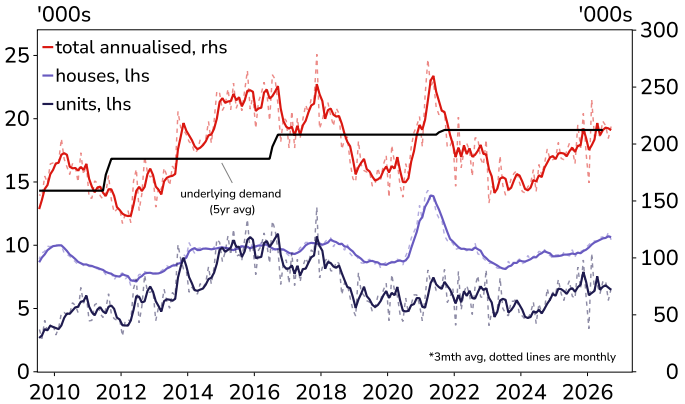
September's result reinforces the importance of looking through headline volatility in unit approvals. While total approvals rose in the month, detached dwelling approvals slowed on a quarterly basis and fell across all states, pointing to softer underlying momentum. The annual pace of total approvals also moved into contraction for the first time since January. Interest rate increases, the sharp downturn in established housing markets and rising costs are likely to weigh on further growth, with pessimistic consumer sentiment an additional headwind (see here).

Building approvals – September 2026

		3mth %chg*		%yr	
3mth avg	latest	Aug	Sep	Aug	Sep
Private houses	10,633	2.7	0.9	15.3	12.9
Private units	6,478	2.8	-3.6	5.3	-3.1
Public dwellings	574	12.3	35.4	-5.3	30.1
Total dwellings	17,684	2.9	flat	10.7	6.9
Total dwellings, mthly*	17,948	-5.2	5.1	12.1	-0.8
– units in 'high rise'^	3,748	11.1	0.1	16.3	4.9
– units in 'low rise'^	3,185	-2.7	3.7	-7.7	-1.4
Renovations, $bn	1.314	-3.4	-3.5	8.3	9.1
Non–res., $bn	7.805	-5.0	-12.8	9.1	10.3

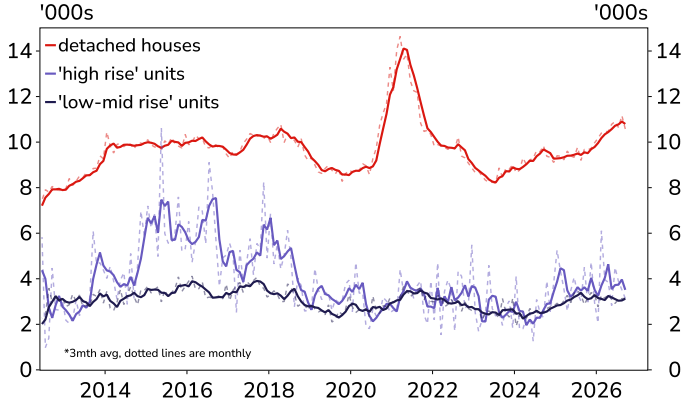
*figures for 'total dwellings mthly' are monthly and mthly%ch, all others are rolling 3mth avg and 3mth%ch; ^all sectors, Westpac estimates
Sources: ABS, Westpac Economics

Dwelling approvals: major segment



Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

Dwelling approvals: detailed segment



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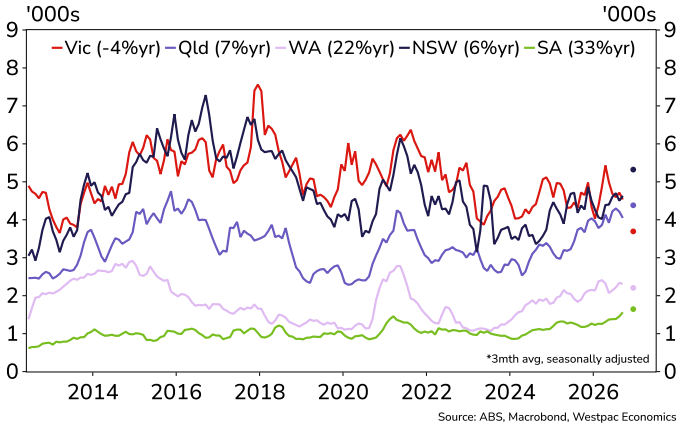
Total dwelling approvals: by state



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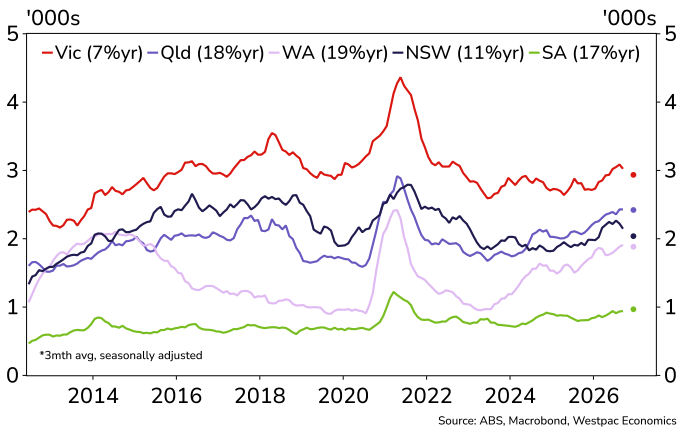
Detached house approvals: by state



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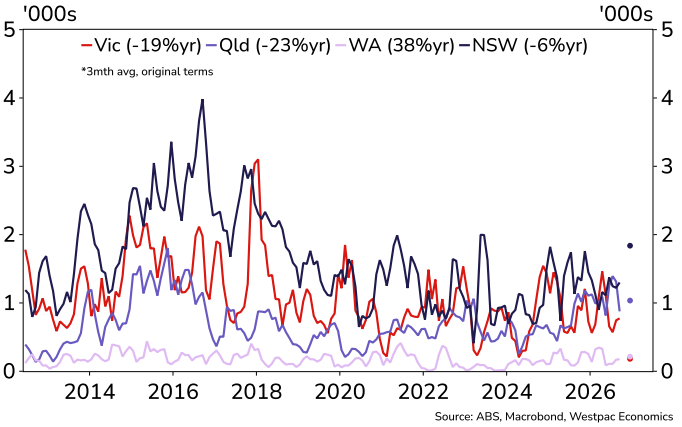
'High rise' approvals: by state



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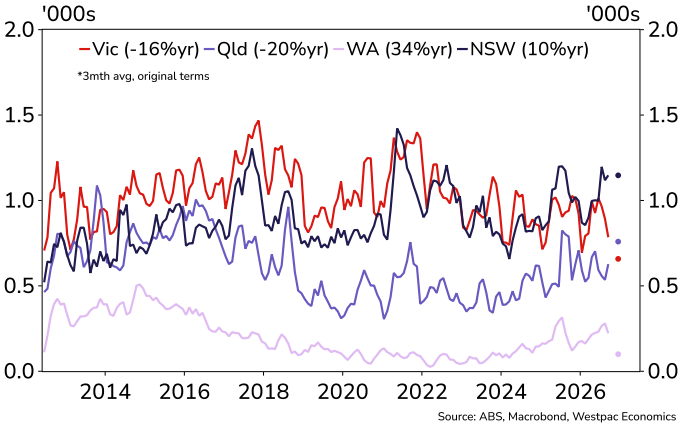
'Low-mid rise' approvals: by state



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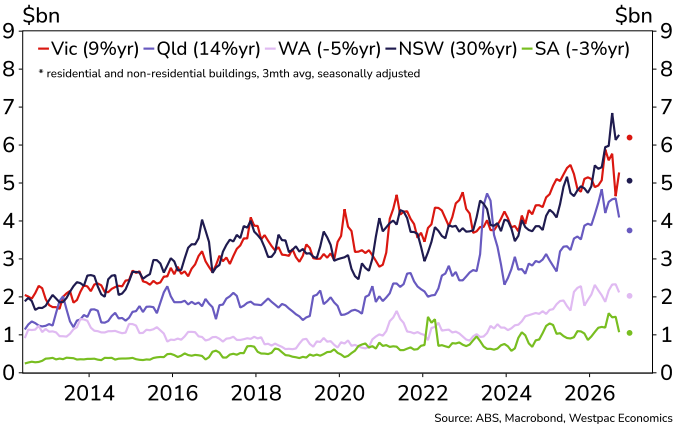
Total building approvals: by state



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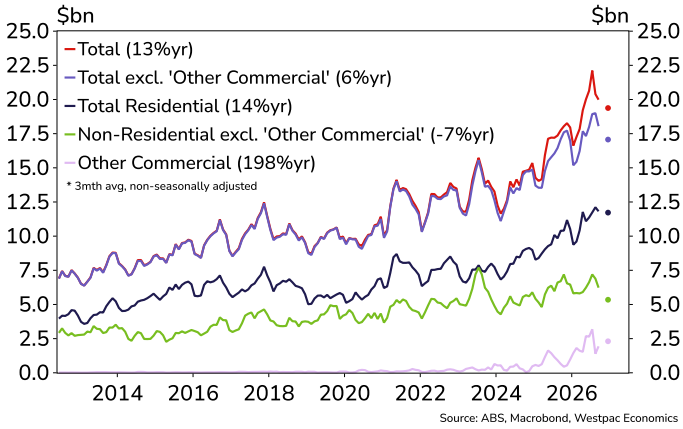

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11 November 2026

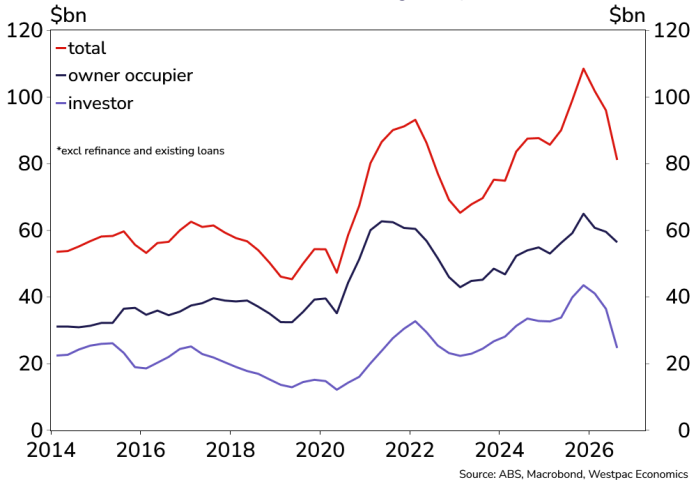
AUSTRALIAN DWELLING FINANCE BULLETIN

Steep fall

Key points

- The value of new dwelling finance approvals excl. refinance dropped 15.5%qtr, the biggest quarterly decline on records going back to 1991. Annual growth swung to –18.1%yr. While the decline was widely expected, it was larger than the median forecast of -8.5% and Westpac's forecast of –10%.
- The quarterly drop was mostly driven by lower volumes: total loan numbers down 15%qtr (-21%yr). Smaller average loan size contributed a further 0.5ppts to the value decline in the quarter.
- Investors were the primary driver, volumes in this segment down over 30%qtr and the value of new loans off by nearly a third.
- Borrowing by owner occupiers significant but somewhat milder declines, both the volume and value of new loans down 5.3%qtr.
- More weakness looks likely for Q4.

New finance approvals by segment: value



Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

Q3 new dwelling finance: –15.5%qtr, –18.1%yr

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Bigger than expected investor pull back

Matthew Hassan
Head of Australian Macro–Forecasting

The value of new dwelling finance approvals fell steeply in Q3, a 15%qtr drop to be down 25% year to date. The quarterly fall was the largest since the series began in 1991 while the fall over the last nine months is on a par with the 2022 downturn, which was the largest on record. The outcome was significantly weaker than the consensus forecast of an 8.5% drop. The downturn reflects the combined impact of rising interest rates and major housing-related tax policy changes announced at the May budget which have hit investor loans for the purchase of existing dwellings particularly hard.

The detail shows volumes were the main driver, the number of new loans dropping 15%qtr with the average loan size accounting for 0.5ppts of the quarterly decline in the total value of new loans.

The segment split showed a 5.3%qtr fall in new owner occupier loan approvals and a whopping 30% drop in new investor loans. Within the latter, the number of investor loans for the purchase of existing dwellings (which no longer receive 'negative gearing' and capital gains tax concessions) fell 35.6%qtr and are down by a half over the year to date. In contrast, the number of investor loans for the construction or purchase of newly built dwellings (which are still eligible for concessions) declined 8.7%qtr and 8.5% year-to-date. This segment now accounts for 27.6% of all investor loans, up from 17% late last year.

Owner-occupier loans reflected the wider influence of interest rate and market uncertainty. The detail here shows a more pronounced 8.6%qtr drop in first home buyer numbers, a more interest rate sensitive segment. High construction costs also look to be a factor with the number of owner occupier loans for the construction and purchase of newly built dwellings down 11.9%qtr. Lending for land purchases and renovations also declined 12.9%qtr in value terms.

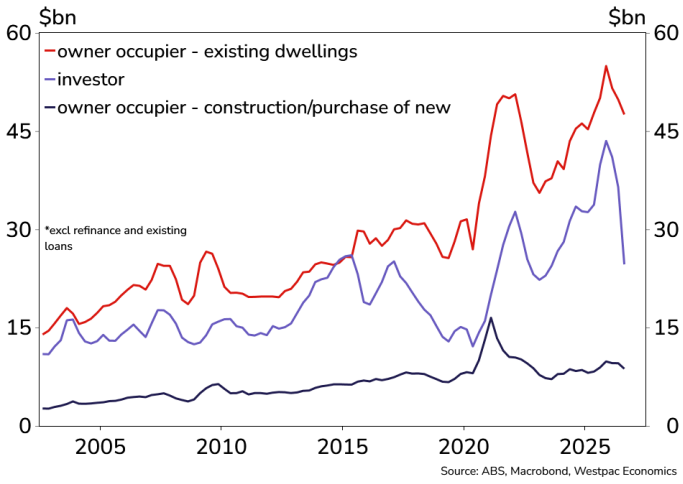
Today's results were weaker than expected with a bigger pull-back in investor activity than we assessed when the tax policy changes were announced back in May. Some of this may be an overshoot with uncertainty about policy changes and the wider price correction discouraging investors who might otherwise have considered purchasing even without the tax benefits. That said, conditions look far from conducive for even a muted bounce near term. More weak reads look likely for the final quarter of 2026.

Dwelling finance: Q3 2026

		%chg qtr		% chg yr	
	latest	Jun	Sep	Jun	Sep
Number ('000s)					
Owner–occupiers	76.6	-4.0	-5.3	-1.7	-9.8
Investors	35.3	-12.0	-30.6	2.4	-38.5
Total dwelling finance^	**111.9**	**-7.2**	**-15.0**	**-0.2**	**-21.4**
Value ($bn)					
Owner–occupiers	56.5	-2.0	-5.3	5.9	-4.6
Investors	24.7	-11.2	-32.3	7.8	-38.1
Total dwelling finance	**81.2**	**-5.7**	**-15.5**	**6.6**	**-18.1**
Land and renovations	5.8	-6.2	-12.9	14.8	-10.6
Refinance	58.3	-0.5	-3.6	5.1	-3.6
Total housing incl. refinance	145.2	-3.9	-11.0	6.4	-12.5

* unless specified, all figures exclude land, additions and alterations, and refinance. Where specified, refinance is 'external' only, i.e. with a new lender.
^seasonally adjusted by Westpac.
Sources: ABS, Cotality, APM, Westpac Economics

New finance approvals by detailed segment



Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

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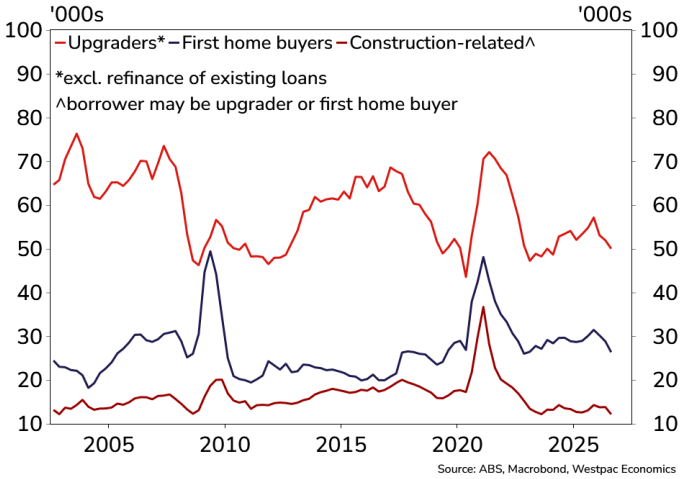
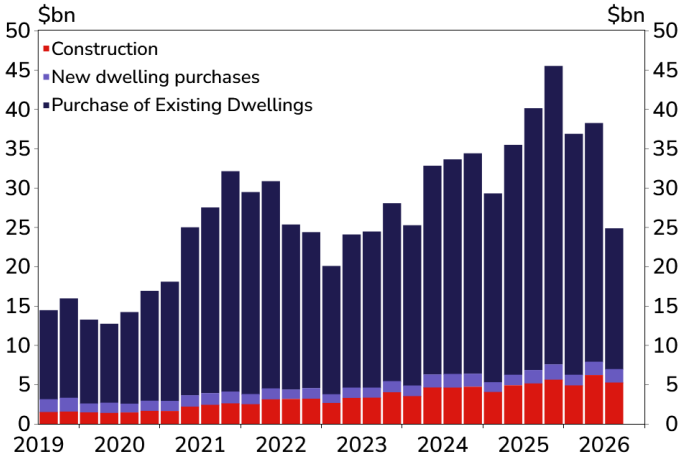
Owner occupier finance approvals (number)



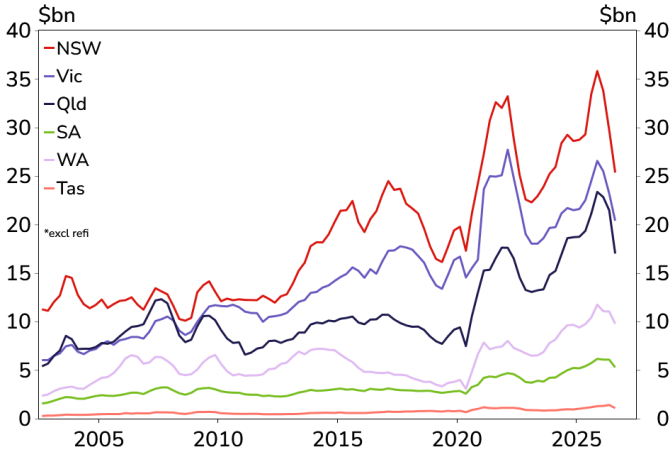
Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

Investor loan by purpose



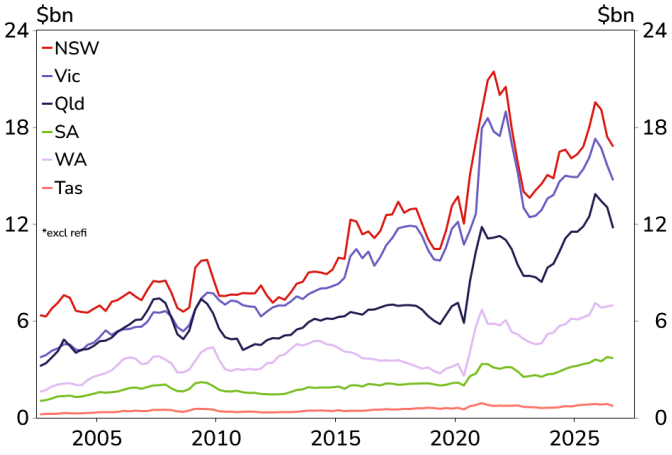
Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

Dwelling finance by state: total value



Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

Dwelling finance by state: owner occupier



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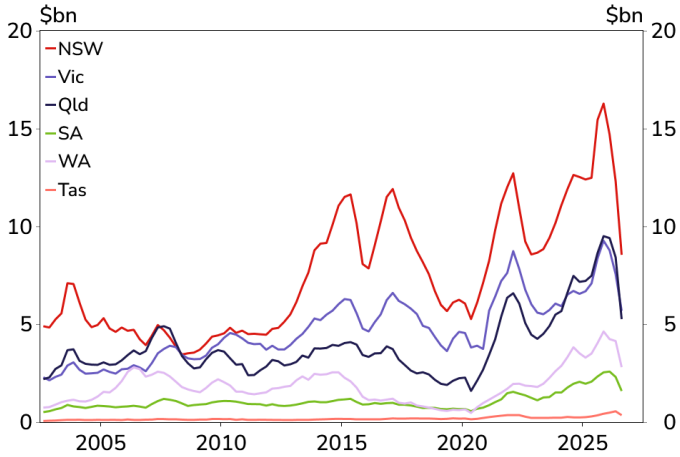
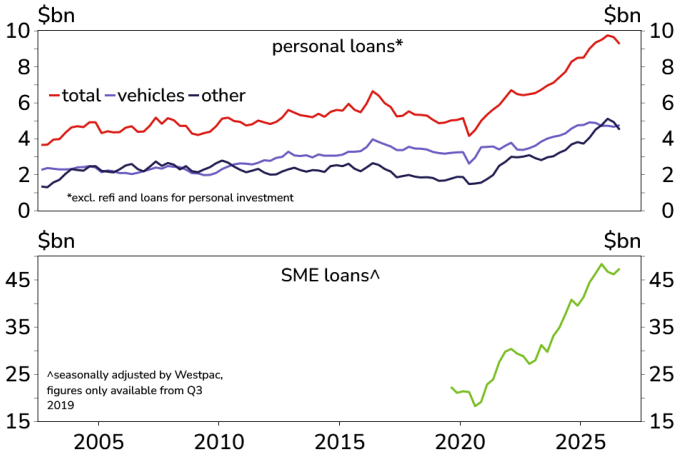
Dwelling finance by state: investor



Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

Dwelling finance as a share of housing credit



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4 November 2026

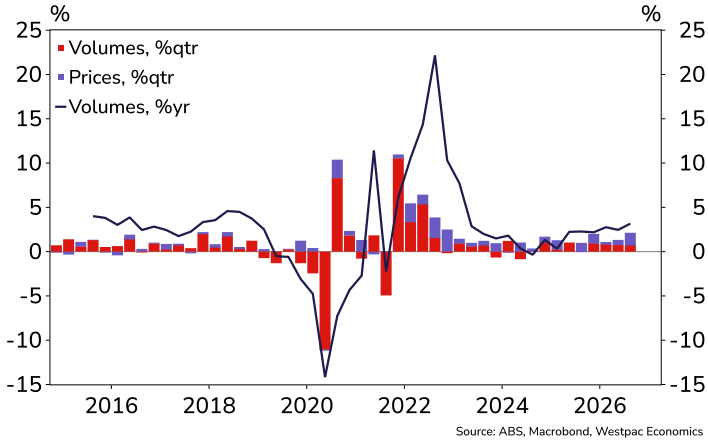
HOUSEHOLD SPENDING INDICATOR BULLETIN

Spending resilient despite headwinds

Key points

- Household spending rose 0.6%mth in September, returning to growth after August's brief decline. Q3 spending increased 2.1%qtr, while volumes rose a more subdued 0.7%qtr, pointing to a sharp acceleration in price growth through the quarter.
- Services spending rebounded and goods spending remained supportive. Non-discretionary spending outperformed discretionary categories, with higher fuel spending providing significant support.
- In real terms, spending growth over the quarter was led by transport but with most other categories also recording gains. All states except Tasmania recorded positive volume growth in Q3, led by WA and Victoria.
- Today's volumes outcome was broadly in line with expectations and consistent with our consumption outlook ahead of the Q3 National Accounts (due 2 December).

Quarterly spending volumes and prices



Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

Q3 real household spending: 0.7%qtr, 3.2%yr

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Spending returns to growth in September

Luka Belobrajdic
Economist

The monthly household spending indicator rose 0.6%mth in September (nominal), exceeding both Westpac and market expectations. We had anticipated a 0.5%mth contraction (on the basis of a softer read on vehicle sales in the month), while the market had pencilled in a 0.2%mth rise. Today's result instead marks a return to growth following August's brief contraction (revised down 0.1ppt to –0.1%mth), with annual growth strengthening to 6.8%yr. For Q3 as a whole, nominal spending rose 2.1%qtr, the strongest quarterly result since the December quarter of 2022. In real terms, volumes increased a more subdued 0.7%qtr, pointing to a sharp acceleration in price growth through the quarter.

Non-discretionary spending outperforms

By broad category, services spending more than reversed last month's decline, rising a solid 1.1%mth (+6.8%yr). Goods spending held around its recent pace, increasing 0.3%mth (+6.7%yr). Discretionary spending returned to growth in September, rising 0.3%mth (+6.9%yr), although this failed to fully unwind August's decline.

The relative strength in non-discretionary spending observed last month continued into September, with the category rising 1.2%mth (+6.5%yr). While the headline result was stronger, the breakdown aligns with findings from our **Westpac–DataX Card Tracker**, and **Westpac-DataX Consumer Panel** which show discretionary goods continuing to underperform other categories (see here and here).

At the detailed level, transport and health led the gains, both rising 1.5%mth. The increase in transport spending was largely attributable to higher fuel spending, up 5.4%mth, reflecting elevated fuel prices, with volumes down 2.2%mth. The ABS also noted higher spending on vehicle repairs and maintenance, while domestic air travel increased as households travelled to attend major sporting events. Recreation & culture rose 0.8%mth, while miscellaneous goods & services (+0.6%mth), hotels, cafes & restaurants (+0.5%mth), and clothing & footwear (+0.1%mth) also recorded gains.

Partially offsetting these increases, food spending declined 0.1%mth, while furnishings & household equipment fell 0.2%mth, likely reflecting the ongoing weakness in housing turnover (see here). Alcoholic beverages & tobacco recorded the largest decline, falling 0.7%mth.

State outcomes were positive across the board in September. WA led the gains, rising 1.1%mth and reversing last month's decline. Victoria also rebounded (+1.0%mth), while Queensland (+0.6%mth), SA (+0.6%mth), Tasmania (+0.5%mth) and NSW (+0.3%mth) all recorded increases.

Household spending indicator – September 2026

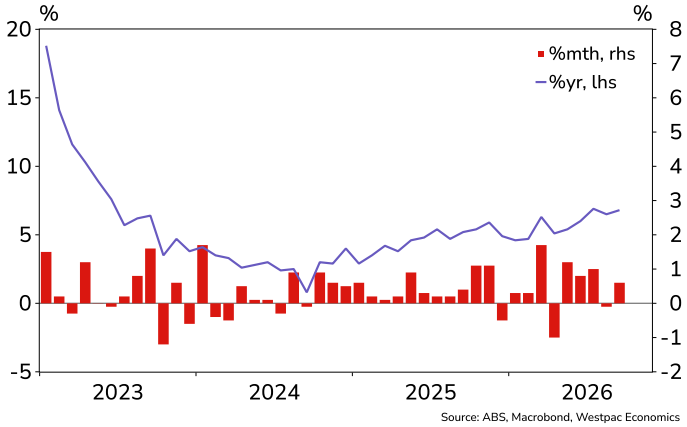
	$bn	% chg mth		% chg yr	
	Sep-25	Jun-25	Sep-25	Jun-25	Sep-25
sa	82.61	-0.1	0.6	6.5	6.8
trend	82.37	0.5	0.4	6.2	6.0

Chained volumes – Q3 2026

	real $bn	% chg qtr		% chg yr	
	Q3	Q2	Q3	Q2	Q3
sa	234.56	0.7	0.7	2.5	3.2

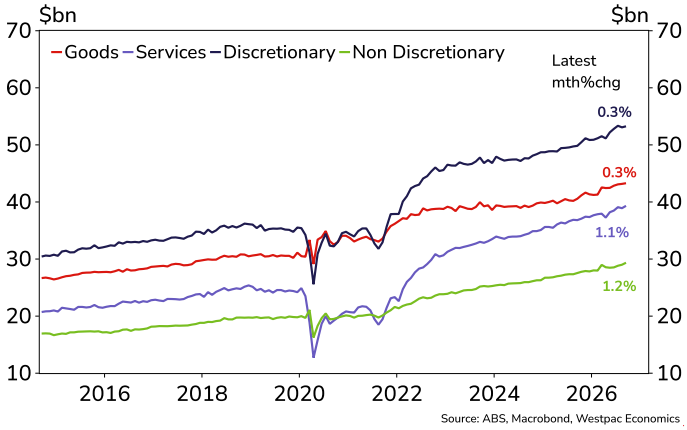
Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics.

Monthly Household Spending Indicator Growth



Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

Goods, services, discretionary & non-discret.



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Volume growth remains firm

Nominal spending rose a firm 2.1%qtr in Q3, while volumes increased a more subdued 0.7%qtr, matching the pace recorded in Q2. This implies a sharp acceleration in price growth to 1.4%qtr, from 0.6%qtr in Q2, and marks the strongest quarterly increase in prices since the December quarter of 2022. Through the year, volume growth strengthened to 3.2%yr, remaining well above the 1.8%yr average recorded through 2025.

Transport led gains in volume terms, rising 1.6%qtr, likely partly reflecting base effects in air travel following disruptions associated with the Middle East conflict in the June quarter. Clothing & footwear (+1.2%qtr), health (+1.1%qtr), miscellaneous goods & services (+1.1%qtr), food (+0.5%qtr), recreation & culture (+0.5%qtr), and furnishings & household equipment (+0.1%qtr) also recorded increases. Hotels, cafes & restaurants spending declined 0.1%qtr in volume terms, while alcoholic beverages & tobacco was the main drag, falling 1.2%qtr.

Most states recorded real spending growth over the quarter, led by WA (+1.4%qtr), Victoria (+0.9%qtr), NSW (+0.5%qtr), Queensland (+0.5%qtr) and SA (+0.4%qtr). Tasmania lagged its state peers, recording a 0.1%qtr decline.

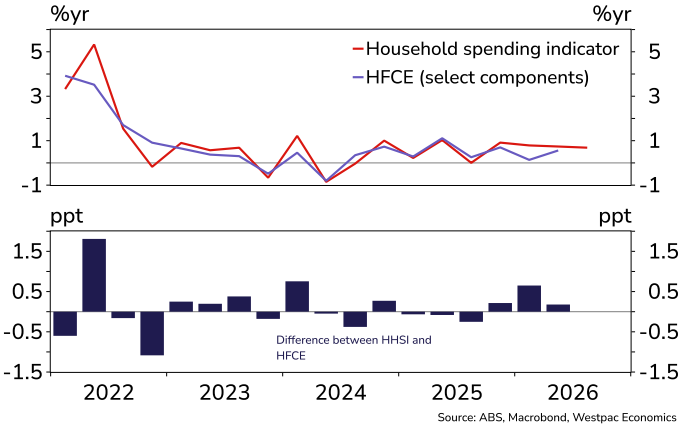
Conclusion

The household spending indicator provides a useful guide to around two-thirds of total consumer expenditure. Importantly, it excludes several major categories included in the National Accounts measure of real household consumption, including rents and utilities.

Today's volumes outcome was broadly in line with our expectations, with Westpac anticipating around a 0.6%qtr rise in Q3, and remains consistent with our view on consumption ahead of the Q3 National Accounts (due 2 December). However, this will likely be the high water mark for spending. The renewed deterioration in global energy markets and the cumulative effect of four rate increases over the first three quarters of the year are likely to weigh more heaveily on household spending in Q4.

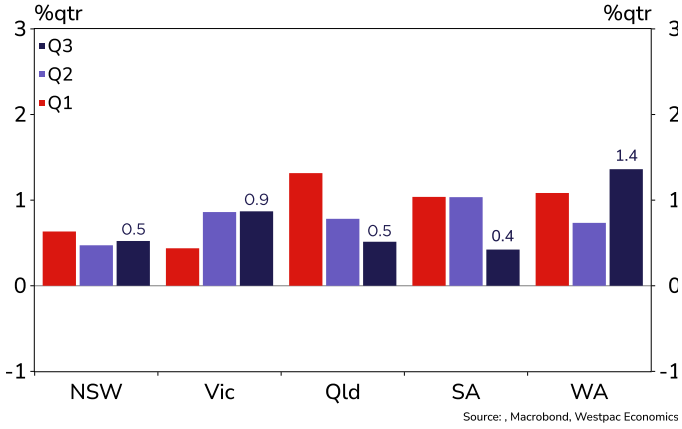
Looking further ahead, households will continue to face a restrictive monetary policy environment, with the RBA delivering an additional rate increase at yesterday's November meeting (see here). Combined with persistent consumer pessimism, ongoing cost-of-living pressures (see here) and a housing downturn impacting household wealth, spending looks set to slow further in 2027.

Household spending indications vs nat accs



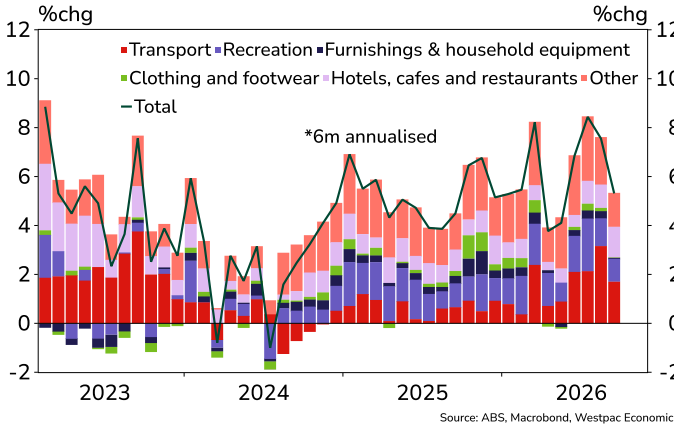
Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

Household spending volumes



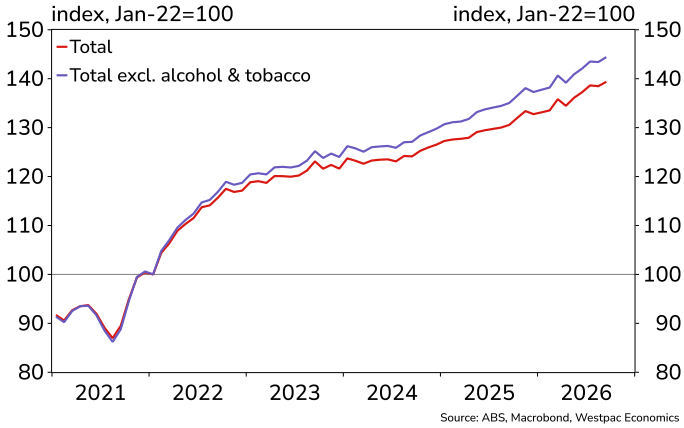
Source: , Macrobond, Westpac Economics

Contribution to growth by category: nominal



Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economic

Nominal spending excluding alch & tobacco



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First Impressions: NZ labour market surveys, September quarter 2026

#labour #newzealand

By Michael Gordon
Senior Economist, Westpac NZ

09:01 November 04 2026

Share

The unemployment rate rose to 5.7% in the September quarter, against expectations for a small decline. Spare capacity in the labour market is keeping wage pressures subdued.

Unemployment rate: 5.7% (prev: 5.6%, Westpac: 5.5%, RBNZ: 5.5%, mkt: 5.5%)

Employment change: -0.1% (prev: +0.3%, Westpac: +0.5%, RBNZ: +0.3%, mkt: +0.4%)

Participation rate: 70.4% (prev: 70.6%, Westpac: 70.8%, RBNZ: 70.6%, mkt: 70.7%)

Labour costs (private sector): +0.5% (prev: +0.7%, Westpac: +0.5%, RBNZ: +0.4%, mkt: +0.5%)

The September quarter surveys pointed to ongoing softness in New Zealand's labour market. The unemployment rate rose from 5.6% to 5.7%, continuing an almost five-year run of increases. Employment was softer than expected, and wage growth remains subdued despite increasing cost-of-living pressures.

The Household Labour Force Survey (HLFS) showed a surprise 0.1% fall in employment in the September quarter, after a downwardly revised 0.3% increase in the June quarter. That went against the Monthly Employment Indicator (MEI) measure of filled jobs, which had suggested some upward momentum emerging in the jobs market (and notably, the HLFS measure had outpaced the MEI for the previous nine quarters). It was also softer than suggested by the business-focused Quarterly Employment Survey (QES), which recorded a 0.2% rise in full-time equivalent employees, a 0.1% rise in filled jobs and a 0.6% rise in hours paid.

The fall in HLFS employment was accompanied by a fall in labour force participation rate, from 70.6% to 70.4%. These co-movements are effectively a reversal of the surprisingly large increases that we saw in the June quarter, which we noted at the time were indicative of sampling error in the survey.

This is why we generally recommend focusing on the unemployment rate, as it's less vulnerable to sampling error. And in that respect, the message on the jobs market remains weak: to the extent that employment may be rising, it's still not fast enough to absorb the growth in the population (which is itself a fairly low bar, as net migration remains at a relatively low ebb).

The HLFS also recorded a sharp 1.6% fall in hours worked (although usual hours worked were down just 0.4%). This seems to have been influenced by Matariki – a floating holiday that was only introduced a few years ago, so will not be picked up by the seasonal adjustment. This may have also been responsible for a marked shift from full-time to part-time employment, as some people may have been pushed into the part-time category simply by virtue of only working four days during the survey week.

The Labour Cost Index (LCI) rose by 0.5% in the September quarter, in line with our expectations overall but a bit weaker in the details – private sector wages were up by 0.5%, while there was a surprisingly large 0.7% increase in public sector wages. There was a notable jump in the number of employers citing cost-of-living adjustments as a reason for increasing pay rates, although the size of those increases varied a great deal, with many substantially less than the headline inflation rate.

Overall, we think the details are soft from the RBNZ's perspective – an important consideration ahead of the 9 December Monetary Policy Statement, as there are few other major data releases between now and then. The unemployment rate is a more reliable signal than the employment measures, and the ongoing rise in unemployment points to more slack in the labour market than the RBNZ was hoping to see in an economy that has been growing for over a year now. The doves on the policy committee will be encouraged in their view that there is limited scope for headline inflation shocks to pass through into second-round effects.

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Week beginning 9 November 2026

AUSTRALIA & NEW ZEALAND WEEKLY

Analysis and forecasts for this week's key releases.

In this week's edition:

Economic Insight: RBA hikes cash rate to new high of 4.85%, a December pause likely.

The Week That Was: Whiplash.

Focus on New Zealand: No deals are done.

For the week ahead:

Australia: Westpac-MI Consumer Sentiment, business survey, dwelling finance approvals, RBA's Hunter and Baker speaking.

New Zealand: retail card spending, RBNZ's Conway speaking.

China: CPI, PPI, trade balance, current account, new loans.

Euro Area: Q3 GDP, trade balance.

United Kingdom: Q3 GDP, BoE Governor Bailey speaking.

United States: Veterans Day, CPI, PPI, small business optimism, inflation expectations.

Information contained in this report current as at 6 November 2026.

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RBA hikes cash rate to new high of 4.85%, a December pause likely

Luci Ellis
Chief Economist, Westpac Group

As expected, the RBA Monetary Policy Board (MPB) lifted the cash rate 25bps to 4.85% at its November meeting. This follows the increase at the previous (late-September) meeting and is a marked turnaround from the outlook back in August. The post-meeting media statement cited higher global energy prices resulting from the Middle East conflict, tighter domestic capacity pressures and an increase in inflation expectations for the decision.

However, the decision was a split vote, 6 votes to 3, a possibility we have flagged for some time. In the post-meeting media conference, Governor Bullock explained that the dissenting minority put more weight on the downside risks and did not see signs of wages growth picking up as much as the staff forecasts implied. Those members were reportedly more confident that slower growth would prevent higher inflation expectations becoming entrenched.

Financial conditions are restrictive and this is expected to bring inflation down over time. Because the RBA assesses the risks to the inflation outlook to still be skewed to the upside, the outlook for coming meetings will still be for a decision between holding and hiking. But we note that the post-meeting statement omitted September's language "including increasing the cash rate target further if needed" from the commitment to do what is necessary to get inflation down.

In the post-meeting media conference, the Governor commented that after five hikes, this is probably a good time to "take stock". Together with the dissents, we read this as confirming our current view that the MPB will keep rates on hold in December. There is also considerable data flow between now and then, which could go either way, including the Q3 national accounts.

Similarly, a lot could happen between now and February, but we see it as the next most likely timing for a hike, should one eventuate. We still see that as a risk rather than a base case.

Revised forecasts published in the accompanying Statement on Monetary Policy (SMP) show underlying inflation lingering around current rates for longer. This contrasts with the previous SMP forecasts in August, which showed trimmed mean inflation returning to the 2–3%yr target range by late 2027 and a little below the 2.5%yr target midpoint in 2028. We note, however, that the conditioning assumptions on oil prices, which are based on futures prices, were at a local peak at the time the forecasts were finalised.

The RBA's GDP growth forecasts for 2027 and 2028 were both revised down –0.3%pts to 1.3% for 2027 and 1.5% in 2028, despite an upward revision to the near term. This is well below even the RBA's downbeat view of potential output growth. Within the GDP aggregate, recent misses and leading indicators have required upward revisions to the near-term outlooks for business and dwelling investment, and downside revisions to public demand. These revisions were offset further out with downward revisions to the 2028 outlook for business and dwelling investment and an upward revision to public demand. Household consumption forecasts were revised down across most of the profile.

"RBA lifts cash rate 25bps to 4.85% in split vote, citing "broadly based" domestic inflation pressures, Middle East conflict and AI boom."

With the unemployment rate already at 4.7% in August and September – a rate the RBA did not forecast until end-2027 in its August SMP forecasts – the RBA has lifted its unemployment forecast to show a peak of 5.1% in at end-2028, the end of the forecast horizon. This largely reflects stronger labour supply, with forecasts for employment growth essentially unchanged. We have repeatedly flagged that cost-of-living pressures are likely to keep people in the labour force and thus boost the participation rate. The RBA had previously not factored this adequately into its forecasts but acknowledged in the SMP that this mechanism had kept participation higher than it had expected at the time of the August SMP.

However, because inflation surprised to the upside recently, this additional labour supply has had no bearing on the RBA's assessment of capacity pressures. The RBA assesses the domestic economy to still be a little tight, and tighter than previously judged. The RBA's framework for assessing the degree of spare capacity or tightness in the economy necessarily translates an upside surprise on inflation (or unit labour costs) into a conclusion that the economy must be tighter than previously judged. Indeed, the RBA's estimate of the NAIRU (unemployment rate consistent with inflation stable at target) has been revised up to 4.75%.

The RBA highlighted that elevated inflation expectations may be contributing to higher realised inflation. Consumer inflation expectations have started to lift again but remain below where they peaked earlier this year. However, the RBA appears

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to be putting more attention on the inflation expectations of firms and the frequency of mentions of pricing in their liaison program. This is putting a lot of weight on proprietary information that is not clearly validated by other, longer-running data sources.

The AI boom is heavily cited in the SMP and other post-meeting communication. The RBA has lifted its forecasts for major trading partners, especially high-income Asian economies that are the centre of high-tech manufacturing. Demand for AI-related goods is also cited as a driver of both global and domestic inflation. And although the RBA has revised up its near-term forecasts for business investment on the back of strong data centre activity, it is working on the assumption that Australia does not become 'a significant regional hub for data centres'. Nor does it allow for any boost to productivity trends from the technology, even in 2028. This is a very different view of the risks from AI than the RBNZ expressed last week. For the RBA, it is all about inflation, a little bit about pressure on domestic construction resources, and nothing about either an ugly unwind of the current financing boom or a future productivity dividend.

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Cliff Notes: whiplash

Elliot Clarke, Head of International Economics
Ryan Wells, Economist

In Australia, the RBA delivered another 25bp rate increase at its November meeting, taking the cash rate to 4.85%. The move was widely expected, reflecting the Board's continued concern around inflation following the recent run higher in global energy prices, firmer domestic capacity pressures and signs that inflation expectations have edged up. Inflation is now not expected to return to the mid-point of the target band until mid-2028. This is despite weaker growth expectations and the unemployment rate trending up to 5.1% by end-2028 on the RBA's forecasts.

Importantly, though, the decision was not unanimous, with three members preferring to remain on hold given downside risks to activity and the restraining influence of slower growth. Governor Bullock's suggestion that it was time to "take stock" after five rate increases also struck a less hawkish note, while the statement dropped September's explicit reference to raising rates further "if needed". In our view, February represents the next plausible opportunity for another hike, but we see this only as a risk.

Policy's effect on housing is becoming increasingly visible. Cotality home prices fell a further 1.2% in October to now be 6.7% below March's peak. The cumulative price decline is approaching the scale of previous housing corrections but appears to have regained momentum after September's rate increase. Dwelling approvals saw a 5.1% headline gain in September, but this was driven by volatile unit approvals while detached house approvals fell sharply, suggesting higher rates and the established-market downturn are beginning to weigh on the construction pipeline.

Official data on nominal household spending meanwhile rose 0.6% in September and 2.1% for Q3; however, much of the recent acceleration looks to be price-driven, particularly for fuel. Real spending volumes expanded by a much more modest (but still solid) 0.7% in Q3.

The Westpac-DataX Consumer Panel provides a granular look at income, spending and saving flows. The latest update suggests that, beneath the resilient headline story, households are increasingly being squeezed, particularly those with low savings buffers. With another rate increase now delivered, housing wealth declining and sentiment weak, Q3 increasingly looks like the high-water mark for growth in consumer spending.

Lastly for Australia, in September the goods trade surplus widened sharply to $2.8bn, with non-monetary gold trade yet again adding considerable noise month-to-month. The most notable development was another exceptionally strong result for data-processing equipment imports, taking the Q3 total to $11.1bn. This is another clear marker of the scale of Australia's data-centre investment boom, which should feature prominently in both business investment and imports in the Q3 National Accounts.

"The RBA and Bank of England both tightened policy this week, in part due to price pressures emanating from the Middle East."

Offshore, the world has been focused on the US mid-term elections. In the House, Senate and a series of State Governor races, the Democrats experienced resounding victory. Come 2027, the Democrats will have a comfortable majority in both houses of Congress and are expected to make use of this strength to respond to voter concerns, particularly over cost-of-living pressures. The election result also limits President Trump's ability to fund an extended military action against Iran. Notably, both immediately before and after the election, President Trump and the administration have exhibited a greater interest in furthering negotiations with Iran. It is therefore not a surprise that Brent oil has backed off its most recent highs around USD118 last Friday, although the scale of the drop to near USD93 yesterday is arguably too optimistic. Brent has since traded back up to above USD99, still 16% below Friday's peak.

While the initial reaction to the US election result was a robust broad-based rally in major equity indexes, concerns over the potential for tighter regulation of AI and the related infrastructure buildout jolted US equities lower overnight – the Nasdaq falling 5.5% and S&P500 4.4%, both a multiple of the prior session's gains. That said, US term interest rates and FOMC rate expectations have also been scaled back; so, while tech may come under greater scrutiny, a foundation for better outcomes across the rest of the US economy may become evident in time. US data out this week continued to suggest their economy is in robust health overall. And, if tensions in the Middle East abate, the FOMC's concerns over US inflation should subside. Gaining enough comfort for the FOMC to not hike in December is a high bar, but the probability of further hikes in 2027 should continue to fall.

Turning then to the UK, the Bank of England raised Bank Rate by 25bps to 4.00% at their November meeting as expected. On the Bank's baseline expectation, UK inflation is forecast to rise from 3.5%yr at September to 5.00% by mid-2027. Activity data has also surprised to the upside in recent months, though "there remains limited evidence of knock-on effects on other prices and wages".

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In the press conference, Governor Bailey recognised the nascent improvement in energy price pressures over the past 48 hours and the effectiveness of monetary policy but also conveyed that "Unless progress towards resolving the conflict is made, or there is other news which softens the risk to inflationary pressures, a further increase in Bank Rate may be warranted". Governor Bailey's tone and comments made in the minutes by other Committee members did not suggest this was a decision that needs to be made in December, but rather a risk to be judged as additional information is received. This points to further tightening being more likely in early 2027 than before, and only if conditions / risks warrant.

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No deals are done

Michael Gordon
Senior Economist

This week's developments underscore our message that a rate hike at the RBNZ's December meeting is far from a done deal. New Zealand's labour market remains softer than expected, and that will be noted by those on the policy committee who question the extent of second-round inflation pressures. The rout in the US mid-term elections has also taken significant heat out of oil prices for now, although it's unclear whether that situation will hold through to next month. Our view on the endpoint for this OCR cycle remains unchanged, but there's a growing risk that the RBNZ could slow the pace of tightening in the new year.

The September quarter labour market surveys pointed to ongoing softness in the jobs market. The unemployment rate rose from 5.6% to 5.7%, continuing a four-year run of increases, and reaching its highest level since 2015. Employment was softer than expected, and wage growth remains subdued despite increasing cost-of-living pressures.

The Household Labour Force Survey (HLFS) showed a surprise 0.1% fall in employment in the September quarter, after a downwardly revised 0.3% increase in the June quarter. That went against the Monthly Employment Indicator (MEI) measure of filled jobs, which had suggested some upward momentum emerging in the jobs market (and notably, the HLFS measure had outpaced the MEI for the previous nine straight quarters).

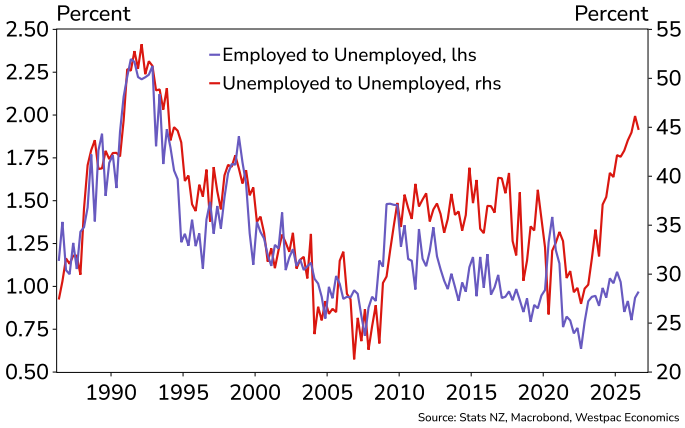
The fall in HLFS employment was accompanied by a fall in the labour force participation rate from 70.6% to 70.4%. These co-movements essentially reversed the surprisingly large increases that we saw in the June quarter, which we had suggested at the time were more likely due to sampling error in the survey rather than a genuine surge.

We generally recommend focusing on the unemployment rate, which is less vulnerable to sampling errors – and the message here is one of softness. Our best interpretation is that, to the extent that jobs are growing, it's not fast enough to absorb the growth in the population (which itself is a fairly low bar, as net migration remains at a low ebb).

Even with the economy returning to growth over the last year or so, hiring activity has remained weak. This may be an ongoing legacy of employment trends in previous years. Businesses have told us that they felt burned by the severe skill shortages that developed over 2021-23, and looked to hold on to workers to the extent they could during the 2024-25 downturn. The flipside of this is that they may now find themselves overstaffed even as activity picks up again.

This shows up most strikingly in labour force transition rates. The rise in unemployment over the last few years has not been driven by an increase in job losses, but by accumulation of people who, once out of work, are finding it increasingly difficult to get back in again. That also extends to young people trying to enter the workforce for the first time – youth unemployment of around 25% is the highest in the history of the survey going back to 1986.

Labour force transition rates



Source: Stats NZ, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

The Labour Cost Index (LCI) rose by 0.5% in the September quarter, in line with our expectations overall but a bit weaker in the details – private sector wages were up by 0.5%, while there was a surprisingly large 0.7% increase in public sector wages. There was a notable jump in the number of employers citing cost-of-living adjustments as a reason for increasing pay rates – although the size of those increases varied a great deal, with many substantially less than the headline inflation rate.

Potential RBNZ implications

The labour market data was unequivocally weaker than expected by either us or the RBNZ. While likely not a gamechanger for the cycle overall, it will add ammunition to the arguments of the doves on the Monetary Policy Committee that a pause in interest rate rises will make sense soon – perhaps in December or early next year. It's likely the case that interest rate markets were over-pricing the odds of a hike at the 9 December MPS, so the subsequent pullback in pricing makes sense.

The message from the RBNZ in the October meeting was to be careful about pricing in "done deals", and that the outlook

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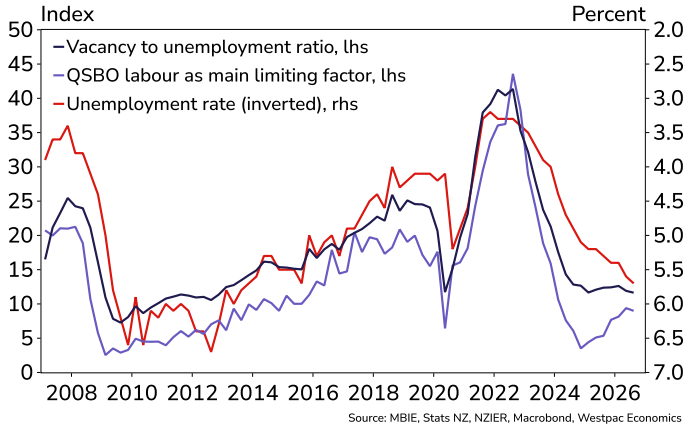
will be data-dependent. As we noted at the time, alongside measures of inflation expectations, the key domestic data to watch ahead of the RBNZ's 9 December meeting will be indicators of what is happening to excess capacity (the output gap), as this will be a key determinant of the Bank's assessment of the outlook for inflation over the coming year.

The RBNZ looks at a broad suite of indicators of labour market slack, although their research found that only four of them seem to have predictive power: the unemployment rate, the vacancy to unemployment ratio, the QSBO measure of labour as the main limiting factor to growth, and the rate of transition between jobs. The first three of these all pointed to a softening in the September quarter. (The fourth one is calculated from income tax data, so it's not publicly available and even the RBNZ receives it only with a lag.)

RBNZ measures of labour market tightness



Source: MBIE, Stats NZ, NZIER, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

In the eyes of the dovish MPC members, the softness in the labour market indicators will likely push in the direction of having greater comfort with the medium-term inflation outlook. The outcome of the election, with the possibility of a return to a dual inflation/employment mandate, could increase the prominence of these factors. This likely won't be an explicit factor in the RBNZ's reasoning at its December review, but it may be in the minds of individual MPC members.

That said, it's important to remember that in the RBNZ's forecasting framework, the GDP figures are the main determinant of excess capacity in the economy. The most recent GDP data tells us that the output gap probably narrowed a bit through the June quarter, mainly reflecting historical revisions. In light of the latest labour market figures, there may be some downside risk to the outlook for Q3 GDP – but there are conflicting indicators there, so it's not that clear.

At last month's surprise on-hold OCR decision, Governor Breman lamented that there was no protocol for the RBNZ to be able to signal how it was reading the economic data – in particular the softer than expected Q3 CPI print – ahead of the policy meeting. In that light, it will be interesting to see whether they use some already-scheduled speaking engagements to signal what they make of the labour market data. Top of mind is Chief Economist Conway's 10 November speech to the UBS Australasia Conference (pointedly titled "How is the NZ economy tracking"). Governor Breman is also speaking to the Institute of Directors on 19 November.

Our view remains that the December OCR hike is more likely than not. But there will be a clear debate to be had between the MPC hawks and doves, and it may again come down to a vote. We still expect a 4% peak in the OCR for this cycle, but the time taken to get there could be more flexible. Takes along the lines of "3% is the terminal rate" seem rather hasty on the basis of a single data release.

Aside from how the Committee interprets the labour market data, the key considerations in December will be: the RBNZ's surveys of inflation expectations by households and businesses; whether the US mid-term elections lead to a sustained de-escalation in the Middle East and a pullback in oil prices; and whether developments in the AI space exacerbate some MPC members' concerns about the global economic environment.

And then of course there's the result of the General Election, with voting closing on Saturday evening. The actual formation of a government is likely to take weeks of negotiation, so the outcome may not be known by the 9 December MPS but at least the range of possibilities should be clearer. We'll publish our initial thoughts on the election results early on Monday morning.

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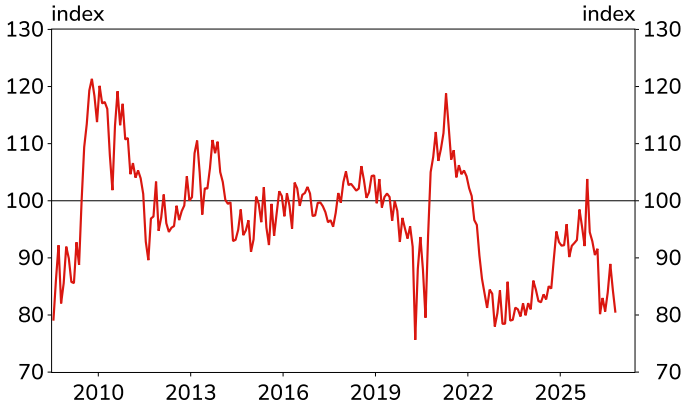
AUS: Nov Westpac-MI Consumer Sentiment (index)

Nov 10, Last: 84.4

Consumer sentiment fell 4.7% to 80.4 in Oct, returning to the deeply pessimistic levels seen earlier in the year. Responses over the course of the survey week showed a very sharp deterioration after the RBA rate hike.

The Nov survey is in the field over the week ended Nov 7. Interest rates will again factor with the RBA raising the cash rate by another 25bps to 4.85%, an 18yr high. Average pump prices also pushed higher, the national average just under $2.40/litre, while the housing market downturn has continued to broaden and deepen. The US mid-term election results may have some effects on sentiment locally as well.

Consumer Sentiment Index



Source: Melbourne Institute of Applied Economic & Social Research, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

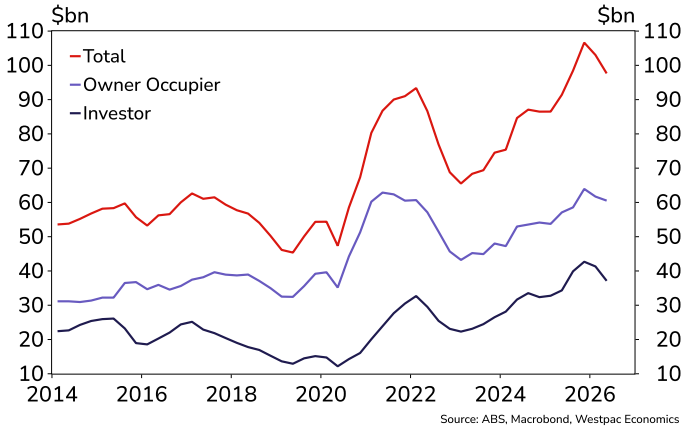
AUS: Q3 Housing Finance Approvals (%qtr)

Nov 11 Last: –5.2, Westpac f/c: –10
Market f/c: –8.5, Range: –15 to –5

The total value of housing finance approvals fell The value of new dwelling finance approvals excl. refinance fell 5.2%qtr, the largest quarterly drop in three years. Annual growth eased to 7.3%yr. The weakness was accounted for mainly by lower lending volumes: loan numbers were down 4.0%qtr (–0.6%yr), while average loan size also contributed negatively.

Q3 is expected to see an even bigger decline with the full impact of interest rate rises and tax policy changes showing through. The value of both loan enquiries and turnover fell by around 10% in the quarter. We expect total finance approvals to show a 10% drop as well, with investor loan approvals likely to be down 16%qtr and owner occupier approvals down 6%qtr.

Dwelling Finance Approvals



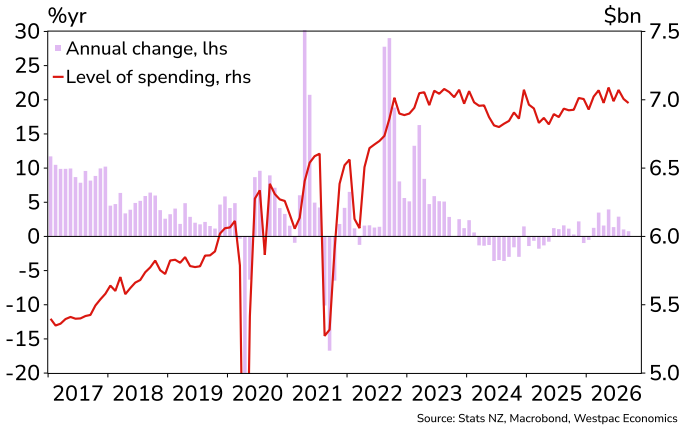
Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

NZ: Oct Retail Card Spending (%mth)

Nov 12, Last: –0.4, Westpac f/c: 1.4

We're forecasting a 1.4% rise in retail spending in October. While that would be a solid increase, it's in large part due to the 11% rise in petrol prices over the past month. Stripping out fuel spending, we're forecasting a 0.6% rise in core spending categories. Core spending has been very choppy recently, and the increase we're assuming follows falls in the past few months. A result in line with our expectations would leave the trend in core spending relatively flat since the start of this year with the rise in fuel prices weighing on spending in other areas.

NZ retail card spending



Source: Stats NZ, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

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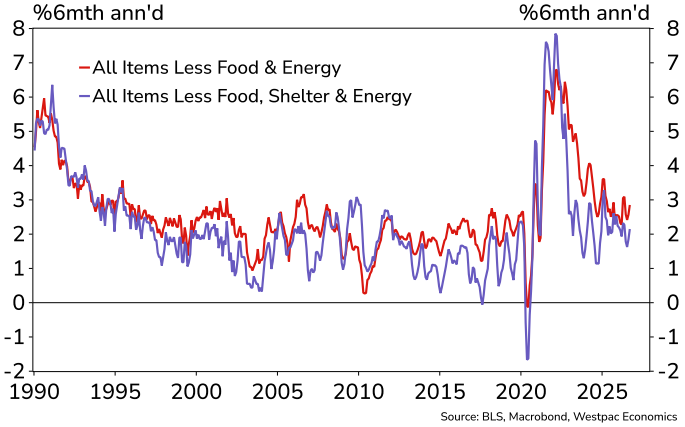
US: Oct CPI (%mth)

Nov 11, Headline, Last: 0.6, Market f/c: 0.3, Westpac f/c: 0.4

US consumer prices rose by 0.6% in September, although half of the gain was due to energy inflation, with core prices instead up 0.3%. Over the year, prices were reported to have risen 3.7%yr overall and 2.6%yr excluding food and energy. Constructively, ex food, energy and shelter, annual inflation met the FOMC's medium-term target of 2.0%yr.

Come October, energy price pressures are set to recede given the pre-election run higher in oil prices came late in the month. A softer print for shelter is also likely to moderate core momentum. We see a 0.4% gain for the headline measure and a 0.2% result for core inflation as most probable. Looking to 2027, disinflation is expected to continue at a measured pace towards the medium-term target.

Ex shelter, core inflation at target



Source: BLS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

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What to watch

	For	Data/Event	Unit	Last	Market f/c	Westpac f/c	Risk/Comment
Mon 09							
Aus		RBA Chief Economist Hunter	–	–	–	–	Speaking at UBS Australasia Conference, 9:30am AEDT.
Chn	Oct	PPI	%ann	5.0	5.4	–	China's inflation remains supply–led ...
	Oct	CPI	%ann	0.9	0.8	–	... while consumer inflation is comparatively subdued.
	Oct	New Loans YTD	CNYbn	11520	11580	–	Credit growth continues to slow year–on–year ...
	Oct	M2 Money Supply	%ann	7.2	7.3	–	... note this data is due 9–14 November.
Eur	Nov	Sentix Investor Confidence	index	2.7	2.0	–	Has recovered from recent lows.
UK		BoE Governor Bailey	–	–	–	–	Speaking in Zurich.
US		Fedspeak	–	–	–	–	Goolsbee.
	Sep	Wholesale Inventories	%mth	0.6	0.6	–	Final estimate.
	Oct	NY Fed 1–Yr Inflation Expectations	%ann	3.9	3.8	–	Will test whether price concerns are easing.
Tues 10							
Aus	Nov	Westpac–MI Consumer Sentiment	index	80.4	–	–	Cost–of–living pressures bring about deep pessimism again.
	Oct	NAB Business Conditions	index	–1	–	–	Conditions are at their weakest since the pandemic.
NZ		RBNZ Chief Economist Conway	–	–	–	–	Speaking on the NZ economy at 11:15am AEDT.
Jpn	Sep	Household Spending	%ann	–3.1	–2.8	–	Household spending remains a weak link.
	Sep	Current Account Balance	¥bn	4062.0	3262.2	–	External accounts remain well supported.
Chn	Oct	Trade Balance	US$bn	133.5	127.0	–	Export growth has held up despite global headwinds.
US	Oct	NFIB Small Business Optimism	index	97.9	98.2	–	Small business confidence has struggled for momentum.
	Oct	CPI	%mth	0.6	0.3	0.4	Energy costs are driving headline inflation higher.
Wed 11							
Aus	Q3	Dwelling Finance Approvals	%qtr	–5.2	–8.5	–10	Even bigger decline in housing finance on the cards for Q3 ...
	Q3	Owner–Occupier Approvals	%qtr	–1.9	–	–6	... as interest rates and tax changes continue to impact ...
	Q3	Investor Approvals	%qtr	–10.2	–	–16	... investor loan approvals likely to fall more sharply.
US		Veterans Day	–	–	–	–	Stock markets open, bond markets closed.
Thu 12							
Aus	Nov	MI Inflation Expectations	%ann	5.3	–	–	Picking up once again.
		RBA MPB Member	–	–	–	–	Baker speaking at ARCA Credit Summit, 10:30am AEDT.
NZ	Oct	Retail Card Spending	%mth	–0.4	–	1.4	Higher fuel price boosting spending, core more moderate.
	Sep	Net Migration	no.	1530	–	–	Gradually trending higher with departures slowing.
Jpn		BoJ Board Member	–	–	–	–	Asada speaking in Nagasaki.
	Oct	PPI	%	–0.3	0.2	–	Upstream price pressures have moderated.
UK	Q3	GDP	%ann	0.5	0.7	–	The UK was the fastest–growing G7 economy in H1 2026.
US		Initial Jobless Claims	000s	189	195	–	Claims remain low and stable.
	Oct	Existing Home Sales	%mth	1.5	–3.3	–	Higher rates continue to weigh on housing demand.
		Fedspeak	–	–	–	–	Hammack, Goolsbee, Daly.
Fri 13							
NZ	Oct	Manufacturing PMI	index	56.5	–	–	Has remained firm in recent months.
Chn	Q3	Current Account Balance	US$bn	193.7	–	–	External strength remains an important growth support.
Eur	Q3	GDP	%qtr	0.4	0.4	–	Growth has proven resilient despite the energy shock.
	Sep	Trade Balance	€bn	–6.8	–	–	Higher imports from China are weighing on the trade balance.
US	Oct	PPI	%mth	1.3	0.4	–	Producer inflation is running at its fastest pace since 2022.
		Fedspeak	–	–	–	–	Williams, Daly, Jefferson.

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Economic & financial forecasts

Interest rate forecasts

Australia	Latest (6 Nov)	Dec–26	Mar–27	Jun–27	Sep–27	Dec–27	Mar–28	Jun–28	Sep–28	Dec–28
Cash	4.85	4.85	4.85	4.85	4.60	4.35	4.10	3.85	3.85	3.85
90 Day BBSW	4.93	4.95	4.95	4.80	4.55	4.30	4.10	3.95	3.95	3.95
3 Year Swap	4.71	4.90	4.85	4.75	4.65	4.55	4.45	4.35	4.30	4.25
3 Year Bond	4.69	4.90	4.85	4.75	4.65	4.55	4.45	4.35	4.30	4.25
10 Year Bond	5.02	5.20	5.15	5.10	5.05	5.05	5.00	5.00	5.00	5.00
10 Year Spread to US (bps)	17	15	15	15	15	10	0	–5	–10	–15
United States										
Fed Funds	3.875	4.125	4.125	4.125	4.125	4.125	3.875	3.625	3.625	3.625
US 10 Year Bond	4.85	5.05	5.00	4.95	4.90	4.95	5.00	5.05	5.10	5.15
New Zealand										
Cash	2.75	3.00	3.50	3.75	4.00	4.00	4.00	4.00	3.75	3.75
90 Day Bill	3.11	3.40	3.75	4.00	4.20	4.20	4.20	4.15	3.95	3.95
2 Year Swap	3.69	4.10	4.20	4.25	4.20	4.20	4.15	4.15	4.10	4.10
10 Year Bond	4.64	5.00	5.00	5.00	5.05	5.05	5.05	5.05	5.05	5.05
10 Year Spread to US (bps)	–20	–5	0	5	15	10	5	0	–5	–10

Exchange rate forecasts

	Latest (6 Nov)	Dec–26	Mar–27	Jun–27	Sep–27	Dec–27	Mar–28	Jun–28	Sep–28	Dec–28
AUD/USD	0.6902	0.72	0.72	0.73	0.73	0.73	0.73	0.72	0.72	0.72
NZD/USD	0.5566	0.56	0.58	0.61	0.63	0.64	0.64	0.64	0.65	0.65
USD/JPY	157.82	156	154	153	152	151	150	149	148	146
EUR/USD	1.1199	1.14	1.16	1.18	1.20	1.21	1.22	1.22	1.21	1.21
GBP/USD	1.3433	1.34	1.35	1.36	1.38	1.39	1.40	1.41	1.41	1.40
USD/CNY	6.6688	6.65	t6.60	6.50	6.45	6.40	6.35	6.35	6.30	6.30
AUD/NZD	1.2399	1.27	1.24	1.20	1.16	1.15	1.13	1.12	1.12	1.11

Australian economic forecasts

	2026				2027				Calendar years			
% change	Q1	Q2	Q3(f)	Q4(f)	Q1(f)	Q2(f)	Q3(f)	Q4(f)	2025	2026(f)	2027(f)	2028(f)
GDP %qtr	0.3	0.4	0.5	0.2	0.4	0.3	0.4	0.5	–	–	–	–
%yr end	2.5	2.1	2.2	1.5	1.6	1.5	1.4	1.6	2.6	1.5	1.6	2.4
Unemployment rate %	4.2	4.4	4.6	4.7	4.7	4.8	4.8	4.7	4.3	4.7	4.7	4.5
Wages (WPI) (sa) %qtr	0.8	0.8	1.0	0.8	0.8	0.8	0.8	0.8	–	–	–	–
%yr end	3.2	3.2	3.4	3.4	3.4	3.4	3.2	3.2	3.4	3.4	3.2	3.4
Headline CPI %qtr	1.4	0.6	1.3	1.3	0.4	0.5	1.0	0.5	–	–	–	–
%yr end	4.1	3.9	3.9	4.6	3.6	3.4	3.2	2.4	3.6	4.6	2.4	2.3
Trimmed Mean CPI %qtr	0.8	0.8	1.0	0.9	0.7	0.7	0.7	0.7	–	–	–	–
%yr end	3.5	3.6	3.7	3.5	3.3	3.3	3.1	2.9	3.3	3.5	2.9	2.4

New Zealand economic forecasts

	2026				2027				Calendar years			
% Change	Q1	Q2	Q3(f)	Q4(f)	Q1(f)	Q2(f)	Q3(f)	Q4(f)	2025	2026(f)	2027(f)	2028(f)
GDP %qtr	0.9	0.2	0.6	0.7	0.9	0.5	0.6	0.7	–	–	–	–
Annual avg change	0.9	1.7	2.1	2.4	2.4	2.5	2.6	2.6	0.3	2.4	2.6	3.0
Unemployment rate %	5.4	5.6	5.7	5.7	5.6	5.5	5.3	5.1	5.4	5.7	5.1	4.5
CPI %qtr	0.9	1.5	0.7	1.2	0.3	0.4	0.5	0.2	–	–	–	–
Annual change	3.1	4.1	3.7	4.3	3.7	2.5	2.3	1.4	3.1	4.3	1.4	1.9

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Week beginning 2 November 2026

AUSTRALIA & NEW ZEALAND WEEKLY

Analysis and forecasts for this week's key releases.

In this week's edition:

Economic Insight: RBA to hike in November, as inflation remains too high.

The Week That Was: Cliff Notes: the source and persistence of inflation.

Focus on New Zealand: A lesson to be learned.

For the week ahead:

Australia: RBA policy decision, Cotality home value index, household spending indicator, goods trade balance, dwelling approvals.

New Zealand: Q3 labour market surveys, building permits, LCI wage inflation.

China: Ratingdog manufacturing and services PMIs.

Euro Area: CPI, PPI, retail sales.

United Kingdom: BoE policy decision.

United States: nonfarm payrolls, enemployment rate, ISMs, UoM consumer Sentiment, trade balance.

Global: S&P Global manufacturing and services PMIs.

Information contained in this report current as at 30 October 2026.

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RBA to hike in November, as inflation remains too high

Luci Ellis
Chief Economist, Westpac Group

We reaffirm our expectation that the RBA Monetary Policy Board will again increase the cash rate at the November meeting. Today's inflation data and Senate testimony are the final pieces of information before the RBA Monetary Policy Board (MPB) meets next week. Recent data and communication have consistently pointed to the staff recommending an increase in the cash rate. We expect a majority of the external members to agree, though some members might dissent.

Inflation is above target, and above what the RBA's August forecasts implied. Some upside risks identified in August have partially materialised, particularly energy prices. The RBA is especially worried that above-target inflation will become embedded in people's expectations and pricing decisions. It will therefore deem that further policy tightening is needed.

The RBA has made it clear that it is down-weighting the recent easing in the labour market, even though this was more than it forecast. In today's opening statement to the Senate hearing, the Governor said, "Despite the unemployment rate recently rising a little more than we had expected, the labour market seems a little tighter than we had previously judged. The evidence for this is elevated underlying inflationary pressures. That is, when we exclude some of the large volatile price movements such as fuel we see inflationary pressure in areas that reflect domestic demand for goods and services." In the Senate, the Governor also said that they were not worried about the current pace of increase in unemployment.

Of course, this takes no account of the lagged relationship between the labour market and inflation. The argument is that if that measure of inflation last quarter was too high, it must therefore be that the labour market is too tight. Nor does it allow sufficiently for non-labour cost shocks, which business surveys indicate are the real issue. But whether this judgement by the RBA turns out to be right or not will not be revealed for some time, certainly not soon enough to change its mind before next week. And while some MPB members might have a more optimistic view about labour supply trends than the RBA staff, they are likely to be a minority.

The RBA is also relatively sanguine about the current downturn in the housing market. The Governor and other RBA officials are at pains to highlight that they do not target housing prices; nor should they. The RBA considers that most, though not all, of the current downswing is an expected effect of tighter monetary policy.

The question then turns to the future beyond November. While we still expect a hawkish tone in the RBA's communication until inflation has clearly turned down, further hikes beyond next week are not currently our base case. Clearly, though, the risks of another hike – most likely in February – have increased. Our current forecast for Q4 inflation would seem to give them cover for such a move. We note, however, that home-building costs in the CPI have undershot expectations in the past couple of months. This might imply a different view of the extent of domestic demand pressures than the RBA currently believes.

> **"We reaffirm our expectation that the RBA Monetary Policy Board will again increase the cash rate at the November meeting"**

However, a lot can happen in three months, as we have just seen. The conflict in the Middle East could escalate further, lifting energy prices beyond our current base case. It could also go the other way, though, if the US and Iran manage to strike a post-midterm-election deal. And as their counterparts in New Zealand highlighted today, one risk is that the global economy weakens suddenly. In the post-meeting statement, the RBNZ Monetary Policy Committee said, "the world economy could tip abruptly into a downturn causing weaker inflation over the medium term." This risk was something the RBNZ MPC thought could crystallise in the next six weeks. Whether on this timetable or something more drawn out, this possibility does not appear to be on the RBA's radar. Nor is it our base case, though we have previously worried that the AI financing boom could hit a wall quite suddenly.

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Cliff Notes: the source and persistence of inflation

Elliot Clarke, Head of International Economics
Ryan Wells, Economist
Illiana Jain, Economist

In Australia this week, all eyes were on the September CPI. Headline inflation rose 0.8% (4.3%yr) in the month, largely owing to a 9.4% jump in fuel prices and a seasonal surge in domestic and international holiday travel & accommodation. The underlying inflation pulse also proved hotter than anticipated for Q3 overall, up 1.0% (3.7%yr).

While some parts of the basket are seeing disinflation – housing in particular looks to be cooling faster than expected as builders lure sales with discounts – other components are still showing persistence. Highlighting this is market services ex volatiles, which the RBA watches closely as an indicator of price pressures related to domestic capacity. In Q3, this metric rose 1.2% (3.2%yr), and the monthly detail points to momentum holding up – in line with our expectations for another chunky read in Q4.

With inflation running well above the RBA's August forecasts, and some of the energy risks flagged then materialising, we continue to expect the Monetary Policy Board will deliver a 25bp rate hike to 4.85% in November. Beyond November, another rate hike in February is a risk, but is not currently part of our base case.

Across the Tasman, the RBNZ this week surprised market expectations for a 25bp rate hike, deciding instead to wait for further information before taking the next step with policy. The decision was made 4:3, with the Governor in the 'on hold' camp. A 25bp hike in December to 3.00% and further tightening in 2027 (Westpac NZ forecasts a peak of 4.00% in September) seems probable; however, each decision will depend on fuel prices, inflation expectations and evidence of second-round pricing pressures, along with the evolution of global economic risks.

In the US, the FOMC also held rates steady at its October meeting. Based on prior comments by key members, the decision was not a surprise, and neither were Governor Cook and Cleveland Fed President Hammack's dissents in favour of a 25bp hike. The Committee remains positive on economic activity, characterising it in the statement as "expanding at a strong pace" (an upgrade from "solid" in September). Chair Warsh also subsequently emphasised the breadth of economic growth outside of tech-related investment (evinced by Q3 GDP the day after; see below).

The Committee refrained from spotlighting key price risks in the statement. However, inflation "remains elevated" and the FOMC are determined to achieve a "timely" and sustainable return of annual inflation to 2.0%yr after 6 years above target. This guidance and the "accumulation of more information will help the Committee determine the policy stance" suggests another 25bp hike is likely in December. Thereafter, the FOMC will remain attentive to any broadening in inflation and related risks through 2027; although, in the absence of another shock, we expect them to remain on hold.

The Q3 GDP report certainly supported Chair Warsh's view on the breadth of growth, the 3.4% annualised gain for GDP benefitting from a 3.8% annualised increase in household consumption, 12.7% growth in non-residential investment as well as a robust increase in government spending. Notably though, the contribution from business investment was effectively offset by net exports' drag given most of the componentry related to AI infrastructure investment is imported. This is not to say that US firms won't benefit from the investment once complete, but simply that much of the initial return goes to the foreign businesses who provide the necessary capital equipment.

On consumption, the monthly PCE data implies downside risks remain for the consumer, the increase in nominal spending seen in the month requiring dissaving and, on a real basis, consumption flat in the month following a 0.5% gain in August. Cost-of-living pressures and uncertainty over the outlook is expected to see household consumption growth average around trend over the coming year, albeit with considerable volatility quarter to quarter. This should see PCE inflation slow back towards its 2.0%yr medium-term target as the FOMC desires, from 3.6%yr and 3.1%yr for the headline and core measures respectively as of September.

Across the Atlantic, the ECB also left its key policy rates unchanged in October. Of note from the meeting communications, energy prices continue to pose upside risks for inflation, but also downside risks for growth. "While the full effects of the energy shock are still unfolding, underlying inflation has remained broadly stable so far and wages do not show a material response". "Financing conditions have [also] tightened", "which is likely to weigh on inflation and growth". In the press conference, President Lagarde noted that, between the October and December meetings, a significant amount of new economic information will be released, allowing forecasts and risks assessments to be tested.

Based on the October meeting communications, we continue to expect a rate hike at the December meeting but believe this will be prove to be the last hike of the cycle. Note though, the spectrum of risks Europe faces is broad and skewed towards inflation in the near term, hence the Council's guidance will remain hawkish. President Lagarde also announced today that she will step down as ECB President in February ahead of the scheduled conclusion of her term next October.

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A lesson to be learned

Kelly Eckhold
Chief Economist NZ

The RBNZ delivered the biggest shock to markets outside of a crisis period in over 20 years this week by leaving the OCR unchanged. Markets had priced around a 98% probability of a 25bp increase, and all major domestic analysts concurred. After the CPI data the week earlier, we belatedly shifted our call to a hike despite plenty of good arguments in favour of the RBNZ sticking to its plan to pause. With the benefit of hindsight, too much weight was put on market pricing and short-term inflation drivers and not enough on the medium term. That's an important lesson to be learned.

The highlight of an action-packed week of central banking news was the unexpected decision of the RBNZ to leave the OCR at 2.75%, despite near unanimous analyst expectations and market pricing in favour of a 25bp hike. We had shifted sides from a hold to a hike just a week earlier, in the wake of a CPI outcome that was weaker than RBNZ expectations on the surface, but with some evidence of firm core inflation undertones.

While we clearly cannot claim to have gotten this call right, we always thought that the outcome was not the "done deal" that markets had priced in. For example, in our preview of the meeting we noted:

"We still think a more measured tightening approach is appropriate from here. Raising the OCR at every meeting until something 'breaks' could be a risky strategy if downside growth concerns crystalise."

And we saw a vote on the decision as very possible:

"A vote seems very possible as differences in view will likely remain among the MPC about how much the medium-term inflation outlook has really shifted in recent weeks."

The 4:3 vote that was ultimately required to bring the MPC to a decision is a testament to just how finely balanced the decision was. We had thought that the hike was perhaps around a 60-70% probability whereas the Record of Meeting implies something more like a 50:50 call.

In the final analysis, the RBNZ has merely followed through on the pause it signalled for this meeting back in the September Monetary Policy Statement. All MPC members continue to see a case for a higher OCR in time, but there are different views around the timing of those increases. Governor Breman noted that further interest rate increases remain likely in coming meetings but are conditional on the whether the outlook evolves in line with expectations. Indeed, the Governor noted in later comments to press that a December hike was a "high" probability and that the outlook remains for OCR "hikes" as the base case. This suggests that the RBNZ's view on the terminal OCR hasn't really shifted down from the 3.25% level presented back in September. And it may be reasonable to speculate, subject to data evolving as the RBNZ expects, that a modest upgrade in those forward OCR forecasts could be in the offing.

So how did we all get this so wrong? This outcome was a real shock given the historical record shows that over the history of the OCR the market has without exception correctly predicted a 25bp hike when the implied probability built into markets was as high as it was. Clearly some recalibration of the model is required. We can identify two key areas where lessons should be learned: too much weight on market pricing; and not enough on drivers of medium-term inflation.

Market pricing did not adequately reflect the MPC's desire to shift strategy.

Firstly, and most importantly, we put too much weight on market pricing and too little on the RBNZ's clearly stated strategy of preferring a pause at the October meeting to assess the impact of interest rate increases already done. In our Preview we incorrectly surmised that silence equated to assent and that market pricing of a hike would make an OCR hike the less disruptive option – especially given the sense that a hike to 3% was still likely in December as implied by the RBNZ's September forecasts. From a macroeconomic perspective, raising rates six weeks early is of little consequence.

This logic, as sound as it was, was wrong, as market pricing did not reflect a large enough change in the medium-term inflation outlook to justify a change in RBNZ strategy. Markets at least partially held the view, based on a long history of revealed RBNZ preference, that the RBNZ keeps moving the OCR in the same direction until confronted with compelling evidence that a halt to the cycle is in prospect. That operating approach may be under review now.

It's not uncommon for other central banks to take breaks while amid an interest rate cycle to gather information on the impact of work already done before moving forward. This week's pause by the FOMC in the face of a fierce set of monthly inflation readings in the last month is an example. Pausing does not need to imply stopping or reversing. Indeed, taking a more measured approach could prove to be solid risk management – as we identified in our MPR preview note. Risk management concerns probably should have greater prominence in this cycle given we are seeing a measure of

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supply side cost shocks that might not be persistent. The Statement of Record contains a wealth of material related to these sorts of uncertainties and concerns. Markets were not listening to these concerns, however.

An insufficient focus on drivers of medium-term inflation

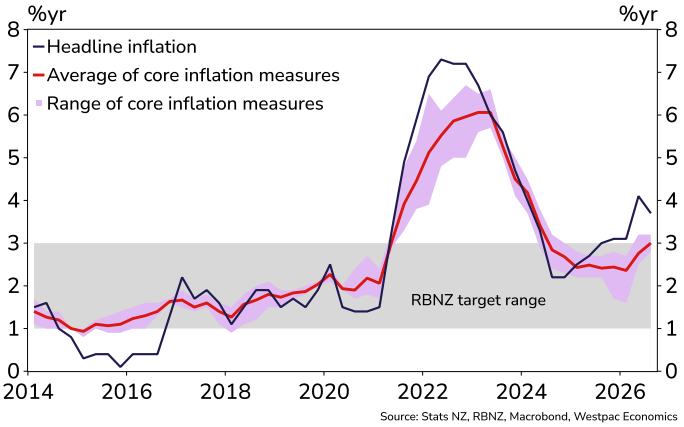
Markets were not listening to the alarm bells because there was a heavy focus on factors that may be more relevant to the short-term inflation outlook than medium-term inflation. Top of mind were the rise in energy prices and fall in the exchange rate. Both factors look set to significantly boost the short-term inflation outlook – for example we currently forecast December quarter annual inflation of 4.3%, with upside risks from there if fuel prices do not fall over the balance of the quarter. However, our analysis of the data surprises suggested no significant shift to the implied RBNZ OCR track one year ahead. Upward pressure on the future OCR projection from the lower exchange rate and stronger GDP was balanced by higher long term interest rates and the lower Q3 CPI outcome. Higher energy prices were not seen as a key factor as they don't impact medium term inflation unless inflation expectations are dislodged (no evidence was found of that since September) or if the increase in energy prices is viewed as persistent (futures markets continue to imply lower forward energy prices, although MPC hawks clearly see risks of persistent inflation coming from supply shocks).

The RBNZ's communications at the MPR and in its aftermath are directing markets to pay more attention to medium-term inflation drivers in the future. Hence the references to the strength of demand and inflation expectations. The risk to the RBNZ's inflation forecasts are to the upside, and hence we might reasonably expect some upgrade of the OCR profile when we see new forecasts in December. But it's not a done deal by any means as data and events between now and then will dictate what stance the RBNZ takes. This week's business and consumer confidence reports do not seem to present many smoking guns of imminent second-round inflation pressures, even though business and consumer sentiment seems to be taking the higher oil price in its stride.

Is core inflation high enough yet to shift the strategy?

Another interesting point made by the Governor was that the markets (and analysts) misinterpreted how the September quarter CPI was read by the RBNZ, which evidently took greater comfort from the outcome. Governor Breman has noted she wished the RBNZ has protocols in place to communicate with markets the RBNZ's view on that CPI data given that it seems to have been a factor that figured importantly in at least some MPC member's thinking. Headline inflation was lower than the RBNZ expected and importantly the core inflation measures, that we had thought might have been of concern to the MPC, do not yet seem to have been at a level sufficient to shift the RBNZ from its pause-then-hike strategy. We remain sceptical that a 3.25% OCR will prove sufficient to bring core inflation down significantly. But core inflation appears to need to lift for the MPC to become more agitated. It likely will lift, but we won't get more data on that until January 2027.

Headline and core inflation measures



Source: Stats NZ, RBNZ, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

December hike likely but not a done deal

We expect a further 25bp hike at this year's final meeting on 9 December and then 25bp increases in the February and March 2027 meetings, followed by a slower pace of increases at the June and September Monetary Policy Statement meetings. Our forecast of a peak OCR of 4% from September 2027 has remained unchanged throughout, as has our assessment of a 3.75% neutral OCR.

That said, in the current uncertain environment, it goes without saying that the evolution of monetary policy will depend on how both global events and key data evolve. Therefore, as the RBNZ noted itself, the exact timing of the tightening profile is highly uncertain and even the tightening we forecast at the December meeting should not be regarded as a done deal.

Looking ahead, the 'hardest' data to come will be the Q3 labour market surveys where we anticipate a small fall in the unemployment rate to 5.5% but still moderate wage pressures. The December quarter RBNZ inflation expectations surveys will be of significant interest (17, 20 and 24 November) for MPC members looking for persistent inflation impacts. The usual run of monthly activity and selected prices indicators will be useful in narrowing down Q4 growth and inflation momentum. And finally, the MPC's focus on external risks will imply keeping an eye on global fixed income, equity and credit markets for signs of imminent calamity.

Finally, November 7 is the general election. A close race is envisaged that could impact on the RBNZ's mandate. We will be offering client briefings on Monday 9 November and Tuesday 10 November to outline the immediate implications of the election outcome for markets and the economy. Contact your relationship manager for details.

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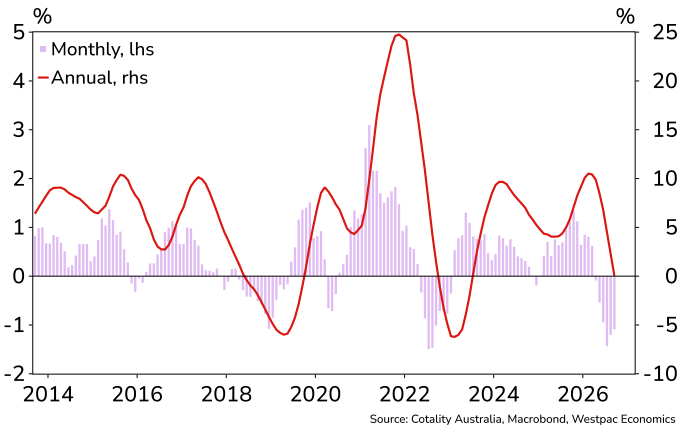
AUS: Oct Cotality Home Value Index (%mth)

Nov 2, Last: –1.1, Westpac f/c: –1.3

The Cotality home value index – covering all of Australia – fell 1.1% in Sep with downward revisions shaving a further 0.4% off prices. The correction has now seen prices decline 5.2% from their March peak, annual growth stalling flat. Cotality reported 97% of capital city suburbs experienced falls over the three months to September.

The October update is set to be another weak one with an added hit coming from the RBA's interest rate rise in late September. The daily measure (covering the five major capital cities rather than all of Australia) is tracking a 1.5% decline vs 1.3% in September. The detail points to slightly bigger falls in Sydney, Brisbane and Perth with Melbourne continuing to record more moderate declines. Note that seasonality is usually a slight positive in the October month.

Dwelling price correction deepening



Source: Cotality Australia, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

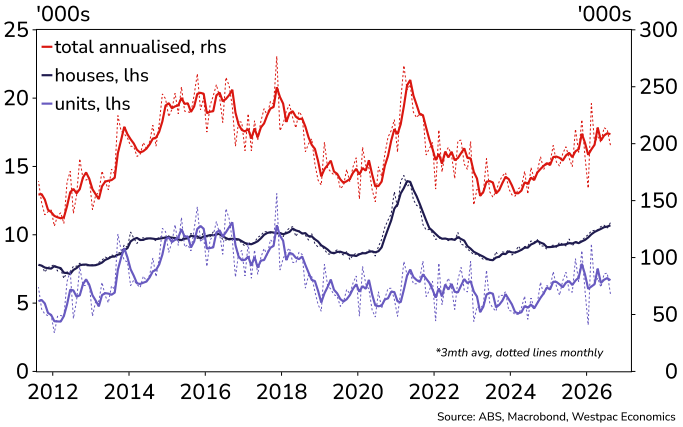
AUS: Sep Dwelling Approvals (%mth)

Nov 2, Last: –6.1, Westpac f/c: –7.0
Market f/c: 2.0, Range: –7.0 to 5.0

Dwelling approvals fell 6.1%mth in August, with the annual pace easing slightly to 10.3%yr. Weakness centred on unit approvals with private detached house approvals actually posting a solid rebound from a July month fall, touching a new cycle high (up 18.4%yr).

We expect the September update to show a much clearer weakening. New construction is coming under pressure from multiple fronts: interest rate rises; a sharp downturn in established markets; and rising costs – with a great deal of uncertainty around each of these. New home sales have fell sharply through the September quarter and we expect to see detached house approvals show something similar. Unit approvals are coming off a weak read and should be more stable. Total approvals are expected to print 7% lower.

Building approvals



Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

AUS: RBA Policy Decision (%)

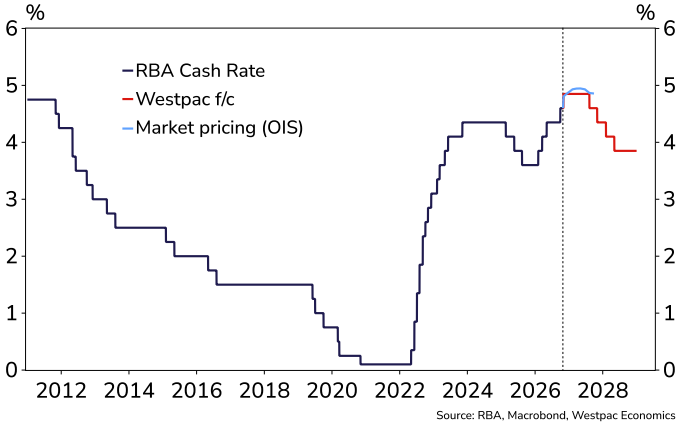
Nov 3, Last: 4.60, Westpac f/c: 4.85
Market f/c: 4.85, Range: 4.60 to 4.85

We reaffirm our expectation that the RBA Monetary Policy Board (MPB) will decide to raise the cash rate by 25bps to 4.85% at the November meeting.

Inflation is above target, and above what the RBA's August forecasts implied. Some upside risks identified in August have partially materialised, particularly energy prices. The RBA is especially worried that above-target inflation will become embedded in people's expectations and pricing decisions.

Recent data and communication have consistently pointed to the RBA staff recommending an increase in the cash rate. We expect a majority of the external board members to agree, though some members might dissent.

RBA to raise cash rate by 25bps in November



Source: RBA, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

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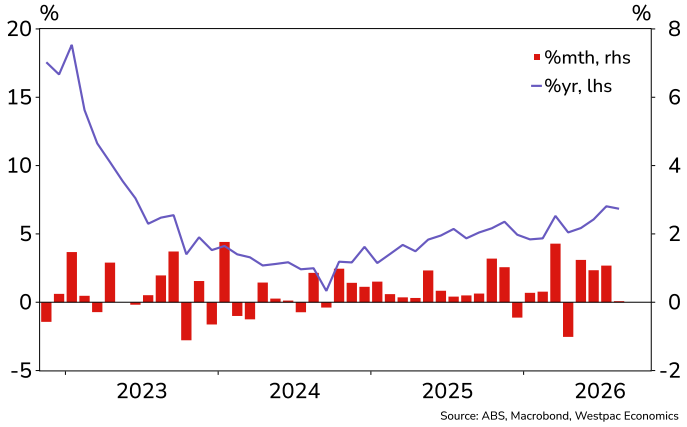
AUS: Sep Household Spending Indicator (%mth)

Nov 4, Last: flat, Westpac f/c: –0.5
Market f/c: 0.2, Range: –0.5 to 0.8

The household spending indicator was unchanged in August, annual growth easing to 6.8%yr. The detail showed a modest rotation away from discretionary categories towards non-discretionary.

Our **Westpac-DataX Card Tracker** showed a decent rise in the September month although new vehicle sales (which are not covered by the tracker but are in scope for the spending indicator) look to have posted a decline. Overall we expect the indicator to show a 0.5% decline in the September month. Note that the update with also include Q3 estimates of real spending – we expect this to show a 0.6%qtr gain with prices up 1.2%qtr and nominal spend up 1.8%qtr.

Monthly household spending indicator



Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

AUS: Sep Goods Trade Balance ($bn)

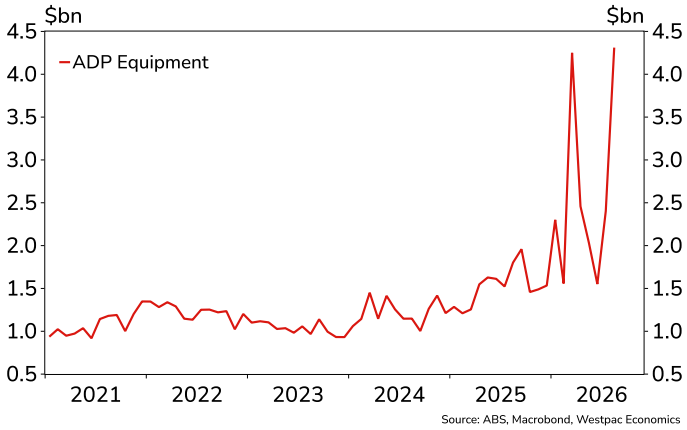
Nov 5, Last: 0.5, Westpac f/c: 2.0
Market f/c: 1.0, Range: –1.0 to 2.5

Australia's goods trade surplus narrowed to $0.5bn in August. Recently, the trade balance has been oscillating between small deficits and surpluses with significant volatility in the underlying trade mix.

Swings in non-monetary gold, fuel and cars have all played a large role, but the most eye-catching result from Aug was the 79% surge in automatic data processing equipment (ADP) imports, which captures the investment upswing related to data centres.

For September, we expect an increase in the surplus as the ADP import surge unwinds, though we are likely in store for ongoing monthly volatility in trade for some time.

ADP equipment imports



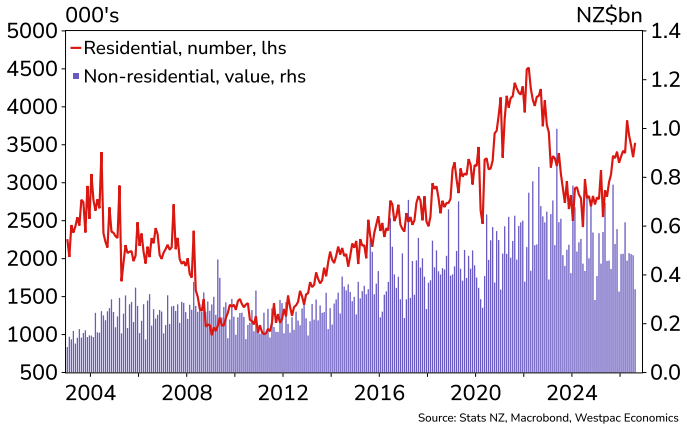
Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

NZ: Sep Building Consents (%mth)

Nov 3, Last: +5.6%, Westpac f/c: Flat

Annual residential building consent numbers are currently at a three year high, and we expect that they will remain firm in the September update. However, monthly consent numbers are showing signs of peaking, with falls in three of the last four months. We're watching to see if that trend has continued, particularly given the ongoing softness in the housing market. In the non-residential space, we've seen softness in the number of retail and office developments, but greater resilience in the industrial and storage segment.

NZ building consents



Source: Stats NZ, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

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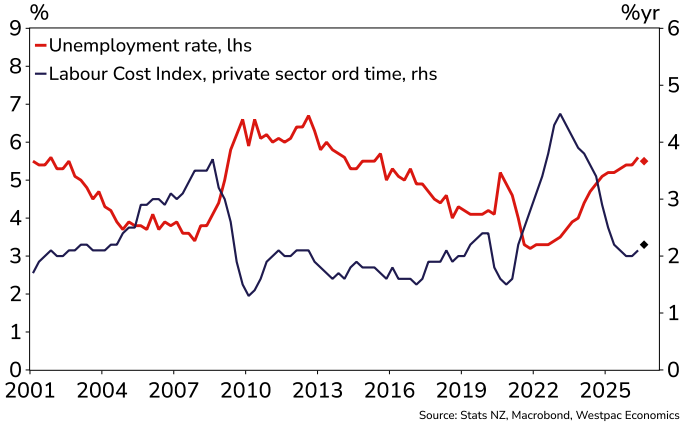
NZ: Q3 Labour Market Surveys (%)

Nov 4, Unemployment Rate, Last: 5.6, Westpac f/c: 5.5
LCI Private Sector, Last: 0.7, Westpac f/c: 0.5

We expect the unemployment rate to edge down to 5.5% for the September quarter. Job numbers have been gaining momentum in recent months, and now look to be enough to outstrip population growth. However, the existing slack in the labour market is likely to be keeping wage growth subdued, despite cost-of-living pressures on workers. Our forecasts are a little more positive overall than what the RBNZ assumed in its September MPS forecasts.

Labour market surveys



Source: Stats NZ, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

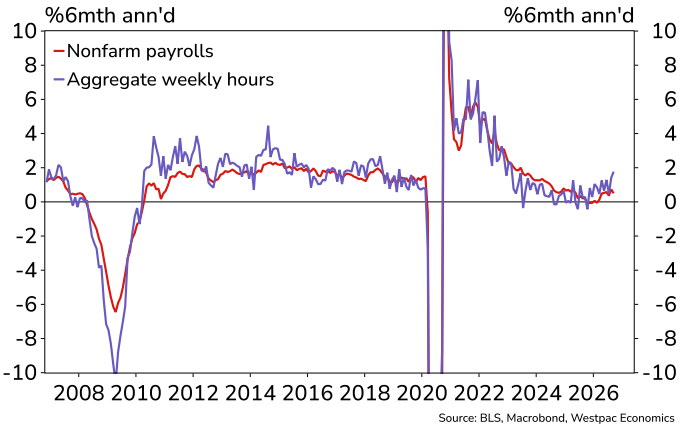
US: Oct Employment Report

Nov 6, Payrolls, Last: 29k, Market f/c: 55k, WBC f/c: 75k
Nov 6, U/E rate, Last: 4.2%, Market f/c: 4.2%, WBC f/c: 4.3%

Nonfarm payrolls have shown considerable volatility of late, July's -10k followed by a 133k gain in August then a 29k increase in September. However, the 3-month average of 51k is likely a good guide on underlying momentum. In October, we look for a 75k gain, although we expect some of that increase to be offset by a modest reduction to the prior two months, keeping the 3-month average around 50k.

While the participation rate has lifted in recent months, it remains well below the average of 2025. Month-to-month, a change either way is not guaranteed, but it seems likely that the participation rate will trend higher in coming months. We therefore expect the unemployment rate to edge up.

Labour demand resilient



Source: BLS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

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What to watch

	For	Data/Event	Unit	Last	Market f/c	Westpac f/c	Risk/Comment
Mon 02							
Aus	Oct	Cotality Home Value Index	%mth	–1.1	–	–1.3	Interest rate rises are adding downward pressure.
	Oct	MI Inflation Gauge	%ann	4.8	–	–	Provides a reliable directional signal for monthly inflation.
	Sep	Dwelling Approvals	%mth	–6.1	2.0	–7.0	New construction is under pressure from mutlipel fronts.
Chn	Oct	RatingDog Manufacturing PMI	index	52.1	52.0	–	A bright spot as low borrowing rates support manufacturers.
US	Oct	ISM Manufacturing	index	54.5	54.7	–	Underlying momentum solid despite brewing cost pressures.
	Sep	Construction Spending	%mth	0.9	0.5	–	Data centres supporting as higher rates hit housing demand.
		Fedspeak	–	–	–	–	Goolsbee.
World	Oct	S&P Global Manufacturing PMI	index	–	–	–	Final estimate for Japan, Europe, UK and US.
Tues 03							
Aus	Nov	RBA Policy Decision	%	4.60	4.85	4.85	RBA worried above–target inflation could become entrenched.
NZ	Sep	Building Permits	%mth	5.6	–	Flat	Annual total elevated, maybe close to a peak.
US	Sep	JOLTS Job Openings	000s	7079	7100	–	Vacancies to unemployed almost in balance.
	Sep	Factory Orders	%mth	0.1	1.1	–	Core orders running stronger than the headline figure.
	Sep	Durable Goods Orders	%mth	1.8	–	–	Final estimate.
Wed 04							
Aus	Sep	Household Spending Indicator	%mth	0.0	0.2	–0.5	Softer new vehicles sales to act as a drag.
NZ	Q3	Employment	%qtr	0.5	0.4	0.5	Jobs growth is gradually picking up momentum...
	Q3	Unemployment Rate	%	5.6	5.5	5.5	...potentially enough to tip the unemployment rate lower..
	Q3	LCI Wage Inflation (Pvte, Ord Time)	%qtr	0.7	0.5	0.5	...though existing slack will keep wage pressures subdued.
	Oct	ANZ Commodity Prices	%mth	0.6	–	–1.0	Pullback in beef prices, some gains in dairy.
Chn	Oct	RatingDog Services PMI	index	51.6	51.4	–	Growth accelerated for second consecutive month.
Eur	Oct	CPI	%ann	3.8	3.9	3.9	The ECB sees effects of the energy shock as still unfolding.
US	Sep	Trade Balance	US$bn	–105.6	–107.9	–	Capital goods imports driving the widening deficit.
	Oct	ISM Services	index	54.9	54.7	–	Higher costs the key pressure point among surveyed firms.
World	Oct	S&P Global Services PMI	index	–	–	–	Final estimate for Europe, UK and US.
Thur 05							
Aus	Sep	Goods Trade Balance	$bn	0.5	1.0	2.0	Unwind in data centre–related equipment import surge.
		RBA Deputy Governor	–	–	–	–	Hauser speaking in Canberra, 5:45pm AEDT.
Eur	Sep	PPI	%ann	8.2	–	–	Energy accounting for near 60% of the annual increase.
UK	Nov	BoE Policy Decision	%	3.75	4.00	–	Economic activity proving resilient, price pressures mount.
US		Initial Jobless Claims	000s	194	–	–	Trending lower.
		Fedspeak	–	–	–	–	Hammack, Barkin.
Fri 06							
Eur	Sep	Retail Sales	%mth	0.1	–	–	Weak demand for consumer credit a headwind.
US	Oct	Nonfarm Payrolls	000s	29	55	–	The FOMC views the labour market as both resilient and ...
	Oct	Average Hourly Earnings	%mth	0.1	0.3	–	... broadly in balance. Continued gains in tech infrastructure ...
	Oct	Unemployment Rate	%	4.2	4.2	–	... is likely to support outcomes over the coming year and ...
	Nov	Uni. Of Michigan Sentiment	index	48.0	47.3	–	... precluding a broadening of weakness in consumer spending.
	Sep	Consumer Credit	%bn	8.3	12.0	–	Softer–than–expected in September; some firming anticipated.
		Fedspeak	–	–	–	–	Logan, Williams.

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Economic & financial forecasts

Interest rate forecasts

Australia	Latest (30 Oct)	Dec–26	Mar–27	Jun–27	Sep–27	Dec–27	Mar–28	Jun–28	Sep–28	Dec–28
Cash	4.60	4.85	4.85	4.85	4.60	4.35	4.10	3.85	3.85	3.85
90 Day BBSW	4.90	4.95	4.95	4.80	4.55	4.30	4.10	3.95	3.95	3.95
3 Year Swap	4.82	4.90	4.85	4.75	4.65	4.55	4.45	4.35	4.30	4.25
3 Year Bond	4.81	4.90	4.85	4.75	4.65	4.55	4.45	4.35	4.30	4.25
10 Year Bond	5.13	5.20	5.15	5.10	5.05	5.05	5.00	5.00	5.00	5.00
10 Year Spread to US (bps)	20	15	15	15	15	10	0	–5	–10	–15
United States										
Fed Funds	3.875	4.125	4.125	4.125	4.125	4.125	3.875	3.625	3.625	3.625
US 10 Year Bond	4.92	5.05	5.00	4.95	4.90	4.95	5.00	5.05	5.10	5.15
New Zealand										
Cash	2.75	3.00	3.50	3.75	4.00	4.00	4.00	4.00	3.75	3.75
90 Day Bill	3.16	3.40	3.75	4.00	4.20	4.20	4.20	4.15	3.95	3.95
2 Year Swap	3.96	4.10	4.20	4.25	4.20	4.20	4.15	4.15	4.10	4.10
10 Year Bond	4.85	5.00	5.00	5.00	5.05	5.05	5.05	5.05	5.05	5.05
10 Year Spread to US (bps)	–10	–5	0	5	15	10	5	0	–5	–10

Exchange rate forecasts

	Latest (30 Oct)	Dec–26	Mar–27	Jun–27	Sep–27	Dec–27	Mar–28	Jun–28	Sep–28	Dec–28
AUD/USD	0.7039	0.72	0.72	0.73	0.73	0.73	0.73	0.72	0.72	0.72
NZD/USD	0.5633	0.56	0.58	0.61	0.63	0.64	0.64	0.64	0.65	0.65
USD/JPY	157.47	156	154	153	152	151	150	149	148	146
EUR/USD	1.1187	1.14	1.16	1.18	1.20	1.21	1.22	1.22	1.21	1.21
GBP/USD	1.3386	1.34	1.35	1.36	1.38	1.39	1.40	1.41	1.41	1.40
USD/CNY	6.6587	6.65	t6.60	6.50	6.45	6.40	6.35	6.35	6.30	6.30
AUD/NZD	1.2479	1.27	1.24	1.20	1.16	1.15	1.13	1.12	1.12	1.11

Australian economic forecasts

	2026				2027				Calendar years			
% change	Q1	Q2	Q3(f)	Q4(f)	Q1(f)	Q2(f)	Q3(f)	Q4(f)	2025	2026(f)	2027(f)	2028(f)
GDP %qtr	0.3	0.4	0.5	0.2	0.4	0.3	0.4	0.5	–	–	–	–
%yr end	2.5	2.1	2.2	1.5	1.6	1.5	1.4	1.6	2.6	1.5	1.6	2.4
Unemployment rate %	4.2	4.4	4.6	4.7	4.7	4.8	4.8	4.7	4.3	4.7	4.7	4.5
Wages (WPI) (sa) %qtr	0.8	0.8	1.0	0.8	0.8	0.8	0.8	0.8	–	–	–	–
%yr end	3.2	3.2	3.4	3.4	3.4	3.4	3.2	3.2	3.4	3.4	3.2	3.4
Headline CPI %qtr	1.4	0.6	1.3	1.3	0.4	0.5	1.0	0.5	–	–	–	–
%yr end	4.1	3.9	3.9	4.6	3.6	3.4	3.2	2.4	3.6	4.6	2.4	2.3
Trimmed Mean CPI %qtr	0.8	0.8	1.0	0.9	0.7	0.7	0.7	0.7	–	–	–	–
%yr end	3.5	3.6	3.7	3.5	3.3	3.3	3.1	2.9	3.3	3.5	2.9	2.4

New Zealand economic forecasts

	2026				2027				Calendar years			
% Change	Q1	Q2	Q3(f)	Q4(f)	Q1(f)	Q2(f)	Q3(f)	Q4(f)	2025	2026(f)	2027(f)	2028(f)
GDP %qtr	0.9	0.2	0.6	0.7	0.9	0.5	0.6	0.7	–	–	–	–
Annual avg change	0.9	1.7	2.1	2.4	2.4	2.5	2.6	2.6	0.3	2.4	2.6	3.0
Unemployment rate %	5.4	5.6	5.5	5.5	5.4	5.3	5.2	5.0	5.4	5.5	5.0	4.4
CPI %qtr	0.9	1.5	0.7	1.2	0.3	0.4	0.5	0.2	–	–	–	–
Annual change	3.1	4.1	3.7	4.3	3.7	2.5	2.3	1.4	3.1	4.3	1.4	1.9

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November 2026

WESTPAC MARKET OUTLOOK

Your monthly report on Australia and the global economy.

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Taking stock

It has been an action-packed few weeks for markets. The US 2026 mid-term elections saw a repudiation of President Trump with the Democrats now set to take control over both houses of Congress. The outcome and easing Middle East tensions saw Brent crude oil fall from just under US$120/bbl to roughly US$95/bbl, back around the post-Iran-conflict average. The associated easing in inflation fears has supported a continued descent in bond yields and rally in risk sentiment – albeit with significant 'wrinkles' around a high US inflation read and an AI-led pull-back in equity markets that has been compounded by the sudden resignation of NVIDIA's CEO.

Many central banks have already begun re-tightening policy – with the Bank of Canada and Bank of England the latest additions to the pack – but what comes next will differ widely across jurisdictions. In the US, the combination of strong activity and sticky inflation have led FOMC members to more strongly advocate for further tightening. We have added a January hike to the December move already in our forecasts, before a long pause and eventual cuts in 2028.

Europe shares has similar inflation concerns but not so much strength on the growth front. The ECB sees activity near trend and is uncomfortable with inflation at 3.8%yr, so we expect a December hike as insurance. Unlike market pricing though, we think this will be the last, with energy and investment-related price pressures easing through 2027 and scope to ease back towards neutral in 2028. China faces a very different challenge – not too much demand but too little. Industrial strength and technology investment are providing support but we expect policy direction and stimulus will be needed to turn household demand, with this expected to come in 2027 and property the most likely catalyst.

The RBA meanwhile followed its September hike with another in November, but the Governor's call to 'take stock' signals a December pause and we think the hiking phase is now more clearly over. We continue to pencil in a move to cuts in the second half of 2027. While a February hike is not completely out of the question, policy is clearly restrictive and downside risks are crystallising. Reflecting this, we have downgraded our GDP, labour market and housing market forecasts for 2027.

Australia: The housing downturn has been sharper than expected and is set to spill over more materially to the broader economy. The scale of these spillovers should become clearer over coming months, keeping the RBA on hold as downside risks to growth build. Business investment remains a source of resilience, led by data centres and renewables, but rising costs and growing community opposition have seen some projects shelved. Still, the supply-side picture is constructive, with strong investment in the market sector driving capital deepening and productivity gains, albeit uneven ones.

Commodities: The commodities complex was a story of two halves in October, with sharp gains across energy offsetting weakness elsewhere and lifting our broadest commodities index 0.6%mth. Reflecting continued energy-market tightness, we expect Brent to average US$101/bbl in Q4 and have raised our Q4 Japanese LNG forecast to US$27.

Global FX Markets: Of late, risks have favoured the US dollar and FOMC member concerns have been decidedly one-sided towards higher inflation. The DXY has consequently continued to test the upper limit of its 18-month range, but remains inside it.

New Zealand: A busy month has included a tight – and currently inconclusive – general election, a surprise hold by the RBNZ in October and a somewhat disappointing Q3 labour market report. However, the medium-term outlook remains little changed, with a recovering economy and above-target inflation likely to lead to further monetary tightening in coming months.

Pacific: Distance from major markets, small domestic economies and a heavy reliance on imported fuel and food mean global disruptions tend to reach the Pacific at a higher cost. However, most Pacific countries face the latest shock with somewhat better buffers.

United States: Data suggests the US carried strong momentum in to H2 2026. But questions are being asked over the profitability of AI deployment, household real incomes are trending flat to down, and term interest rates continue to weigh.

China: China GDP surprised to the upside in Q3, keeping authorities on track for 2026, but more importantly offering a little more time to accelerate domestic demand in to 2027.

Asia: We expect the BoJ to raise its policy rate by 25bps to 1.50% in December, before gradually taking it to 2.0% through 2027. The case for further tightening rests on the evidence that firms are more willing to raise prices, labour scarcity supports persistent wage growth, which should in turn support spending.

Europe & UK: The ECB left its key policy rates unchanged in October. Another hike is forecast in December. Against market pricing, we expect this will prove the last for the current cycle.

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Global asset market rotation ...

Luci Ellis
Chief Economist, Westpac Group

All major central banks are now in a rate-hiking phase. The stance of policy nonetheless varies considerably across economies, as does the policy outlook.

The Bank of England and Bank of Canada increased their policy rates for the first time this cycle and the RBA a fifth time since the last *Market Outlook*. The pace of increase is generally moderate: the FOMC and RBNZ paused at their latest meetings – the RBNZ unexpectedly so – but both are expected to lift policy rates further. Policy is likely still accommodative in New Zealand and Canada, consistent with the economic and labour market slack evident in these economies. In Australia it is clearly restrictive, as discussed below.

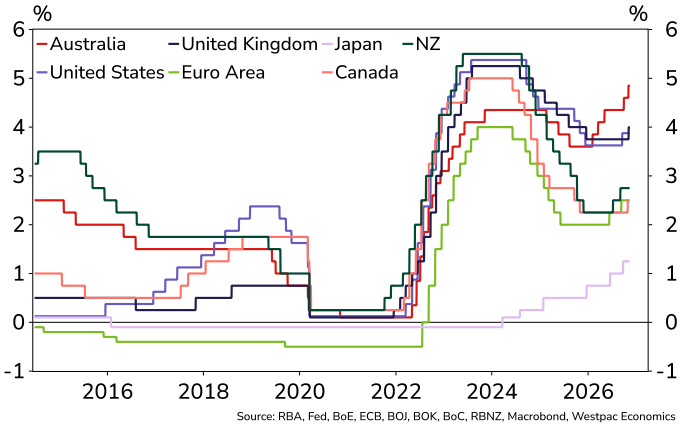
The US is contending with sticky inflation, as evidenced by recent CPI and labour market data. We have long been of the view that the US is likely to be structurally more inflationary than many peers, and concerns about inflation are increasingly coming to the fore in FOMC members' comments. Accordingly we have added another hike in January to our US rates view, on top of the one in December already forecast (see page 20).

The main, but not sole, driver of the pivot to tightening has been the energy price shock. That said, exclusion-based core inflation measures (excluding food and energy) are also above central bank targets. Market pricing of future central bank moves had been sensitive to oil prices and the outlook in the Middle East earlier in the year. That correlation broke down during the bond sell-off, which was mostly a phenomenon of real yields, but seems to have re-emerged in the pricing for policy in 2027.

Spot and daated Brent oil prices have fallen markedly in recent days as tensions have eased and negotiations appear to have restarted. This has not affected very near-term pricing of central bank decisions, and an initial moderation of mid-2027 pricing retraced after the strong US CPI print and some Fed speeches.

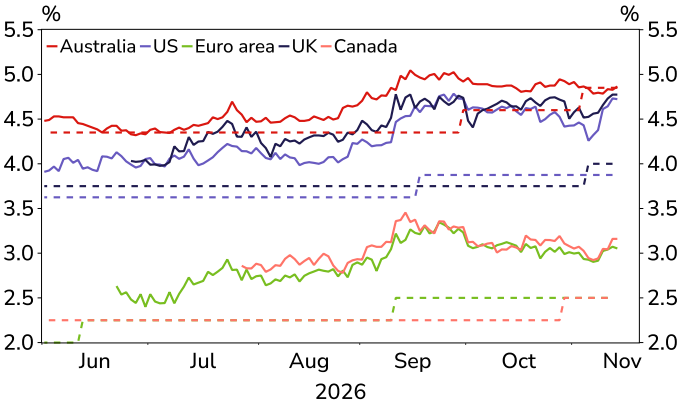
Further along the yield curve, last month's sell-off in bond markets has largely reversed. Unlike the increase in yields, when longer-run market-based measures of inflation expectations relatively stable, the more recent rally has involved some decline in these expectations measures. Most of the adjustment has been front-loaded: the 1-year expectations derived from swaps have declined 45bps for Australia and nearly 60bps for the US since the beginning of November. However, inflation expectations derived for future years have also moderated. The 5-year-5-year forward measures derived from swaps and breakevens have both declined, with the latter noticeably below the 2.5% RBA target midpoint. The same measures for the US have also declined over this period, but by less, and remain further above the Fed's 2% target, consistent with our view about inflation pressures there.

Central bank policy rates



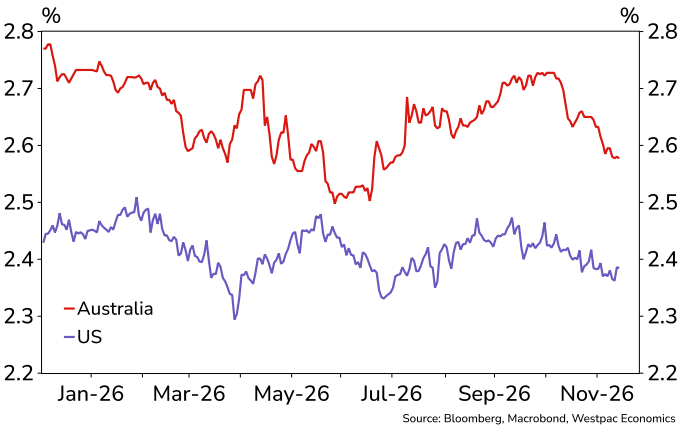
Source: RBA, Fed, BoE, ECB, BOJ, BOK, BoC, RBNZ, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

Market-implied policy rates for June 2027



Source: RBA, BoE, Fed, ECB, BoC, Bloomberg, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

5-Year, 5-Year Forward Inflation Swap Rate



Source: Bloomberg, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

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… while the RBA nears a pause

The rally in long bond markets has occurred at the same time as equity markets have tended to sell off, particularly in the tech sector. Another wave of scepticism around the sustainability of the data centre build-out has formed and found expression in the equity prices of many semiconductor manufacturers and other related firms. One possible trigger for the latest sell-off may have been the release of Anthropic's prospectus ahead of its IPO. As well as the more existential risks flagged in the documents, its stated plans for further data centre investment have concentrated focus on the scale of the data centre and AI boom more broadly, and the enormous funding task involved.

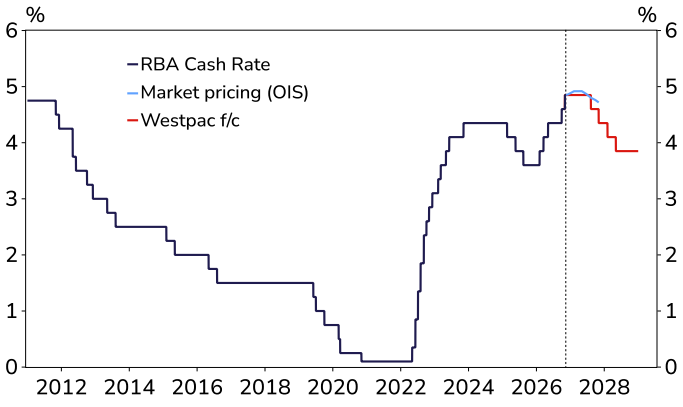
The RBA Monetary Policy Board (MPB) hiked at its November meeting following up the late September hike as expected. As we noted at the time, the MPB was responding to the apparent crystallisation of some of the risks that it had flagged back in August. In particular, the re-emergence of pressures on fuel prices led to fears of a further wave of pass-through of energy costs into the prices of other goods and services. The Q3 outcome for underlying inflation outstripped expectations and Q4 is also likely to be uncomfortably high. With inflation already materially above target, the RBA is worried that inflation expectations could be rising, pointing to liaison and business survey evidence. So far, though, other business surveys suggest that pass-through has been less severe than the original wave of price increases at the outbreak of the Middle East conflict.

In the post-meeting media conference, the Governor flagged that it was a good time to "take stock" of the policy tightening to date. Both we and the market read this as a signal that the MPB would pause at the December meeting. The 6:3 split vote at the meeting also suggests that some external members are more attentive to downside risks than the internal members.

We think the most likely outcome from here is that the RBA has ended its rate-hiking phase, and that a cutting phase will begin in the second half of 2027. There is still a risk of a hike in February, and we believe the MPB will at least discuss the option at that meeting. The staff and senior officials remain sensitive to inflation risks, and have a downbeat view of supply capacity growth. The latter meant that the RBA had to upgrade its forecasts for the labour force participation rate in its However, policy is clearly restrictive, and while there are upside risks to inflation, there are clearly downside risks, too.

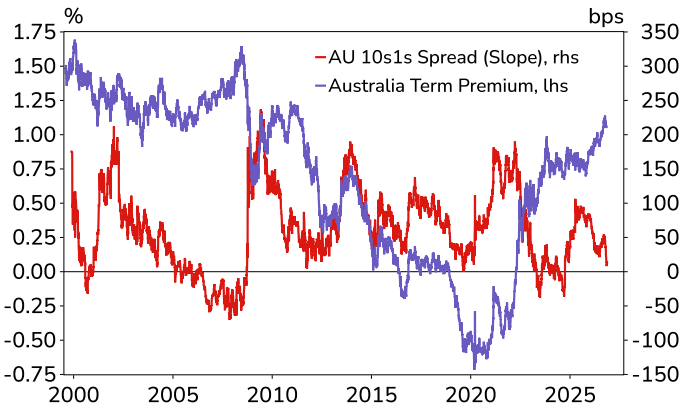
With markets now expecting that the RBA is likely at the end of its hiking phase, while most peers are expected to have 2–3 hikes to go, short-end yield differentials have narrowed. This has been reflected in the AUD exchange rate, which has tended to underperform in recent days. We have tempered our near-term outlook for the AUD, but note that the TWI remains abourt 4% above the 2022–2024 average, and that this appreciation will be contributing to the disinflationary impact of tight policy.

RBA Cash Rate and Expectations



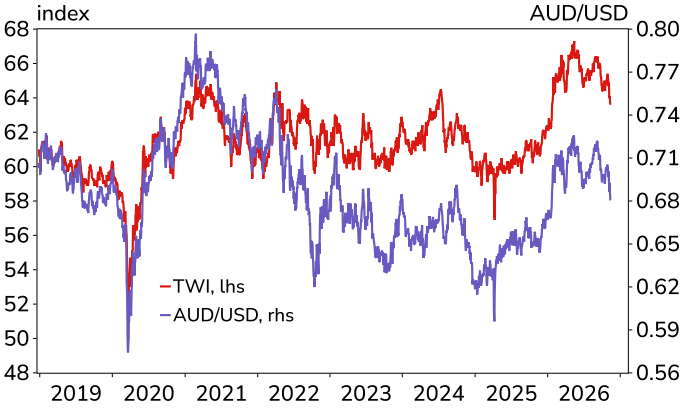
Source: RBA, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

Australian Government Bond Market



Source: AOFM, Bloomberg, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

Australian dollar – spot USD rate and TWI



Source: , Macrobond, Westpac Economics

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Steepest housing downturn in almost 50 years ...

Pat Bustamante, Senior Economist

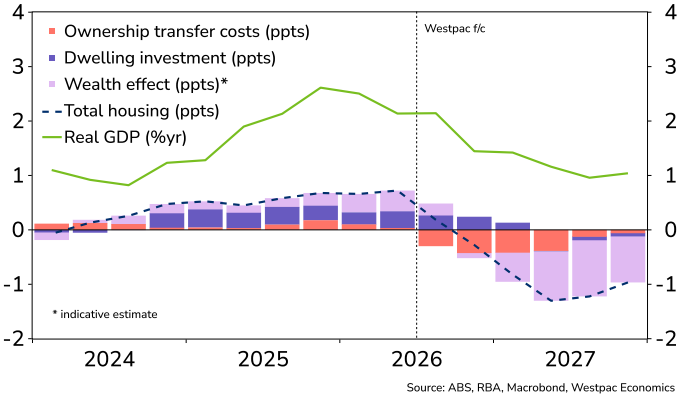
The housing downturn has been sharper than expected and is set to spill over more materially to the broader economy. The scale of these spillovers should become clearer over coming months, keeping the RBA on hold as downside risks to growth build. Business investment remains a source of resilience, led by data centres and renewables, but signs of strain are emerging, with rising costs and growing community opposition seeing some projects shelved. The 2026 Annual National Accounts offered a more constructive supply-side picture, with strong investment across parts of the market sector driving capital deepening and supporting productivity, but this has been uneven.

As set out on page 26, we expect the lift in inflation this year to subside through 2027, with underlying measures easing back from 3.7%yr currently to 2.7%yr by end 2027 and 2.3%yr in 2028. Indeed, the deeper housing downturn and associated spillovers give us greater conviction in this view. The correction is now the largest nominal price decline on records going back to 1980 and appears to have accelerated following the November 25bp RBA rate hike. This is on the back of dismal dwelling finance approvals outcome which showed the value of new loans plunged 15.5%qtr in Q3, the biggest quarterly decline on records going back to 1991.

This downturn has some clear direct effects. The housing sector, covering both real estate transactions and residential construction, accounts for around 5–6% of GDP. The drop in turnover will take about 0.4ppts off GDP growth over calendar 2026 (captured through the "ownership transfer costs" component of expenditure GDP) with the downturn also expected to have a significant drag on dwelling construction heading into 2027.

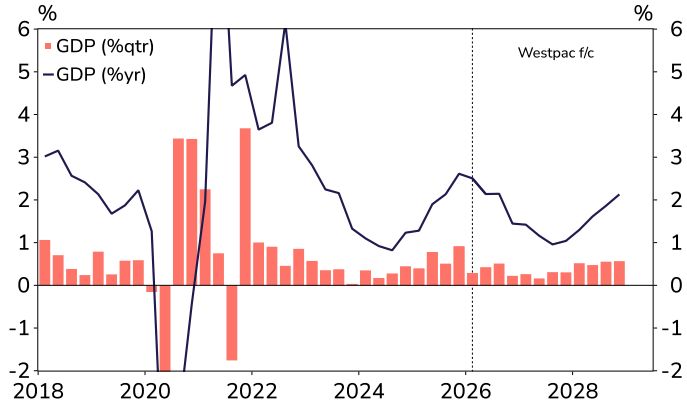
Housing-related drivers of GDP

Contributions to year-ended GDP growth



Source: ABS, RBA, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

GDP forecasts



Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

However, the impact goes well beyond these direct effects. Falling housing wealth will weigh on household spending, while the residential building has strong linkages to the rest of the economy. Residential investment supports activity across manufacturing, transport and professional services; dollar for dollar, we estimate its broader economic impact is around 1.5 times that of consumer spending. The flow on impacts via employment and broader confidence are also substantive.

We have lowered our forecasts for household consumption, ownership transfer costs and dwelling investment. Consumption growth is now expected to trough at 1.1%yr during 2027, from 1.8%yr forecast in our October *Market Outlook*, before recovering to 2.7%yr in 2028. Ownership transfer costs are expected to see a 25%yr decline over 2026, the sharpest decline since the March quarter 1990, even larger than what we saw during the pandemic. New dwelling investment is expected to contract by 1.0%yr in 2027, rather than grow by 2.1%yr as we expected back in October, before recovering by 3.2%yr in 2028, down from 4.9%yr. Together with some flow-on dampening effect on employment, these revisions lower our GDP growth forecast to just 1.0%yr in 2027, from 1.6%yr, and 2.1%yr in 2028, from 2.5%yr.

We do not expect the slowdown to become immediately apparent in the data. Consumer spending looks to have been relatively resilient through the September quarter. Discretionary services spend has been notably firm in particular, with only some of this due to a catch-up on travel and tourism spend disrupted by the Middle East conflict earlier in the year. Household disposable incomes were still relatively well supported through the quarter with some lift coming from tax cuts and the FWC award wage increase. However, our card tracker data suggests discretionary spending momentum has faded noticeable over the first half of the December quarter.

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… to drive a sharp economic slowdown …

The confidence impacts from housing downturn may also be starting to show. While the drop in consumer sentiment back to extreme lows has more to do with rate rises and fuel prices, the weakening in business confidence became more prominent in October with a notably sharp fall in forward orders. While this has not had a flow-on impact on employment and capex expectations to date, these will likely soften if confidence remains negative and the signal from forward order starts to be reflected in wider business conditions.

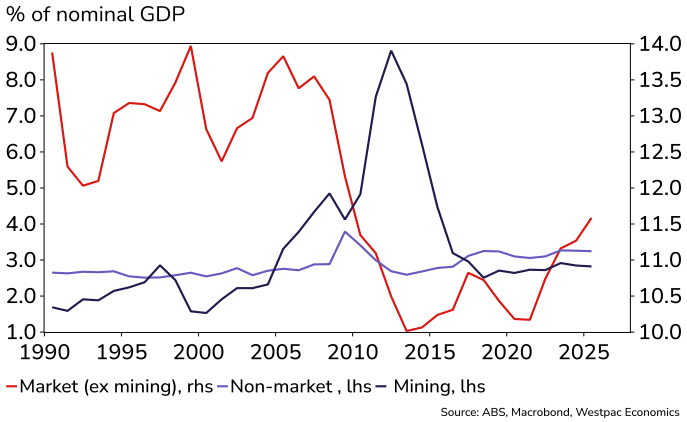
Business investment is still likely to be an important offset, with data centres and renewables supporting activity. But even here, some cracks are starting to emerge. Reports of project delays in NSW and South Australia amid community opposition pose limited risk to projects already underway but could increasingly affect the pipeline of proposed data-centre investment (with the notably cancellation of an IPO for a local operator as well). Sentiment across the AI sector more broadly has also weakened with equity valuations dropping, leadership instability at NVIDIA. Anthropic's 'mega IPO' due November 18 and expected to land at market valuation of ~US$1trn will be an important test of how fundamental the shift in sentiment may have been.

Annual National Accounts

The Annual National Accounts (the 'Annuals') provide updated benchmarks and some useful detail including on investment trends across industries, the capital stock and productivity.

The 2025–26 figures show somewhat firmer economic activity and business investment than previously estimated, particularly in 2024–25. The economy grew by 2.3% in year-average terms, broadly in line with the initial quarterly National Accounts estimate of 2.4%. However, growth in 2024–25 was revised up by 0.3ppts to 1.6%, largely reflecting stronger private business investment. Business investment is now estimated to have increased by 1.1% in 2024–25, compared with the initial estimate of a 0.2% decline. The revisions do not materially alter the broader productivity story, but they do suggest that the economy was growing a little more strongly but with the same degree of inflation in 2025.

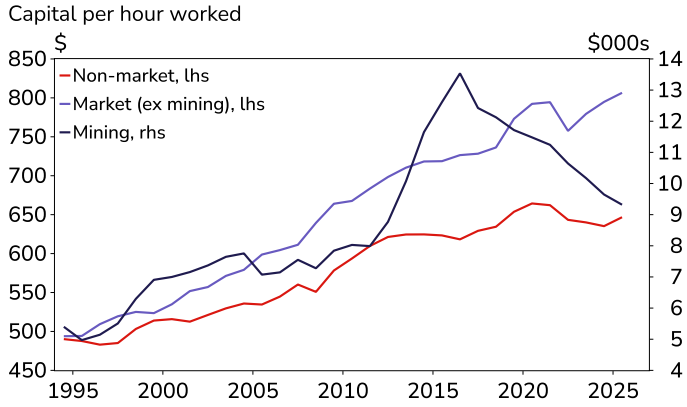
Investment by sector



Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

The Annuals also provide a richer picture of the supply side, including investment by industry and the evolution of the capital stock, details that are not available in the quarterly accounts. These data point to a notable lift in investment in the market (ex-mining) part of the economy, where investment has gone from around 10% of nominal GDP in to just over 11.5%. Outside of this, investment has been softer, particularly in the mining sector.

Capital to labour ratio by sector



Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

Within the market sector, investment by the IT industry, increasingly focused on data centres, has risen to its highest share of nominal GDP since the technology boom of the 1990s. Utilities investment, including renewables and associated infrastructure, is stronger still, at its highest share since 1983, while investment by the professional services industry has reached a record high. Across the non-market sector (including health, education and public administration), investment has also held at a slightly higher share of the economy, driven by the health and public administration (including defence) industries.

The investment upswing is also beginning to translate into capital deepening as industries look to rebuild capital stocks after a period of soft growth. Outside mining, market-sector capital per hour worked is at a record high and well above its pre-pandemic level. That is an encouraging development, particularly given that the sector accounts for 70% of total employment.

There are important divergences beneath the aggregate. Mining continues to experience capital shallowing, as investment has been insufficient to cover wear and tear and capital requirements associated with additional workers. By contrast, the capital stock in the non-market sector appears to have caught up with the surge in employment we have seen since the pandemic, with capital per worker increasing for the first time since the pandemic.

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... as non-mining sector rebuilds capital, productivity

Capital deepening will help support productivity growth across the economy. The Annuals show that productivity in the market sector (excluding mining) continues to grow by around 1% in year-average terms, while mining remains a drag on aggregate productivity (down 0.8% in 2025–26 and almost 30% since 2017).

At the same time, a major recent headwind is easing as the rapid expansion of the non-market sector slows. This matters for aggregate productivity. Productivity growth reflects both gains within industries, through capital deepening, technology and better processes, and the 'reallocation' of resources between industries with different productivity levels.

Measured productivity in the non-market sector is considerably lower than across much of the market sector, partly reflecting measurement issues (output is generally not well measured, particularly when there are quality changes). As employment shifted towards these industries, this compositional effect weighed on aggregate productivity. Our estimates suggest it has reduced the level of aggregate productivity by a significant 1ppt over the past 15 years and almost 0.3ppts over the three years to 2025–26.

What drove growth in market-sector productivity?

It wasn't only capital deepening that drove productivity growth. Multifactor productivity (MFP), which captures how efficiently businesses combine labour and capital through changes in processes, technology, know-how, was the dominant driver of market-sector productivity growth this year. This gives us more conviction that the supply side is normalising, and productivity growth will improve from its recent lows.

At the industry level, some of those recording stronger investment are also beginning to deliver stronger productivity outcomes, although the picture remains uneven.

IT stands out at the positive end of the spectrum, alongside improving outcomes in manufacturing, administrative and support services, and transport. These are also industries where the diffusion of AI and other digital technologies could deliver further productivity gains. Utilities and professional services should also benefit as stronger investment translates into greater capital intensity and efficiency.

At the other end, mining remains a major drag, consistent with the capital shallowing evident in the investment and capital-stock data. Construction is another notable laggard, with productivity continuing to deteriorate despite strong demand from housing, population growth, renewable-energy infrastructure and data-centre projects. Construction productivity fell around 2% in 2025–26 and almost 21% over the 13 years from 2012–13 to 2025–26.

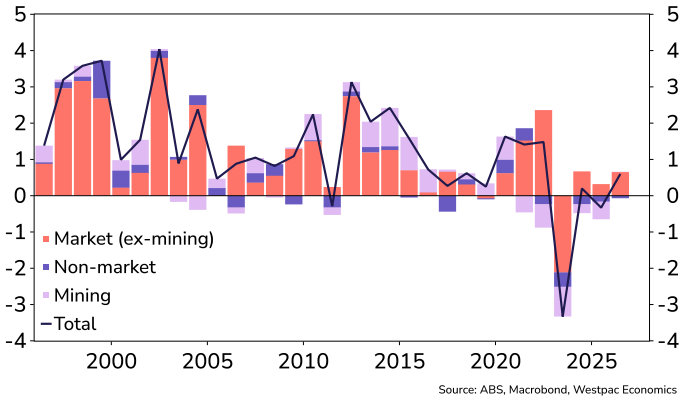
Bottom line

The Annuals provide a more constructive supply-side picture than the aggregate productivity figures alone suggest. Market-sector productivity outside mining continues to advance, the reallocation drag from the expanding non-market sector looks likely to fade, and capital deepening is strengthening across important parts of the economy. The strong MFP outcome in the market sector gives us more conviction that conviction that the supply side is normalising, and productivity growth will improve going ahead.

The critical question is whether the strong investment underway in technology, professional services, electricity and related infrastructure translates into stronger productivity growth as that new capital is put to work. If it does, the improvement in capital intensity evident in the Annuals could mark the beginning of a more durable lift in Australia's productivity performance.

Productivity by sector

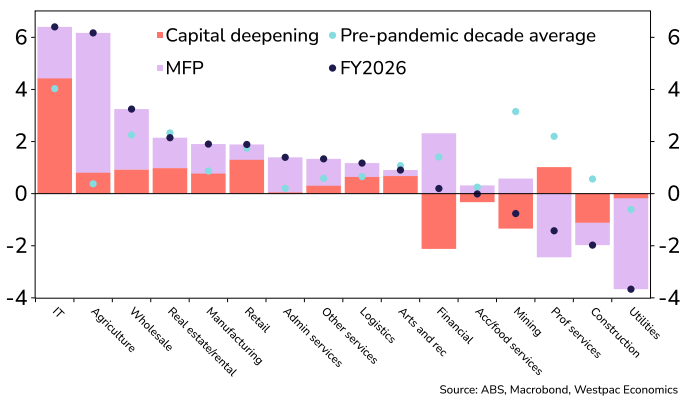
Cont. to year-average % change



Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

Productivity by industries in the market sector

Year-average % change



Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

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Energy commodities push higher ...

Justin Smirk, Senior Economist
Luka Belobrajdic, Economist

The commodities complex was a story of two halves in October, with energy prices rising sharply while most other commodities weakened. Our broadest commodities index gained 0.6%mth, led by Japanese LNG (+12.8%mth), with Brent (+6.1%mth) and thermal coal (+2.9%mth) also higher amid energy-market disruption. Copper edged 0.1%mth lower as AI sentiment weakened, while coking coal (–3.5%mth) reversed recent gains and elevated yields continued to weigh on gold (–5.0%mth). Iron ore extended its slide (–6.1%mth), while aluminium fell 6.5%mth. Lithium was the clear underperformer, with spodumene down 26.1%mth as environmental approval for CATL's Jianxiawo mine renewed oversupply concerns.

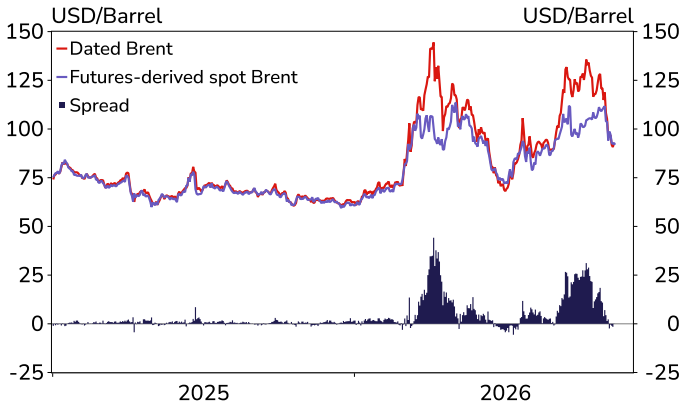
Oil supply returns, risk premium remains

Brent crude rose 6.1%mth in October to average US$106.2/bbl as ongoing strikes and attacks on shipping through the Strait of Hormuz continued to weigh on sentiment. Inventory buffers remain depleted, with the EIA estimating OECD inventories remain 141mb below pre-conflict levels in February. This comes despite reported crude exports from Gulf producers recovering to above 85% of year-ago levels in October. Reflecting improving supply, Dated Brent moved to a discount to the front-month futures contract at the start of November. Futures prices were further subdued following the Republican defeat in the US midterms and market expectations of a less intense US campaign against Iran. Nonetheless, prices remain elevated, with fewer tankers available after vessels were redeployed to other markets, while higher insurance premiums continue to add to costs.

Refined product markets remain tight, with reduced Gulf supply compounded by Ukrainian strikes on Russian refineries. Together with higher shipping costs and elevated Dated Brent prices, Singapore Gasoil 10ppm has roughly doubled since the Strait closed, with the crack spread averaging around US$60.8/bbl in the first week of November.

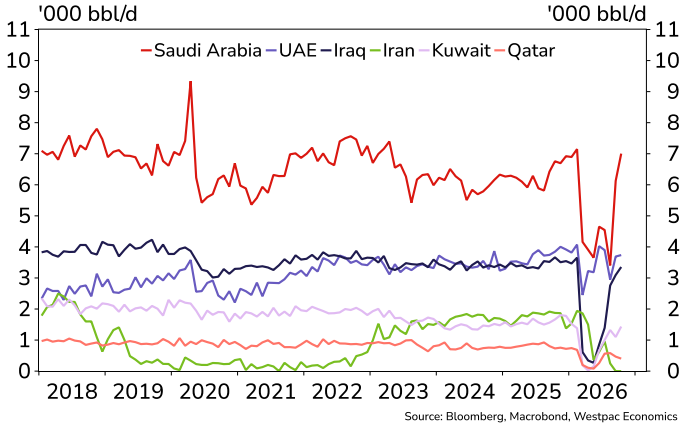
We do not expect a lasting US-Iran agreement until mid-2027. In the meantime, we assume there will not be a return to full-scale military intervention. However, periodic Iranian attacks on ships and facilities are expected to continue, alongside the US blockade of Iranian exports, maintaining a supply risk premium. We expect Brent futures to average around US$101/bbl in Q4, albeit with considerable volatility, before easing gradually as recovering supply is partly offset by demand from refiners and governments rebuilding inventories. As the risk premium fades and the market moves into surplus in late 2027, we forecast Brent at around US$77/bbl in Q4 2027. Refined product supply is expected to recover more slowly than crude. For additional analysis, including our October scenarios for further escalation and an earlier resolution, see here.

Dated Brent and Brent futures



Source: Bloomberg, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

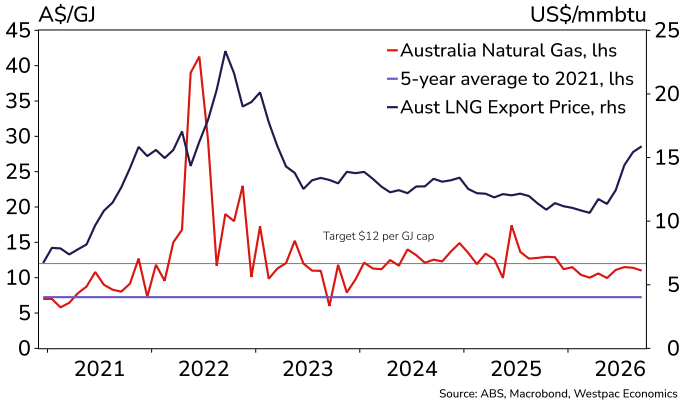
Monthly Oil Exports



Source: Bloomberg, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

Domestic vs Export Gas Prices

Wallumbilla Benchmark Price, Westpac Est. Aust. Export Price



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... while the broader complex struggles to keep pace

Qatar's limited bypass options keep LNG tight

LNG prices continued to climb through October. Damage to the world's largest LNG export complex at Ras Laffan in Qatar and the country's inability to divert flows around the Strait of Hormuz continue to weigh on supply. These constraints have been compounded by stronger competition between Northeast Asia and Europe for flexible Atlantic Basin cargoes ahead of the Northern Hemisphere winter, with European gas storage remaining below seasonal norms. As a result, Japanese LNG prices rose 12.8%mth in October, averaging US$28.6/mmbtu.

Reflecting the continued acute disruption, we have raised our December quarter forecast for Japanese LNG prices to US$27.5/mmbtu. The severity of the Northern Hemisphere winter will be the key risk to the near-term outlook. Supply recovery is expected to remain constrained, with prices unlikely to return to pre-conflict levels until 2028. Domestically, the Australian gas market remains relatively insulated, supported by the FY2027 Federal Budget's domestic gas reservation scheme, with an objective to cap domestic gas prices at around $12/GJ.

Gold caught between yields and haven demand

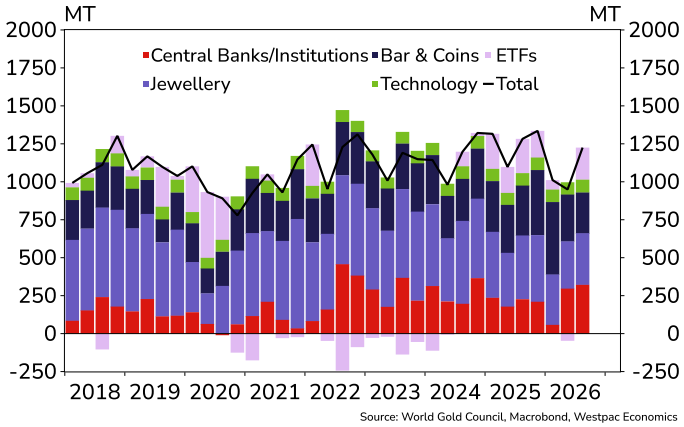
Gold struggled through October, with prices down 5.0%mth to average US$4,105/oz. As a non-yielding asset, gold has faced broader pressure throughout the Middle East conflict as markets weighed the inflationary implications of elevated energy prices and the prospect of further central bank tightening. Despite these headwinds, some pillars of support have emerged. A meaningful bid has developed around US$4,000/oz, with dip-buying supporting a recovery in gold ETF demand. Yields also moved lower at the start of November prior to the US CPI release as safe-haven demand increased against a backdrop of macroeconomic, geopolitical and market uncertainty.

With these supports increasingly evident, we expect modest gains through the remainder of 2026, with a December quarter average of US$4,200/oz. From there, we expect a period of consolidation through 2027 as brownfield expansions at existing operations lift supply in response to recent high prices, while an elevated Fed Funds rate limits upside for non-yielding assets. Over the longer term, structural support should persist, underpinned by growing Asian demand, and central bank buying.

Democrat sweep weighs on copper's bull case

LME copper prices were broadly stable through October, edging 0.1%mth lower to average US$14,478/t. The pace of COMEX inventory accumulation slowed further to 2.9%mth following reports in September that the US Government's decision on Section 232 tariff implementation had stalled amid concerns higher copper prices could add to already elevated manufacturing costs. Supply disruptions in Chile provided more meaningful support, with two fatal accidents at separate operations resulting in production suspensions in

Gold Consumption

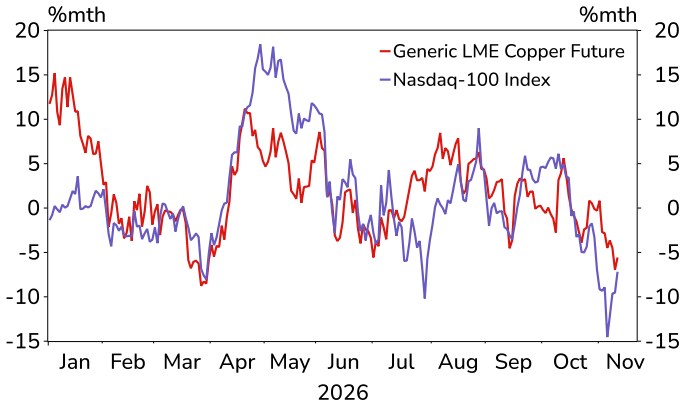


Source: World Gold Council, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

a region already affected by weather disruptions. Alongside broader electrification trends and metal shortages outside the US, these disruptions supported copper through October. However, a weaker macroeconomic outlook amid elevated energy costs and a sharp rotation out of the copper-linked AI trade left prices broadly unchanged over the month.

Several recent sources of support have come under pressure in early November. The key shift has been the Democratic sweep of Congress at the US midterm elections. The initial equity-market reaction saw the AI trade pull back on concerns that a Democrat-controlled Congress could impose greater regulatory constraints on AI-infrastructure investment. Copper's exposure to the AI buildout made it a casualty of the broader sell-off, with LME prices falling sharply at the start of the month. A Democrat controlled Congress has also reduced the perceived risk of more severe Section 232 tariff implementation. Against this backdrop, we have downgraded our near-term LME copper forecast, with prices expected to average US$14,000/t in Q4. Ongoing electrification trends, AI and data-centre investment, and metal shortages outside the US should, however, continue to provide a floor under prices.

Copper has traded in line with market sentiement



Source: Bloomberg, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

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US dollar support ...

Elliot Clarke
Head of International Economics

The past month has seen a wave of risk events favouring the US dollar. Meanwhile, concerns shown by FOMC members have been decidedly one-sided, their clear message being that the question is how many more hikes are needed. The DXY has consequently continued to test the upper limit of its 18-month range, circa 103, but has held to it.

Underlying the DXY's movements are several key narratives. Europe is the first port of call. Since mid-September, euro has fallen from almost USD1.17 to a low near USD1.11. Uncertainty surrounding France's fiscal and economic outlook was part of that turn, however, most of the move aligns to concerns amongst market participants over the persistence of inflation and the resetting of policy rate expectations. Albeit marginal, expected fed fund rate hikes outnumber those for the ECB, entrenching short and long-end rate differentials.

Sterling has held up better than euro, falling from around USD1.36 in September to near USD1.32. But, to our mind, the chances of the sequence of rate hikes priced by the market for the Bank of England is low. After November's policy meeting, Governor Bailey showed caution over the activity outlook and a greater willingness to incorporate the recent drop in oil prices into inflation forecasts than FOMC members have.

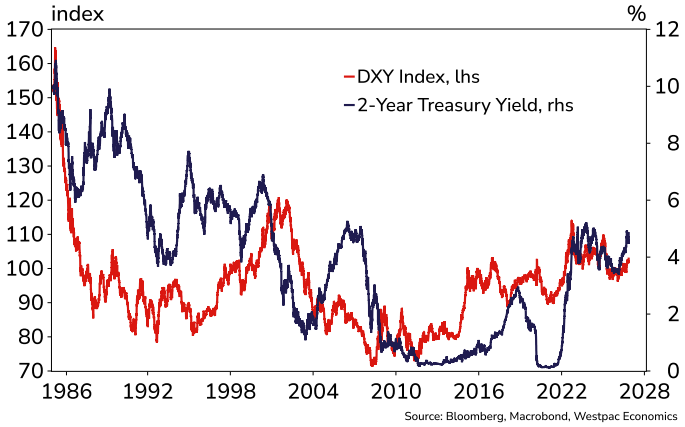
Interest rates are not the only comparable favouring the US dollar; each nation's growth story is also important. While Europe and the UK have recently delivered economic outcomes consistent with a return to trend growth, US data continues to point to momentum in excess of potential. Moreover, as discussed on page 19, the pipeline of AI related investment and funding continues to strengthen, favouring the US.

It is intriguing then that the US dollar has not broken the range of the past 18 months. Based on this performance, lingering downside risks for the US economic outlook and the potential for a more constructive outturn for energy, we remain of the view that the US dollar is likely to recommence its downtrend in mid-2027, once this monetary policy cycle definitively ends.

For euro, a slow (but likely volatile) uptrend is anticipated, from USD1.11 today to USD1.17 at end-2027 then USD1.21 come end-2028. Sterling is similarly forecast to lift from USD1.32 at present to USD1.38 at end-2027 and then USD1.41 by late-2028 – seeing broad stability between euro and sterling. Dissipating global risks over the coming two years should also result in both euro and sterling lifting against the Swiss franc – albeit only at the margin.

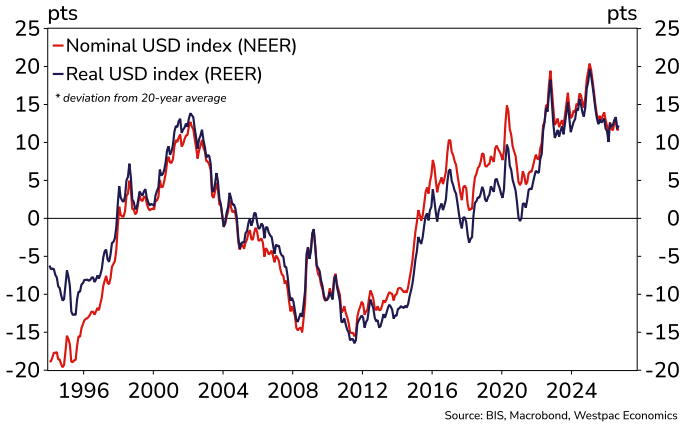
The primary risk to this view is that appreciation against the US dollar comes later. Though, as we are only targeting

USD demand range bound



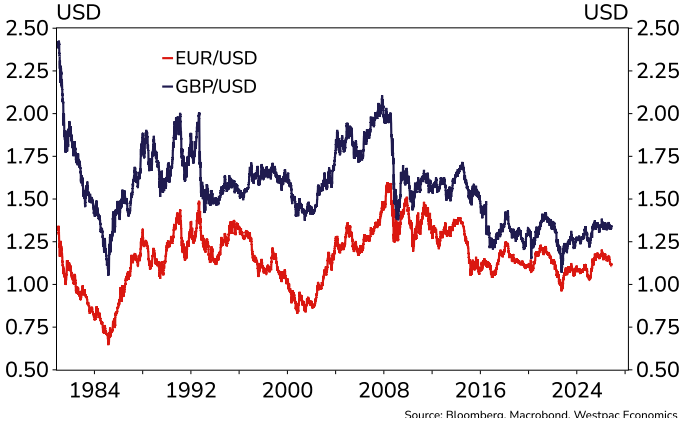
Source: Bloomberg, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

Valuation remains stretched



Source: BIS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

Euro and UK risks to recede



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... has limits

'around average' levels for the bilateral, further out there is also the likelihood of more sizeable advances for euro and sterling versus both the US dollar and Swiss franc.

Over in Asia, there has been little change in the narrative surrounding Japan. Growth is solid and inflation appears sustainable at or above the Bank of Japan's 2.0%yr medium-term target. Yet the market continues to take every opportunity to doubt the Bank of Japan's resolve in normalising policy. This has resulted in USD/JPY trending back up near JPY160 after each test of a lower level – most recently JPY158.

A reset of investor expectations for the yen seems highly unlikely until the US rate story has turned. Even then, US activity growth will probably also need to ebb, as we forecast, if USD/JPY is to sustainably move away from JPY160 towards USD150. We only see a break of this level in late-2028, with USD/JPY forecast at USD147 at the close of 2028.

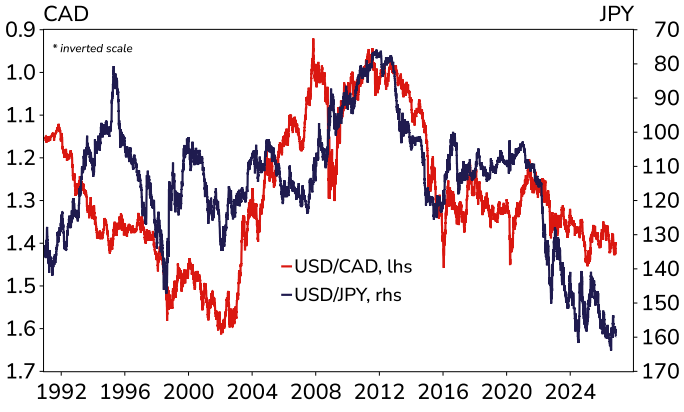
For DXY, the net effect is a shallow downtrend from 103.2 today to 98.2 at end-2027 then 94.7 come late-2028. Conviction on the downtrend through 2027 is lower than previous owing to the above developments in the US growth and interest rate narratives relative to the other nations. However, this is made up for in 2028 on the expectation that each nation's growth track will normalise around trend, cyclical inflation risks abate and central banks rebalance for known risks, easing back towards neutral.

Coming after a lengthy period of US dollar strength, it is important to highlight that our end-2028 level of 94.7 for DXY is still above average relative to its full history. Whereas DXY's 5-year average is 102.3 and the 10-year figure is 98.8, over 20-years the DXY index has instead oscillated around 91, 4.0% below our end-2028 level and 12% under today's spot. Assuming conditions normalise in time, downside risks to the US dollar's dominance are likely to build.

Such an outcome will become more probable if Asia's economic story continues to strengthen, attracting additional capital away from US dollar assets.

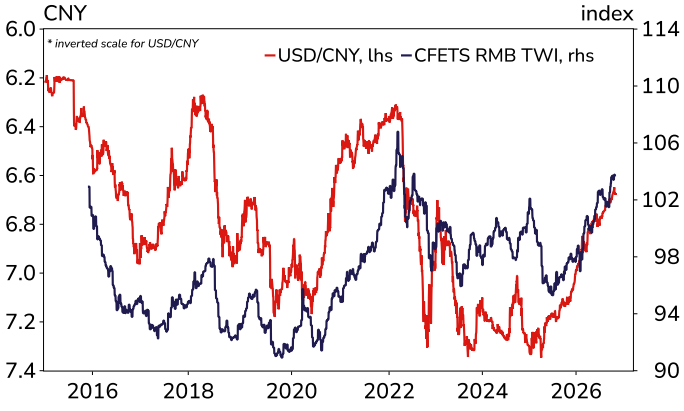
A number of factors have a role to play here. While China's renminbi has already strengthened from around CNY7.00 at the beginning of the year to CNY6.67 currently, a pro-active stimulus initiative of scale would buoy sentiment materially, with flow-on consequences for many others in the region. Similarly, the sustaining of strong growth by developed economies of the region like Singapore and Taiwan and those still on their development path, Vietnam being a prime example, will offer investors a deep and diversified environment to position for long-term growth. The greater the array of alternatives, the more pressure the US dollar will face.

JPY may finally get a bid



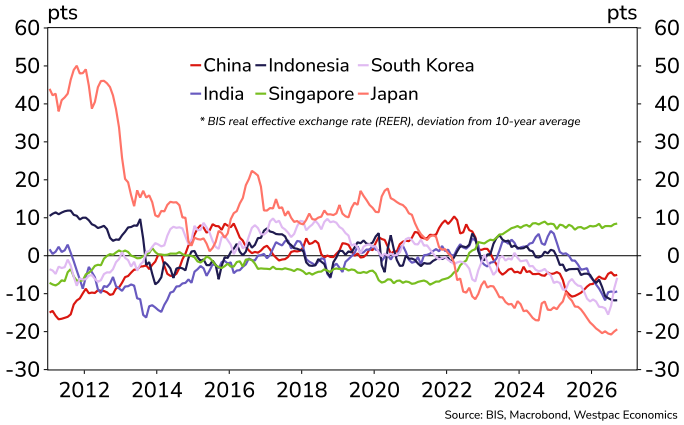
Source: Bloomberg, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

Renminbi breaking up



Source: Bloomberg, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

Asia's outlook promising



Source: BIS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

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A busy month with some surprises ...

Darren Gibbs
Senior Economist

There have been several significant developments in New Zealand since we released the October edition of our Market Outlook, including a General Election, an RBNZ policy meeting and some surprising economic data.

Starting with the General Election on 7 November, as polls had suggested, this proved to be a very tight contest. Indeed, the ultimate winner of the election will not be known with certainty until the final official results are published on 27 November. The theme of the election was one of fragmentation, with the traditional major parties – National and Labour – recording their lowest combined vote on record.

As we set out in more detail in our post-election report, on election night the centre-right bloc of National, NZ First and ACT won 67 seats. In what is currently expected to be a 131-seat parliament – thus requiring 66 seats to govern – this gives the bloc a one seat majority. The centre-left bloc of Labour, Greens and Te Pāti Māori won 57 seats on election night, while the Opportunity Party – entering parliament for the first time – won seven seats. Relative to 2023, there was a swing away from National both to its coalition partners and to the centre left bloc. Notably, several senior National ministers have not been re-elected, including Finance Minister Nicola Willis.

While the election night count means that the centre-right is in the box seat, there are still around 400,000 special votes to be counted (including around 100,000 overseas votes). Historically, these votes have significantly favoured the centre-left parties, especially the Greens, thus reducing the centre-right's vote share when the final count is completed. If that were to occur again, it is quite possible that a party list seat will transfer from the centre-right (most probably NZ First) to the centre-left (most probably the Greens).

In addition, the National Party's current 42 seat haul – seven seats greater than its normal entitlement based on its party vote share – would decline should it lose one of several seats it currently holds by a narrow margin (e.g., the Wairarapa seat, where the National candidate currently leads by just 139 votes) without a pick-up elsewhere. The loss of an electorate seat by National combined with the transfer of a party-list seat from the centre-right to the centre-left would leave the centre-right with just 65 seats in what would become a 130-seat Parliament. The centre-right would thus need the support of the Opportunity Party to govern – support that that centre-right might seek in any case given the narrowness of even its current majority.

Whilst less likely, it remains mathematically possible that the final vote could deliver a centre-left government, supported by the Opportunity Party. This would occur if NZ First were to a lose a party list seat to the Greens whilst National were to lose two electorate seats (it currently holds the Hamilton East seat by 456 votes). In this situation, the centre-right bloc would control just 64 seats in a 129-seat parliament. Therefore, understandably, both the Prime Minister and the leader of the Labour Party have indicated that substantive coalition negotiations will not take place until the final count is known.

In other news, the RBNZ surprised financial markets at its 28 October meeting by leaving the Official Cash Rate (OCR) unchanged at 2.75%. A 25bp increase had been almost fully priced, and Westpac Economics, along with most forecasters, had expected a hike to 3% (we had changed our view just a week prior to the meeting, in part because we thought the Bank would be reluctant to disappoint market pricing). Instead, the Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) voted 4–3 to hold, implementing the pause that it had originally signalled in September and allowing more time to assess the effects of the 50bps of tightening delivered since July.

The close vote reflected differences over the timing of further tightening rather than disagreement about the broad outlook. All seven MPC members accepted that additional monetary restraint would probably be needed, conditional on how the economy evolved. The three members favouring an immediate increase placed greater weight on elevated core inflation, the increasing breadth of price rises and the risk that the latest fuel and exchange-rate shocks could become embedded in inflation expectations, wage-setting and firms' pricing behaviour. They argued that acting promptly would reduce the danger of having to tighten more aggressively later.

The four-member majority, including Governor Anna Breman, preferred to wait. They emphasised that September-quarter annual inflation, at 3.7%, had been lower than the Bank expected; wage growth remained subdued; inflation expectations were stable; and the indirect effects of higher fuel prices had so far been smaller than assumed. Weak household spending and residential investment were limiting firms' ability to pass higher costs through to customers or rebuild margins. The majority also saw value in observing the delayed impact of the two recent OCR increases before adding further restraint. Global risks also received considerable prominence. The Committee highlighted geopolitical tensions, high energy prices, elevated debt, financial vulnerabilities and uncertainty over whether booming AI investment was justified by economic fundamentals. It was argued that these factors could sustain inflation but could also trigger an abrupt global downturn, reinforcing the case for waiting.

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… but medium-term outlook is little changed

Nevertheless, the decision was not dovish. The Bank expected annual inflation to rise to 4.4% in the December quarter, reflecting elevated fuel prices and a roughly 3% fall in the exchange rate since early September. Core inflation had moved towards the top of the 1–3% target range, while price increases had become more broad-based. The Committee therefore retained a clear tightening bias, stating that a higher OCR was likely, although incoming information could change the appropriate stance in either direction.

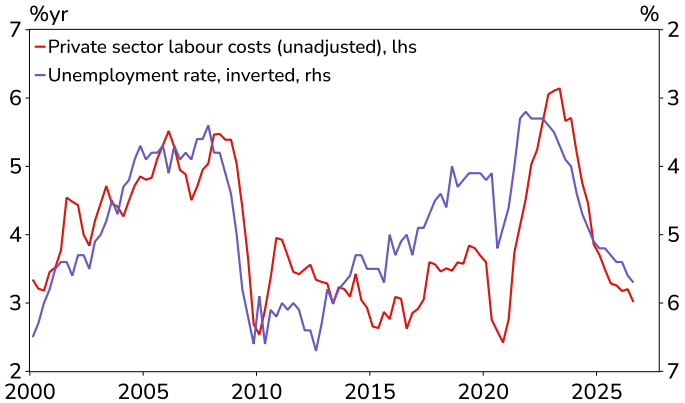
Looking ahead, our baseline forecast remains for a 25bp hike at the RBNZ's next meeting on 9 December. However, as we commented at the time of the October meeting, a rate hike should not be regarded as a done deal. And the likelihood of the RBNZ extending the October pause increased following the release of the labour market reports for the September quarter. The household survey measure of employment unexpectedly fell 0.1%qtr, which together with downward revisions to previous quarters saw annual growth slow to 0.7%yr – just half of the growth forecast by the RBNZ in the September MPS.

We think that underlying momentum in the September quarter is somewhat stronger than suggested by the household survey, with the tax-based Monthly Employment Indicator suggesting modest growth (and similar growth to the household survey over the year as a whole). However, the weak signal was further demonstrated by the unemployment rate, which is less susceptible to the quarter-to-quarter sample volatility seen in the household survey. This rose 0.1ppts to a fresh 11-year high of 5.7%. Moreover, youth unemployment is at levels not seen since the survey first began in 1986.

Wage growth also remained subdued in the September quarter, with the unadjusted private sector Labour Cost Index rising just 2.9%yr – the smallest increase since 2021 (and since 2017, excluding the disruption caused by the pandemic). Together with signs of greater than expected slack in labour market, this result is likely to embolden those members of the RBNZ's MPC that believe that second-round inflation impacts from oil shock are likely to be contained (especially if oil prices sustain their recent decline). That said, this week RBNZ Chief Economist, Paul Conway, said that he would still have voted for a hike in October, even if he had known the Q3 labour survey outcome.

There are a few further important domestic data releases before we get the next RBNZ meeting, including the RBNZ's suite of inflation expectations indicators, consumer and business confidence surveys and monthly partial CPI data for October. Together with developments in the global economy and financial markets – a key focus for some MPC members –

Unemployment rate and private sector wages



Source: Stats NZ, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

	2025		2026									
Monthly data	**Nov**	**Dec**	**Jan**	**Feb**	**Mar**	**Apr**	**May**	**Jun**	**Jul**	**Aug**	**Sep**	**Oct**
REINZ house sales %mth	–0.1	0.6	–5.4	4.3	–2.4	–1.1	–3.8	–0.3	–2.9	–0.1	–4.1	–
Residential building consents %mth	2.6	–4.2	2.2	2.5	–0.8	12.6	–5.4	–3.8	–4.7	5.3	–7.9	–
Electronic card transactions %mth	1.1	–0.1	–1.1	1.3	0.6	–1.3	1.6	–1.4	1.1	–1.0	–0.5	–0.7
Private sector credit %yr	4.4	4.6	4.6	4.7	4.9	4.7	4.8	4.9	4.9	4.8	5.0	–
Commodity prices %mth	–1.6	–2.2	2.0	4.2	4.2	–0.8	0.8	–1.1	–4.0	–0.4	0.6	0.6
Trade balance $mn	–379	–216	–352	–918	–376	207	–1113	–764	–1318	–263	–204	–

Quarterly data	**Q2:24**	**Q3:24**	**Q4:24**	**Q1:25**	**Q2:25**	**Q3:25**	**Q4:25**	**Q1:26**	**Q2:26**	**Q3:26**
Westpac McDermott Miller Consumer Confidence	82.2	90.8	97.5	89.2	91.2	90.9	96.5	94.7	80.4	89.5
Quarterly Survey of Business Opinion	–26	–29	–27	–22	–21	–15	–3	0	1	–1
Unemployment rate %	4.7	4.9	5.1	5.2	5.2	5.3	5.4	5.4	5.6	5.7
CPI %yr	3.3	2.2	2.2	2.5	2.7	3.0	3.1	3.1	4.1	3.7
Real GDP %yr	1.1	0.4	–0.3	–0.9	–1.1	–0.5	0.3	0.9	1.7	–
Current account balance % of GDP	–5.5	–5.3	–4.9	–4.4	–3.6	–3.1	–3.0	–3.0	–3.2	–

Sources: Government agencies, Bloomberg, Macrobond, Westpac Economics. Some data omitted from certain series due to Lunar New Year distortions. *4qma

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Pacific economies deal with external shocks ...

Shamal Chand, Senior Pacific Economist
Justin Smirk, Senior Economist

Pacific economies are exposed to major external shocks. Distance from major markets, small domestic economies and a heavy reliance on imported fuel and food mean global disruptions tend to reach the Pacific at a higher cost than in larger, wealthier nations. This time is no different. However, robust tourism, remittances and commodity earnings combined with healthy foreign reserves mean most Pacific countries face the latest shock with somewhat better buffers from the start.

Geopolitical focus has shifted

Geopolitical interest in the Pacific has evolved over time. China's growing presence over the past decade saw Australia, New Zealand, the United States and others deepen their engagement in the region across infrastructure, development and security. The headlines may have become quieter, but the strategic interest has not disappeared. Pacific countries sit at the cross road of important sea and communication routes and control vast ocean territories rich in fisheries and potential mineral resources. Governments have generally used this interest to their advantage, maintaining the familiar Pacific position of being **"friends to all and enemies to none"**.

The latest Middle East conflict brings the Pacific's vulnerabilities back into focus. There is limited direct trade exposure, but that hardly makes the region immune. Higher fuel, freight, insurance and shipping costs find their way into the cost of imported food, transport, electricity and the overall cost of doing business. The regional central banks' heavy focus on foreign reserves management, and pegged exchange rate regimes, has provided something of a buffer to the immediate shocks.

Tonga perhaps captures this exposure best. The National Reserve Bank of Tonga Annual Report 2026 noted that global shocks transmit "almost instantly through prices to the local economy". The good news is that Tonga has substantial buffers, with reserves enough to cover 11.5 months of imports.

Tourism is critical for Fiji, and resources for PNG

In Fiji, tourism is doing much of the heavy lifting. Some 762,352 visitors arrived in the first nine months of 2026, 3.7% more than a year earlier, while September recorded a monthly high of 95,970. Australia accounted for nearly half of September arrivals, followed by New Zealand. Foreign reserves provide another cushion, standing at FJ$4.1 billion in September, equivalent to 5.7 months of retained imports.

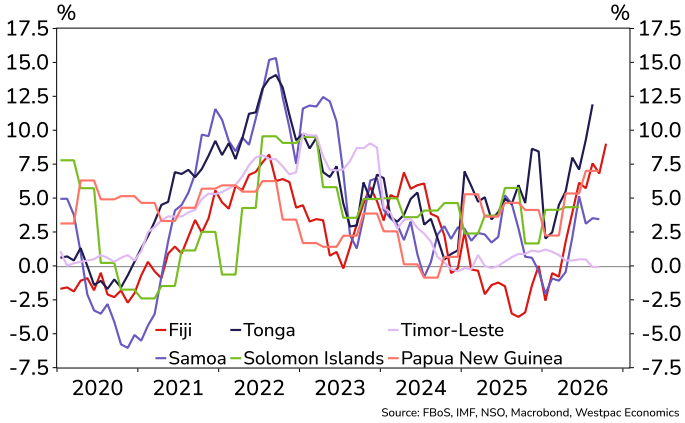
The story is slightly different elsewhere. Samoa continues to receive sizeable tourism and remittance inflows, with July receipts reaching SAT70.6 million and SAT94.2 million respectively. Vanuatu had enough reserves in May to cover 14.6 months of imports, although higher petrol and diesel costs are flowing into transport expenses.

PNG has commodities providing a different cushion. Resource exports support foreign exchange earnings, but households remain exposed to expensive fuel. The government's K1 billion fuel stabilisation package offered some relief before the direct subsidy was phased out in November. Port Moresby's maximum indicative diesel price subsequently moved to K6.69 per litre, a 51% increase after remaining mostly unchanged since March.

Other Pacific economies have their own buffers: gold and fisheries in Solomon Islands, fishing revenues and offshore assets in Kiribati and Tuvalu, the Petroleum Fund in Timor-Leste, and nickel in New Caledonia. But high prices remains the common theme across the small island countries.

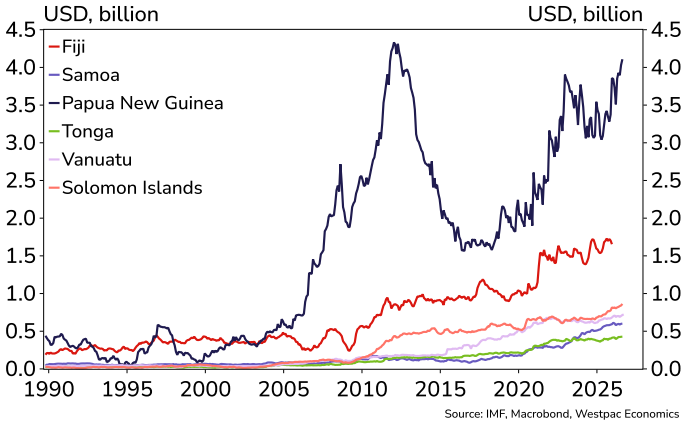
So far, these buffers are holding. The bigger question is how long will they need to? A prolonged period of expensive energy and freight, particularly if tourism and/or commodity prices weaken, would make the next phase more difficult for these small islands. As such, the risks are skewed to the downside.

Pacific inflation swings



Source: FBoS, IMF, NSO, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

Pacific international reserves holding



Source: IMF, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

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… and have stronger COP31 expectations this time

The 31st United Nations Climate Change Conference (COP31) opened in Antalya, Türkiye, on November 9th with a familiar challenge: turning years of climate commitments into tangible action. Türkiye is presiding over the summit, while Australia's Climate Change and Energy Minister, Chris Bowen, is serving as President of Negotiations. For Pacific countries, expectations are high with Australia at the negotiating table.

The Pacific is pushing for immediate action to keep global warming within 1.5°c, accelerate the transition away from fossil fuels, improve access to climate and Loss and Damage finance, and give the oceans a stronger place in climate action. As UN Climate Change Executive Secretary Simon Stiell acknowledged at the opening, global climate progress remains "nowhere near far enough or fair enough."

These priorities were reinforced through the "Taku Pakasoa Declaration", adopted at the Pre-COP31 meetings in Fiji and Tuvalu in October, alongside calls for stronger implementation, better access to finance and greater recognition of the ocean. "Taku Pakasoa" is Tuvaluan and essentially means strength through unity and collective action.

Early opening day moves

The opening days in Antalya have begun to translate some of these priorities into the negotiating agenda, although no major outcome has yet emerged. Discussions on climate finance are under way, while Chris Bowen has initiated work towards a Presidency-initiated, Party-driven COP31 decision intended to provide a focused and practical response to the challenges facing the summit. Countries are being encouraged to shape the political package early, rather than leaving the hardest discussions until the final days.

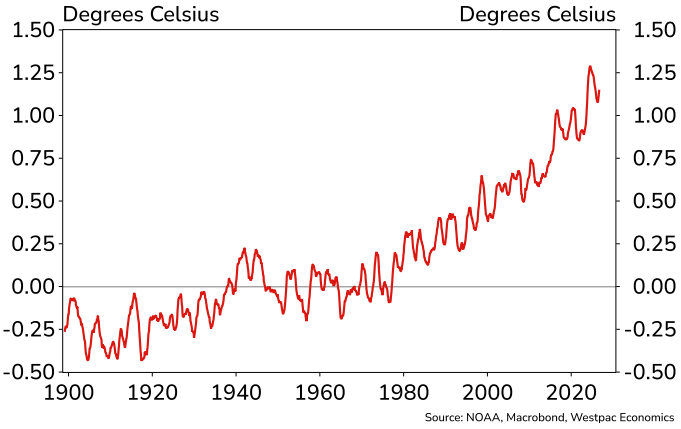
Energy is also moving to the centre of discussions. Brazil presented a roadmap aimed at translating global commitments to transition away from fossil fuels into national plans. Meanwhile, an IEA report, commissioned by Türkiye and Australia, finds that electricity could cost-effectively rise from around 23% of global final energy consumption in 2025 to 33% by 2035. This assessment assumes currently available technologies and broadly pre-2026 energy-shock prices and financing conditions. For import dependent Pacific economies, greater electrification could offer an additional benefit by reducing exposure to volatile global fuel markets.

The climate finance gap

For Pacific leaders, delivery remains the real test. Fiji's Environment and Climate Change Minister, Lynda Tabuya, called for climate finance to reach "the people who really need it" and for the ocean to take "its rightful place in the climate agenda."

The Fund for responding to Loss and Damage illustrates the challenge. US$822.06 million had been pledged by March 2026, but its initial operational funding envelope was only US$250 million.

Global temperature nearing threshold



Source: NOAA, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

The distinction between money pledged and finance actually reaching vulnerable communities remains important.

For the Pacific, success will therefore depend less on headline commitments and more on whether finance becomes easier and faster to access for adaptation, resilience and clean-energy projects domestically.

Australia's test

Australia remains something of a double-edged sword for Pacific climate interests.

It is a major development and climate-finance partner and now has an influential role in the negotiations. Yet Australia also remains a significant fossil-fuel producer and exporter, creating tension with the Pacific's push for a credible pathway to keep 1.5°c within reach.

That makes COP31 an important test of Australian regional leadership. The summit is increasingly moving from debating whether the transition should occur towards how it will be delivered. The fossil-fuel roadmap, electrification push and renewed focus on climate finance are early steps, but they remain processes rather than final outcomes.

For the Pacific, COP31 is not about another declaration of ambition. It is about whether commitments finally translate into outcomes on the ground.

For Australia, the test is whether its influence at the negotiating table can help bridge the gap between Pacific expectations, global commitments and delivery.

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Patience is a virtue ...

Elliot Clarke
Head of International Economics

China GDP surprised to the upside in Q3 2026, quarterly growth accelerating from 0.9% in Q2 to 1.2% in Q3. Annual growth lifted from 4.3% to 4.5% as a result. Though, on a year-to-date basis, growth edged down 0.1ppts to 4.6%.

The Q3 result keeps authorities on track to achieve their 4.5-5.0%ytd ambition for 2026, and also provides a little more time to accelerate domestic demand into 2027. Broad-based stimulus is required because net exports' contribution to growth will likely abate in coming quarters now that the trade surplus is back at record highs, and as many Chinese firms diversify their risks by expanding domestic and offshore production networks contemporaneously.

While annual retail sales growth accelerated from 0.4% to 1.1% in September, the Q3 year-to-date growth pulse of 1.1% is just a quarter of the gain reported a year ago. Automobiles, construction materials and jewellery have been particularly heavy detractors over the past year; however, most of the other sub-categories lack momentum.

As we last detailed two months ago in our September Market Outlook, this is not because households are cash constrained, but rather as sentiment is extremely weak and the outlook for employment and wealth highly uncertain.

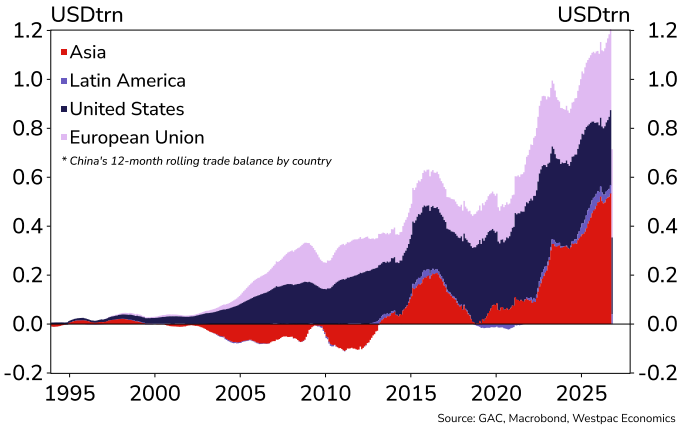
Key for wealth is that house prices for new and established homes continue to decline month-on-month (respectively 0.1% and 0.3% in September), five years into the downturn. Property investment's ongoing decline (–20.6%ytd) makes clear that this persistent weakness in sales and prices is demand driven.

More broadly, total fixed asset investment has been an outright negative for annual GDP growth since April. But a recovery is not beyond either the public or private sector's capacity. Rather, across the economy, entities are waiting for direction and incentive from the Central Government. This is likely to come by early-2027, to offset the loss of support from trade and as downside risks to global growth linger.

Helpfully, industrial production continues to grow at a robust pace, 5.3%ytd, borrowing rates for businesses and households are low, and authorities are beginning to provide banks with additional lending capacity.

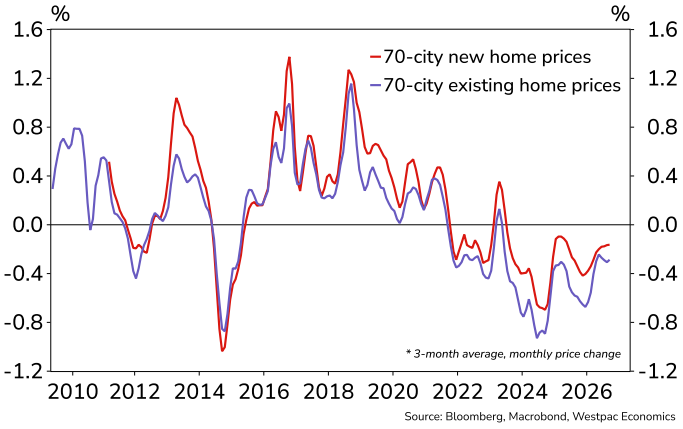
For larger businesses, officials are also reportedly encouraging major institutional investors to increase their structural allocation to domestic equities, building lasting appetite for new equity issuance to fund future waves of real economic capacity and income generation.

Trade surplus at record high



Source: GAC, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

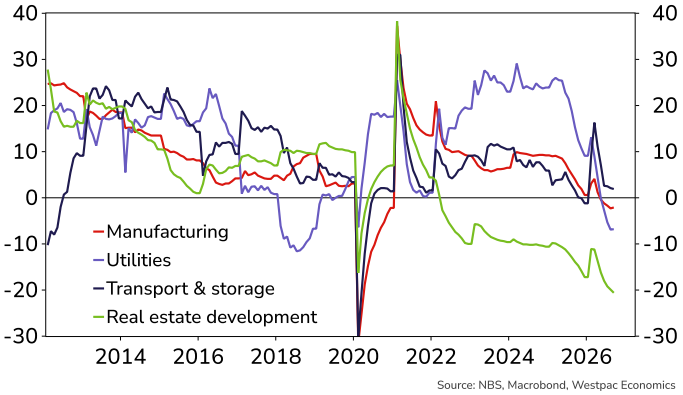
Wealth needs additional support ...



Source: Bloomberg, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

... as does investment

Fixed Asset Investment by Industry (%ytd)



Source: NBS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

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... but also a risk

China's strong position in global technology should provide firms with the confidence to continue investing ahead of expected demand. This is particularly the case in areas which are in structural uptrends, most notably electric vehicles and other green technology as well as components of high-tech manufacturing and infrastructure – not to mention the race to develop AI.

The consumer is expected to prove much harder to win over to the growth story. The relationship between investment and employment is likely to remain abnormally weak owing to Chinese firms' success with robotics and efficiency.

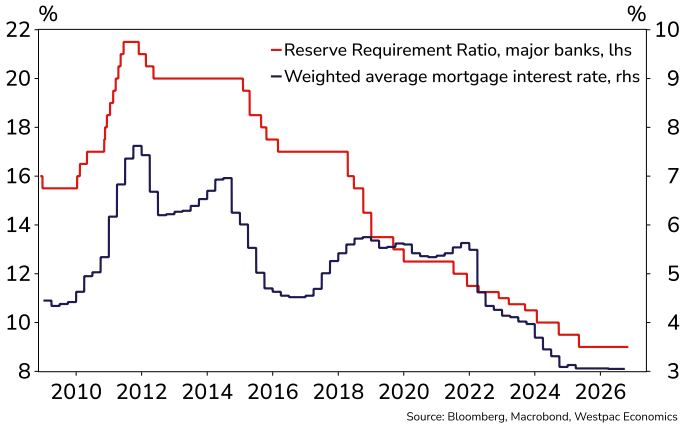
In services, the co-ordination across China's major technology firms for the development and adoption of AI is expected to have a similar effect on employment demand.

The risks on this front are to the downside too. Young workers today are considerably more educated and skilled than in the past, and increasingly beholden to a long work week culture. All else equal, this should lead to high output per marginal worker.

The flow-on benefit to household income from increased labour demand will also potentially be curtailed by Chinese firms' focus on research & development and capacity over reporting and distributing profits. The pall over the market also needs to lift to allow households to realise capital gains from China's industrial success.

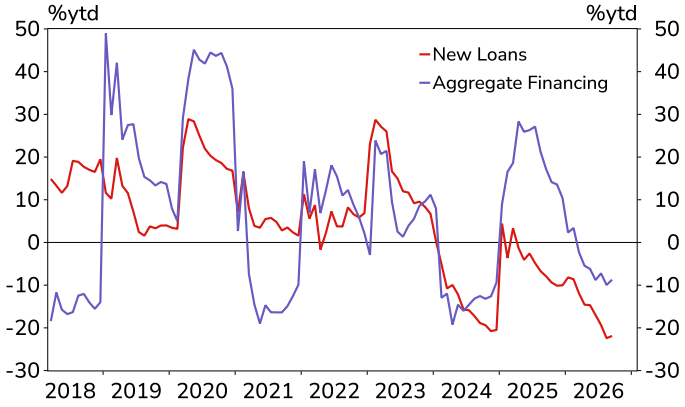
The above means a stimulus-induced recovery in the property sector and real asset investment by local government entities is, once again, most likely to prove the catalyst for a turn in household demand. With a lag, the tightening up of the labour market and a dividend to consumers from past and current industrial development could then with a delay accelerate the trend.

Monetary policy already accommodative



Source: Bloomberg, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

Credit impulse deeply negative



Source: Bloomberg, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

	2025			2026								
Monthly data %yr	Oct	Nov	Dec	Jan	Feb	Mar	Apr	May	Jun	Jul	Aug	Sep
Headline CPI %yr	0.2	0.7	0.8	0.2	1.3	1.0	1.2	1.2	1.0	0.5	0.8	0.9
M2 money supply %yr	8.2	8.0	8.5	9.0	9.0	8.5	8.6	8.6	8.0	7.7	7.5	7.2
Manufacturing PMI (official)	49.0	49.2	50.1	49.3	49.0	50.4	50.3	50.0	50.3	49.2	49.8	50.1
Fixed asset investment ytd %yr	–1.7	–2.6	–3.8	–3.8	1.8	1.7	–1.6	–4.1	–5.7	–6.7	–7.2	–
Industrial production %yr	4.9	4.8	5.2	5.2	6.3	5.7	4.1	4.5	5.3	4.5	5.2	–
Exports %yr	–1.3	5.8	6.4	10.0	39.6	2.5	14.0	19.2	26.9	23.9	25.0	36.3
Imports %yr	1.8	2.6	6.4	26.9	14.7	28.4	25.3	27.4	35.8	27.5	28.2	31.0
Trade balance USDbn	88.0	109.9	111.9	120.0	89.2	49.8	84.4	105.0	125.5	112.5	119.1	133.5

Quarterly data	Mar–25	Jun–25	Sep–25	Dec–25	Mar–26	Jun–26
Real GDP %yr	5.4	5.2	4.8	4.5	5.0	4.3
Nominal GDP %yr	4.6	3.9	3.7	3.9	4.9	5.9

Sources: Government agencies, Bloomberg, Macrobond, Westpac Economics. Some data omitted from certain series due to Lunar New Year distortions. *4qma

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AI build out risks justified ...

Elliot Clarke
Head of International Economics

Economic data received over the past month suggests the US economy carried strong momentum into the second half of 2026. That said, of concern for the outlook, questions are being asked over the profitability of AI infrastructure and deployment – a critical contributor of recent economic growth – household real incomes are trending flat to down, and term interest rates continue to weigh on housing investment. An offset to these risks may be forthcoming, however, with the mid-term result a call to President Trump to make a deal with Iran.

Momentum was certainly broad in Q3, the 3.4% annualised gain for GDP benefitting from a 3.8% annualised increase in household consumption, 12.7% growth in non-residential investment as well as a robust increase in government spending. That said, the contribution from business investment was effectively offset by net exports in Q3, as most of the componentry related to AI infrastructure investment is imported.

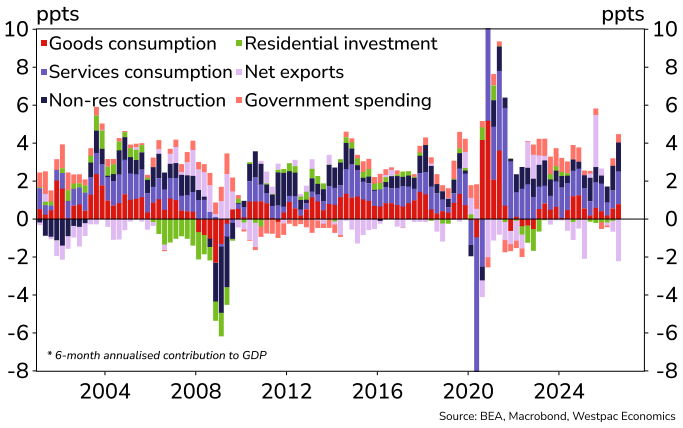
While strong overall, consumer spending lost momentum through the quarter, the September PCE data indicating that – on a real basis – consumption was flat in the month following a robust 0.5% gain in August and reliant on dissaving. Conscious or not, this is clearly a concern for many households, with University of Michigan consumer sentiment holding near historic lows. The pressure on housing activity is also acute, with first-home buyer and upgrader serviceability heavily constrained.

Still, aggregate wealth remains near record highs, and consumers continue to add to their stock of assets. Employment growth also remains positive and the unemployment rate low. For established households too, only the marginal dollar spent on housing investment attracts current elevated interest rates, with the cost of servicing loans contracted in prior years unchanged.

While questions are beginning to be asked over the scalability and profitability of businesses at the vanguard of AI and tech infrastructure, and greater regulation is a risk come 2027 or 2028, financing continues to flow to the sector in scale. Meta, Oracle and Alphabet have all undertaken successful equity and / or debt raisings over the past month; and the much-anticipated Anthropic IPO (expected to be one of the largest ever) is due within weeks.

Rapid infrastructure development is always at risk of delays and a change in sentiment. But the capital being made available to these firms and the urgency the companies are showing over their opportunity set suggests construction activity will continue to grow through 2027 and 2028 and thereafter have a long tail.

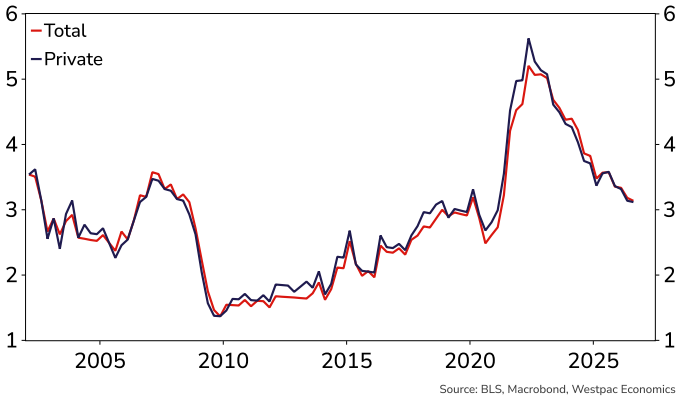
GDP growth had breadth in Q3



Source: BEA, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

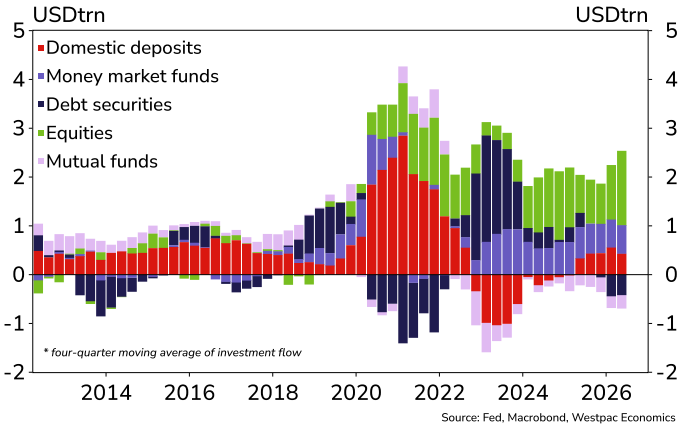
Inflation netting out wage gains

Employment Cost Index (%yr)



Source: BLS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

But consumer wealth rising



Source: Fed, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

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... come 2028

Ahead of their IPO, Anthropic alone has announced commitments totalling USD895bn related to computing power and infrastructure, up USD100bn since end-September. According to Bloomberg, just USD70bn of the total spend (less than 10%) is slated for construction by September 2027, and USD448bn due through 2030.

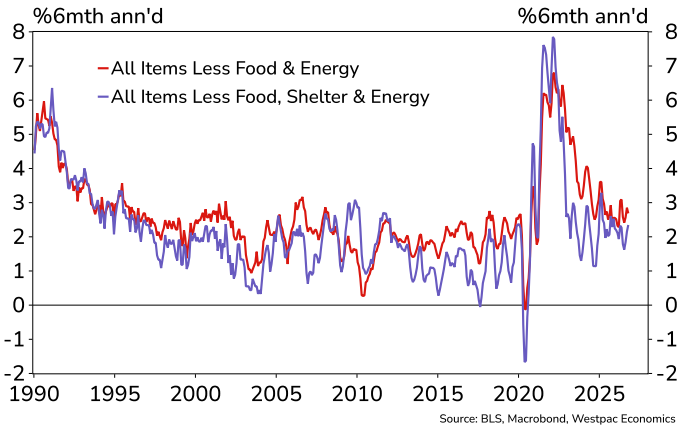
The key questions related to US GDP are therefore not the scale and persistence of AI-related spending, but rather how much will be eaten up by sectoral inflation and, although these are US-based firms, how quickly the investment drive will broaden across borders. Current capacity restrictions for US power and logistics certainly favour a larger share of new investment increasingly being undertaken outside the US. The risk of additional regulation also argues for geographic spread.

So, given recent announcements and the flow of capital, and with the Democrats' win likely to help ease cost-of-living pressures early in the next Congressional term, we have revised up our growth view for the US to 2.4% broadly in line with 2026. But, come 2028, a return to trend growth seems probable, arguably with building downside risks.

While inflation risks are therefore likely to dissipate over the forecast period, in the near term they will remain acute. A December 25bp hike has seemed inevitable since the October on hold decision. And, based on the telegraphed fears of many FOMC members, a further 25bp increase in January has become more probable than not.

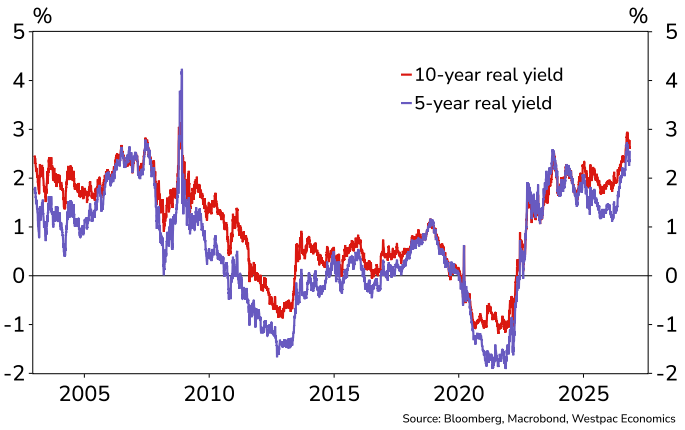
These decisions are responses to the inflation experienced to date and concern over the potential lagged impact of tariff, tech and energy pressures experienced by US firms over the last year. Two hikes would also put off any concerns over lingering risks for expectations. Note though, on our estimates, this will set policy at a modestly restrictive setting, which is not sustainable as growth normalises. So, come 2028, we continue to look for two rate cuts, with the risk of more.

Shelter critical for core inflation pulse



Source: BLS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

Real yields up on growth and fiscal risk



Source: Bloomberg, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

	2025	2026										
Monthly data	**Dec**	**Jan**	**Feb**	**Mar**	**Apr**	**May**	**Jun**	**Jul**	**Aug**	**Sep**	**Oct**	**Nov**
PCE deflator %yr	2.8	2.7	2.8	3.4	3.6	3.8	3.5	3.4	3.4	3.6	–	–
Unemployment rate %	4.4	4.3	4.4	4.3	4.3	4.3	4.2	4.1	4.1	4.2	4.1	–
Nonfarm payrolls chg '000	–17	160	–156	214	148	63	31	–10	186	60	165	–
House prices* %yr	1.5	1.3	1.0	1.0	1.2	1.7	2.1	2.5	2.6	–	–	–
Durables orders core 3mth %saar	8.9	5.5	8.5	22.0	20.6	22.2	12.4	18.1	16.4	11.8	–	–
ISM manufacturing composite	47.9	52.6	52.4	52.7	52.7	54.0	53.3	55.6	54.6	54.5	55.5	–
ISM services composite	53.8	53.8	56.1	54.0	53.6	54.5	54.0	54.1	55.4	54.9	54.5	–
Personal spending 3mth %saar	4.0	3.6	4.4	6.9	9.2	10.1	7.6	5.4	5.8	6.6	–	–
UoM consumer sentiment	52.9	56.4	56.6	53.3	49.8	44.8	49.5	55.2	51.7	48.1	48.0	51.0
Trade balance USDbn	–76.1	–52.7	–52.5	–53.7	–52.9	–75.8	–71.2	–92.8	–105.7	–105.0	–	–

Quarterly data	**Sep–25**	**Dec–25**	**Mar–26**	**Jun–26**	**Sep–26**	**Dec–26(f)**
Real GDP % saar	3.9	0.2	2.5	2.2	3.4	2.4
Current account USDbn	–262.9	–221.1	–212.6	–246.0	–	–

Sources: Government agencies, Bloomberg, *S&P Case–Shiller 20–city measure.

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The Bank of Japan's normalisation ...

Illiana Jain
Economist

The Bank of Japan's normalisation cycle has further to run. We expect the BoJ to raise its policy rate by 25bps to 1.50% in December, before gradually taking it to 2.0% through 2027. The case for further tightening is not principally that headline inflation is high. Rather, the evidence increasingly suggests Japan has shifted into an environment where firms are more willing to raise prices, labour scarcity supports persistent wage growth and nominal wage gains should increasingly translate into real incomes and household spending. With inflation anchored at around 2%, a nominal policy rate of 2.0% would also leave real rates around zero, suggesting policy would be closer to neutral than outright restrictive.

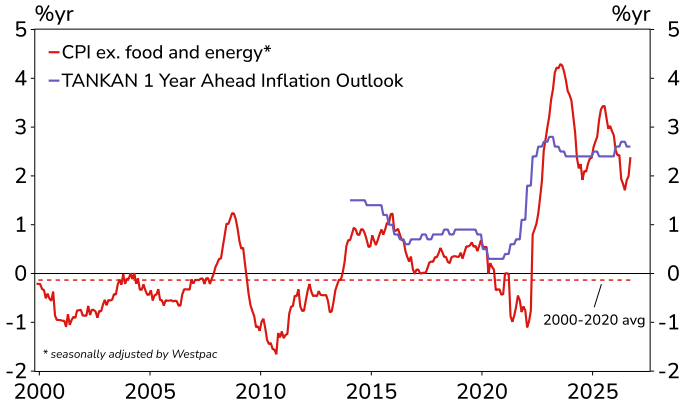
That is increasingly consistent with the BoJ's own assessment. In the October minutes, the BoJ judged underlying inflation to be at a level broadly consistent with its 2% target, while medium-to-long-term inflation expectations are around 2%. More significantly, the discussion has shifted towards the risk of inflation exceeding target. Risks to prices are now skewed to the upside, with firms increasingly willing to raise both wages and prices.

Recent energy-price developments provide an important test of that change in behaviour. Higher crude prices have naturally lifted energy inflation, but the effects are spreading beyond the petrol pump. Higher input costs are increasingly being passed through to a broader range of consumer prices rather than absorbed in firms' margins, while inflation excluding fresh food and energy is expected to remain above 2%. This broader pass-through is important evidence that Japan's inflation psychology has changed. Services inflation has already remained above 1% for almost four years, compared with an average of just 0.3% between 2011 and 2021.

For the BoJ, however, wages remain the critical test of whether 2% inflation can endure. The evidence remains encouraging. Rengo's FY2026 negotiations delivered wage increases of 5.08%, following 5.25% last year. Importantly, the gains have broadened across the economy: SMEs agreed increases averaging 4.84%, little different from the 5.10% delivered by larger firms.

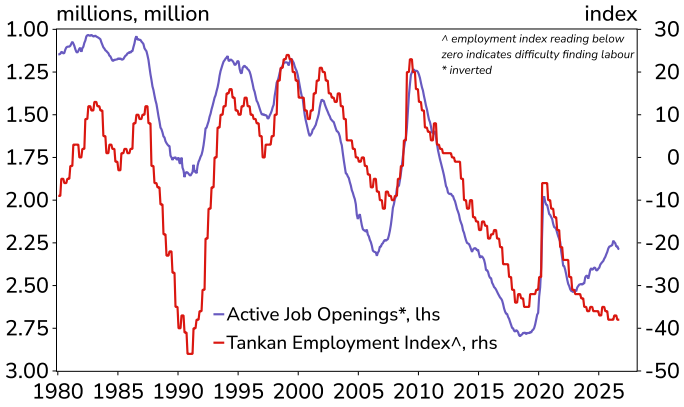
Bonus payments provide another important signal. Summer bonuses increased by around 7%yr, adding to growth in regular earnings. Attention now turns to winter bonuses, due shortly. With corporate profits remaining elevated, another strong outcome would provide an early indication that firms have both the willingness and capacity to deliver sizeable wage increases again in 2027.

Inflation is structurally higher



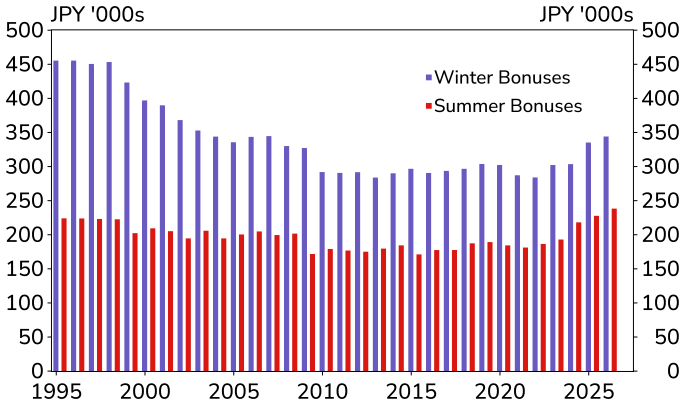
Source: SBJ, BOJ, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

Still a tight labour market



Source: BOJ, MHLW, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

Summer bonuses pave the way for strong wages



Source: MHLW, RENGO, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

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... has further to run

There are already encouraging signs. The BoJ reports hearing from firms that they intend to raise wages at a similar rate next year, while its baseline forecast assumes base-pay increases around the same level as in 2025 and continued nominal wage growth through 2027. The question is increasingly whether these nominal gains can finally translate into sustained gains in household purchasing power.

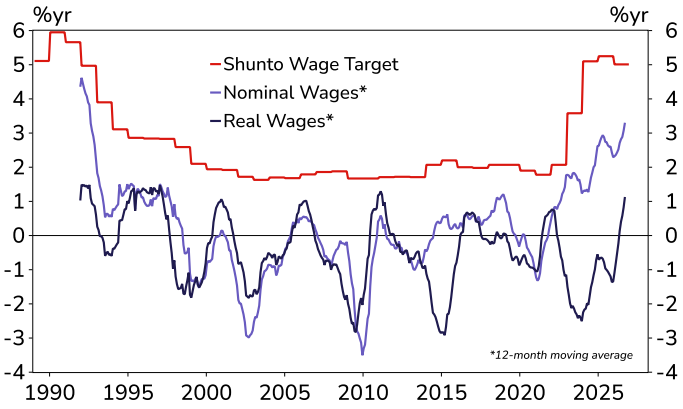
That is also the key link to consumption. Higher energy prices have eroded real incomes, leaving private consumption resilient but lacking momentum despite strong nominal wage growth. This restraint should ease through 2027. As energy pressures fade while wages continue rising, real income growth should strengthen and allow wage gains to feed more clearly into household spending. The BoJ similarly expects the virtuous cycle from income to spending to intensify from FY2027, supporting a return to moderate consumption growth.

Corporate Japan appears well placed to sustain this adjustment. The operating profit-to-sales ratio is around 6.01%, its highest since the 1960s, including 5.5% for manufacturers and 6.2% for services. More importantly, those profits are increasingly being deployed domestically. Governor Ueda recently noted that more than 70% of Japanese firms reported investing more actively at home in 2023-24 than previously, with labour shortages the most commonly cited motivation. Business investment has exceeded its early-1990s peak, while bank lending is growing at more than 5%, the strongest pace in three decades outside 2020.

This combination of strong profitability, investment and persistent labour scarcity reinforces the prospect that higher wages can be sustained without placing undue pressure on firms. It also strengthens the case for further normalisation. At the October meeting, one opinion argued that firms' resilience to higher rates meant the BoJ had entered a new phase in which it should step up the pace towards neutral, while another judged the neutral rate to be considerably above 1%.

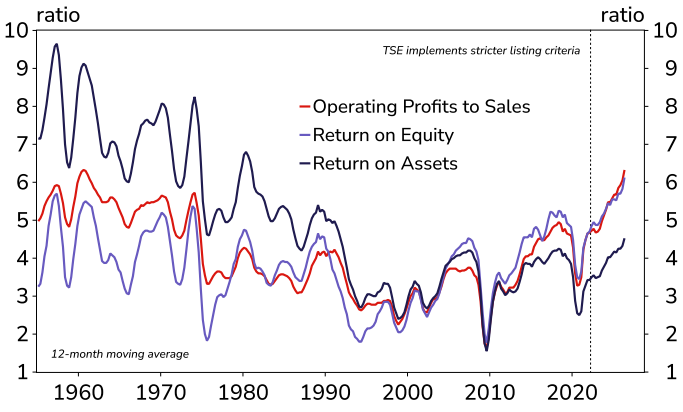
December therefore looks less like the end of the hiking cycle than another step towards neutral. Provided wage growth remains firm, increasingly feeds into real consumption and keeps underlying inflation around 2%, we expect the BoJ of Japan to gradually take the policy rate to 2.0% through 2027.

A monumental lift in wages



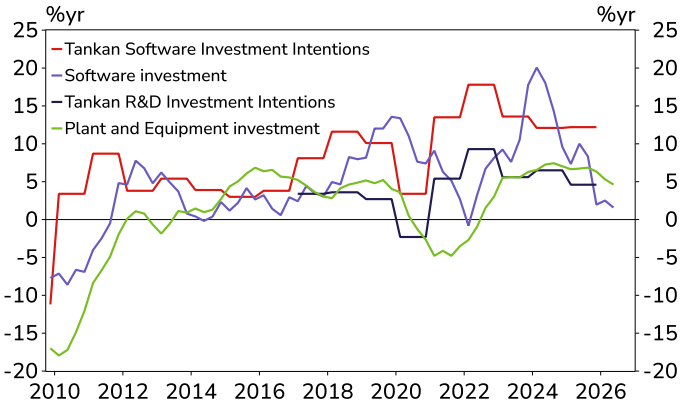
Source: RENGO, MHLW, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

Better capex to aid productivity and wages



Source: MOF, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

Software investment dominates total investment



Source: MOF, BOJ, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

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Cautious optimism ...

Elliot Clarke
Head of International Economics

The ECB left its key policy rates unchanged in October. Another 25bp hike is forecast in December. Against market pricing though, we expect this will prove the last for the current cycle and be reversed in early-2028 once price risks have subsided.

Evident in the communications that accompanied the October decision is a sanguine view of current economic momentum, with activity growth expected to hold near trend and the unemployment rate stable around its historic lows.

While employment and population growth is currently subdued, productivity is gradually picking up. "Over the medium term, a recovery in confidence and real incomes, driven by gradually declining energy prices and a robust labour market, should bolster domestic demand".

"Investment in AI-related activities and government spending on infrastructure and defence should also continue to support growth" and spark optimism over the medium-term outlook.

"Simplifying and harmonising rules across the EU's Single Market, accelerating the energy transition and completing the savings and investments union" also holds promise for business profitability, the public sector's financial position and household wealth and consumer choice.

In contrast to their view on activity, the Council is uncomfortable with the current pace of inflation, its expected trajectory and associated risks.

Highlighted in the decision statement, headline inflation rose to 3.8%yr in September as energy inflation surged to 18.9%yr – diesel and petrol prices reaching new peaks in the month. At the time of the meeting in October, oil prices were back near their cycle highs and persistence in services inflation gave additional cause for concern.

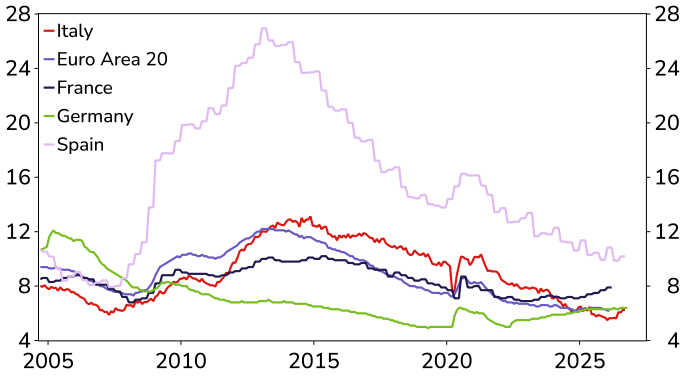
Still, the Council perceived time to be on their side with respect to responding to inflation.

"While the full effects of the energy shock are still unfolding, underlying inflation has remained broadly stable so far and wages do not show a material response". "Financing conditions have [also] tightened", "which is likely to weigh on inflation and growth".

President Lagarde also noted in the press conference that, between the October and December meetings, a significant amount of new economic information will be released, allowing forecasts and risks assessments to be thouroughly tested.

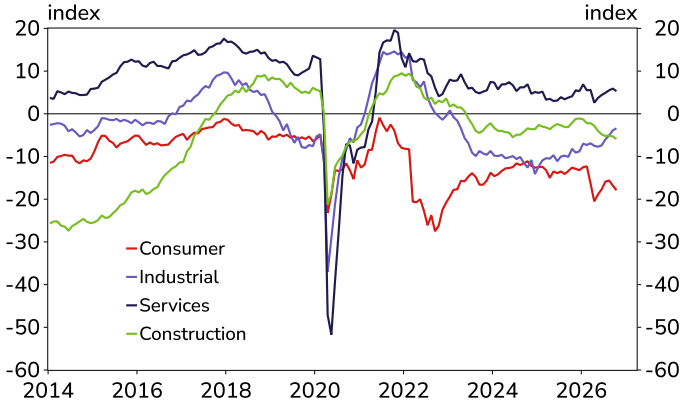
Labour markets fully employed

Unemployment rate (%)



Source: Istat, Eurostat, INSEE, German Federal Employment Agency (Bundesagentur fuer Arbeit), INE, Macrobond, Westpac

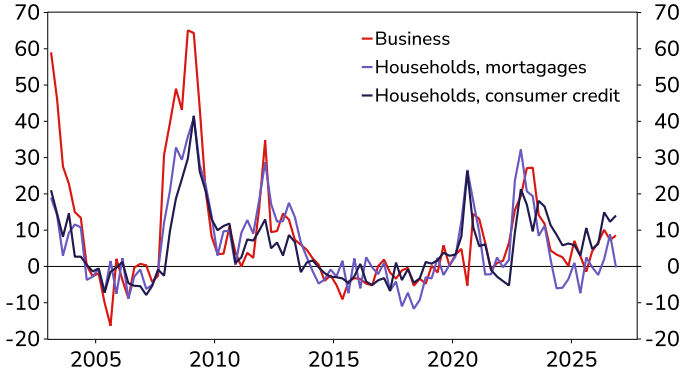
Confidence showing resilience



Source: DG ECFIN, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

Credit standards have been tightened

Net % of banks reporting a tightening of credit standards



Source: ECB, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

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... warranted

During November to date, risks to the energy inflation outlook have materially reduced, the price of Brent oil falling from USD118 at the end of October to USD91 currently.

This abrupt turn largely stems from the market's worst fears regarding the Middle East post the US mid-term election not eventuating as well as a regular flow of anecdotes on indirect communciation between the US and Iran. An active bilateral approach to negotiations should see a further large decline in energy prices, when it occurs. Obviously, this is not a given, but current circumstances offer promise.

Even if progress towards a deal between the US and Iran continues over the next month, however, the Governing Council is likely to take out additional protection against persistent inflation as a result of the underlying health of the economy and as, after this hike, monetary policy will only be marginally contractionary.

In our view though, and against market pricing, another rate hike in Q1/Q2 2027 seems unneccessary at this stage. Over this period, inflation risks related to energy supply should subside at a steady pace. The completion of investment currently being undertaken may also offer an early disinflation dividend, drawing inflation near the 2.0%yr medium-term target. And, with the labour market broadly balanced, there is also little reason for concern over a wage-induced uplift in price pressures.

Looking further ahead, there is reason to believe that, come 2028, the ECB will be able to ease back to a neutral stance despite continued growth at trend.

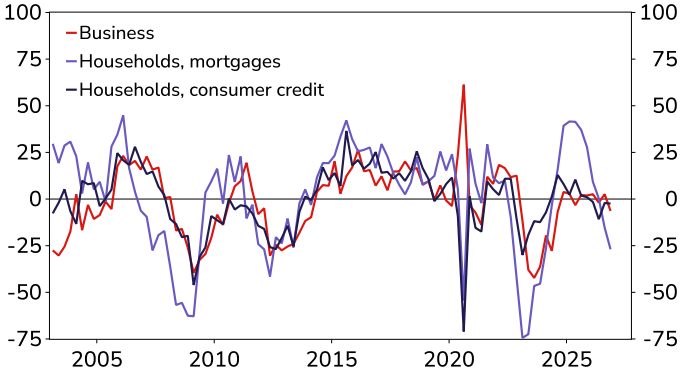
Simply, another 12 months of investment completions should improve the economy's ability to grow without excessive inflation. An uptrend in the euro towards long-run average will also be beneficial vis à vis inflation without placing undue restraint on the region's growth prospects.

The above notwithstanding, there is a need to remain vigilant of alternative paths for the Continent. Of immediate concern aside from the Middle East is the threat posed by Russia's aggression against Ukraine and the effectiveness of Ukrainian forces' counterstrike capability on Russia's energy infrastructure.

Also, while collectively in much better shape than the US, the fiscal position of individual nations, particularly France, requires careful study. Financial conditions have always been critical for the euro area growth outlook. Currently, this is as much the case for the public sector as private enterprise.

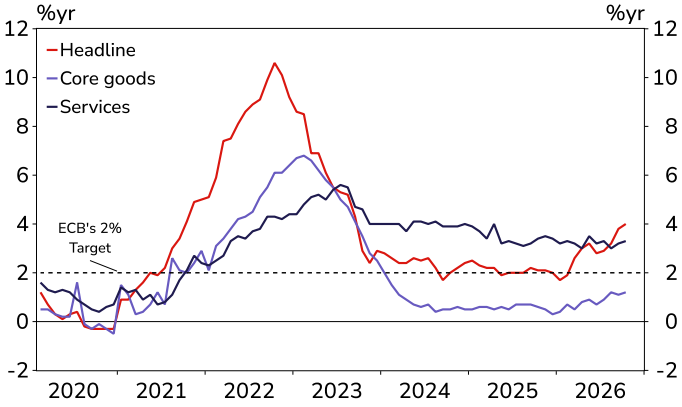
Loan demand turning down

Net % of banks reporting an increase in demand



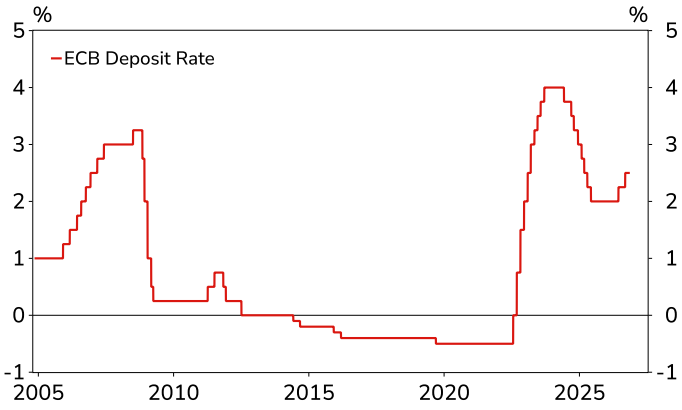
Source: ECB, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

Inflation to tend to target ...



Source: Eurostat, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

... with mildly restrictive policy



Source: ECB, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

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Australia

Interest rate forecasts

	Latest (13 Nov)	Dec–26	Mar–27	Jun–27	Sep–27	Dec–27	Mar–28	Jun–28	Sep–28	Dec–28
Cash	4.85	4.85	4.85	4.85	4.60	4.35	4.10	3.85	3.85	3.85
90 Day BBSW	4.95	4.96	4.96	4.81	4.56	4.31	4.11	3.96	3.95	3.95
3 Year Swap	4.78	4.75	4.70	4.65	4.60	4.50	4.40	4.35	4.30	4.25
3 Year Bond	4.78	4.75	4.70	4.65	4.60	4.50	4.40	4.35	4.30	4.25
10 Year Bond	5.11	5.00	4.95	4.90	4.95	4.95	5.00	5.00	5.00	5.00
10 Year Spread to US (bps)	–2	5	5	5	5	0	0	–5	–10	–15

Currency forecasts

	Latest (13 Nov)	Dec–26	Mar–27	Jun–27	Sep–27	Dec–27	Mar–28	Jun–28	Sep–28	Dec–28
AUD vs										
USD	0.6806	0.70	0.70	0.71	0.71	0.71	0.72	0.72	0.72	0.72
JPY	108.77	110	110	110	110	110	110	109	108	106
EUR	0.6156	0.62	0.62	0.62	0.61	0.61	0.61	0.61	0.60	0.60
NZD	1.2269	1.24	1.22	1.19	1.16	1.15	1.15	1.15	1.14	1.14
CAD	0.9706	0.98	0.98	0.98	0.97	0.97	0.97	0.96	0.96	0.96
GBP	0.5141	0.52	0.52	0.52	0.52	0.52	0.52	0.51	0.51	0.51
CHF	0.5685	0.57	0.57	0.57	0.56	0.56	0.55	0.55	0.54	0.54
DKK	4.6015	4.65	4.61	4.63	4.59	4.57	4.58	4.54	4.50	4.49
SEK	6.8199	6.95	6.92	6.99	6.96	6.96	7.00	6.97	6.94	6.95
NOK	6.5086	6.64	6.61	6.68	6.65	6.65	6.68	6.66	6.63	6.64
ZAR	11.39	11.6	11.6	11.6	11.6	11.7	11.7	11.7	11.7	11.8
SGD	0.8755	0.89	0.89	0.89	0.89	0.89	0.90	0.90	0.90	0.90
HKD	5.3387	5.48	5.47	5.55	5.54	5.55	5.60	5.59	5.60	5.61
PHP	43.47	43.4	43.1	43.3	43.0	42.8	42.8	42.5	42.2	42.3
THB	23.06	23.1	22.8	22.7	22.4	22.1	22.0	21.7	21.7	21.7
MYR	2.7839	2.84	2.80	2.80	2.77	2.75	2.77	2.74	2.74	2.75
CNY	4.5395	4.66	4.62	4.62	4.58	4.56	4.57	4.57	4.55	4.56
IDR	12413	12670	12600	12780	12709	12549	12456	12240	11913	11920
TWD	22.42	22.4	22.1	22.0	21.7	21.4	21.2	20.9	20.6	20.6
KRW	908	938	935	944	941	941	947	943	942	941
INR	64.21	66.5	65.8	66.0	65.3	64.9	64.8	64.1	63.5	63.0

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Australia

Activity forecasts

	2026				2027				Calendar years			
%qtr / %yr end	Q1	Q2	Q3(f)	Q4(f)	Q1(f)	Q2(f)	Q3(f)	Q4(f)	2025	2026(f)	2027(f)	2028(f)
Household consumption	0.4	0.4	0.8	0.3	0.3	0.2	0.3	0.5	2.5	1.9	1.3	2.7
Dwelling investment	1.5	1.6	1.2	0.2	–0.6	–1.0	0.1	0.3	5.2	4.5	–1.1	4.1
Business investment *	6.2	–0.5	5.9	2.1	3.9	1.4	1.5	1.3	4.5	14.3	8.4	4.7
Private demand *	1.4	0.3	1.4	0.6	0.8	0.4	0.5	0.6	3.2	3.7	2.4	3.2
Public demand *	–0.5	0.2	0.7	0.7	0.6	0.6	0.6	0.6	2.4	1.1	2.5	2.6
Domestic demand	0.9	0.3	1.2	0.6	0.8	0.4	0.6	0.6	3.0	2.9	2.4	3.0
Stock contribution	–0.1	–0.1	–0.0	–0.1	0.0	0.0	–0.1	0.0	0.1	–0.2	–0.1	0.1
GNE	0.8	0.2	1.2	0.5	0.8	0.4	0.5	0.6	3.1	2.7	2.3	3.1
Exports	–1.1	0.8	0.5	0.8	0.4	0.7	0.7	0.6	5.2	1.1	2.4	2.4
Imports	2.0	0.5	3.2	2.0	2.5	1.7	1.3	1.8	6.8	7.8	7.5	5.9
Net exports contribution	–0.7	0.1	–0.7	–0.3	–0.5	–0.3	–0.2	–0.3	–0.3	–1.6	–1.3	–1.0
Real GDP %qtr / %yr avg	**0.3**	**0.4**	**0.5**	**0.2**	**0.3**	**0.2**	**0.3**	**0.3**	**2.0**	**2.1**	**1.1**	**1.7**
%yr end	**2.5**	**2.1**	**2.1**	**1.4**	**1.4**	**1.2**	**1.0**	**1.0**	**2.6**	**1.4**	**1.0**	**2.1**
Nominal GDP %qtr / %yr avg	0.6	0.8	1.7	1.0	0.5	0.5	0.8	0.7	4.8	4.9	3.3	4.0
%yr end	5.4	5.3	5.1	4.1	4.1	3.8	2.9	2.7	6.2	4.1	2.7	4.7
Real household disp. income	–0.3	0.6	1.3	–1.4	0.4	0.7	1.1	0.1	4.0	0.2	2.3	3.6

Other macroeconomic variables

	2026				2027				Calendar years			
% change	Q1	Q2	Q3(f)	Q4(f)	Q1(f)	Q2(f)	Q3(f)	Q4(f)	2025	2026(f)	2027(f)	2028(f)
Employment %qtr **	0.5	0.2	0.4	0.2	0.3	0.2	0.4	0.5	–	–	–	–
%yr end **	1.5	1.1	1.3	1.3	1.0	1.0	1.1	1.4	1.1	1.3	1.4	2.3
Unemployment rate % **	4.2	4.4	4.6	4.8	5.0	5.2	5.2	5.1	4.2	4.8	5.1	4.7
Wages (WPI) %qtr	0.8	0.8	1.0	0.7	0.7	0.7	0.8	0.8	–	–	–	–
%yr end	3.2	3.2	3.4	3.3	3.3	3.2	3.0	3.0	3.4	3.3	3.0	3.3
Headline CPI %qtr	1.4	0.6	1.3	1.2	0.4	0.5	0.8	0.4	–	–	–	–
%yr end	4.1	3.9	3.9	4.6	3.5	3.4	2.9	2.1	3.6	4.6	2.1	2.2
Trimmed Mean CPI %qtr	0.8	0.8	1.0	0.9	0.7	0.7	0.6	0.6	–	–	–	–
%yr end	3.5	3.6	3.7	3.6	3.5	3.3	2.9	2.7	3.4	3.6	2.7	2.3
Current account $bn, qtr	–25.4	–27.2	–29.1	–33.8	–39.5	–41.8	–43.4	–43.6	–	–	–	–
% of GDP	–3.5	–3.7	–3.9	–4.4	–5.1	–5.4	–5.6	–5.6	–3.1	–4.4	–5.6	–5.3
Terms of trade %yr avg	–1.2	–0.6	–0.4	–0.3	–1.4	–1.9	–3.1	–3.7	–2.5	–0.3	–3.7	–1.2
Population growth %yr end	1.4	1.4	1.4	1.4	1.4	1.3	1.3	1.3	1.5	1.4	1.3	1.2

Calendar year changes are annual through–the–year percentage changes unless otherwise specified.
* Business investment, private and public demand are adjusted to exclude the effect of private sector purchases of public sector assets. ** Quarter–averages.

Macroeconomic variables – recent history

	2025	2026										
Monthly data	Dec	Jan	Feb	Mar	Apr	May	Jun	Jul	Aug	Sep	Oct	Nov
CPI %yr	3.8	3.8	3.7	4.6	4.2	4.0	3.8	3.5	4.0	4.3	–	–
Employment '000 chg	57.4	33.6	22.3	21.2	–41.2	34.9	76.4	–17.1	29.3	–39.3	–	–
Unemployment rate %	4.1	4.1	4.3	4.3	4.5	4.4	4.4	4.5	4.7	4.7	–	–
Westpac–MI Consumer Sentiment	94.5	92.9	90.5	91.6	80.2	83.0	80.6	83.9	89.0	84.4	80.4	78.3
Household spending %mth	–0.5	0.3	0.3	1.7	–1.0	1.2	0.8	1.0	–0.1	0.6	–	–
Dwelling approvals %mth	–15.5	–13.5	44.2	–13.6	1.4	–1.3	6.4	–1.7	–5.2	5.1	–	–
Private sector credit %mth	0.8	0.5	0.7	0.7	0.7	0.8	0.8	0.6	0.6	0.6	–	–
Trade in goods balance AUDbn	3.2	2.6	5.2	–2.1	1.5	–2.6	2.3	1.5	0.2	2.8	–	–

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New Zealand

Interest rate forecasts

	Latest (13 Nov)	Dec–26	Mar–27	Jun–27	Sep–27	Dec–27	Mar–28	Jun–28	Sep–28	Dec–28
Cash	2.75	3.00	3.50	3.75	4.00	4.00	4.00	4.00	3.75	3.75
90 Day Bill	3.20	3.40	3.75	4.00	4.20	4.20	4.20	4.15	3.95	3.95
2 Year Swap	3.79	3.95	4.10	4.25	4.20	4.20	4.15	4.15	4.10	4.10
10 Year Bond	4.71	4.80	4.85	4.95	5.05	5.05	5.05	5.05	5.05	5.05
10 Year Spread to US	–42	–15	–5	10	15	10	5	0	–5	–10
10 Year Spread to Aust	–40	–20	–10	5	10	10	5	5	5	5

Sources: Bloomberg, Westpac Economics.

Currency forecasts

	Latest (13 Nov)	Dec–26	Mar–27	Jun–27	Sep–27	Dec–27	Mar–28	Jun–28	Sep–28	Dec–28
NZD vs										
USD	0.5547	0.56	0.58	0.60	0.61	0.62	0.62	0.63	0.63	0.64
JPY	88.65	88	90	93	95	95	95	95	94	94
EUR	0.5017	0.50	0.51	0.52	0.53	0.53	0.53	0.53	0.53	0.53
AUD	0.8150	0.80	0.82	0.84	0.86	0.87	0.87	0.87	0.88	0.88
CAD	0.7910	0.79	0.80	0.82	0.84	0.84	0.84	0.84	0.84	0.84
GBP	0.4190	0.42	0.43	0.44	0.45	0.45	0.45	0.45	0.45	0.45
CNY	3.7010	3.74	3.80	3.87	3.93	3.96	3.96	3.99	3.98	4.01

Sources: Bloomberg, Westpac Economics.

Activity forecasts

	2026				2027				Calendar years			
% change	**Q1**	**Q2**	**Q3(f)**	**Q4(f)**	**Q1(f)**	**Q2(f)**	**Q3(f)**	**Q4(f)**	**2025**	**2026(f)**	**2027(f)**	**2028(f)**
Private consumption	0.6	0.0	0.5	0.6	0.7	0.9	1.0	1.0	1.0	1.3	2.9	3.9
Government consumption	0.9	–1.7	0.3	0.3	0.3	0.3	0.6	0.5	2.4	2.3	0.9	2.2
Residential investment	–1.6	4.4	3.0	3.5	3.5	2.5	2.0	1.8	–5.3	5.4	12.5	5.5
Business investment	4.2	0.3	0.8	1.5	1.6	1.4	1.1	0.9	0.5	4.6	5.1	4.1
Stocks (ppt contribution)	0.0	–0.4	0.3	0.0	0.2	0.0	0.1	–0.1	–0.1	0.4	0.3	–0.1
GNE	1.1	–0.4	0.9	0.9	1.1	0.9	1.0	0.9	0.7	2.8	3.6	3.6
Exports	2.2	3.3	–0.2	0.0	0.8	0.8	0.8	0.7	4.3	5.8	2.9	2.7
Imports	3.3	–0.8	0.3	0.5	1.3	2.3	2.1	1.4	3.7	5.3	4.3	4.8
GDP (production)	0.9	0.2	0.6	0.7	0.9	0.5	0.6	0.7	0.3	2.4	2.6	3.0
Employment annual %	0.3	0.9	0.7	0.7	1.3	1.6	2.5	2.8	0.1	0.7	2.8	2.7
Unemployment rate % s.a.	5.4	5.6	5.7	5.7	5.6	5.5	5.3	5.1	5.4	5.7	5.1	4.5
LCI, all sect incl o/t, ann %	2.0	2.0	2.1	2.1	2.1	2.1	2.1	2.2	2.0	2.1	2.2	2.4
CPI annual %	3.1	4.1	3.7	4.3	3.7	2.5	2.3	1.4	3.1	4.3	1.4	1.9
Current account % of GDP	–3.0	–3.2	–3.8	–4.3	–4.5	–4.7	–4.9	–4.6	–3.0	–4.3	–4.6	–4.1
Terms of trade annual %	1.9	–6.1	–5.9	–9.3	–4.5	1.5	2.8	8.1	3.3	–9.3	8.1	2.9

Sources: Statistics NZ, Westpac Economics.

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Commodity prices

Quarter average	Latest (6 Nov)***	Dec–26	Mar–27	Jun–27	Sep–27	Dec–27	Mar–28	Jun–28	Sep–28	Dec–28
Australian commodities index#	424	426	402	367	354	345	340	340	339	340
Bulk commodities index#	**398**	**390**	**357**	**332**	**327**	**327**	**329**	**331**	**333**	**335**
iron ore finesTSI @ 62% US$/t	94	95	88	84	83	83	84	85	85	86
Premium low vol met coal (US$/t)	260	250	225	203	195	191	192	193	194	196
Newcastle spot thermal coal (US$/t)	145	135	122	115	115	115	115	116	116	116
crude oil (US$/bbl) Brent	100	101	91	84	83	77	76	74	73	71
LNG in Japan US$mmbtu	31.6	27.5	25.1	18.8	16.0	14.0	12.8	12.4	12.0	11.7
gold (US$/oz)	4,018	4,200	4,100	3,950	3,900	3,850	3,860	3,890	3,920	3,940
Base metals index#	**267**	**267**	**260**	**254**	**250**	**248**	**245**	**243**	**241**	**240**
copper (US$/t)	14,092	14,000	13,500	13,150	13,010	12,950	12,900	12,870	12,840	12,820
aluminium (US$/t)	3,123	3,230	3,150	3,100	3,050	3,000	2,940	2,900	2,860	2,840
nickel (US$/t)	15,707	16,200	16,500	16,750	16,870	16,950	17,040	17,120	17,210	17,290
zinc (US$/t)	3,834	3,910	3,830	3,640	3,450	3,320	3,190	3,110	3,050	3,010
lead (US$/t)	1,865	1,870	1,880	1,890	1,910	1,920	1,890	1,870	1,860	1,850
Rural commodities index#	**159**	**153**	**151**	**147**	**142**	**138**	**137**	**135**	**133**	**132**
NZ commodities index ##	**393**	**399**	**406**	**398**	**394**	**396**	**397**	**398**	**399**	**399**
dairy price index ##	324	337	346	333	327	331	334	336	337	339
whole milk powder USD/t	3,971	3,920	4,100	3,920	3,830	3,880	3,930	3,980	4,020	4,060
skim milk powder USD/t	4,109	4,040	4,040	3,760	3,630	3,680	3,730	3,780	3,820	3,860
lamb price index ##	686	681	678	674	670	666	660	652	644	636
beef price index ##	397	378	396	397	397	397	396	393	391	389
forestry price index ##	172	164	160	160	160	161	161	162	163	164

	levels				% change			
Annual averages	**2025**	**2026(f)**	**2027(f)**	**2028(f)**	**2025**	**2026(f)**	**2027(f)**	**2028(f)**
Australian commodities index#	**324**	**412**	**367**	**340**	**4.1**	**27.2**	**–10.8**	**–7.4**
Bulk commodities index#	**378**	**397**	**336**	**332**	**–12.7**	**5.1**	**–15.4**	**–1.2**
iron ore finesTSI @ 62% US$/t	102	101	85	85	–6.8	–0.4	–16.6	0.3
Premium low vol met coal (US$/t)	189	241	203	194	–22.5	28.0	–15.8	–4.6
Newcastle spot thermal coal (US$/t)	106	132	116	116	–21.6	24.1	–11.7	–0.5
crude oil (US$/bbl) Brent	68	91	84	73	–14.6	32.8	–7.9	–12.2
LNG in Japan US$mmbtu	12.3	20.1	18.5	12.2	3.1	64.0	–8.2	–33.7
gold (US$/oz)	3,440	4,470	3,950	3,900	43.9	29.9	–11.6	–1.3
Base metals index#	**208**	**263**	**253**	**242**	**3.0**	**26.4**	**–3.8**	**–4.2**
copper (US$/t)	9,960	13,580	13,150	12,860	8.6	36.3	–3.2	–2.2
aluminium (US$/t)	2,630	3,310	3,070	2,880	8.2	25.9	–7.3	–6.2
nickel (US$/t)	15,200	17,080	16,770	17,160	–9.9	12.4	–1.8	2.3
zinc (US$/t)	2,860	3,610	3,560	3,090	2.5	26.2	–1.4	–13.2
lead (US$/t)	1,970	1,910	1,900	1,870	–5.3	–3.0	–0.5	–1.6
Rural commodities index#	**138**	**147**	**144**	**134**	**8.3**	**6.4**	**–1.9**	**–6.9**
NZ commodities index ##	**390**	**398**	**398**	**398**	**9.2**	**1.9**	**0.2**	**0.0**
dairy price index ##	348	330	334	336	9.7	–5.3	1.3	0.7
whole milk powder USD/t	3,902	3,690	3,933	3,999	13.5	–5.4	6.6	1.7
skim milk powder USD/t	2,702	3,466	3,778	3,798	0.6	28.3	9.0	0.5
lamb price index ##	587	671	672	648	27.0	14.4	0.1	–3.6
beef price index ##	337	417	397	392	19.1	23.6	–4.8	–1.2
forestry price index ##	152	161	160	162	–4.9	6.2	–0.6	1.4

Chain weighted index: weights are Australian export shares. * Australian export prices fob – ABS 5432.0 Merchandise Trade Exports. ** WCFI – Westpac commodities futures index. *** Latest figures are weekly averages. ^ AWEX market prices. Sources for all tables: Westpac Economics, Bloomberg ##ANZ NZ commodity price index ^^ GlobalDairyTrade

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United States

Interest rate forecasts

	Latest (13 Nov)	Dec–26	Mar–27	Jun–27	Sep–27	Dec–27	Mar–28	Jun–28	Sep–28	Dec–28
Fed Funds*	3.875	4.125	4.375	4.375	4.375	4.375	4.125	3.875	3.875	3.875
10 Year Bond	5.13	4.95	4.90	4.85	4.90	4.95	5.00	5.05	5.10	5.15

Sources: Bloomberg, Westpac Economics. * +12.5bps from the Fed Funds lower bound (overnight reverse repo rate).

Currency forecasts

	Latest (13 Nov)	Dec–26	Mar–27	Jun–27	Sep–27	Dec–27	Mar–28	Jun–28	Sep–28	Dec–28
USD vs										
DXY index	103.20	101.5	100.7	99.8	99.0	98.2	97.3	96.4	95.2	94.7
JPY	159.82	157	157	156	155	154	153	151	149	147
EUR	1.1055	1.13	1.14	1.15	1.16	1.17	1.18	1.19	1.20	1.21
AUD	0.6806	0.70	0.70	0.71	0.71	0.71	0.72	0.72	0.72	0.72
NZD	0.5547	0.56	0.58	0.60	0.61	0.62	0.62	0.63	0.63	0.64
CAD	1.4261	1.40	1.39	1.38	1.37	1.36	1.35	1.34	1.33	1.32
GBP	1.3239	1.34	1.35	1.36	1.37	1.38	1.39	1.40	1.41	1.41
CHF	0.8354	0.82	0.81	0.80	0.79	0.78	0.77	0.76	0.75	0.75
ZAR	16.74	16.5	16.5	16.4	16.4	16.4	16.3	16.3	16.3	16.2
SGD	1.2865	1.28	1.27	1.26	1.26	1.25	1.25	1.25	1.25	1.25
HKD	7.8444	7.83	7.82	7.81	7.80	7.79	7.78	7.77	7.76	7.75
PHP	63.69	62.0	61.5	61.0	60.5	60.0	59.5	59.0	58.5	58.4
THB	33.89	33.0	32.5	32.0	31.5	31.0	30.5	30.2	30.0	30.0
MYR	4.0783	4.05	4.00	3.95	3.90	3.85	3.85	3.80	3.80	3.80
CNY	6.6724	6.65	6.60	6.50	6.45	6.40	6.35	6.35	6.30	6.30
IDR	18239	18100	18000	18000	17900	17600	17300	17000	16500	16464
TWD	32.95	32.0	31.5	31.0	30.5	30.0	29.5	29.0	28.5	28.4
KRW	1335	1340	1335	1330	1325	1320	1315	1310	1305	1300
INR	94.05	95.0	94.0	93.0	92.0	91.0	90.0	89.0	88.0	87.0

Activity forecasts

	2026				2027				Calendar years			
% annualised, s/adj	**Q1**	**Q2**	**Q3**	**Q4(f)**	**Q1(f)**	**Q2(f)**	**Q3(f)**	**Q4(f)**	**2025**	**2026(f)**	**2027(f)**	**2028(f)**
Private consumption	0.7	3.8	3.8	2.9	2.6	2.4	2.4	2.4	2.6	2.5	2.8	2.2
Dwelling investment	–7.6	2.8	–3.3	0.8	0.8	1.2	1.6	2.0	–2.7	–3.2	0.6	2.0
Business investment	9.9	9.0	12.7	6.5	4.9	4.6	4.6	4.7	5.4	7.5	6.3	4.7
Public demand	4.7	–0.1	5.3	0.4	0.4	0.4	0.4	0.4	1.6	1.1	1.0	0.4
Domestic final demand	2.4	3.9	5.2	3.0	2.6	2.4	2.4	2.4	2.7	2.8	3.0	2.3
Inventories contribution ppt	–0.8	–0.1	0.3	0.2	0.2	0.3	–0.1	0.0	–0.2	0.2	0.0	0.1
Net exports contribution ppt	1.4	–0.2	–1.4	–1.4	–1.5	–1.2	–0.5	–0.5	0.3	–1.4	–0.5	–0.5
GDP	2.5	2.2	3.4	2.4	2.3	2.1	2.0	2.0	2.3	2.4	2.4	1.9
%yr annual chg	2.6	2.2	2.1	2.6	2.6	2.5	2.2	2.1	–	–	–	–

Other macroeconomic variables

Non–farm payrolls mth avg	43	97	59	90	80	90	100	105	26	68	94	115
Unemployment rate %	4.3	4.3	4.1	4.2	4.3	4.4	4.5	4.5	4.3	4.2	4.4	4.5
CPI headline %yr	2.7	3.9	3.5	3.7	3.3	2.5	2.4	2.2	2.7	3.5	2.6	2.2
PCE deflator, core %yr	3.0	3.1	3.1	3.2	3.2	2.7	2.4	2.2	2.8	3.1	2.6	2.2

Sources: Official agencies, Factset, Westpac Economics.

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Europe & the United Kingdom

Interest rate forecasts

	Latest (13 Nov)	Dec–26	Mar–27	Jun–27	Sep–27	Dec–27	Mar–28	Jun–28	Sep–28	Dec–28
Euro Area										
ECB Deposit Rate	2.50	2.75	2.75	2.75	2.75	2.75	2.50	2.25	2.25	2.25
10 Year Bund	3.35	3.35	3.30	3.25	3.30	3.25	3.25	3.25	3.25	3.25
10 Year Spread to US	–178	–160	–160	–160	–160	–170	–175	–180	–185	–190
United Kingdom										
BoE Bank Rate	4.00	4.00	4.00	4.00	4.00	3.75	3.50	3.25	3.25	3.25
10 Year Gilt	5.30	5.25	5.15	5.05	5.05	5.00	5.00	5.00	5.00	5.00
10 Year Spread to US	17	30	25	20	15	5	0	–5	–10	–15

Sources: Bloomberg, Westpac Economics.

Currency forecasts

	Latest (13 Nov)	Dec–26	Mar–27	Jun–27	Sep–27	Dec–27	Mar–28	Jun–28	Sep–28	Dec–28
euro vs										
USD	1.1055	1.13	1.14	1.15	1.16	1.17	1.18	1.19	1.20	1.21
JPY	176.68	177	178	178	179	179	180	179	179	177
GBP	0.8350	0.84	0.84	0.84	0.84	0.84	0.85	0.85	0.85	0.85
CHF	0.9236	0.92	0.92	0.92	0.91	0.91	0.90	0.90	0.90	0.90
DKK	7.4752	7.47	7.47	7.47	7.47	7.47	7.47	7.47	7.47	7.47
SEK	11.08	11.2	11.2	11.3	11.3	11.4	11.4	11.5	11.5	11.6
NOK	10.57	10.7	10.7	10.8	10.8	10.9	10.9	11.0	11.0	11.0
sterling vs										
USD	1.3239	1.34	1.35	1.36	1.37	1.38	1.39	1.40	1.41	1.41
JPY	211.58	210	212	212	212	213	213	211	210	207
CHF	1.1060	1.09	1.09	1.09	1.08	1.08	1.07	1.06	1.05	1.06
AUD	0.5141	0.52	0.52	0.52	0.52	0.52	0.52	0.51	0.51	0.51

Sources: Bloomberg, Westpac Economics.

Activity forecasts

Annual average % chg	2022	2023	2024	2025	2026(f)	2027(f)	2028(f)
Euro area GDP	3.7	0.5	1.1	1.3	0.9	1.2	1.5
private consumption	5.3	0.7	1.5	1.4	1.0	1.1	1.4
fixed investment	2.4	2.8	–2.0	2.9	0.7	1.7	2.3
government consumption	1.2	1.2	2.7	1.5	2.0	2.0	2.0
net exports contribution ppt	–0.1	0.3	0.3	–0.6	0.1	0.1	–0.3
Germany GDP	2.0	–0.8	0.0	0.3	1.0	1.2	1.7
France GDP	2.8	1.8	1.4	0.9	0.4	0.8	1.2
Italy GDP	5.0	1.0	0.6	0.7	0.9	0.7	1.0
Spain GDP	6.4	2.5	3.5	2.8	2.5	2.0	2.1
Netherlands GDP	5.0	–0.6	1.1	1.6	1.3	1.2	1.6
United Kingdom GDP	5.1	0.3	1.0	1.4	1.2	1.0	1.5

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Asia

China activity forecasts

Calendar years	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025	2026(f)	2027(f)	2028(f)
Real GDP	8.6	3.1	5.4	5.0	5.0	4.7	4.6	4.4
Consumer prices %yr	1.5	1.8	–0.3	0.1	0.1	1.1	1.2	1.4
Producer prices %yr	10.3	–0.7	–2.7	–2.3	–2.6	2.9	1.2	1.5
Industrial production (IVA)	9.6	3.6	4.6	5.8	5.9	5.2	4.9	4.7
Retail sales	12.5	–0.2	7.2	3.5	3.7	1.4	3.4	4.0
Money supply M2 %yr	9.0	11.8	9.7	7.3	8.0	7.7	7.6	7.2
Fixed asset investment	4.9	5.1	3.0	3.2	–1.4	-4.0	3.5	4.5
Exports %yr	20.9	–9.9	–2.3	10.7	5.4	21.0	8.0	5.0
Imports %yr	19.5	–7.5	0.2	0.9	0.3	25.0	7.5	4.0

Source: Macrobond, Bloomberg. Year–to–date growth unless otherwise noted.

Chinese interest rates & monetary policy

	Latest (13 Nov)	Dec–26	Mar–27	Jun–27	Sep–27	Dec–27	Mar–28	Jun–28	Sep–28	Dec–28
Required reserve ratio %*	9.00	8.50	8.50	8.50	8.50	8.50	8.50	8.50	8.50	8.50
Loan Prime Rate, 1–year	3.00	2.80	2.80	2.80	2.80	2.80	2.80	2.80	2.80	2.80

* For major banks.

Japanese interest rates & monetary policy

	Latest (13 Nov)	Dec–26	Mar–27	Jun–27	Sep–27	Dec–27	Mar–28	Jun–28	Sep–28	Dec–28
Policy Rate	1.25	1.50	1.50	1.75	1.75	2.00	2.00	2.00	2.00	2.00
10 Year Bond Yield	2.81	2.90	2.85	2.80	2.75	2.70	2.65	2.60	2.55	2.50

Currency forecasts

	Latest (13 Nov)	Dec–26	Mar–27	Jun–27	Sep–27	Dec–27	Mar–28	Jun–28	Sep–28	Dec–28
JPY	159.82	157	157	156	155	154	153	151	149	147
SGD	1.2865	1.28	1.27	1.26	1.26	1.25	1.25	1.25	1.25	1.25
HKD	7.8444	7.83	7.82	7.81	7.80	7.79	7.78	7.77	7.76	7.75
PHP	63.69	62.0	61.5	61.0	60.5	60.0	59.50	59.00	58.50	58.44
THB	33.89	33.0	32.5	32.0	31.5	31.0	30.5	30.2	30.0	30.0
MYR	4.0783	4.05	4.00	3.95	3.90	3.85	3.85	3.80	3.80	3.80
CNY	6.6724	6.65	6.60	6.50	6.45	6.40	6.35	6.35	6.30	6.30
IDR	18239	18100	18000	18000	17900	17600	17300	17000	16500	16464
TWD	32.95	32.0	31.5	31.0	30.5	30.0	29.5	29.0	28.5	28.4
KRW	1335	1340	1335	1330	1325	1320	1315	1310	1305	1300
INR	94.05	95.0	94.0	93.0	92.0	91.0	90.0	89.0	88.0	87.0

Source: Bloomberg, Westpac Economics.

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Worldwide

Economic growth forecasts (year average)

Real GDP %ann	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025	2026(f)	2027(f)	2028(f)
World	**6.7**	**3.8**	**3.3**	**3.5**	**3.5**	**3.3**	**3.4**	**3.3**
United States	6.3	2.4	2.9	3.0	2.3	2.4	2.4	1.9
Japan	3.6	1.2	0.9	0.1	1.1	0.7	0.8	0.9
Euro zone	6.4	3.7	0.5	1.2	1.3	0.9	1.2	1.5
Group of 3	**6.0**	**2.8**	**1.8**	**1.9**	**1.8**	**1.6**	**1.8**	**1.6**
United Kingdom	8.5	5.0	0.4	1.0	1.3	1.2	1.0	1.5
Canada	6.0	4.7	2.0	2.0	1.9	0.9	1.6	1.8
Australia	5.4	4.2	2.1	1.0	2.0	2.1	1.1	1.7
New Zealand	5.5	2.7	2.2	–0.3	0.3	2.4	2.6	3.0
OECD total	**6.2**	**3.2**	**1.9**	**1.9**	**1.8**	**1.7**	**1.7**	**1.6**
China	8.4	3.1	5.4	5.0	5.0	4.7	4.6	4.4
Korea	4.7	2.9	1.5	2.2	1.1	3.5	2.6	2.2
Taiwan	6.7	2.7	1.1	5.3	8.8	11.2	6.0	4.0
Hong Kong	6.5	–3.7	3.2	2.6	3.6	4.1	3.0	2.6
Singapore	10.1	4.0	1.5	5.3	5.0	5.3	3.5	2.5
Indonesia	3.7	5.3	5.0	5.0	5.1	5.2	5.2	5.2
Thailand	1.6	2.7	2.2	2.9	2.4	2.1	2.1	2.2
Malaysia	3.3	9.0	3.6	5.2	5.2	5.0	4.8	4.6
Philippines	5.7	7.6	5.5	5.7	4.4	3.1	4.5	5.0
Vietnam	2.6	8.5	5.1	7.0	8.0	8.5	8.0	7.8
East Asia	**7.2**	**3.6**	**4.7**	**4.8**	**4.9**	**4.9**	**4.6**	**4.4**
East Asia ex China	4.4	4.7	3.3	4.5	4.7	5.4	4.6	4.3
NIEs*	**6.1**	**2.4**	**1.5**	**3.5**	**4.1**	**6.2**	**3.8**	**2.9**
India	9.7	7.6	7.3	7.2	7.8	7.0	6.9	6.7
Russia	5.9	–1.4	4.1	4.9	1.0	0.6	0.9	1.1
Brazil	4.8	3.0	3.2	3.4	2.3	1.9	1.6	2.0
South Africa	4.9	2.1	0.8	0.5	1.1	1.0	1.3	1.5
Mexico	6.0	3.7	3.1	1.5	0.5	1.5	1.8	2.2
Argentina	10.4	6.0	–1.9	–1.4	4.5	2.1	3.5	4.2
Chile	11.3	2.1	0.7	2.8	2.5	0.6	2.6	2.4
Middle East	2.8	2.8	2.8	2.9	2.9	0.0	2.9	2.9
C & E Europe	9.3	4.5	3.1	3.6	3.5	3.2	3.1	3.5
Africa	3.9	4.4	3.8	4.2	4.5	4.5	4.5	4.6
Emerging ex–East Asia	**6.8**	3.7	**3.7**	**4.7**	**4.5**	**3.5**	**4.3**	**4.3**
Other countries	**6.8**	**5.1**	**5.0**	**2.1**	**2.3**	**3.4**	**3.0**	**3.1**
World	**6.7**	**3.8**	**3.3**	**3.5**	**3.5**	**3.3**	**3.4**	**3.3**

#Regional and global groupings are weighted using PPP exchange rates updated to reflect ICP 2011 benchmark revisions.* "NIEs" signifies "Newly Industrialised Economies" as defined by the IMF, viz; Republic of Korea, Hong Kong SAR, Taiwan Province of China, and Singapore.

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Economic Calendar

November 2026

MON	TUE	WED	THU	FRI
2	**3**	**4**	**5**	**6**
AUSTRALIA Cotality Home Value Index Oct exp –1.3% prev –1.1% (12:01am) MI Inflation Gauge Oct y/y prev 4.8% (11:00am) Dwelling Approvals Sep exp –7.0% prev –6.1% (11:30am) **CHINA** RatingDog Manufacturing PMI Oct prev 52.1 (12:45pm) **UNITED STATES** ISM Manufacturing Oct exp 54.7 prev 54.5 (2:00am) Construction Spending Sep exp 0.5% prev 0.9% (2:00am) Fedspeak – Goolsbee (3:15am) **GLOBAL** S&P Global Manufacturing PMI Oct (F)	**AUSTRALIA** RBA Policy Decision exp 4.85% prev 4.60% (2:30pm) **NEW ZEALAND** Building Permits Sep prev 5.6% (8:45am) **UNITED STATES** JOLTS Job Openings Sep exp 7129k prev 7079k (2:00am) Factory Orders Sep exp 1.1% prev 0.1% (2:00am) Durable Goods Orders Sep (F) prev 1.8% (2:00am)	**AUSTRALIA** Household Spending Indicator Sep exp –0.5% prev 0.0% (11:30am) **CHINA** RatingDog Services PMI Oct prev 51.6 (12:45pm) **EURO ZONE** CPI Oct y/y (P) exp 3.9% prev 3.8% (9:00pm) **NEW ZEALAND** Labour Force Survey Q3 (8:45am) Employment prev 0.5% Unemployment Rate prev 5.6% Private Wages Ex. Overtime prev 0.7% **UNITED STATES** ADP Employment Change Oct exp 68k prev 90k (12:15am) Trade Balance Sep exp –US$107.9bn prev –US$105.6bn (12:30am) ISM Services Oct exp 54.6 prev 54.9 (2:00am) **GLOBAL** S&P Global Services PMI Oct (F)	**AUSTRALIA** Goods Trade Balance Sep exp $2.0bn prev $0.5bn (11:30am) RBA's Hauser – Speech (5:45pm) **EURO ZONE** Ger. Factory Orders Sep prev –10.6% (6:00pm) PPI Sep y/y prev 8.2% (9:00pm) **UNITED KINGDOM** BoE Policy Decision exp 4.00% prev 3.75% (11:00pm) **UNITED STATES** Fedspeak – Hammack (12:50am) Fedspeak – Barkin (1:10am)	**EURO ZONE** Ger. Industrial Production Sep prev 2.0% (6:00pm) Retail Sales Sep prev 0.1% (9:00pm) **JAPAN** BoJ's Ueda – Speech (Sat 7 Nov) **UNITED STATES** Fedspeak – Logan (11:00am) Fedspeak – Williams (8:30pm) Employment Report Oct (12:30am) Nonfarm Payrolls Chg exp 55k prev 29k Unemployment Rate exp 4.2% prev 4.2% Avg Hourly Earnings exp 0.3% prev 0.1% UoM Consumer Sentiment Nov (P) exp 47.5 prev 48.0 (2:00am) Consumer Credit Sep exp US$12.0bn prev US$8.3bn (7:00am)
9	**10**	**11**	**12**	**13**
AUSTRALIA RBA's Hunter – Speech (9:30am) **CHINA** CPI Oct y/y prev 0.9% (12:30pm) PPI Oct y/y prev 5.0% (12:30pm) **EURO ZONE** Sentix Investor Confidence Nov prev 2.7 (8:30pm) **UNITED STATES** Fedspeak – Goolsbee (2:00am) Wholesale Inventories Sep (F) prev 0.6% (2:00am) NY Fed 1-Yr Inflation Expectations Oct y/y prev 3.9% (3:00am)	**AUSTRALIA** Westpac–MI Consumer Sentiment Nov prev 80.4 (10:30am) NAB Business Survey Oct (11:30am) Conditions prev –1 Confidence prev –13 **CHINA** Exports Oct y/y prev 36.3% Imports Oct y/y prev 31.0% Trade Balance Oct prev US$133.5bn **JAPAN** Household Spending Sep y/y prev –3.1% (10:30am) Current Account Sep prev ¥4062.0bn (10:50am) **UNITED STATES** NFIB Small Business Optimism Oct prev 97.9 (10:00pm) CPI Oct prev 0.6% (12:30am)	**AUSTRALIA** Dwelling Finance Approvals Q3 (11:30am) Total exp –10.0% prev –5.2% Owner-Occupier exp –6.0% prev –1.9% Investor exp –16.0% prev –10.2%	**AUSTRALIA** MI Inflation Expectations Nov y/y prev 5.3% (11:00am) RBA's Baker (MPB Member) – Speech (10:30am) **NEW ZEALAND** Retail Card Spending Oct prev –0.4% (8:45am) Net Migration Sep prev 1530.0 (8:45am) **UNITED KINGDOM** GDP Q3 (P) prev 0.5% (6:00pm) **UNITED STATES** Fedspeak – Hammack (1:30am) Existing Home Sales Oct prev 1.5% (2:00am) Fedspeak – Daly (5:10am)	**CHINA** Current Account Q3 (P) prev US$193.7bn **EURO ZONE** GDP Q3 (S) (9:00pm) Trade Balance Sep prev –€6.8bn (9:00pm) **NEW ZEALAND** BusinessNZ Mfg PMI Oct prev 56.5 (8:30am) **UNITED STATES** PPI Oct y/y prev 1.3% (12:30am) Fedspeak – Daly (4:00am) Fedspeak – Jefferson (11:00am)

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Economic Calendar

November 2026

MON	TUE	WED	THU	FRI
16	**17**	**18**	**19**	**20**
CHINA Activity Data Oct ytd y/y (1:00pm) Retail Sales prev 1.1% Industrial Production prev 5.3% Fixed Asset Investment prev –7.2% **EURO ZONE** Industrial Production Sep prev –0.5% (9:00pm) **JAPAN** GDP Q3 (P) prev 0.4% (10:50am) Industrial Production Sep (F) prev 2.2% (3:30pm) **UNITED KINGDOM** Rightmove House Prices Nov prev 1.0% (11:01am) **UNITED STATES** NY Fed Empire Manufacturing Nov prev 25.5 (12:30am)	**AUSTRALIA** RBA's Bullock – Panel (10:00am) RBA Minutes (11:30am) **EURO ZONE** EU ZEW Expectations Nov prev 18.5 (9:00pm) **UNITED KINGDOM** ILO Unemployment Rate Sep prev 4.7% (6:00pm) **UNITED STATES** Retail Sales Oct prev 0.8% (12:30am) Import Price Index Oct prev 1.1% (12:30am) Industrial Production Oct prev 0.7% (1:15am) Fedspeak – Hammack (1:30am) Business Inventories Sep prev 0.4% (2:00am) NAHB Housing Market Index Nov prev 29.0 (2:00am)	**AUSTRALIA** Westpac–MI Leading Index Oct ann'd prev –0.03% (10:30am) Wage Price Index Q3 (11:30am) q/q exp 1.0% prev 0.8% y/y exp 3.4% prev 3.2% **EURO ZONE** CPI Oct (F) (9:00pm) **NEW ZEALAND** PPI Q3 prev 1.6% (8:45am) **UNITED KINGDOM** CPI Oct y/y prev 3.5% (6:00pm) **UNITED STATES** Housing Starts Oct prev –5.2% (12:30am) Building Permits Oct (P) prev –0.4% (12:30am) Pending Home Sales Oct prev –7.3% (2:00am) FOMC Minutes (6:00am)	**AUSTRALIA** Labour Force Survey Oct (11:30am) Employment Change exp 40k prev –39.3k Unemployment Rate exp 4.7% prev 4.7% Participation Rate exp 66.8% prev 66.8% **JAPAN** Core Machinery Orders Sep prev 5.2% (10:50am) **NEW ZEALAND** RBNZ's Breman – Speech (5:00am) RBNZ's Conway – Speech (7:00am) Trade Balance Oct prev –NZ$2.0bn (8:45am) RBNZ's Conway – Speech (1:00pm) **UNITED STATES** Phily Fed Manufacturing Index Nov prev 20.9 (12:30am) Fedspeak – Hammack (12:50am) Leading Index Oct prev 0.0% (2:00am) Kansas City Fed Manufacturing Index Nov prev 11.0 (3:00am) Fedspeak – Goolsbee (4:30am)	**EURO ZONE** EC Consumer Confidence Nov (P) prev –17.9 (2:00am) **JAPAN** CPI Oct y/y prev 2.1% (10:30am) **UNITED KINGDOM** GfK Consumer Sentiment Nov prev –24 (11:01am) Retail Sales Oct prev –0.4% (6:00pm) **UNITED STATES** UoM Consumer Sentiment Nov (F) (2:00am)
23	**24**	**25**	**26**	**27**
EURO ZONE S&P Global PMIs Nov (P) (8:00pm) **NEW ZEALAND** Retail Sales Volumes Q3 prev –0.5% (8:45am) **UNITED KINGDOM** S&P Global PMIs Nov (P) (8:30pm) **UNITED STATES** Chicago Fed Nat Act Index Oct prev 0.07 (12:30am) S&P Global PMIs Nov (P) (1:45am)	**EURO ZONE** IFO Business Climate Survey Nov prev 90.2 (8:00pm) **JAPAN** S&P Global Manufacturing PMI Nov (P) (11:30am) S&P Global Services PMI Nov (P) (11:30am) **UNITED STATES** FHFA House Prices Sep prev 0.3% (1:00am) S&P CoreLogic CS House Prices Sep prev 0.27% (1:00am) Conf. Board Consumer Confidence Index Nov prev 91.7 (2:00am) Richmond Fed Manufacturing Index Nov prev –2 (2:00am)	**AUSTRALIA** CPI Oct (11:30am) Headline m/m prev 0.8% Headline y/y prev 4.3% Trimmed Mean m/m prev 0.3% Trimmed Mean y/y prev 3.6% Construction Work Done Q3 exp 1.0% prev –2.1% (11:30am) RBA's Jacobs – Speech (10:50am) **UNITED STATES** GDP Q3 (S) prev 3.4% (12:30am) Personal Income Oct prev 0.2% (12:30am) Personal Spending Oct prev 0.5% (12:30am) PCE Deflator Oct prev 0.5% (12:30am) Durable Goods Orders Oct (P) (12:30am) New Home Sales Oct prev –0.6% (2:00am) Federal Reserve's Beige Book (6:00am)	**AUSTRALIA** Private Capital Expenditure Q3 exp 2.0% prev –3.6% (11:30am) **EURO ZONE** M3 Money Supply Oct y/y prev 3.5% (8:00pm) **UNITED STATES** Building Permits Oct (F)	**CHINA** Industrial Profits Oct y/y prev 14.4% (12:30pm) **EURO ZONE** EC Economic Confidence Nov prev 96.9 (9:00pm) EC Consumer Confidence Nov (F) (9:00pm) **JAPAN** Tokyo CPI Nov y/y prev 2.8% (10:30am) **NEW ZEALAND** ANZ Consumer Confidence Nov prev 96.2 (8:00am) **UNITED STATES** Wholesale Inventories Oct (P) (12:30am)

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Economic Calendar

November 2026

MON	TUE	WED	THU	FRI
30				
AUSTRALIA MI Inflation Gauge Nov y/y (11:00am) Company Profits Q3 prev 1.8% (11:30am) Inventories Q3 prev –0.2% (11:30am) Private Sector Credit Oct prev 0.6% (11:30am) **CHINA** NBS PMIs Nov (12:30pm) Manufacturing Non–Manufacturing **JAPAN** Industrial Production Oct (P) (10:50am) **NEW ZEALAND** Filled Jobs Oct prev 0.3% (8:45am) ANZ Business Confidence Nov prev 52.5 (11:00am) **UNITED STATES** Chicago PMI Nov (1:45am) Dallas Fed Manufacturing Index Nov prev 13.4 (2:30am)				

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Week beginning 26 October 2026

AUSTRALIA & NEW ZEALAND WEEKLY

Analysis and forecasts for this week's key releases.

In this week's edition:

Economic Insight: Open mouth operations.

The Week That Was: Managing Expectations.

Focus on New Zealand: RBNZ now expected to hike in October.

For the week ahead:

Australia: CPI, RBA senate appearance, private sector credit, PPI, export and import price index.

New Zealand: RBNZ policy decision, employment indicators, business confidence, consumer confidence.

China: NBS manufacturing and Non-manufacturing PMIs, industrial profits.

Japan: BoJ policy decision, Tokyo CPI, jobless rate, industrial production.

Euro Area: ECB policy decision, Q3 GDP, unemployment rate, economic confidence.

Canada: BoC policy decision.

United States: FOMC policy decision, Q3 GDP, PCE deflator, personal income and spending.

Information contained in this report current as at 23 October 2026.

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Open mouth operations

Luci Ellis
Chief Economist, Westpac Group

- **Central banks' communication is carefully scrutinised for every nuance. Lately, there seems to have been more RBA communication to pore over. The method of delivery has also evolved. This has sometimes caused confusion when tone seems to vary. Different audiences call for different tone and varying complexity.**
- **The content has evolved, too. RBA officials are increasingly using speeches directed to professional audiences to discuss more technical estimates of inferred variables such as neutral rates and financial conditions. They are also highlighting that monetary policy combats inflation in more ways than just squeezing mortgage holders.**
- **One thing has not changed: the RBA is not in the business of providing 'forward guidance' promises about the future path of interest rates. It does, however, give more running commentary about how it is interpreting recent data. These interpretations are themselves useful signals about what the RBA thinks it might do.**

Market participants pore over every utterance by central banks for clues to future rate moves. They will have plenty to pore over in the run-up to the November RBA decision. After the flurry of fireside chats this week, '60 Minutes' will run a pre-recorded interview with chief economist Sarah Hunter on Sunday. Next Wednesday, the whole senior policy team will appear before Senate Estimates, just as the quarterly CPI is released. (This timing will have been the Senate's choice, not the RBA's.) After the decision will come the *Statement on Monetary Policy*, a media release and press conference. More speeches will follow, including one by the Deputy Governor on the Thursday.

RBA communication does seem to have changed, not just following the RBA Review but also more recently. There may be fewer policy meetings each year, but the communication outside that certainly feels more frequent than a couple of years ago. Back in 2024, speaking engagements felt a little sparse outside the post-meeting media conference and parliamentary appearances. We have counted 58 public engagements so far this year on the Speeches page on the RBA's website. This compares with 58 for the whole of last year and 52 in 2024. Excluding the 'compulsory' press conferences and parliamentary appearances, fewer than half of the 2024 events were related to economics, markets and monetary policy.

The 'how' has changed

The way the RBA communicates with markets has changed as well. There are fewer set-piece speeches on policy and a lot more semi-scripted 'fireside chats'. Compared with a few years ago, there are more interviews across a wide range of media. This is a big change from the pre-Review world. It was a huge deal when the previous Governor appeared on the *7:30 Report*; it is hard to imagine him agreeing to an Assistant Governor appearing on *60 Minutes*.

Part of the change reflects increased efforts to reach a general audience. Central banks want to explain why they do what they do. This matters especially when interest rates are rising but the household sector is not the source of the inflation.

Speaking differently to different audiences can sometimes confuse markets. As the RBA's Chief Communication Officer highlighted in a recent panel discussion, the post-meeting media conference is designed to speak to the public. Market participants and economists certainly tune in, but we are not the primary audience. So, if you think that what the Governor said in the media conference sounded more 'dovish' than what another official says in a more market-oriented forum, it is partly because she is trying to convey that the RBA understands that its recent policy actions are making things harder for many Australians. But this is in much the same way that a doctor might say, "This might hurt a bit." It does, but that will not stop the treatment.

A related issue is that it is easier to control tone in pre-drafted material such as the minutes and set-piece speeches than in unstructured Q&A. Senior central bankers are trained to be careful with their words in unscripted settings. If the tone differs, the minutes are still more likely to say what the Board really means than an off-the-cuff answer.

> **"The RBA does not want to promise what it will do, but it is increasingly trying to tell us what it thinks. "**

Greater communication with the broader public might have reduced the pressure to make the set-piece speeches more accessible. Research on central bank communication often uses measures such as the Flesch–Kincaid Grade Level and Flesch Reading Ease score. A comprehensive analysis was beyond the scope of this note. However, a spot comparison suggests four speeches from 2026 (1, 2, 3, 4) were harder to read than four from 2021 (1, 2, 3, 4). The 2021 speeches scored in the 11 to 12 range, which is high-school-level

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complexity. The 2026 speeches scored between 12 and 15, which is academic or technically dense text requiring university-level education. (Including two of my own 2021 speeches is an obvious caveat, but the two speeches by then-Governor Phil Lowe also scored better on these metrics than the sample from this year. It should be noted, though, that readability metrics do not necessarily imply better clarity if the concepts discussed are more abstract.)

The 'what' has changed

As noted above, the content of RBA communication has evolved, too. As its intellectual framework has begun to put more weight on the balance of supply and demand, and those invisible 'star' variables (NAIRUs, neutral real rates, 'financial conditions', etc.), the communication to professional audiences has increasingly focused on those topics.

More recently, the RBA has also placed more emphasis on the full range of transmission channels from interest rates to inflation (though not, as we have noted previously, the labour supply channel). This is understandable in a world of supply shocks. People need to understand that monetary policy is not simply an exercise in hitting mortgage borrowers. We doubt they would be comforted, though, by the Deputy Governor's explanation this week that the 'cashflow channel' was the smallest of the transmission channels from interest rates to inflation, with the exchange rate much more prominent. That implies a lot of pain for a small group, for little effect on inflation. It raises the question of whether other policy tools or institutional arrangements might get the same effect on inflation through the other channels without hitting a minority of households disproportionately.

We have also seen a move away from using catchphrases to summarise the position. From 'narrow path' to 'not ruling anything in or out' to 'cautious and predictable', once entrenched, a phrase can outlast its usefulness.

One thing that has not changed is the way the minutes record the presentations to the Board and the members' discussion. The minutes rarely convey much new information beyond the post-meeting statements. Sometimes, though, the minutes reveal the Board's reaction to the staff's analysis. The August 2024 minutes were a good example: the discussion highlighted just how sensitive the forecasts were to key judgements by the staff.

The 'why' has not changed

Despite these changes, the underlying objectives of the RBA's communication have not changed. It wants to explain – and perhaps justify – its decisions. And it wants to describe how it interprets incoming data, especially inflation, the labour market and the balance of supply and demand.

The RBA, like any central bank, is not really in the business of providing 'forward guidance' about future moves. Circumstances change, so it can never guarantee a particular future path for interest rates. Some academic literature argues that promising to keep rates low for a long time (or high, for that matter) independently amplifies the transmission of monetary policy beyond the effect of current-period interest rates alone, by shifting the short end of the yield curve. Central banks including the RBA have certainly tried jawboning in this way from time to time. The prevailing view, though, is that the potential cost of reputational loss if things do not turn out as predicted outweighs the benefits of a slightly stronger transmission mechanism.

In this context, it is the interpretation of data that provides the signal about future policy directions. This is why it was noteworthy that the Governor still characterised the labour market as 'a little tight' after the September meeting, even though the Board's post-meeting communication did not. We have been noting for some time that the RBA staff have a downbeat view of supply capacity. Together with the RBA's oft-stated concerns about inflation, this is why the Deputy Governor's 'hawkishness' did not surprise us.

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Cliff Notes: managing expectations

Elliot Clarke, Head of International Economics
Ryan Wells, Economist
Illiana Jain, Economist

With little domestic data of significance, participants' attention focused on RBA Deputy Governor Hauser's fireside chat, which saw an abrupt shift in market expectations of a follow-up rate hike at the November meeting.

Hauser warned in his remarks that the current inflation outlook was "materially worse" than the RBA's August forecasts. Three upside inflation risks were characterised as having "crystallised" ahead of the September meeting – the Middle East, the AI boom, and domestic supply constraints. Hauser noted the Middle East picture "looks worse" given oil prices are "about a third higher than [the RBA] assumed in August". He then positioned AI and data centre developments among an "extraordinary sequence of positive demand shocks around the world", with "higher AI prices, tech prices feeding through into CPI". Finally, on domestic capacity pressures, the Deputy Governor noted that "inflation's been coming in at or a little bit above expectations, despite an apparent easing in the labour market". He went on to state that the staff are currently assessing "whether [the RBA] need to change [its] judgement on capacity pressures in the labour market again" – in other words, revise up their assumption for the NAIRU.

Hauser's comments prompted a material reassessment of market pricing for a follow-up November hike, from just a 20% chance at the end of last week to a 50/50 proposition today ahead of next week's Q3 CPI. For that release, we are forecasting a 1.3% (4.1%yr) lift in headline inflation and a 0.9 (3.5%yr) increase in trimmed mean inflation. Our preview provides more detail behind the component mix for Q3 as well as our upward revisions to the preliminary Q4 forecast. Provided inflation prints broadly in line with our expectations, the RBA is likely to hike by 25bp at the November meeting.

Across in New Zealand, consumer prices rose 0.7% in Q3 and annual inflation eased from 4.1%yr to 3.7%yr. Under the surface of this 'as expected' read though, several closely watched measures of core inflation took a step higher to now be at or slightly above the top of the RBNZ's target band. Our NZ economics team consequently expect the RBNZ will raise the OCR 25bps to 3.00% at its October policy review, while retaining a 4.00% terminal OCR forecast for September 2027.

Earlier in the week, China's economy surprised to the upside in Q3, GDP growth accelerating from 0.9%qtr to 1.2%qtr, lifting annual growth from 4.3%yr to 4.5%yr – keeping authorities on track to achieve their 4.5–5.0% full-year growth objective.

While annual retail sales growth improved in September, rising from 0.4%yr to 1.1%yr, the current pace of growth is only a quarter of the gain seen just a year ago and very weak versus history. Consumer spending continues to be constrained by weak confidence, particularly with respect to employment prospects and wealth. On housing wealth, five years into the property downturn, house prices continue to decline month-on-month and investment remains in a deep downturn, –20.6%ytd.

"With little domestic data of significance, participants' attention focused on RBA Deputy Governor Hauser's fireside chat. Offshore, China GDP was the key release. "

Total fixed asset investment has been detracting from annual GDP growth since April owing to a lull in high-tech investment, a lack of confidence in future demand amongst domestically oriented businesses as well as property's malaise. For aggregate growth to hold up through 2027 and 2028 as the contribution from net exports moderates, broad-based stimulus in scale will prove necessary. Expect recent targeted support measures to be broadened and given much greater scale in coming months.

Finally, in the UK, inflation accelerated from 3.1%yr to 3.5%yr in September, exceeding both market expectations and the Bank of England's July forecast. The surprise was largely driven by energy, fuel prices rising 5.4%mth. However, core inflation also edged up from 2.6%yr to 2.8%yr as services inflation increased from 3.4%yr to 3.7%yr. While not an immediate concern inflation, the labour market showing resilience, the ILO unemployment rate falling from 4.9% to 4.7% in August, suggests demand risks for inflation will need close monitoring as well as supply-side concerns.

Next week will see the focus once again return to the US as the FOMC meet and US Q3 GDP is released. For both events, the implications for risks to the outlook will be the focus. The week after, the US mid-term elections are due.

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RBNZ now expected to hike in October

Satish Ranchhod
Senior Economist

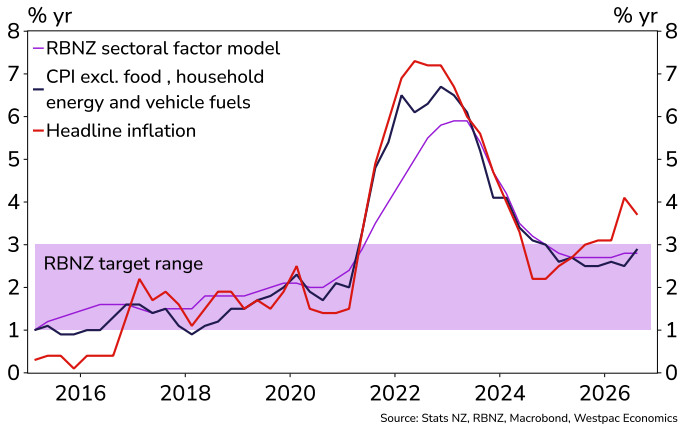
We now expect the RBNZ will deliver a 25bp hike at its policy review on 28 October. While September quarter inflation was slightly below the RBNZ's forecast, the underlying detail was firm. More recently, increases in fuel prices point to a material lift in inflation by year-end. We expect further interest rate increases over the coming months, with the OCR reaching a peak of 4% next year.

Softer headline inflation but firm core pressures leave RBNZ on course to hike in October

We now expect the RBNZ to raise the Official Cash Rate by 25bp at its October policy review (previously, we had expected a pause at this meeting). This change in view reflects significant upside risks to near-term inflation relative to the RBNZ's previous forecast.

While in line with our forecast, the September quarter inflation figures were slightly softer than the RBNZ expected, with prices rising 3.7% over the past year (compared with the RBNZ's forecast of 3.9%). However, the details were less reassuring. Excluding volatile items such as food and fuel, underlying inflation pressures remained firm. Closely watched measures of core inflation moved higher and now sit close to, or a little above, the top of the RBNZ's target band. We also saw an increase in the number of goods recording price rises, taking that measure back to levels seen in the wake of the pandemic.

New Zealand headline and core inflation



Source: Stats NZ, RBNZ, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

Alongside the existing firmness in underlying inflation, the risks for inflation over the coming quarters are firmly tilted to the upside. That near-term upside risk has also been noted by the Governor. Following a sharp rise in global fuel costs, we expect inflation to reach 4.3% by the end of this year (above the RBNZ's September MPS forecast for +3.9%). While that is mainly due to higher prices at the pump, businesses in sectors such as construction are also reporting related increases in transport and materials costs. Consistent with those trends, we expect core inflation to remain in the upper part of the RBNZ's target band through 2027.

Reinforcing the case for an OCR hike at the October meeting, the New Zealand dollar is notably weaker than the RBNZ assumed: on a trade-weighted basis, the NZD is currently 3.6% below the RBNZ's September projections. If sustained, that would add to inflation pressures over the next few quarters. We suspect this will not have shifted the RBNZ's medium-term outlook for inflation.

Several other developments need to be weighed against that firmer inflation outlook. First, wholesale long-term interest rates have risen markedly, and there has also been a more moderate rise in some mortgage rates. The RBNZ is likely to note the role of those increases in managing medium-term inflation risks.

In addition, the RBNZ is likely to continue to emphasise that there is little evidence of a lift in businesses' longer-term plans for price setting at this stage in response to the rise in energy prices (sometimes referred to as "second-round inflation effects"). We expect the RBNZ to highlight the risk that more persistent inflation pressures could emerge, depending on the duration of the oil price shock.

We also expect the RBNZ to note that the labour market remains cyclically weak and is not a significant driver of inflation. Employment growth that remains weak relative to labour force growth, subdued growth in job vacancies and low labour market turnover are consistent with this view and could be emphasised.

Finally, the RBNZ is likely to acknowledge that while the global growth outlook remains solid, there are significant downside risks from the Iran war and concerns about the sustainability of the AI investment cycle.

Balancing those concerns, we think the MPC will lift the cash rate next week. However, a vote seems very possible as differences in view will likely remain among the MPC about how much the medium-term inflation outlook has really shifted in recent weeks.

In September, the bulk of the MPC saw upside risks to the inflation outlook while two members (Conway and Hansen) thought the risks were balanced. Recent developments will not have made those seeing upside risks to inflation more

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comfortable, while the more dovish MPC members will likely focus on the ongoing downside risks for growth given continued softness in house prices and the mounting pressure on real incomes. Indeed, all MPC members saw some degree of downside risks to growth which likely remain relevant. All these messages should remain in the RBNZ's updated views.

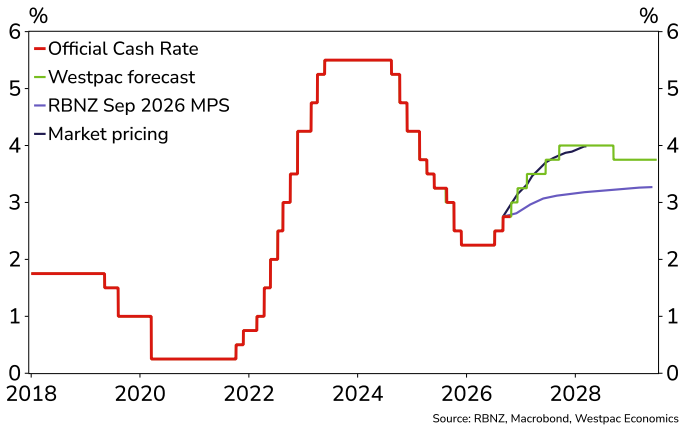
The MPC is likely to continue to present its decision as a gradual evolution of the approach taken since July: a higher OCR now provides insurance against the need for a much higher OCR later if upside risks to medium-term inflation materialise. We doubt the aim will be to push market interest rates materially higher.

RBNZ to leave door open for further hikes, OCR still expected to peak at 4% in 2027

In its forward guidance, the RBNZ is likely to leave open the option of raising the OCR further at the December Monetary Policy Statement, without presenting an increase as certain. While the RBNZ will not publish an updated OCR projection at this review, the press statement is likely to note that further increases may be needed, depending on economic conditions. The September projection showed the OCR eventually rising to 3.25%.

We expect the RBNZ will end up delivering another 25bp hike in December, followed by a further hike in February. That would take the OCR to 3.5%, roughly where the RBNZ estimates the neutral rate to be. At that point, we expect the RBNZ to slow the pace of rate increases (previously, we had expected that point to be reached a little later).

RBNZ Official Cash Rate



Source: RBNZ, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

We continue to expect further 25bp hikes at the June and September 2027 meetings, taking the OCR to a peak of 4.0%. While oil prices are generating significant swings in inflation, underlying pressures remain firm. More restrictive conditions are likely to be needed to bring core inflation sustainably back to 2%.

Scenarios

Our central scenario, with a probability of around 60%, is that the RBNZ increases the OCR by 25bp and signals that a further increase in December remains an option, without committing to a markedly tighter future stance than it outlined in September.

Alternative scenarios include:

- A hawkish scenario (around a 20% probability) would see the OCR increase to 3%, with the RBNZ placing greater emphasis on upside risks to core and medium-term inflation. That would suggest an upward revision to the RBNZ's projected OCR path in December. Downside risks to the exchange rate could also be emphasised.
- A dovish scenario (around a 20% probability) would see the RBNZ leave the OCR unchanged and signal that the medium-term inflation outlook has not changed meaningfully from its September forecast, despite higher near-term inflation. In this scenario, the RBNZ would reiterate its previous forecast: a 25bp increase in December and one further hike during 2027.

How might the election play into the decision?

While next week's meeting is close to the General Election on 7 November, the decision taken by the MPC will not be politically motivated. However, the election outcome is close. And should it result in a Labour Party-led coalition, it seems likely the new government would adopt the Labour Party's promise to restore the RBNZ's dual mandate. That would require the MPC to weigh the degree of labour market slack more highly in its deliberations. As the degree of labour market slack currently seems high, a new mandate might justify the MPC taking more time to return inflation to the middle of the target range (our earlier note discusses this issue). This could figure into the deliberations of some MPC members if the decision between leaving the OCR unchanged and raising it now is viewed as finely balanced.

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AUS: Q3/Sep CPI (%qtr/%mth)

Oct 28, Quarter, Last: 0.6%, Westpac f/c: 1.3%, Market f/c: 1.3%, Range: 0.6 to 1.4.

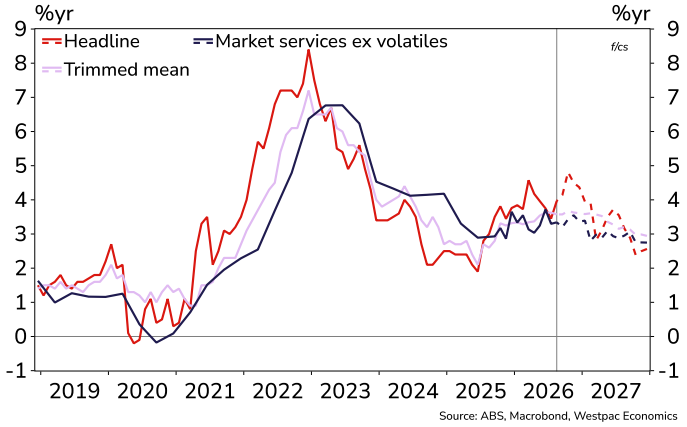
Oct 28, Month, Last: 0.4%, Westpac f/c: 0.6%, Market f/c: 0.6 Range: 0.3 to 0.8

As noted in the review of the August CPI, our September quarter CPI estimate is unchanged at 1.3%qtr holding the annual pace flat at 3.9%yr. At the margin there was a 0.04ppt increase due to a lift in auto fuel but it still rounds to 1.3%. The seasonally adjusted CPI gains 1.1% highlighting that part of the increase is due to usual seasonality.

In the month, the September CPI is expected to rise 0.6% with the annual pace lifting to 4.1%yr. Recreation & culture make the largest contribution but transport is not far behind. Our seasonally adjusted estimate increases 0.5%.

For more details please see "September CPI Preview".

Monthly inflation indicators



Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

AUS: Q3/Sep Trimmed Mean (%qtr/mth)

Oct 28, Quarter, Last: 0.8%, Westpac f/c: 0.9%, Market f/c: 1.0%, Range: 0.9 to 1.0.

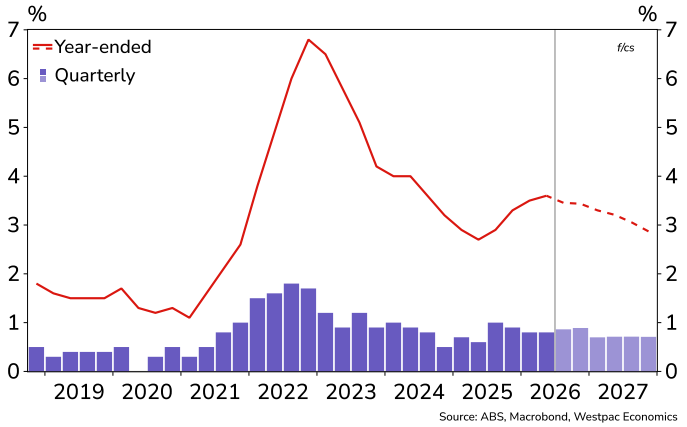
Oct 28, Month, Last: 0.2%, Westpac f/c: 0.3%, Market f/c: 0.3%, Range: 0.2 to 0.4

Our September quarter Trimmed Mean estimate is unchanged at 0.9%qtr with the annual pace dipping a touch from 3.6%yr to 3.5%yr. There was a small downward revision of 0.03ppt to 0.88% compared to our original published estimate but it still rounds to 0.9%qtr.

In the month of September we are looking for a 0.3% in the Trimmed Mean holding the annual pace steady at 3.6% which will be the fourth consecutive month at this pace. The distribution of the September Trimmed Mean ranges from –0.3% to 0.7%.

For more details please see "September CPI Preview".

Trimmed Mean Inflation



Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

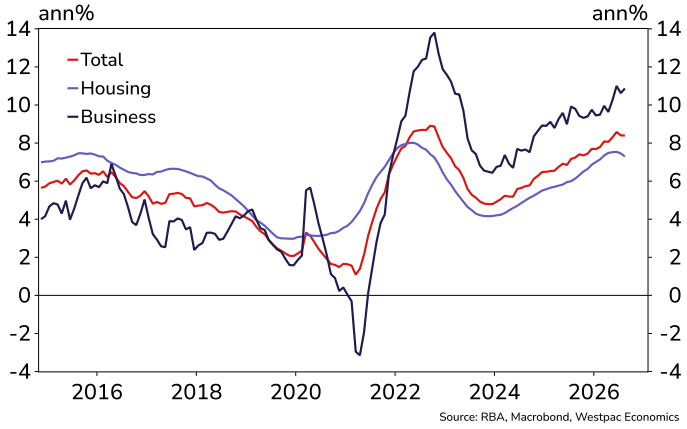
AUS: Sep Private Sector Credit (%mth)

Oct 30, Last: 0.6, Westpac f/c: 0.5
Market f/c: 0.5, Range: 0.4 to 0.6

Private sector credit growth came in slightly firmer than expected at 0.6%mth in August, above Westpac's and the market's forecast for a 0.5%mth gain, leaving credit growth running at 8.4%yr. Growth in housing credit continued to ease, as we expected, though the mix highlights that the waning in momentum is uneven, centred on investors rather than owner-occupiers. Business credit meanwhile remains a source of strength, notwithstanding some slowing recently.

For September, we expect credit growth to nudge to 0.5%mth, with the divergence between housing credit and business credit persisting.

Private sector credit growth



Source: RBA, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

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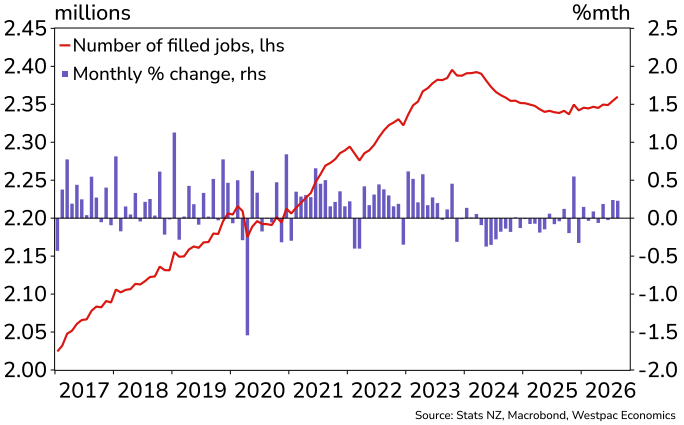
NZ: Sep Monthly Employment Indicator (%mth)

Oct 28, Last: 0.2, Westpac f/c: 0.3

The MEI has been gradually ticking higher in recent months, showing that the jobs market has held its ground through the Iran conflict and the consequent surge in fuel prices. The weekly snapshots provided by Stats NZ have been running ahead of year-ago levels and suggest another solid result for September – we've pencilled in a 0.3% increase. Given the history of this measure, however, both this month and the previous month are likely to be revised down a little from their initial release.

Monthly Employment Indicator



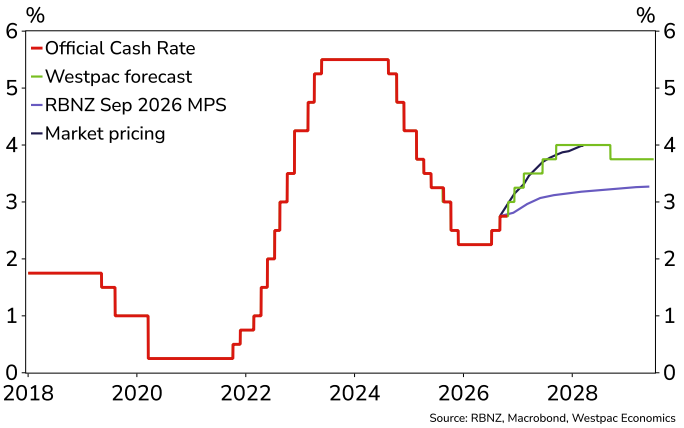
Source: Stats NZ, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

NZ: RBNZ Official Cash Rate Review (%)

Oct 28, Last: 2.75, Westpac f/c: 3.00, Mkt f/c: 3.00

We expect the RBNZ to raise the OCR by 25bps to 3% at the 28 October Review. Data since September show a higher outlook for year-end inflation and a stronger GDP starting point, but increased risks to domestic consumption and residential investment. On balance, the medium-term inflation picture will probably be judged to have worsened slightly given recent movements in energy prices and the exchange rate. A vote seems very possible as differences in view will likely remain among the MPC about how much the medium-term inflation outlook has really shifted in recent weeks. Forward guidance will likely leave open the option to raise the OCR further at the December Monetary Policy Statement without presenting it as a sure thing.

RBNZ Official Cash Rate



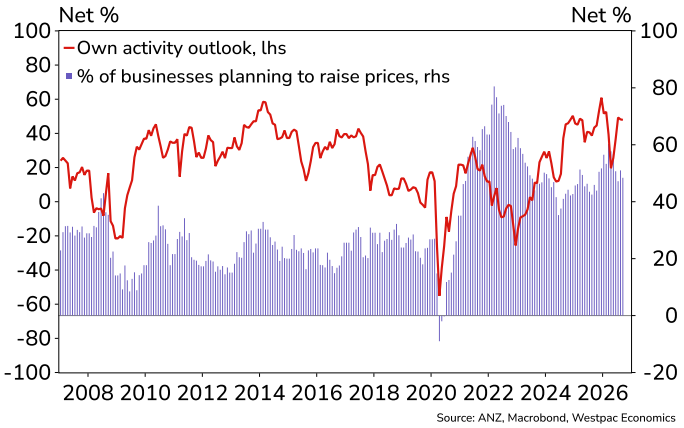
Source: RBNZ, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

NZ: Oct ANZ Business Confidence (index)

Oct 29, Last: 51.9

Firms remained optimistic in the September survey of business confidence, with both the activity and inflation measures broadly holding steady. However, it's likely that most responses were submitted in the early part of the month, while fuel prices took a sharp step higher from the second half of September. The survey comes too late for the RBNZ's October policy review, but evidence about the breadth of cost and price pressures could have a bearing on the RBNZ's thinking about the total amount of policy tightening needed in the months ahead.

ANZ Business Outlook survey



Source: ANZ, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

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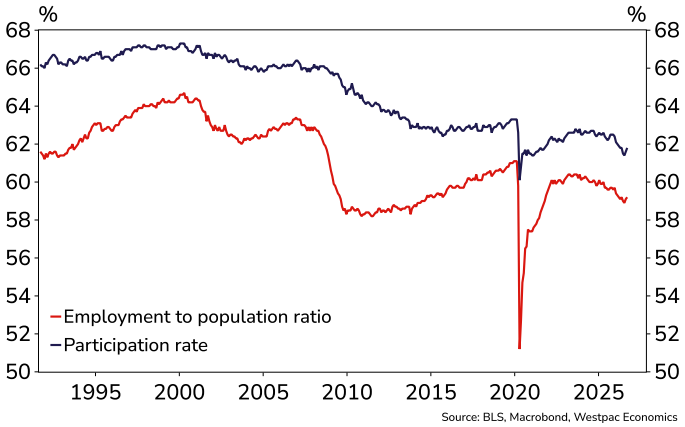
Oct FOMC meeting

Oct 27-28, Last: 3.875%, Mkt f/c: 3.875%, WBC f/c: 3.875%

Core CPI inflation and producer price inflation both surprised to the upside in September, and the price of Brent oil has risen back to around USD110. Underlying momentum in the economy also remains robust, although employment disappointed in the latest update. Given the concerns shown by Committee members over price risks and their collective resolve to return annual inflation to target, the above data could easily justify a follow-up hike at the October meeting.

That said, Committee members who have spoken recently have shown patience with respect to assessing the economy and positioing policy. The market has responded, effectively pricing out the chance of an October hike in favour of a December move, which is also our expectation.

Labour market is not a concern for inflation



Source: BLS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

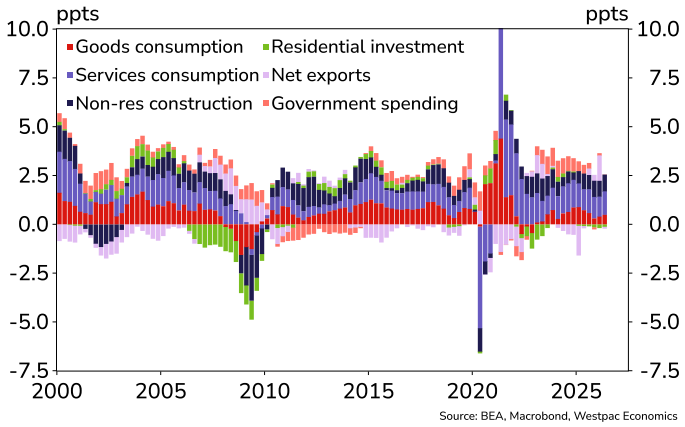
US Q3 GDP

Oct 29, %ann'd, Last: 2.2%, Mkt f/c: 3.0%, WBC f/c: 3.1%

The US economy continues to grow at a pace well above trend. This outperformance is almost entirely due to the strength of investment in data centres and other AI related assets. The pipeline for this activity remains strong, limiting near-term risks to the downside.

Abstracting from AI investment's contribution, other business investment and residential investment is weak, weighed down by high term interest rates and uncertainty related to trade policy. Household consumption growth is volatile month-to-month, but the trend is solid. Absent a marked deterioration in the labour market, which is not our expectation, this momentum is likely to persist, as wealth continues to grow and household income gains neutralises inflation. Come 2027 and 2028, growth is expected to slow to trend, but not below.

Growth supported by AI and consumer



Source: BEA, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

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What to watch

	For	Data/Event	Unit	Last	Market f/c	Westpac f/c	Risk/Comment
Sun 25							
Aus		RBA Assist' Governor (Economic)	–	–	–	–	Hunter interviewed on 60 Minutes, 8:30pm AEDT.
Mon 26							
Aus		RBA Assist' Governor (Fin System)	–	–	–	–	Jones panel participation at AFR Summit, 8:40am AEDT.
Ger	Oct	IFO Business Climate Survey	index	89.9	90.0	–	Recovered from initial Iran war shock, but delicately poised.
US	Sep	Chicago Fed Activity	index	–0.04	–0.10	–	Suggests growth is around trend, but likely underestimating.
	Oct	Dallas Fed Manufacturing	index	9.8	–	–	Solid recovery, even in the face of higher fuel costs.
Tue 27							
Chn	Sep	Industrial Profits	%ann	4.2	–	–	Profit growth narrowly based; consumer-facing sluggish.
US	Sep	Durable Goods Orders	%mth	–0.1	1.4	–	Points to a solid underlying investment pulse.
	Aug	S&P/CS Home Price Index	%mth	0.32	0.30	–	Prices continue to edge higher despite record long-term rates.
	Oct	Richmond Fed Manufacturing	index	–2	–	–	Momentum fading over recent months.
	Sep	New Home Sales	%mth	6.4	–6.4	–	Affordability limits number of buyers and available homes ...
	Oct	Conf. Board Consumer Confidence	index	81.9	80.4	–	... which among other factors, is weighing heavily on confidence.
Wed 28							
Aus		RBA Senate Appearnce	–	–	–	–	RBA's top brass appear before Senate, 11:15am AEDT.
	Sep	Headline CPI	%mth	0.4	0.6	0.6	Uptick in headline inflation anticipated in September month ...
	Sep	Trimmed Mean CPI	%mth	0.2	0.3	0.3	... broad-based enough to see trimmed mean lift also.
	Q3	Headline CPI	%qtr	0.6	1.3	1.3	Chunky increase in Q3 headline inflation given fuel prices ...
	Q3	Trimmed Mean CPI	%qtr	0.8	1.0	0.9	... RBA will closely watch the quarterly trimmed mean.
NZ	Sep	Employment Indicator	%mth	0.2	–	0.3	August likely to be revised down from previous print.
		RBNZ Policy Decision	%	2.75	3.00	3.00	Near term inflation pressures have been mounting.
US	Sep	Wholesale Inventories	%mth	0.5	–	–	Business working hard to build inventory buffers.
	Oct	FOMC Policy Decision	%	3.875	3.875	3.875	Committee members have advocated for patience near-term.
Can	Oct	BoC Policy Decision	%	2.25	2.25	–	Markets split on whether to BoC will hold or hike.
Thur 29							
Aus	Q3	Export Price Index	%qtr	1.1	–	–	Mixed price action among Australia's key resource exports ...
	Q3	Import Price Index	%qtr	5.7	–	–	... while fuel prices remain a clear driver on the import side.
NZ	Oct	ANZ Business Confidence	index	51.9	–	–	Resilient in recent months, price pressures will be a key focus.
Eur	Oct	EC Economic Confidence	index	97.9	–	–	Sensitive to consumer sentiment, which remains sluggish.
	Oct	ECB Policy Decision (Deposit Rate)	%	2.50	2.50	2.50	Will remain on hold, but one final rate hike due by year-end.
US	Sep	Personal Income	%mth	0.2	0.3	–	Nominal incomes rising at a slower pace than inflation ...
	Sep	Personal Spending	%mth	0.9	0.6	–	... but consumer spending continues to charge ahead.
	Sep	PCE Deflator	%mth	0.3	0.5	–	Fed's preferred inflation gauge to remain elevated.
		Initial Jobless Claims	000s	194	–	–	Still at a low level versus history.
	Q3	GDP	%ann'd	2.2	3.0	3.1	Growth well above trend, thanks to data centres and AI.
Fri 30							
Aus	Q3	PPI	%qtr	1.3	–	–	Elevated fuel costs at the core of upstream price pressures.
	Sep	Private Sector Credit	%mth	0.6	0.5	0.5	Investor credit growth continues to slow.
NZ	Oct	ANZ Consumer Confidence	index	97.6	–	–	Continued increases in fuel costs likely to weigh on sentiment.
Jpn	Oct	Tokyo CPI	%ann	2.7	2.7	–	Elevated core inflation gives green light for another rate hike.
	Sep	Jobless Rate	%	2.5	2.5	–	Low, stable unemployment reflects a fairly tight labour market.
	Sep	Industrial Production	%mth	–2.4	1.3	–	Factory output starting lift, albeit off a weak base.
	Oct	BoJ Policy Decision	%	1.25	1.25	1.25	Expected to hold steady for now, hike in Dec looks likely.
Eur	Q3	GDP	%qtr	0.6	0.2	–	Should still eke out some growth amid significant headwinds ...
	Sep	Unemployment Rate	%	6.4	6.4	–	... low unemployment a positive sign of the region's health.
US	Q3	Employment Cost Index	%qtr	0.9	0.8	–	Wages growth expected to tick slightly lower in Q3.
Sat 31							
Chn	Oct	NBS Manufacturing PMI	index	50.1	50.1	–	Bumping around broadly neutral so far this year ...
	Oct	NBS Non–Manufacturing PMI	index	50.2	–	–	... policy stimulus should support services activity, in time.

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Economic & financial forecasts

Interest rate forecasts

Australia	Latest (23 Oct)	Dec–26	Mar–27	Jun–27	Sep–27	Dec–27	Mar–28	Jun–28	Sep–28	Dec–28
Cash	4.60	4.85	4.85	4.85	4.60	4.35	4.10	3.85	3.85	3.85
90 Day BBSW	4.82	4.95	4.95	4.80	4.55	4.30	4.10	3.95	3.95	3.95
3 Year Swap	4.85	4.90	4.85	4.75	4.65	4.55	4.45	4.35	4.30	4.25
3 Year Bond	4.83	4.90	4.85	4.75	4.65	4.55	4.45	4.35	4.30	4.25
10 Year Bond	5.16	5.20	5.15	5.10	5.05	5.05	5.00	5.00	5.00	5.00
10 Year Spread to US (bps)	20	15	15	15	15	10	0	–5	–10	–15
United States										
Fed Funds	3.875	4.125	4.125	4.125	4.125	4.125	3.875	3.625	3.625	3.625
US 10 Year Bond	4.97	5.05	5.00	4.95	4.90	4.95	5.00	5.05	5.10	5.15
New Zealand										
Cash	2.75	3.25	3.50	3.75	4.00	4.00	4.00	4.00	3.75	3.75
90 Day Bill	3.31	3.60	3.75	4.00	4.20	4.20	4.20	4.15	3.95	3.95
2 Year Swap	4.04	3.95	4.10	4.25	4.20	4.20	4.15	4.15	4.10	4.10
10 Year Bond	4.90	5.00	5.00	5.00	5.05	5.05	5.05	5.05	5.05	5.05
10 Year Spread to US (bps)	–6	–5	0	5	15	10	5	0	–5	–10

Exchange rate forecasts

	Latest (23 Oct)	Dec–26	Mar–27	Jun–27	Sep–27	Dec–27	Mar–28	Jun–28	Sep–28	Dec–28
AUD/USD	0.7014	0.72	0.72	0.73	0.73	0.73	0.73	0.72	0.72	0.72
NZD/USD	0.5693	0.56	0.58	0.61	0.63	0.64	0.64	0.64	0.65	0.65
USD/JPY	156.94	156	154	153	152	151	150	149	148	146
EUR/USD	1.1213	1.14	1.16	1.18	1.20	1.21	1.22	1.22	1.21	1.21
GBP/USD	1.3394	1.34	1.35	1.36	1.38	1.39	1.40	1.41	1.41	1.40
USD/CNY	6.6729	6.65	6.60	6.50	6.45	6.40	6.35	6.35	6.30	6.30
AUD/NZD	1.2312	1.27	1.24	1.20	1.16	1.15	1.13	1.12	1.12	1.11

Australian economic forecasts

	2026				2027				Calendar years			
% change	Q1	Q2	Q3(f)	Q4(f)	Q1(f)	Q2(f)	Q3(f)	Q4(f)	2025	2026(f)	2027(f)	2028(f)
GDP %qtr	0.3	0.4	0.5	0.2	0.4	0.3	0.4	0.5	–	–	–	–
%yr end	2.5	2.1	2.2	1.5	1.6	1.5	1.4	1.6	2.6	1.5	1.6	2.4
Unemployment rate %	4.2	4.4	4.6	4.7	4.7	4.8	4.8	4.7	4.3	4.7	4.7	4.5
Wages (WPI) (sa) %qtr	0.8	0.8	1.0	0.8	0.8	0.8	0.8	0.8	–	–	–	–
%yr end	3.2	3.2	3.4	3.4	3.4	3.4	3.2	3.2	3.4	3.4	3.2	3.4
Headline CPI %qtr	1.4	0.6	1.3	1.3	0.4	0.5	1.0	0.5	–	–	–	–
%yr end	4.1	3.9	3.9	4.6	3.6	3.4	3.2	2.4	3.6	4.6	2.4	2.3
Trimmed Mean CPI %qtr	0.8	0.8	0.9	0.9	0.7	0.7	0.7	0.7	–	–	–	–
%yr end	3.5	3.6	3.5	3.5	3.3	3.3	3.1	2.9	3.3	3.5	2.9	2.4

New Zealand economic forecasts

	2026				2027				Calendar years			
% Change	Q1	Q2	Q3f	Q4f	Q1f	Q2f	Q3f	Q4f	2025	2026f	2027f	2028f
GDP %qtr	0.9	0.2	0.6	0.7	0.9	0.5	0.6	0.7	–	–	–	–
Annual avg change	0.9	1.7	2.1	2.4	2.4	2.5	2.6	2.6	0.3	2.4	2.6	3.0
Unemployment rate %	5.4	5.6	5.5	5.5	5.4	5.3	5.2	5.0	5.4	5.5	5.0	4.4
CPI %qtr	0.9	1.5	0.7	1.2	0.3	0.4	0.5	0.2	–	–	–	–
Annual change	3.1	4.1	3.7	4.3	3.7	2.5	2.3	1.4	3.1	4.3	1.4	1.9

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First Impressions: NZ retail card spending, October 2026

#retail #newzealand

By Michael Gordon
Senior Economist, Westpac NZ

10:26 November 12 2026

Share

Card spending was surprisingly weak again in October.

Retail spending

Monthly change: -0.7% (prev: -0.5%, Westpac forecast: +1.4%)

Annual change: +0.3% (prev: +0.9%)

Core retail spending (excluding fuel/autos)

Monthly change: -1.2% (prev: -0.7%)

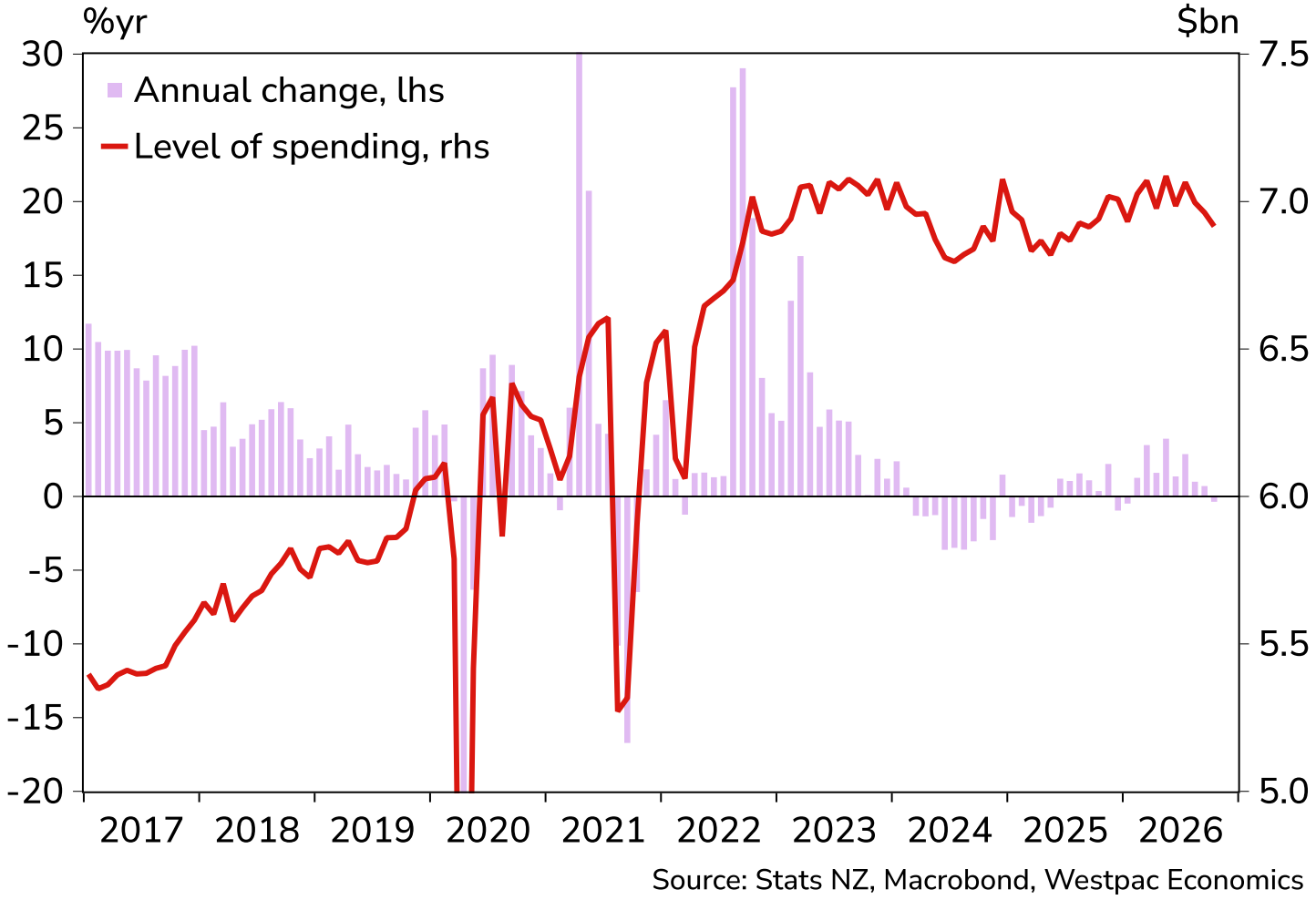
Annual change: -0.8% (prev: +0.1%)

Retail spending on credit and debit cards was reportedly down 0.7% in October, a third straight monthly decline. Spending was down across all categories with the exception of fuel, which saw a 4.8% rise in spending – and with fuel prices around 10% higher over the month, that still points to a decline in spending volumes.

We should note that we have had concerns for some time about the coverage of this data. The monthly result was again significantly weaker than what we recorded for spending on Westpac-issued credit and debit cards (ANZ also reported an increase in spending on its own figures). And as a lead indicator of the quarterly retail survey (which feeds into GDP), it has undershot in every one of the last six quarters. We don't suggest that spending is growing strongly by any means – and it is likely the case that higher fuel prices are crowding out spending elsewhere. But we suspect that the true picture is not as weak as today's release suggests.

A drop in oil prices since the start of November has provided some relief for fuel prices at the pump, although they remain high. We anticipate that growth in consumer spending volumes will remain subdued in the near term, with regional variations dependent on exposure to the well-performing export sector. What happens beyond this year will depend on how the Middle East conflict evolves and how the RBNZ responds to the rebound in inflation.

NZ retail card spending



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October 2026

THE RED BOOK

Quarterly update on the Australian consumer

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Staggering into year end

Coming into the home strait for 2026, the Australian consumer has again got the staggers. Spending has held up surprisingly well given the intense headwinds that have buffeted household budgets over the year. But the same cannot be said for sentiment which has fallen off badly in the face of more shocks.

Our October **Red Book** surveys the scene. Psychologically, consumers has seen a return to the 'cost of living nightmare' they struggled with through much of 2022, 2023 and 2024. Global forces and domestic factors are again having pervasive negative impacts on budgets.

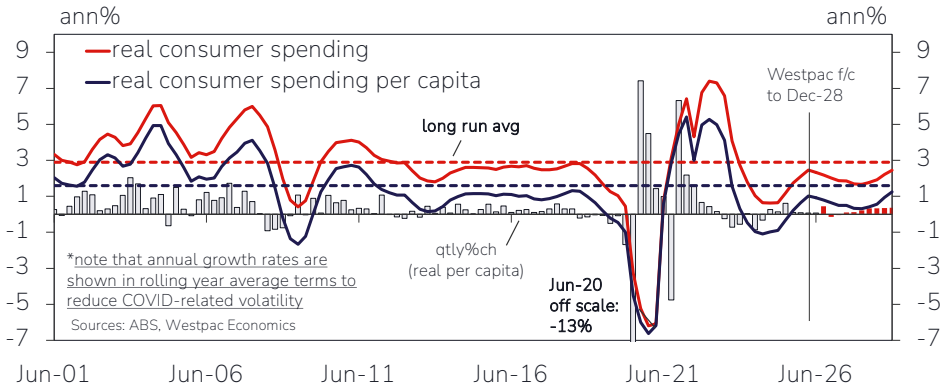
The scale may not be as severe as the previous episode – inflation is running in the 3-4% range not the 7-8% and interest rates have risen 1ppt not 4 – but the feeling is similar. In part this because there has was very little reprieve in between – despite tax cuts and a partial unwind of the interest rate tightening in 2025, household incomes never got a chance to regain the lost ground.

The inflation 'relapse', and the difficulty the RBA and governments seem to be having in managing the situation, is likely feeding into fears about the outlook for the wider economy as well.

Exactly what this means for spending is not entirely clear. As discussed in our last report, sentiment reads have been much weaker than actual spending in recent years. The apparent disconnect is likely due to a mix of legacy effects from COVID, and the specific challenges posed by high inflation (including the lingering effects of high prices even once inflation has subsided).

On balance we expect the spending side to slow materially, particularly as we head into year end. Indeed, the seven weeks between now and Christmas could prove decisive for the consumer outlook, beginning with another important sentiment survey update and then the high season for retail. How spending performs **outside** of key sales windows will be most telling.

1. Consumer spending: slowdown ahead



"... sentiment ... has fallen off badly in the face of more shocks"

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Quick run-down

The **Westpac–Melbourne Institute Consumer Sentiment Index** declined 4.2% over the three months to Oct, unwinding a mini-rally through the middle of the year. At 80.4 the average read over the Oct survey implies that pessimists outnumber optimists by nearly 20%, a deeply pessimistic level by historical standards that is amongst the forty worst reads since the survey began in the 1973.

The survey detail shows concerns are still primarily about the cost-of-living and high interest rates than the more acute job and insolvency problems that arise during a recession. The RBA's Sep rate hike, mid-way through the survey week looks to have badly rattled consumers.

The component detail shows a broad pull-back but with bigger declines in assessments of family finances and buyer sentiment and milder declines in assessments of the economic outlook.

Consumers remain intensely risk averse. The **Westpac Risk Aversion Index** held near historical highs in Sep, readings still only a touch of the 52-year high of 60.8 recorded in June 2023. Recall that the index is based on responses to questions on the 'wisest place for savings'. Responses show 'safe options' remain very heavily favoured.

The sentiment mix points to a significant weakening in spending momentum is weakening. **CSI±,** a modified indicator that shows a better correlation with per capita spending, points to a shift back to significant outright contractions in per capita spending. That said, spending in 2026 has held up better than these indicators have suggested so far.

Consumers are on high alert for interest rate. The **Westpac–Melbourne Institute Mortgage Rate Expectations Index** rose 5.5% to 179 over the three months to Oct, just shy of May's cycle peak of 181. The RBA has raised interest rates 25bps since then. The Nov survey update due Nov 10 will be an important update on how expectations have evolved.

The **'time to buy a major item'** index dropped 4.3% over the last three months, taking it back near the lows seen earlier in the year and a full 40pts below the long run avg. Durables spend has been mixed over the first half of 2026, posting a surprisingly solid gain in Q2 but with most of this centred on new vehicle spend where 'extenuating circumstances' were at play.

Homebuyer sentiment has been understandably unsettled in recent months given heightened uncertainty around interest rate and tax policy changes amid evidence of a broadening downturn in established markets.

The **'time to buy a dwelling'** index actually lifted 3.6% over the three months to Oct but is still at firmly pessimistic levels. Both monthly reads and sub-group detail have been very unsettled.

The broadening and deepening downturn in Australia's housing markets is seeing an equally rapid shift in consumer house price expectations although these have not turned as negative as they did during the 2022-23 correction.

The **Westpac–Melbourne Institute Consumer House Price Expectations Index** declined a further 2.4% over the 3mths to Oct, following a steep 25% drop over the previous 3mths. At 115.6, the Oct index read is miles below the 15yr high of 174 at the start of the year and below the long run avg of 130. That said, the read is still above 100, meaning more consumers expect prices to rise than fall.

The labour market remains an island of relative calm for consumers. The **Westpac–Melbourne Institute Unemployment Expectations Index** rose 9.3% over the three months to Oct, reversing most of the 12.1% improvement over the previous three months (recall that higher reads mean more consumers expect unemployment to rise over the year ahead). At 142.2, the Oct index read is now decisively above the long run avg of 129 again but still well below the levels that would sound more worrying alarms.

As noted, the Nov survey, currently in the field and due to be released on Nov 10, will provide critical updates on many of these themes.

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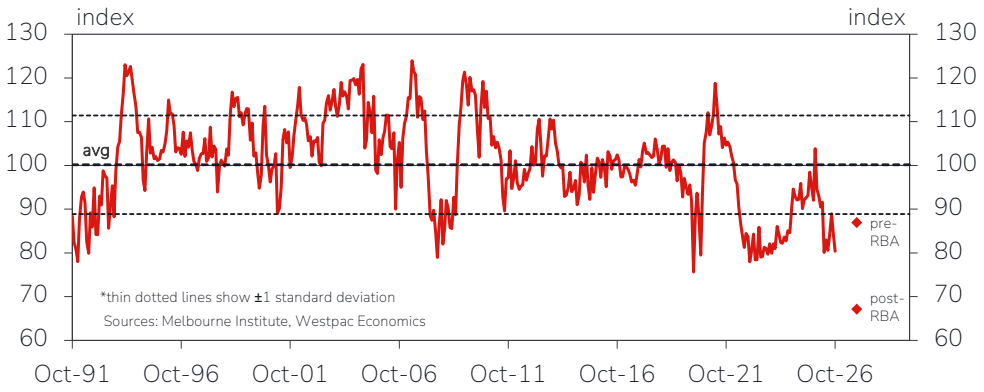
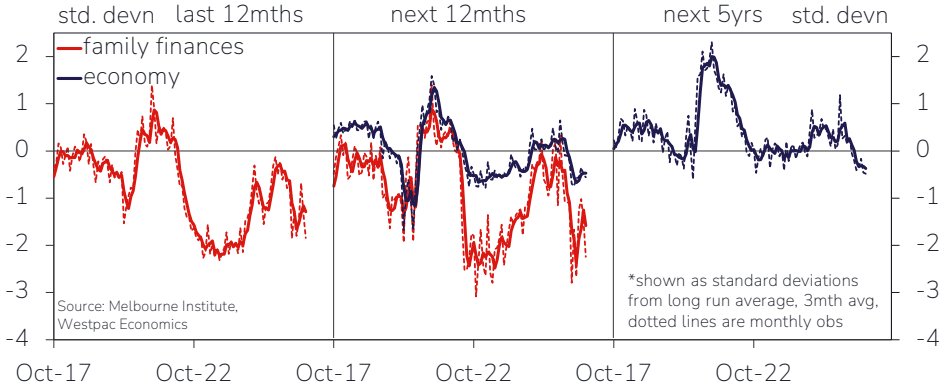
Cost-of-living nightmare continues

- Consumers remain stuck in a cost-of-living nightmare that seems to have not end in sight. Sentiment remains deeply pessimistic, weighed down by continued uncertainty about the path for inflation and interest rates, the latter providing a clear negative 'jolt' midway through the Oct survey week.
- The **Westpac Melbourne Institute Index of Consumer Sentiment** declined 4.2% over the three months to Oct, unwinding a mini-rally through the middle of the year. At 80.4 the average read over the Oct survey implies that pessimists outnumber optimists by nearly 20%, a deeply pessimistic level by historical standards. It is amongst the forty worst reads since the survey began in the 1973. We have had two others in this unfortunate group already this year (in Apr and Jun) with another eight in 2022–23. Altogether this marks the worst period of recurring extremely weak sentiment since the disastrous recession in the early 1990s.
- The survey detail shows consumer concerns are still primarily about the cost-of-living and high interest rates than the more acute job and insolvency problems that arise during a recession.
- Average weekly pump prices pushed back over $2.30/litre nationally in early Oct, rising to over $2.35/litre since. This is near the peaks seen back in April and up nearly 25% since the start of the year. Meanwhile the RBA interest rate rise in late Sep took the cash rate to 4.6%, the highest since 2011, with the standard variable mortgage interest rate pushing above 9% for the first time since 2008.
- The RBA's Sep move badly rattled consumers. Sentiment amongst the 60% of the sample surveyed prior came in at 86.9, up slightly from the Sep read. The sentiment read across the 40% surveyed after the RBA decision came in at just 67.2, an alarmingly weak read that, for complete surveys, has only been registered during the depths of the early 1990s recession. The nearly 20% drop between pre and post RBA samples is also the largest negative swing we have seen since we started tracking daily responses in 2019.
- The RBA has delivered another hike as we go to press, meaning Nov is likely to see yet another interest rate hike to sentiment (the survey result will be released on Nov 10).

2. Consumer sentiment: rate rise jolt



3. Consumer sentiment: finances, economic conditions



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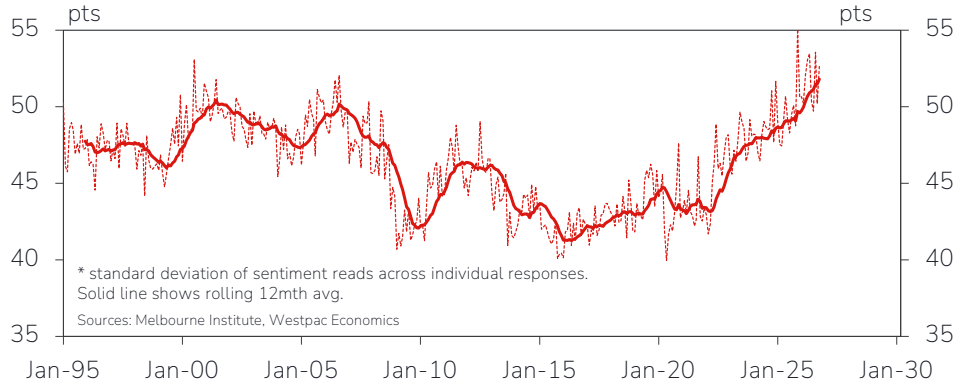
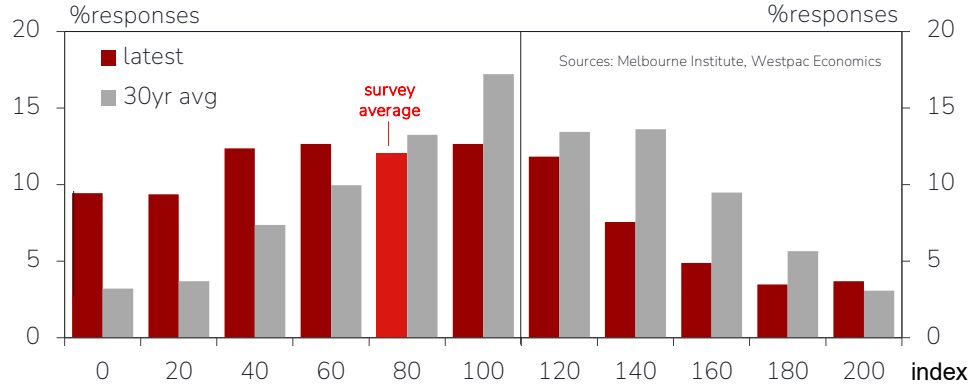
- The component detail shows a broad pull-back but with bigger declines in assessments of family finances and buyer sentiment. The 'finances vs a year ago' sub-index dropped 6% over the 3mths to Oct to just 66.9, on a par with April's extreme low. The pressure is not expected to ease up any time soon, the 'finances, next 12 months' sub-index also down 8.3% to 88.4, in the bottom 10% of reads for this sub-index since the survey began.
- Consumer views on the economy recorded milder declines, the 'economy, next 12 months' sub-index unchanged on Jul, holding at 78.3 and the 'economy, next 5 years' sub-index down 1.8% to 85.5. However, the latter is now back near the lows seen in Aug 2020. This was a dark time during the COVID crisis when Melbourne had entered its second lockdown and just prior to the Federal government significantly expanding its JobKeeper supports. The readings suggest there are shades of COVID now with a similar sense of helplessness – that Australia is unable to avoid a global inflation problem and that there is relatively little authorities can do to help the situation that does not add to pressures on consumers.
- The cost of living and interest rate pressures are both broad and intense. Pessimists outnumber optimists in 102 of the 106 sub-groups we track, and by over 20% in nearly two thirds of these. This speaks to the pervasive influence of higher fuel costs in particular.
- That said, sentiment is becoming more dispersed. It is possible to compute sentiment index scores for each individual respondent. Chart 4 shows how the spread across these scores has evolved since 1995. The average standard deviation over the full history is 46pts. It was about 4pts lower over the decade prior to COVID but has risen steadily since to over 52pts in Oct, the average spread over the last 12mths marking a record high. Chart 5 shows the full distribution of individual scores in the last 3mths compared to history.
- We noted in our last report that the widening spread has been accompanied by a notable divergence in sentiment across major and minor party voters. There are likely multiple underlying reasons for the shift which the voter group split may be picking up indirectly rather than directly due to the way these skew across different demographics.

4. Consumer sentiment: spread across individual respondents



5. Consumer sentiment: distribution



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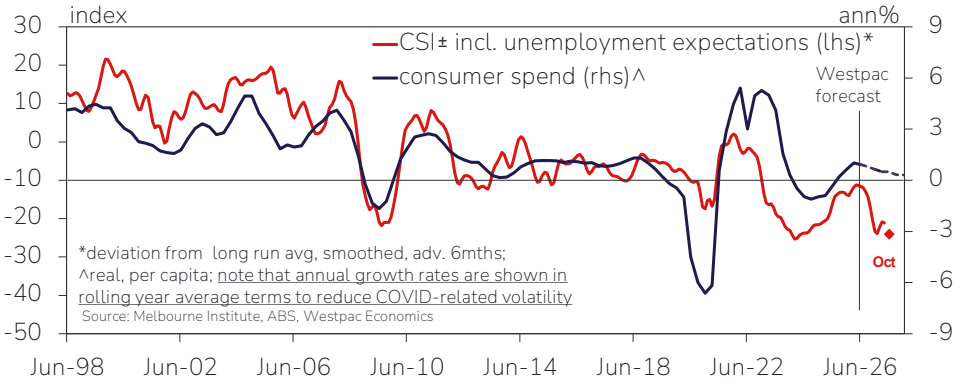
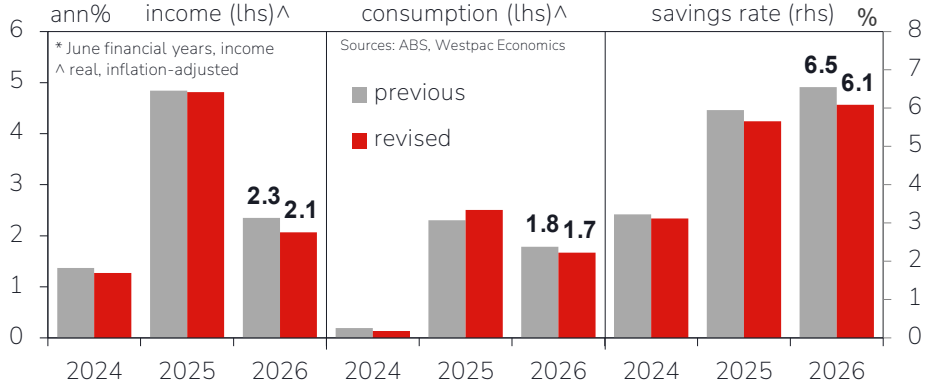
Spending: squeeze ahead

- Our **CSI±** composite combines sub-indexes tracking views on 'family finances' and 'time to buy a major item' with the **Westpac Consumer Risk Aversion Index** and usually provides a good guide to trends in spending over the next 3–6mths.
- However, as discussed in detail in our last report the composite has been of more limited use in recent years due to both the volatile spending around COVID lock-downs and the nature of the post-COVID cost-of-living shock to sentiment. Analysis shows adding the **WestpacMelbourne Institute Index of Unemployment Expectations** (p15) to the composite goes some way to redressing these issues. Accordingly, our **CSI±** indicator will now include this additional component going forward. As Chart 6 highlights, the composite should still mainly be viewed as a directional guide to where per capita spending growth momentum is heading rather than a point estimate.
- Unsurprisingly, the **CSI±** indicator fell steeply over the 3mths to Oct, dropping from 75.6 to 67.6, putting the measure over 26pts below its long run avg of 93.8.
- The move reflected the more marked falls in assessments of finances and 'time to buy' with a significant deterioration in unemployment expectations as well. Risk aversion remained unchanged at very high levels.
- Chart 6 shows the current read is consistent with a large contraction in real per capita consumer spending, even allowing for the wedge that has opened up between observed spending growth and the **CSI±** indicator over the last few years.
- The Q2 national accounts showed some slowing in consumer spending although it was more resilient than feared to the combined effect of higher fuel prices and interest rates while incomes posted a robust rise. More generally a range of shocks and shifts made for a messy quarter (see here for more).
- Real consumption rose 0.4%qtr taking annual growth to 1.8%yr, down from a peak of 2.7%yr in Q3 last year. The detail showed declines in fuel spend and transport services (including air travel) were more than offset by a 10% surge in vehicle sales, led by a big rise in EVs and hybrids.

6. CSI± vs consumer spending



7. Annual national accounts: benchmark revisions



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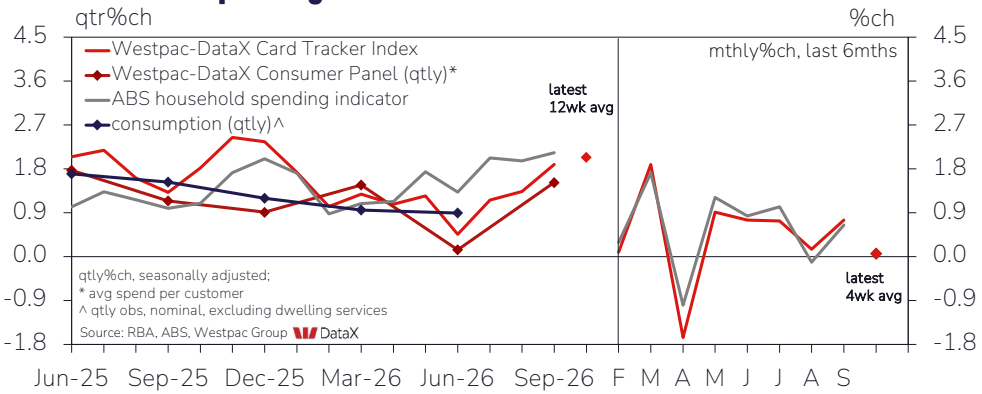
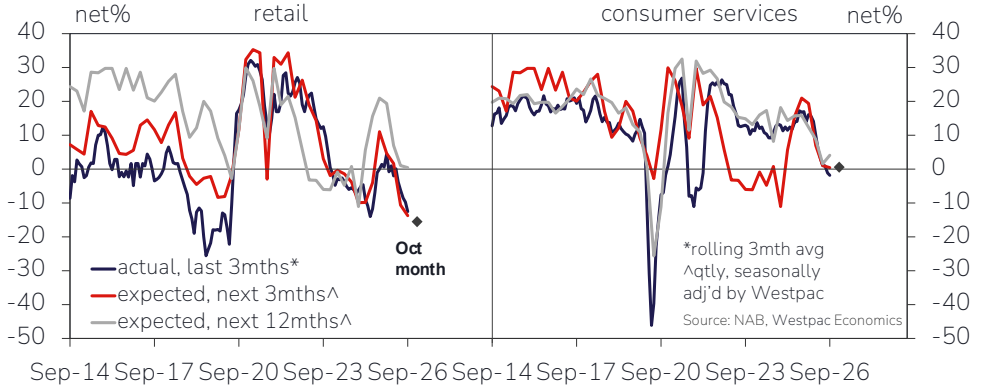
- Household disposable incomes rose 0.6%qtr, lifting annual growth to 2.3%yr, supported by a continued robust rise in labour income (more due to average compensation than head count in the latest quarter). This in turn meant the household savings rate ticked up slightly from 6.4% to 6.5%.
- New annual benchmarks released by the ABS since the Q2 accounts were published showed relatively minor revisions (Chart 7). For the full financial year, annual growth in disposable income was nudged 0.2pts lower to 2.1%yr with real spending shaved back from 1.8%yr to 1.7%yr and the savings rate lowered from 6.5% to 6.1%. These changes will be rolled into the quarterly estimates when the Q3 national accounts are released on Dec 2.
- Partial data suggests Q3 has seen a lift in nominal spend although most of this is a price effect. The ABS household spending indicator, which covers around two thirds of the total consumption basket, showed a 2.1%qtr rise in nominal terms in Q3 up from 1.3%qtr in Q2. However, all of that was due to stronger price growth with volumes posting a 0.7% rise in line with Q2 (see here).
- Our **Westpac-DataX Card Tracker Index** foreshadowed the spending indicator result and suggests quarterly growth momentum is still tracking at around 2% in mid-Oct in nominal terms. That said, quarterly growth rate is likely slowing in real terms given our estimates that Oct saw a further step-up in price growth. The latest monthly pace of gains also looks to be about flat in nominal terms (see Chart 8).
- Private sector business surveys point to weak conditions for retail (consistent with under-performing discretionary goods segments) and stalling activity for consumer services. Near term expectations are at similar levels for both but with year-weak expectations flat rather than negative for retail.
- The ABS will publish full spending estimates with the Q3 national accounts on Dec 2. Based on partials we expect these to show a solid +0.8%qtr gain, lifting annual growth to 2.1%yr, an upgrade on the +0.4%qtr, 1.5%yr forecast in or last report. However, that's expected to be the high water mark for growth with forecast to slow abruptly into year end and early 2027, growth tracking back to 1.4%yr by Q3 2027.

8. Consumer spending: selected indicators



9. Business conditions: retail and consumer services



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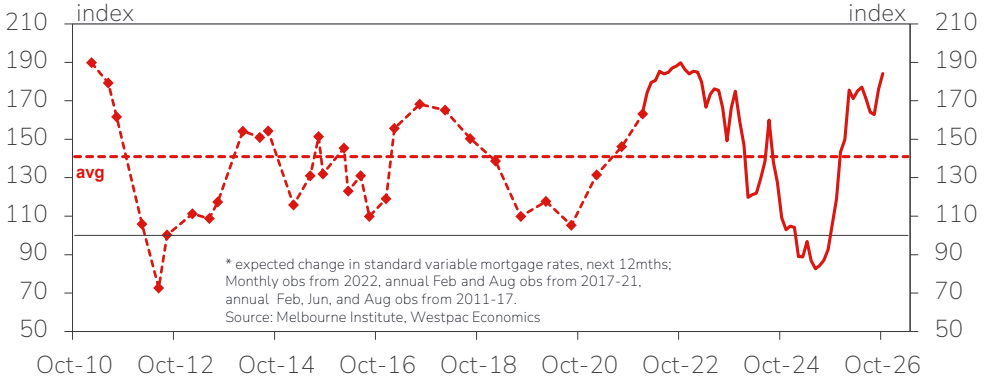
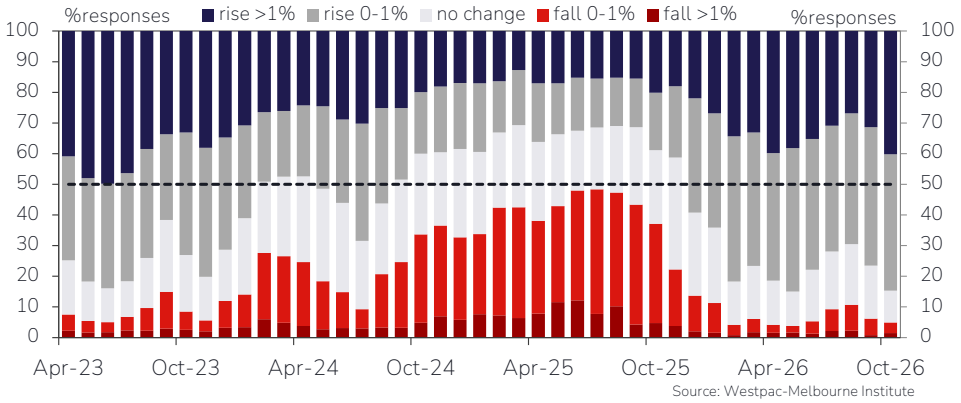
Interest rates: hike fears realised

- Consumers have been on high alert for interest rate rises for some time. Those fears materialised in late Sep and again in early Nov. The Oct survey was in the field during the week of the Sep move. Not surprisingly, the **Westpac–Melbourne Institute Mortgage Rate Expectations Index**, which tracks consumer interest rate expectations, rose 5.5% to 179, just shy of May's cycle peak of 181.
- Amongst those surveyed after the RBA decision, just over 80%, an overwhelming majority, expect mortgage rates to increase further over the next 12mths. This compares to 64% in Sep. Across the mortgage belt, the share is closer to 90%, with over 40% of this sub-group expecting rates to rise by more than a percentage point over the next twelve months.
- While the Sep and Nov interest rate increases were widely expected, the scale of the rise over the last 12mths, a full 1.25%, has come as a surprise. This time last year, consumers were in two minds, 39% of those with a view expecting interest rates to rise and 37% expecting them to fall. Only 20% of consumers expected mortgage rates to rise by over 1ppt.
- As at Oct, just over 40% of consumers with a view expected mortgage interest rates to rise by more than 1ppt. While some hawkishness is clearly warranted, this is extreme – it would take the standard variable mortgage rate well above 10%, to levels not seen since the mid-1990s, thirty years ago.
- Overall, Oct responses suggest consumers were broadly expecting another three 25bp rate hikes from the RBA. The Nov survey, currently in the field, will capture how expectations have shifted after the RBA's more recent move. While this may have amplified rate rise fears, the split vote and some indications from the Governor that there may be a pause to assess things in Dec could work the other way (see here for more).
- The near term inflation outlook clearly remains challenging. However, Westpac expects the RBA to leave rates on hold through the remainder of 2026. And while there are risks of a further tightening in early 2027 we think rates will more likely be maintained at current levels with an eventual gradual relaxation in policy beginning in the second half of 2027.

10. Mortgage interest rate expectations



11. Consumer expectations for mortgage rates



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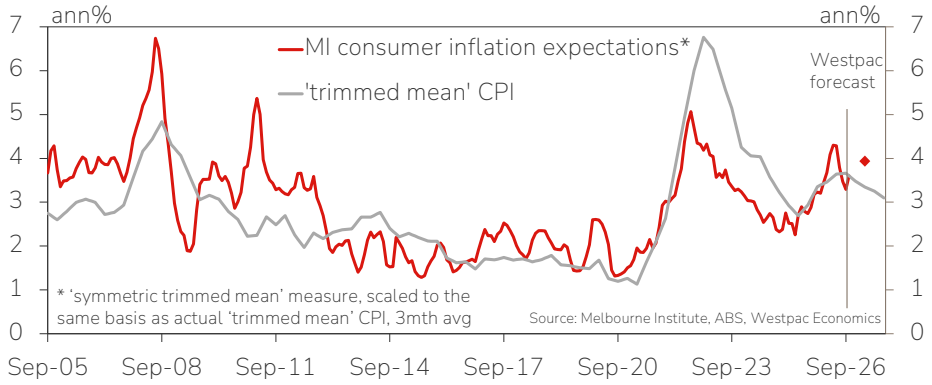
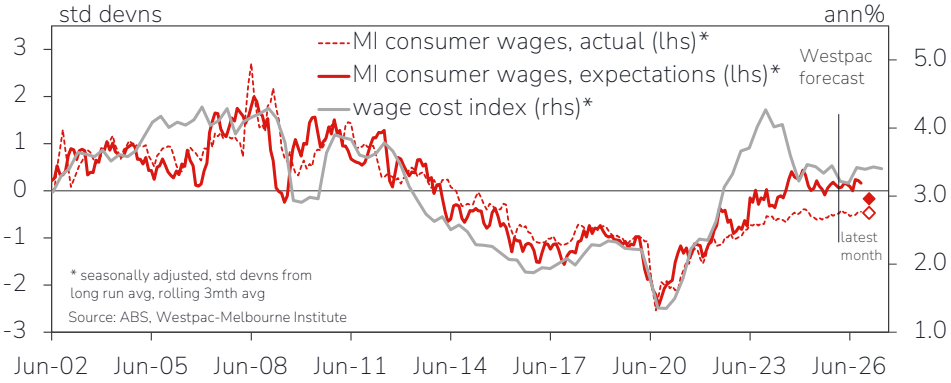
Inflation: still too hot but wages flat

- Inflation has kicked up again over the last 3mths, led by a resurgence in global energy prices. Near term consumer inflation expectations have risen sharply again as well although consumer wage expectations have not moved, if anything moving marginally lower in the latest month.
- The Sep CPI report showed headline up 1.3%qtr, the annual pace holding at the Jun qtr pace of 3.9%yr. The key 'trimmed mean' measure lifted 1.0%qtr, the annual pace ticking up from 3.6%yr to 3.7%yr. The detail revealed underlying inflationary pressures continuing even while a moderation in housing inflation (dwellings in particular) is unfolding slightly faster than anticipated. Near-term risks for inflation are to the upside but more balanced further out (see here)
- Consumer inflation expectations have moved higher again. After peaking at 5.9% in Apr, the Melbourne Institute's 'symmetric mean' measure of consumers' year-ahead inflation expectations eased back to 4.7% in Jul, ticking up slightly to 4.9% in Aug and Sep but jumped again back to 5.3% in Jul. Expectations are likely being skewed by the jump in fuel prices.
- Scaling according to historical inflation outcomes suggests current expectations are consistent with inflation of around 4%yr. It is difficult to look through the effects of fuel price volatility, which amplified expectations in Mar and Apr but dampened them again when the temporary halving in fuel excise tax came into effect through Apr-May.
- From the RBA's perspective, it will be important for inflation expectations to track back towards historical levels in a timely manner as a sign that expectations more generally remain firmly anchored at low inflation rates.
- Certainly there are no signs that the latest lift in inflation is becoming embedded into expectations for wages. Consumer assessments of actual wages lifted a little when the new Award decision came into effect but have settled back to 1.4%, a touch above the Jun qtr avg of 1.2% but below the long run avg of 1.8%. Expectations have tracked a slightly softer path, dipping to 1.2% in Oct, down from a Jun qtr avg of 1.3% and long run avg of 1.3%. At face value, expectations are consistent with a significant deterioration in real wages.

12. CPI Inflation: actual vs expected



13. Wages growth: actual vs expected



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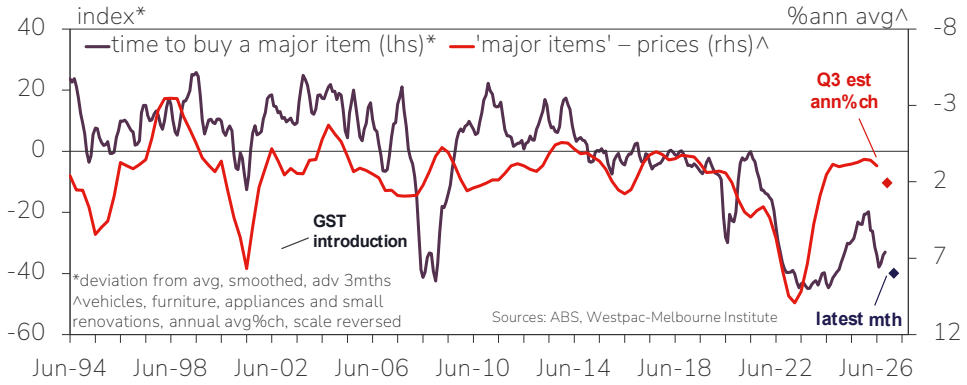
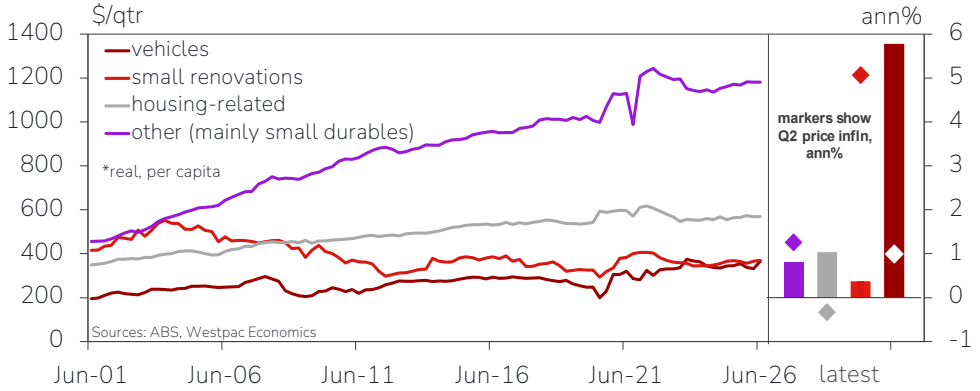
Durables: soft spend, dire sentiment

- Durables spend has been mixed over the first half of 2026, posting a surprisingly solid gain in Q2 but with most of this centred on new vehicle spend where 'extenuating circumstances' were at play. Even excluding this, the flat underlying trend is not nearly as weak as the dire reads on the 'time to buy a major item' sub-index would suggest. The last 3mths has seen the sub-index drop back again, a 4.3% decline taking it to 83, near the lows seen earlier in the year and a full 40pts below the long-run avg of 123.
- As discussed regularly over the last four years, the extreme weakness appears to relate to the collapse in purchasing power since 2022. While prices have stabilised somewhat, their still high level is casting a dark shadow over buyer sentiment.
- As Chart 18 shows, durable goods prices have been more stable since 2024 but look to have posted a bigger rise in the Sep quarter, our estimates based on the CPI detail pointing to annual price growth lifting back above 2.1%yr.
- There are a range factors at play here for prices. Construction costs have fed into the renovation segment of our measure. Some major durable items also have higher transport costs components. However, a notable medium term trend has been the absence of trend price declines for audio-visual and computing equipment, which make up a large part of the 'small durables' segment.
- As chart 15 shows, growth in real per capita spend on the 'major item' segments centred on a 10%qtr jump in vehicles in Q2, led by strong take-up of EVs that was partly in response to the sharp move higher in fuel prices this year. Excluding vehicles, per capita spend was up just 0.3%qtr, 0.8%yr.
- Partial data suggests Q3 is softer with the industry data pointing to a much slower 1%qtr gain for vehicle sales and the ABS Household Spending Indicator detail showing flat volumes for furnishings and household equipment. Our card data also suggests there has been a further shift to outright weakness in discretionary goods in the Oct month.

14. 'Time to buy a major item' vs prices



15. Consumer spending: 'big ticket' items



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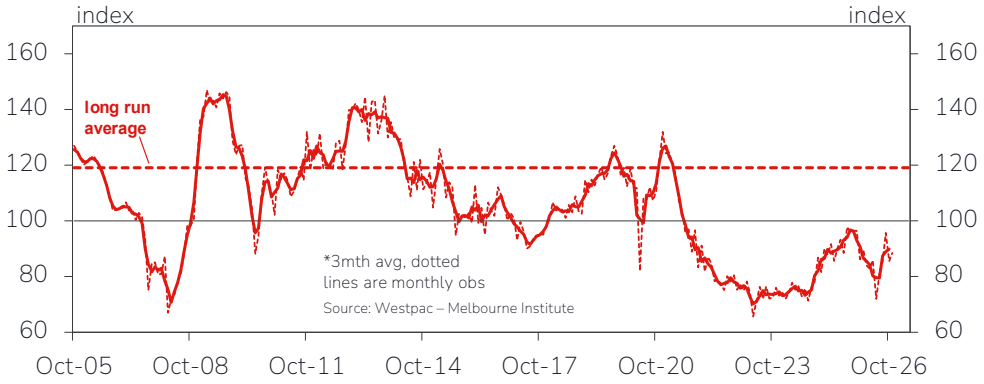
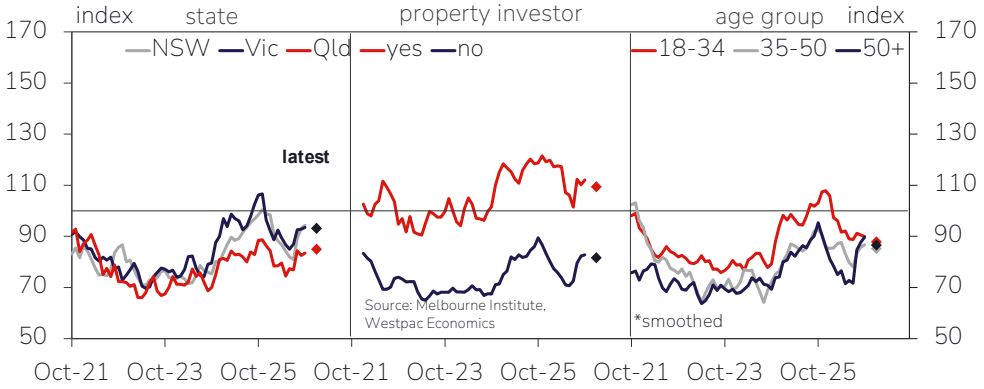
Dwellings: pessimistic and uncertain

- Housing-related sentiment has been understandably unsettled in recent months, reflecting the heightened uncertainty around interest rate and tax policy changes amid evidence of a broadening downturn in established markets.
- Assessments of 'time to buy' – generally seen as being from the perspective of owner occupiers rather than investors – have been choppy month to month but still in firmly pessimistic territory, albeit off the extreme lows seen in previous years.
- The **'time to buy a dwelling'** index actually lifted 3.6% over the 3mths to Oct sharply in May (–16%) but tracked a volatile monthly path, up 12% at one stage but unwinding most of that as inflation and rate rise fears returned.
- At 88.4, the Oct index read is still far from positive, over 30pts below the long run avg of 119.
- The sub-group detail is also quite unsettled. The Oct month improvement was more pronounced for outright homeowners, retirees, 25–34-year-olds and those earning over $80k a year. But on a quarterly basis the biggest improvement has been amongst those aged 50+ and earning over $100k.
- Interestingly, existing owners of residential property investments (25% of all respondents) continue to be outright positive on 'time to buy'.
- By state, buyer sentiment is still a little less downbeat in NSW and Vic (both state indexes at 93), where dwelling prices have seen bigger moves lower, but more pessimistic in Qld (85) and deeply pessimistic in WA (71) and SA (70).
- The overarching question is whether improving affordability – reflecting a mix of lower prices and higher interest rates – will be sufficient to offset unease about the pace of price declines.

16. 'Time to buy a dwelling'



17. 'Time to buy a dwelling': selected sub-groups



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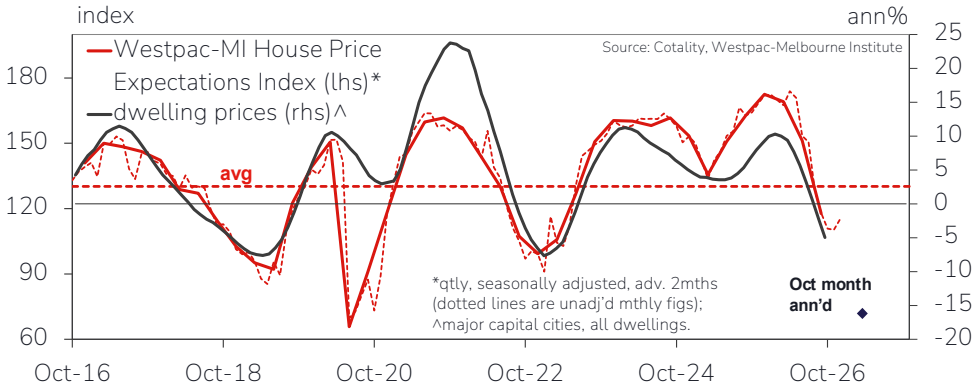
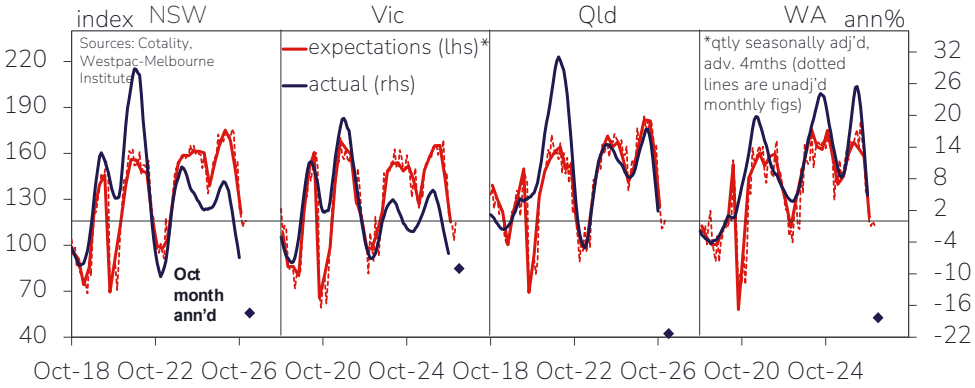
House prices: uncertain vs downbeat

- The broadening and deepening downturn in Australia's housing markets is seeing an equally rapid shift in consumer house price expectations although these have not turned as negative as they did during the 2022-23 correction.
- The **Westpac Melbourne Institute House Price Expectations Index** declined a further 2.4% over the 3mths to Oct, following a steep 25% drop over the previous 3mths. At 115.6, the Oct index read is miles below the 15yr high of 174 at the start of the year and below the long run avg of 130.
- That said, the read is still above 100, meaning more consumers expect prices to rise than fall. This compares to the low of 91 during the 2022-23 correction when the consensus view was for continued declines. The Nov survey update will be an important gauge of whether a negative consensus has again emerged about the house price outlook. If it does, price momentum is likely to remain weak as buyers will be more inclined to hold off and sellers more willing to accept low prices now.
- The detailed responses in Oct were a picture of uncertainty, 46% of those surveyed expecting prices to rise, 18% expecting no change, 31% expecting prices to decline and 5% reporting "don't know". This was a similar mix to Jul.
- That said, there is little doubt that the downturn is deepening. The Cotality home value index – covering all of Australia – fell 1.2% in Oct, annual growth dropping into negative (–2.8%yr) for the first time and prices down 6.7% from their peak in Mar (see here for a full run down).
- Actual price growth has been broadly comparable to consumer house price expectations overall (see Chart 18), although the latest monthly result suggests the latter is set to move materially lower. By state, expectations have overshot outcomes in NSW and Vic, been very closely aligned in Qld but undershot to date in WA.
- Notably, the sub-group detail shows price expectations have outright pessimistic (sub-100) for older age groups.

18. Westpac-MI House Price Expectations Index



19. Dwelling prices: actual vs expected by state



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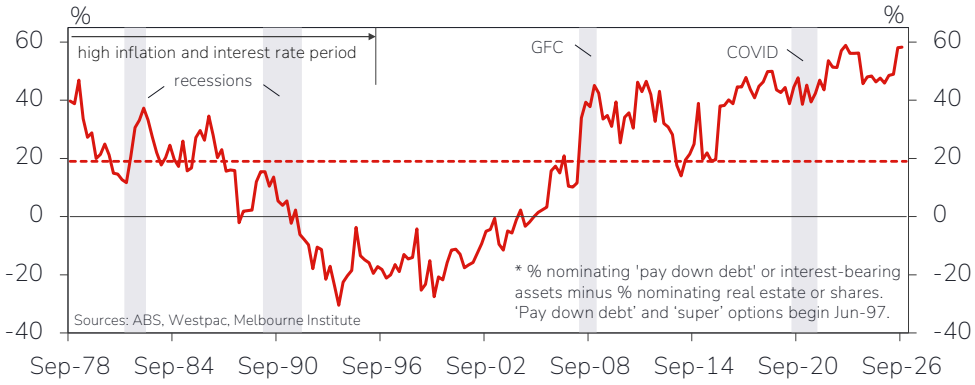
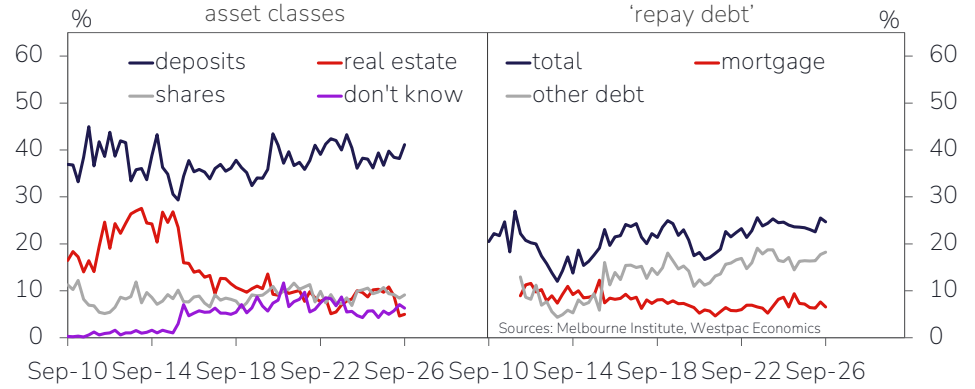
Risk aversion: bracing

- Consumers remain intensely risk averse. The **Westpac Consumer Risk Aversion Index** remained near historical extreme highs in Sep, dipping slightly from 60.1 to 57.5, but unchanged in seasonally adjusted terms (as shown on Chart 20). Readings are just a touch of the 52-year high of 60.8 recorded in June 2023.
- Recall that the index is based on responses to questions on the 'wisest place for savings'. These ask consumers to nominate from a range of options, the risk index being the difference between the share nominating 'safe' options such as 'deposits' and 'repay debt' and the share nominating 'risky' options such as 'shares' and 'real estate'.
- 'Safe options' remain very heavily favoured: 33% of consumers nominating 'bank deposits'; 24% nominating 'pay down debt' and 7% nominating 'superannuation'. The share nominating 'real estate' hold near historic lows at just 4.7%.
- As noted previously, the mix of high inflation, interest rate rises, tax policy changes, a housing downturn, and numerous other factors – including conflict in the Middle East, tariffs, and a range of disruptions from AI – is creating an extremely uncertain environment for consumers when it comes to financial decisions.
- This 'safety first' mode is typically associated with more elevated savings rates, increased voluntary debt repayments and an aversion to new borrowing that drives debt to income ratios lower over time. Notably, mix of responses on 'repay debt' suggests the focus is primarily on non mortgage rather than mortgage debt.
- The survey detail showed a fair bit of variation across sub-groups, with material declines in Vic and SA, 35-44 year olds, retirees and males but rises in NSW and amongst 45-54 year olds. Note that all of these reads were taken from the Sep survey and so pre-date the RBA's rate rise in late Sep.

20. Westpac Consumer Risk Aversion Index



21. Consumer: 'wisest place for savings'



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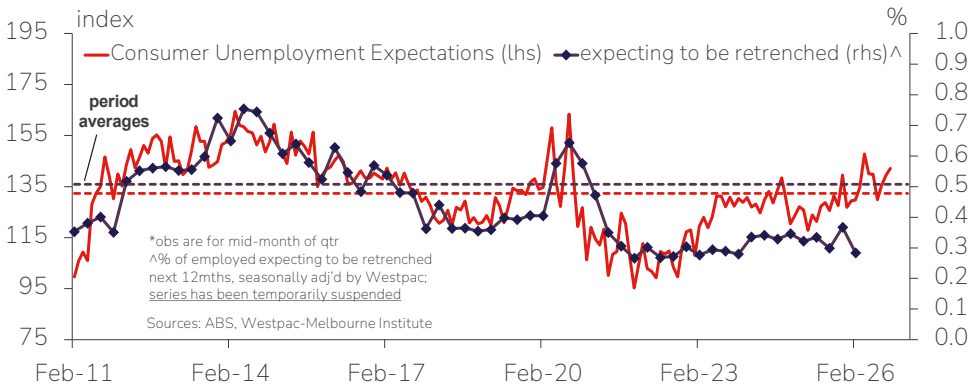
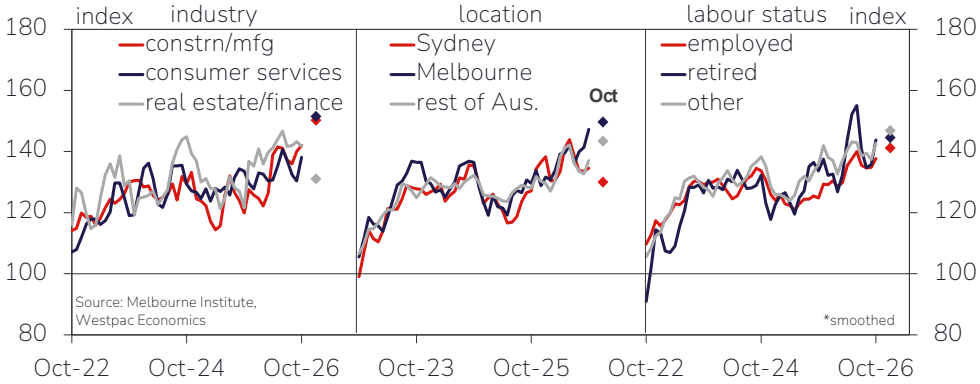
Job security: a wind shift?

- For Australian consumers, the labour market remains an island of relative calm amid the swirling mix of cost-of-living stresses, rate rise and housing downturns. Job-loss fears have moved around, most recently rising again over the last three months, but the moves have been mild compared to wider sentiment swings and the overall level of concern still relatively mild.
- The **Westpac-Melbourne Institute Index of Unemployment Expectations** rose 9.3% over the three months to Oct, reversing most of the 12.1% improvement over the previous three months (recall that higher reads mean more consumers expect unemployment to rise over the year ahead). At 142.2, the Oct index read is now decisively above the long run avg of 129 again but still well below the levels that would sound more worrying alarms.
- The latest ABS labour force figures show employment gains have been lumpy month to month but have averaged +34k/mth through May-Aug, a tick up from the +22k/mth average over the six months prior.
- Annual employment growth has been slower, holding within the 1.0-1.5%yr range over the past year or so. With the working age population expanding 1.7%yr, the mix has seen the unemployment rate drift higher, reaching 4.7% in Aug vs 4.4% in May (see here for more). While there is evidence of a little more slack emerging in labour markets this appears to be mainly coming from a combination of increased supply and more moderate growth in hiring rather than retrenchments. Unfortunately changes to the ABS survey mean official estimates of both retrenchments and expected retrenchment (as shown in Chart 26) are unavailable.
- Based on historical outcomes and adjusting for biases, the latest index read is roughly consistent with a 0.4-0.6ppt rise in the unemployment rate, which would take it into the 5.2-5.3% range by this time next year.
- The sub-group detail shows real estate and construction workers led the deterioration in Oct, suggesting it is linked to interest rate and housing market developments.

22. Unemployment expectations



23. Unemployment expectations: selected sub-groups



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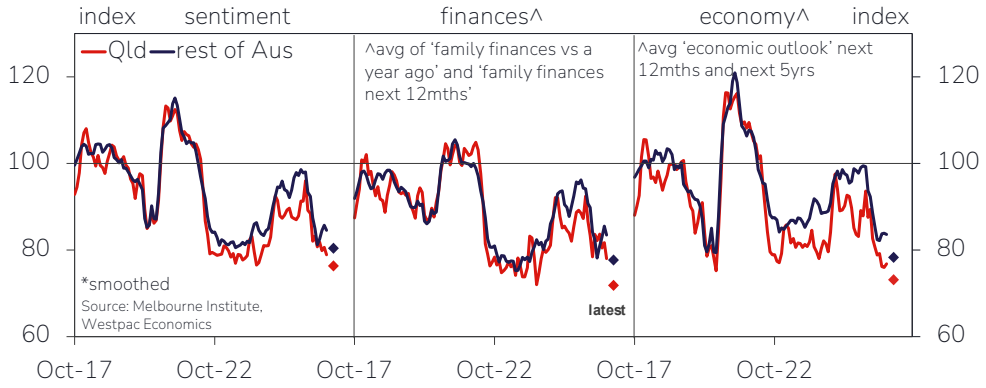
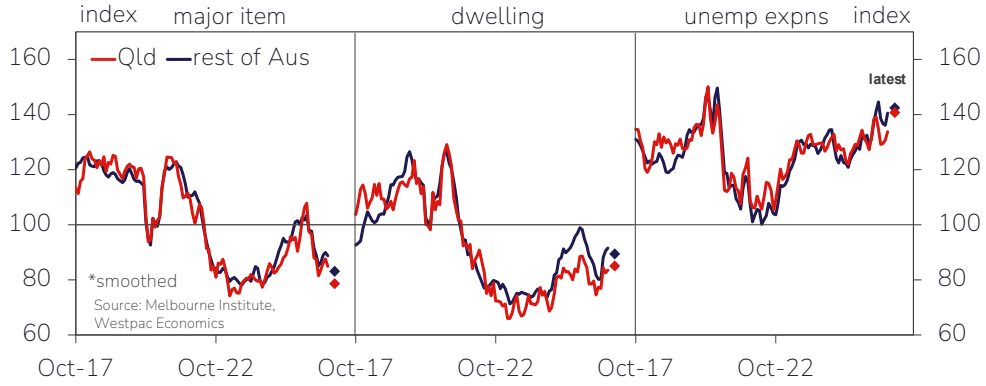
Queensland

- The last time we profiled consumer sentiment in Qld, a year ago, it was seeing a marked divergence with the rest of Aus with Qlders much more pessimistic. Some of that shift appeared to be linked to the withdrawal of what were more material cost-of-living supports provided by the Qld state government, and an associated sharper rise in headline inflation. That in turn suggested the negative wedge on sentiment could close up a little. And for a time this was the case: Qld more-or-less re-converged sentiment-wise with the rest of Aus around the start of 2026. However, since then, sentiment amongst the state's consumers has deteriorated more sharply again. At just 76.3 in Oct, the 'Sunshine state' is the gloomiest of the big 3 eastern states and plumbing 2022-23 lows.
- Component-wise, the 6pt gap with the rest of Aus in recent months has mainly centred on differing assessments of the economic outlook where there has been a 7-8pt wedge. However, assessments of finances deteriorated particularly sharply in the Oct month suggesting the housing downturn, which came on later in Qld, may be a factor now as well.
- Qld'ers are also more pessimistic on time to buy questions (especially dwellings) but interestingly are less troubled about unemployment.
- The latter may speak to a different take on the wider economic and inflation challenges: as a state, Qld has tended to see stronger demand growth (including an expected lift in infrastructure and Olympics-related build) that it putting more pressure on capacity, particularly across its labour market. Qld's unemployment rate is sitting at 4.5% a touch below the national rate which is unusual for a state that has tended to see unemployment track slightly above the national rate for most of its history (not because of labour demand issues but because the strength and composition of its population growth has tended to see more ample supply. This excessive fear factor may be a view in Qld that Australia's capacity and inflation problems may be more substantive and enduring.
- Looking ahead, housing may be the next area to weigh more heavily on sentiment with prices in the state now showing a very abrupt slowing (p13).

24. Consumer sentiment, finances, economy: Qld vs rest of Aus



25. Consumer sentiment: 'time to buy', unemp expns: Qld vs rest of Aus



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Economic and financial forecasts

Interest rate forecasts

Australia	Latest (6 Nov)	Dec–26	Mar–27	Jun–27	Sep–27	Dec–27	Mar–28	Jun–28	Sep–28	Dec–28	Dec–28
Cash	4.85	4.85	4.85	4.85	4.60	4.35	4.10	3.85	3.85	3.85	3.60
90 Day BBSW	4.93	4.95	4.95	4.80	4.55	4.30	4.10	3.95	3.95	3.95	3.70
3 Year Bond	4.71	4.90	4.85	4.75	4.65	4.55	4.45	4.35	4.30	4.25	3.90
3 Year Swap	4.69	4.90	4.85	4.75	4.65	4.55	4.45	4.35	4.30	4.25	3.90
10 Year Bond	5.02	5.20	5.15	5.10	5.05	5.05	5.00	5.00	5.00	5.00	4.65
10 Year Spread to US (bps)	17	15	15	15	15	10	0	–5	–10	–15	–20
US											
Fed Funds	3.875	4.125	4.125	4.125	4.125	4.125	3.875	3.625	3.625	3.625	3.625
US 10 Year Bond	4.85	5.05	5.00	4.95	4.90	4.95	5.00	5.05	5.10	5.15	4.85

Exchange rate forecasts

	Latest (6 Nov)	Dec–26	Mar–27	Jun–27	Sep–27	Dec–27	Mar–28	Jun–28	Sep–28	Dec–28	Dec–28
AUD/USD	0.6902	0.72	0.72	0.73	0.73	0.73	0.73	0.72	0.72	0.72	0.72
NZD/USD	0.5566	0.56	0.58	0.61	0.63	0.64	0.64	0.64	0.65	0.65	0.66
USD/JPY	157.82	156	154	153	152	151	150	149	148	146	146
EUR/USD	1.1199	1.14	1.16	1.18	1.20	1.21	1.22	1.22	1.21	1.21	1.21
GBP/USD	1.3433	1.34	1.35	1.36	1.38	1.39	1.40	1.41	1.41	1.40	1.40
USD/CNY	6.6688	6.65	t6.60	6.50	6.45	6.40	6.35	6.35	6.30	6.30	6.30
AUD/NZD	1.2399	1.27	1.24	1.20	1.16	1.15	1.13	1.12	1.12	1.11	1.10

Sources: Bloomberg, Westpac Economics.

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Economic and financial forecasts

Australian economic growth forecasts

	2026				2027			
	Q1	Q2f	Q3(f)	Q4(f)	Q1(f)	Q2(f)	Q3(f)	Q4(f)
GDP %qtr	0.3	0.4	0.5	0.2	0.4	0.3	0.4	0.5
%yr end	2.5	2.1	2.2	1.5	1.6	1.5	1.4	1.6
Unemployment rate % *	4.2	4.4	4.6	4.7	4.7	4.8	4.8	4.7
Wages (WPI) (sa) %qtr	0.8	0.8	1.0	0.8	0.8	0.8	0.8	0.8
%yr end	3.2	3.2	3.4	3.4	3.4	3.4	3.2	3.2
Headline CPI %qtr	1.4	0.6	1.3	1.3	0.4	0.5	1.0	0.5
%yr end	4.1	3.9	3.9	4.6	3.6	3.4	3.2	2.4
Trimmed Mean CPI %qtr	0.8	0.8	1.0	0.9	0.7	0.7	0.7	0.7
%yr end	3.5	3.6	3.7	3.5	3.3	3.3	3.1	2.9

	Calendar years			
	2025	2026(f)	2027(f)	2028(f)
GDP %qtr	–	–	–	–
%yr end	2.6	1.5	1.6	2.4
Unemployment rate % *	4.3	4.7	4.7	4.5
Wages (WPI) (sa) %qtr	–	–	–	–
%yr end	3.4	3.4	3.2	3.4
Headline CPI %qtr	–	–	–	–
%yr end	3.6	4.6	2.4	2.3
Trimmed Mean CPI %qtr	–	–	–	–
%yr end	3.3	3.5	2.9	2.4

* Quarter–average.

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Consumer demand

	2026				2027			
% change	**Q1**	**Q2f**	**Q3f**	**Q4f**	**Q1f**	**Q2f**	**Q3f**	**Q4f**
Total private consumption*	0.4	0.4	0.8	0.2	0.3	0.5	0.5	0.6
annual chg	2.4	1.8	2.1	1.8	1.7	1.8	1.4	1.8
Real labour income, ann chg	2.8	3.0	2.3	1.0	1.3	1.2	1.8	3.2
Real disposable income, ann chg**	1.9	2.3	3.1	0.2	1.1	1.5	1.3	2.8
Household savings ratio, %	6.4	6.5	7.2	5.1	5.8	6.4	7.1	6.1
Motor vehicle sales ('000s)***	846	928	939	907	912	916	921	925
annual chg	-1.9	10.3	10.9	8.0	7.8	-1.3	-2.0	2.0

	Calendar years			
	2025	**2026f**	**2027f**	**2028f**
Total private consumption, ann chg*	2.1	2.0	1.7	2.4
Real labour income, ann chg	3.4	2.3	1.9	3.3
Real disposable income, ann chg**	4.3	1.9	1.7	3.1
Household savings ratio, %	6.5	6.3	6.4	7.0
Motor vehicle sales ('000s)	848	905	918	948
annual chg	-3.9	6.8	1.5	3.3

Notes to pages 23 and 24:
* National accounts definition.
** Labour and non–labour income after tax and interest payments.
*** Passenger vehicles and SUVs, annualised (includes EVs).
^ Average over entire history of survey.
^^Seasonally adjusted. # Net % expected rise next 12 months minus % expecting fall (wage expectations is net of % expecting wages to rise and % expecting flat/decline).
Note that questions on mortgage rate and house price expectations have only been surveyed since May 2009.

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Consumer sentiment

		2026									
% change	avg^	Jan	Feb	Mar	Apr	May	Jun	Jul	Aug	Sep	Oct
Westpac–MI Consumer Sentiment Index	100.2	92.9	90.5	91.6	80.1	83.0	80.6	83.9	88.9	84.4	80.4
family finances vs a year ago	87.7	82.7	78.8	80.2	66.8	72.8	67.3	71.1	80.0	72.6	66.9
family finances next 12 months	106.4	97.8	97.7	97.6	84.0	93.0	85.1	96.5	98.2	94.5	88.4
economic conditions next 12 months	90.5	88.4	88.5	85.9	75.3	74.2	77.8	78.3	82.8	79.5	78.3
economic conditions next 5 years	92.1	96.5	94.1	96.3	91.4	89.3	86.5	87.1	89.8	85.8	85.5
time to buy major household item	123.0	99.1	93.5	98.0	83.3	85.6	86.4	86.8	93.8	89.3	83.0
time to buy a dwelling	119.1	89.6	84.0	82.9	85.8	72.0	81.1	85.4	95.7	85.5	88.4
Westpac–MI Consumer Risk Aversion Index^^	19.3	–	–	49.0	–	–	58.0	–	–	58.3	–
CSI±	93.7	80.3	78.3	78.4	66.9	71.3	68.2	73.3	75.6	71.7	67.6
Westpac–MI House Price Expectations Index#	130.2	167.5	173.9	171.0	153.5	150.6	128.2	118.0	110.8	110.3	115.1
consumer mortgage rate expectations#	40.5	52.8	77.5	70.5	77.2	81.2	72.6	62.6	58.8	70.4	79.7
Westpac–MI Unemployment Expectations	129.3	129.4	129.8	134.7	147.8	140.0	139.8	129.9	135.7	139.4	142.1
MI inflation expectations (trimmed mean)	4.4	4.6	5.0	5.2	5.9	5.6	5.5	4.7	4.9	4.9	5.3
MI wage expectations (trimmed mean)	1.3	1.3	1.3	1.3	1.3	1.3	1.3	1.3	1.6	1.2	1.2

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RETAIL SPENDING PULSE

6 November 2026

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Discretionary spending flat as high fuel prices bite

- Per-person spending on Westpac issued credit and debit cards was up 1.2% in October and is 7.8% higher than this time last year.

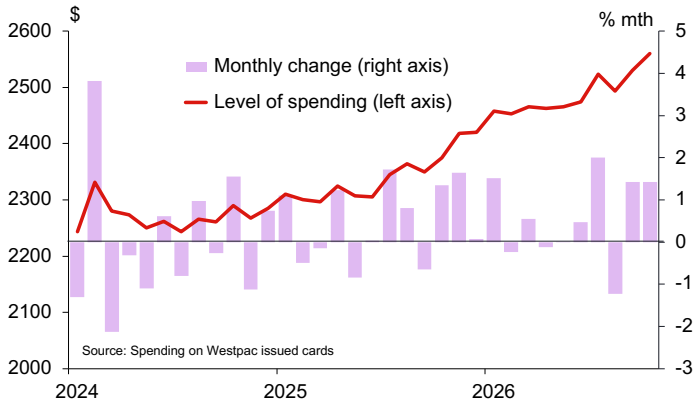
October spending.

- October's rise in spending was mainly related to the sharp increase in petrol prices, with the average price for 91-unleaded around the country climbing to a record high of over $3.60/ltr. That saw spending on fuel rise 14% over the month.
- Those higher fuel prices, along with other cost of living pressures, have put the brakes on other purchases. Spending in discretionary areas was down 0.4% in October and has essentially been tracking sideways since May. There's been notable softness in spending on travel and household furnishings. However, spending in restaurants has been holding up.

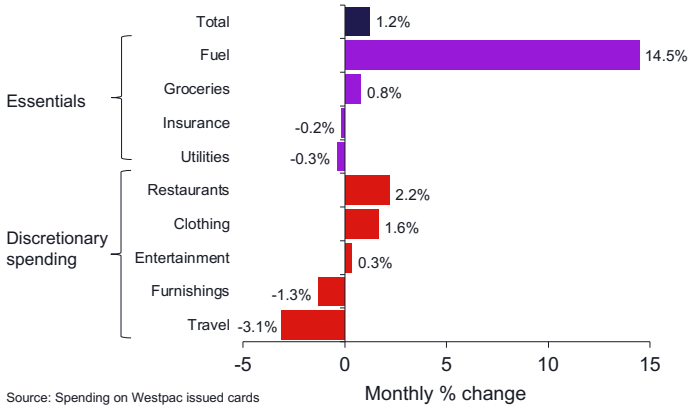
Annual growth.

- While spending has certainly been constrained by the rise in living costs since the start of this year, spending levels are still well above those we saw in 2025. And that's not just because of high fuel prices, with spending in discretionary areas also up compared to this time last year.
- That's been supported by factors such as the drop in borrowing costs over the past year and strength in export earnings. The boost from those factors is helping to balance the impacts of factors such as softness in the labour market and high fuel prices. However, as we highlight over the page, the strength in spending has been uneven across the country.

Monthly retail spending (per person, seasonally adjusted)



Monthly spending growth (per person)



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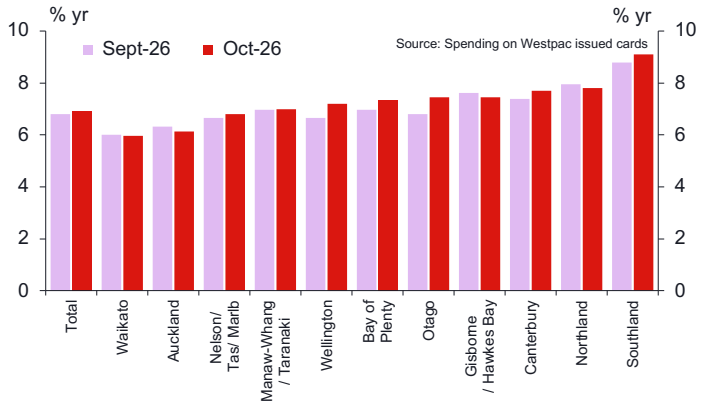
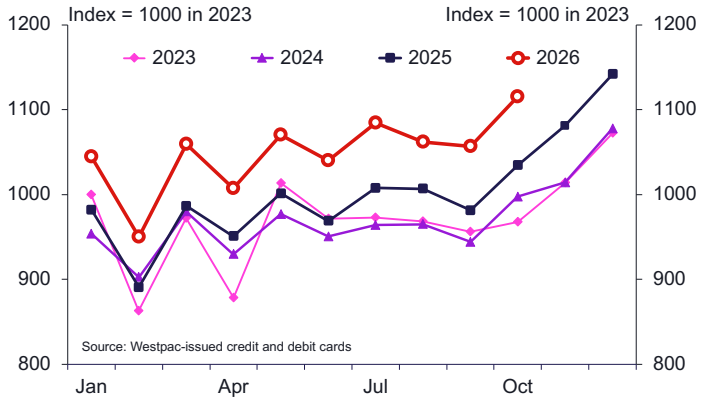
Regional breakdown

- As has been the case for some time, spending growth has been strongest in Southland. Other parts of the country with strong rural backbones like Canterbury and Northland have also continued to see solid gains.
- Spending growth remains more modest in Auckland. However, we expect that spending in Auckland will take a step higher next month, with hospitality spending in particular likely to be boosted by events like the Indian cricket tour, Diwali and Auckland Marathon.
- In a notable move, Wellington has shifted up the ranks and now sits in the middle of the pack. Wellingtonians are no doubt holding their breath ahead of Saturday's tight election and many will be stocking up for the traditional election night barbecue and watch party.*

Annual spending growth - past three months compared to same time last year



Spending on Westpac credit and debit cards (per person)



* Speaking from experience, the Westpac Economics Team can't guarantee that you'll have a good time at those parties.

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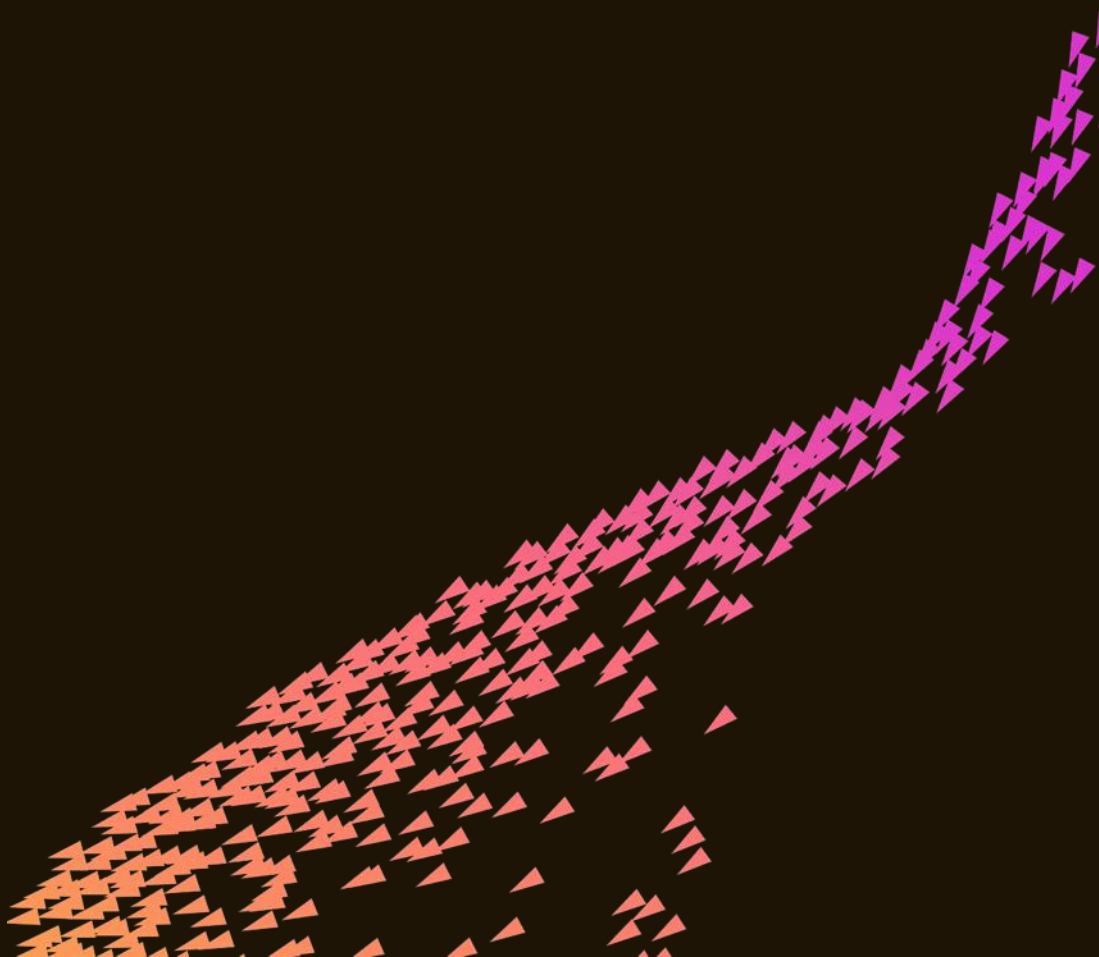
First Home Buyer Report

October 2026



Cotality – Westpac

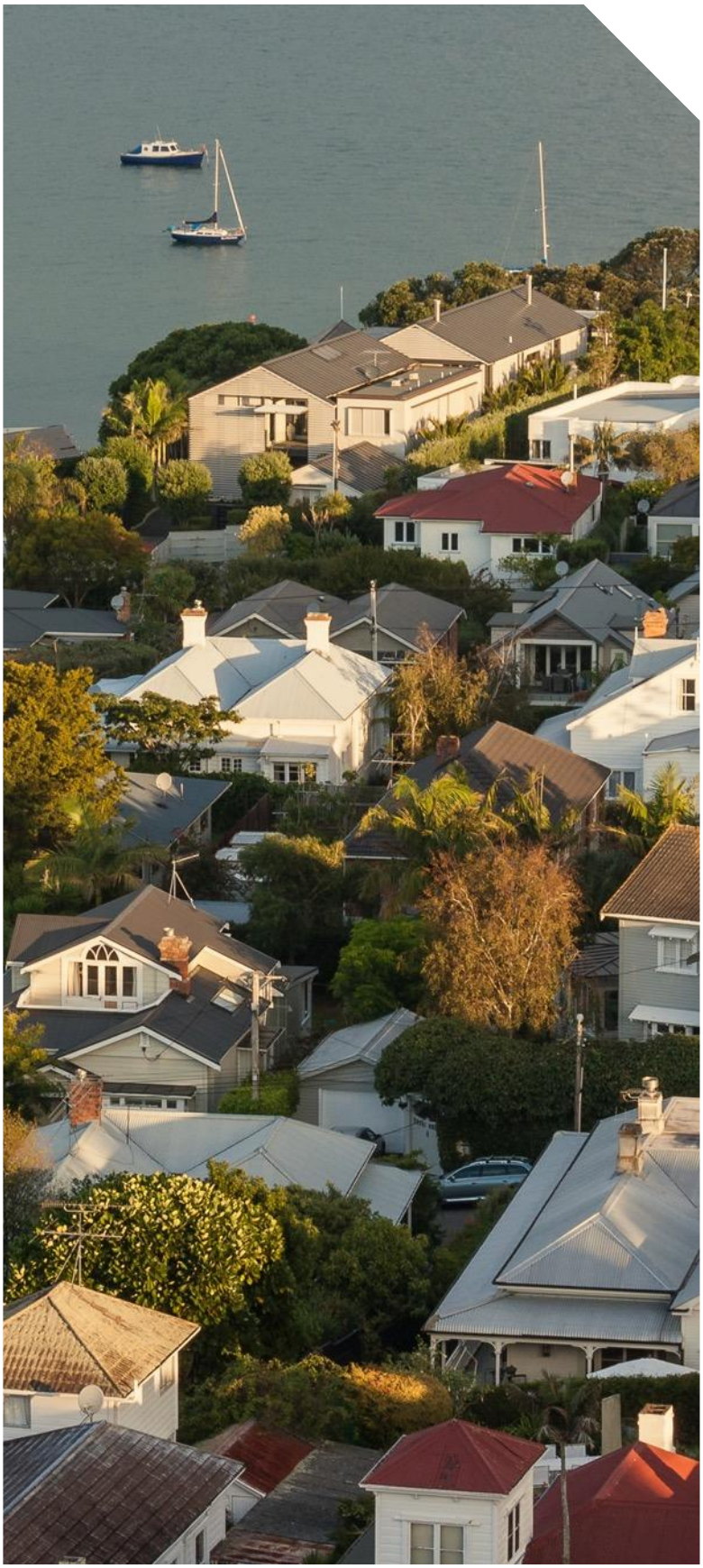
First Home Buyer Report

Cotality's First Home Buyer (FHB) Report has tracked purchasing activity for several years, analysing the types of properties bought, the prices paid, and broader shifts in entry-level demand. The latest edition updates these measures and extends the analysis to examine FHB activity across different price brackets.

Now in its fourth edition in partnership with Westpac, the report also draws on the bank's mortgage lending data to provide additional insight into borrower characteristics. That includes the average age of FHB borrowers, a measure not widely available elsewhere, as well as loan-to-value ratios across new mortgages.

For clarity, we define a first home buyer purchase to be where no party involved has owned property in New Zealand before and are using a mortgage to make the deal.

Note:
The Westpac FHB age and LVR data are sourced from their lending records and is not matched to the Cotality database for this report.



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First Home Buyer Report

Key findings

- **FHBs' market share remains at record high levels.** In Q3 2026, they accounted for 29.5% of property purchases across NZ, surpassing the previous mark of 28.3% only set three months earlier. The number of deals remains at historically high levels too, bucking the wider trend of slowing sales volumes for groups such as investors and relocating owner-occupiers.

- **This strength for FHBs is being seen right across the country,** with market shares generally running above their own long-term averages (since 2005). The wider Wellington area remains a hotspot for FHBs, accounting for 37% of activity so far in 2026. But FHBs have also been at least 30% of the market in Hamilton and Auckland, as well as Gisborne, Rotorua, Hastings, Palmerston North, and Invercargill – South Waikato and Waikato District too.

- **This high level of activity hasn't meant too many compromises either;** standalone houses have comprised 76% of all FHB purchases so far in 2026, up from 75% last year, and the highest figure since 2020 (78%). To be fair, FHBs have had to pay a little more, with a median price so far this year of $715,000, but still less than nearly $719,000 in 2022.

- **FHBs are more active across the value spectrum too.** For example, in the middle 40% of the market by value, their share rose from 21% in 2015 to 28% in 2025, and now about 30% so far this year.

- **Access to low deposit finance under the LVR rules remains a key support for first home buyers.** Recent Reserve Bank data shows that more than half of FHB loans are done at less than 20% deposit (or above 80% LVR), and Westpac's own lending records show a recent average LVR for FHBs of a touch more than 80%.

- **The average age for FHBs on Westpac's books has ticked higher lately, from around 35 late last year to about 35.5 now.** But rather than necessity due to affordability pressures, this is more likely to reflect a choice from many buyers to just wait for the right property without fear the market will run away again in the meantime.

- **Looking ahead, although it's never easy to get that first home, conditions should remain favourable for FHBs.** Mortgage rates remain lower than at many points in the past, KiwiSaver access for at least part of the deposit remains a strong support, and the banks remain willing and able to lend at low deposit/high LVR too.

- **This is clearly a 'good news story' which we should never get blasé or complacent about,** after so many previous years (even decades) of intense housing affordability pressures and a declining home ownership rate.

- As we head into November's election, the bottom line is that first home buyers are starting from a strong base.

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First Home Buyer Report

Commentary from Satish Ranchhod, Westpac NZ Senior Economist

It's been another solid few months for first home buyers with their share of house sales remaining around record highs across the country. That's a stark contrast to the softness in the broader housing market over the past year.

Helping to support those high levels of first home buyers have been a couple of big trends. The first is the large number of properties available for sale. That's meant those looking to get their foot on the property ladder have had plenty of options. As a result, first home buyers have often been able to get into newer and larger standalone homes without having to pay significantly more.

The other factor that has boosted first home buyer numbers has been the relatively low level of mortgage rates in recent years. Combined with broadly flat house prices, that's meant servicing a mortgage has been much more affordable, with the share of disposable income being spent on debt-servicing costs back around pre-pandemic averages. For the average first home buyer, lower mortgage interest rates in recent years shaved around $560 off their monthly mortgage payments compared to 2023 when interest rates were at their peak. And in Auckland, where first homes tend to be more expensive, the saving is around $685 a month.

While those are encouraging trends for first home buyers, there are some big changes in economic conditions occurring which are likely to have important implications for the housing market over the year ahead.

Most notable has been the sharp rise in inflation in the wake of the Middle East war, with oil prices rocketing higher since the start of this year. That contributed to consumer prices rising by 3.7% in the year to September. Relatively high core inflation levels mean we expect inflation will push above 4% before the end of this year and remain high for much of 2027.

In response to those mounting inflation pressures, and concerns that they will persist for some time, the RBNZ began lifting the Official Cash Rate (OCR) back in July. We expect further hikes in coming months. The resulting pressure on borrowing costs has seen mortgage rates push higher in recent months, with one- and two-year fixed rates up around 0.75 percentage points over the past year.

Even with the recent rise in mortgage rates, the housing market is still a lot more accessible for first home buyers than a few years ago. But with growing upward pressure on interest rates, it's a good time for prospective first home buyers (or anyone with a re-fix coming up) to think about the best way to structure their borrowing. That could help insulate them from the likely trend higher in the OCR over the next couple of years and could save them a lot of money over the life of their mortgage. There's a relatively modest difference between short- and longer-term fixed mortgage rates right now, which means the cost of taking this 'insurance' is not prohibitive.

Minimum monthly mortgage payments*

		Two year fixed mortgage rate		Fall in minimum monthly payment
		2023	Current	
	Median price Q3 2026	6.99%	5.29%	
Nationwide	$707,000	$4,382	$3,824	-$558
Auckland	$868,000	$5,380	$4,695	-$685
Wellington	$720,000	$4,463	$3,895	-$568
Christchurch	$650,000	$4,029	$3,516	-$513

(*Calculations based on a median price first home with an 80% mortgage fixed for two years and a term of 20 years.)

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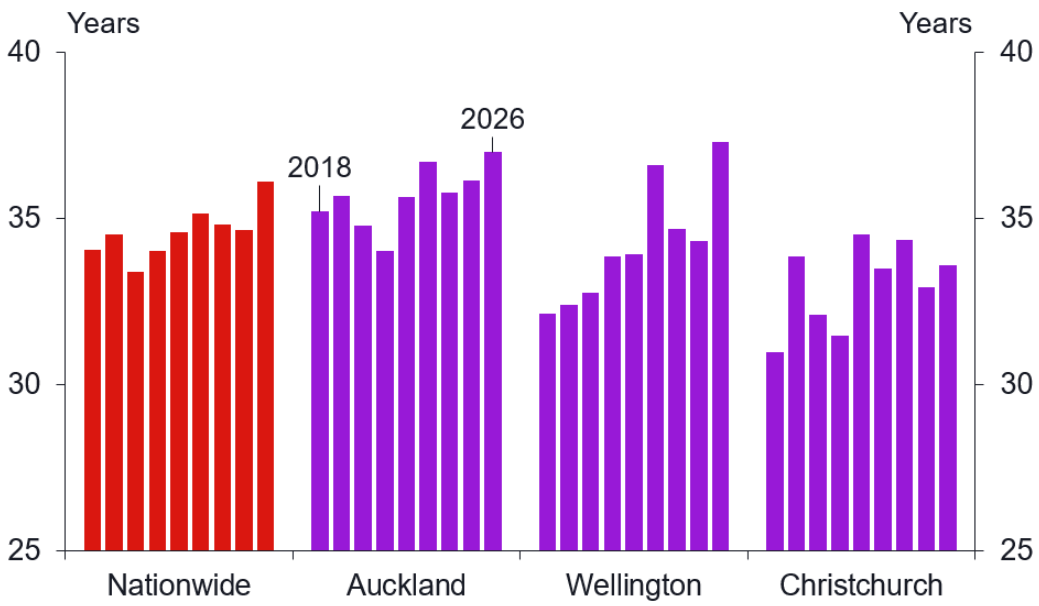
First Home Buyer Report

Providing some offset to the lift in borrowing costs, house price inflation is low, with effectively no growth in average house prices for three years now. And with mortgage rates pushing higher, prices are expected to remain soft for some time. We expect that average house prices will fall by 1.4% over 2026, with a rise of just 1.8% in 2027.

At the same time, the supply of housing is continuing to lift, with more than 40,000 new dwellings consented over the past year. We expect population growth to increase, but from low levels, which means the demand for housing might not be shifting sharply higher any time soon.

That combination of conditions means that there is still likely to be a lot of options for those looking to get into their first home over the coming year.

Average age of first home buyers from Westpac loans (2018 to 2026)



Source: Cotality, Westpac

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First Home Buyer Report

The national picture

Since our previous FHB Report back in May 2026, the wider housing market has remained subdued and patchy – generally sales volumes have been flat to falling, while property values have been showing a similarly soft picture, albeit not everywhere. Amongst the main centres, Auckland and Wellington, as examples, have been more sluggish than say Christchurch or Dunedin. It's also noteworthy that the stock of listings available for sale remains elevated across the country.

It's not difficult to find the reasons why the market remains in the doldrums. The economic backdrop is still uncertain, the unemployment rate is above average, and mortgage rates have been drifting higher in recent months as inflation fears remain strong. A better balance of physical housing supply versus our population is also dampening prices, while the election has been a recent reason for caution too. It's harder to measure, but 'animal spirits' aren't a key factor at the moment either.

FHBs have gone from strength to strength

In this purchaser-friendly environment, first home buyers have continued to take full advantage. The Cotality Buyer Classification data shows that their market share hit a new quarterly record high of 28.3% in Q2 2026, only to push higher still in Q3 – reaching 29.5%. They're also faring well in terms of the number of deals too, recently hovering at around 25,000 on a 12-month rolling basis, back to levels last seen (for a brief period) at the height of the post-COVID boom.

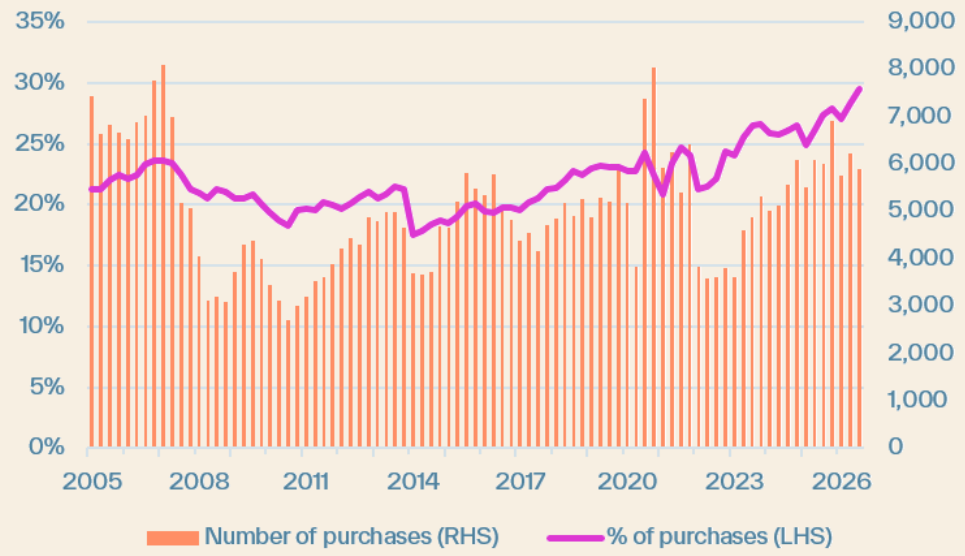
Clearly, lower property values – still down by more than 18% nationally from the peak – and improved housing affordability (even despite some recent rises in mortgage rates) are helping FHBs. But those aren't the only factors; access to (ever-growing) KiwiSaver pots for at least part of the deposit is also a factor, alongside decent availability of high LVR finance at the banks.

Indeed, the 25% allowance/speed limit to lend to owner-occupiers at less than 20% equity (or >80% LVR) is not being tested at the moment and recently more than half of FHB loans have been advanced at less than 20% deposit. **Westpac's own mortgage lending records show this in a different way – with the average LVR for their loans to FHBs in recent months still running a touch above 80%.** LVRs tend to be higher in Auckland, but a bit lower in Canterbury and Wellington.

They're also getting more for their money

FHBs have always tended to be willing to compromise on location or property type to make the shift from renting into ownership, but lately there hasn't been much need to take such an approach. **Over 2026 to date (Q3), standalone houses have comprised 76% of all FHB purchases, up from 75% last year, and well above 2023's cyclical trough of less than 70%.** For comparison, standalone houses have accounted for around 72% of deals across all buyers year to date.

National FHB activity



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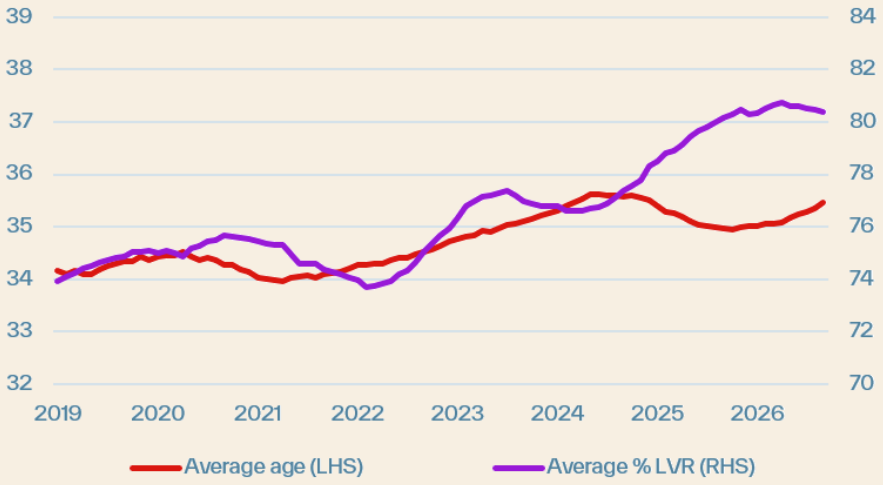
First Home Buyer Report

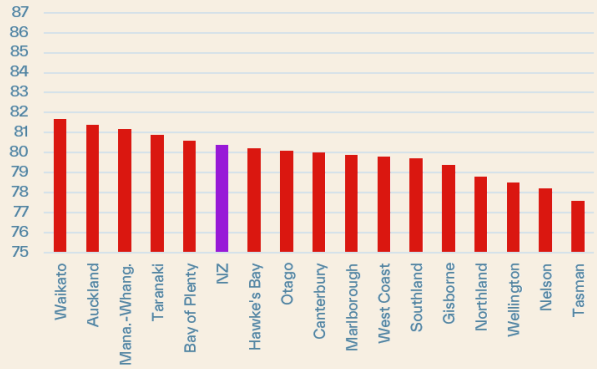
Average % LVR for Westpac FHB loans and average age of borrower (12-month rolling averages)

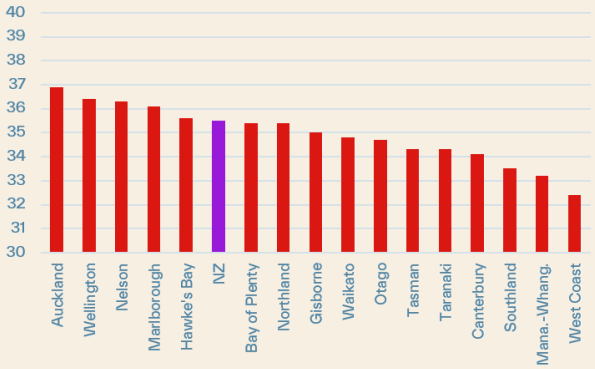
Source: Westpac



Regional % LVRs and average FHB age (12-month rolling averages)

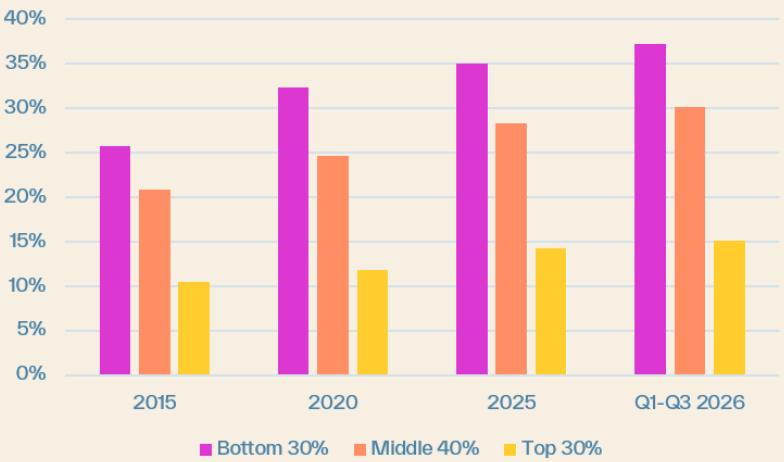
Source: Westpac





FHB % market share by price paid band

Source: Cotality



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First Home Buyer Report

This shows that FHBs are getting the most for their money in a quieter market. Admittedly, the median price they've paid so far this year has risen to $715,000, up from $701,000 in 2025 and also higher than the 2023 ($695,000) and 2024 figures ($692,000). But that latest price is still around $4,000 lower than in 2022, yet FHBs are still getting 'more house'.

Another important point to make is that FHBs don't always enter at the bottom of the housing ladder and work their way up – many actually enter well above the lowest tiers of the market. Indeed, the FHB median price paid of $715,000 this year is below the all-buyer figure of $785,000, but well above the all-buyer lower quartile (bottom 25%) of $595,000.

This point can be made another way too, with Cotality figures showing a rising share of activity for FHBs right across the price spectrum. Perhaps most notably, FHBs have accounted for 30% of purchases in the middle 40% price bracket of transactions so far this year, up from a 28% share in 2025, 25% in 2020, and only 21% in 2015. They've even accounted for 15% of activity so far this year in the top 30% of deals split by price.

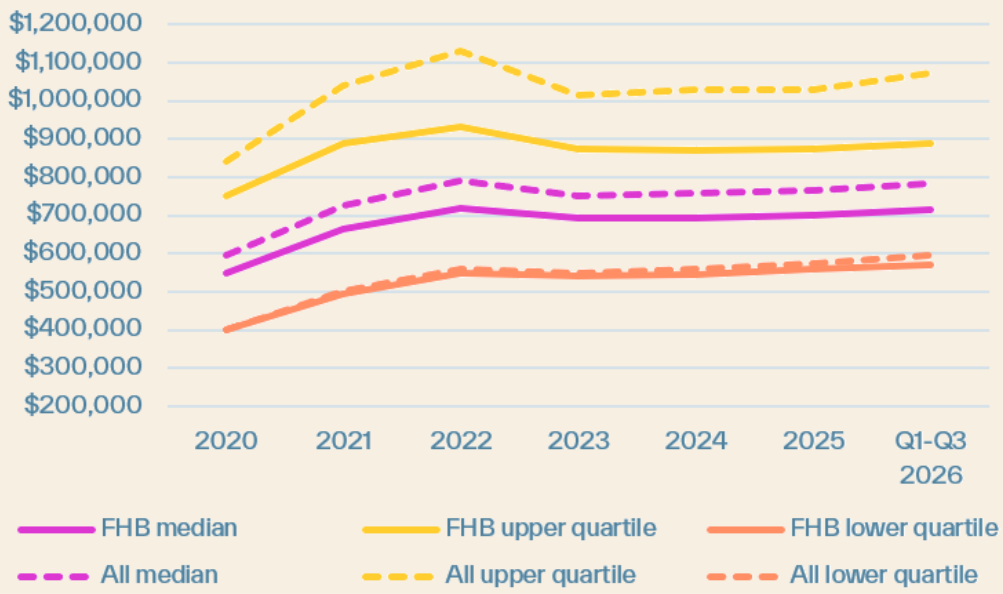
FHBs' average age has edged higher again, but probably just due to a lack of pressure

Meanwhile, at face value, Westpac's data showing that the average age of a FHB has recently edged back up to around 2024 levels of 35.5 again, after a trough of 35 late last year, could seem at odds with the other, more encouraging trends. But rather than being out of necessity (e.g. due to affordability pressures), this could reflect the abundance of listings and subdued house prices, meaning that **some/many FHBs might just be choosing to wait a bit longer to get their ideal property, without fear they'll be left behind by a rising market.**

A solid outlook

Overall, it's never easy to buy that first home and FHBs certainly continue to face challenges. But their presence has remained strong in recent months and, although nothing lasts forever, it's not hard to imagine that FHBs stay a solid presence into 2027 as well. This is a 'good news story' which we should never get blasé or complacent about, after so many previous years (decades) of intense housing affordability pressures and a declining home ownership rate.

Purchase price paid



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First Home Buyer Report

The main centres

Looking at the data across Auckland, Hamilton, Tauranga, wider Wellington (i.e. combined City, Lower Hutt, Upper Hutt, Porirua), Christchurch, and Dunedin, the national trends can also be seen at the more granular level – indeed, all of these areas have had FHB market shares lately that are above their own averages.

The wider Wellington area remains a standout for FHBs, where their share so far this year has been a touch above 37%, well in excess of their long-term average in that market of 30%. FHBs have also had a market share in 2026 above 30% in Hamilton and Auckland. The figures have been a little lower in Christchurch and Dunedin (both around 28%), as well as Tauranga (circa 25%), but in each of those markets the figures have still been 4-8%-points above their own averages.

Looking at the different property types, standalone houses still dominate in most areas, accounting for 85-90% of FHB purchases in Dunedin, Tauranga, and Hamilton – broadly in line with the long term norms in those areas. The share for houses amongst FHB purchases is always lower in Christchurch, Wellington, and Auckland, but it's perhaps the former that stands out most at present – with only 66% of FHB purchases so far in 2026 in Christchurch being standalone houses, versus the historical average of 75%. This no doubt reflects the recent townhouse construction upswing.

In each main centre, the median FHB price is lower than the figure for all buyers, but higher than the lower quartile for all buyers – in other words, FHBs don't always enter at the bottom. In terms of the prices themselves, Auckland is the main centre where FHBs pay the most, at a median of $880,000 so far in 2026, which is $110,000 less than the all-buyer median, but $110,000 more than the all-buyer lower quartile. Median FHB prices paid are $795,500 in Tauranga so far in 2026, followed by Wellington at $736,250, Hamilton $715,000, and lower still in Christchurch and Dunedin.

FHB % share of purchases

Source: Cotality

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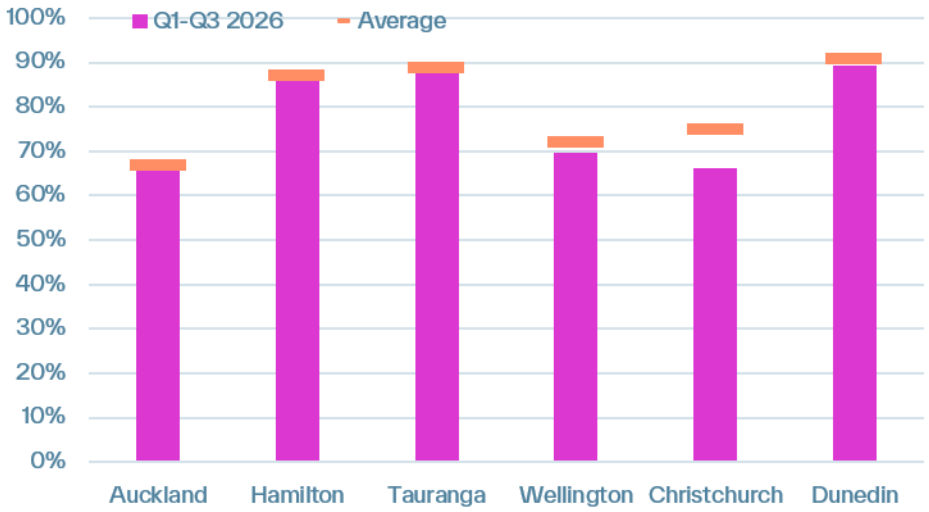
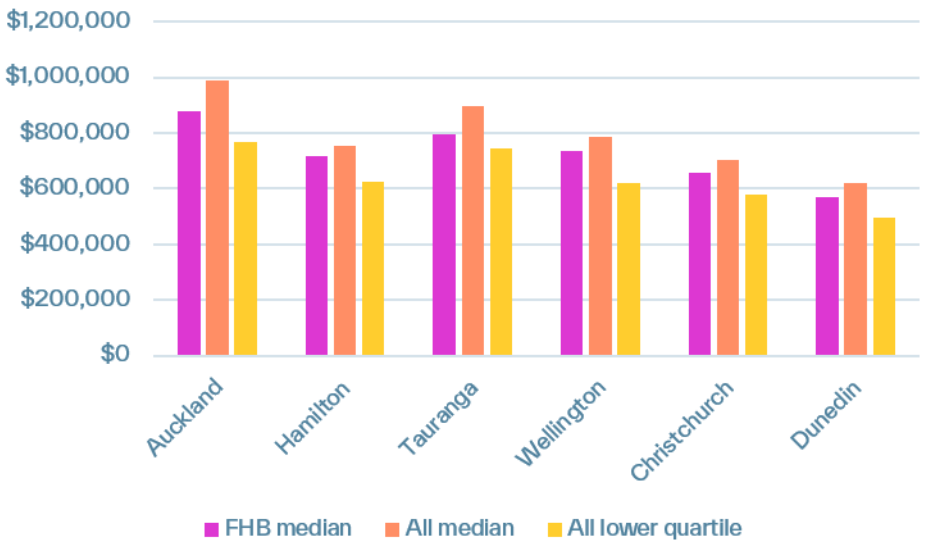
House % share of FHB purchases



Source: Cotality

Purchase price paid Q1-Q3 2026



Source: Cotality

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First Home Buyer Report

The main urban areas

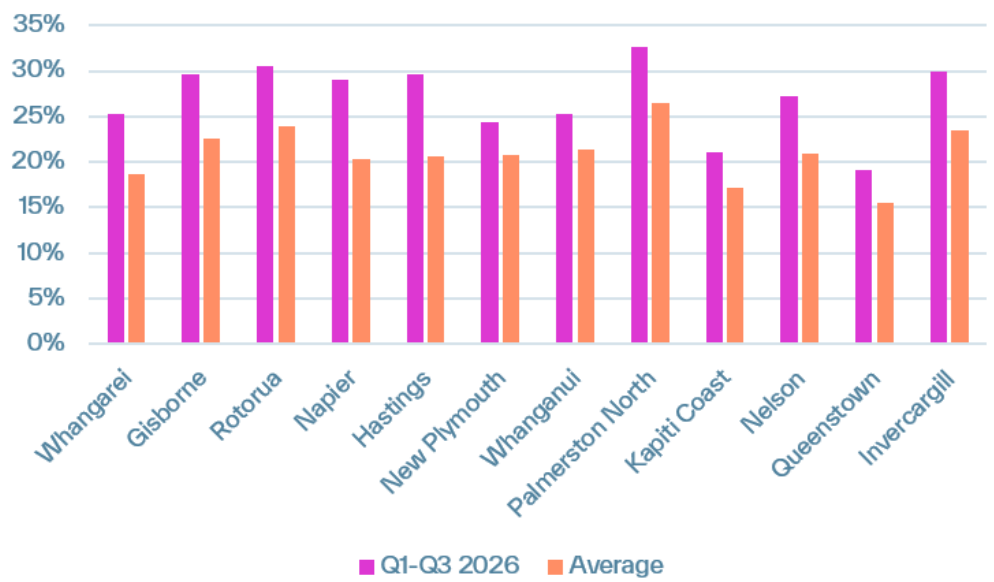
Digging deeper into the next 12 key centres around New Zealand, the story of relative strength for FHBs' market share has remained in place so far in 2026. Palmerston North stands out with 33% of transactions in the year to date going to FHBs (6%-points above its average), although Rotorua, Gisborne, Hastings, and Invercargill have also had FHB shares of 30% or more this year. Relative to their own averages, Napier and Hastings have been strongest, with figures 9%-points above normal.

But even in areas where FHBs have traditionally found conditions harder or have simply been less interested, there's still been relative strength this year. For example, Whangarei's share going to FHBs has been 25% in 2026 (versus average since 2005 of 19%), Kapiti Coast at 21% versus 17%, and Queenstown-Lakes at 19% versus 15%.

Standalone houses tend to be the dominant type of property amongst the existing dwelling stock in many provincial areas, and therefore also account for a high share of FHB purchases. So far this year, houses have been at least 90% of FHB purchases in Invercargill, Palmerston North, Whanganui, Rotorua, and Gisborne. It's been 80-89% in Nelson, Kapiti Coast, Hastings, Whangarei, Napier, and New Plymouth. Queenstown is lower at just 64%, but that's likely to reflect a wider range of property types amongst the existing stock of dwellings, as well as affordability pressures which are probably pushing FHBs towards lower price brackets (and hence smaller dwellings).

Indeed, in terms of median prices paid by FHBs so far this year, the highest figure (amongst the main urban areas) has been in Queenstown, at $1,275,000. Kapiti Coast comes in at $700,000, with Whangarei, Rotorua, Napier, Hastings, New Plymouth, and Nelson all at least $600,000. By contrast, Invercargill ($480,000) and Whanganui ($460,000) are at the lower end.

FHB % share of purchases



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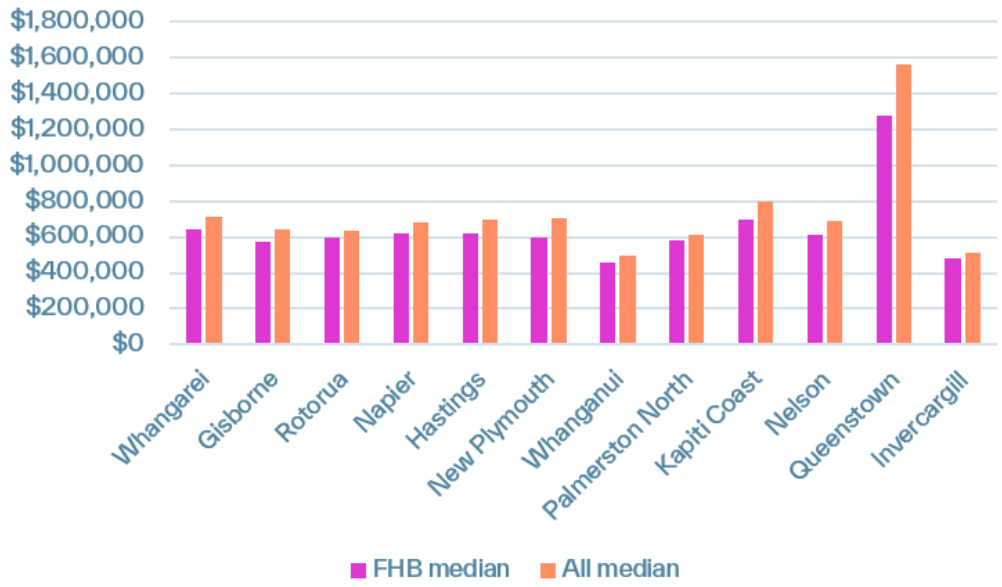
Purchase price paid Q1-Q3 2026



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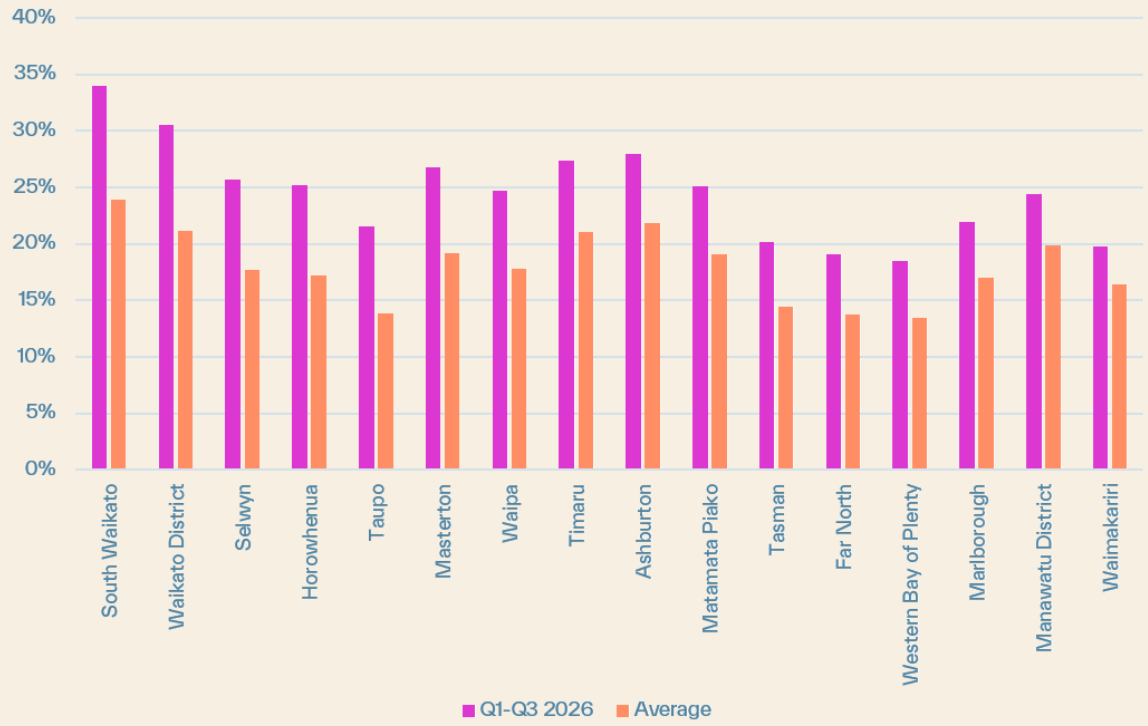
The provinces

Around NZ's provincial markets (with a minimum number of 125 FHB purchases so far in 2026), all have had a FHB % market share above the long-term average. The highest raw numbers have been in South Waikato (34%), Waikato District (31%), along with Ashburton (28%), Timaru and Masterton (27% apiece), and Selwyn (26%). The figures have been less than 20% in Far North, Western Bay of Plenty, and Waimakariri. Compared to their own averages, South Waikato and Waikato District have also been robust for FHBs, along with Selwyn and Horowhenua.

Meanwhile, in terms of the prices being paid by FHBs in these provincial areas, Western Bay of Plenty has had the highest figure so far in 2026 ($760,000), with Selwyn at $749,000, and Waipa and Waikato District both on $730,000. By contrast, the prices have been $500,000 or less in Masterton, Timaru, Horowhenua, and South Waikato.

FHB % share of purchases



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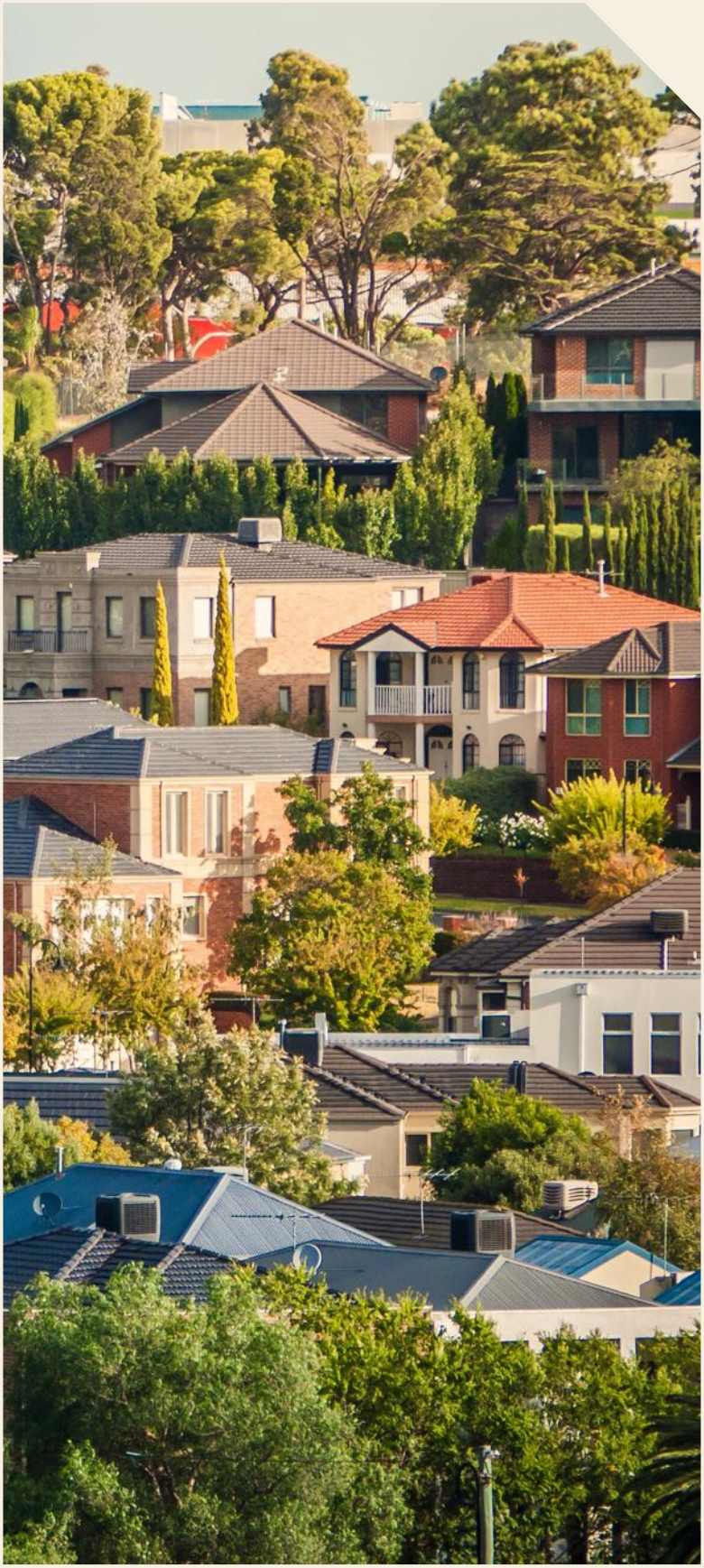

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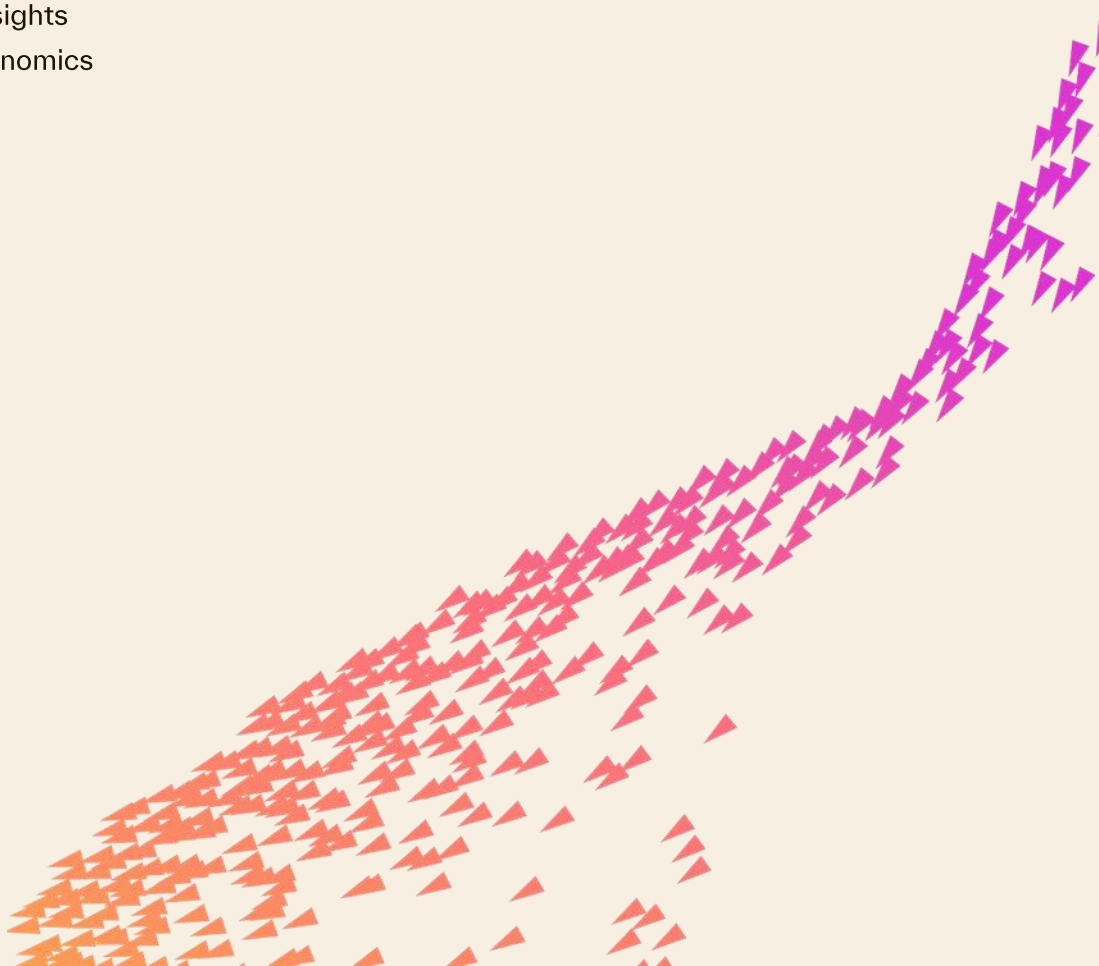

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